EDITED BY
CHAN SIN-WAI

THE ROUTLEDGE ENCYCLOPEDIA OF TRADITIONAL CHINESE CULTURE

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The Routledge Encyclopedia of Traditional Chinese Culture offers an in-depth discussion of cultural aspects of China from the ancient period to the pre-modern era, lasting over 5,000 years, comprised of 7,000 word pieces by more than 20 world-leading academics and experts.

Addressing areas such as China studies, cultural studies, cultural management, and more specific areas – such as religion, opera, Chinese painting, Chinese calligraphy, material culture, performing arts, and visual arts – this encyclopedia covers all major aspects of traditional Chinese culture.

The volume is intended to be a detailed reference for graduate students on a variety of courses, and also for undergraduate students on survey courses to Chinese culture.

Chan Sin-wai is Professor and Dean of the School of Humanities and Languages, Caritas Institute of Higher Education, Hong Kong, China. His teaching and research interests lie mainly in the areas of translation studies, translation technology, and bilingual lexicography. He has published more than 60 books in 80 volumes, mainly scholarly monographs, dictionaries, and translated works in different fields. His most recent book publications include *The Future of Translation Technology: Towards a world without Babel* (2017), *An Encyclopedia of Practical Translation and Interpreting* (2018), *The Human Factor in Machine Translation* (2018), and *A New Comprehensive Cantonese-Putonghua-English Dictionary* (2019).

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ASPECTS OF TRADITIONAL CHINESE CULTURE

Chan Sin-wai

Introduction

China is a country with a long history of culture, originating from several thousand years ago. As China is a large country with many people, regions, nationalities, and languages, Chinese culture is diversified and varied and its influence on Asia and the world has been dominant and far-reaching. This encyclopedia attempts to introduce a number of areas in traditional Chinese culture to enhance our understanding of the intellectual, spiritual, material, and aesthetic life of the Chinese people through the ages. Its coverage may not be comprehensive, but the topics discussed in this encyclopedia are highly important and some are much understudied.

Aspects of traditional Chinese culture

We have invited twenty-four scholars and specialists from China, Hong Kong, Australia, the United States, and the United Kingdom to contribute chapters on various aspects of Chinese culture. As the scope of each aspect varies, the length of each chapter is also different. We tried to maintain consistency in length and coverage, but also allowed authors on broad topics to exceed the word limit. The following introduces what is contained in this encyclopedia.

Architecture

This volume begins with a chapter on traditional Chinese architecture, written by Professor Nancy S. Steinhardt, Professor of East Asian Art and Curator of Chinese Art at the University of Pennsylvania. Professor Steinhardt is a leading scholar of this area, having published ten books and more than 100 articles on Chinese architecture and related topics. Her chapter, beautifully illustrated with eleven images, is a survey of Chinese architecture through more than four millennia of history. According to her, Chinese architecture is a multi-millennial tradition of primarily timber-frame buildings. Regardless of the material used in building, almost every building is elevated on a platform, supported by columns and covered by a ceramic-tile roof and nearly all the roofs are supported by bracket sets or facsimile bracket sets. These special features are present in religious and secular architecture, both imperial and humble. The uniformity across building types, the vast territory of China, and through time is achieved through the use of modules that are explained in building manuals. Building groups also are modular, usually positioned around courtyards.

Only occasionally, in garden and vernacular construction, does Chinese architecture break out of ever-recognizable tradition.

Agriculture

We all know that China is an agricultural country, with a very high percentage of its people living in the rural areas to engage in farming. A chapter on agriculture is therefore indispensable for an encyclopedia on Chinese culture. This chapter on agriculture is written by Professor Liu Yingchun and Professor Wang Haiyan of Dalian Maritime University in China. They hold the view that agriculture in traditional China emphasizes the importance of harmony between man and nature, which means that agricultural production is to combine manpower with the natural forces in accordance with the laws of nature to produce food to eat. They introduce what had been achieved in the field of agriculture up to the Ming dynasty (1366 CE—1644 CE). Topics covered in this chapter include the cultivation of different varieties of grains, the soaking of seed rice, care of the rice paddy field and wheat field, and the prevention of rice disasters. This chapter then discusses different ways of processing grains and the making of sugar, covering the planting of sugar cane, the making of brown sugar, white sugar, and animal-shape candies. It ends with a discussion on the making of salt, including sea salt, lake salt, and well salt.

Bees

The chapter on bees is written by Professor David Pattinson of the University of Leeds, the United Kingdom. In recent years, Professor Pattinson has extended his academic interests from history, literature, and translation to bees and beekeeping in traditional China. His view is that bees are found all over China, yet they did not receive the attention they deserve, at least until the third century. The limited literature on bees that survives from the third century onwards suggests that honeybees gradually emerged more clearly in their own right, and more positively, in cultural representations. With the spread of printing, there were more works on bees from the tenth century onwards. Professor Pattison is of the view that with increased literature on bees and their relationship with humans and a better understanding of bee behaviour that came with it, we began to have a clearer picture about bees before contact with Western apicultural science at the end of the nineteenth century.

Beijing opera

There are regional operas all over China. It is not possible, in the space of this volume, to cover even most, not least all, of them. We introduce three regional operas to readers of this encyclopedia: Beijing opera, *Kun* opera, and Cantonese opera. We start with *jingju*, or Beijing opera. This topic is written by Professor Li Ruru, Professor of Chinese Theatre Studies in the School of Languages, Cultures and Societies at the University of Leeds and a renowned scholar on Chinese theatre. Of the four recent books that Professor Li authored or edited, *The Soul of Beijing Opera: Theatrical Creativity and Continuity in the Changing World* (2016) is most relevant to the topic that she wrote for this encyclopedia. Professor Li believes that *jingju* is one of the most important genres in *xiqu* (the traditional/indigenous Chinese song-dance theatre), which consists of over 300 regional theatres. The importance of *jingju* is due both to its sophisticated formation in Beijing in the nineteenth century and its capability of absorbing and digesting the nutrients from other theatres and artistic forms. *Jingju* has therefore become an amalgamation of Chinese culture, epitomizing features of poetry, storytelling, painting, dance, and martial arts. This chapter discusses the audiences' impressions of this theatre, main features of the genre, its position in the traditional Chinese culture, and current status of *jingju* to provide a general review of *jingju* and its relationship with the traditional Chinese culture. In the view of Professor Li, *jingju* has actively responded to the conflicts and challenges of the external world as well as within the genre.

Boat building

Building boats and ships is fundamental to a country. The work of boat building or ship building is usually done at seaports, such as Dalian in China. The topic of boat building in this volume is authored by two scholars from Dalian Maritime University, Professor Liu Yingchun and Professor Han Qing. Their chapter is a survey of boat and ship building in traditional China up to the Ming dynasty. In their view, China in the traditional times led the world in boat/ship building. This is very much in evidence when we look at the development from the building of the raft or canoe by primitive people to the building of large ocean-going civilian ships and warships up till the Ming dynasty (1366–1644). The Chinese craftsmen have been diligent in improving boat/ship building techniques and have therefore created a good variety of boats and ships. The development of boat/ship building and nautical science in China has made a great contribution to the boat/ship building sector and shipping industry in the world. The ocean-going voyages by the great Chinese mariner Zheng He had set a good example for his peers in China and the rest of the world to follow.

Buddhism

Buddhism was introduced to China during the Eastern Han dynasty and has since become a major religion in China. Many people in China are Buddhists and Buddhist rituals are performed at many occasions in the country. Professor Xue Yu, who is Professor at the Department of Philosophy of East China Normal University and Research Fellow of The Chinese University of Hong Kong, writes on Buddhism from a historical perspective and he examines how Buddhism influenced and reshaped features of Chinese culture. He is of the view that the meeting of Buddhism and Chinese culture in the turn of the first century was one of the great wonders in the history of world civilization. The subsequent spread of Buddhism in China not only enriched the contents of Chinese civilization but also changed the course of the development of culture and philosophy, as well as society in China. Buddhism not only transformed China but had also transformed Confucianism and Daoism. This chapter first briefly introduces the history of Chinese Buddhism and then examines major features of culture which were deeply influenced or rather shaped by Buddhism.

Calligraphy

Chinese calligraphy, like Chinese painting, is an art that has been practised in China since the time of oracle bones, about 3,600 years ago. This chapter on Chinese calligraphy in traditional China is written by Professor Xu Yangsheng, President of The Chinese University of Hong Kong, Shenzhen, and Professor Chan Sin-wai, Dean of the School of Humanities and Languages, Caritas Institute of Higher Education, Hong Kong. Professor Xu is a well-known calligrapher whereas Professor Chan is a lover of Chinese calligraphy. Together, they completed this chapter on calligraphy. In this chapter, they examine the components of calligraphic creation, different styles of calligraphy, the evolution of different scripts, tools for calligraphy, techniques of calligraphy, evaluation and appreciation of Chinese calligraphy, and notable calligraphers through the dynasties, including Wang Xizhi, Mi Fu, and Zhao Mengfu. They conclude that calligraphy is the quintessence of art in China. What is noteworthy is that this chapter contains eleven calligraphic works by Professor Xu.

Cantonese culture

This chapter, authored by Professor Chan Sin-wai, explores the Cantonese culture through its dialect, mainly through its folk sayings. Cantonese is the major dialect in the southern part of China, with around 59 million speakers in 2017. Cantonese culture, as is the case with many other cultures, is best shown in the

folk sayings, which reflect to a great extent the life philosophy of the Cantonese people. Cantonese folk sayings include three major types: idioms, common sayings, and end-clippers. Cantonese culture is studied through folk sayings from two major perspectives: topics relating to the body and topics unrelated to the body. The aim of this chapter is therefore to show that language and culture are two sides of the same coin.

Cantonese opera

This chapter is the second piece of work on regional operas in China. Professor Chan Sau-yan, a leading expert on Cantonese opera with twenty academic books to his name, is formerly of the Department of Music, The Chinese University of Hong Kong. This chapter describes the evolution of Cantonese opera in Hong Kong and Guangzhou in terms of its music, repertoire, artists, and related government policies and considers the aspects of performance, research and education, film production, and sound records of the Cantonese opera. According to Professor Chan, Cantonese opera was the most popular form of performing art in the Pearl River Delta, Guangzhou, Hong Kong, and Guangxi. Since the 1950s, Cantonese opera in Guangzhou has been tied to the political ebbs and flows of the Mainland. In Hong Kong, Cantonese opera had its ups and downs from the 1940s to 1997. It suffered a setback from 1942 to 1945 due to Japanese occupation, renewed its vitality in the 1950s, endured a decline from the 1960s to 1980s, but flourished again from 1992 to 1997. The future of Cantonese opera lies with a transformation of the genre into a refined art form and a better artist education and training to its practitioners.

Chinese sayings and quotes

Professor Chan Sin-wai, based on his work *A dictionary of Chinese popular sayings and famous quotes*, contributes a chapter on the topic of Chinese culture in popular sayings and famous quotes. To him, Chinese culture can be reflected, to a great extent, by Chinese popular sayings and famous quotes as it is generally acknowledged that the richness and beauty in the popular sayings and famous quotes in Chinese literature and culture are most representative of the mind and spirit of the Chinese people. Sayings and quotes are used by people of all walks of life in China as a common way to express themselves with a kind of flavour. In the long history of Chinese civilization, a huge amount of sayings and quotes have been created by different people in different ages and by different authors in different genres of writings. The 417 topics and 6,441 entries in the dictionary provide an adequate basis to reveal how the Chinese people live, behave, think, and do things.

Chinese painting

Chinese painting is a popular subject in any book on Chinese culture as it is generally considered as a unique art spectrum in the realm of world arts. This topic is authored by Professor Tang Hoi-chiu, formerly Chief Curator of the Hong Kong Museum of Art and currently Adjunct Professor of the Academy of Visual Arts, Hong Kong Baptist University.

In this chapter, Professor Tang discusses the development of Chinese painting in mainland China and Hong Kong. In the context of China, Chinese painting has a history of over 2,000 years, evolving from the Warring States period (475–221 BCE) to the present. In a local context, the history of Hong Kong ink painting is short, just over 100 years. Yet Hong Kong has many talented painters. In the early twentieth century, influential masters of the Lingnan School of Painting were dominant. In the 1960s and 1970s, the masters Lu Shoukun and Liu Guosong pioneered the new and modern ink painting movements imbued with fresh directions of technical and conceptual visions that reshaped Chinese ink art. It can be observed that since the 1970s, while painters from the mainland continued to come and bring new ideas to transform tradition, local-born artists attempted to inject Hong Kong identity into their paintings.

Confucianism

Anyone interested in Chinese philosophy understands how important it is to know Confucianism, the dominant school of thought in China. Dr Cheung Yu-kit, who teaches translation at Hong Kong Lingnan University, is an expert on Confucianism and has contributed a chapter on it. This chapter represents a somewhat novel approach to a systematic understanding of the core values of Confucianism. It seeks to explore the enduring concepts and virtues of the Confucian ethos not only in their own right with reference to the Confucian canon, but also in relation to its *summum bonum* "*an* 安", roughly meaning "peace". Solid and substantial evidence will be drawn from the "Thirteen Classics" and relevant Confucian works such as the *Xunzi*. Chinese etymological and philological methods, together with analysis of Chinese culture, will be called upon where necessary. His chapter is divided into two parts. Part A is a thorough elucidation of the *summum bonum "an"*. Part B seeks to address how this fundamental goal in Confucianism can be achieved via the time-honoured concepts, which fall broadly into two groups. The first enjoys universality in application, including prescience, timing, position, and the optimal way. The second is more specific, concentrating on the moral subjectivity of mankind and all Confucian moral virtues. Five of them have been singled out for in-depth analysis: *ren*, rightness, rituals and the proprieties, learning, and moral discretion.

Whilst the same subject matter has been dealt with from richly varied perspectives in a plethora of works in both Chinese and English, this chapter is original in its emphasis on how the Confucian concepts and virtues covered relate to the *summum bonum "an"*. It is hoped that the present chapter will enable the reader to get to grips with the subject matter and provide them with a solid basis for further reading and research, serving a complementary role to the existing literature, not least Hall and Ames (1987) and Ames (2011).

Education

This chapter on education in traditional China is authored by Professor Thomas H.C. Lee, Chair Professor Emeritus of National Tsinghua University in Taiwan and Professor Emeritus of The City College of New York in the United States. According to Professor Lee, education in China has a long history, tracing back to Confucius, who was the first scholar to articulate on formal education. He argues that "education is for one's self" (*xue yi weiji*) is the fundamental maxim of China's traditional education, that it is its best characterization, and an often-used *raison d'etre* and pretext. This chapter is a summary of the historical development of education in China, from about 1000 BCE to the early Qing dynasty (1661–1911), discussing the main institutional development, especially its government schools. It discusses the leading trends of classical learning, its changing contents through time, and how it became the standard of the civil service examinations (*keju*) which was the primary mechanism to recruit government officials (605–1905 CE). This chapter also briefly presents how and whether the civil service examination system affected the social structure and its channel of social mobility. It also discusses the more widely used primers and elementary readers through Chinese history, and how they were composed and developed to respond to changing intellectual concerns. The development of "privately" organized or established academies (*shuyuan*) are also presented as yet another manifestation of the educational belief in the rectitude of a person's moral self. The major trends of educational thinking are selectively discussed to demonstrate how education in traditional China was understood and defined. Finally, this chapter discusses the process in which elitist education and selection for government service gradually transformed after the rise of the Ming dynasty (1368–1661) to a more commoner-focused orientation and how it was couched in purportedly egalitarian terms, in that the ultimate purpose of education was now informed by a conviction that education should be universal, and that the educated must consider "education" so as to know broadly, and to be "concerned with everything (affair) under Heaven" (*shishi guanxin*).

Eight characters and fortune-telling

Fortune-telling is so fascinating that this volume has two chapters on it. One by Li Chao, author of this chapter, and the other by Richard Smith. But they differ in approach and emphasis. Dr Li Chao, an engineer by vocation, is a devoted believer of fortune-telling. Li in the chapter points out that the newly educated generation since the early-twentieth century generally regard fortune-telling as superstitious and unfounded. This, however, is a misconception as Chinese fortune-telling goes much beyond superstition with deep roots in Chinese philosophy and a long tradition among Chinese intellectuals. Fortune-telling is an art as it is based on a clear logical structure. This chapter focuses on a mainstream fortune-telling method, which is often called *eight characters* 八字 or *four pillars* 四柱. This chapter demonstrates the complicated context of fortune-telling in Chinese culture by using the method of separating the objective and subjective parts of *eight characters* to study their philosophical background.

Embroidery

Ms Margaret Lee is an expert on embroidery. In this chapter on embroidery, she focuses on embroidery as a generic theme. In her view, every culture in the world has some form of embroidery in their history, but the role played by embroidery in Chinese culture is far more visible and significant than it plays in other cultures. Embroidery has a long history in China, tracing back to the Neolithic period. Embroidery in China has continued to play a role that permeated into every aspect of the Chinese society, and with the passage of time, it has developed from the role of decoration to the status of fine art. Other roles that embroidery plays are numerous. It is a political tool in the form of gifts to fortify political ideology, a status symbol for the imperial family and aristocracy, a decoration for furnishings of daily life, an expression of personal aspirations and feelings, and a tool for the fortification of social and political ideals.

Fortune-telling

This chapter on fortune-telling, which is drastically different from the one written by Dr Li Chao, is authored by Professor Richard Smith, George and Nancy Rupp Professor of Humanities emeritus at Rice University. According to Professor Smith, divination played an important role in Chinese history for more than 3,000 years. It was deeply embedded in social and political institutions, closely related to Chinese culture heroes, essential to a wide variety of state and domestic rituals and linked to such seemingly diverse areas of Chinese life as science, technology, military affairs, music and medicine. Virtually everyone in pre-modern China believed in divination, elites and commoners alike. The question was therefore not whether to believe in it, but whom to believe. Criticisms of fortune-tellers focused primarily on those who divined for profit, or those who used questionable methods, not on the fundamental cosmological assumptions of divination itself.

This chapter traces the general evolution of fortune-telling in pre-modern China, giving particular attention to the following overlapping practices: (1) astrology, numerology and fate extrapolation, (2) divination by lots, (3) dream interpretation, (4) geomancy, (5) the interpretation of written characters, (6) meteorological divination, (7) the use of oracle bones and prophetic texts, (8) physiognomy, (9) the selection of auspicious dates and times, and (10) shamanism and spirit-writing.

Gongfu

One of the most popular transliterated terms from Chinese known by the English-speaking public is *gongfu*, or Chinese martial arts. This chapter on *gongfu*, entitled "*Gongfu*: *Rouquan* – A Mysterious School of Chinese Martial Arts", is jointly authored by Mr Devin Tam, Dr Wang Ling, and Mr Zhang Yaoting.

Gongfu is generally known as a physical, mental, and spiritual exercise with a history of thousands of years. Though it originated from the battles in primitive times and the art of attack and defense is considered as one of the fundamental characteristics of martial arts, the real spirit of Chinese martial arts is not to fight others or self-defence, but to seek for peace, in particular inner peace, as it is a mind-body exercise aiming at an uninterrupted tranquility and serenity of the soul advocated by Daoism. *Rouquan* 柔拳 (soft school boxing) in this chapter refers to a mysterious school of Chinese martial arts which observes the abovementioned ideals and principles. *Rouquan* is therefore a specially coined term for the purpose of disambiguation and clarification, referring to any school of *gongfu* which could subdue the opponents without causing any harm to the body.

The learning of the Yellow Emperor and Laozi on *yin-yang* and the cultivation of *qi* in Daoism exert great influence in the development of *Rouquan*. The training of *liangyiquan* as the representative of *Rouquan* focuses on cultivating and circulating *qi* in preparation for real combat along the twelve main meridians and two extraordinary meridians *renmai* and *dumai* and thirty-six lethal acupoints with them. By seemingly magical wielding of the power of *qi* to attack the opponent's acupoints, a *Rouquan* master subdues the opponent without causing any harm to the skin, skeleton or internal organs. In this way, *Rouquan* fulfils the ideal of martial arts of *zhige* 止戈, or the end of war and the search for peace.

Handicraft

Handicraft in China is co-authored by Professor Wang Haiyan and Professor Liu Yingchun, both of Dalian Maritime University in China. This chapter on handicraft in China briefly introduces the achievements made in the six major sub-branches of handicraft, namely the making of paper, carts, yeast, casting, forging, and ceramics. In their view, handicraft in China was well-developed in traditional China and it used to lead the world. It is hoped that handicraft could continue to flourish into the future.

Kun opera

The chapter on *Kunqu*, or *Kun* opera, is written by Professor Lindy Li Mark, Emeritas Professor of Anthropology and East Asian Studies at California State University in the United States. Professor Mark has conducted extensive research on *Kun* opera. Her chapter on this genre of opera is entitled "Some Mysteries of Kunqu Music and Its Melodic Characteristics", which is a detailed study of the evolution of *Kun* opera in China and she intends to offer suggestions to improve the genre as played in China.

According to Professor Mark, Kunqu opera (also Kunqu, Kunju) is the general appellation for two types of literary operas: Nanqu, or southern drama: a genre of long cyclical music drama composed of scores of scenes. Musically, Nanqu is primarily in five-tone modes (black keys on the piano); but some scenes may be scored in seven-tone modes (white keys on the piano).

Beiqu, or northern drama: within the general Kunqu opera repertoire are a smaller number of operas and scenes from another genre known as *beiqu* 北曲, or northern opera scored primarily in seven-tone modes. Northern operas are shorter, usually consisting of four acts or scenes; and in some instances, an added transitional or introductory scene. Although differing greatly in length, the structure of scenes within an opera is similar.

Each scene is composed of: (1) spoken dialog in several dialects; (2) recitation of classical poetry in *shi* 詩, or *ci* 詞 forms; (3) singing of *qu* 曲 poetry; and (4) dance pantomime in elaborate make-up and costumes. Kunqu opera is arguably the oldest Chinese drama in continuous performance since the sixteenth century. Poetry and singing are the twin pillars of the genre, which are accompanied by instrumental ensembles of melodic and percussion instruments. On stage, singing and dialog is performed with dance-like movements by actors and actresses wearing beautifully embroidered costumes. They appear in elaborate role-specific facial make-up, headdresses, and beautiful costumes. Kunqu opera is a feast for the eyes, ears, and *mind*.

Leisure culture

We all know that leisure is a very important part of our life. We cannot live without leisure. The significance of leisure to the Chinese people is examined by Professor Ma Huidi, Director and Distinguished Research Fellow at the Center for China Leisure Studies of the Chinese Academy of Arts, who has published a number of books on leisure culture in China, including her recent publication, *Traditional Chinese Leisure Culture and Economic Development* (2017). According to Professor Ma and her co-author Professor Li Er, leisure, or *xiuxian* (休閒) in Chinese, can be examined etymologically. The character *xiu* (休) means quietude and *xian* (閒), rectitude. The Chinese people in the old days cultivated the virtues of benevolence, righteousness, courtesy, wisdom, faithfulness, cordiality, kindness, respectfulness, frugality, and humility through quietude and rectitude. Leisure has had a great impact on the philosophical ideas, spiritual outlook, life aesthetics, and political institutions of traditional China. They conclude that China's cultural history is in fact a history of leisure culture.

Shadow play

Chinese shadow play is a traditional opera folk art in China. This form of art is fully explained by Professor Li Jie of the Foreign Languages College of Northeastern University in China. This chapter introduces Chinese shadow play through its cultural values, historical development, craftsmanship in puppet making, art of puppet design, art of performance, features of some local schools, and its current situation. According to Professor Li, Chinese shadow play incorporates the artistic elements of a variety of traditional Chinese art forms and has been popular among people of all walks of life for thousands of years. The shadow puppets manipulated by an artist behind a screen perform with flexible actions, lifelike expressions, and rich emotions, telling about people's weal and woe, life and death. Its content unfolds a panorama of Chinese people's daily life, beliefs, pursuits, traditions, and customs as well as social outlooks in different periods, providing a wealth of resources for Chinese folklore and cultural studies. The magic and complicated process of making shadow puppets is the best manifestation of the superb craftsmanship of traditional Chinese artisans. The two-dimensional shadow puppets, including characters, props, and stage settings, are elaborate in design and handicraft and have been cherished as artistic treasures for aesthetic appreciation, art collection, and academic and cultural studies. In shadow play performances, the vivid and lively shadow puppets on the screen, the portrayal of a complete series of Chinese dramatic roles, the speaking and singing with strong local flavours, and the accompaniment by musical instruments with distinctive Chinese characteristics altogether present to spectators a grand audio-visual feast.

Taijiquan

Taijiquan has been practised in China for a long time. Professor Kit Chunyu of the Department of Linguistics and Translation, City University of Hong Kong, is himself a leading expert and practitioner of the Water Taiji School. In the view of Professor Kit, *taijiquan*, which has evolved from ancient Chinese martial arts under the guidance of *taiji* theory, has become not only one of the most popular and the most influential exercises in the world but also one of the most representative symbols for Chinese culture. This chapter presents *taijiquan* as a unique living embodiment of Chinese philosophy that is rooted in the *taiji* theory, which takes *yin*, *yang,* and five agents as cornerstone notions. After introducing the fundamentals of the *taiji* theory that underlies all schools of ancient Chinese philosophy, Professor Kit points out for the very first time that *taijiquan* is an exercise of martial arts to cultivate practitioners' sensation of *taiji* principles, and summarize the essentials, with many untold tips and secrets, in *taijiquan* practice, teaching, and learning in a systematic way that unifies the key notions in the *taijquan* canons as instantiations of *yin* and *yang* in various dimensions. This chapter helps readers to understand the importance of *taiji* philosophy in guiding

taijiquan practice and that of the mastery of *taijjiquan* in resolving typical puzzles in philosophical thinking under the name of *taiji*.

Conclusion

It can be seen from the preceding that Chinese culture has a long history with many aspects that deserve exploration and examination. Due to space limitation and time constraints, we have not been able to cover as many topics as we have planned. But as a Chinese proverb says: "A journey of a thousand miles begins with the first step". We have begun our journey of exploration into Chinese culture in a small way, and we hope that we will be able to do more and better in the future, bringing Chinese culture closer to the world at large, and the English-reading public in particular.

1
ARCHITECTURE IN TRADITIONAL CHINA

Nancy S. Steinhardt

Introduction

Architecture stands across the nearly ten million square kilometres of land on the eastern side of the Asian continent that today comprises China. Above ground, buildings remain from the earliest centuries CE; the archaeological record of Chinese architecture is more than five millennia older. China's major building materials through the entire period have been wood, brick, and stone. From group settlements to multiple-walled urban centres, whether royal or vernacular, religious or secular, public or private, China's built environment has been erected almost exclusively by craftsmen and artisans. Chinese architecture is distinguished from buildings worldwide by the length and consistency of its building tradition and so few architects whose names are associated with it.

Wood joinery and the timber frame that is achieved are defining features of Chinese architecture. The interlocking network of vertical, horizontal, and sometimes diagonal or curved wooden members is the result of a modular system whereby the measurement of almost any piece can be calculated from the dimensions of another piece. Modular construction means that from individual components such as pillars to entire planar sections of a building, all can be replicated, increased, decreased, repositioned, or eliminated to change a temple into a palace, a shrine into a house, or a humble dwelling into a lavish family compound. The proportional relationships make it possible to repair or replace damaged parts and to assemble a building in the style of the distant past.

The wooden pieces of a standard Chinese building divide into three layers: the column network, the bracket set layer, and the roof frame. Below and above these three wooden networks, buildings are made of other materials. The base of a Chinese building, the part that interfaces wood above it and earth below, is made of non-rotting material; expensive stone such as marble for an eminent structure, brick for a more humble one, and rammed earth when funds are limited. Only rarely are columns implanted directly into the ground. In more expensive buildings, columns are placed in pilasters rather than directly into a podium. Outside, the building presents as base, structure, and roof. The roof is a defining feature of Chinese architecture. Usually made of ceramic tile, glazed for more important buildings, it is one of the silent symbols that identify the status of the building. The simple, hipped roof covers China's most eminent buildings, followed in status by the hip-gable roof, with overhanging eaves of yet lower status. The main ridge of any of them may be decorated, adding to its status.

The arrangement of Chinese buildings in space similarly exhibits continuity over millennia. The horizontal axis is primary. It is usually north–south and the most important buildings are positioned on it.

Spatial magnitude is expressed by longer and longer lines of buildings along horizontal planes, not vertically, for space requires ownership of land; someone with wealth expands one-storey buildings across more and more space. Even China's most important buildings, including the Hall of Supreme Harmony in the Forbidden City, are only one storey. The height of columns across the front façade of the Hall of Supreme Harmony is about 8.43 metres, a mere five times the height of a man.

Chinese buildings are positioned around courtyards according to a principle known as four-sided enclosure. When only three sides of a courtyard have buildings, the principle is called three-sided enclosure, for the fourth side is implied. South, the orientation of the Forbidden City, is the cardinal direction. Every courtyard has one most important structure. Almost every courtyard and building complex is entered through a gate. Gates are so important that in rare cases of a single building, it is never in total isolation because a gate is in front of it. The gate is psychological as much as physical. Like the enclosing space to which a gate may join, it marks the boundary between more sanctified or imperial space behind and the profane world outside it.

A final feature distinguishes the Chinese building tradition from all others. Upon the establishment of the People's Republic on 1 October 1949, archaeology became a state-sponsored enterprise. Since then, the history of Chinese architecture has been written through physical evidence above and below ground.

China's earliest architecture

The physical evidence of cities in China is earlier than evidence of individual buildings, probably because buildings were made of perishable materials whereas city walls were constructed of rammed earth. Urbanism in China began by the sixth millennium BCE. For the next four millennia, the evidence is primarily archaeological, with a wall defining a city. This physical definition is reflected in the translation of the Chinese character *cheng* as both wall and city. When a wall is found, Chinese archaeologists assume it signifies a group settlement. At least one wall, at Pingliangtai in Henan, was squarish, about 185 metres on each side. The square is an ideal shape that would be associated with Chinese cities through history.

Much of China's earliest architecture developed along major rivers. If we believe texts, the earliest Chinese residences were below ground in the form of cave dwellings and elevated aboveground on wooden stilts. Evidence for both types has been found from the Neolithic period (ca. 6000–2000 BCE) along China's two major rivers: semi-subterranean dwellings along the Yellow River in the North and stilted houses near the Yangzi River (Changjiang) in the south. The southern site Hemudu in Yuyao county, Zhejiang, preserves evidence of timber-framing, including both straight posts for raising a structure above swampland and interlocking wooden pieces. Dadiwan in Gansu province of western China had two structures joined by an arcade. One of the largest Neolithic sites is at Banpo, due east of the modern city Xi'an, where it is expected that size of ruins will be sixty square kilometres. Banpo had circular and four-sided dwellings, drainage ditches, and a large structure known as the Great House that may have been used for ceremonies.

Ceremonial architecture is also believed to have been included in Neolithic villages in southeastern and northeastern China. Altars dated ca. late fifth to early third millennium BCE have been found at Yuhang in Zhejiang and in Liaoning. The Liaoning remains, examples of the Neolithic culture known as Hongshan, include stone-covered tombs and stone altars. The largest Neolithic walled city excavated to date is at Shimao in Shaanxi province. Heavily fortified with corners towers, it was about four kilometres square.

By the second millennium BCE, capital city and palace building were underway in China. The city at Erlitou dates ca. 1900–ca. 1500 BCE. At its peak the population was as high as 30,000. So was royal necropolis construction. According to tradition, the dynasty Shang (ca. 1600–1046 BCE) ruled from seven capitals. An early one, whose ruins lie beneath the modern city Zhengzhou in Henan province, had a wall nearly seven kilometres in perimeter. Another Shang city was at Shixianggou, in Yanshi, near Erlitou. The last Shang capital, at today's Anyang, also in Henan, had a royal cemetery with the graves of at least eleven Shang kings and more than 1,400 subsidiary burials (Figure 1.1).

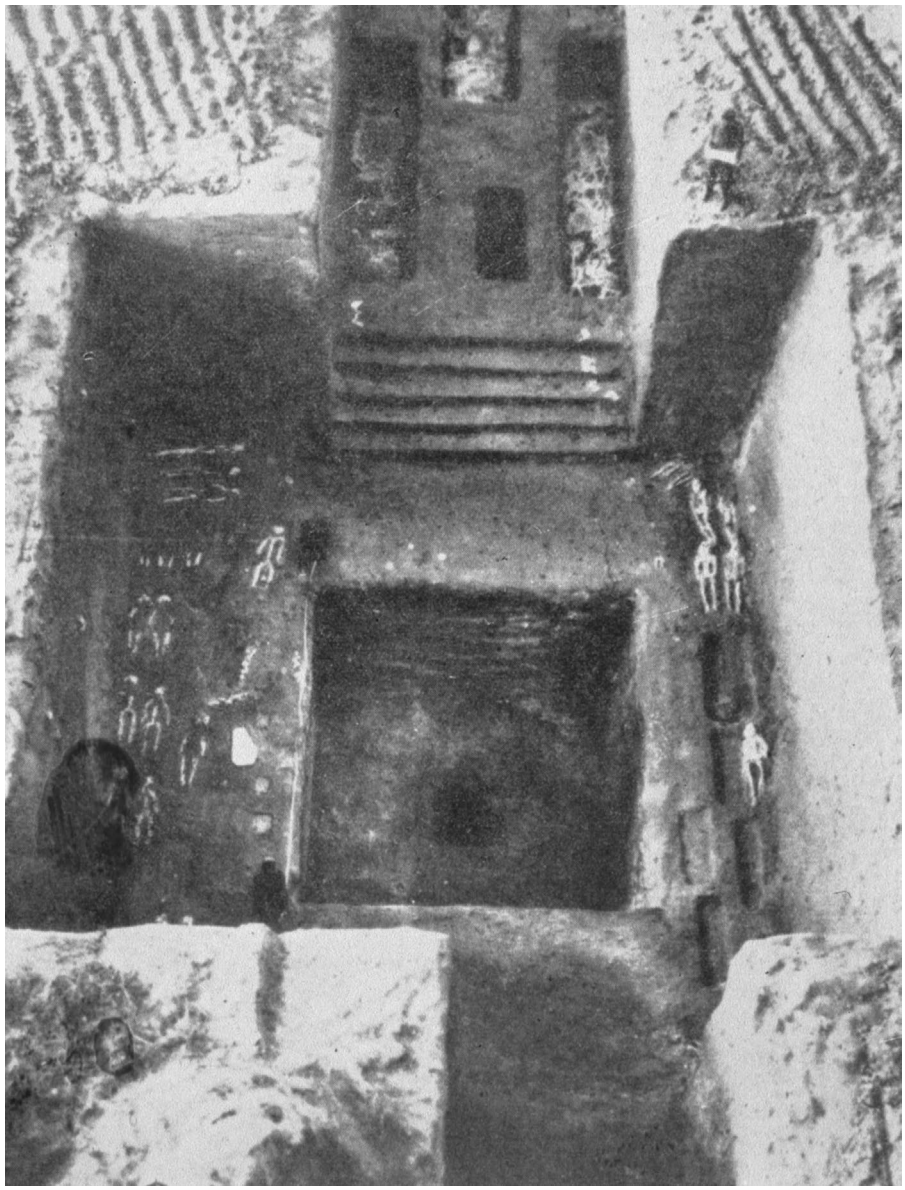

Figure 1.1 Royal Tomb No. 1001, cemetery at Anyang, ca. thirteenth century BCE
Source: Public domain

Sacrificial victims were found in the subsidiary burials as well as in the royal tombs. Anyang included the grave of the female warrior Lady Hao. Every Shang capital had palaces enclosed by walls or arcades on four sides and workshops for the production of bronze vessels and other crafts.

The first millennium BCE witnessed an unprecedented burst of city building in China. Although the Zhou dynasty (1046–221 BCE) had two primary capitals, one at Chang'an from 1046–770 and one in Luoyang from 770–221, every ruler aspired to control a state, and every state needed a capital. Among the

hundreds of excavated Zhou cities, several patterns of urbanism dominate. Each would persist for several millennia. Most important is the designation of a walled area distinct from the rest of the city for the imperial palace. A central palace-city, with an outer wall approximately equidistant from its four faces, follows the description of a ruler's city (*wangcheng*) in the contemporary text, *Rituals of Zhou*. Qufu, in Shandong province, where Confucius was born in 551 BCE, was of this plan. An alternate pattern had the ruler's palace area in the north centre of the outer wall. Most common were double cities, two adjacent walled enclosures positioned north and south, east and west, or at the corners of each other.

Before their conquest of Shang, the Zhou royal family lived in Zhouyuan (plain of Zhou), a fifteen-square-kilometre site in Shaanxi province about 140 kilometres west of Xi'an near the modern city of Baoji. The building complex in Fengchu, Qishan, was 32.5 metres east-west by 43.5 metres north-to-south. Excavation confirms that building complexes were designed around courtyards and that their principal buildings were arranged in straight lines or in the shape of a U. The complex was announced by a screen wall. The main central hall was approached by three sets of stairs. Important buildings were elevated on platforms and their entries were marked by free-standing gates. Shaochen in Shaanxi, about twenty-five kilometres southeast of Fengchu, has yielded fifteen building foundations that date from ca. the eleventh century to late in the Western Zhou period. All buildings were supported by timber frames and elevated on earthen platforms. One building was seven-by-three bays with an almost complete grid of columns whose roof was framed by a main ridge and four additional ridges that emanated from its two ends. Another building was eight-by-three bays and had an entry on one of the shorter sides. The Shaochen site also indicates the use of horizontal bay frames that run from the front to the back of the building. A foundation at Majiazhuang, (about twenty-five kilometres northwest of Fengchu) comprised five courtyards along a 326.5-metre roughly north–south line, each entered by a south central gate, each with at least one gate on the east, and three courtyards with one or more western gates.

Chu, the largest Eastern Zhou state, has yielded more than 5,000 tombs. Royal tombs have approach ramps, stepped sides, and a coffin pit at the centre. They are simpler than tombs of the late Shang rulers in Anyang. The tomb of Marquis Yi of Zeng, who died in 433 BCE, is one the most important Warring States tombs. Located in Sui county of Hubei, the subterranean tomb was divided into four compartments, each lined with wooden planks and each connected to adjacent sections by four-sided tunnels. It is a pit tomb with no approach ramp. Space between rooms was sealed by charcoal and other materials. The tomb is best known for the set of sixty-five bronze bells weighing about two-and-a-half tons. Another extremely important late-fourth-century BCE tomb belongs to King Cuo (r. 327–313 BCE) who was buried in a necropolis with close relatives. Burials were beneath truncated pyramidal mounds, his 100.5 by ninety metres at the base and eighteen metres square at the top. A funerary hall was on top of the mound. A bronze plate of ninety-four by forty-eight centimetres and about one centimetre thick inside the tomb had a plan of the burial precinct inlaid with gold on the obverse side. The representation of three-dimensional space in two dimensions in the third century BCE is extraordinary anywhere in the world; the use of scale on this plate is more amazing. Perhaps even more important is the forty-two-character directive on the plate that there be two copies, one for the palace and this one buried with the ruler so that future generations would know how to construct a tomb in the manner of their ancestors. One infers that the patterns of antiquity were to be followed, or more explicitly, that the intent of royal architecture was to model itself after its past and to be continued in the same manner in the future.

Architecture of China's first empires

Between 230 and 221 BCE, the remaining six warring states fell to Prince Zheng (259–210 BCE) of the state of Qin who declared himself Shi Huangdi, First Emperor, and founded the Qin dynasty (221–206 BCE) in 221. As he conquered, he built imitations of the palaces of the toppled states in his new capital north of today's Xi'an in Shaanxi province. He also built new, larger palaces. By the early twenty-first century,

foundations of four palaces had been excavated. Evidence is strong that at least one of them had two-storey architecture. The First Emperor's greatest achievement in palatial architecture was Epang Palace. Its remains are about fifteen kilometres west of Xi'an.

The concept of a travelling palace (*xinggong*) also blossomed under the First Emperor. He used travelling palaces in the manner they would be used by emperors for the rest of Chinese history: during inspection tours to demonstrate and consolidate his power, he inscribed rocks and erected buildings at sacred and strategic sites en route.

No single tomb in China has aroused as much interest or has been excavated or studied as intensely as the First Emperor's. It is believed that 700,000 men laboured there and that 16,000 men carried away 42,000 tons of earth that was supplied by 200 diggers over a period of 300 days. Only the squarish mound, approximately 350 metres on each side, is above ground. The underground mausoleum was begun in 246 BCE when Prince Zheng became king of Qin. It was the central focus of a double-walled funerary precinct, the outer wall 6.21 kilometres in perimetre with a gate in each face and the inner wall 3.87 kilometres in perimetre with two north gates and one at each of the other sides. The underground areas were numbered as they were opened. Pits 1 through 3 contained more than 7,000 life-size warriors. Other pits contain small numbers of terra cotta officials, weapons, tools, stone armor and helmets, a 212-kilogram bronze tripod, and cranes and other bronze birds. The First Emperor's own burial chamber has not been entered, perhaps because of the mercury (or cinnabar) historical accounts say was used to preserve his corpse.

The city of Chang'an, capital of the Western Han (206 BCE – 9 CE), was south of the Wei River and the First Emperor's capital. With an irregularly shaped outer wall that pre-modern Chinese historians explain as resembling the combined form of the Big and Little Dippers, the Han capital had six large palatial complexes, two main markets, an arsenal and limited residential space. Three of the palaces have been extensively excavated. The second Han capital, however, in Luoyang, of the Eastern Han (23–220 CE), had only two palace areas, only one of which was the primary residence at any given time. Both capitals had at least one major thoroughfare that crossed from a northern to a southern or an eastern to a western wall gate, and other wide roads that were blocked only by the location of a palace. South of the emperor's palace were building complexes where he or his officials performed state rituals. Building foundations believed to be Han ritual buildings have been excavated south of Han Chang'an. They are identified as Mingtang (Numimous Hall), Biyong (Jade-ring Moat), Lingtai (Spirit Altar), Taixue (Imperial Academy), Jiumiao (Nine Temples), Yuanqiu (Round Mound), and a pair of altars or temples for sacrifices to soil and grain.

Mingtang is the most intriguing ancient Chinese ritual structure. The configuration of rooms of the Mingtang and their symbolism are debated to this day; theoretical reconstructions group rooms in fours, fives, nines, and twelves and include sections with circular and square ground plans, the circle representing heaven and the square representing earth. One set of remains has been proposed as a composite ritual structure in which the functions of Mingtang, Biyong, and Lingtai were performed.

The tombs of eleven Western Han emperors are within thirty kilometres of the Chang'an palaces, nine north of the capital and two to the southeast. Each imperial tomb consisted of four parts: the mounds, one for the emperor and a smaller one for the empress, located within a funerary precinct that may have been walled; aboveground ritual halls; the funerary city where workers lived during tomb construction and where tomb caretakers continued to reside after imperial interment; and auxiliary tombs that could include burial plots awarded to officials for service to the emperor and servant/slave tombs. Sacrificial burial had terminated by this time.

Changling, tomb complex of the Han founding emperor, who died in 195 BCE and his empress, who died in 180 BCE, was the hub of all subsequent Western Han imperial burials. Its funerary precinct was 3.12 kilometres in perimetre. Yangjiawan tomb 4 is a large auxiliary tomb to the east. Baling, tomb of the third Han emperor, is carved directly into natural rock. Yangling, tomb of the fourth Han emperor who reigned from 188–141 BCE, has received tremendous attention since the 1990s when hundreds of naked figurines (possibly originally clothed with perishable materials) were excavated in pits adjacent to the tumuli.

Maoling, tomb of Western Han's most famous emperor, Wudi (156–87 BCE), has not been excavated. It is renowned because of the auxiliary tomb approximately two kilometres to the east, awarded by Wudi to his young military officer Huo Qubing in 117 BCE, for Huo's valor. The statue, Horse Trampling the Barbarian, in front, became a symbol of China's triumph over the threat of foreign peoples. No tombs of Eastern Han emperors north of Luoyang have been excavated.

Thousands of non-royal tombs have been excavated from the four Han centuries. From them, one observes the evolution from simple, earthen pit tombs such as the one excavated at Mawangdui in Hunan province to tombs with ten or more chambers whose walls were made of small, solid bricks and covered with paintings. Tombs made of large, hollow, and stamped bricks survive in the Luoyang region from the Eastern Han dynasty. Tombs with murals that portray the occupants in scenes of his life are in Anping, Hebei province, and at Helinge'er in Inner Mongolia. Both mural programs also include architecture, a city wall with a tower in Anping and five walled towns shown both from the side and from the top. The Helinge'er tomb also includes paintings in imitation of timber frames on its walls. Relief sculpture, especially from Henan, Shandong, and Sichuan, also includes images of walled towns and towers. The towers in both paint and relief are images of the few aboveground structural remains from Han China. They are known as *que*, a word usually translated as gate-tower or pillar-tower (Figure 1.2). Stone tombs also remain from the Han dynasty. Important examples are in Xuzhou, Jiangsu province, and in Shandong. Brick relief with architecture has been found in tombs near Chengdu, Sichuan province. Tombs carved into cliffs are also found in Sichuan. Chinese tombs are often considered microcosms of the world outside the tomb. The recreation of life underground often included a sun, moon, and star groups on the ceiling.

Many Han tombs preserve evidence of vaulting, a technique mastered by Han builders. Segmented vaults and barrel vaults were achieved in Han times. Corbel bracketing atop pillars to help support the undersides of ceilings also was accomplished. Bracket sets would identify Chinese architecture for the rest of its history. Han is also the period from which hundreds of miniature buildings with accurate roof tiles and bracket sets survive among burial goods.

Before the end of the Han dynasty, Buddhism had come to China. Buddhist symbols such as the lotus and signs of an awareness of South Asia such as elephants are present in relief in second-century-CE architecture of Han China.

Architecture of four centuries of disunion

Buddhism and non-Chinese rulers dominated the politics, culture, and resulting architecture of China's third through sixth centuries. To construct Buddhist architecture, three South Asian structures had to become part of the Chinese building system. First was the relic mound, or stupa, the symbol of the Buddha and Buddhist death. Stupas of Indian Buddhism were earthen, and later stone, circular structures with egg-shaped domes. Known as pagodas in East Asia, by the time the form appeared in China it was taller, often multi-storied, and often four-sided. Some consider the *que* the dominant Chinese influence on the transformation from stupa to four-sided pagoda. Surely it was one influence, but stupas in southern Xinjiang dated to the third and fourth centuries show the influence of Buddhist architecture from the region of today's Pakistan and Afghanistan that was known as Gandhara in the first CE centuries as well as directly from South Asia. A unique dodecagonal pagoda, dated 523, survives on the sacred, central peak Mount Song in Henan province. The intent may have been to mimic a circle with the straight sides of Chinese construction that made it possible to replicate pillars and bracket sets in brick masonry. Pagodas also appear in the centres and back-centres of Buddhist worship caves in the fifth and sixth centuries. Known as central-pillar-pagoda caves, the pillar-pagodas usually are storeyed. The storeys can be of uniform dimensions from base to roof or may taper inward toward the top. In either variety, imitation ceramic-tile roofs are carved on each storey.

The rock-carved cave-temples in which central-pillar pagodas are sometimes found are the second architectural form that entered China with Indian Buddhism. Known as *chaitya* in Sanskrit, cave-chapels

Figure 1.2 *Que*, originally along approach to tomb of Gao Yi, Ya'an, Sichuan, 209 CE
Source: Steinhardt photograph

are the major repository for extant Buddhist statuary and painting in the four centuries following the Han dynasty. Some of the most famous cave-temple sites were oases on the Silk Roads between China and Central and West Asia, locations trafficked by monks and merchants. Hundreds of grottoes with hundreds of square metres of sculpted and painted surfaces cluster around the Kucha region of Xinjiang and in the Dunhuang oasis in Gansu province. Buddhist cave-temples with architectural relief believed to replicate the period's buildings are found at Maijishan in Gansu, Yungang, near Datong, and in Longmen, just outside

Figure 1.3 Detail, Cave 9, Yungang, Northern Wei

Source: Steinhardt photograph

Luoyang. The majority of Yungang caves date to the second half of the fifth century when Datong was the primary Northern Wei capital. Storeyed pagodas as well as ogee-shaped arches, nicknamed *chaitya* arches because the form is used at cave-temple entrances in India, cover the Yungang walls (Figure 1.3).

Facades and relief sculpture with architectural features of sixth-century China also are found at Tianlongshan, near Taiyuan, in central Shanxi, and at the Xiangtangshan caves in southern Hebei and northern Henan that were carved in the third quarter of the sixth century under Eastern Wei-Northern Qi rule (535–577). Among details associated with the sixth century are bracket sets with three projections known as arms placed above columns; inverted-V-shaped braces positioned on lintels between the three-arm bracket sets; roof eaves supported by two sets of purlins, one on top of the other; and entryways decorated above with pointed, horse-shaped arches.

The third architectural type imported from India is the *vihara*, residential space for the monastic community. In China, the *vihara* transformed into a monastery where resident monks entered stupas, worshipped in front of images in halls, listened to lectures in yet other buildings, and where buildings housed scriptures, towers contained bells and drums that were rung or beaten at specified times and where there were refectories, kitchens, etc. Already in the fourth century halls that housed images became increasingly prominent in Chinese monastery space. Often the pagoda and Buddha hall shared a monastery's focus, often in front of and behind one another on the main building line, enclosed by a covered arcade or wall, and fronted and sometimes backed by a gate. To date archaeological evidence has made it possible to reconstruct monasteries in the major capitals of the centuries of disunion: Datong, Luoyang, Taiyuan, and Ye in the north and Nanjing in the south.

A unique monument was built in in Dingxing county of Hebei in 570 to commemorate the pious deeds of the community in a period of extreme strife. Known as the Pillar of Righteousness, Kindness, and Beneficence (Yicihuizhu), it rises 6.6 metres. A small hall with a hip-gable roof is at the top. Sarcophaguses also are small-scale, detailed evidence of sixth-century halls. The sarcophaguses of Ning Mao who died in

527, Shedi Huoluo who died in the 560s, An Qie who died in 572, and Master Shi who died in 592 present bracket sets with two layers of arms, inverted-V-shaped braces, hip-gable roofs, two sets of roof rafters, and even details as specific as the "suspended fish" (*xuanyu*) that hangs from the top of a gable.

From the more than thirty polities that rose and fell in the kingdoms, states, and dynasties of China's third through sixth centuries, dozens of imperial tombs and countless non-royal tombs have been excavated. Marked by mounds as in past ages, in general the numbers of underground rooms are fewer than in the Han dynasty, but the subjects of relief sculpture and murals are similar.

Architecture of Sui-Tang

The seventh, eighth, and ninth centuries that comprised the short Sui (581–618) and long Tang (618–907) dynasties produced an architectural system that was admired and imitated across East Asia. The Sui-Tang capital was enormous, 84.1 square kilometres. A pounded-earth wall 9.7 by 8.6 kilometres enclosed it. Two walled areas were north and south of each other in the north centre, the palace city and imperial city, where the emperor lived and affairs of government were conducted, respectively. Fourteen outer wall gates were the beginning or terminus of major boulevards that ran through the city, dividing it, together with narrower, parallel streets, into 108 wall-enclosed wards plus two markets. Residential wards were further divided into sixteen districts. The widest of the streets was 220 metres. Each of the major thoroughfares was tree-lined and divided into three lanes, the middle for imperial passage. Peoples from every region of the Asian continent did business in China's Tang capital. Each of their native tongues could be heard and religious institutions representing the faiths of most of their homelands were present in this truly cosmopolitan city.

The Chang'an plan was the dominant influence in imperial city building in China through the duration of the Tang dynasty and in Japan and Korea during the same centuries. The Chinese cities Luoyang and Yangzhou borrowed from this plan, as did P'yŏngyang and Kyŏngju in Korea, five capitals of the Parhae kingdom (698–926) located on the Korean peninsula and Heilongjiang and Jilin in China, and the Japanese cities that are today Nara, Kyoto, Osaka, and Nagaoka. Among them, the Heian-period capital, today Kyoto, built at the end of the eighth century, achieved the most perfect version of the Tang plan.

A trapezoidal-shaped parkland spilled beyond the city to the northeast of Chang'an. Turned into a palace complex in the 630s by the second Tang emperor and renovated by the third, it was named Daminggong. The palace Xingqinggong was in its own ward on the eastern side of Chang'an, a palace with hot springs named Huaqinggong was located east of Chang'an near the Neolithic village Banpo, and the Sui-Tang emperors had a travelling palace Renshougong-Jiuchenggong in Shaanxi. Daminggong is the most extensively excavated. Four parallel sectors occupied 3.11 square kilometres. Hanyuan Hall where grand imperial rites were performed was fifty-eight metres across the front, elevated fifteen metres on a two-layer platform and joined to elevated arcades that projected frontward and joined quadruple-bodied *que*. Linde Hall had a contrasting plan of three halls in a front-to-back line, also with covered arcades that joined two pavilions. Although not every hall of every Tang palace has been excavated, detailed records and drawings incised in stone make it possible to reconstruct the size and location of almost every one.

Eighteen tombs of Tang rulers survive in Shaanxi province. The aboveground mound and statuary of four of them, belonging to Taizong (r. 626–49), Gaozong (r. 649–83) and Empress Wu (r. 690–705), Ruizong (r. 684–690 and 705–10), and Xuanzong (r. 712–56), are almost completely preserved. Beginning with Taizong, it became customary to focus the tomb on a natural mound, approached by a lengthy causeway lined with pairs of monumental stone sculptures known as the spirit path. Fourteen Tang emperors were interred beneath natural formations. Originally aboveground construction at Tang tombs included enclosing walls and numerous structures for sacrifices and storage of goods that might be needed in the afterlife.

Hundreds of other Tang tombs have been excavated, more than 100 of them in Shaanxi province and nearby regions with murals. Underground the tombs are single- or double-chamber. Architecture,

particularly a hall or *que*, are standard subjects above archways and along the walls of diagonal ramps leading into the burial area. Architecture with specific details of the Tang period also is painted in Buddhist cave-temples. Paintings of paradise in Mogao caves at Dunhuang dated to the seventh and eighth centuries depict imperial buildings, for the model for the Buddha in paradise was the emperor in his palace.

Tang is the first period from which a significant number of Buddhist buildings survive. Four wooden halls, two on the sacred Buddhist mountain Wutai and two in villages, remain in Shanxi. Three are of a humble variety. The splendid structure, the East Hall of Foguang Monastery, dated by an inscription on a wooden member to the year 857, is considered an archetypical example of a high-status hall, or *diantang*, from the early period of Chinese construction (Figure 1.4). Features of a Tang *diantang* include elevation on a platform; pilasters under the columns; four-layer bracket sets with two cantilevers; a drop, lattice ceiling; and hipped roof. Other features associated both with the east hall and ninth-century Chinese architecture are inner and outer rings of columns; pillars that exhibit batter and rise (the shortest pillars define the central bay on any side and the tallest pillars are at the ends); a bracket set on the lintel between each pair of columns to help support the weight of the roof eaves; curved tie beams; and bracketing whose length is half the length of the column beneath it. The main image halls of the three lower-status buildings, by contrast, are elevated on lower platforms, supported only by an exterior ring of columns that are not placed in plinths, have simple, two-arm bracket sets and no intercolumnar units, and have combination hip-gable roofs.

By the late seventh century, two forms of tall pagodas were common. One, represented by Great Wild Goose Pagoda (Dayanta) in Xi'an, dated 704, consists of superimposed storeys of diminishing perimeter from base to roof. It is named *louge*, literally, tower-pavilion. The alternate form is *miyan*, densely placed eaves, a structure with a tall shaft and closely positioned eaves above it. This is the form of the pagoda of Songyue Monastery on Mount Song dated 523. Two *miyan*-style Tang pagodas also survive on Mount Song, as does an octagonal pagoda dated 746. Three extraordinary pagodas from the Tang dynasty are in Shandong, a single-storey funerary pagoda above the remains of the monk Huichong at Lingyan Monastery in Changqing and in Licheng, the Nine-Pagoda Pagoda, an octagonal brick structure on a tall foundation with

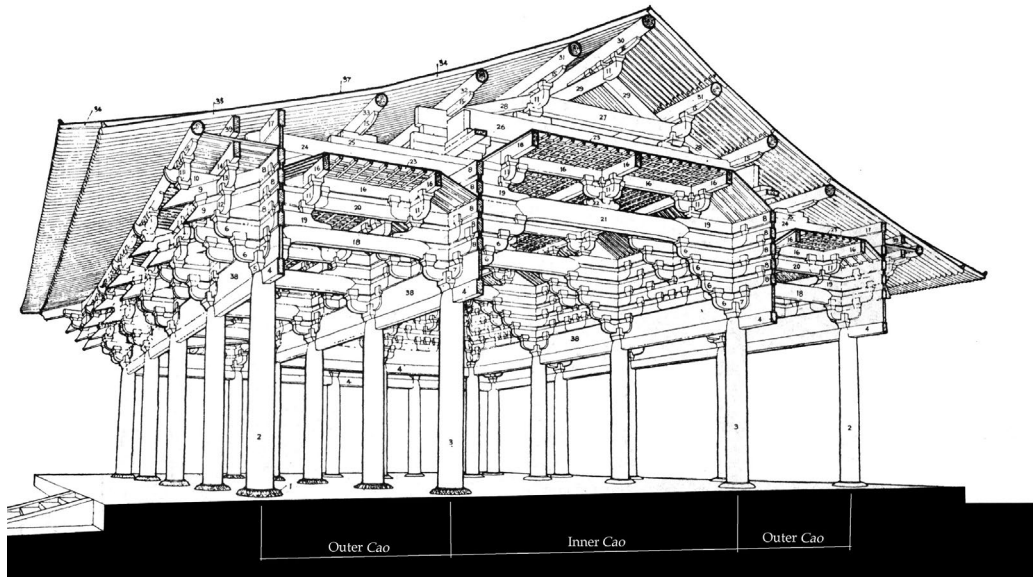

Figure 1.4 Infrastructural drawing of East Hall, Foguang Monastery, Wutai, Shaanxi, 857

Source: From Steinhardt, *Chinese Traditional Architecture*, reference pl. 1

a tall central pagoda flanked by eight three-storey pagodas on top and the intricately decorated Dragon Tiger Pagoda.

Finally, the Sui-Tang period was also known for impressive advances in structural engineering. The Grand Canal that extended more than 2000 kilometres joined Hangzhou to north China just south of Beijing. In Zhao county, the first open-spandrel, segmented-arch bridge was built in the Sui dynasty. Before then, pontoon bridges were common. Cast-iron men and oxen to which pontoon bridges were anchored survive from 720 in southern Shanxi.

Architecture of the tenth through thirteenth centuries

Between the fall of Tang in 907 and the year 1368, China was ruled by Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms, as well as the dynasties Song, Liao, Jin, and Yuan and the Western Xia kingdom. Although at least half of the rulers were not Chinese, the building system was codified during this period in one of two construction manuals issued at the Chinese court that survive from pre-modern China. Known as *Yingzao fashi* (*Building Standards*), the earlier was issued at the Song court in 1103 and re-issued in 1145. The thirty-four chapters set forth national standards of construction: definitions of architectural terms of China's classical age; rules of construction for small- and large-scale timber, tile, brick, and masonry; quotas of labour calculated according to the season and type of work; and illustrations. The module, formation of bracket sets, and ranked scale from most to least eminent building are explained in *Yingzao fashi*.

City planning from the tenth century until the middle of the thirteenth followed the designs of former dynasties. The Song capitals, of Northern Song (960–1127) at today's Kaifeng and Southern Song (1127–1279) in today's Hangzhou, had one palace-city in addition to imperial- and outer cities. The foreign Liao (947–1125) and Jin (1115–1234) dynasties ruled from a five-capital system. Capitals near the native lands of their rulers had two adjacent walled areas but only one palace-city; capitals of Liao and Jin in China proper, including those beneath today's Beijing and the Song capital at Kaifeng that they appropriated as their southern capital, more closely followed Chinese models of a palace area near the centre of the outer city. The greatest achievement in urban planning of the period was Khubilai Khan's (1215–94) Great Capital, Dadu. Following the recommendation of a Chinese advisor, Dadu was based on the prescription for a "ruler's city" in the *Rituals of Zhou*. Initiated by the designation of a mid-point and the measuring from it of equidistant north and south, and east and west walls, and comprised of three concentric enclosures, the plan would be the basis for imperial Beijing.

Nothing of China's grandest architecture remains among the fifteen wooden Buddhist or Daoist buildings in Shanxi, Fujian, and Hebei dated to the tenth century. Several eleventh-century buildings in north and south China suggest what they might have looked like. Sage Mother Hall of the Jin Shrines just southwest of Taiyuan, Shanxi, constructed in the eleventh century, is dedicated to a female spirit associated with rain and the Jin Springs since the Zhou dynasty. It is the oldest of more than thirty structures at this site through which water flows. The layout developed over centuries so that there is more than one focal building and axis. Sage Mother Hall is almost unique in the use of an eight-rafter beam that extends the entire width between the lowest rafter of the front and back eaves.

More Song buildings survive at Longxing Monastery than at any other temple complex in China; the grand Song tradition also survives there (Figure 1.5). Foxiang (Buddha's Fragrance), also known as Dabei (Great Compassion), Pavilion, associated with the date 971 although it was repaired in 1944 and substantially repaired again in the 1990s, is the tallest. A pavilion to Cishi (the Bodhisattva Maitreya) and one named after its Revolving Sutra Cabinet form a symmetrical pair in front of Foxiang Pavilion. None of the three pavilions has a ceiling. The interior cabinet in the pavilion is an example of small-scale carpentry described in *Yingzao fashi*. The only curved brace known in Song buildings in north China is in the front part of the pavilion. The three-pavilion arrangement also was used at Xiangguo Monastery, now destroyed, in the Northern Song capital. The gem of Longxing Monastery is Moni Hall, a unique, cruciform structure

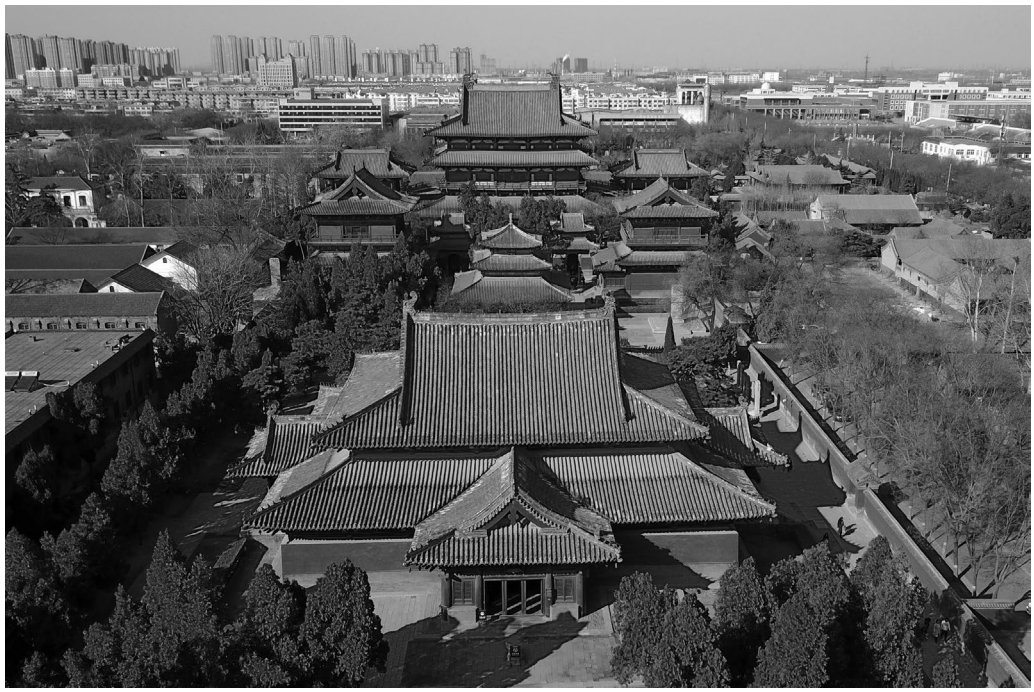

Figure 1.5 Longxing Monastery from air, most buildings Song dynasty
Source: Photo by and with permission of Ren Chao

and the only Song building wider than Sage Mother Hall. Dated 1052, it is dedicated to the Buddha Śākyamuni. A feature of bracket sets at Moni Hall confirms their date as Northern Song: the end of the descending cantilever is concave and roughly pentagonal in section. The same cantilever tip is found at Sage Mother Hall.

These cantilever tips also are used in the most eminent eleventh-century building in south China, Daxiongbao (Treasure of the Great Hero) Hall of Baoguo Monastery in Yuyao, near Ningbo, Zhejiang province. Dated 1013, it is the oldest surviving building in a sprawling, spectacularly sited mountain monastery whose history began in the Eastern Han dynasty. Most of the architecture was added or rebuilt in the Qing dynasty, including parts of Daxiongbao Hall. Four features distinguish it: three caisson ceilings across the front of the original Song structure; *gualunzhuang* (melon-wheel)-shaped pillars, a style described in *Yingzao fashi*; bracket sets with a clear perpendicular thrust; and curved, or rainbow-shaped, beams. Curved beams are used in the ninth-century east hall of Foguang Monastery. After that, they are found only in South China, at the tenth-century Daxiongbao Hall of Hualin Monastery and Three Purities Hall at Xuanmiao Daoist Monastery in Fujian built in 1016, as well as at the Baoguo Monastery Hall.

Approximately 100 Northern Song wooden buildings survive, at least twenty-five of which are dated. Many have two bracket sets between columns across the front façade. Ten wooden buildings in Shanxi, Hebei, or Liaoning, three of them dated to the tenth century, were part of the Liao empire (907–1125), sometimes referred to as a grasslands empire. Four are extraordinary. Guanyin Pavilion rises twenty-one metres above its base with an open interior built to contain a sixteen-metre statue of the Bodhisattva and two much smaller attendants. In order to achieve the space, the pavilion was constructed as two stories with a mezzanine level. More than 1,000 wooden pieces and twenty-four varieties of bracket sets are used. The statue is positioned

so that when the upper storey central doors are open, the eyes of the deity project to a reliquary pagoda 380 metres to the south. The pagoda was built later in the Liao dynasty, placed to receive this view. The Buddha hall at Fengguo Monastery in Yi county, Liaoning, built in 1019, is 48.2 metres (nearly 160 feet) across the front by 25.13 metres deep. It is elevated on a three-metre platform with base dimensions of 55.8 by 25.91 metres. The hall contains seven oversized Buddhas, perhaps the Seven Buddha of the Past. The bracket sets above columns across the front of this hall consist of seven fundamental parts. The intercolumnar sets are equally complex. More than twenty-three kinds of crossbeams or tie beams are used. Daxiongbao Hall of Huayan Monastery in Datong, the eastern capital of Liao, is even larger. The hall was renovated in 1140. It measures 53.75 by 29 metres and is approached by a 32.42-by-18.48-metre platform. Bracket sets however, are of only five fundamental components. Yet they have a distinguishing feature of the Liao and subsequent Jin (1115–1234) periods of which some of the best examples are in Datong: they are fan-shaped, that is, they fan out at several angles other than parallel or perpendicular to the building façade.

The greatest achievement in Liao wooden construction is the Timber Pagoda of 1056 (Figure 1.6). The pagoda is more than sixty-seven metres with five stories, four mezzanine levels, six sets of roof eaves on the exterior, and fifty-four types of bracket set. It is a highly complicated version of Guanyin Pavilion in which two stories and one mezzanine level are found. Each interior level has an individual iconographic program of deities that in composite form a three-dimensional mandala, or representation of a Buddhist universe. Further, the year of construction falls in the period calculated by Buddhologists as *mofa* (termination of the Buddhist Law), making plausible an interpretation of the pagoda as a monumental symbol of Buddhist death intended to counteract impending universal doom. Further, the pagoda was built by the eighth Liao emperor, Daozong (r. 1055–1101), for the empress dowager Qin'ai in the place where she had been born. The location declared his decision to honor his grandfather's primary wife, not the birth mother of his recently deceased father, Liao emperor Xingzong (r. 1031–1055). Scriptures and other relics are buried underneath in a reliquary. Other surviving Liao wooden buildings are humbler: the main hall of Kaishan Monastery in Xincheng, Hebei, dated 1033; the sutra repository of Huayan Monastery, dated 1038; and the main hall and a pavilion for the Bodhisattva Puxian (Samantabhadra), dated eleventh century and rebuilt in the twelfth century. A Buddha hall at Guangji Monastery in Baodi, Hebei, dated 1025, a Buddha hall at Huayan Monastery dated 1038, and three buildings from the early twelfth century at Kaiyuan Monastery in Yi county, Hebei, were destroyed in wars of the 1930s and 1940s. The front gate of Dule Monastery also survives.

The Liao building system in wood is echoed in masonry pagodas. Liao pagodas have two main ground plans: squarish and octagonal. The four-sided plan is represented by North and South Pagodas in Chaoyang, Liaoning, the former dated 1043–1044. Both have densely placed eaves. All other extant Liao pagodas of *miyan* style are octagonal. Important examples are in the Liao capital Shangjing, today in Balinzuoqi, Inner Mongolia; in Liaoning; and at Jueshan Monastery in Lingqui, Shanxi.

The majority of *louge*-style Liao pagodas are eight-sided. In addition to the Timber Pagoda, the 71.43-metre White Pagoda in Qingzhou, Balinyouqi, built in 1047, near the tombs of the sixth, seventh, and eighth Liao emperors; the eleventh-century, 73.02-metre Great Pagoda (Data) today in Ningcheng, once the site of the Liao central capital; and Wanbu Avatamsaka Sutra Pagoda in Hohhot, all in Inner Mongolia, are examples.

Hundreds of Liao tombs have been opened and hundreds more await excavation. In addition to the three aforementioned royal tombs in Qingzhou, those with murals or extraordinary artifacts are the best known. One of the two tombs in Baoshan, Chifeng county, Inner Mongolia, was constructed in 923. It is believed to belong to a relative of the Liao imperial family. Chinese and Khitan officials and perhaps the prince himself are painted on the walls. Chinese and Khitan officials also are depicted on the walls of imperial tomb in Qingzhou. The princess of the state of Chen and her husband, she the daughter of an emperor and he the brother of an empress, were buried in 1018 in silver-wire body suits, their faces covered with gilded masks, their heads and feet with gilded or silver crowns and boots. Eight people believed to be relatives of the consort clan Xiao are probably buried in a cemetery in Kulunqi in eastern Inner Mongolia. All

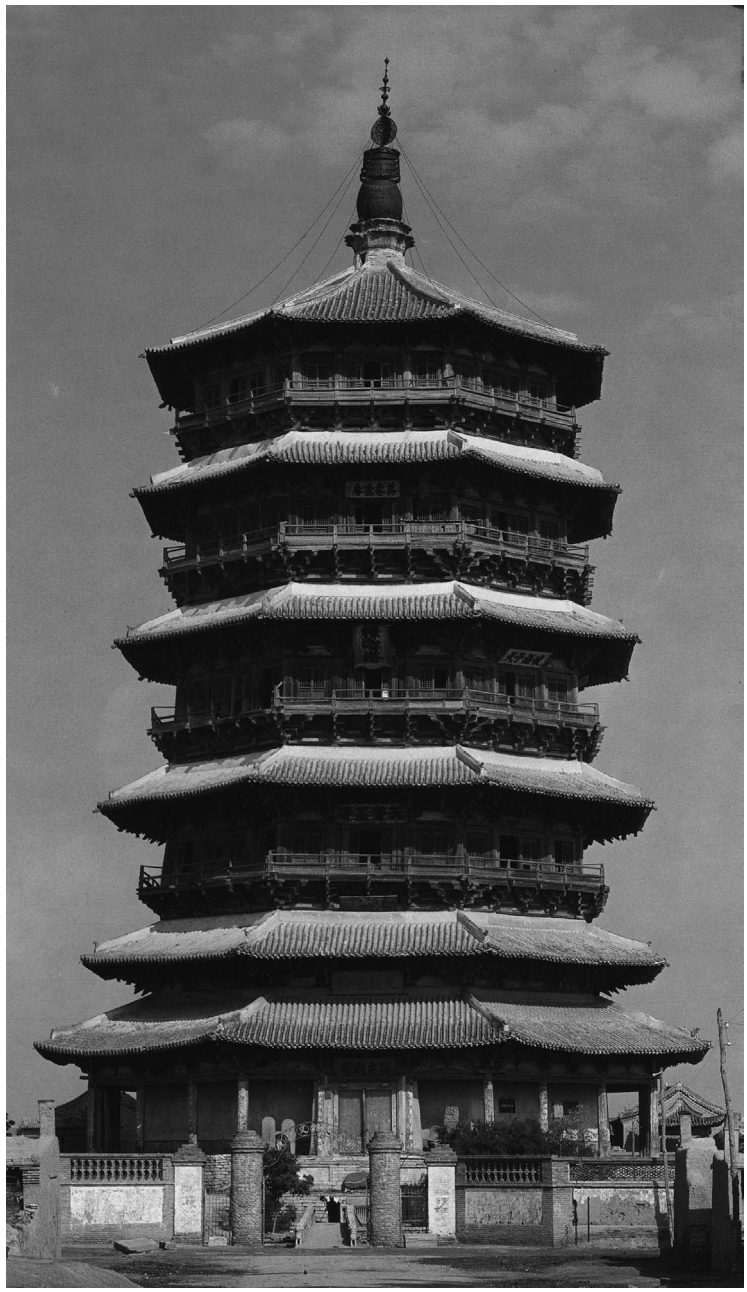

Figure 1.6 Timber Pagoda, Ying county, Shanxi, 1056

Source: Public domain

eight have a main chamber approached by a long ramp from ground level. Only one has a second room, but some have side rooms known as ear chambers. Imitation wooden architecture is painted on the walls of every tomb mentioned here. Among the approximately twenty tombs in a cemetery at Xiabali in Xuanhua, Hebei province, all but one have only one main chamber. As at other Liao tombs, the main room may be quadrilateral, hexagonal, circular, or octagonal. Most of the tombs in this cemetery belong to members of the Zhang family, and at least one belongs to a man surnamed Han, all Chinese living under Liao rule.

A wooden sarcophagus uncovered at Yemaotai tomb 7 in Faku county, Liaoning, stood in the back of a single chamber tomb with ear chambers and a long approach ramp. Inside it was a stone sarcophagus that contained the bones of an elderly woman whose body was covered with silk embroidered with gold thread. She wore a belt from which were suspended precious objects, held a crystal ball, had a silver plug in her nose, and more than ten pieces of silk garments were in the coffin. A painting was hung on either inside wall of the wooden sarcophagus. The wooden structure is three bays across the front by two bays in depth. The roof eaves project at forty-five-degree angles, significantly sharper than the projection on an actual building which is rarely more than twenty-eight degrees. Among the many sarcophaguses in the shapes of buildings known since the Han dynasty, the one from Yemaotai and Master Shi's sarcophagus discussed above bear the greatest number of specific building components that replicate actual pieces. The Yemaotai coffin conforms to the description for a small container with a hip-gable roof (*jiuji xiaozhang*) in *Yingzao fashi*.

The royal cemetery and approximately ten pagodas survive from the Western Xia empire in Ningxia, Gansu, and Inner Mongolia that endured from 1038–1227. Above ground the nine imperial Western Xia tombs begin with *que*. Behind them are pavilions that contain stele. There follow spirit paths with statues of men and beasts. Next is a front, central gateway of an inner-walled complex with a gate at the centre of its other walls and corner towers. Behind the gate is an offering hall. The passage to the underground tomb begins there. At the three excavated Western Xia tombs, the passageway and burial were north and slightly west of the axis created by the *que*, pavilions, spirit path, front gate, and offering hall. The approach and underground structure are those of a Song tomb complex.

As in Liao territory, Song pagodas towered above the landscape. Beginning in the tenth century, the majority of Song pagodas were octagonal, but hexagonal and four-sided pagodas also exist. They include both *miyan* and *louge* structures. Song and Liao pagodas appear in the same locations in their monasteries, both along the central axis and in pairs. At least eighty-five pagodas survive in Song territory from the mid-tenth century until the fall of Northern Song. There is a sharp drop in pagoda construction under Southern Song because the pagoda was not important in Chan Buddhist monasteries, the major affiliation in the Southern Song dynasty. Four pagodas remain in Suzhou: on Tiger Hill, built between 959 and 961, at Ruiguang Monastery built between 1009 and 1030, and twin pagodas known as *luohan* pagodas built in 982. Longhua Pagoda was constructed in Shanghai in 977. A six-storey, octagonal pagoda erected at Xiude Monastery in Quyang, Hebei, in 1019 has a tall, undecorated first storey and a second storey decorated with five rows of small pagodas. The thirteen-storey, octagonal Iron Pagoda in Kaifeng, location of the Northern Song capital, gets its nickname from the shiny exterior glaze. Song China's tallest pagoda was built in 1055 at Kaiyuan Monastery in Ding county, Hebei. The eleven-storey, eighty-four-metre, octagonal structure is one of the few surviving Song pagodas commissioned by the emperor. Lingyan Monastery in Shandong and Shaolin Monastery in Dengfeng have groups of pagodas known as pagoda forests. A seventy-six-metre pagoda at Bao'en Monastery in Suzhou was built between 1131 and 1162. Hangzhou's most renowned pagoda is the wood-and-brick, 59.89-metre Six Harmonies Pagoda that faces Qiantang River built in 1163. As many as thirteen pagodas are dated to the Jin period in Henan, Shanxi, Liaoning, Jilin, and Beijing. Most are at Liao monasteries that were restored under Jin rule.

Five Mountains and Ten Monasteries was a ranked system of sixty Southern Song government-designated Chan complexes. The five most important were in Hangzhou or Mingzhou in Zhejiang. Many Chan monasteries had an eight-hall plan which is documented in a text of 1248. The front gate, Buddha Hall, and Law Hall are along the main south-north line, with the abbot's hall, the building that identifies

a Chan monastery at the back. The Buddha hall is considered the heart with the kitchen and bathing halls and the bell tower and sutra library forming symmetrical pairs on either side.

Three Purities Hall at the Daoist monastery Xuanmiaoguan in Suzhou, dated to its rebuilding in 1176, is a rare example of a Southern Song Daoist building. From the Jin dynasty, two buildings remain at Chongfu Monastery in Shuo county, in northern Shanxi; the hall dedicated to the Buddha Amitabha survives from 1143. Both it and the hall dedicated to the Bodhisattva *Mañjuśrī* at Foguang Monastery on Mount Wutai built in 1137 have the fan-shaped bracket sets and pillars eliminated from a complete interior grid associated with the Liao-Jin period. Almost every other extant Jin building, more than 100, is small and humble, only three or five bays across the front and with a single-eave, hip-gable roof and uncomplicated bracket sets.

In spite of the fact that by the 1270s not only was China ruled by the Mongols but China was part of a much larger empire, the architecture in China from the 1260s until the establishment of the Ming dynasty in 1368 was primarily a continuation of the three previous centuries. Virtuous Tranquility Hall is the largest surviving building from the Yuan period. Forty metres across the front and almost thirty metres in depth, the building was for ceremonies to the northern sacred peak. Three Purities Hall is the grandest of four buildings constructed between 1247 and 1262 at the Daoist monastery Yonglegong in southern Shanxi (Figure 1.7). *Gong* is the same suffix used to designate a palace complex. Here it refers to a Daoist monastery whose buildings are on par with those of palatial architecture. The eminence of the two buildings is underscored through comparison with the second and third buildings at Yonglegong and two Yuan halls at Guangsheng Monastery, south of Taiyuan and north of Yonglegong, also in Shanxi province.

Comparisons include the height and materials of an elevation platform, existence of an approach platform, number of bays across the front of the hall, number of bracket sets between pillars, lattice patterns in doors and windows, use of pilasters, complexity of bracket sets, use of cupola ceiling, and hipped as opposed

Figure 1.7 Three Purities Hall, Yonglegong (Daoist Monastery), Ruicheng, Shanxi, 1247–1262

Source: Photo by and with permission of William Steinhardt

to hip-gable roof or a roof with overhanging eaves. All four Yuan buildings at Yongle Daoist Monastery halls also are important because of the paintings of architecture in them that include accurate details of building parts. Two buildings at Guangsheng Monastery are dated 1309 and 1319, both rebuilt in the aftermath of an earthquake that destroyed the monastery. They stand at the foot of a hill, a location that gives this section the designation Lower Monastery. The juxtaposition of Buddhist and Daoist precincts is unusual, but not unique. One might expect it during the Mongol period when the same craftsmen workshops painted interiors of both Buddhist and Daoist temples and because the Mongol rulers and their wives were patrons of Muslim and Christian architecture as well as Buddhist and Daoist.

Three Buddha halls in south China share features with the halls at Guangsheng Monastery and the second and third Yonglegong halls: at Yanfu Monastery in the mountains of Wuyi county of Zhejiang, repaired and rebuilt under between 1317 and 1324; at Zhenru Monastery in Shanghai, built in 1320; and at Tianning Monastery in Jinhua, Zhejiang, dated 1318. More than ten buildings in Hancheng in eastern Shaanxi date twelfth to fourteenth centuries. A similar number survive in Sichuan. Large residential mansions remain in the capital Dadu from the Yuan dynasty and to date two Yuan houses have been identified in Shanxi. More than twenty stages from the Jin and Yuan dynasties stand in Shanxi also.

Yuan is the period from which the oldest mosques survive in China. They are in the southeastern sea ports of Guangzhou, Quanzhou, Hangzhou, and Yangzhou. It is also the period from which China's oldest observatory survives, in Dengfeng, Henan. It is one of five that were planned in China under Mongol rule. West Asians worked at China's observatories, and Chinese worked at observatories in Iran. Astronomical instruments moved across Asia, but there is no evidence that Chinese structures took on features of West Asian architecture or vice versa.

The impact of Mongolian rule on China was dramatic, but the impact on Chinese architecture was much less. The few buildings remarkable for their distinctiveness such as the White Pagoda in Beijing would still be anomalies in the twentieth century. Khubilia's capital would be the basis for all future Chinese capitals except for brief periods when the capital was in Nanjing.

Ming-Qing architecture

The architecture of China's last two dynasties, Ming (1368–1644) and Qing (1644–1911), has been overshadowed by the period's most famous monument, the Forbidden City, and the many other imperial buildings in Beijing. The last five centuries of pre-modern Chinese architecture are also the period from which we have the first excellent evidence of Chinese gardens and vernacular buildings. Qing, the Manchu dynasty, is the age from which architecture reflecting the dozens of nationalities of the empire, people today known as minorities, can be seen.

The sources of Ming-Qing Beijing lie both in Khubilai's capital and the capital built by the first Ming emperor Hongwu (1328–1398) in Nanjing. In addition to palaces and offices of government, Hongwu built a tomb for himself and his wife and he was the patron of Linggu Monastery, location of one of China's few "beamless" halls, or structures made of brick that imitate wooden architecture, and Bao'en Monastery where stands the Porcelain Pagoda that attracted the attention of Europeans in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, all in Nanjing.

Begun under the emperor Yongle (r. 1403–24), Ming-Qing Beijing is the culmination of 2,000 years of Chinese imperial planning. In the 1420s, the city consisted of three walled enclosures: Forbidden City, surrounded by the imperial-city, surrounded by an outer city whose perimeter was 22.5 kilometres. In 1553, a southern extension that came to be known as the outer city doubled the walled area, increasing it to 62 square kilometres. Thereafter, the original outer walled area was known as the inner city because of its closer proximity to the centre. At that centre were the Three Great Halls of the Forbidden City where the emperor held audiences; celebrated the New Year, the winter solstice, and his birthday; announced the names of those who passed the highest exams necessary to become a Chinese official; examined seeds for the annual harvest;

honoured successful scholars; made high official appointments; and held banquets for foreign dignitaries. After 1553, the approach to the Forbidden City began at Eternal Settlement Gate, flanked on the east and west by the Altar of Heaven and Altar of Agriculture complexes. North of Eternal Settlement Gate were Due South Gate, Great Ming (later Great Qing) Gate, a T-shaped approach to the Gate of Heavenly Peace, Gate of Uprightness flanked by the Ancestral Temple and Altars of Soil and Grain, Meridian Gate, and the Gate of Supreme Harmony. Only then, after having in addition crossed two sets of five marble bridges over water, did one arrive at the Three Great Halls. Behind them were the Back Halls, originally two and later three, location of the imperial bedchambers and empress' hall of audience, flanked by twelve residential palaces, and two more major residential palace complexes, named Repose and Longevity and Mind Nurturing. The area between Heavenly Peace Gate and the entrance to the Back Halls was known as the "five gates;" continuing to the back end of the Back Halls, were the "three courts:" outer, governing, and resting (Figure 1.8). Continuing due north were Coal Hill and Drum and Bell Towers. No more explicit example of the pre-eminence of horizontal space in Chinese architecture has ever been attempted or achieved.

The architecture of altar complexes follows the principles of the Forbidden City on smaller scale. Both palace and altar complexes were built according to modules, and in the eighteenth century some of the imperial buildings followed rules in *Gongbu gongcheng zuofa zeli* (Engineering manual of the Board of Works), dated to the first half of the eighteenth century. It is the only complete manual for elite architecture besides *Yingzao fashi*. Most symbolic of the altars is the three-altar complex dedicated Heaven. Enclosed by a double horseshoe-shaped wall, itself combining the shapes of circle, representing the heavens, and square,

Figure 1.8 Airview of Forbidden City, Beijing, today

Source: Public domain

representing earth, the three main structures of Circular Mound, Imperial Vault of Heaven, and Hall for Prayer for a Prosperous Year are circular in plan (Figure 1.9). In addition, the flagstones on the Circular Mound are laid in concentric rings of multiples of nine, the number symbolizing the emperor, and the pillars inside the Prosperous Year Hall are arranged in groups of twelve, twelve, and four, symbolizing the lunar months of the years, divisions of the Chinese days, and seasons, respectively. The Altars to Earth, Sun, and Moon, were north, west, and east of the Forbidden City, respectively. Beijing also had an Altar of Silkworms and Temple to Jupiter.

Thirteen Ming emperors and twenty-three empresses or concubines are buried in Changping county in an area known as the tomb valley, approximately fifty kilometres northwest of the Forbidden City. Yongle and his empress' tomb is the focus of the thirteen, all sharing one spirit path. The tombs of the Qing (1644–1912) emperors are in three groups. The first two emperors, Nurhaci (1559–1626) and Hong Taiji (r. 1626–1643) are buried outside Shenyang in Liaoning province where they ruled from an imperial city that followed Chinese building patterns in the central area but had an eastern wing with pavilions for the eight Manchus banners under which the pre-dynastic Qing had been organized. Upon the establishment of the Qing capital in Beijing, Shunzhi (r. 1644–1661) began construction of a necropolis in Zunhua, 125 kilometres northeast of Beijing in Hebei province. By the fall of the Qing dynasty, five emperors, four empresses, and five imperial concubines were buried there. The site became known as the Eastern Qing Tombs after the 1730s when the emperor Yongzheng (r. 1723–1735) moved to a new site 120 kilometres southwest of Beijing. The other emperors, as well as empresses and concubines, are buried in the Western Qing Tombs.

Thousands of buildings in addition to the ones built by or for emperors survive in China from the fifteenth through nineteenth centuries along with hundreds of city walls. Guangsheng Monastery where the Dragon King Temple is alongside Buddhist buildings has a 47.31-metre, Flying Rainbow Pagoda covered with tri-colour glazed tiles from the Ming period as the focus of the Upper Monastery. Zhihua Monastery in eastern Beijing was founded in 1443 by a powerful eunuch who built it as a temple for his family. When the eunuch was forced to commit suicide in 1449, the monastery was taken over by the court. The two-storey Rulai Hall, named for the historical Buddha Śākyamuni, dominates the third courtyard. Chongshan Monastery in Taiyuan, Shanxi, was built between 1381 and 1391 by the third son of the emperor Hongwu. Duofu Monastery in the same region is roughly contemporary. All these large monasteries of north China have three or more courtyards, one behind the next, with major buildings along their central axes. Sichuan's major Ming monastery, Bao'ensi in Pingwu, has a similar plan. It was built by a powerful family in the 1440s and 1450s. Kaiyuan Monastery in Quanzhou was founded in 686 and added to ever since. Its most important structure is Daxiongbao Hall, repaired many times between 1389 and 1633. It is nicknamed Hundred Column Hall although only eighty-six pillars support it. The hall is known for twenty-four *apsaras*, or flying deities, that emerge from its bracket sets.

Many of Ming and Qing China's most important buildings are on sacred peaks. Taishan, the sacred eastern peak in Tai'an, Shandong province, where the souls of the deceased are believed to go and from where they can be reborn, has Bixia (Azure Dawn) Shrine at its summit. The Monastery Suspended in Air (Xuankongsi) is on Mount Heng, the northern sacred peak since the Ming dynasty. Support for its buildings is achieved by oak beams positioned into holes in the cliff. At least a dozen monasteries on Mount Wutai, location of Foguang and Nanchan Monasteries, have noteworthy Ming-Qing buildings. A white plaster Lamaist-style pagoda built in 1434 to commemorate an Indian monk who had come to preach in the early fifteenth century stands behind the five-bay Buddha hall at Yuanzhao Monastery. Copper halls were built at Guangzong and Xuantong Monasteries. Mount Putuo is a 12.5-square-kilometer island, thirty kilometres in circumference, in Zhejiang province, with a pagoda dated 1334. Mount Wudang, a sacred Daoist peak, has eight complexes designated *gongguan* (palace abbeys). Seven of them were built or significantly rebuilt in the early fifteenth century. Taihe (Supreme Harmony, the same name as one of the Three Great Halls at the Forbidden City) Palace Abbey contains Golden Hall, the oldest gilded copper structure

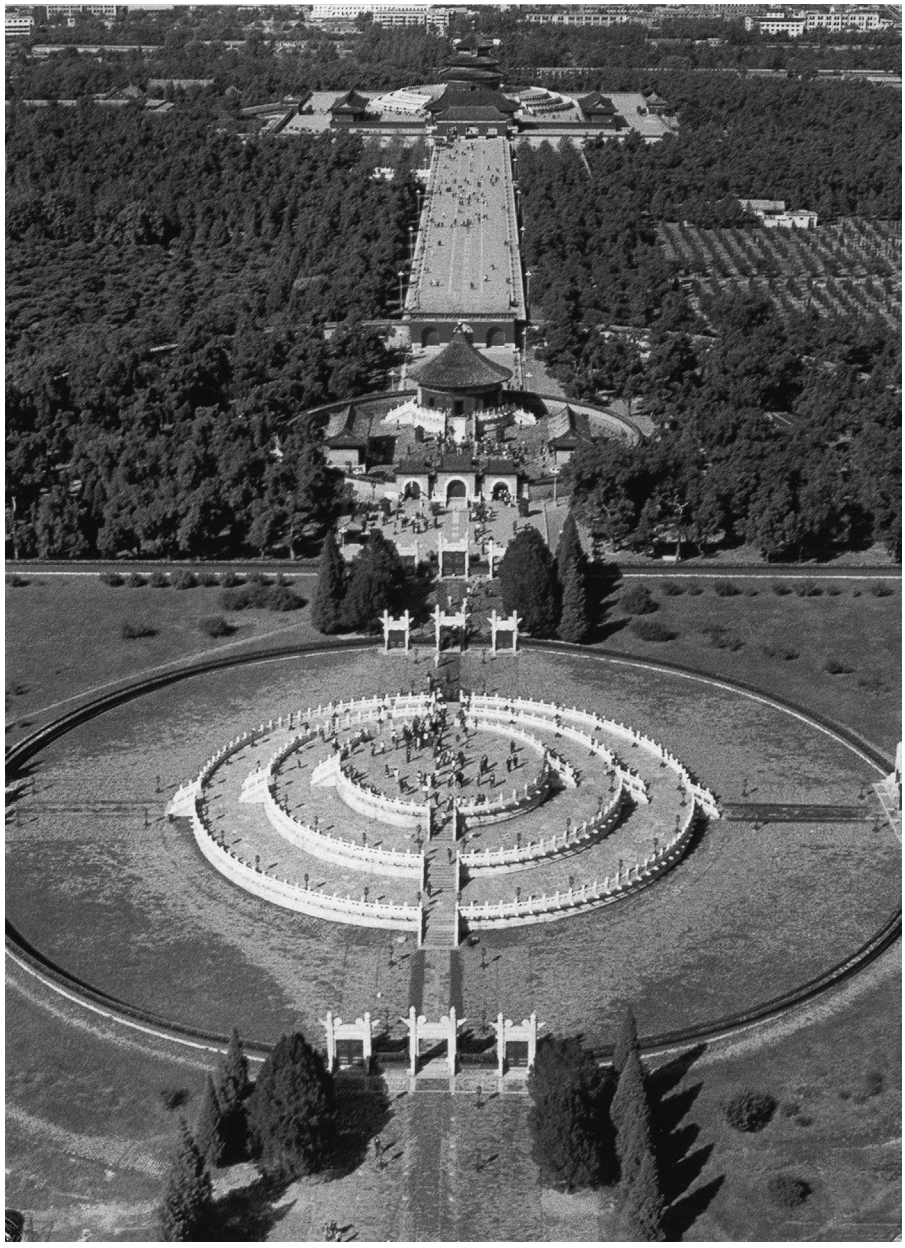

Figure 1.9 Airview of Altar to Heaven complex, Beijing, today, showing Circular Mound, Imperial Vault of Heaven, and Hall for Prayer for a Prosperous Year

Source: Public domain

in China. Purple Empyrean Palace is the best-known monastery on Mount Wudang. Two important Daoist monasteries in Beijing are Baiyunguan (White Cloud Daoist Monastery), established in 741, and the Temple to the Eastern Sacred Peak.

Many buildings at Confucian temples survive from the Ming and Qing dynasties. Confucianism pays homage to men and their teachings. Its origins lie with the sage, moral leader, teacher, and philosopher of the state of Lu, today Qufu in Shandong, known as Confucius (551–479 BCE). Qufu is filled with Confucian architecture: the tomb of the Yellow Emperor; a temple to the Duke of Zhou; a temple to Mencius; a temple to Confucius' father; and Confucian schools, as well as Confucius' tomb. The most important complex is the nine-courtyard temple to Confucius. Star of Literature Pavilion, a library, is one of the major structures. It is at the approximate centre of the complex in front of Great Achievement (Dacheng) Hall that honors Confucius and is where offerings were made to five generations of his ancestors.

Every major Chinese city had a Confucian temple, the structure representing civil officials, and most cities also had a temple to military officialdom, the Guandi Temple dedicated to the military official, Guan Yu (d. 219). China's largest Guandi (ruler Guan) temple is in Yuncheng in southern Shanxi, near his birthplace. Most buildings there date to the eighteenth century. Government offices, or yamen, and guild halls also survive across China from the Ming and Qing dynasties.

Qing rulers had a resort capital known as the Mountain Hamlet for Escaping the Heat in Chengde, Hebei, 226 kilometres northeast of Beijing. The retreat divides into four sections: a palace area where the emperor could hold court, lake area, plain, and mountains. Scenic spots were built into the hamlet, some of them "borrowed views" based on garden or lake designs emperors had seen in inspection tours of south China. The 60,000-square-metre section known as Eight Outlying Temples consists of eleven complexes designed to reference Chinese, Mongolian, and Tibetan styles of religious architecture. It is a unique realization of the symbolic use of buildings for political ambition and ethnic unity of the Qing empire. All construction occurred between 1713 and 1780. Puning (worldwide peace) Monastery was built in 1755 both to mark the final defeat of the Mongolian rebels, the Zünghars, and to host them in Chengde. Seven structures follow a south-north line in three rectangular courtyards, terminating in a serrated semi-circle that is mimicked by the landscape behind it. Puyou Monastery, directly to the east, is two courtyards with Chinese-style buildings but Tibetan imagery and functions. Anyuan Temple was begun in 1756, also modeled after a monastery in the territory of the conquered Zünghars in western Xinjiang. Pule Monastery was built in 1766 for chieftains of the Kazak and Khirgiz who began to pay tribute to Qianlong after his victory over the Zünghars. There was also an imitation of Potala Palace in Lhasa.

Architecture of Lamaist Buddhism also flourished in Ming and Qing China. Ta'ersi (Monastery of the Pagoda), twenty-six kilometres southwest of Xining in Qinghai province, was established in 1379 and has grown since the sixteenth century. The Great Silver Pagoda, built in 1582 to commemorate Tsongkhapa, the Tibetan founder of the Gelupa sect, is the most sacred hall at Ta'ersi. The monastery of the Five-Pagoda Pagoda (Wutaisi) in Beijing was begun by emperor Yongle (r. 1402–1424). With four corner pagodas and one at the centre, examples of this pagoda style known as Diamond Throne also are on Mount Wutai and at Biyun (Azure Clouds) Monastery in the Fragrant Hills of Beijing (Figure 1.10).

Yonghegong (Harmony Peace Palace) is Beijing's largest lamasery. The 66,000-square-metre complex was built in 1694 by the Kangxi emperor as a residence for his fourth son. After the son ascended the throne, it was used as a residential retreat. In 1744, Emperor Qianlong had the site converted into a lamasery, but it remained laid out like a mansion. One of Beijing's best-known Lamaist monuments is the White Pagoda in Beihai (North Sea) Park. It is often understood as a Manchu response to the White Pagoda of Miaoying Monastery

Outside Beijing, the most important Ming and Qing lamaseries are in Gansu and Inner Mongolia. Four are in the Hohhot-Baotou region: Dazhao (Yeke Juu), Xilituzhao (Shireetū Juu), Meidaizhao (Maidari Juu), and Wudangzhao (Badgar Süme).

Figure 1.10 Diamond Throne Pagoda, Biyun Monastery, Fragrant Hills, Beijing, eighteenth century
Source: Photo by and courtesy of Chen Zhe

Mosque construction continued across China in the Ming and Qing dynasties. In Ming times, the structures of a mosque were as much part of the Chinese building tradition as those of a Buddhist, Daoist, or Confucian temple. Huajuexiangsi (the mosque on Huajue alley) in Xi'an is China's largest mosque and one of the best examples. It was built with the support of the seafarer Zheng He (1371–1433). Ox Street Mosque, Beijing's largest mosque, was founded in 960 but stands as a Ming-Qing structure. In addition to the minaret, the Beijing mosque has a Wangyuelou, a tower for viewing the moon during Ramadan. Large numbers of mosques in Chinese-style stand from the Ming period along the Grand Canal and in north-western China near the meeting point of Gansu, Ningxia, and Qinghai provinces. Shrines to Muslim holy men known as *gongbei* in Chinese also survive in this region, as well. Sugongta (tower of Sugong) in Turfan, is China's tallest minaret. It was completed in 1778. 'Idgah (Aidika'er/Etigar) Mosque in Kashgar was begun in 1442 and enlarged to its current size, larger even that Huajuexiang Mosque, in 1838. The mausoleum of Aba Khoja in Kashgar is China's largest Muslim architectural complex.

Often gardens are part of mosque complexes, but China's largest and most important gardens were built by emperors in the north and private citizens in the south. Garden construction began by the Qin dynasty but there is little physical evidence before the Song. Beijing's gardens are often considered extensions of the Forbidden City. A section of Yuanming Garden, which included European-style buildings made of stone, was designed in the eighteenth century by Italian missionary Giuseppe Castiglione. Much of it was heavily damaged or destroyed by the British and French attack on Beijing in 1860. The garden complex known as the Summer Palace is associated with Empress Dowager Cixi (1835–1908) who built the Buddha Fragrance Pavilion, long arcade, Jade Belt Bridge, and Marble Boat in the 1880s.

The Southeast, especially the city of Suzhou, is best known for its private gardens, many of which were built by the wealthy merchant population who resided there and were some of China's greatest art patrons. Suzhou's gardens include Garden of Surging Waves Pavilion which may have the oldest garden remains in Suzhou; Master of Fishnets Garden, built in 1140 by Song official Shi Zhengzhi, one of the smallest in Suzhou; Lion Grove, built as a monastery in 1342 on the site of a garden; Garden of the Unsuccessful Politician built in 1490 by a member of the Censorate who was wrongly accused, demoted, and built the garden in his hometown; and Lingering Garden, built in 1593 by a retired official who was cashiered and later exonerated (Figure 1.11).

Some of Suzhou's gardens were designed or redesigned by Ji Cheng (1582-ca. 1642) who was born and lived in Jiangsu province. Between 1631 and 1634, he wrote a three-chapter treatise on garden design called *Yuanye*, usually translated into English as *The Craft of Gardens*.

Figure 1.11 Garden of the Unsuccessful Politician, Suzhou, Ming dynasty and later

Source: Photo by author

Residential architecture also survives from Ming and Qing China. China's most famous residential architecture is probably the lanes and alleys of Beijing's grid-patterned *hutong*. Enclosure in quadrilateral courtyards is a more general principle of residential construction. Sometimes a skywell is a source of light in the courtyard. Although built across China, residential architecture with these features and whitewashed walls, sometimes with gabled entries, are characteristic of Anhui province and Suzhou. Deeper in China's countryside, regional vernacular architecture takes over. *Tulou*, literally earthen multi-storey buildings, often circular with skywells inside, are associated with the Kejia, often known by the Cantonese pronunciation Hakka. *Yaodong*, earth-sheltered dwellings, alternately known as semi-subterranean architecture, are found in north central China. Houses raised on stilts are found in the swamplands of south China. Tibetan-style residential architecture known as block houses are in Tibet, Mongolia, and Gansu. *Lu Banjing*, the *Classic of Ban from Lu*, is a guide for residential architecture, particularly auspicious and inauspicious ways to build. Surviving in late-Ming versions, it is named after a legendary master-craftsman and inventor of the fifth century BCE. By the fifteenth century Lu Ban had become a patron saint of carpenters. Like China's other architectural manuals, the three-chapter work is illustrated.

The architectural landscape of China on the eve of the twentieth century was little different from its appearance one, two, or three thousand years earlier. The emperor's palace was impenetrable to all but China's imperial elite. Every city was walled, even if by then only wall portions or gates survived. Every city and town had Daoist and Buddhist monasteries, and many had a Confucian temple. Those who could afford them constructed gardens adjacent to their residences. Diversity in the tradition was apparent only in residential architecture; and the timber frame, lodged into a base and supporting a ceramic tile roof via a roof frame and bracket sets, dominated.

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2
AGRICULTURE IN TRADITIONAL CHINA

Liu Yingchun and Wang Haiyan

Introduction

Traditional agriculture is a kind of subsistence agriculture with relatively limited agricultural products obtained. Agriculture in traditional China emphasizes the combination of manpower and natural forces. Traditional Chinese agricultural development is the product of the self-sufficient economy at that time while it contributes to modern agriculture both home and abroad. By making use of the existing production techniques, Chinese farmers produce the daily necessities they need from the natural world.

Traditional agriculture is based on manual labour that employs human power, animal power, hand tools, and iron tools and is also based on the traditional experience accumulated by the previous generations. This chapter briefly introduces the cultivation and processing of grains of several types, and the making of sugar and the production of salt in traditional China.

Cultivation of grains

The term "grain" is a general term for "as many as a hundred food crops," while "the five grains" refer to sesamum, beans, wheat, panicum millet, and glutinous millet, with rice excluded because the ancient sages who write on this topic are all born in northwestern China where rice is not grown. Nowadays rice constitutes seventy percent of the people's staple food while wheat, barley, and various kinds of millet constitute the other thirty percent in China.

Rice

There are many types of rice. The non-glutinous kind is called round-grained non-glutinous rice, and the grain obtained from it is called polished round-grained non-glutinous rice. The glutinous kind is called glutinous rice, and the grain obtained from it is called polished glutinous rice. Another kind of rice, originally of the round-grained non-glutinous rice type, ripens late and produces slightly glutinous grain, which is used only to cook porridge, not to brew wine. There is still another kind of rice called "fragrant rice". It is known for its fragrance and enjoyed by the aristocrats, but the yield is small, so the planting of it is not recommended.

The shapes of rice are different from place to place; there is a long-speared rice and a short-speared one. The grains obtained vary from the long grain rice to the pointed grain one, or from the round-top one to

the flat-top one, and so on. The colours of the grains of rice vary from snow white to ivory, red, semiviolet or dappled black.

The soaking of seed rice can be done before the Spring Equinox at the earliest or after Pure Brightness at the latest. The seed rice is wrapped in rice or wheat straw and soaked for a few days. When the rice shoots grow to about one *cun* tall, they are called "young rice plants". After growing for about thirty days, the young rice plants are pulled up and transplanted into the paddy field. If the paddy field is suffering from a drought or a flood, transplanting is done later. However, if transplanting is delayed beyond the period of time required for transplanting, the young rice plants will grow tall and develop sections in their stalks. In this case, the rice yield will be reduced, with only a few grains of rice to be harvested. Seventy days after transplanting, the early-ripening rice can be harvested, but the late-ripening type has to grow throughout the entire summer to be harvested in winter, 200 days after transplanting.

Due to the fact that there is neither frost nor snow in the southern province of Guangdong, rice is planted in winter and harvested in midsummer. In the plains in southern China, rice is planted and harvested twice a year. After the first crop is harvested in the sixth month, the same paddy field is ploughed over so that the second crop, the late-ripening glutinous rice, is planted. The young rice plants of the late-ripening rice are transplanted at the same time as those of the early-ripening type at Pure Brightness. The transplanted young rice plants of the early-ripening type will die for lack of water in just one day, while those of the late-ripening type will grow through the hot summer and the dry weather of the fourth and fifth months.

The late-ripening rice must be irrigated constantly in times of continuous fine weather in autumn when there is little rainfall. Farmers toil in the field so that the paddy field will produce enough rice for them to eat and brew wine with. Since rice plants will die for lack of water in ten consecutive days, the Chinese farmers develop a kind of non-glutinous rice which can be planted on hilly areas without requiring watering.

If the paddy field is barren, the rice spears and grain will not grow well, hence the industrious farmers fertilize their paddy fields in various ways. Human and animal excretions, dry cakes of pressed seeds from which the oil has been removed, and grass or tree leaves can all be used as fertilizers. These organic fertilizers are widely used throughout the country. If the soil contains cold water, then bone ashes of any bird or animal, or lime are sprinkled around the roots of rice seedlings. But if the soil faces the sun and is warm, this procedure is not followed. If the soil is hard, the paddy field should be ploughed into ridges. The clods should be stacked on top of firewood or straw and burned to be loosened. But this procedure is not followed if the soil is clayey or sandy.

If the paddy field is not to be planted again after the harvest, it must be ploughed over so that the stalks will rot in the ground. The decomposed stalks make a good fertilizer twice as effective as manure. If the paddy field is not ploughed over until the next spring due to a drought in autumn or the farmers' laziness, the following harvest of rice will be affected. If dry cakes of pressed seeds or liquid manure are applied to fertilize the paddy field and there happen to be consecutive rainy days, the fertilizers will be washed away. Therefore, experienced farmers always observe the weather conditions in deciding when to fertilize their fields. Industrious farmers plough over the fields two or three times before they use the harrow to break the soil evenly and finely (Figures 2.1 and 2.2). In this way the fertilizers will be well distributed in the soil.

In farming families where there are no oxen available, farmers fix a pole to the plough and two men will pull the plough by placing the pole on their shoulders. If the farmers have no oxen to pull a harrow, they construct a rotary harrow pulled by two men, using their shoulders and hands to operate the harrow to break the clods. Considering the cost of cattle and the risk of sickness, theft and death, the farmers in areas centred around Suzhou in eastern China use hoes instead of working cattle to plough.

The old leaves wither on the rice plants and new leaves grow out a few days after transplanting. When new leaves start to grow, it is time to heap mud around the roots of the rice plants. Farmers lean on a stick for balance and heap mud with their feet. Meanwhile, they bend the weeds with their feet to bury them

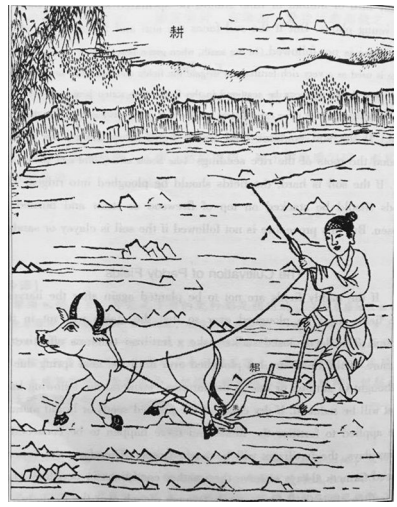

Figure 2.1 Loosening the soil by ploughing

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 12

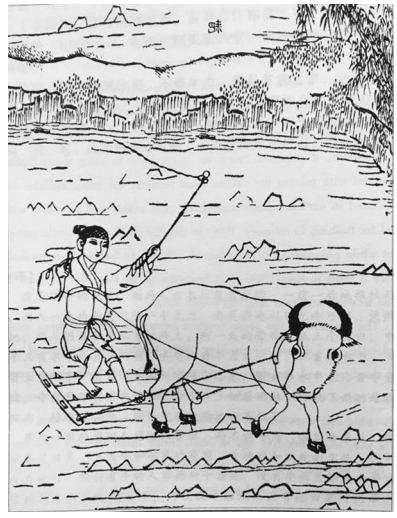

Figure 2.2 Breaking the clods into fine particles by harrowing

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 13

deep in the mud, not to grow out again. Weeds such as beckmannia erucaeformis can be broken by foot, but darnels, tares, and sweetweed cannot be broken this way and have to be uprooted by hand (Figure 2.3). Weeding in the paddy field is hard on one's back and hands, and distinguishing rice plants from weeds requires keen eyesight. The rice plants will flourish after all undesirable weeds are eliminated. After all these steps, farmers need to drain excessive water to prevent flooding or to irrigate the paddy field to prevent a drought. In about a month's time, farmers are ready to harvest with their scythes.

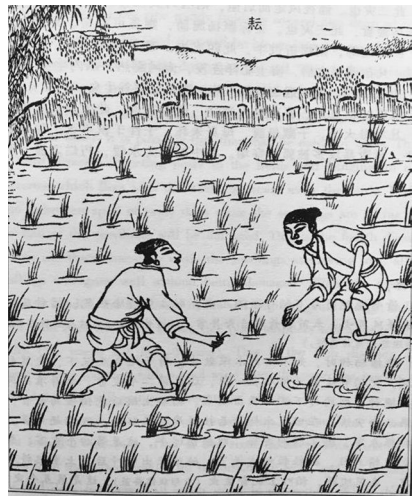

Figure 2.3 Hand weeding the paddy field

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 19

If the early-ripening seed rice is exposed to the scorching sun when being collected and stored in early autumn, it will have internal heat concealed in the seed rice. If the door of the barn is closed right after the seed rice is put into, heat is dormant in it. After sowing in the next spring, with the manure in the fields raising the temperature of the soil and warm wind blowing from the southeast, the rice will suffer from the dormant heat and the seedlings will be damaged. This is the first rice disaster. If the seed rice is put into the barn when the weather is cool in the evening, or if a jar of snow water or ice water, collected in the coldest day of the year after the Winter Solstice, is stored and several bowls of such water are sprayed into a *dan* of the seed rice which is being soaked for quick sprouting, the heat inside the seed rice will immediately disappear and the seedlings will grow well in spite of the warm wind blowing from the southwest.

If the water in the paddy field is several *cun* deep when the seeds are scattered, they will be blown into a corner by a sudden strong wind before they sink down into the soil. This is the second disaster. If the seeds are scattered after the wind stops, then they will sink evenly and the young rice plants will grow well. When the seedlings grow out of water, they may be eaten by birds. This is the third disaster. Erecting posts in the fields and hanging an eagle scarecrow which flies with the wind can scare away the birds. If there is an unbroken spell of rainy days while the seedlings are taking root, over half of the seedlings will be damaged. This is the fourth disaster. If there are three fine days while the seedlings are taking root, all the seedlings will grow well without being damaged. When the seedlings grow new blades, the fertilizers in the soil begin to emit energy, and the warm wind from the south blows, rice plant skippers will appear on the blades. This is the fifth disaster. If a shower occurs together with a cool wind coming from the west, the insects will die and the rice will gain a momentum of growth.

When the rice seedlings are earring up, they will possibly be burned at night by will-o'-the-wisp. This is the sixth disaster. This kind of fire comes from the rotten wood. Fire is dormant in wood and does not come out when wood is not rotten. When there is much rain in some years, the graves in the fields collapse due to the holes that foxes make into the graves. The planks of the coffin are soaked in water and are rotten. The fire dormant in the planks has no place to attach to and thus comes out to float in the air. But the fire of the nether world always avoids sunlight and rushes out from cracks only at dusk when the sun sets. The fire burns the ears and blades of rice plants. Farmers who chase the fire find that there is a flame near the tree

and think it is a ghost. They put out the fire by beating it with a stick, and so there appears the saying that "the ghost has turned into a tree". However, they do not know that will-o'-the-wisp extinguishes when it meets the lamplight of the farmers.

From the time of growing blades to earring up and bearing fruit, the seedlings need irrigating, without which the seedlings wither. This is the seventh disaster. The early-ripening rice needs three *dou* of water and late-ripening rice, five *dou*. This means that irrigation is imperative and farmers are well skilled therein. When the rice is ripening, the grains of rice will be blown off the stalks if there is a strong wind passing over, or the grains become wet and rotten if there is an unbroken spell of wet weather for ten consecutive days. This is the eighth disaster. But the strong wind affects no more than a circumference of thirty *li* and the wet weather, no more than a circumference of 300 *li*. The disasters are limited to a local area and are not extended to a broader area. It cannot be prevented if the wind blows off the grains of rice. A poor family which suffers losses of grains due to the wet weather can collect the fallen grains of rice and bake them in the wok to get rid of the husk so that they can be eaten as food. This is a good remedial measure for the natural disaster.

Rice is more vulnerable to drought than other food crops. The soil of the rice paddy field is of many types, being sandy, muddy, barren or fertile, varying from place to place. Without irrigation for just three days, certain types of paddy field soil become dry, while others may not become dry for half a month. If it does not rain, farmers should draw water for irrigation. Farming families living near rivers build dams and construct waterwheels with small tubes along the outer edge of the wheel so that the river water turns the waterwheel (Figure 2.4). Each of the small tubes on the wheel draws water from the river and, in turn, all the water collected into the tubes is poured into the groove and finally goes to the paddy field. Near lakes

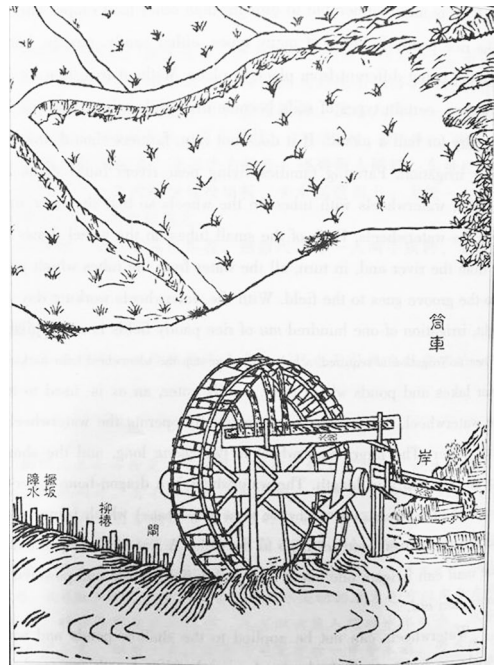

Figure 2.4 The tube waterwheel

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 26

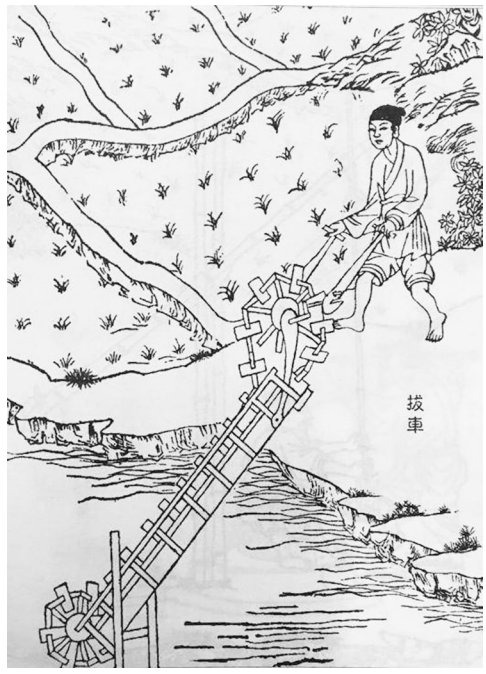

Figure 2.5 The hand-cranked waterwheel

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 29

and ponds where there is still water, an ox is used to turn the waterwheel, or several men manually operate the waterwheel to draw water for irrigation.

The waterwheel cannot be applied to a shallow pond and canal, so a hand-cranked waterwheel of several *chi* in length is used instead. A man turns the handle with both hands to quickly turn the waterwheel to draw water for irrigation (Figure 2.5). In Yangzhou, East China's Jiangsu province, a number of sails are employed to turn the waterwheel by wind power, but the waterwheel stops when the wind stops. This kind of water-drawing wheel is usually used to drain flooded fields. If water is drawn by using a counterweight lever and a pulley wheel, the efficiency is rather low.

Wheat

Different types of wheat are planted in China. Wheat in the narrow sense is called *lai*, which is the main type of wheat. Barley is called *mou* or *kuang* wheat. And there are miscellaneous types of wheat, such as oat and buckwheat, but they are all sown at the same time. They have similar blossoms and all of them are ground into powder for food, and all of them are called wheat in general. In such places as Hebei, Shaanxi, Shanxi, Henan, and Shandong provinces, wheat contributes to half of the grain of the people, while millet, proso millet and rice make up the other half, within a circumference of 6000 *li* reaching as far as Sichuan province in the west and Fujian, Zhejiang, and Jiangsu provinces and the State of Chu (part of Hubei, Hunan, Anhui, and Jiangxi provinces nowadays) in the east and mid-east. Wheat is ground into powder to make fancy shaped steamed rolls, thin pancakes, steamed bread or noodles.

The *kuang* wheat, sometimes called highland barley, is planted only in the northwestern province of Shaanxi. The black barley is grown there to feed horses, yet in times of famine humans also eat it for food.

Oat has fine ears, and each ear has over ten finer ears. There is also a kind of wild oat. Buckwheat is actually not wheat, yet it is ground into powder for food.

Wheat in northern China has a longer growing period, which covers the four seasons of the year. It is sown in autumn and harvested in early summer the next year. The growing period for wheat in southern China is shorter due to the warm weather there. Wheat blossoms at night, and in daytime south and north of the Yangtze respectively. The sowing and harvesting of barley is the same as that of wheat. Buckwheat is sown in mid-autumn and harvested in less than two months' time. But the seedlings of buckwheat die if they are stricken by frost.

Tilling and turning up the soil of the wheat field are the same as is done to the rice paddy field. Unlike the rice paddy field, which requires heaping mud or fertilizer around the roots, the wheat field requires only weeding after sowing. The soil in the north is porous and easily smashed. The way of planting wheat and the tillage implements are different from those of planting rice in that the ploughing and sowing of wheat are done simultaneously. In the north, the ox is used to turn up the soil. In this case, the plough's point is removed and two iron diggers are fixed in its place on the cross-beam which is called *jiang* in the local dialect (Figure 2.6). A small square box containing seed wheat is placed in the centre of *jiang*. Plum blossom-size holes are drilled at the bottom of the box through which the seeds drop onto the ground when the apparatus is shaken as the ox pulls it forward. If farmers wish to sow wheat densely, they will make the ox go faster, otherwise they will sow wheat sparsely. After sowing, a donkey is used to pull a stone roller to level the ground so that the seeds are well covered underneath. Wheat seeds must be covered firmly in the ground for sprouting.

Figure 2.6 The plough-seeder

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 36

Figure 2.7 Hand-sowing and foot-covering the seeds

Source: Tian Gong Kai Wu, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 38

Different from the north, the wheat field in the south must be ploughed and harrowed many times before sowing. The wheat seeds are first mixed with ashes of grass and then sown by hand. After sowing, cover the seeds firmly by foot instead of using a donkey-pulled stone roller (Figure 2.7).

Frequent weeding with a wide-blade large hoe is required after wheat seedlings appear. With the weeds removed, the fertilizer in the soil fully promotes the growth of wheat. The more diligent the farmer is, the fewer weeds remain, and this is the same both in southern and northern China. Farmers apply manure to the wheat field before sowing because fertilizing after sowing is not necessary. In the locality of Luoshui, Shaanxi province, it is possible for pests to eat the wheat seeds. Therefore, the seeds are mixed with arsenic before sowing, whereas in the south the seeds are mixed with grass ashes (commonly called "ground ash").

In southern China, farmers sometimes grow wheat or barley to just fertilize the rice paddy field, rather than for harvesting purposes. When the wheat or barley grows dark green, they are ploughed underneath to rot, thus the output of rice in the next autumn will probably double.

The wheat field can be used to plant other crops after the harvest in the half-year period from early summer to late autumn. Farmers are always rewarded for their hard work. They can decide which crops to plant in the wheat field according to the local soil conditions. In the south, some farmers plant late-ripening round-grained non-glutinous rice after harvesting barley. Buckwheat is sown in the south after rice is harvested, and in the north after beans and proso millet are harvested. Buckwheat, which requires rich fertilizer, makes the soil barren. However, if the increased output of buckwheat is taken into account, it is worthwhile to apply more manure to the field.

Disasters happening to wheat are just one-third of those happening to rice. Snow, frost, draught, and waterlogging do not affect the growing of wheat after sowing. Wheat does not require much water. In the

north, wheat will blossom and bear fruit if there is a good rain in mid-spring. However, south of Jingzhou, Hebei province, and Yangzhou, Jiangsu province, the intermittent drizzle in the rainy season in late spring and early summer in the middle and lower reaches of the Yangtze is harmful to the growth of wheat. If there are ten consecutive fine days during the ripening period, the grains of wheat will grow to the fullest and abundant food is secured. A saying in Yangzhou goes "Wheat of one *cun* tall is not afraid of water of a *chi* deep", which means that during the beginning phase of the growing period, abundant water is not a problem. However, the saying "Wheat of one *chi* tall is afraid of water of one *cun* deep" means that during the ripening period even water of one *cun* deep will make the wheat roots loosen, therefore the wheat straws will fall into the muddy field and the wheat groat will rot. A kind of fat sparrow south of the Yangtze will flock to the wheat field for food. These sparrows affect an area of no more than a circumference of tens of *li*. But north of the Yangtze, if locusts appear, it will definitely be a disastrous year.

Millet

Millet can be glutinous or non-glutinous (with the glutinous millet used to brew wine). People in the north regard the round-grained non-glutinous food crop as rice, and the rest of the varieties as millet in general. Proso millet is non-glutinous. Millet and proso millet are put in the same general category of millet. Glutinous millet and foxtail millet are called *shu* which is white, red, yellow or black in colour. Some people call the black *shu* proso millet, which is incorrect. Proso millet ripens earlier than other food crops and is used for memorial services.

In the Chinese classics *Book of Poetry* and *Book of History*, millet has different names such as *qi*, *ju*, and *pi*, while in modern dialect it is alternatively called ox hair, swallow's cheek, horsehide, donkey skin, rice tail, and so on. The earliest millet is sown in March and ripens in May; if it is sown in April, it ripens in July. The latest sowing of millet is in May and it ripens in August. The blossoming and fruit-bearing of millet are different from those of barley and wheat. The size of millet grains depends on the fertility of the soil and whether it is planted at the right time. Therefore, it is inappropriate for the scholars in the Song dynasty to rigidly use the grain of millet of a particular locality as a standard to judge the quality of all millet produced everywhere.

Foxtail millet and millet are both referred to as coarse rice, and glutinous millet can be used for brewing wine. Another kind of millet is called sorghum because its stalk is seven *chi* tall like reeds and amur silvergrass. Sorghum and millet are of more types and have more names than millet and proso millet. They are named after a surname, a mountain or a river, the shape, or the time when it is planted. People in Shandong province call sorghum and millet "grain". All these food crops are sown in the spring and harvested in the autumn. The way they are sown and weeded are the same as those of barley and wheat, but the time of sowing and harvesting is quite different.

Beans

There are as many kinds of beans as there are of rice and millet. The sowing and harvesting are done anytime throughout the year. Beans have become an integral part of the daily food. Soybeans are further divided into May soybeans, June soybeans, and winter soybeans. May soybeans have the lowest output, while the output of winter soybeans is twice as much as that of May soybeans. Black soybeans are harvested in August. The horses and mules that travel long distances north of the Huaihe River in eastern China are fed with black soybeans to maintain their strength.

The output of soybeans depends on the soil quality, the frequency of weeding and the amount of rainfall. Soybeans are the raw materials for fermented soybeans, soybean sauce, and bean curd. South of the Yangtze, there are long-stalk soybeans, which are sown after the harvest of early-ripening rice in June and harvested in September or October.

In the locality of Ji'an, Jiangxi province, the method of soybean sowing is quite unique. The rice paddy field is not ploughed after the harvest. Three or four seed soybeans are dropped by hand into each rice stubble. The dew gathered on the stubble moistens the seeds, and the rotten rice stubble nourishes them. After the seed soybeans grow into seedlings, they are watered once in dry weather. Weeding is required to secure a good harvest. But before the seed soybeans grow into seedlings, farmers have to prevent the turtle doves and sparrows from eating the seeds.

Mung beans are as small as beads. They must not be planted until the Lesser Heat. If they are planted before that, the mung bean seedlings will grow a few metres tall, but bear fewer pods. If planting is delayed until The End of Heat, the beans will blossom and bear pods all the time. There are two kinds of mung beans, the "ripe-and-pick" type, which means farmers pick the ripe pods on a daily basis, and the "ripe-and-pull" type, which means farmers harvest by pulling up the bean stalks when all the beans are ripe. Mung beans can be ground into bean milk or ground into powder, which can be made into sheet jelly and flat noodles. The liquid waste left over in the process of making mung bean powder is used as fertilizer. For storage, seed mung beans are mixed with ashes of grass, lime, knotweed or loess so that they will not be eaten by worms.

When planting mung beans in summer and autumn in the rice paddy field after rice is harvested, pound the lumps of earth with a long axe handle so that bean seedlings will grow well. If there is a heavy rainfall the day the mung beans are planted, the soil will become so hard that the seedlings cannot come out of the earth. After the seedlings appear, drain the irrigation furrows in the fields to prevent the seedlings from being drowned. The mung bean and soybean fields are not to be ploughed deep because these two types of beans do not have deep roots and the seedlings are straight. Lumps in the process of deep ploughing bend the seedlings, and it is possible that up to half of them will not grow well. Deep ploughing is not suitable for the growing of beans, but it was not realized by farmers before.

Red beans have been used as medicine and proved effective besides being used as food. White beans, also called rice beans, are cooked together with rice. Both types of beans are sown at the Summer Solstice and harvested in September. They are widely planted in areas between the Yangtze and Huaihe River. Another kind of beans is called black lentil, which in the old days was a wild plant, but is now planted widely in northern China. As a replacement for mung beans, they can be ground to make sheet jelly. Pedlars in Beijing sell sheet jelly from street to street, which indicates its large output. White hyacinth beans, also called eyebrow-shape beans, grow along fences. There are still other kinds of beans, such as cowpeas, tiger-spot beans, knife-shape beans, black-colour soybeans, and brown-colour soybeans, which are planted in certain areas, to name just a few. Beans can be used as vegetables or the main food. No wonder naturalists value them.

In the western part of Zhejiang province, broad beans are extensively planted under mulberries, bearing pods even if the tree leaves are dense. But some other food crops cannot grow well under trees. Broad bean pods look like silkworms and the kernels are larger than soybeans. If they are planted in August, they will be harvested in April of the following year. In the upper reaches of the Xianghe River and Hanshui River in central China, broad beans are also plentiful, therefore less expensive. Broad beans are no less significant than millet or proso millet in terms of their usefulness as food.

Processing of rice, wheat, millet, and beans

Rice

The grains of rice are removed from the stalks after harvest, half of which are obtained by thrashing the stalks on a hard object, and the other half by spreading the rice stalks on the ground to be run over by an ox-pulled stone roller. A handful of rice stalks held in both hands are thrashed on a cask or on a slate. If it is sunny and the rice stalks are dry, it is more convenient to do the thrashing (Figure 2.8). If there are more

Figure 2.8 Rice thrashing on dry ground

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 59

rainy days and fewer sunny days during the harvest season, both the field and the rice will be wet, and the rice stalks should not be put on the ground. In this case, thrashing the rice stalks on the inside of the cask in the field is done after harvest.

Obtaining rice grains with an ox-pulled stone roller requires just one-third of the labour compared with the hand-thrashing method. However, using a stone roller has the danger of damaging the rice grains, reducing the chance of germinating of the seed rice the next year, so farmers thrash rice stalks on slates to get seed rice for next year's planting. Farmers in southern China who grow plentiful rice often use an ox-pulled stone roller to obtain rice grains (Figure 2.9). In the best rice there are nine full grains out of ten and only one is blighted. People in the south use winnowers to blow off blighted grains. Less rice is planted in the north than in the south.

People use a *Long*, a rice huller like a stone mill, to remove the rice husks. They use pestles and rollers to grind rice. People can also hull rice with a mill, a treadle-operated tilt hammer for hulling rice. Dry rice can be processed by rollers without using the *Long*.

After hulling rice with a *Long*, people use a winnower to remove the chaff and blighted grains, and then shake it in a sieve (Figure 2.10). The rice grains which are not hulled well will come to the surface and are poured into the *Long* to be hulled again. Big sieves have a circumference of five *chi* and small ones are only half this size. The small sieves have edges of two *cun* tall around and are sunken a little in the centre, but light enough for women to use. After being sieved, the rice grains are poured into a mortar to be pounded. There are two types of mortars. A family of eight or more members will dig a hole in the ground and fix a stone mortar in the hole. Big mortars can hold five *dou* of rice, while small ones hold half of this amount. A crossbar is inserted into the head of a mill. The pounding mill is operated by hands and feet. A farmer will step on the end of the crossbar and begin to pound.

A water-powered mill is used by people who live beside rivers in the mountainous areas. It is constructed the same way as the cylinder wheel for irrigation. The number of mortars placed on the water-powered

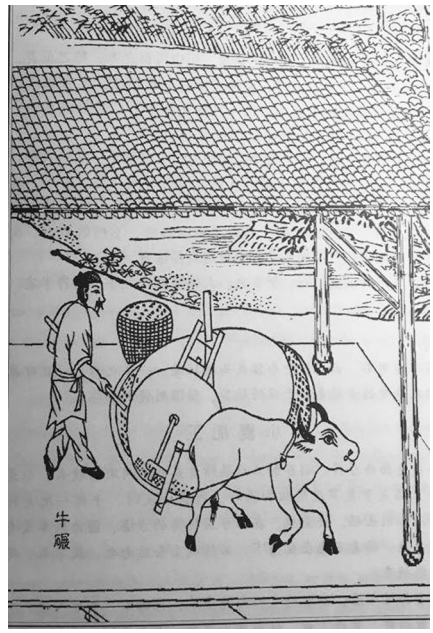

Figure 2.9 The ox-pulled rolling mill

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House(2011), p. 73

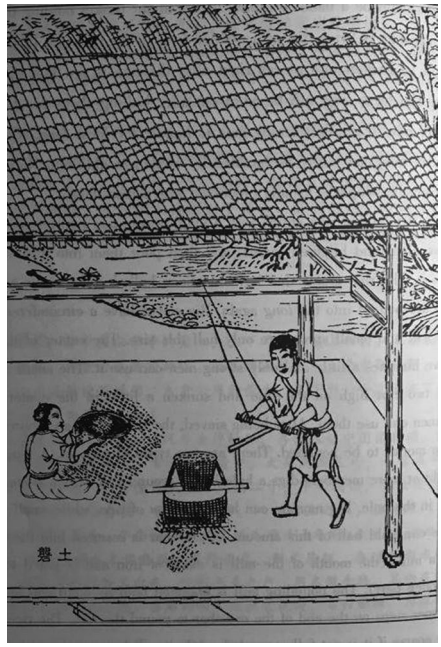

Figure 2.10 The loess *Long*

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 66

mill varies. People put two or three mortars in places where the water supply and the land area are limited. There is no problem placing ten mortars side by side where the volume of water is large and land is plentiful.

Wheat

Wheat is the raw material for flour. The finest rice is obtained from the processing of unhusked rice by pounding twice, while the top quality wheat flour is obtained from the processing of wheat by sifting repeatedly. The way of reaping wheat by hand is the same as reaping rice. People in the north winnow wheat by hand, for the winnower is not widely used. Farmers cannot winnow wheat under the eaves, and they have to wait till it is windy. Winnowing can't be done when there is no wind or when it is raining.

After being winnowed, the wheat is washed in water to get rid of the dust, dried in the sun and then ground. Wheat is of two colours, purple or yellow; the purple wheat is better than the yellow one in quality. One hundred and twenty *jin* of flour is obtained from every *dan* of good wheat, while one-third less comes from the inferior wheat. There is no fixed size for flour mills. The large ones are operated by strong oxen; the small ones are light, easy to turn, and are operated by donkeys; and the still smaller ones can be operated by human beings.

The mill is made of two kinds of stone, thus the quality of flour produced in this manner depends on the stone from which the mill is made. There is little top-grade flour south of the Yangtze. The stone gets hot when grinding, so the bran is broken and mixed with the flour and cannot be sifted out. The stone north of the Yangtze is cold, fine and smooth, especially the stone produced in Chizhou Prefecture in Jiuhua Mountain (Qingyang County, Anhui province nowadays). The mill made of this kind of stone will not easily get hot, and the bran will not be broken even though it is pressed flat, and the bran will not mix with the flour, and the flour obtained is extraordinarily white as a result. Mills south of the Yangtze will be worn out after twenty days of use, while those north of the Yangtze will last as long as six months. What's more, 100 *jin* of flour for every *dan* is obtained by a mill south of the Yangtze, as there is bran mixed in the flour, while north of the Yangtze, only eighty *jin* is obtained. Therefore, the price of the wheat flour will increase by twenty percent. After being ground, the flour is poured into a sifter and sifted several times. The ready-to-eat flour can be stored for three months in cold weather, but in spring and summer, the flour will turn bad within twenty days if stored in an improper way.

Millet and beans

Farmers winnow to get millet, pound to get millet grains and grind to get millet powder. Besides winnowing in the wind or using a winnower, another method is shaking the millet with a winnowing riddle. Thin bamboo strips are woven into an oblong pan called a riddle. Pour the millet into the riddle and shake the riddle in the air. The lighter particles will fly to the front and fall to the ground, and the heavy particles remaining in the riddle are the good fully-grown millet. The method of pounding, grinding and winnowing is the same as that of processing other grains, like rice and wheat. In addition, a small rolling mill is used to process millet in northern China. A stone frustum whose centre is higher than the outer edges is placed in the house. Millet is spread on the frustum. Two women sit face to face, each holding a stone roller to press and grind the millet in turn. The roller is cylindrical in shape and is much the same as the roller driven by an ox, but there are wooden handles on both ends. At the same time, when the millet falls off to the edges, the millet should be immediately swept to the centre with a small brush. There is no need to use any mortar and pestle when a household has such a stone roller to use.

After the reaping of beans, farmers use a flail to get the pods from the bean stalks. The flail is constructed by using a bamboo or wooden pole as the handle, by drilling a round hole in one end and tying on a crab-stick about three *chi* long. Spread the bean stalks on the ground and beat them with a flail. When there is a

large amount of beans, farmers spread the stalks on the ground, dry them in the sun, and then get the pods by using an ox-pulled stone roller. After that, farmers use a winnower to get rid of the remaining pods. Then after sifting in a sifter, the beans can be stored in a barn.

The making of sugar

There are two types of sugar cane, abounding in Fujian and Guangdong provinces. The output of all the other provinces combined makes up only ten percent of the output of these two provinces. The "fruit" sugar cane, looking like bamboo but bigger, can be cut off and chewed raw for the sweet juice. However, it cannot be used to refine sugar. The "reed-like" sugar cane, looking like reed but smaller, is too thorny to be eaten raw, because it cuts one's lips and tongue. White sugar and brown granulated sugar are made from the "reed-like" sugar cane.

The planting of sugar canes

The best time to plant sugar canes is the early winter before the fall of frost. The sugar cane are uprooted and buried in the earth (avoiding low ground or places where water gathers) after removing the tops and roots. Five or six days before the solar term of Rain Water in the following spring, the sugar canes are dug out of the earth on sunny days. They are cut into sections of five or six *cun* long, with two joints in a section. Then all the sections will be laid on the ground next to each other and then covered with earth. The ends of the sections overlap like fish scales. The two buds on each section of the sugar cane should be put in a level position since it is difficult for them to sprout when the buds are covered by each other. When the buds grow to one or two *cun* tall, they are watered with liquid manure frequently. When the young sugar cane plants are six or seven *cun* tall, it is time to transplant them.

The sandy soil is best for planting sugar canes, especially the alluvial soil along rivers. To test whether the soil is right for the sugar canes, the earth is dug one *chi* and five *cun* deep and a sample of the sandy soil is tasted in the mouth. If it tastes bitter, no sugar cane should be planted in it. However, sugar canes should not be planted along the upper reaches of rivers or streams close to remote mountains either, even though the soil there is sweet because the cold weather in the mountain areas will give the sugar cane a bitter taste later on. The flat land near the river facing the sun, which is about forty or fifty *li* away from the mountains, is the best location for planting sugar canes (but sugar canes are not planted in yellow soil).

The land for planting sugar canes should be prepared by ploughing it into four-*chi*-wide ridges with four-*cun*-deep ditches. Three sections of sugar canes are put in every seven-*chi*-long ditch and covered with one *cun* of soil. It is difficult for the sugar cane to sprout when the earth is too thick. When four or five buds appear on the sugar canes, they should be dug up gently. Frequent ploughing and weeding are needed for the sugar canes to grow well. The amount of manure needed depends mainly on the fertility of the soil. When the sugar canes are one or two *chi* tall, water-soaked cakes of sesame or rapeseeds can be used as manure for the sugar canes within the ditches. When the sugar canes are about two or three *chi* tall, the ox can be used to cultivate the fields. The field should be ploughed twice a month, first for turning up the soil and cutting off the side roots, and the second time for banking up the soil and protecting the roots which should be done at the beginning of September so that the roots will not be damaged by frost and snow.

The types of sugar refined from the "reed-like" sugar canes include rock sugar, white sugar and brown sugar. The variety of sugar is determined by the age of the sugar cane juice. The rind of the sugar cane will become dark red in autumn gradually and then turn brown after the Winter Solstice and finally turn white. In the frostless area in the south of Wuling Mountains which run across Hunan, Jiangxi, and Guangdong provinces, the sugar canes can be kept in the field for making white sugar. But in the north of Nanxiong and Shaoguan, Guangdong province, frost occurs in October and consequently the sugar canes will be destroyed, therefore they should be cut down ten days before frost occurs in order to make brown sugar. If

they are cut down earlier, there will be not enough juice, and if later, it is possible that the frost will nullify all the previous efforts. Therefore the farmers, who plant ten *mu* of sugar canes, should prepare a cart for making sugar and a pan for urgent use. In the frost-free area of southern Guangdong, the time to cut down sugar canes is completely up to the farmers.

Brown sugar

The vertical roll crusher used for crushing sugar canes in sugar making is constructed as follows: Take two wooden boards measuring five *chi* long, two *chi* wide, and five *cun* thick. Drill holes at the ends of each board to accommodate the supporting posts. The upper ends should extend two or three *chi* below the lower board and be buried in the ground, so that the whole apparatus will be stable. At the centre of the upper board two openings should be made, through which two large rollers made of very hard wood are placed next to each other. It would be best to have the rollers measuring seven *chi* in circumference. One of the rollers should be three *chi* long, the other four and a half *chi* in length. Affixed to the protruding end of the latter one is a curved pole measuring one *zhang* and five *chi* in length which is made of a bent pole, attached to an ox which turns the roll crusher. The surfaces of both rollers are deeply corrugated or cogged; the cogs of one roll fit into the grooves between cogs of the other. The sugar canes pass between the two toothed rollers and are pressed and crushed (Figure 2.11). This works on the same principle as the cotton gin.

Juice will flow out when the sugar canes are pressed by the wooden rollers. Then the pressed sugar canes will be inserted into the duckbill on the roller again and again to make sure all the juice has been squeezed

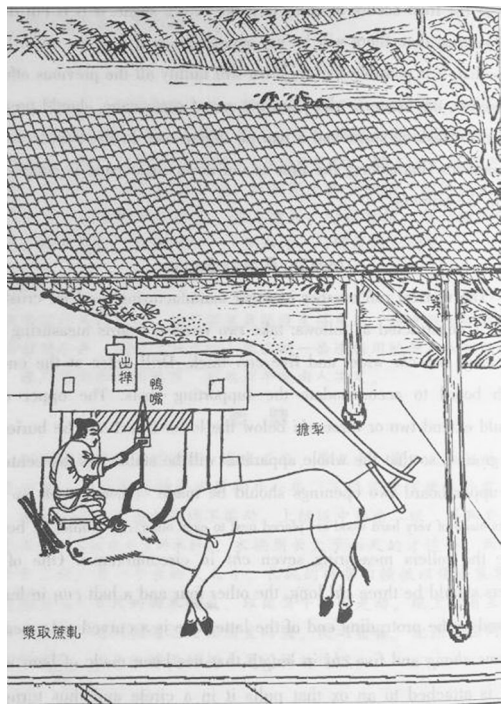

Figure 2.11 Crushing sugar canes with a vertical-toothed roll crusher

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 114

out, with the residue used as firewood. Dig two holes of one and a half *cun* deep on the horizontal plank which support the pair of rollers to prevent the axle from cutting through the plank. Then the sugar cane juice will remain on the plank. In order for the roller to rotate more smoothly, some iron pellet is affixed to the bottom of the axle. There are slots on the horizontal plank through which the sugar cane juice can flow into the jar. Every *dan* of sugar cane juice should be mixed with half a *sheng* of lime to coagulate undesirable impurities. In boiling the sugar cane juice for sugar, put three cooking pots to form a triangle and use them simultaneously. Gather the thick syrup which is obtained after boiling the thin juice in the three pots and transfer it into one pot. Then pour more thin juice into the other two pots. If the heat is insufficient, even with a lack of just a handful of firewood, the juice will become irregular, and it will be full of foam and become useless.

White sugar

The old sugar canes kept in the field throughout the winter in the south of Fujian and Guangdong provinces are pressed in roll crushers to get juice in the same way as described in the previous section. The heat control for refining the juice of the sugar cane can be adjusted by watching the bubbles when boiling. When small bubbles like the bubbles of boiled meat broth appear and the juice becomes sticky, the boiling is sufficient. The colour of the boiled syrup is dark yellowish. Next the syrup is put in a barrel for it to turn into dark granule. An earthenware funnel, made of pottery, is set on the jar. The top of the funnel is wide while the bottom is narrow; there is a small hole at the bottom, which is clogged with straw. The dark granule is put into the funnel. When it is congealed, the straw in the hole is removed and yellow-earth water is poured into the funnel. The black residue is rinsed into the jar so the white sugar is left in the funnel (Figure 2.12). The five-*cun*-thick top layer, purely white, is called "western sugar," because western sugar is very white. At the bottom part, the sugar is somewhat yellow-brown in colour.

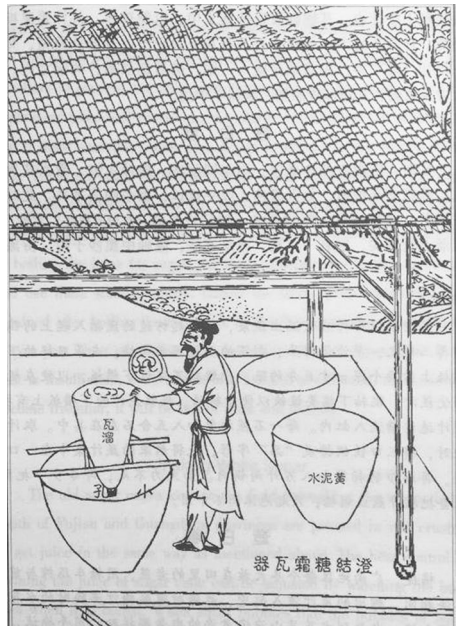

Figure 2.12 Making white sugar

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 115

To make rock sugar, the white sugar is dissolved in water and the dross is distilled with egg white, with sufficient heating. New bamboo is split into thin strips one *cun* long and put into the white sugar syrup. Overnight they will become rock sugar, like natural ice cubes. Rock sugar can be made into different shapes such as lions, elephants or dolls. The quality of rock sugar varies. There are five grades of white sugar including "rock mountain", which is of the top grade, followed by "clustered branch", "glossy jar", "small grain" and "sandy bottom", the lowest grade.

Animal-shaped candies

To make animal-shaped candies, put fifty *jin* of sugar in a large pot and light a fire under the pot to boil the sugar slowly. When the heating starts from one side of the pot, the sugar syrup will boil slowly. But if the heating starts directly under the pot, the sugar syrup will seethe in an all-round way and spatter and overflow. Dissolve egg white from three eggs in five *sheng* of cold water to make a mixture of liquid, and add it with a spoon slowly into the pot. The sugar syrup with the added mixture of liquid in the pot is heated slowly so that the impurities and scum will come to the surface, which are skimmed off with a rattan strainer. At this moment the sugar syrup will become very pure and white. Then put the sugar syrup into a small copper pot with handles and an outlet. Keep it warm over a slow fire of coal powder. Then pour the sugar syrup into a mould when the temperature is just proper. The mould for lion and elephant shapes is composed of two pieces of pottery that come together to form a complete mould. Pour the sugar syrup into the mould and turn the mould around so that the syrup will flow off to make the animal-shape candies. Because the syrup is hot but the mould is cold, a layer of sugar close to the mould will naturally adhere to the interior of the mould and become solidified. The candies made this way are called "feast candies" and are used at banquets only.

The production of salt

Types of salt

Generally speaking, there are six sources of salt, namely sea salt, lake salt, well salt, earth salt, rock salt, and gravel salt. In traditional China, sea salt accounts for eighty percent of all the salt produced and consumed. Some of these salts are produced by using human labour, while others are obtained in their natural state. In those areas where boats or carts cannot reach to provide the local people with salt, nature will offer some kind of salt for them.

Sea salt

Sea water contains plentiful salt. The high ground beside the sea is called a tidal mound and the low ground is called a marsh, and in both places salt is produced. There are different methods to obtain salt from the sea. One way is to extract salt on the high ground which cannot be flooded by the tides. When salt producers predict that it will not rain the next day, they will spread ashes of rice, wheat, and reed stalks about one *cun* thick over a wide area, and press to make them smooth. When the dew begins to evaporate the next morning, salt will come out of the ashes, just like couch grass. When the sun comes out, the salt will be swept up together with the ashes to be leached and crystallized (Figure 2.13).

Another way of extracting salt is to obtain it on the low ground without using ashes. The low ground is first submerged by the tide. Wait until the tide recedes and the weather is sunny. Then a layer of salt frost will appear on the surface after the ground is exposed to the sun for half a day. The salt thus obtained is swept up and refined immediately. People can also dig pits in the ground and lead the sea water into the pits. Some bamboo or wooden sticks are put across the opening of the pit; it is then covered with a reed mat, and sand

Figure 2.13 Extracting sea salt

Source: Tian Gong Kai Wu, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 102

is spread over the mat. When the tide comes in and covers the ground, the brine will drip through the sand into the pit. The mat and sand are then removed and a lamp is used to heat the brine in the pit. When the brine evaporates, the lamp goes out. The brine is then taken out and refined.

A very important factor for all these methods of extracting salt is the fine weather, and if there is a prolonged spell of rain, a "salt famine" will result. In Huai'an and Yangzhou, Jiangsu province, salt frost in the shape of horse teeth rises to the surface of the ground and crystallizes in the sun naturally. It is called "sun-dried salt" and does not need decocting and refining. After it is collected from the ground, it is ready to use. If some grass and straw come along with the sea water and sea wind, and are drift ashore, they can also be collected and boiled to obtain salt. Salt obtained this way is called "straw salt".

The way to leach and decoct salt is to dig two pits side by side, with a shallow one about one *chi* deep, and a deep one about seven or eight *chi* deep which will receive the brine from the shallow pit. Cover the pits with a reed mat using the support of crossbars of bamboo or wood over the shallow pit. Spread the salt collected from the ground on the mat (the method of draining is the same whether or not ashes are mixed with the raw salt). The edges of the mat should be a little tall and be shaped like a dam. Pour sea water into the centre of the mat; the sea water will become brine and drain into the shallow pit. The brine then drains down into the deep pit. Finally, boil the brine in a pan for crystallization.

In traditional China there are two types of pans for crystallizing salt, the Iron Pan and the Bamboo Pan. The Iron Pan has a circumference of several *zhang* and is about one *zhang* in diameter. It is constructed by striking iron into iron plates and the iron plates are put together by iron rivets. The bottom of the Iron Pan is level and the outer edges should be 1.2 *chi* tall. The seams of the pan are filled with the salt from the brine and so they are watertight at all times. The furnace under the pan has as many as thirteen (at least seven to eight) doors at which fire is lighted at the same time to heat the pan. In the coastal areas in the south some

pans are made of bamboo, thus called the Bamboo Pan. Bamboo is woven into pans one *Zhang* in width and one *chi* in depth. The Bamboo Pan is plastered with clamshell lime and is attached to the inside of a large iron pot. When fired is lighted under the pot, heat is transmitted to the Bamboo Pan, and the brine boils, subsequently crystallizing into salt. But these pans are not as practical as the iron ones.

Salt dissolves whenever it meets water, becomes brine whenever it meets wind, and turns stronger when meeting fire. It is not necessary to store salt in a warehouse, as salt can stand moisture, but not wind. Spread a layer of straw about three *cun* thick on the ground. It doesn't matter whether the ground is low and wet. If people lay adobes around and fill the gaps with loess, then cover it with one *chi* of couch grass, the salt will stay intact and fine even for as long as 100 years.

Lake salt

Lake salt is produced in two places in China: one in Ningxia Hui Autonomous Region, northwestern China, which is supplied to the northwestern frontier towns, and the other in Jiechi (the Jie Lake), Shanxi province, also in northwestern China, which is provided for the counties and towns in Shanxi and Henan provinces. Jiechi, surrounded by a rampart for protection, is located in the intersection of Anyi, Dishi, and Linjin, the locality of Yuncheng in Shanxi province nowadays. The deep lake water is dark green. Native salt producers plough the field beside the lake into ridges and conduct clean water to the ridges. They take care not to let in turbid water; otherwise, the turbid water will silt up the ridges.

People plough the land near the lake into plots separated by dykes and introduce clear brine from the lake into the plots. The extracting of salt is done in spring. If it is done later than the required time, the brine will turn red. Toward late summer or early autumn when the south wind blows hard across this area, the brine evaporates completely and salt crystallizes overnight, which is called "grain salt", also termed "large salt" in ancient books, because this kind of lake salt is formed in big crystals – hence the term "large" while sea salt is finely granulated. Lake salt can be used as table salt soon after it crystallizes and is gathered. In both Haifeng, today's Salt Mountain County and Shenzhou, today's Shenxian County in Hebei province, where sea water is introduced into ponds on the shore and crystallized by the sun, salt can also be used directly as table salt without refining, which is the same as Xiechi salt.

Well salt

Yunnan and Sichuan provinces are remote from the sea. Moreover, these places are geographically at a high altitude, so boats and carts cannot reach there easily. Their source of salt is buried deep underground. But there are rocky mountains in Sichuan province which are not far from rivers. People dig wells and get salt from them. The shaft of the well is no more than several *cun* in diameter. It is so small that a small-sized basin can cover it. But the well has to be drilled over ten *zhang* deep to get to the salt bed. Therefore, it takes great efforts to dig such a salt well. The tool used to drill holes in the mountain rocks is an iron drill with a very hard and sharp tip which is shaped like the blade of a chisel. The drill is suspended and held in place by a bundle of split bamboo strips and fastened together with ropes. Each time the rock is drilled a few *chi* deep, the bamboo-suspender is lengthened by fixing another section of bamboo to it. When the salt well is drilled one *zhang* deep or so, the drilling device is operated by stepping on it with one's feet, in the same way of pounding rice in a mortar. When the salt well is drilled still deeper, the drilling device is operated by hand (Figure 2.14). The fragments of rock that result from the drilling are scooped up with an iron vessel attached to a long bamboo pole. It takes more than a month to dig a shallow salt well, and half a year to dig a deep one.

The reason why the shaft of a salt well is made small is that a wide shaft allows the brine to degrade through dissipation of its vapour and become unsuitable for salt making. When the brine level in the well is reached, good bamboo poles about one *zhang* long are chosen, and all the inner section partitions except the one at the bottom end are removed; a valve that allows the brine to enter is set in that partition. The

Figure 2.14 Drilling a salt well in Sichuan Province

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 103

bamboo pole is lowered into the well with a long rope. After it is filled with brine, it is lifted to the surface by means of a pulley fixed over the well and a windlass turned by an ox-powered wheel. The brine thus obtained is then poured into a pan for evaporation and crystallization (only a medium-sized pan rather than an Iron Pan is used). Well salt with a very white colour is obtained from the crystallization process.

Conclusion

In summary, the Chinese farming techniques up to the Ming dynasty used to lead the world. Farmers in traditional China made great achievements in the cultivation of rice, wheat, millet, and beans, the processing of them, the making of sugar and the production of salt of many different types, which have promoted agricultural development in China on the one hand, and contributed much to world agricultural progress on the other. It is hoped that researchers and scholars both home and abroad will find this brief introduction informative and useful to their academic research.

Note 1: Equivalents of Chinese Units of Weight and Measure to Metric Units

Li (里) in kilometres	one *li* is 0.5 kilometres
zhang (丈) in centimetres	one *zhang* is 311 centimetres
chi (尺) in centimetres	one *chi* is 31.10 centimetres
cun (寸) in centimetres	3.11 centimetres
dan (石) in liters	one *dan* is 107.4 liters
dou (斗)in liters	one *dou* is 10.74 liters

sheng (升) in liters	one *sheng* is 1.074 liters
jin (斤) in grams	one *jin* is 596.82 grams
mu (亩) in hectare	one *mu* is one fifteenth of a hectare, that is about 0.067 hectare

(Ten *sheng* makes one *dou* and ten *dou* makes one *dan*)

Note 2: Some Solar Terms in China

Solar Term	**Approximate Solar Date**
雨水 Rain Water (2nd solar term)	Feb.18,19 or 20
春分 Spring Equinox (4th solar term)	Mar.20,21 or 22
清明 Pure Brightness (5th solar term)	Apr.4,5 or 6
夏至 Summer Solstice (10th solar term)	Jun.21 or 22
小暑 Lesser Heat (11th solar term)	Jul.6,7 or 8
处暑 End of Heat (14th solar term)	Aug.22,23 or 24
冬至 Winter Solstice (22th solar term)	Dec.21,22 or 23

Note 3

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3
BEES IN CHINESE CULTURE

David Pattinson

The honeybee seems to have been nearly ubiquitous in pre-modern China. Many local gazetteers record bees and bee products in their lists of produce; sundry essays, notebook entries, and poems further attest to the presence of bees and beekeeping in many parts of China. Nevertheless, bees occupied a less prominent place in Chinese culture than this ubiquity suggests. There are only scattered and mostly brief references to them before the Song dynasty (960–1279 CE), and while the spread of printing from the tenth century did mean more texts on bees were produced and have survived, they remained comparatively few in number throughout the late imperial period. Perhaps crucially, there are almost no clear references to honeybees in the pre-Qin philosophical classics; the specific term *mifeng* 蜜蜂 "honey-bee", does not appear in any extant text until the third century CE. Before that, the character *feng* 蜂, which can refer to wasps and hornets as well as bees, is usually used alone, and *feng* are portrayed negatively as swarming, stinging insects. Although we know honey was being consumed in what is now northern China by the seventh millennium BCE, the word for it, *mi* 蜜, rarely appears in early texts; archaeological finds and textual references suggest that beeswax may have been the more important bee product. While honey clearly became more important with time, even in the 1630s Song Yingxing 宋應星 (1587–1666) in his *Works of Heaven and the Inception of Things*, a kind of technical encyclopedia, claimed that four-fifths of sweeteners came from plants, mostly sugar cane, and only a fifth of honey came from kept bees, the rest being hunted from cliffs and caves (*Tiangong kaiwu*《天工開物》62, 66). Nevertheless, by the Song period more sophisticated understandings of honeybees and beekeeping had developed, probably not coincidentally paralleled by richer literary representations of bee colonies, mostly as Confucian royal courts.

The earliest evidence we have for human use of a bee product is traces of honey on pottery from the Jiahu culture some 8,000 years ago, where it seems to have been used in a rice-based alcoholic beverage along with fruit (McGovern *et al* 2004). However, it is only in tombs dating from approximately 500 BCE excavated in central China that we find the next clear evidence for the use of bee products, now as a binding agent for inlaid turquoise ornamentation on swords (Luo *et al* 2012; Wei *et al* 2016). There is some textual evidence for beeswax candles by the early Han period in the book *Miscellaneous Notes of the Western Capital*, a collection of stories and anecdotes about the Western Han (206 BCE – 8 CE) capital Chang'an attributed to the Daoist scholar Ge Hong 葛洪 (282–343 or 363). In one entry, the Prince of Min and Yue (approximately the region of modern Fujian province and beyond) presented the first Han emperor, Gaozu (r. 206–195 BCE) with 200 beeswax candles *mizhu* 蜜燭, with which the emperor was very pleased (*Xijing zaji*《西京雜記》4.2b).[1] Ge is said to have obtained the material for his book from the surviving library of the Han scholar Liu Xin 劉歆 (c. 50 BCE.-23 CE), but it is difficult to know how reliable anecdotes such as

this are. If the story is true, the emperor's pleasure at receiving the candles suggests that they were novel, so the use of beeswax for lighting probably does not precede the Han by very long. Perhaps the earliest physical evidence we have for beeswax being used for lighting comes from a first-century BCE tomb in western Jiangsu province, where two lumps of beeswax were found close to several bronze lamps (Ma *et al* 2015).

However, the most tantalizing, and controversial, question regarding the early use of beeswax is whether or not the Chinese knew lost-wax bronze casting techniques by at least the early Warring States period. Those who argue that lost-wax casting was known in China by this time assert that certain bronze vessels, such as the *zunpan* 尊盤 ritual wine vessel discovered in the late fifth-century BCE tomb of Marquis Yi 侯乙 of the state of Zeng 曾, could not have been cast by any other technique, and point to certain features of the bronzes they believe are symptomatic of lost-wax casting. Those who disagree contend that it is possible to produce such bronze items using piece-mould casting techniques, offering alternative explanations for the characteristics which seem to indicate that beeswax was used, while drawing attention to other characteristics, such as mould seam lines, which suggest the piece-mould casting was used (Zhou and Huang 2015; Mei J et al., 2015). A further argument against the early use of the lost-wax technique is that there are no textual references to it until the thirteenth-century book on cultural artefacts by Zhao Xigu 趙希鵠 (fl. 1180–1240) (*Dongtian qinglu*《洞天清錄》*·la mo* 蠟模). In any case, the question remains far from resolved.

It has been suggested that beeswax being used for candles by the Western Han is indirect evidence for the existence of beekeeping by the same period (Ma et al 2015: 557); if lost-wax casting was known that would suggest an even stronger need for a reliable supply of beeswax. However, the quantities of beeswax discovered, and even the number of bronze items claimed to have been manufactured using lost-wax techniques, are not sufficient to suggest that beekeeping was necessary to supply beeswax in addition to that which could be obtained by hunting wild honeycombs. Furthermore, while it would not be necessary to have the sort of abundant evidence we have from, say, ancient Egypt (Kritsky 2015) to prove the existence of beekeeping by the early Han, the lack of any textual or physical evidence for beekeeping at all suggests that if beekeeping was practised by this period, it was the preserve of farmers, and not something with which the state or other elites felt the need to concern themselves.

The earliest apparently reliable evidence for beekeeping is for the mid-second century CE in the biography of the Confucian scholar Jiang Qi 姜岐 (fl. 158–166), who lived in Hanyang commandery in the region of modern Tianshui 天水 in Gansu province. This appears in the *Biographies of Men of Noble Character* written by Huangfu Mi 皇甫謐 (214–282) (*Gaoshi zhuan*《高士傳》, *xia*.17a-b). After successfully resisting threats against him and his mother from the governor of Hanyang if he did not join the governor's administration, Jiang "went to live in the mountains, where he kept bees and pigs". The biography says nothing about his beekeeping techniques or the consumers of his bee products, only noting in a verse at the end of the biography that "Minding pigs and managing bees, on society's edge he lived unfettered and free".

Writing soon after Huangpu, the Western Jin dynasty official and writer Zhang Hua 張華 (232–300) included an entry on bee-baiting and beekeeping in his *Record of Myriad Things*. Zhang describes how in springtime people in mountain areas made wooden boxes and drilled into them a hole (or a few holes) just big enough for bees to enter through, then rubbed the inside and out of these boxes with beeswax. They would then catch a few bees and put them in the boxes, letting them out a few days later. The bees would fly away, but soon return with more bees until there were countless numbers of them. In summer the farmers would open the boxes and extract the beeswax (*Bowu zhi*《博物志》, 10.2a-b; *Taiping yulan*, 950.3b-4a).

Both this and the Jiang Qi biography suggest that beekeeping was mainly the preserve of people living in mountain districts where wild swarms were more common. Zhang's account suggests that although farmers had worked out how to capture swarms, they did not yet know how to keep them over the winter, so their success owed a great deal to chance. It also makes no mention of honey, further suggesting that beeswax was the more important product. However, a surviving fragment from *Yongjia Gazetteer*, a fifth-century text about the area around modern Wenzhou on the southeast coast, describes a similar bee-baiting

process but mentions honey, not beeswax. It also uses the specific term *mifeng* "honeybee" (*Yongjia diji* 永嘉地記, in *Taiping yulan* 950.3b).

This was not the first extant native Chinese text to use the term *mifeng*, though. That occurs in the *Rhapsody on Honeybees* (*Mifeng fu* 蜜蜂賦) by the official and scholar Guo Pu 郭樸 (276–324). Guo's rhyme-prose text describes the behaviour of wild honeybees in some detail, albeit with poetic licence: Guo marvels at how the bees soar and swirl over the forests and valleys, yet come together at the appointed time to build their palace and produce honey in a highly disciplined court presided over by their great ruler *da jun* 大君 (*Quan shanggu sandai Qin Han Sanguo Liuchao wen*, 120.6a-b).

In fact, the word *mifengwang* 蜜蜂王 "honeybee king" had appeared a few decades earlier in a Chinese translation of a Buddhist sutra completed in 251 CE by the monk Kang Senghui 康僧會 (d. 280). However, this "honeybee king" appears in a cautionary tale about two monks, one of whom metamorphoses into a "honeybee king" in order to warn the other: the "honeybee king" stings the other monk when he falls asleep while meditating, then itself falls asleep after drinking the nectar from a flower for long time, dropping into the mud below before flying out again, all to demonstrate the dangers of sloth and indulgence to the other monk (*Liudu jijing* 《六都集經》 64). There is no sense that the "honeybee king" is part of a colony, and although the story draws on actual bee behaviour, it does not pretend to be an accurate depiction of it. Although it is likely that Kang drew on pre-existing vocabulary – in one place he also uses what became the usual word for the bee queen *fengwang* 蜂王, understood as a king until the nineteenth century – we cannot be certain that he did not just invent the word for the sake of translation, and there is no link between this and human responses to bee behaviour in China.

Having briefly surveyed the archaeological evidence up until the earliest conclusive mentions of honeybees appear in literature, we can now turn to look at the cultural record. The appearance in the decades around the turn of the fourth century both of texts recording the existence of beekeeping and of a more positive representation of bees in Guo Pu's *Rhapsody on Honeybees* may not be entirely coincidental, though with so few texts as evidence, any conclusions must be tentative. As noted above, before this period, bees, wasps, and hornets are all simply *feng*, and these *feng* are nearly always stinging, swarming insects which are to be feared. In an exchange which allegedly took place in 638 BCE recorded in the *Zuo Commentary*, the official Zang Wenzhong 臧文仲 warned Duke Xi 僖 that he should not underestimate the small state of Zhu 邾 because small states had venom like *feng* and scorpions – the pairing of *feng* and *chai* 蠆 scorpions to allude to dangerous officials and other enemies became common (*Chunqiu Zuozhuan zhu* 《春秋左傳注》, p. 395/Duke Xi, year 22). Writers alluded to the facial features of *feng* to describe cruel people: again according to the *Zuo Commentary*, in 626 BCE the prime minister of Chu 楚 warned King Cheng 成 not to make his eldest son Crown Prince because "he has the eyes of a *feng* and the howl of a jackal" (*Chunqiu Zuozhuan zhu*, p. 514/Duke Wen, year 2), while in the first century BCE the historian Sima Qian 司馬遷 (145–86 BCE), in his *Records of the Grand Historian*, describes the First Emperor of Qin as "having the nose of a *feng* and long eyes", which although meant primarily to indicate that he had a high nose, was probably also meant to allude to his cruelty (*Shiji* 《史記》, 6.230). Sima Qian also seems to have been the first to use the term *fengqi* 蜂起 "arise like (swarming) *feng*"; in the context this referred to the emergence of local strongmen in the power vacuum that followed the death of the First Emperor, but it was later commonly used to refer to bandits, rebels, and natural disasters. Meanwhile, the sage in the Daoist *Laozi* tradition who had cultivated sufficient charismatic energy *de* 德 would be able to bring about a state in which "*feng*, scorpions and poisonous snakes will not sting or bite" (*Laozi* 《老子》, p. 276), while the Western Han *Record of the Rites of Dai the Elder* says that when a sage is in charge of a state "*feng* and scorpions do not sting children" (*Da Dai Liji* 《大戴禮記》, 71.185); being able to remove the threat of these and other dangerous animals was a sign that one had cultivated profound charismatic virtue.

Even in early reference works, where *feng* were less likely to be employed for rhetorical purposes, the negative aspects of bee behaviour were prominent. The third-century BCE lexicon *Approaching Refinement* simply records that there are earth-*feng* and tree-*feng* (*Erya zhushu* 《爾雅注疏》, 9.14b–15a), but the

first-century CE dictionary *Explaining Simple and Analysing Complex Characters* defines *feng*, here written with in the ancient variant form 螽, as "flying insects that sting people" (*Shuowen jiezi*《說文解字》, p. 13B.2b).

Even honey is seen to be potentially harmful, if Wang Chong's 王充 (27–ca. 97 CE) comments in his *Discourses Weighed in the Balance* reflect wider beliefs. Wang lists *feng* among animals that harm humans, along with the likes of tigers, snakes, and scorpions. He explains that creatures born in high places are closer to the sun, which produces hot *qi* that is *yang* (the mode of *qi* associated with the sunlight and therefore heat and brightness, in contrast to *yin*), so such creatures carry *yang* poisons which feel like burning. For this reason, Wang claims that if one eats even a bit too much honey, which because it is produced by *yang* insects is itself *yang*, one will be poisoned (*Lunheng*《論衡》, 23.1b–3b). Admittedly Wang's views on honey were not widely cited in later times, but they are consistent with the negative view of *feng* which seems to have been prevalent in his own time. And while we cannot read too much into Wang's description of the bees' habitat – and he must mean honeybees here – he seems to take for granted that honey comes from bees who live in trees, not in hives.

The only relief from the negativity comes from the *Explaining Simple and Analysing Complex Characters* entry for *guoluo* 蜾蠃, or potter wasp, which is described as "a narrow-waisted earth-*feng* (*tufeng* 土螽); according to its nature given by Heaven and Earth . . . is entirely male, and does not bear children". The *Odes* (*Shijing*《詩經》) say, "The *mingling* (snout moth) has offspring and the potter wasp carries them away on its back" (*Shuowen jiezi*《說文解字》, 13A.48b). What had actually been observed was the potter wasp stealing snout moth larvae to feed its own offspring, but it was thought that the snout moth larvae actually became potter wasps. In the *Exemplary Words of Master Yang*, written just before *Explaining Simple and Analysing Complex Characters*, Yang Xiong (53 BCE–19 CE) claimed that the potter wasps would chant over the snout moth larvae, "Be like me, be like me", after which the larvae would indeed grow into potter wasps (*Yangzi Fayan*《揚子法言》, 1.5). This understanding of the reproduction process for potter wasps would be applied to the similar-looking honeybees, whose actual reproductive process would remain unknown in China until the late nineteenth century. Since these insects apparently could reproduce without mating, they were also sometimes referred to as *zhenchong* 貞蟲 "chaste insects"; this is what Guo Pu seems to take the term to mean when he begins his *Rhapsody* by asserting that honeybees are "the aristocracy among the chaste insects". However, the earliest surviving use of the term *zhenchong* is in the fourth century BCE philosophical text *Mozi*, where it appears with general terms for other animals who, unlike humans, do not need to work for their food and clothing (*Mozi*《墨子》, 8.7a). The second-century BCE *Huainanzi* states that "the movement of chaste insects enables them to sting with their venom" (*Huainan honglie jijie*《淮南鴻烈集解》, 16.553), so if they were associated with chastity by then, this did not curb their ability to inflict harm. Nor does the idea of bees as chaste insects seem to have had much wider cultural influence, unlike in medieval European Christianity, for example.

Guo Pu's *Rhapsody on Honeybees* marks a turn in how bees are represented in literature. For the first time, honeybees are distinguished from other *feng* and are represented more positively; even their strict discipline ("their punishments are more severe than those inflicted by battle axes"), which Guo probably imagined was maintained by stinging those bees who fall short, was admired. Although Guo's bees are wild and his description of them poetic, that this text displays greater familiarity with the nature of the bee colony, and less fear of bees, suggests that by this time bee behaviour was better understood, which may have been a result of more widespread beekeeping. The proximity to bees, and time for observation which beekeeping allows, provides greater opportunities to understand how a bee colony works, including identifying the "ruler", even if the sex of that "ruler" was misunderstood.

Perhaps surprisingly given the Tang period's reputation as a "golden age" of Chinese literature, little really fresh material about bees survives from between Guo's *Rhapsody* and the late tenth century. Bees are mentioned in poems, most commonly in relation to spring and flowers, and the late Tang poet Bai Juyi 白居易 (772–846) twice refers to the *jun-chen* 君臣 ruler-official relationship within bee colonies (*Bai Juyi ji*

《白居易集》, pp. 217 & 730). However, it is not until the 990s that an essay simply entitled "On Bees" 紀蜂 by the official Wang Yucheng 王禹偁 (954–1001) describes bees, and humans' relationship with them, in detail not seen before. Wang's essay recounts a conversation he had with a monk at a temple in Shangzhou 商州 in northwest China in which the monk describes the basic characteristics of the bee colony; there were many bees in the vicinity of this temple, though it is not clear that the monks themselves kept them. The monk describes the "king" bee and the larger cells which house the developing "kings" (i.e. "princes"), and relates how the farmers in the area, afflicted by the many swarms, kill the young "kings" by poking thorns into their cells.

Much of Wang's description of bee behaviour is more or less factual, but in the last part of his essay Wang, like Guo Pu, appraises the bee colony by the standards of human government, albeit with a more marked Confucian tint. Wang took the monk's assertion that the "king" did not have any venom as evidence that the "king" ruled because of his virtue; he also approves of the way in which the "princes" went on to become kings themselves, like the orderly succession of rulers with the same surname. He also points to the monk's statement that bees did not dare sting in the vicinity of their "king" as evidence that the laws were clear, before turning in the last lines to humans' treatment of bees. Wang approves of the principle that beekeepers should not take too much honey from the hives or the bees will be hungry and not multiply, yet should also not take too little or the bees will become lazy: he compares this to a "moderate" tax of ten percent. Wang is, however, horrified at the farmers' practice of killing the offspring, which he says is extremely "inhumane" *bu ren* 不仁 (*Xiaoxu ji*《小畜集》, 14.6b-7a).

That Wang seemed to know little about bees and beekeeping before the monk explained it to him suggests that even some 700 years after the cluster of texts from the early third century discussed earlier, this was a subject about which an educated man might know little. Indeed, an entry on beekeeping in an agricultural manual did not appear until 1273, when the Mongol government, keen to encourage agriculture, published *Fundamentals of Agriculture and Sericulture* (*Nongsang jiyao*《農桑輯要》). Nevertheless, whether because beekeeping and knowledge about bees developed more strongly during the Song dynasty, or simply because it was during this period that printing became widespread, making it more likely that texts would be produced in significant numbers and survive, there is more evidence for how bees were perceived in Chinese culture than before.

Wang Yucheng's approval of the beekeepers collecting a "tax" from their bees was in fact the first instance we have of an idea which would appear in a number of later texts: that the bees would pay a "tax" or "rent" in honey or beeswax to the beekeeper. No text explicitly explains what the basis for this was, but a poem "Catching honeybees" *Shou mifeng* 收蜜蜂 written in about 1105 by the eminent writer Su Zhe 蘇轍 (1039–1112) hints at why this idea might have arisen, even though Su does not actually use the words "rent" or "tax". The poem begins with a swarm, led by a king, which "Dividing the house and reducing the mouths to feed/still has found no place to settle". An old farmer, who "knows how to talk to the bees", is able to capture the bees using honey as a bait and smoking moxa to coax the bees into a bag, then releases them into the hive which he has prepared for them. They soon settle in, begin to visit the flowers, and multiply. However, the poem concludes by saying that this year the bees would not produce enough to give their master *zhuren* 主人 his share of the honey and beeswax, but in the following year he will be able to harvest some to mix with medicines. The final line notes the farmers' good fortune in finding a source of benefit, or profit (*Luancheng houji*《欒城後集》, 4.3b–4a).

The idea that bees produced honey for humans may also have extended to bees in the wild. Writing just a short time after Su Zhe, the official and poet Wang Zao 王藻 (1079–1154) began his poem "Ballad of the Bee Larvae" with the couplet, "Honeybees' livelihood is honey/Collecting honey for humans, they are happy among the flowers". However, the poem then turns to criticize humans for raiding and destroying wild bee colonies to collect the bee larvae, for which there is strong demand from the wealthy in the capital, where the larvae is regarded as a delicacy (*Fuxi ji*《浮溪集》, 30.6a). The distinction being made seems to be that while honey could be collected from the bees without killing them and, providing only

an appropriate amount is taken, without significantly weakening the colony, there is no way of collecting large amounts of larvae without heavily damaging or destroying the comb.

This theme of violence against bee larvae would be taken up later in the twelfth century by the eminent poet Yang Wanli 楊萬里 (1127–1206) in his poem "Bee Larvae". The poem begins with an idyllic picture of a kingdom of bees busy "collecting from flowers" or "making honey", daring not to taste the honey themselves, but presenting it to their king; there is no mention here of a portion being due to humans. However, in the second part of this poem, Yang unusually depicts the destruction wrought by giving the "bee king" a voice; the poem ends, "The greedy ones attack with fire, knowing not when to stop/My house destroyed to take my sons" (*Chengzhai ji*《誠齋集》: 29.2a–b). Yang thus makes the contrast between the orderly kingdom of bees dutifully producing honey for their king and the violence of humans, destroying that order out of greed.

Wang Yucheng's essay criticized farmers for killing the bee "princes", but violence against bees generally may also have been seen as unacceptable, at least in the eyes of elite observers. Some evidence for this appears in a poem by Wang Yang 王洋 (1087–1154), but in this case the target of Wang's disapproval is a Buddhist monk. Wang explains in a short preface that a neighbouring monk had a wooden beehive which fell from the rafters to which it was attached and smashed on the ground. Rather than responding by trying to help the bees, however, the monk attacked the fallen hive with a knife and smoke, greedily seeking to gather all the honey, harming the bees as he did so. Wang points out that this contravened the monk's vows not to harm living creatures or steal food. He exhorts the monk to show compassion by making sure he leaves enough honey for the bees to be able to pay their annual tribute to the king, while at the same time commanding the bee king to reduce the tax burden (*Dongmou ji*《東牟集》, 2.4a–b).

That this poem and Wang Yucheng's account take place in or near Buddhist temples raises the question of the role bees might have played in Chinese religion. Another twelfth-century poem "Following the rhyme of the monk Daogui: the bees leave and gather together again" 次僧道規蜜蜂去而復集韻, by Zeng Ji 曾幾 (1084–1166), also places beekeeping in a Buddhist context. It begins, "You, sir, like honey as much as the monk Zhongshu/Planting flowers in the mountains to attract the bees", an apparently unique example of a text recording someone planting flowers to attract bees. The poem continues by describing how, although the bees had been seeking food for the monk "as if obsessed" 如風狂, they had for some reason departed, in response to which the monk prays for their return. They do return, whereupon the monk dances with joy, and Zeng concludes that no longer will the monk and his bees be separated (*Chashan ji*《茶山集》, 3.4a). However, neither this nor other texts which mention bees in a Buddhist context explain what the purpose of the relationship between bees and Buddhism was, if indeed there was any special relationship. There is no clear evidence that they were kept for a specifically religious purpose. Most likely keeping bees ensured a supply of honey, a vegetarian food which was commonly used in Buddhist medicines, and of course as a sweetener. The beeswax could also be used for candles.

Indeed, in contrast to the prominence of bees and honey in Islam and medieval Christianity, for example, bees do not seem to have played an important role in religion in China. We have seen that they are not significant in any of the classical philosophical texts, which was probably decisive. Nevertheless, in later times bee colonies were usually interpreted as Confucian courts, ruled over by a king, with order maintained through strict discipline. The drones, whose real function was not understood, were sometimes called "minister bees", in the sense of ministers who served their ruler, though in the section on honeybees in Song Yingxing's *Works of Heaven and the Inception of Things* they are depicted as imperial bodyguards accompanying their king on a tour of inspection. The role of the other bees is usually less clearly defined, but normally they work industriously making honey for their king and are admired for their discipline and order. In his essay on beekeeping written in the midst of the violence which accompanied the Qing dynasty conquest of China in the 1640s, the Ming loyalist Chen Hongxu 陳弘緒 (1597–1666), having noted the discipline and order of bees' behaviour (including quoting verbatim his friend Song Yingxing's description of the king's imperial inspection tour), expresses his desire to lie down

and watch the bees come and go, in contrast to the turmoil of his time (*Dunsu tang liushu* 敦宿唐留書, 2.34a–35b). However, while an important element in maintaining the legitimacy of the human imperial houses which ruled over China was the "mandate of Heaven" – the idea that cosmic forces granted a certain house the right to rule based on their moral rectitude and fitness to rule with benevolence, which required the maintenance of religious cults in which the emperor as the "Son of Heaven" regulated the relationship between Heaven and earth and with the imperial ancestors – there is little evidence of these concepts being applied to bee "kingdoms".

Chen Hongxu's essay also describes how in popular religion, in the area around his home city of Nanchang 南昌 in Jiangxi at least, the arrival of a swarm of bees at one's home was an auspicious omen. The family would burn incense and cut coloured ribbons to welcome them and report the arrival to their ancestors. This was possibly linked to the money that could be made from beekeeping. In a poem written upon visiting his uncle's grave in 1585, the painter and essayist Xu Wei 徐渭 (1521–1593) records how the uncle's grandchildren, who were farmers, had beehives under the eaves of their houses. When Xu asked how many hives there were, they said more than forty, and added that if all the hives succeeded, they would make more money than they would from the rent from ten acres of land (*Xu Wei ji*《徐渭集》, pp. 100–101). A later contemporary of Chen Hongxu, Yu Jin 余縉 (1617–1689), begins his essay on bees, "The villages in which my ancestors lived all kept bees as a business. When I was young I also kept them, not because I craved profit, but because I admired how these insects have a sense of proper social relationships" (*Daguan-tang wenji*《大觀堂文集》, ch. 19). It is not clear when Yu wrote this essay, but he passed the highest civil service examinations in 1652 and became an official in the new Qing government, so he would have been keen to stress his devotion to Confucian social morals and to distance himself from any hint that he might have been involved in commercial money-making. Nevertheless, his disavowal of any profit motive suggests that it was widely known that beekeeping was a profitable business. Interestingly, Yu imagines the bees carrying out gendered roles, which reflected those amongst humans in the China's Confucian society at that time, but makes no attempt to justify this biologically.

There are a small number of references to "bee king shrines" in surviving texts in popular religion, but usually without detail. An exception is an entry in the *Yi Jian zhi*, a twelfth-century collection of accounts of the strange written by Hong Mai 洪邁 (1123–1202), which tells of a Bee King Shrine *Fengwang miao* 蜂王廟 in what is now Nanling 南陵 county in Anhui province in the 1130s. The origin of this shrine was unknown, but the locals worshipped at it devoutly. However, when a newly-arrived official, having been assured of the efficacy of the god, had the decorated niche which was the centre of the cult brought to the government offices to pray for rain, he looked inside the niche to discover no statue, but just a large bee which flew into the air a short distance away. When the bee failed to respond to the official's challenge to sting him if it really had the powers popularly attributed to it, the official had the niche with the bee back in it and the whole temple burnt to the ground (*Yi Jian zhi*《夷堅志》, p. 830; Lin 2014: 241–2).

One final point to note in this overview of bees in Chinese culture is the relative paucity of the pictorial record. Bees do appear in paintings from the early Song dynasty onwards, mostly in conventional settings with seasonal flowers. In fact the earliest extant paintings of bees might be amongst the most unusual. The tenth-century "Rare Birds Sketched from Life" by Huang Quan 黃筌 (903–965) is a scroll of quite realistic depictions of various birds, insects, and tortoises. Four of the insects seem to be *feng* of some sort, but while one may be Apis cerana, it could also be a wasp. Bees are more definitely present on a silk painting from just slightly later, "Bees, Butterflies and Autumn Flowers" by Qiu Qingyu 丘慶餘 (fl. 10th century). Despite the superficially peaceful setting of two bees, two butterflies, and a grasshopper by autumn flowers which grow by a rock, there is also a hornet that seems imminently about to attack one of the bees (Kang, p. 214). A slightly later scroll by Zhao Chang 趙昌 (active late 10th – early 11th centuries) depicts a small swarm of bees near a wasps' nest which hangs from the branch of a pink rose bush. Significantly, the "king" bee is clearly among them, and a later colophon by the poet and calligrapher Qiu Yuan 仇遠 (1247–1326) refers to it as "the painting of the bee king" *fengwang tu* 蜂王圖.

Beyond this bees-and-flowers genre, however, there is little more. None of the illustrated agricultural manuals which appeared after Wang Zhen 王禎 published his *Nong shu*《農書》in the early fourteenth century contains images of beekeeping, and nor do such images appear anywhere else. The earliest surviving pharmacopoeia, the *Zhenglei bencao*《證類本草, originally published by Tang Shenwei 唐慎微 in 1082, then revised and published by the Song government in 1108, does contain pictures that include *feng*; because this book was so influential, these diagrams were often reproduced in later manuals. The first page of the entry on *feng* larvae includes two pictures: the first, simply labelled "*feng* larvae", appears to be a skep with several bees flying around it: it is bell-shaped and has an entrance towards the bottom, though there are no descriptions of similar hives in any of the beekeeping manuals or essays, and the entrance looks larger than would normally be the case. The second is labelled "*feng* larvae in Xiazhou", and is a drawing of a wasps' nest hanging in a cave (*Zhenglei bencao*《證類本草》, 20.8a–b); Xiazhou was a prefecture at the eastern end of the Three Gorges on the Yangtze River, but it is unclear why this location was specified. There is no other explanation of these pictures, but they may be meant to illustrate that larvae can be gathered from bee or wasp colonies in the wild, or from bees kept in hives.

The preceding discussion has described the contours along which traditions about bees in Chinese culture emerged. In the period at least up to the end of the Han dynasty and beyond, bees seem to have been lumped in together with wasps and hornets as swarming, stinging insects. From about the end of the third century, a more positive view of bees began to emerge, at least as far as we can tell from the small number of texts that have survived. The textual record until the tenth century remains thin, but from the Song dynasty onwards, a richer understanding of bee colonies as Confucian royal courts developed, accompanied by more nuanced representations of the relationship between bees and humans. The contours of the evolution of traditions about bees seem broadly to reflect the development and spread of beekeeping, which would have drawn humans into a closer relationship with bees, especially as knowledge about how to manage bees grew. There are of course examples which deviate from this pattern to some degree, but broadly speaking cultural representations of bees reflected it until modern bee science and beekeeping techniques were introduced to China at the end of the nineteenth century.

Note

1 Note that citations for quotes from woodblock editions are chapter (*juan*) numbers followed by page numbers.

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Recommended readings

There is currently very little scholarship about bees in Chinese culture in English. The first attempt to describe bee-keeping in China systematically can be found in Eva Crane's *World History of Beekeeping and Honey Hunting* (1999,

London: Duckworth), especially in a chronology appended at the end, but these efforts amount to just a few pages, and Crane was restricted by her inability to read Chinese. This author's contributions to this point are:

Pattinson, David (2012) Pre-modern beekeeping in China: A short history. *Agricultural History* 86.4: 235–255.

Pattinson, David (2019) Bees in China: A brief cultural history. In R. Sterckx, M. Siebert and D. Schäfer (eds.), *Animals through Chinese history: Earliest times to 1911*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, pp. 99–117. This covers this topic in more detail than the entry here.

Although there is considerable Chinese-language scholarship on bees, beekeeping, bee products, and some elements of bee-related culture, much of it is on quite specific topics. The main scholar to address beekeeping and bee-related topics in pre-modern China in a more systematic way is Qiao Tingkun 喬廷昆:

Qiao, Tingkun (1993) *Zhongguo fengye jianshi*《中國蜂業簡史》(A basic history of the Chinese apiculture industry). Beijing: Zhongguo yiyao chubanshe. However, only the first chapter is concerned with the pre-nineteenth-century apiculture; the rest describes the development of modern beekeeping.

Qiao, Tingkun (1995) *Gudai fengye wenxian yizhu*《古代蜂業文獻譯注》(Translated [into modern Chinese] and annotated documents of [Chinese] apiculture in pre-modern times). Beijing: Zhongguo kexue jishu chubanshe. Despite its title, this book does include translations of literary texts from classical Chinese into modern Chinese as well as more technical texts.

4

JINGJU

The treasures of classical Chinese theatre

Li Ruru

Introduction

Jingju, often known as Peking Opera or Beijing Opera in the West, is one of the most important genres in the classical Chinese song-dance theatre (or *xiqu* in Chinese), which consists of 348 regional theatres (Ministry of Culture and Tourism 2017: 16). Within the big family of the classical theatre, the oldest genres can be traced back to the fourteenth century when they first appeared while some did not emerge until the mid-twentieth century. As a result, the artistic features of these theatres form a wide spectrum: some such as *puxian xi* (popular in the eastern area along the coast of Fujian province), *kunju* and *jingju* are all stylized containing a specific and rich acting vocabulary, while others are similar to the straight theatre in the West. Yet, they all share the same essence whereby "stories are uttered in the form of song and dance" (Wang 1984: 161). *Jingju* enjoys a special position in the big family, because, as a highly developed urban theatre, it was not formed until the beginning of the nineteenth century and thus its formation was more sophisticated on a large scale, absorbing all the nutrients from the well-established theatres all over China that had come to Beijing during the previous 200 years.

This chapter argues that *jingju*, as a live theatrical form of the traditional Chinese culture, has actively responded to the conflicts and challenges of the external world as well as within the genre. It comprises four parts, starting from people's impressions of *jingju* performances (including Chinese and non-Chinese audiences); these comments naturally lead to a discussion of the main features of the genre. *Jingju*'s characteristics are actually based on its origin and its position in the traditional Chinese culture and these discussions form part 3. The final part will offer readers a brief overview of *jingju* today.

Part I: What is *jingju*?

Theatre is a live art. In order to let readers "see" what is happening on the stage, this part starts from a description written by a Chinese critic who was once sitting in the auditorium as a member of the audience. The play concerned is entitled *The Green Wind Village* and is taken from the famous 13th-century classical novel *Water Margin*. The writer starts from the protagonist and what role type the play used to present him:

> This is a delightful mini martial play focusing on a subtype of the painted face role who specializes in dance-acting. Two outlaws, Li Kui, nicknamed Black Whirlwind, and Yan Qing, nicknamed

> Prodigal Son, have heard that a young girl was forced to marry the local tyrant Liu Tong. Disguised as the bride, Black Whirlwind, with the help of Prodigal Son, manages to get into Wind Village, kill the tyrant and rescue the young woman.
>
> Before his entrance, the audience can clearly hear Li Kui's words "Let's go" in a pleasant husky voice from backstage; they get excited and applaud loudly. These two words are uttered in the style of the Huang San (Runfu) school, using a specially trained method of breathing and enunciating. Li Kui enters following Yan Qing who is played by a military male role type. Yan starts the song in the style of "shaking-metre[1] (*yaoban*): "Ordered by our Big Brother", followed by the painted-face Li, "We're going on patrol and must be on our guard." Then the two start addressing the audience directly about their background and their task. . . . Then Li Kui says: "My little brother Yan, you and I should raise our heads and watch!" At this moment Yan Qing squats down, while Li Kui, putting his left hand on the right shoulder of Yan, raises his left leg and his right arm. The graceful gesture and movement, a convention of the painted-face role type, plus his facial expression, brings the audience with him to look straight ahead. We often say "both singing and acting should be in the play". Good actors not only put themselves in the play, but can also bring audiences along with them into the play.
>
> *(Ding 1995: 231)*[2]

The preceding description tells us a number of important features of *jingju*: there are role types (a painted-face role specializing in acting and a military male role). Performers speak, sing, and act with dance-like movements, and since it is categorized as a martial play, there must be a display of martial arts and acrobatics, although these are not discussed in the excerpt. However within this brief quotation, the critic mentions particular acting styles a number of times. The passage touches upon the stage layout and the play sources, and also talks about the relationship between performers and audiences who know exactly what is going on and applaud before the actor enters the stage. All these will be analyzed and discussed in Part II: Main Features of Jingju.

The above quote by a Chinese critic (apparently knowing the *jingju* techniques very well) offers us some important *jingju* characteristics through a vivid depiction of a short episode on the stage. It is also helpful to consider the impressions of non-Chinese people after viewing this type of performance.

Mei Lanfang[3] (1894–1961), an actor playing the female role in *jingju*, is the most important figure of the genre, and has been regarded as a representative of classical Chinese theatre. During the 1920s and 1930s, he visited Japan, the USA, and the USSR. Following are short reviews or criticisms from each country.

Mei visited Japan in 1919 and in 1924. The excerpt below is a quotation from a Japanese scholar's article on Mei's two visits to Japan, and the author has compiled a great number of contemporary writings from the media. The review concerned in this chapter is "Mei's *Imperial Stela Pavilion*" published on 14 May 1919 in the *Yomiuri Shimbun*, one of the five national Japanese newspapers. The play tells the story of a misunderstanding between a couple and how husband Wang Youdao realizes his mistake and apologizes to his wife Meng Yuehua. The writer starts his review from the stage arrangement:

> It only employed a Chinese style of curtain, on which a very pretty pattern was placed. The performance started. Previously I saw *Heavenly Maiden Scattering Flowers*, and its set was ugly. This time it was far more comfortable, full of delights of Chinese drama. In the middle of the play, a set of the *Imperial Stela Pavilion* was used. Since this was the most splendid scene of the play, it was quite possible that in China they would use such a set as well. However, I did not think it was necessary.
>
> The only props they used were chairs and tables. I was rather surprised to have found that their property man[4] who moved the props around diligently was more noticeable than those in the Japanese theatre.

> I could not understand a word of the language, and thus I had no idea about the details. However, Meng Yuehua acted by Mei and Wang Youdao by Gao Qingkui showed the affections between the couple vividly. Their acting, for example, the way that expressed the inner pain that Wang felt when he had to write a note to abandon his wife; Wang's apology to his wife because he had wrongly doubted her chastity; and the wife's anger expressed by swaying her head, was all-enthralling.
>
> Meng Yuehua played by Mei was beautiful and gentle, showing the characteristics of a chaste woman. What was particularly good was that the female's image was delicate, pretty and lovable. It was a pity that I could not understand the lyrics and thus I could not appreciate the most important parts of the play. In the show, they used a drum to let audiences know it was raining, and used the sound of a bell to express the desolation in the midnight. This is similar to our Japanese style.
>
> I felt that Gao Qingkui's skilful acting (Wang Youdao) was almost as good as Mei's, while Zhao Tongshan's Meng Delu came across a little odd when he imitated Meng Yuehua's voice to persuade Wang to apologize to his wife. Possibly in a play as profound as this one, it was necessary to use a comic role to act [the character]. I feel that the dance and skills of singing in *Heavenly Maiden Scattering Flowers* expressed nothing more than offering us some Chinese flavour. However, only by seeing *The Imperial Stela Pavilion* did I learn the features of Chinese theatre and where the peculiar interest lay.
>
> *(Yoshida 1987: 84)*

As the writer emphasized a few times, he had no Chinese language at all, yet he seemed to have done thorough "homework" before going to the theatre. The small character Meng Delu he mentioned was indeed conventionally played by the comic role type, but the Mei Company chose Zhao Tongshan, who specialized in the female role, to act the character in Japan. The Japanese writer certainly expressed some regrets in his writing about the mismatching arrangement. In other words, his impression helped us understand the importance of role types in *jingju*. The writer also compared *The Imperial Stela Pavilion*, a traditional repertoire with *Heavenly Maiden Scattering Flowers*, a new play created by Mei himself who took inspirations from Chinese mythology and images of women from scroll paintings. The writer's preference was very clear for the *Pavilion*, yet actually the latter was extremely well received by audiences both in and beyond China. Another Japanese review commented: "It is said that the opening show *Heavenly Maiden Scattering Flowers*, on the basis of the *kun* theatre, has absorbed Japanese theatrical expressions and Western dance. It is purely Mei's own creation (Yoshida 1987: 83).

The Japanese critic not only compared two Chinese plays by Mei, but also from time to time placed Chinese theatre against the Japanese as if he were using two pairs of eyes looking at the stage at the same time. One pair enjoyed the exotic unfamiliarity while the other pair, through the presentation on the stage, continually made comparisons between Chinese and Japanese theatres. Such intriguing comparisons are made possible due to the constant historical exchanges between the two cultures.

Mei's visit to the USA in 1930 was also received extremely favourably. Both newspapers and magazines published a great number of articles about his performances. following is a piece published in *The New Republic magazine* (5 March 1930) written by Stark Young, a famous American theatre critic.

> As to the Chinese theater we perceive in the first place that it is an art based on music, or at least musically seen, and is a complete art consisting of music, speech and dancing in the full sense, which includes dance movement, gymnastic, pantomime and gesture. Most of the music was lost on me, of course, with its foreign scale and intention, but I was surprised to find how much it takes on meaning for an outsider and how often the themes are easily distinguishable. But most of all I was struck by the mingling of music and action that I saw on the stage, the admirable accentuation of gesture by music, the way in which the music gave the tempo to the acting; and

> by the security of an effect achieved through such delicate means. I could tell, however foreign the music, or rather his tone, by a curious brightness and metal, that Mei Lan-Fang's voice was unusual, and that the poetic wholeness of his art arose from an astonishing unity of time, tone, emotional rhythm and bodily control.
>
> This Chinese art is, in the second place, stiffened and syllabled with conventions; some of which are familiar to us and thought of largely with naïve, indulgent humor, but many of which, not known at all, underlie like an alphabet, the entire theatrical occasion.
>
> *(Young 1930: 3–4)*

Even if some elements of *jingju* were foreign and strange to Young's eyes and ears, he was astonished by "the poetic wholeness" of *jingju* and its ability to blend well the music, gestures, movements, poetry, and emotions.

In 1935, invited by the All-Union Society for Cultural Relations with Foreign Countries (VOKS), Mei Lanfang toured both Moscow and Leningrad successfully; originally planning to offer eight shows, in the end he gave fifteen performances altogether, while audiences included high-ranking officials and celebrated artists including Gorky, Meyerhold, Eisenstein, and others (Zhou 2016: 1). Like in Japan and America, Mei's acting as an actor with manifold accomplishments raised great interest in Chinese classical theatre; but unlike the previous two countries, Mei's performance in the USSR was far more significant for the Russian theatre circles owing to the political and ideological pressure to push through Stalin's "socialist realism". The Chinese theatre represented by Mei was certainly at odds with the Soviet artistic doctrine of the time, and thus the *jingju* performances became a touchstone of each individual's artistic stance.

Many important Soviet artists wrote about Mei Lanfang, and following is an excerpt from a welcome speech by Sergei Eisenstein, a film director and theorist who was a pioneer in the theory and practice of montage.

> The performances of the Chinese theatre, in the most ancient periods of its history, were synthetical: the dance was inseparable from singing. . . . Studying the ancient art, this great actor [Mei Lanfang] – who is equally great an erudite in the knowledge of his national culture – brings back the histrionic craft of the actor to its former synthesis. He revives the spectacular character of the stage performance, the exquisite complex combination of motion with music to which he adds the sumptuousness of ancient scenic costumes.
>
> Mei Lanfang is, however, no mere restorer. While reviving the perfect forms of the old tradition, he manages to combine them with a renovated content. He endeavours to widen the thematic field. This is indicated by the fact that his repertory contains also some plays which deal with the social status of the woman and with the struggle against backwardness and religious superstitions. These plays, enacted in the ancient conventional style but depicting scenes bearing on modern problems, prove to be particularly poignant and fascinating.
>
> *(Eisenstein 1935: 23–24)*

As the article title "The Magician of the Pear Orchard" demonstrates, Eisenstein seems to be utterly captured by Mei's masterful stage techniques as a "magician" and his ability of combining stylized theatrical conventions with themes that are relevant to contemporary society.

The preceding comments from Chinese and non-Chinese critics and artists on *jingju* performances, from different angles, illustrate well what *jingju* is like. Irrespective of what impressed them the most, all the writers seem to point to the essential feature of the genre: conventions that *jingju* possesses and how these conventions are synthesized. Indeed, conventionalization (*chengshi*) is the "soul of *jingju*" according to performer Li Yuru (Li 2010: 56), and it is conventionalization that decides the main features of the genre.

Part II: Main features of *jingju*

As discussed in *The Soul of* Beijing *Opera*, conventionalization is both abstract and concrete for *jingju*.

> [It is] abstract because it is the aesthetic concept underpinning *jingju*'s core attributes, such as its codified acting/musical system and its categorization of role types. It becomes concrete in *jingju*'s stage techniques: performers of each role sub-type must learn many sets of stipulated techniques, including styles of singing, facial expressions, and movements of eyes, fingers, hands, arms, feet and legs. Each play has uniquely formulated conventions for presenting its plot, characters and their feelings under specific circumstances. These conventions are not only valuable assets of the genre but also carry emotional weight.
>
> *(Li 2010: 55)*

Indeed, conventionalization means that every aspect of the performance – singing, speaking, dance-acting, acrobatics/martial arts, costuming, and make-up – has to follow certain modes, patterns or rules. It is the key to understanding the complexity of the performance system.

In the centre of conventionalization there is categorization of role types; each role type is codified by specific requirements for voice, singing, gesture, body movements, dance, make-up and costume.

Role types

There are four basic role types: *sheng* (male role), *dan* (female role), *jing* (painted face) and *chou (*comic role). Chinese role categorization is based on gender, taking account of age, social status, and personality. There is also a division between civilian (or *wen*, focusing on singing and speaking) and military (or *wu*, focusing on acrobatics and martial arts). *Jingju*'s basic role types all have subcategories and even sub-subcategories.

Sheng, *male role type*

The *sheng* occupies an important position in the genre because it was this role type and its repertoire that made audiences realize a new genre had emerged. The main subtype in the category is "old male role" or *laosheng*. "Old" in this context on the one hand refers to the age, thus this role type uses a natural male voice. On the other hand, the characters this role type plays do not necessarily have to be old; perhaps "mature" would be a better word, and they can be as young as in their late twenties. The *laosheng*, always wearing a robe and a long beard, are dignified men, no matter whether they are educated or illiterate, rich or poor, and they can be officials and emperors. This role type can be interpreted as a singing role, because all characters acted by *laosheng* have long arias to sing. Opposite to the "old", there is a subtype of young male role or *xiaosheng* who sings and speaks falsetto to express the youth of a young man. This subtype often plays young scholars, lovers or brave generals (who would actually be specifically played by the "military young male role", a sub-subcategory).

The two subtypes of *laosheng* and *xiaosheng* are concerned about the age, yet, alongside the singing or the "*wen*" (civilian) part, it would need a "*wu*" or military to make the *sheng* role full in order to present plays which exhibit both arias and martial arts/ acrobatics. The actor who plays Prodigal Son in the Chinese review of *Green Wind Village* is specialized in martial arts and thus he is a military male role (*wusheng*). This subtype actually did not appear until the late nineteenth century. New plays told contemporary stories about the prosperous business of armed escorts fighting against bandits. At that time the Qing court faced both foreign attacks and internal peasants' upheavals; revolts caused security problems for travellers and transportation. Social issues were thus reflected in the theatre, and as a response to the new repertoire, the military male role was created. Within this subgroup "military male role" there are further divisions

between those who act as generals and those who act as bandits or outlaws. The former is identified as a "military male role in amour", since generals would wear special costumes, while the latter is a "military male role in a short outfit". Costumes in *jingju* are closely linked with role types and their acting.

Dan, *female role type*

The subdivision of female role is similar to that in the male role. The traditional main set of female subcategories are *qingyi* (blue-gown), *huadan* (flowery female role), *wudan* (military female role) and the *laodan* (old female role). In the female role, "old" only refers to age.

Similar to the *laosheng* in the male role, the *qingyi* requires excellent voice and singing techniques. It portrays characters like the faithful wife, filial daughter, good mother or lover in distress. She is generally demure in character, her movements are graceful and often subdued in action, symbolizing the good and virtuous woman as defined in the traditional Chinese culture. The *huadan* on the other hand represents the woman of bold, more vivacious and flirtatious – and sometimes questionable – character. The *wudan* is the female warrior, good at martial arts and gymnastics, while the *laodan* acts as old mother or another aged woman.

When new plays were written with new female characters, a new subtype was demanded to be created by the plot. The new subtype, called *huashan* (flowery-gown), was a blending of the traditional "blue-gown" and "flowery female role", and, understandably, the actors who specialize in *huashan* have to be more versatile than those who play either *qingyi* or *huadan*. Perhaps it is helpful if we use the previous impressions again as an example: the heroine Meng Yuehua by Mei in *The Imperial Stela Pavilion* belonged to the traditional *qingyi* range, while *Heavenly Maiden* was played by the *huashan* role.

Similar to the appearance of the *huashan* role, *daomadan* (broadsword and horse female role) derived from *wudan*. Often in armour, using big weapons like a spear or a broadsword, and riding a horse, *daomadan* had to master the skills of singing and speaking in addition to the martial arts to create new female military characters on the stage.

Indeed, it was these new repertoires which demanded new singing and acting vocabulary to present them on the stage that led to the creation of new role types. *Jingju*, as a result, evolved.

Female role types, except for *laodan*, use falsetto/false voice to speak and sing, and this is the vital part of the heritage of the first generation of male performers who played female roles.

Actresses existed in the history of classical Chinese theatre, for example, *The Collection of the Green Building* by Xia Tingzhi in the fourteenth century recorded stories and career of over 100 actresses and singers. However, when *jingju* was first formed, all the female roles were played by male actors until the beginning of the twentieth century. There are Four Great Dan in *jingju*, who are all male actors, and Mei Lanfang is the foremost among the four. They all made great contributions to *jingju* because they founded styles that have dominated female role acting; every *jingju dan* performer (apart from the old female or the military roles) would study a particular style for their future career.

Jing, *painted-face role*

Jing as a term existed in the history of classical Chinese theatre, however, the function of the role in *jingju* was very different from that in ancient times. Historians believe that *jing* and its subtypes, with colourful and striking facial patterns, powerful gestures and movements, and robust, full and nasal voices, were largely the creation of *jingju*, although influences from pre-existent genres can be traced. Similar to the experience of military male role, the painted-face role developed very quickly when new repertoires were established during the period of *jingju*'s formation, and the singing *sheng* role needed a complementary partner to make plots about war and states rather than family or love stories. Thus painted-face characters are usually warriors, officials, heroes, bandits or demons.

The painted-face role consists of three subtypes. The first one specializes in singing; the second subtype in dance-acting and Li Kui, the heroic outlaw discussed in the Chinese review quoted at the beginning of the chapter, is acted by this role type. The third is the military *jing* specializing in acrobatics and martial arts.

The actors who play *jing* normally wear padded shoulder jackets beneath their outer costumes and boots with high platforms to increase their bulk and height. The striking feature of *jing* is its painted facial patterns and this will be discussed in the section when we discuss costume and make-up.

Chou, *comic role type*

Chou is the comic character role in *jingju*. This type wears a white patch on the nose/eye area, and it is called "small flowery face" as distinct from the "big flowery face" of the *jing* role. Not necessarily a fool, *chou may* be serious and well-educated, either a hero or a villain. This role type "can be threatening and dangerous, ironic and satirical, while also sensitive and touching" (Thorpe 2007: 6). The *chou* not only entertains audiences with slapstick-type routines like Western clowns, but commands the *jingju* basic skills of speaking, dance-acting, martial arts and sometimes the singing too.

Regarding the category of role types, *chou is* number four at the bottom of the rank, but actually it occupied a special position in theatre troupes in the old days. This was associated with its historical background. Acting in China seems to have started from the court jester or *you*, the ancestor of the modern *chou*. The word "*you*" soon evolved into a word meaning "actor". There are stories about *you*'s sharp tongue and mimetic skills, and thus he could entertain the court and the emperor and criticized officials. One anecdote also says that the Xuanzong Emperor in the Tang dynasty (618–907), who was respected as the ancestor of the classical theatre circles, often acted *chou* roles on the stage to satisfy his passion for theatre. For such reasons, a *chou* enjoyed special privileges: he was permitted to sit on any of the costume trunks backstage while other actors had to follow strict rules; and no actor was allowed to apply make-up before him. However, when the classical theatre evolved into a more synthesized form that paid more attention to song and dance, the singing role types of *sheng* and *dan* became more important and more plays were written focusing on these role types.

The subtypes in the *chou* are broadly divided between "civilian" and "military". The civilian *chou* is less acrobatic but demands more speaking and singing skills, and is expected to play scholars, officials, aristocrats, working commoners, old men, or sometimes teenagers. He can also play comic female characters. Paired with the civilian, the military *chou* role is expected to display combat with weapons and acrobatics, and most characters this role type plays are bandits or thieves.

The categorization of role types in *jingju* shows that some are borrowed from other pre-existent genres, and some were created or developed by *jingju* itself as a response to the new repertoire. New plays were made either for artistic development of the genre, to meet the needs of the audience, or to reflect social issues that caused people concern.

The discussion of role types has already touched upon both costumes and make-up, because certain role types must wear specific costumes and make-up, and at the same time costumes and make-up are also used as "tools" for acting.

Costume, headdress, and make-up

Unlike the Western theatre in which what a character wears and how (s)he appears on the stage signal the character's personality, social status, and given circumstances, in *jingju* what a character should wear depends instead on the role type and specific rules. There is a saying in the *jingju* circles: "We'd rather wear a torn piece of costume than put on a wrong one". Actually this saying applies to all the aspects discussed in this section, i.e. a role type must wear the "correct" costume, headdress and make-up according to the codified system. Meanwhile all the costume, headdress, and make-up are used as tools for acting containing a full

vocabulary. Within the space of this chapter it is impossible to discuss everything for every role type, and thus we use the *sheng* role as an example for the costume and headdress, the *jing*'s facial patterns for the examination of make-up.

Both old and young male roles often wear robes with long sleeves, but according to the social status, there are different robes for emperors (in apricot yellow colour embroidered with dragons, for example), officials (in maroon, olive or blue colour embroidered with roundels) and for young scholars (with coloured flower embroidery). There is a specific robe worth mentioning. It is called the "wealth and rank robe" but ironically it is actually worn by scholars in poverty. These characters in the plays would normally work diligently and pass the imperial examination in the future, and this is another reason for the name of the robe. The supposed "torn" piece of a costume is made of black silk patched with small coloured pieces. The military male role wears battle dress including armour, and sometimes has four flags in a range of colours. Except for the young male role, other *sheng*'s make-up is skin toned with a small amount of peach blush around their eyes and between the eyebrows. Eyes and brows are highlighted with black liner. The military role sometimes paints an arrowhead in rouge between their brows to show their bravery. The old male role always has a long beard, and according to the age and social status, the beard comes in different colours such as black, grey, and white and in different shapes.

Among the headdresses for the *sheng* role, it is worth examining the pair of pheasant feathers used by the young male role. The long feathers inserted in the headdress symbolize the young man's handsomeness and bravery. There are specific techniques of using fingers to play with the pair of feathers or merely employing the strength of the actor's neck and head to move them gracefully without using hands. Feathers are normally used to show the character's feelings and specific behaviour within the circumstances. Because of the difficulty of mastering the techniques, there is a sub-subdivision called "male role with pheasant feathers" within the subtype of young male role.

We should note that the long feathers can also be worn by other role types, such as male or female warriors, but they do not employ as complicated feather-acting techniques as the previous sub-subdivision does.

Both *jing* and *chou* role types wear facial patterns and yet there are differences. The comic roles' white patches around the nose and eyes are much smaller than the *jing*'s. These white patches can be square, round, triangular or diamond shaped. (The round shape is usually used for teenagers or good-natured comic roles.) The *chou*'s patterns are much simpler and mainly use white and black, sometimes with faded red to line the patch. In addition, the *chou*'s patterns are more illustrative. For example, the facial pattern of Lou the Rat, a thief in *Fifteen Strings of Cash* depicts a white-coloured rat running downward on his nose (replacing the normal patch) to symbolize the character's profession as a thief and his wickedness.

Jing's painted facial patterns are the most striking feature of *jingju*. In the traditional repertoire, a *jing* character tends to follow a dominant facial pattern, the main colour and shape of which usually tell audiences immediately whether the character is a good or bad man. The colours are often symbolic, especially when a particular colour dominates the *jing*'s facial pattern: red typically symbolizes goodness, loyalty, and bravery; black is for a character who is honest, straightforward, and upright; matt white stands for cruelty and treachery; and glossy white denotes an inflated and domineering person. Blue often indicates roguish characters such as bandits; gold and silver are used for deities, spirits, and the Buddha while green suggests a ghostly quality.

For instance, Judge Bao, the legendary hero who personifies justice on the stage, always wears a black face with a white crescent pattern on his forehead. Black symbolizes his honest and upright personality because in some stories he dares challenge the power of the emperor's close relatives. The white crescent represents a scar. Folk tales recount that Judge Bao has a deprived family background and was born in a stable where a kick from a donkey left a hoof mark on his forehead for the rest of his life. After Bao has become a high-ranking official, the poverty of his birth urges him to punish evil and to help the poor. The essential elements in the facial pattern for Judge Bao are thus the dominant black colour and the white

crescent on the forehead; audiences would refuse to recognize the character without these two features. However, while observing the basic pattern, individual performers, especially the founding masters of particular schools, always make their own modifications to the precise shade of black, or to the size or shape of the crescent.

Each *jingju* role type wears distinctive make-up, headdress, and costume, and they support the specific acting techniques that each individual role type has to employ to create the character. For the remarkable feature of "syntheses" that some reviewers noted (see part I), *jingju* actors have to master the skills of singing, speaking, dance-acting and combat,[5] although there is an emphasis on either singing or movements between subtypes of roles. *Jingju* performers never behave like a Western opera singer who sings standing still. These four skills are ruled by five canons: mouth, hands, eyes, body, and steps. In *jingju* they are called *sigong wufa*, i.e. four skills and five canons. The skills and canons have made *jingju* a total theatre in a real sense and a *jingju* performer has to be a total actor.

Four skills and five canons; conventionalization vs. individuality?

Both quoted reviews and the discussion of role types together with their specific costuming and make-up referred to the content of the four skills and five cannons without mentioning the specific expression. The two skills of singing and speaking are easy to understand, but what is dance-acting? The first review by Ding Bingsui on Li Kui's way of watching afar helps us see the meaning of dance-acting. As Ding describes: "At this moment Yan Qing squats down, while Li Kui, putting his left hand on the right shoulder of Yan, raises his left leg and his right arm". This is certainly not a movement from everyday life but, being stylized into a dance-like routine, it is nevertheless drawn from life. In order to look afar, Li Kui needs to be in a higher position. Thus, an ordinary body movement, such as standing on toes or climbing up on a rock to be higher, metamorphoses into the routine Ding depicts, which involves elements of dance, pantomime, and any visible or physical elements of acting in the Western sense. Furthermore, all the routines are controlled by conventionalization, for example, Li Kui's way of raising his arm (as a subtype of painted-face specializing in acting) is different from any of the male role types, such as an old male role, a young male role, a military male role, a civilian or military comic role, and even different from a painted-face specialized in singing. The "way" or "how" involves the height that the arm reaches, whether or not the hands are open or clenched in a fist, the size of the fist, the arrangement of the fingers adopted (if in a palm shape), and many other details.

Both singing and speaking are involved with music, which again very much impressed all the reviewers. Although on most occasions, speaking is not accompanied by the stringed instruments (but by the percussion), the speech itself is melodic, especially the heightened speech (*yunbai*, literal meaning "rhymed speech"). It contains both semi-classical and vernacular Chinese, combining speech and verse singing. It uses special pronunciations and tones, a mixture of accents from the Hubei, Anhui, Jiangsu, Shaanxi, and Beijing areas based on two types of rhymes. The music is conveyed by the rise and fall of pitch with the slow tempo of drawn-out vowels. Even for the colloquial speech that is based on the Beijing dialect, the actors exaggerate the tones that each word is designated and thus the rising and falling effect of changing tones of the words in lines gain a musical quality. The musical system of *jingju* is mainly comprised of two musical modes: *xipi* and *erhuang*, both of which are taken from pre-existent theatres. It also absorbs other musical modes of a variety of theatres including the *kun* music. The cadence in the heightened speech as discussed gives *jingju* arias, accompanied by the musical instruments including percussion, a more distinctive rhythm. All the musical modes are conventionalized; there are patterns and rules to follow. Like the role types that include subtypes, both *xipi* and *erhuang* contain secondary modes. The lyrical structure of *jingju* aria is in couplets, and therefore the musical construction consists of opening and closing lines. Each line of the libretto contains either seven or ten syllables (since a Chinese character contains one syllable, there are seven or ten written characters). The principal instrument

for song accompaniment is *huqin*, a two-string spike fiddle. Different modes are organized according to metrical types that provide a pattern of an accented beat and unaccented beat(s). The beats are achieved by the *danpi* drum and clappers in different ways of making the sound. The person who plays both the drum and clappers functions as the conductor of the *jingju* orchestra; he therefore commands the rhythm, pace, and tempo of the performance. The synthesis of various conventions as previously discussed left a deep impression on Stark Young regarding "the admirable accentuation of gesture by music, the way in which the music gave the tempo to the acting".

Among the four basic skills, combat is the last. This combat is stylized fighting with hands and fists, knives, swords, spears, and acrobatics as well as martial arts. Sub role types specialized in singing do not normally display these techniques on the stage, but for the basic training, every trainee has to learn how to act using all these "weapons".

Having discussed the four basic skills, we can now see the function of the five canons, because the rules of "mouth" govern the singing and speaking, while those of hands, eyes, body, and steps direct the dance-acting and combat.

The brief discussion of role types and the four basic skills that an actor must master helps us understand that the *jingju* training is lengthy, rigorous, and strictly disciplined; actors acquire competence in the skills needed in this stylistic theatre. Training normally takes eight years, although now graduates of the college (six years) can hardly find a job in a *jingju* company, and thus most of them will continue to the university level, which means ten years altogether. Good actors also continue the training themselves one way or another throughout their career.

Training covers two aspects: basic training and repertoire learning. Basic training again has two areas to go through: techniques for movements, all the students/trainees (not role-type decided) learn them together; specific role-type training including voice, gestures, steps, and other movements. The first part continues even after someone has become a professional performer, while the second part gradually evolves into specific repertoire learning because every character in the play requires the four skills of a particular role type. The strictly disciplined training attempts to "mould" young trainees into the conventions and thus their bodies become artistic bodies; they also gain accuracy and perfection in movements and singing. They must learn concentration and cooperation, otherwise during the combat lives can be at risk. Through eight to ten years of rigorous drills, these four skills governed by five canons are synthesized into a single organically whole mode of dynamic performance.

Here now come the questions, if everything is conventionalized and every trainee is "moulded": where is the individuality, and how can these great masters all have their own specific style or in Chinese, the "*pai*"? More importantly, isn't it boring to watch such a rigid theatre?

Back in 1935 in the Mei Lanfang Company to the USSR, there were two academic members: Zhang Pengchun and Yu Shangyuan. There are prints of two talks given by Zhang, a Columbia University graduate, who taught at both Nankai School and Nankai University after returning to China. He was a great activist promoting modern Chinese drama and organized the famous Nankai New Company for young students. It is Zhang and the New Company that led the later to be the most important Chinese playwright Cao Yu (1910–1996) to *huaju* (modern spoken drama – the term specifically distinguishing it from the traditional song-dance theatre). The first printed talk by Zhang was at the reception to welcome Mei in Moscow. Speaking broadly about *jingju*, he particularly touched upon the topic of "individuality" and this was a necessary "lesson" for those who have a strong drama tradition of naturalistic theatre. He used the word "patterns" to refer to the stage conventions:

> It may be cause for wonder that, if there are alphabets of acting, singing, dancing, make-ups, and costumes, and if all actors receive training in the execution of the same alphabets or patterns, what is the chance for individuality? How can a great actor be distinguished from an unaccomplished one? And where does progress come in?

> Roughly speaking, there are three ways whereby a great actor may be recognized and his individuality acknowledged. First, a great actor executes his patterns with keen finish and proper feeling. He does not go through the motions mechanically. And his attention is strained for the perfect production of significant details.
>
> Secondly, a great actor, in the execution of the continuous sequence of patterns that makes up a whole performance, gives one no chance of detecting where one pattern ends and another begins. In other words, there is no tearing or jarring anywhere in the continuity and a certain organic rhythm suffuses and transpierces [misprint: transpires] the whole. One may say that, hovering about a performance of this character, there is an aroma of unity.
>
> And thirdly, a great actor, after having achieved distinction in the rendering of patterns that belong to the common stock of tradition, earns for himself the right creating new patterns and of contributing his share to the heritage of the stage. Not any wilful innovation, but only the acknowledged virtuoso can claim the prerogative of leaving his mark on history.
>
> *(Chang 1935: 42–43)*

If Zhang's writing only discusses the principles about individuality in *jingju*, Elizabeth Wichmann-Walczak in her article offers a more concrete example of creative interpretation, which exemplifies Zhang's theory of how a good actor can create new patterns and contribute his share to the heritage of the stage.

Wichmann-Walczak uses *The Favourite Concubine Becomes Intoxicated* performed by Mei Lanfang and his disciple Li Yuru (female) to examine how individuality can stand out within conventionalization. Li studied this character from Mei, but before Mei, she had also studied it from Guo Jixiang (1884–1938), a male flowery *dan* and also specialized in the *daomadan* role, and Xiao Cuihua, another famous flowery *dan*. "Li generally follows Mei's blocking and the basic patterns of his footwork and gestures, speaks the same words, and sings the same lyric and melodies" (Wichmann-Walczak 2011: 105). Certainly the play is in the Mei School canon, any disciple or even amateur follower would have to imitate all the details. However, after close-reading the two performances, one is a film version by Mei (when he was 62) and the other a video recording by Li (when she was 70), Wichmann-Walczak discerns the differences:

> By re-interpreting the same basic movement patterns, and in some crucial instances using additional and/or entirely different techniques, Li Yuru creates a character quite unlike Mei Lanfang's in terms of age, self-perception, and indeed overall personality. . . . While both interpretations of the character belong to the *huashan* role type subcategory created by combining *qingyi* and *huadan* characteristics, Mei's is closer to the refined *qingyi* while Li has clearly drawn on her work with masters of the vivacious *huadan*. Overall, Mei's Yang Yuhuan is a mesmerizingly lovely mythological/legendary beauty, while Li's is a lively and heartbreakingly real woman.
>
> *(2011: 108)*

Mei's disciple Li Yuru in her writing confirms that her way of acting Yang Yuhuan has taken a variety of skills from both Guo and Xiao Cuihua, experts of the flowery female role, in addition to Mei's style (Li 2008: 190–210). Wichmann-Walczak's analysis points clearly to the nature of the conventionalization of *jingju*. Underneath this concept there is a solid foundation formed by hundreds of basic gestures and body movements, each defined by precise rules. They are the heritage to which scholar Zhang refers. To portray a particular character like Yang Yuhuan in the preceding case, the performer, according to his or her understanding of the character, keeps certain acting conventions but also selects various units and re-combines them to create new sequences of movement. Even for the exact same words and melody, each sound of the word uttered by a different actor can be imbued with a rich timbre that modifies the colouring of the same tone. Thus the same lyrics controlled by the same conventionalization spoken or sung by different actors

gain differing styles. Here comes the essence of *jingju* training: actors must master as many conventions as possible; the more conventions actors have learned, the more creative they can become. During the process of re-creating prescribed conventions, actors may recurrently draw on their observations of behaviour in everyday life or elements from other artistic forms. In this way, alterations happen all the time and thus creativity continues perpetually. Audiences come back to see the same play performed by different actors. Such a differing creative process is determined by the inception of the genre and its position in traditional Chinese culture.

Part III: *Jingju*'s origin and its position in traditional Chinese culture

Jingju, if translated literally, means "capital drama", relating to Beijing, which was the capital of the Qing dynasty (1644–1911), and it was in Beijing where the genre started at that time. The name of the genre is seemingly of the same type as other regional theatres, as it is formed by a geographical term to indicate where the genre is from plus drama (*ju*) or theatre (*xi*) or melody (*qiang*) and so on.[6] But actually it is not, because *jingju* is not a local theatre of Beijing. Instead it was born as an amalgamation synthesizing features from pre-existent theatres. As seen in the discussions, the two main musical modes are *xipi*, from the pre-existent theatre *handiao* (popular in the area along the border of present-day Jiangxi and Hubei provinces), and *erhuang* from *huidiao* (popular in the area along the border of present-day Anhui and Hubei provinces) and above *handiao*.

Before *jingju* emerged, theatre in the capital was dominated by the *kun* and then *jingqiang* (also called *gaoqiang*), a theatre derived from the earlier Yiyang Music. In 1790 for the celebration of the Qianlong Emperor's eightieth birthday southern officials and merchants sent a few troupes to the capital, among them Anhui Sanqing Troupe was the first. After the official celebration, these performers remained in Beijing. They were versatile because most actors were from Jiangsu where the most elegant *kun* music/theatre originated, and thus they performed the *kun* repertoire, yet they also presented other regional theatres. In order to compete with the well-established and successful theatrical genres in the capital, and to overcome the difficulty that Anhui local theatre would appear alien to Beijing audiences, these Anhui troupes started employing actors from *jingqiang* and *bangzi*[7] to join their companies. Thus they were able to offer audiences variety bills on the stage and their work became far more exciting. However, actors from different local theatres all spoke with different accents and sang different melodies. In *jingju* (as in the classical Chinese theatre) singing is actually an exaggeration of the spoken language, the music makes the tones and the sound of different dialects more melodious. This explains why all the non-Chinese writers mention music in their reviews (see part I of this chapter).

At that time, Beijing was a prosperous city. Officials through imperial examination from all over China came to work in the court, while merchants also travelled there. They formed a large percentage of the audience (the former were forbidden by the court to attend the public theatre but there were private theatres. Hiring troupes to perform for a special family occasion was also popular). Audiences also included Beijing locals from peddlers to merchants, the gentry class, literati, and even the Manchu court.

The hustling and bustling stage – different melodies and plays, even different styles of theatre, sung and spoken in different accents in front of a large audience from all over China speaking different dialects – became an obstacle for the theatre to develop further. Ingenious performers of the first generation of *jingju* formulated the heightened speech (as seen previously), *jingju*'s very own unique language-delivery that could be understood easily by every member of the audience because it is artificial, invented on the basis of a number of dialects. The creation of heightened and colloquial speeches (*yunbai* and *jingbai*) marked the completion of the new genre. In *jingju* only the comic role (*chou*) can speak in dialects.

Based on an assorted cast and through selecting, rearranging, and assimilating conventions from other pre-existent theatres, a new genre, *jingju*, metamorphosed and appeared as a complex theatrical amalgamation. It was boldly innovative in its treatment of the repertoire and performing conventions. *Jingju*,

a child of mixed blood surpassing its "regional ancestors", was able to become a "rebel" to challenge the older theatres and keep developing to meet the demands of the time. Meanwhile other old or new theatres started taking good elements from jingju, and influences have thus flowed back and forth. The formation of *jingju*, full of insights into the dynamics of the Chinese indigenous theatre, explains from where the main features of the genre have come and why conventionalization is the essence of *jingju* and how it works.

However, so far the discussion of conventionalization has only focused on its concrete side, we should not forget its aesthetic quality because this is what has determined how *jingju* looks and why the practical side works. The aesthetics of conventionalization is deeply rooted in classical Chinese culture. For example, the purpose of the costume "wealth and rank robe" as mentioned earlier is to depict the poor man whose clothing is torn that has to be stitched together in order to be possible to wear. However, the piece is made of black silk while the patches are also made of brightly coloured silk. This means that *jingju*, like the traditional painting and poetry, does not pay any attention to the resemblance of a real object. It is an art of *xieyi* (lit. writing meaning) rather than *xieshi* (lit. writing reality). In other words, its ultimate objective is expression rather than mimesis. It pays much attention to the emotions of the characters in certain circumstances by using the skills of singing, speaking, dance-acting, and combat.

We again take *The Favourite Concubine Becomes Intoxicated* as an example. The plot is that the Xuanzong Emperor orders his favourite concubine Yang Yuhuan to meet him in the garden. However, after her arrival, the eunuchs learn that the Emperor has decided to visit another concubine. So Yang has to go back to her own chamber alone. Such a simple story makes a play of 65–70 minutes and the whole performance depicts the changing emotions of the protagonist: how Yang changes from joyful, arrogant, and conceited, comparing herself to the moon and immoral spirit of Chang'e, to being angry and despairing. In this play Yang sings and dances, both of which are not part of the story as such, but the means of delivery of the story and her deep inner feelings. This is exactly as the *Great Preface to the Book of Songs* states:

> The affections (*qing*) are stirred within and take on form (*xing*) in words (*yan*). If words alone are inadequate, we speak them out in sighs. If sighing is inadequate, we sing them. If singing them is inadequate, unconsciously our hands dance them and our feet tap them.
>
> *(Owen 1992: 41)*

Yang Yuhuan's psychological status and her emotions towards the external world (including the unpresented Emperor and the existing eunuchs and attendants) as well as herself is the "meaning" that the whole play writes and the performer acts.

The concept of "writing meaning" originated from ancient Chinese aesthetics of a dialectical pair: *xu* (empty) and *shi* (solid), and the dichotomy plays an important role in classical art and literature. It is exemplified in the way that traditional Chinese scroll paintings never convey the exact resemblance of any real object in reality, but use brushstrokes and water/ink effects to express the balance between a formal likeness [*shi*] and spirit-resonance [*xu*] of the object, and therefore these artistic works demand more involvement and imagination on the part of the viewer. Classical poetry applies to the same concept.

Conventionalization of *jingju* works alongside the dialectic pairs of aesthetics that the traditional ink-and-wash painting adopts: "false but true, empty but full, and few but many". A riding crop or an oar is often the example used to discuss non-realistic nature of *jingju*, however, what needs to be emphasized is that it is merely a prop (a real object and thus "*shi*") when it is seen on its own. Perhaps it does not look like a real riding crop or an oar in daily life. Only when it is seen through the performers' acting – in a way it is "empty" and "false" because of the stylized dance sequences on an empty stage – would it become "true". In addition it not only represents the form of "a horse" or "a boat" on the stage, but also transforms the flat stage into a three-dimensional road, mountain, battlefield or river. A few soldiers

dancing with spears and making acrobatics become armies fighting with each other. On an empty stage, Yang Yuhuan's movement conventions of "reclining fish" and the "bridges" (using the performer's head, back, and legs) make an everyday action of bending down to smell flowers into dance-like acting. With the help of a few lines and lyrics which have taken place before this moment, audiences understand that she is nearly intoxicated and in despair that she has only flowers for company. Yet, she is playing with them and this shows her pride to the attendants and eunuchs. A rather complicated and unstable psychological state of the character is beautifully revealed by a set of stage conventions. The sound and music work are also guided by the same concept. *Jingju* never uses sound effects, instead, it uses musical instruments to express the wind, the rain, or any other sound, as the previously quoted Japanese critique points out (see part I).

Having discussed the main features of *jingju*, its origin and its aesthetic principles, we can see why performers often have difficulty dealing with plays of contemporary themes.

However presenting *jingju* with contemporary themes was first of all executed by the performers own will. At the beginning of the twentieth century, responding to the criticisms of *jingju*'s ornamental nature and to the crisis of the nation, a group of *jingju* performers including Mei Lanfang decided to present contemporary stories, discussing social issues and even war affairs directly through their performances. Representing the external world with contemporary costumes, make-up, and real props (for example, Mei used a sewing machine in one of his productions), these performances denied the essential aesthetics of *jingju*. The realistic elements in the presentation conflicted with the highly codified acting conventions of singing, speaking, dance-acting, and combat. Having tried and realized the issues, most *jingju* performers decided to let those less-stylized genres in the classical theatre deal with the subject. Instead, they work hard and use traditional stories to express their concerns about contemporary society, and this is exactly why Eisenstein found some of Mei's repertoire "particularly poignant and fascinating".

Nevertheless, from the early 1950s onwards, performers have gradually lost their power to decide what they wanted to stage after the stormy campaign of Theatre Reform "reforming the theatre, the professionals and the institutional system" (*People's Daily* 1948 November 13).[8] The revolutionary model plays produced during the notorious Proletarian Cultural Revolution, which followed the path paved by the 1964 National Gala of *Jingju* Plays on Contemporary Themes (5 June – 31 July), were the outcome of a series of political campaigns and mind-remoulding. Under the heavy political and ideological pressure of being revolutionary or counter-revolutionary and between life and death, performers (with their great capability of selecting, rearranging, and assimilating inherited from the *jingju* tradition) worked out a great number of nearly magic methods to deal with the old issues between "writing meaning" and "writing reality". Elements of ballet, gymnastics, symphony orchestra, and of other artistic forms were blended in *jingju* productions. Some successful model plays that are well received by today's audiences are good examples.

Part IV: *Jingju* today

During *jingju*'s heyday, a rickshaw man in Beijing would hum a libretto to entertain himself while waiting for a client; and a Cantonese man had not seen any *jingju* performance by Tan Xinpei (a famous singing *sheng* role) but hung his portrait on the wall at home because he believed that if someone appeared in the newspapers so often receiving so much admiration he must be as powerful as God (Liu 1932: 4). After 200 years since its inception, *jingju* has entered the 21st century. It has certainly lost its old glory. Like its siblings in the big family of traditional Chinese theatre, *jingju* is facing great problems of losing audiences and low number of candidates for *jingju* schools' recruitment. Yet, unlike other regional theatres, *jingju*, together with *kunju*, has been chosen by the government as the representative of traditional Chinese culture, and therefore it has been placed under the protection of today's cultural policy.

In 2006, the Ministry of Culture announced eleven "national prominent *jingju* theatres" and seventeen "Provincial prominent *jingju* theatres" after assessing thirty-seven companies across the country. Then the "national prominent *jingju* theatres' protection and support plan" was implemented with the support of the Ministry of Finance, and these companies were given extra financial support. In 2006–2010, 50 million RMB (approx. US$7.5 million) was allocated to the national prominent companies, and in 2011 the Ministry of Culture, using an intermediary organization, examined the expenses of the fund over 10 million RMB (approx. US$1.5 million) in 2010. All eleven theatres gained "efficiency" in the following four aspects: producing new plays, training young professionals, international exchanges, and taking *jingju* to university campuses (Ministry of Culture 2011).

It is also worth noting that a special project initiated in Tianjin in 1985 entitled "sound matching image"[9] has continued and has recently been taken over by the central government. The original 1985 project made audio-visual records by matching old masters' gramophone records with young actors' performances, while the current project is focusing on contemporary artists who are still actively performing on the stage, and thus the sound and image are from the same performer. However, it does not merely use live recordings, instead, "in order to accomplish the best result", it takes the video and audio recordings respectively, and then matches the two parts together. The new title of the project is "image-sound-image", containing 102 performers and 127 productions performed by them. As of July 2017, the works of sixty out of 102 performers had been completed and since broadcast on the CCTV4 channel (Ministry of Culture 2017).

Apart from the direct financial support for theatre companies, various *jingju* festivals, exhibitions of excellent performances, and competitions have been organized by both the central and local governments. 2017 witnessed the eighth *Jingju* Arts Festival, held in Nanjing; thirty-four companies took part in the festival, altogether presenting twenty-nine productions, five shows of highlights of martial plays, and two extra productions as a special tribute to the Festival. In order to attract more audiences, the Festival offered tickets at low prices, ranging from 10 to 80 RMB (approx. US$1.5–12). Among these special events, the most interesting one is probably the Little Theatre *Jingju* festivals first launched by the Beijing Jingju Company at the beginning of the millennium. The idea was influenced by the modern theatre *huaju*'s practice of Little Theatre,[10] which was popular in the 1980s and 1990s. Little Theatre *Jingju* festivals seemed to have been locally organized; all the productions presented were low budget and small scale, some were bold reinterpretations of the traditional repertoire, while others were adaptations of literary pieces including foreign works. During the festivals, social media often produced informal reviews and criticisms.

Efforts by the government certainly worked in China. However, theatres also have to meet the requirements of the sponsors, and in the Chinese context it is the authorities. The new production *Roaring across the Horizon*, produced by the China National Peking Opera Company (one of the eleven national prominent companies), may exemplify the situation. It is a newly written play about how China has independently and successfully developed an atomic bomb. It is clearly an appropriate response to President Xi Jinping's comments that "the spirit of 'two bombs and one satellite'[11] has encouraged generations of Chinese people. [Their work] is the precious spiritual treasure of whole Chinese nation" (Li 2011 January 27). Yet, it is questionable whether or not the theme is appropriate for a *jingju* performance. One may argue that anything is possible to be written in a play, but then comes the key issues: what kind of a story is the one about the atomic bomb and from which angle is it told? How is it presented through the stylized song-dance *jingju* conventions? Peng Wei, who works in the National Peking Opera Company, reports that they used stage conventions to present how scientists fight against the sandstorm in the desert and how they created a dance set to show scientists calculating with an abacus (2017 October 27). There are hardly any reviews of the production; a number of media reports seemed to tell the same story and used the same quotes. For example, Director Wu Xiaojiang commented on how he

used *huaju* concepts and methods to deal with the scene where people came to mourn the death of a hardworking and diligent scientist. He also felt that it was a necessity to make use of modern spoken drama approaches in this *jingju* piece, and as a result "conflicts could be pushed forward further, characters made more convincing, and the tension of the plot be further increased" (Ying 2017 September 30). Du Zhe, a "national first-rank" actor specializing in the singing-military *laosheng* role[12], played the protagonist, an experienced physicist who had studied abroad. Du pointed out that the lines in this play, close to dialogue in everyday life, were different from those in the traditional repertoire. These quotations did not tell us much about the production but enough for readers to sense the tension between a plot relating the making of an atomic bomb and *jingju* conventions, between a director educated in the modern spoken drama and performers who have been strictly trained into the song-dance conventions for eight to ten years.

The budget of the production was huge; it took three years and the script was revised more than twenty times. Playwrights, directors, staging team, and leading performers went to the Jiuquan Satellites Launching Centre several times to gain the real experience of working in the atomic field. They also interviewed scientists who had been involved in the projects of making the bombs and satellites. It was premiered in September 2017, when two performances were given on the 29th and 30th, a special tribute for the National Day of October 1. The production has since been revised and a remake has been planned for 2018. However, as yet it is not clear how many people will come to see this special production.

Indeed, governments have ways and means of supporting or opposing an art form, and these can be decisive; however, the performers are the real doers. No doubt, all the performers who worked in *Roaring across the Horizon* tried their utmost to make it good enough to be presented on the stage, but they were fitted into a straitjacket, both ideologically and artistically. Recently quite a good number of productions have been presented in the same way as *Roaring across the Horizon*; budget, time, and efforts of the practitioners are not proportional to how many people want to see the productions.

Of course the scene is not always as bleak as this. The positive side of *jingju* is produced by the practitioners who are making great contributions to their beloved theatrical form. For example, the Little Theatre *Jingju* festival was initiated by a group of young actors in Beijing about twenty years ago. Those *jingju* stars not only enjoy their privilege of being celebrities but have created good works for both the theatre companies they work for as well as for their own private studios. They also do more outreach work with their fans and amateurs. Both the National Peking Opera Company and Shanghai Jingju Theatre have set up an assessment system for young actors to encourage them to make progress in their careers. Such a project would involve retired experts to work with the younger generation. In this general outlining of *jingju*, we should also give small private *jingju* companies and amateur performers a position. The former were organized by those who had gone through the formal training in *jingju* schools but for many reasons could not find a position in a professional theatre. They have to seek funds to produce works occasionally. Most *jingju* amateurs are good at singing, but some have decided to be fully trained and thus they do not go through the rigorous training until they are in their twenties or older. It is their deep love for *jingju* that has given them the strength to take up the hardship (Chuang 2011: 18–29).

It is very clear that *jingju* professionals and supporters, with strong support from the government, are determined to carry on the genre of *jingju*. Through the first generation of actors' hard work and their ingenious creativity, *jingju* gained its "tenacity"; it has actively responded to the conflicts and challenges of the external world as well as within the genre. It is now in the hands of the current generation to preserve the dynamics and to develop *jingju* more innovatively. Perhaps, if the performers do not want to make their beloved *jingju* into a "popular museum piece" (Mackerras 1997: 67), the key is how to make the theatre relevant to today's audiences.

Selected glossary

Plays (including those in the captions)

Favourite Concubine Becomes Intoxicated (The) 貴妃醉酒
Fifteen Strings of Cash 十五貫
Green Wind Village (The) 清風寨
Havoc in Heaven 大鬧天宮
Heavenly Maiden Scattering Flowers 天女散花
Imperial Stela Pavilion 御碑亭
Qin Xianglian 秦香蓮
Roaring across the Horizon 横空出世
Taking Tiger Mountain by Strategy 智取威虎山
Wandering Dragon Plays with a Phoenix 遊龍戲鳳

Terms

chengshi 程式
chou 丑
dan 旦
erhuang 二黃
huaju 話劇
jing 净
jingbai 京白
pai 派
sheng 生
sigong wufa 四功五法
wen 文
wu 武
xipi 西皮
xiqu 戲曲
yaoban 搖板
you 優
yunbai 韻白

Captions

(1) Image of sheng *and* dan

The Wandering Dragon Plays with a Phoenix (1942) is a traditional repertoire for the role types of *laosheng* and *huadan*. It tells the story of how Zhengde Emperor in disguise as an ordinary scholar meets a pretty girl in the countryside and falls in love with her. The Emperor is played by Ma Lianliang, the founder of the Ma school; Li Fengjie (the *huadan*) is played by Li Yuru. Both figures represent the typical posture and costuming for the *laosheng* and *huadan*.

Since the Emperor is in disguise, his robe is plain without any embroidery, and the white parts are the long "water sleeves" that all the robes (for both male or female) have. He wears a black beard (rather thin) to show he is in the prime of his life. He also wears boots, the white parts are the high platforms of the boots.

Figure 4.1 Images of *sheng* and *dan*

Source: Courtesy of Li Yuru's family

Huadan normally wears trousers and a jacket with an apron to show her low social status. Even so, her headdress is fully decorated with artificial stones and flowers. Traditionally *huadan* often wears *qiao*, as this figure shows, a pair of small stilt-like wooden feet simulating a woman's feet that had been bound in the traditional fashion. Wearing *qiao* to act, dance, and to perform combat used to be one the most important basic techniques for both *huadan* and female warrior roles. *Qiao* has been banned on the mainland since the 1950s.

The female stands in the *tabu* position (the feet are in the position that a Western woman adopts when curtseying), with the body's weight on the front leg and the other leg is naturally bent slightly behind. The male stands with his feet in the T position. The arms of both male and female are stretched or placed in a curved style following the rules governed by the Five Canons.

(2) Image of jing

This is a Bao Zheng image in *Qin Xianglian*, a popular play with an eponymous heroine presented by a big variety of regional theatres. Judge Bao, remembering his own deprived family background (see the white crescent mark of the donkey's hoof on his forehead), finally manages to punish Qin's husband, who has abandoned his original wife and two children, to become a son-in-law of the emperor. Judge Bao is played by Wang Yue.

The main colour of black in his facial pattern is now tinged with a slight shade of red which thus adds the symbolic meaning of red in a *jing* role. Not only upright, Judge Bao is also good, kind, and loyal to his people as well as to the emperor. This figure is much larger than the *sheng* image, because he wears a padded jacket under his black robe. The waves at the lower part of the costume indicate the high position of the character in the court. Again the actor stands with his feet in a T position, and his arms are also in the curved style. As a *jing* role, his fingers are stretched according to painted-face canon. The red table cover embroidered roundels portrays the traditional way table and chairs are shown on the stage. The backdrop of blue sky with white clouds is symbolic because Chinese people used "blue sky" to refer to upright and honest judges.

(3) Image of chou

This is a painting of the facial pattern of Lou the Rat in *Fifteen Strings of Cash* drawn by Zhang Jinliang, a famous *chou* actor. The normal white patch around a comic role's nose and eye area is replaced by a running-down white rat to symbolize the character's profession as a thief and his movements as fast as a rat. The slanted black eyebrows, especially the left one, together with the long white tail of the rat, imply a cunning personality. The red triangle shape on the temple indicates a traditional medical plaster that people use to suppress headaches. The small black mark in the middle is the medicine. This painting is stylized but tinged with a type of humour from everyday life.

(4) Image of Sun Wukong, the famous Monkey

In *jingju*, Sun Wukong, the Monkey, can be played by either the *wuchou* (military comic role) or the *wusheng* (military male role), depending on the script. Generally speaking, a *wusheng*'s Monkey emphasizes the character's might and bravery, while a *wuchou*'s Monkey pays more attention to his nimbleness and humorous personality.

The image is the Monkey King in *Havoc in Heaven*, played by Zhu Lingyu specializing in the military male role. This figure is illustrative in several aspects. For costuming: as a King to his mountain, his armour, inner-trousers, and boots are all in the yellow colour. In order to show his power, he wears the pheasant feathers and his armour is decorated with four flags. For make-up: Monkey has a special pattern just for

Figure 4.2 Image of *jing*

Source: Courtesy of the National Peking Opera Company

Figure 4.3 Image of *chou*

Source: Courtesy of Li Yuru's family (a gift to Li from the painter)

himself; no matter whether it is played by a comic or a military male role, and how the details can be altered, the face must be lined in a peach shape, showing the fruit is the Monkey's favourite food (stealing peaches from Heaven is an important part of the original novel *Journey to the West*). For the posture: the actor again stands with his feet in the T position, but the heel of the left foot in the front is slightly raised. The photograph also shows how an actor "plays" with the pair of feathers.

(5) Image of Yang Zirong

The image is taken from the moment in the dance set depicting how Yang Zirong, a brave PLA man, is galloping up and down the snowy mountain. The scene is from *Taking Tiger Mountain by Strategy*, one of the first eight Revolutionary Model Plays produced during the Cultural Revolution. The hero is played by Tong Xiangling. This photograph well illustrates how *jingju* practitioners have dealt with the dichotomic pair of *xu* (empty) and *shi* (solid), one of the essential concepts in traditional Chinese aesthetics. Yang still uses a riding crop to show his galloping movement but it is now plain (closer to a riding crop in everyday

Figure 4.4 Image of Sun Wukong

Source: Courtesy of the National Peking Opera Company

Figure 4.5 Image of Yang Zirong

Source: Courtesy of Shanghai Jingju Theatre

life) without any coloured tassel-decorations. He is wearing an everyday outfit, but the overcoat is modified in order to let the actor dance with it. The jump is not entire *jingju* convention but has absorbed elements from ballet and gymnastics.

Notes

1 This is one of the principal free metrical types in the *jingju* musical system.
2 All the translations are the author's unless otherwise stated.
3 This is the spelling according to the standard *pinyin* system. In quotations, all the original spellings are used and so readers will notice different formats of Mei's name in this chapter.
4 In the old days, *jingju* used property man or *jianchang* to lift the flap (a piece of curtain that separated the back-stage from the performance area) for the star to enter the stage. They could also move around props on the stage if necessary.
5 The English translation follows Elizabeth Wichmann-Walczak's (1991).
6 Since Chinese theatre is non-separated from music, "melody" in the context refers to the theatre. Examples are *qinqiang*, the melody/theatre of the Qin area (in present Shaanxi province), *shaoxingxi*, the theatre of the Shaoxing region, or *jiju*, the drama of the Jilin province.
7 The theatrical form is translated as "clapper drama". It contains several different varieties popular in central and northwestern China.
8 The mass popularity of *jingju* and other regional genres made the traditional song-dance theatre a very useful tool in the reconstruction of the nation's mentality and thus it became a priority to reform it as soon as possible. On 13 November 1948, before the People's Republic of China was founded, the Communist Party newspaper, the *People's Daily*, published an editorial titled "A Step-by-Step Plan for Reforming the Old Drama", stating that "reform of old drama" was one of the Party's "historical tasks". For more discussions see the current writer's *The Soul of Beijing Opera*, pp. 121–54.
9 This project was proposed by Li Ruihuan, the then Tianjin Mayor to "rescue the tradition of the *jingju* art". After some years of experiments, the Tianjin Chinese Culture Promotion Council (Zhonghua Wenhua Cujinhui) produced 355 *jingju* productions involving about 20,000 practitioners nationwide between 1994 and 2002.
10 This is a rather ambiguous term in Chinese theatre. First of all there are two separate Little Theatre practices, one in Taiwan and one on the mainland. Secondly the Taiwanese one was much influenced by the LT movement in the USA, while the latter was not, except for the term. It took inspiration from translations of Little Theatre in the USA and writings about the movement in Taiwan and Hong Kong. The mainland practice was mainly against the rigid style of socialist realism on the *huaju* stage; meanwhile the small scale of its productions and experimental theatrical expressions were its important features. For more discussions see Part IV Independent Theatre: Alternative Space in *Staging China: Staging China: New Theatres in the Twenty-first Century* edited by the current author (Li 2016: 177–232), and Ferrari Rossella (2012). *Pop goes the avant-garde: experimental theatre in contemporary China*.
11 Referring to "atomic and hydrogen bombs and man-made satellites".
12 This is a subtype of *laosheng*, who specializes in singing but can also do martial movements as well. However, the actor is not expected to display martial arts or acrobatics as well as a military *sheng* role.

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5

BOAT/SHIP BUILDING IN TRADITIONAL CHINA

Han Qing and Liu Yingchun

Introduction

Human civilization began to take shape when humans started to use stone tools, and later discovered fire in the dim mists of antiquity. It was almost at this same period that the first appearance of the raft, the canoe, and the wooden boat was identified, indicating the dawning of maritime culture on the banks of the Nile, and on the waters of China, a land cross-cut with rivers, and vast oceans on its eastern coast. In ancient times, China boasted a good variety of boats and ships, making great contributions to the boat/ship building and ocean-going voyages of the world. Up to the medieval period, the "Maritime Silk Road" linked the East and the West closely. When the great Chinese mariner Zheng He in the Ming dynasty led his enormous fleets on his ocean-going voyages along the Indian Ocean, China's "Maritime Age" emerged. China's boat/ship building and nautical science development used to be the most advanced in the world. The following is a brief historical account of boat/ship building in traditional China up to the Ming dynasty.

Boat/ship building in different historical periods

Period prior to the Qin dynasty (2100–221 BCE)

The primitive Chinese made the raft (筏, *fa*) by using wood or bamboo. However, the raft was only an original waterborne tool. Not only were the maneuverability and speed of the raft very limited, but also its simple bundling process could not guarantee safety, which was not beneficial to the further improvement of navigational capabilities. In order to be more seaworthy, to achieve better maneuverability and ensure safety, the primitive Chinese attempted to build the canoe (獨木舟 *dumuzhou*) (Figure 5.1).

Through a long-term observation of nature, the primitive Chinese came to realize that the curling fallen leaves and hollow wood were easy to float on water. Inspired by this, they tried to build canoes and boats. The earliest canoe in Chinese maritime history had the freeboard-like part, the most basic feature of the boat/ship, protecting people on board from falling into the water, but the building of the canoe was quite difficult and time-consuming. The "chiseling a log to build a boat" was like this: first, cut down a big tree, then cut off the branches from the trunk, and use the primitive tools such as a tranchet to chisel a long groove to finally make the log hollow. Because the log was hard to cut, it was very difficult to directly use stone tools to chisel it. The canoe builder then applied wet mud to the part that needed preserving, and

Figure 5.1 A canoe built around 8,000 years ago, unearthed at the Cross-Bridge Relics, Zhejiang province in November 2002

Source: Sun Guangqi (2005), p1

burned the part that needed removing, making it easier to chisel. Such a process of burning and chiseling led to the final product of the canoe.

With the navigation area continuing to expand, the shortcomings of the raft and the canoe began to pop up. As there wasn't a freeboard in the real sense, or the freeboard-like part of the raft was small, and there were gaps between the tree logs or bamboo sticks bound together to make the raft, people and the goods onboard the raft would inevitably be submerged by water when the weight increased. Although the canoe was not leaky, its stability in the water was not good, and the size of a canoe was limited by the size of the original tree trunk. It was difficult for the canoe to meet the ever-increasing demand for the freight to be transported. So people began to build the plank boat with different types of bottoms, based on the basic principles of building of the raft and canoe.

In order to improve the stability of the canoe and increase the space for freight onboard, planks were added around the canoe. The original log, which used to be hollowed to make a canoe, actually became the keel of the boat, and the exhausting chiseling process of building a canoe was not needed at all. Thus a boat with a v-bottom or a round-bottom was built. A raft was built into a flat-bottom plank boat in a similar way. To protect from water permeability, planks were put on the top of the raft first, and then around it. And with a flat bottom, a flat-bottom plank boat was built.

The inscriptions on the oracle bones unearthed from the Yin Relics already had the pictograph of "boat" (舟 *zhou*). The glyph clearly indicated that the boat had evolved into a plank boat by the Shang dynasty (1600—1100 BCE). Such a plank boat was characterized by bilateral symmetry, flat-bottom, square and slightly upturned prow and stern with decks at both ends, and also had a beam or diaphragm. It could be seen that the plank boat up till that time had had a very mature structure of the modern ship and had been in wide use.

China's first warship appeared long ago. In the Spring and Autumn Period (770—476 BCE) and Warring States Period (476—221 BCE), a variety of large warships were already in use. Ever since, the building of warships had been an important part of boat/ship building in traditional China, contributing to a great degree to the global development of the boat/ship building industry. Because stability, speed, maneuverability and attacking strength were especially important for naval warships, a great variety of ships of different styles and sizes were developed.

In these periods, the boat/ship building techniques were greatly improved. First, the scale of boat/ship building increased dramatically, with a larger number of boats/ships built. Second, different types of boats/ships with various functions were built. Third, the hull increased in size as the load onboard increased. Fourth, with improved boat/ship building techniques the structure of the ship was strengthened.

The Qin dynasty (221—206 BCE) and Han dynasties (206 BCE–220 CE)

During the Qin dynasty and the Western Han dynasty (205 BCE–24 CE) and the Eastern Han dynasty (25–220 CE), with the rapid development of the maritime industry, the boat/ship building industry was unprecedentedly prosperous. Many boat/ship building centres had emerged and boat/ship building techniques had been significantly improved. Meanwhile, boats/ships in the Han dynasties were better structured, and the larger vessels had a transverse bulkhead to improve the windbreak capacity of the hull. The strength of the hull guaranteed longer and safer voyages. The ship's maneuvering and propulsion devices in the Han dynasties were in full operation, marking the maturity in the making of nautical tools.

The oar (槳 *jiang*) was the oldest propulsion device of the boat/ship. With the development of the boat/ship, the shape of the oar was constantly changed and improved. The earliest oar was the short paddle (楫 *ji*). Because it was short and could not reach deep enough into the water, it could not provide sufficient propulsion for the boat/ship, so people continued to lengthen and widen it, changed the short one into the long one, and meanwhile the paddling posture changed from the sitting to the standing posture. Because the long oar weighed more than the short one, it was inconvenient to hold it in the hands. Therefore, a hole

was made or a bracket was fixed on both sides of the boat/ship so the long oar could function like a lever and was more labour-saving and efficient while rowing a boat. As the long oar could propel a larger boat, it was widely used during the Qin and Han dynasties.

The invention of the scull (櫓 *lu*) was a big progress in boat/ship propulsion in the Han dynasty. It was more efficient than the oar, both the long and the short one, because it stayed in the water and could propel the boat/ship continuously, thus avoiding the less efficient work of using the oar. The scull, appearing around 100 BCE, served as a device of propulsion for the boat/ship, and was a technical breakthrough in the history of Chinese boat/ship building. In 1742, the British began to use the Chinese sculling oars on their boats, and the screw propeller, invented later, was also influenced by the Chinese sculling oars.

The sail (帆 *fan*) was another development of propulsion for the boat/ship. The sail appeared by the Warring States Period at the latest and was in wide use by the Han dynasties. The advantage of the Chinese type of battened moveable sail was that it was easily manipulated and could be used in all weather conditions regardless of the direction of the wind. In the Song dynasties (960–1279 CE) multiple masts and multiple sails were invented. But it was not until 1466 that the Europeans first began to construct the three-mast boat.

The rudder (舵 *duo*) was a device used to control the direction of the boat. It had appeared and been in use by the first century BCE in traditional China and represented another major Chinese invention. Around the tenth century, the rudder was introduced to the Arab world, and by the twelfth century to Europe. The balanced axial rudder, in widespread use in China by the Song dynasties, was first used in Europe only in the late eighteenth century.

The grapnel (碇 *ding*) was a device for anchoring a boat/ship. The wooden-fluked stone anchor and the wooden anchor, which were invented after the Han dynasty, were constructed on highly scientific principles. Amazingly, the stock anchor, called the naval anchor, which was invented in the Western world and then was used throughout the world, made use of the same basic structure as those of the earlier Chinese versions. In addition, during the Qin and Han dynasties, a more effective wood-stone anchor replaced the original "grapnel", which greatly improved the stability of the large boat/ship when anchoring.

Since 1949, four boat/ship models of the Han dynasty have been unearthed in the ancient tombs in Hunan, Guangdong, and Hubei provinces, which exhibited the following basic features of the boat/ship in the Han dynasty: they all have decks, superstructures, sponson decks, front and rear exits, and the application of nailing in the construction of the boat/ship.

The Three Kingdoms period (220–280), Western and Eastern Jin dynasties (265–420) and Southern and Northern dynasties (421–589)

From 220 CE to 589 CE, China experienced three historical stages, namely The Three Kingdoms period, the Western and Eastern Jin dynasties, and the Southern and Northern dynasties, totaling 369 years. During this period, boat/ship building and marine traffic further developed. The advancement of the boat/ship building industry and the strength of the naval forces played a major role in the Three Kingdoms period, as well as in the destruction of the State of Wu, one of the three kingdoms, by the Western Jin dynasty (265–316). The famous watertight bulkhead and wheel-paddle boat were invented in the Western and Eastern Jin dynasties.

During the Three Kingdoms period, the State of Wei (220–265) ruled by Cao Cao and the State of Wu (222–280) ruled by Sun Quan attached great importance to the development of the boat/ship building industry for military, political, and economic purposes. In Shandong Peninsula and on the Bohai coast ruled by the State of Wei, there were several centres of seagoing boats/ships. The boat/ship building industry in the State of Wu in eastern China built more productive boat/ship building centres all over the southeastern coast. With strict supervision and management applied, a large number of boats and ships were built in

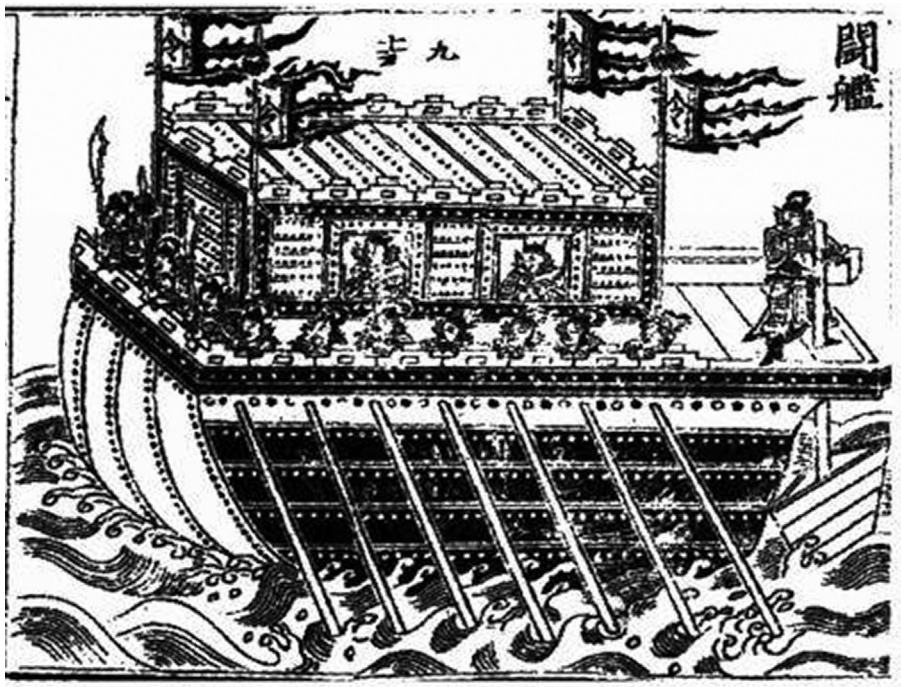

Figure 5.2 The fighting boat (鬥艦 *doujian*)
Source: Jin Qiupeng, *Boat/Ship Building and Navigation in Traditional China* (2011), p. 99

these centres, and a powerful navy emerged in the State of Wu. Various types of warships were built and in operation, including the "fighting boat" (鬥艦 *doujian*) with both offensive and defensive capabilities (Figure 5.2), the "high-speed fighting boat" (走舸 *zouge*) (Figure 5.3) and the "surveillance ship" (斥候 *chihou*), etc. For example, Sun Quan's "flying-cloud ship" (飛雲船 *feiyunchuan*) was a multi-decked royal ship with magnificent decorations, resembling a palace on water. The boat/ship building industry of private ownership in the State of Wu in eastern China also developed rapidly, with various types of civilian boats/ships built in large numbers.

Boat/ship building, including both the public and the private sectors, in the Western and Eastern Jin dynasties developed to a much higher level. The "wheel-paddle boat" (輪槳船 *lunjiangchuan*), alternatively called the "wheel boat" (車輪船 *chelunchuan*), was invented in the Eastern Jin dynasty (317–420) in the early fifth century. The paddles were fixed onto the periphery of the wheels, and with many people paddling the wheels simultaneously, the propulsion efficiency and speed of the wheel-paddle boat were greatly improved. When the wheels were paddled forward, the boat moved forward rapidly, and when the wheels were paddled backward, the boat retreated quickly. Being able to move forward and backward on the water flexibly, the maneuverability of the boat/ship was much improved and this was particularly important for fighting the enemy on the water. The wheel-paddle boat was widely used for a long time from the Eastern Jin dynasty to the Southern and Northern dynasties.

In order to fight with the dynasties ruling southern China, the Southern and Northern dynasties maintained a strong boat/ship building capability. For example, there were plenty of boat/ship building centres along the inland waterways in addition to the ones along the seacoast in the Southern dynasty (420–589); and the "Jingzhou boat/ship building centre" (in today's Hubei province) had a capacity of building about

Figure 5.3 The high-speed fighting boat (走舸 *zouge*)
Source: Jin Qiupeng, *Boat/Ship Building and Navigation in Traditional China* (2011), p. 99

1,000 warships in a fixed period of time. Boat/ship building of private ownership also flourished then. The warships built at this period were very fast in speed.

The Sui dynasty (581–618), Tang dynasty (618–907) and Five dynasties (907–960)

The Sui dynasty was established in 581 CE. Although it was short-lived, lasting just over thirty years, it made significant progress in digging canals, building boats/ships and developing marine traffic. The Tang dynasty achieved rapid economic growth, with the boat/ship building techniques playing a major role in both domestic transportation and international communications. With the continued development of productivity, the boat/ship building centres were established all over the country in the Tang dynasty. And during the Sui and Tang dynasties, and the Five Dynasties that succeeded the Tang dynasty, the boat/ship building industry developed at a fast pace, and good progress was made in the making of nautical tools, and the expertise of boat/ship building ranked at the world's leading level.

In the Sui dynasty, the Grand Beijing-Hangzhou Canal (京杭大運河 *jinghang dayunhe*), an artificial canal from the capital city Beijing in the north to Hangzhou, Zhejiang province in southeastern China, was dug, and dragon boat fleets were established. The huge transportation project of the Grand Beijing-Hangzhou Canal started during the reign of the first emperor Yang Jian of the Sui dynasty. After ending

China's civil wars and division, which lasted more than 300 years, it was imperative for the Sui dynasty to build a canal to strengthen water and land transportation so as to effectively control the regions south of the Yangtze and consolidate national unity. The dragon boat fleets in the Sui dynasty were an indicator of the high level of boat/ship building and the types of boat/ship available. The dragon boat was characterized by a tall superstructure. In order to display the image of the dragon, the hull was long and narrow. Blocks of iron were laid in the hull to increase the stability of the dragon boat because it was quite crucial to ensure the stability of it.

After the reunification of China by the Sui dynasty, Emperor Yang Jian (reign from 581–604) ordered Yang Su, a marshal, to build battleships on a large scale. An even larger scale of boat/ship building started during the reign of Emperor Yang Guang (604–618), the second emperor of the Sui dynasty, to meet the royal needs of officially cruising areas south of the Yangtze. The boat/ship building industry in the Sui dynasty was ranked among the top level of the world. For example, the "five-deck battleship" (五牙艦 *wuyajian*), built under the supervision of Yang Su, was more than three metres high. The dragon boat which Emperor Yang Guang took to tour areas south of the Yangtze was a four-deck ship of more than ten metres high and six metres long.

When the Tang dynasty was powerfully expanding its territory and rapidly developing both economically and culturally, a strong Arab empire was emerging in West Asia and North Africa. The bilateral economic and cultural exchanges between the Tang dynasty and the Arab empire greatly promoted the development of marine traffic in the Chinese Tang dynasty.

It was worth noting that in the Tang dynasty boat/ship building centres were mostly located in areas that abound in silk and ceramics and porcelain products, so boat/ship building and the manufacturing of silk and ceramics and porcelain products promoted each other's development. In the Tang dynasty, government officials were assigned to supervise boat/ship building to guarantee its quality. Emperor Li Shimin (reign from 627 to 649) of the Tang dynasty ordered the boat/ship builders in twelve prefectures south of the Yangtze, in Hangzhou and Shaoxing, Zhejiang province, to build hundreds of large boats/ships at one time. There was no doubt that the boat/ship had become the main mode of transport of the great Tang dynasty.

Coastal areas had always been the main locations for the construction of seagoing vessels. In the north, Dengzhou and Laizhou in Shandong province were the most famous locations for boat/ship building. And in the south, Yangzhou, Jiangsu province, Mingzhou (today's Ningbo) and Wenzhou in Zhejiang province, Fuzhou and Quanzhou in Fujian province, Gaozhou (today's Maoming) in Guangdong province, Qiongzhou (today's Haikou) in Hainan province and Jiaozhou (located in Vietnam today) were quite renowned boat/ship building centres at that time.

Major boat/ship building along or near the inland waterways were mainly located in the following places: Xuanzhou in Anhui province, Runzhou (today's Zhenjiang), Changzhou and Suzhou in Jiangsu province, Huzhou, Hangzhou, Yuezhou (today's Lishui) in Zhejiang province, Jiangzhou (today's Ruichang), Hongzhou(today's Nanchang) and Raozhou (today's Poyang County, Shangrao City) in Jiangxi province, and Jiannandao (in today's Sichuan province) and others along or near the Yangtze.

Boat/ship building made a breakthrough in the Tang dynasty. For a long period, the foreign boats and ships navigating on the shipping lines from the Indian Ocean to the South China Sea were mainly suture-type wooden boats. Olive slabs instead of nails were used in boat/ship building, thus the strength of the hull was not strong enough. But the boat/ship building techniques in the Tang dynasty, with the application of nails in boat/ship building, greatly enhanced the hull's strength to withstand strong wind and waves. In 1960, a Tang dynasty wooden ship was unearthed in Shiqiao Town, Yangzhou city, Jiangsu province, and the application of nails of 17 cm in length and 2 cm in diameter was identified in the building process. In 1973, the nailing technique was again identified in a Tang dynasty wooden ship, unearthed in Rugao, Jiangsu province. The application of nails in boat/ship building helped promote the further development of a watertight compartment. The further enhancing of the wind and wave resistance of the boat/ship and the sturdy structure of the hull made it possible to use more sails and masts for the purpose of ocean-going

voyages. In order to overcome horizontal drift and increase the stability, "floating boards" were put on the left and right sides of the ocean-going vessels, which was an advanced boat/ship building technique in boat/ship building history. Due to the larger size and greater safety, the ocean-going boats/ships in the Tang dynasty were navigating on the Southeast Asian and the Indian Ocean shipping lines.

Another great contribution of boat/ship building made by the Tang dynasty was that several new types of boats/ships were built, such as the flat-bottomed boats/ships and the Guangdong-style boats/ships. The structures of the various types of boats/ships varied according to their seaworthiness and functions.

The Northern and Southern Song dynasties (960–1279), and Yuan dynasty (1271–1368)

From the late Tang dynasty to the succeeding Five Dynasties, the Northern and Southern Song dynasties, and the Yuan dynasty, the Chinese economy was at a downturn due to years of civil wars. The Northern Song dynasty (960–1127), although making all the efforts possible, could not manage to keep the social unrest of the northern and northwestern regions under effective control. During the rule of the Northern and Southern Song dynasties, the communications with the Western Regions (a Han dynasty term for the area west of Yumenguan Pass in Chinese Gansu province, including what is now China's Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region and parts of Central Asia) through the Land Silk Road was severely hindered due to social unrest in those regions. Therefore, China's communications with the outside world mainly depended on the communications on the sea, hence the Maritime Silk Road developed rapidly in the Southern Song dynasty (1127–1279).

The further development in silk and ceramics and porcelain manufacturing contributed to the progress of traditional China's shipping industry, and the international trade of silk and ceramics and porcelain products in the Northern and Southern Song dynasties was mainly conducted through ocean-going shipping. Before the Tang dynasty, China's trade with foreign countries was dominated by silk products, but in the Northern and Southern Song dynasties, trade of ceramics and porcelain products was at a dominant position. The export of exquisite Chinese ceramics and porcelain products were largely shipped from such places as Guangzhou, Guangdong province or Quanzhou, Fujian province to Southeast Asian, South Asian, West Asian, North African and the East African markets via the shipping lines along the South China Sea. The development of the shipping industry in the Northern and Southern Song dynasties brought boat/ship building techniques to a new height. Various types of boats and ships with different functions were built, including the grain-transporting boat/ship, the warship, etc. The boat/ship building centres in the Northern and Southern Song dynasties were located throughout the inland waterways and coastal seaports. The official boat/ship building centres were well-funded and boat/ship building was strictly managed, and they also undertook the repairs of warships and most grain-transporting boats/ships. With the further development of the overseas trade, private shipyards in the southeastern coastal areas in the Southern Song dynasty gradually developed as well.

The Yuan dynasty unified the entire country and chose Beijing as its capital city, then called Dadu. The popular marine route was a north-south path, starting from Liujiagang Harbour in Suzhou and Haimen, Jiangsu province, in the south to Tianjin in the north. The north-south transportation was realized by large seagoing boats/ships, and remained popular until the reign of Emperor Zhu Di (1403–1424) of the Ming dynasty (1368–1644) when it was replaced by river transport due to various risks on the sea. In 1403, Chen Xuan (1365–1433), a transportation officer, first commanded 2000 flat-bottom boats/ships to be built, which actually became the popular design of today's grain-transporting boats/ships.

In the summer of 1974, the archaeological world was stunned by the discovery and excavation of an ocean-going ship of the Southern Song dynasty in the port city of Quanzhou, Fujian province in southeastern China, which lay at the seabed for more than 700 years. This ocean-going Fujian-style cargo ship built in Quanzhou in the Southern Song dynasty represented the peak of boat/ship building technology of that age (Figure 5.4).

Figure 5.4 Ocean-going cargo ship, unearthed in Quanzhou, Fujian province in 1974
Source: Sun Guangqi, *A History of Traditional Chinese Navigation* (2005), p. 5

Although the Yuan dynasty was a short-lived regime, it was a very powerful country at that time, vastly expanding its territory in Asia, and even to eastern Europe, and its prestige spread throughout Asia, Europe and Africa. Due to frequent exchanges between China and foreign countries in the Yuan dynasty, the Chinese four great inventions, namely the compass, gunpowder, paper making, and the art of printing were transmitted to Europe by the Arabs, and the huge Chinese ocean-going boats/ships were known to the world with the help of the great Italian traveler Marco Polo, who stayed in China for a long time and wrote his renowned *Marco Polo's Travels*, introducing China to the outside world. The Yuan dynasty attached great importance to its economic and cultural exchanges with foreign countries. Foreigners from all walks of life of various countries came to China, and they were well received by the government of the Yuan dynasty, some of whom even held important government positions, inclusive of Marco Polo. At the same time, the Yuan dynasty sent envoys and travelers to other countries as well.

The boat/ship building industry in the Yuan dynasty rapidly developed in the process of conquering and opening up the ways of transporting grain up north to the capital. After conquering the Southern Song dynasty, the Yuan dynasty started a large-scale boat/ship building. The main boat/ship building centres were located in such places as Yangzhou in Jiangsu province, Guangzhou in Guangdong province, and Quanzhou in Fujian province, and so forth. For example, from 1274 to 1292 in the Yuan dynasty, a total number of more than 9,900 boats/ships were constructed. The ship structure, seaworthiness and loading capacity in the Yuan dynasty were greatly improved and were among the world's top level.

The Ming dynasty (1368–1644)

The Ming dynasty used to be a powerful empire in Asia, exerting its far-reaching influence on other Asian countries politically, economically and culturally. For example, during the reign of the second emperor Zhu Di, the Ming government sent a large number of ambassadors to Asian and African countries to

Figure 5.5 Zheng He's Treasure Ship, a Restored Illustration

Source: Jin Qiupeng, *The Illustrated History of Chinese Sciences and Technologies* (1999), p. 234

establish contacts with the outside world. Between 1405 and 1433 CE, Zheng He, China's outstanding mariner, led his fleets to navigate on the Indian Ocean shipping lines seven times, visiting more than thirty countries in Asia and eastern Africa. At the beginning of the Ming dynasty, Zheng He's seven ocean-going voyages further promoted the development of traditional Chinese boat/ship building to an unprecedented prosperous period. Up until the Ming dynasty, the traditional Chinese boats/ships can be put into three major categories: the large junk, the Treasure Ship (寶船 *baochuan*) (Figure 5.5), and the Guangdong-style boat/ship.

The boat/ship building industry reached the highest level in Chinese history up to the mid-Ming dynasty, much more developed than the previous dynasties. The official boat/ship building centres were located all over the coastal areas, and also along or near the inland waterways, with larger scales, improved building facilities, higher quality, and stricter supervision of the construction process. There was a strict, standardized management system in boat/ship building, including the firm check of raw materials, strict supervision of the construction process, and careful inspection at the time of delivery of boats and ships. It was just such a technologically advanced and scientifically managed boat/ship building system that enabled Zheng He, the world-renowned Chinese ocean-going mariner, to lead his fleets to successfully carry out the seven ocean-going voyages along the Indian Ocean shipping lines. In some boat/ship building centres, the quality requirements and inspection standards of private boat/ship building centres were to a certain extent even higher than those of the official boat/ship building centres.

To look back, the boat/ship building in the Ming dynasty first started out of the needs of transporting grain by the marine route up north to the capital city, and also fighting against invaders attacking China from the Chinese eastern coast, particularly the Japanese pirates. In 1368, the first year of the Ming dynasty, the first emperor Zhu Yuanzhang (reign from 1368 to 1398), ordered to build seagoing boats/ships in Mingzhou (today's Ningbo) in Zhejiang province for the purpose of transporting grain up north to the capital city. In a period of six to seven years after 1372, Emperor Zhu Yuanzhang ordered to build a large number

of seagoing boats/ships in Zhejiang and Fujian provinces against the invaders coming from the sea, and in 1380 he ordered to build even more seagoing boats/ships in eastern China's Jiangsu province, thus Nanjing became an important boat/ship building centre. In the later period of the rule of Emperor Zhu Yuanzhang, there were boat/ship building centres all over the country, along the seacoast and on the banks of inland waterways as well.

Besides the ship building centre in Nanjing in eastern China, there were many other boat/ship building centres across the country, for example a shipyard in Taichang, Jiangsu province, shipyards in Zhangzhou, Fuzhou and Quanzhou, Fujian province, a shipyard in Mingzhou (today's Ningbo) in Zhejiang province, a shipyard in Zhigu, Hebei province, and shipyards in Chaozhou and Guangzhou, Guangdong province, to name just a few. And various types of boats and ships were built until the mid-Ming dynasty. They were the grain-transporting boats/ships by the marine route and by inland waterways, ships for transporting official supplies, and warships for resisting foreign invaders attacking from the eastern seacoast. There was another type of ship, the Diplomatic Ship, which was specially built for the royal visits to the Lyukyu Islands, then a subordinate to the Chinese Ming dynasty.

Conclusion

Song Yingxing, a Chinese scientist in the Ming dynasty, says in his encyclopedic book *Tian Gong Kai Wu* (17th-century Chinese Agricultural and Handicraft Achievements) that the society is formed and maintained by the mobility of different groups of people, goods, and services from place to place. In traditional China, people in the South rely more on boats and ships to a certain extent and those in the North rely more on carts in their public transport besides other modes of transport. It is obvious that boat/ship building has always played an important role in the social progress of traditional China, reflecting its economic development and technological achievement. This chapter is a brief historical account of the development of boat/ship building in traditional China. It is hoped that this brief introduction can be of some assistance to the academic research by experts and scholars studying traditional Chinese culture both home and abroad, and also can be conducive to the international communication of traditional Chinese culture.

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6

BUDDHISM IN TRADITIONAL CHINA

Xue Yu

Introduction

One of the greatest wonders in the history of world civilization perhaps is the meeting of Buddhism from India with distinctive and advanced Chinese culture represented by Confucianism and Daoism in China in the turn of the first century CE, and thus creating a rich and multihued culture neither the same nor different from the predecessors. Once Buddhism entered China it vigorously sought matching up with Chinese culture through self-adjustment and self-modification willingly undergoing the process of Sinicization by actively absorbing ideas and practices from Confucianism and Daoism, which in return while resisting Buddhist infiltration, also readily adopted certain Buddhist doctrine and practice for self-enrichment. The phenomena of such mutual competition and reciprocal learning continued for more than a thousand years as they could still be seen in the later Ming dynasty (1368–1644). This chapter first briefly introduces the history of Chinese Buddhism and then examines major features of Chinese culture which were deeply influenced or rather shaped by Buddhism. Being aware of its long history of about 2,000 years and its massive contents, the introduction and examination will be concise; only important events and major culture features will be highlighted here. Nevertheless, for the sake of better understanding of Chinese Buddhism in general it is indeed necessary to provide a succinct background of Buddhism in India.

A general consensus is now achieved among the contemporary scholarship on Buddhist studies that the Siddhattha Gotama, the founder of Buddhism, was born as a prince to a royal family in Kapilavastu in 566 BCE. Having seen the suffering of the world, such as sickness, old age, and death, he left the palace and became an ascetic at the age of 29 seeking for the Dharma which could liberate all living beings from suffering. Six years later, he attained the perfect enlightenment or Buddhahood and soon launched the mission of teaching the Dharma. During his lifetime, the Buddha travelled throughout Middle India with a large group of monastics, teaching the world the Dharma he had discovered – basically, the doctrine of dependent-origination. Soon after he passed away or entered into final Nirvana at the age of 80, the monastics collected what the Buddha had taught and passed down his words through oral transmission for generations before it was first written down in Sri Lanka in the 2nd century BCE.

About 100 years after the Buddha's Nirvana, the first schism occurred within the Sangha, the community of Buddhist monastics, over the dispute on Vinaya or disciplinary code. Subsequently, further schisms took place with the controversies over the Buddha's teaching, resulting in the arising of as many as eighteen different sects. In the third century BCE, King Asoka (r. 274–236) of India sponsored a Buddhist council

recollecting Buddhist canon and rectifying the Sangha. At the end of council, Buddhist missions were dispatched to various parts of the world, including Europe, for the first time in human history. One missionary group led by Ven. Mahinda (285–205 BCE), the son of King Asoka, arrived in Sri Lanka and established Buddha-Šāsana in the island. To a large extent, Buddhism Mahinda taken to Sri Lanka was Vibhajyavāda, one of eighteen Buddhist sects that existed in India at the time. From Sri Lanka as well as India directly, Buddhism gradually transmitted to other Southeast Asian countries, such as Thailand. In around first century BCE, texts of Mahayana Buddhism, particularly Prajna doctrine, began to appear in India and Central Asia, advocating great wisdom for universal salvation and Bodhisattva ideals in a vivid contrast to sectarian or Theravada Buddhism, which highlighted self-liberation and monastic practice. In the first century CE, both Theravada Buddhism and Mahayana Buddhism were brought to China by merchants, state emissaries, and Buddhist missionaries through the Silk Roads.

Geographically, Buddhism in the contemporary world can be divided into two major branches in accordance with the path of the transmission: the southern branch and northern branch. Doctrinally, the southern branch mainly follows Theravada tradition while the northern is characterized with Mahayana Buddhism, which was further developed in China. Linguistically, the cannons of these Buddhisms are written in Sanskrit, Pali, and classic Chinese, as well as Tibetan language respectively, and all of them are still available in China today.

Historical survey of Chinese Buddhism

The date and route for the arrival of Buddhism in China are differently recorded in Buddhist literature and historical books, and no consensus is arrived among scholars or in Buddhist circles today. However, a popular Buddhist tradition goes that Buddhism arrived in China under the invitation of Emperor Ming (r.28–75 CE), who dispatched emissaries to the West Regions in 61 CE in search of Buddha-Dharma after the dream in which he saw a Golden figure flying inside the palace. This tradition prevailed among the Chinese Buddhist community for centuries largely because it politically legitimized the existence of Buddhism of foreign orientation in China where Confucianism had already been predominant ideology there. Modern studies, however have updated the arrival of Buddhism in China to about half a century earlier as it was recorded in a Chinese historical book that in 2 BCE a scholarly official from the Han court orally received the transmission of a Buddhist text from an emissary of Yuezhi (月氏) kingdom. Similarly, the route by which Buddhism found its way to China is also revised in contemporary scholarship and three possible routes are proposed to have connected China and India: (1) The North Silk Route through the West Regions or Central Asia; (2) Southwest Silk Route through Miyama; and (3) Maritime Silk Route from Bharukaccha on the western coast of India to Java or Malay Peninsula, arriving in Canton, China. Meanwhile, scholars such as Liang Qichao (梁啟超, 1873–1929) and Hu Shi (胡適, 1891–1962) also suggested that Buddhism first arrived and spread in south China through the Maritime Silk Route and the evidence is now recovered by modern archeological discovery in Xuzhou (徐州) area. It seems that the initial transmission of Buddhism to China was carried out by foreign merchants, who were traditionally in good relationship with Buddhism. The early presence of foreign merchants and existence of Buddhism in the south were unnoticed or rather ignored by the Chinese court or upper class of Confucian society centered in north China at the time.

One piece of evidence suggesting earlier Buddhist arrival in China through the Maritime Silk Route was the record of An Shigao (安世高,148–170 in China), the first foreign missionary of Buddhism to China and well-known translator of Theravada Buddhist texts. One of the important texts he translated is *Anapanasati Sutra*, which deals with the technique of Dhyana or meditation practice. In about 167 CE, Lokasena, another Buddhist missionary from Yuezhi arrived in Luoyan, the capital of China and started to translate Mahayana scriptures, basically Prajñâpâramitâ sutras into Chinese.

Although both Theravada Buddhism and Mahayana Buddhism arrived in China almost simultaneously, the latter however captured religious fascination of Chinese people and became main stream of Chinese Buddhism later on. Kang Senghui (康僧會, ?–280) from the West Regions arrived in China during the Three Kingdoms (220–280) and set up the motion of Dharma-Wheel in Nanjing. Largely due to the social instability and political turmoil in China at the time, he and other foreign monks were forced to wander from one place to another, therefore they could hardly find peace to undertake the systematic translation of Buddhist texts.

After the collapse of the West Jin dynasty in 316, China was divided into two parts, the south China of the Eastern Jin and the north China, which was subsequently plunged into a long period of violence between warring states of non-Han powers. Nevertheless, Buddhism in the north developed rather considerably thanks to the efforts of foreign eminent and enigmatic monks such as Sanghabhuti, Dhamanandi, Sanghadeva, and Zhu Fanian (竺法念). One of them was Fo Tucheng (佛圖澄, 232–348), who arrived in China in 310 from Central Asia. Fo Tuchen, endowed with extraordinary power of performing miracles, was able to win the trust of the rulers of the Later Zhou (319–351) and thus put the cruelty of the vicious ruling in check, reducing the suffering of common people.

Dao An (道安 312–385), one of well-known Chinese monks in the Jin dynasty, made great contributions to the early dissemination as well as Sinicization of Buddhism in China. Daoan renounced the world in childhood shortly after his parents passed away and studied Buddhism under the mentorship of Fo Tuchen. According to Hui Jian (慧皎, 497–554), the author of *Hagiography of Eminent Monks*, Daoan, being a charismatic leader of the sangha, once gathered around him a large group of talented intellectuals and established fully fledged sangha in China. For the first time in the history of Chinese Buddhism, he produced the catalogue of translated texts in Chinese (*Comprehensive Catalogue of Sutras*), drafted regulations for the daily routine of the sangha in accordance with available Vinaya texts, and prescribed the principle for Chinese translation of foreign texts. Most importantly, Daoan, keen in doctrinal inquiry of Buddhism, set up an exemplary paradigm for the academic study of Buddhism through comparative methodology characterized with seriousness and faithfulness. Under his guidance and leadership, more Chinese intellectuals and Confucian literati became interested in Buddhism.

In 365, Daoan sent his monastic disciples away to different regions of China either for the sake of propagating the Dharma or to overcome hardship imposed upon the sangha due to the war and violence at the time. Hui Yuan (慧遠, 344–416), one of Daoan's disciples, therefore travelled to the south and settled down in Lushan where he founded a new Buddhist centre namely Donglin Monastery (東林寺), which quickly became a model of institutional Buddhism. The reputation of Huiyan for spiritual cultivation, religious observance, and Dharma studies quickly spread far away, commanding respect from emperors, nobles, literary figures, as well as common people in the south alike. Meanwhile, Kumārajîva (344–413), well-known translator of Buddhism from the West Regions, arrived in Luoyan in 401 after overcoming lots of adversities. Being a master of both Mahayana and Theravada particularly Sarvāstivādin School, he systematically translated the texts of Mādhyamika school and many other Mahayana texts into Chinese under the patronage of Emperor Yao Xing (姚興) (r. 393–415). His reputation also attracted a large number of gifted monks, such as such as Dao Sheng (道生, 355–443), Seng Zhao (僧肇, 384–414), Dao Rong (道融), and Seng Rui (僧叡) and flowed to Luoyan, studying the Dharma under his guidance and assisting him for the enterprise of Buddhist translation. With such great help and under such a favoured environment, Kumārajîva translated ninety-four texts of Sutras, Vinaya, and commentary, altogether 425 volumes, into Chinese; among them, the *Diamond Sutra*, *Amitabha Sutra*, *Lotus Sutra*, the *Vimalakirti Nirdesa Sutra*, *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* and the *Pañcaviṃśatisāhasrikā-prajñāpāramitā Sutra* are most important. Some texts he translated laid down theoretic foundation for the establishment of Buddhist schools in China, such as the *Lotus Sutra* for Tiantai School, *Amitabha Sutra* for Pure Land School, etc.

In 420, the East Jin dynasty was superseded by the Liu Song dynasty founded by General Liu Yu (劉裕 420–479) while the Northern Wei dynasty of non-Han nationality was founded by Topa people in north

China after 440. Chinese history subsequently entered into the period of Southern-Northern dynasty (440–589) until all of China was reunited under the Sui dynasty (581–618). During this period, Buddhism continued its pace of Sinicization, while increasingly exerting tremendous influence on Chinese culture and society. Political division rather contributed to the development of nuanced forms of Buddhism in different regions, for in the north religious practice such as meditation was highlighted, while doctrinal studies, philosophical elaboration, and literature analysis were preferred in the south. Similarly, despite frequent changes of dynasties and recurrence of war between different non-Han minorities in the north, Buddhism institutionally or economically there expanded rather rapidly as it was estimated to have 2,000,000 monks and nuns and more than 30,000 temples, among them forty-seven in great size constructed in the Northern Wei dynasty (386–534). Several facts might have given rise to such growth, for instance, lack of a powerful central government that would have otherwise imposed vigilant control over institutional Buddhism. Also, incessant wars in the north instead provided Buddhism with an opportunity to attract those who suffered in the midst of violence. Buddhism, full of spiritual ideas for future life, would also offer Chinese people an idealized method to deal with the sociopolitical reality of this world, such as the instability of the world and uncertainty of life. This kind of situation may explain why people then readily accepted Mahayana Buddhism rather than Theravada Buddhism even though the two were transmitted to China almost simultaneously, simply because the idea and practice of compassionate and merciful Bodhisattvas, such as Maitreya in Mahayana, would certainly afford those Chinese with more visionary hope for releasing suffering from this world. Meanwhile, Buddhism in the Southern dynasty also witnessed rapid growth although the cause for such growth might be the increasing interesting in Buddhism shown by the upper class of society which had escaped from the north to avoid the violence there. There were about 1,768 temples and 24,000 clergy in the Eastern Jin (317–420), yet the number increased to 2,864 and 82,700 respectively in the Liang dynasty (502–557). Political patronage and economic supports of emperors and royal families in successive dynasties also contributed to the growth.

The reunification of the south and north under the Sui dynasty in 589 as well as the political stability and economic development in the subsequent Tang dynasty (618–907) provided an opportunity for two trends of Buddhism to merge with new strength, thus accelerating the process of Buddhist Sinicization and prompting a new era of Buddhism full of creativity and dynamism. Profundity of Buddhist philosophy as well as a huge bulk of Mahayana texts rendered into Chinese from Sanskrit and other languages in the previous centuries were now digested, systematically studied, and practised by Chinese sangha as well as Chinese intellectuals. New schools gradually came into existence. Different from those in Japan and Tibet, strong sectarianism however was absent among Chinese Buddhism, for different schools rather showed the eagerness of mutual learning and willingness of collaboration. The Tang dynasty thus witnessed the apogee of Chinese Buddhism, which not only captured fascination of literati but also accelerated the process of Buddhist Sinicization.

In the following dynasties of Song, Yuan, Ming, and Qing, institutional Buddhism, although having witnessed ups and downs, showed a trend of decline gradually in general. Several reasons can be found for this development, such as decreasing and then stoppage of input of Buddhist texts and philosophical ideas from India, the revival of Confucianism and emergence of Neo-Confucianism, stringent political control over the movements of the sangha, as well as the moral corruption and spiritual bankruptcy of Buddhist clergy. Towards the end of Qing dynasty, Buddhism lost its spiritual momentum in leading the new development of Chinese culture, yet it still remained or even strengthened its predominant position in popular religion featured with ancestor worship. The majority of the sangha became professional ritualists, and their duty was no more spiritual cultivation but ritual performance for the dead. Largely in protesting against such practice, a new form of Buddhism called humanistic Buddhism (人間佛教) appeared in the early Republic era (1911–1949) and has become a mainstream of Buddhist development in China even today, calling Buddhists to serve the needs of living human beings and make due contribution to betterment of this world.

Buddhism and politics

The relation between institutional Buddhism and political authority in China was quite different from that in ancient India, where religion exerted tremendous influence over political affairs as traditionally kings should pay due respect to religious ascetics. It was the duty of the king to provide material needs for ascetics in his kingdom, and the state should neither impose any restriction on their religious practice nor should it interfere with their internal affairs. According to Theravada tradition, the Buddha once turned down the proposal by Devadhata that the sangha be put under the protection of the state. Nevertheless, early history of Buddhism in India as well as the history of Buddhist expansion beyond Indian territory illustrates vividly the vital importance of the patronages of kings, for instance Asoka, who was responsible for the internationalization of Buddhism. Later on, Mahayana Buddhism modified its attitude toward politics that kings who practice the Dharma and safeguard Buddhism will be blessed by Bodhisattvas as popularly shown in *Karunikaraja-prajnâ Paramita Sutra*.

When Buddhism was introduced to China in the Later Han dynasty (25–220), highly centralized and bureaucratic government based on secular ideology of Confucianism had already been firmly established that political authority maintained decisive power over religious institutions. Being a foreign religion in China, Buddhism therefore had to double its efforts to win political endorsement and support for only then could it exist and spread in China. Several versions of how Buddhism was first introduced to China were available in both Buddhist and non-Buddhist literature; Chinese Buddhists in general, however, prefer the one that Buddhism came to China under the invitation of Emperor Ming (28–75), simply because this version rather indicates political legitimacy of institutional Buddhism in China. As discussed earlier, Buddhism once having entered China developed rapidly both in the north and south largely due to the active patronage of kings and emperors. Shi Hu (295−354), the vicious ruler of the Latter Zhou, being fascinated by the performance of supernatural power of Fo Tucheng (232–348) showed favouritism to Buddhism as he once stated that both his ancestors and the Buddha were equally foreigners. During his reign, Chinese people were allowed for the first time in history to renounce the world and become monks. A close relationship between institutional Buddhism and the court could also be seen through the interaction between other eminent monks and emperors, such as Kang Senghui (康僧會) and Emperor Sun Hao (孫皓, 242–284) during the Three Kingdoms Period, Daoan and Emperor Fu Jian (符堅 338–358) of Former Qin (350–394), Kumarjiva (343–413) and Emperor Yao Xing of the Later Qin, and Dharmaraksa (385–433) and Juqu Menxun (386–433) of the Northern Liang dynasty. Meanwhile, in responding to the political favouritism, Buddhists readily provided its service to and collaboration with the court. Fa Guo 法果, an imperially appointed chief of the sangha in the Northern Wei dynasty (386–534) even took a lead in worshipping the emperor with a justification that the latter was no other than the present-day Tathâgata.

A similar situation could also be seen during the Southern dynasty in which quite a number of emperors were personally converted to Buddhism, and some of them such as emperor Yuan (317–322) of the Eastern Jin and Emperor Wen (407–453) of the Liu Song also demonstrated great enthusiasm in Buddhist philosophy and practice intensifying the ties between institutional Buddhism and the state. Emperor Wu Di (502–549) of the Liang dynasty (502–557) even three times offered himself as a slave to a Buddhist monastery so that ministers and members of royal family would redeem him by paying large sum of ransom to the monastery. Considering himself as Bodhisattva-Emperor, Wu also made an effort to combine Buddhism and Confucianism in his state administration, elevating Buddhism to the status equal to a national religion and openly calling people to embrace Buddhism.

A controversy once occurred in the Eastern Jin whether monks and nuns who had renounced worldly life should kneel down before secular rulers, particularly emperors in accordance with political and moral ideology of Confucianism. An edict was once issued by the court of Emperor Chen (325–342) that all sramanas or monastics ought to pay homage to kings, and a similar issue was brought up again to a nationwide debate during the reign of Emperor An (396–418). Nevertheless, the implementation of such policy was

intervened and eventually aborted by the powerful opposition of Buddhists as well as aristocratic in favour of Buddhism. Such phenomena rather revealed a reality that Buddhism by then had already been firmly established in Chinese society as capable of defying political authority. Hui Yuan in defending the independence of the sangha urged the court not to implement secular ideas over the sangha by rationalizing the differences between political affairs and Buddhist practices, monastics and lay Buddhists. Buddhist clergy living in this world yet with the aim of leaving the world, according to Hui Yuan, should not bow down before kings, yet this does not mean that they disrespect the authority of kings; on the contrary, by engaging themselves in teaching the Dharma and providing moral advice such as the Five Precepts to people, they were actually serving the state and assisting the ruling.

Buddhist clergy may not worship kings, yet the sangha or institutional Buddhism in China must comply to secular ruling. Daoan, the master of Hui Yuan, once remarked that Buddhism would not be established in China without relying on rulers particularly at the time of war. The state control of institutional Buddhism or rather subjugation of Buddhism under secular rule accelerated in the Tang dynasty which prioritized Daoism before Buddhism because the royal family considered Laozi a legendary founder of Daoism as their remote ancestor. Wu Zetian (武則天 690–705), however reversed the order, showing her preference to Buddhism in her political struggle for power. During this period, Buddhist clergy when addressing to emperor began to call themselves "subject" (臣) rather than "the outsiders of the world" they had used before. In the Yuan dynasty (1271–1368), De Hui (德輝), who assumed abbotship of Baizhang Monastery in 1329, recompiled *The Monastic Regulations* originally composed by Baizhang (百丈 720–814). The regulations then promulgated by the imperial decree of Emperor Shun (1333–1368) begin with the" Congratulation Chapter" and the "Gratitude Chapter", expressing Buddhist appreciation to emperors and willingness to serve the empire. A traditional practice thus formulated in Buddhist temples that monks and nuns would chant certain verses in praying for the long life of emperor, for peace and harmony of the empire during their religious service every morning.

The practice of collaboration or even self-surrendering of institutional Buddhism to secular authority, however, did not always guarantee the safety of the sangha. To a large extent, the fate of Buddhism was extensively determined by rulers who could either support or persecute Buddhism. Throughout history, four state persecutions against Buddhism occurred during the reign of Emperor Taiwu (423–452) of the Northern Wei dynasty, Emperor Wu (560–578) of the North Zhou, Emperor Wuzong (841–846) of the Tan dynasty, and Emperor Shi Zong (954–959) of the later Zhou dynasty (951–961). Different reasons might have contributed to each persecution, such as accumulation of a large sum of temple wealth or rivalry between Buddhism and Taoism, yet personal attitude of emperors toward Buddhism was the key issue in all of them.

In the middle of the Tang dynasty, Confucianism gradually regained its revitalization in society and recaptured its absolute authority over political affairs. Confucianists such as Han Yu (768–824) criticized Buddhism severely for its unsuitability and contradictoriness to Chinese culture. Neo-Confucianism in the Song dynasty increased its criticism against Buddhism. Successive dynasties of Ming and Qing intensified vigilant control over institutional Buddhism, regulating or rather limiting the social activities of the sangha. Buddhism eventually disappeared from state affairs and retreated from social life of the upper class, becoming part of folk religion for ordinary Chinese people. Nevertheless, it is worthy of mentioning that during the Yuan dynasty (1271–1368) and Qing dynasty (1644–1911), Tibetan Buddhism was brought to inner China and prevailed in the court, playing an important role for the national unity between Han, Tibetan, Mongol, and Manchurian.

Buddhism and philosophy

According to Theravada tradition, what the Buddha discovered beneath the Bodhi tree is the Dharma of Paticca-samuppada (Pratiya-samutpada) or dependent-origination which thus laid down a religious and

philosophical foundation of Buddhism. From a historical point of view, early Buddhism in India showed little interesting in metaphysical speculation but highlighted the importance of the practice leading to the end of suffering through eliminating its cause and conditions. Buddhist philosophy based on the doctrine of dependent-origination therefore must be pragmatic for the end of suffering as indicated in the Four Noble Truths. Mahayana Buddhism, particularly Madhiyamika school, reinterpreted the doctrine of causality from a different aspect of negation and urged people to see the reality of unsubstantiality or emptiness of the world. The Yogacara school further developed the idea of causality and advocated the doctrine of consciousness only that everything, mental or physical, is illusion except consciousness, basically the Alayavijnana. Toward the last stage of Buddhist history in India, the doctrine of Tathagathagarbha was elaborated that the Buddha nature is the cause and source of all, characterized with permanence, happiness, self, and purity. These three philosophical systems of Mahayana Buddhism then developed in the West Regions, from where they were subsequently brought to China, providing resources for the establishment of philosophical schools of Buddhism in China.

At the very beginning, Buddhists as well as intellectuals in China made use of traditional Chinese ideas and concepts in philosophic Daoism and Confucianism through the stratagem of meaning match (格義) to interpret *Prajñā* doctrine from India. Such kind of practice made due contribution to further development of Dark Learning (玄學 Xuanxue) and the movement of Pure Talk (*Qingtan* 清談) or metaphysical discussion prevailed in the Jin dynasty, adding Buddhist views to the debates of being and non-being, existence and non-existence, mind and matter, although evidently the Buddhist philosophy of India was also transformed in due course. Continuous input of Buddhist ideas and vocabularies enabled the Chinese to grasp Buddhism more closely to its Indian origin, thus providing a leading role in the later development of Xuanxue and giving rise to the arising of Six Families and Seven Schools of Buddhism in the Jin dynasty.

The philosophy of Chinese Buddhism developed rapidly after Kumārajīva's systematical translation of Madhyamika texts, particularly *The Middle Treatise* (中論 Zhonglun) or *Madhyamakaśāstra*), *The Treatise on the Twelve Gates* (十二門論 or *Dvādaśadvāraśāstra*) and *The Hundred Verses Treatise* (百論 *Śatakaśāstra*) into Chinese, and based on which the School of Three Treaties was founded by Ji Zang (吉藏 549–623) in the Tang dynasty. Elaborating the notion of non-acquisition and the doctrine of emptiness, Ji Zang reformulated the twofold truth – conventional and ultimate, and considered them primarily in epistemological rather than in ontological sense. He advocated the dialectic unity of the two truths or the true meaning of the Two Truths (*Erdi Yi* 二諦意).

The School of Three Treaties faithfully inherited the Madhyamaka philosophy of Indian Buddhism, and so did the School of Consciousness Only (唯識宗) closely followed by the Yogacara School, which upholds that all phenomena arise from the Alayavijnana, the basis and source of all activities and phenomena. Xuan Zang (玄奘 600–664), one of the greatest Chinese pilgrims to India, brought back and translated numerous texts of the Yogacara School composed by Maitreya, Asangha, and Vasudhandu, and thus became the first patriarch of Consciousness Only School in China. In synthesizing the ideas of masters of the Yogacara School in India, Xuan Zang composed a Treaty of the Establishment of the *Doctrine of Consciousness Only* (成唯識論), explicating the structure and function of consciousnesses and its relation with external world. This school almost disappeared from China in the ninth century and its texts were reintroduced from Japan in the later nineteenth century.

The first school of Buddhism distinctive with Chinese characteristics was the Tiantai (天台) School founded by Zhi Yi (智顗 538–597) based on the *Lotus Sutra*. By reinterpreting philosophy of Indian Buddhism, particularly the Madhyamaka philosophy, or rather recreating a new philosophical tradition of Chinese Buddhism, Zhi Yi advocated new unity of Threefold Truth of emptiness, convention, and the middle way. In an effort to rationalize or rather reconcile contradictions within Buddhist texts and traditions, he also classified the Buddha's teaching into a system called Five Periods and Eight Teachings, though such classification was lacking any historical basis. Meanwhile, Zhi Yi made an effort to combine Buddhist meditation of Samadha or calmness and Vipassana or insight, providing pragmatic techniques and concrete

instruction for the practice, such as walking, sitting, half walking and half sitting, neither walking nor sitting. Obviously, to Zhi Yi, both philosophizing of Buddhist meditation and cultivation of Buddhist philosophy are equally valid and vitally important.

The Chan School and Huayan School of Chinese Buddhism are both heavily influenced by the idea of Tathagathagarbha or the womb of Buddha. According to the *Arising of Faith on Mahayana Buddhism* (大乘起信論), one of the most important texts exploring dialectic relation between living being and non-living being, the conditioned or non-conditioned, the conventional or absolute are just manifestation of the womb of Buddha. Every living being is therefore endowed with Buddha nature, and the enlightenment is to see such nature within each of us. Chan Buddhism, introduced to China by a legendary figure Bodhidharma (?–536) from South India as Buddhist tradition claimed but actually founded by Hui Neng (惠能 638–713), the Sixth Patriarch, highlights the original endowment of Buddha nature. Two branches emerged, the Southern Chan and Northern Chan in the early Tang dynasty, claiming Sudden Enlightenment and Gradual Enlightenment respectively. The Northern Chan of Gradual Enlightenment disappeared in the middle of the Tang largely due to the lack of talented masters while the Southern School developed rapidly with the ramification of Five Families and Seven Sects in the Song dynasty. New methodology was developed for the practice of meditation, such as Gong'an or Public Case (公案) or Investigating Critic Phrase (看話頭), and Silent Illumination (默照), stressing the importance of creativity, spontaneity, and intuitionality. Such practices may lead practitioners to attain one-mindedness or mindfulness which would enable them to awaken one's Buddha nature.

The Huayan School founded by Fa Zang (法藏 643–712) is centered on the Avatansaka Sutra, which illustrate the Buddha's world and Bodhisattva's path. By elaborating the doctrine of pratiyasamutpada in connection with the idea of Dharmadhatu, this school provides a different vision of the world, which is the mutual containment and interpenetration. Everything exists in relation to others or as part of the total nexus of reality, depending on the total network of all others. Fa Zang once made use of metaphor of golden lion to illustrate the idea of Dharmadhatu that *li* and *shi*, noumenon and phenomenon are mutually interpenetrating and interdependent. Such ideas were further elaborated by the patriarchs of the school, such as Zong Mi (宗密 781–841). In the Song dynasty, Confucian literati, having reinterpreted the doctrine of Huayan and Chan Buddhism and integrated them into Confucianism, reconstructed the worldview of Neo-Confucianism.

Buddhism and ethics

According to Theravada tradition, the Buddha requested lay Buddhists to observe five precepts, of which only not being intoxicated was particularly Buddhistic while all other (not killing, not stealing, committing no adultery, not lie) are the common religious ethics at the time of the Buddha. Similarly, only when the impurity contradictory to the behaviour of ascetics popularly adopted by all religious traditions at the time occurred did the Buddha began to lay down the precepts or rules for the Sangha. Thus, Buddhist ethics, different from commandments in other religions, is considered as a necessary precondition or foundation for mental training and spiritual cultivation of samadha and vipassana, leading to the attainment of the perfect wisdom or final liberation. Similar to Buddhist philosophy, Buddhist ethics is also drawn from the Dharma or doctrine of causality, specifically the law of cause and effect. Why should one be morally good and abstain from what is bad, such as killing, stealing, adultery, and lying? Buddhist answer is rather pragmatic: not only because such morality is prescribed by the Buddha but also because good begets good and bad begets bad. With this regard, Buddhist ethics is founded on voluntary basis, for one is responsible for one's own action, which automatically produces its outcome, neither punishment nor reward by anyone else.

Soon after the Buddha's nirvana, monastic disciples convened a council to collect Vinaya pitaka or the code of monastic discipline. Altogether several sets of Vinaya of Theravada tradition existed in India and five of them were translated into Chinese before the fifth century CE. One of them is the Vinaya in Four Parts,

which serves as foundation for the Disciplinary School founded by Dao Xuan (596–667), and generally accepted as a norm of disciplinary practice by other schools of Buddhism in China. The Vinaya contains 250 rules for monks and 348 for nuns, providing disciplinary guidance for the ordination ceremony as well as the daily life and religious activities of monastics. Along with the arising of Mahayana Buddhism, scriptures containing the disciplinary code for Bodhisattvas of both monastics and laity also appeared in India and were subsequently translated into Chinese. Different from Theravada tradition, Bodhisattva precepts highlight the importance of the mind instead of action itself, advocating threefold discipline of purity (三聚淨戒): abstaining from doing what is bad, cultivating what is good, and benefiting living beings. Largely due to social, cultural, and geographical diversities between China and India, some precepts could not be easily observed in China, a few Vinaya texts such as *Brahmã's Net Sutra* were therefore codified by the Chinese during the fifth century CE. In the Tang dynasty, Bai Zang, master of Chan Buddhism, composed the first set of pure rules (清規), which is neither same nor different from Vinaya of Theravada and Bodhisattva precepts of Mahayana. This set of pure rules was revised several times and promulgated by imperial decree nationwide in the Yuan dynasty.

One of controversial disputes occurred between Buddhism and Confucian culture was the Buddhist tradition of worldly renunciation, celibacy, and mendicancy. The following three practices were particularly contested as summarized in *On Clarification of Confusion* composed by Mouzi: (1) Buddhist monastics who deformed their body and cut their hair violate the moral principle of the Book of Filial Piety that body, hair, and skin given by parents should not be impaired; (2) Buddhist monastics who would not get married and thus have no heir were in direct contradiction against one of the most important filial behaviour of producing offspring; and (3) One who enters sangha dons with ecclesiastic robes and thus ignores traditional etiquette in Chinese culture. In counterarguing against Confucian criticism such as above, Buddhists in China first endeavored to discover a common ethic ground for both Buddhism and Chinese culture and downplayed the differences. Then they spared no pain to re-interpret Buddhist ethics and to justify the practices that were essential to them.

In counterarguing against Confucian accusations that Buddhist monastics violated the moral principle of filial piety, Chinese Buddhists would first admit the differences between the two, then they would further point out that the filial piety of Buddhism rather exceeds or was superior to that of Confucianism. The best way to show one's filial piety to one's parents and ancestors, according to Buddhism, is to embrace Buddhism and undertake Buddhist practice, such as renunciation and offering which would generate greater merits. By transferring merits gained from such practices to one's parents and ancestors, one would fulfil the duty of filial piety much better, for such merits would deliver them from worldly suffering, even the cycle of rebirth and being born in the happy realm. Qi Song (1007–1072), an eminent monk in the Song dynasty composed *The Treatise of Filial Piety*, highlighting filial piety in Buddhism as the highest precept for all Buddhists. In responding to the revival and subsequent dominance of new Confucianism in Chinese society, Buddhists composed several apocrypha or Weijing, such as the *Fumu-en-zhong-jing* (*Too Heavy to Repay the Kindness of Parents*) to justify the existence of Buddhism by highlighting its value for Chinese society. Such sutras, while expressing the close bond between mother and son, stresses the necessity for one to repay the kindness of parental pregnancy and breeding by transferring merits to them through performing religious activities such as compiling sutras, burning incense, worshipping the Buddha, and material offering to the sangha. Among all these activities, teaching the Dharma to parents is considered the most effective and highest form of filial piety to repay parental kindness.

The Buddhist practice of home-leaving also imposed direct contradiction to the family values of Confucianism and one of them was the duty of producing offspring. Buddhist monks and nuns who renounce worldly life and break down traditional bonds within family members disengage themselves from the family duty. Theravada Buddhism justifies the tradition by claiming that only then could one leave all worldly burden behind and concentrate on religious practice. Yet, Chinese Buddhism would suggest that renunciation would enable one to serve humanity better by adopting the path of Bodhisattva,

the ideal type in Mahayana Buddhism. Serving living beings alike through six perfections (paramita) – generosity, morality, patience, effort, meditation, and wisdom – is morally superior to the ethics of Confucianism. The idea and practice of Bodhisattva as exemplified by Avelokitesvara therefore also opened a way for ordinary people to cherish hope for the end of suffering only if they could sincerely pray for the compassion of Bodhisattvas.

Ethical conflict between Buddhism and Confucianism intensified when Han Yu (768–824), a pioneer of Neo-Confucianism in the Tang dynasty, attacked the Buddhist practice of venerating Buddha's religion in his essay entitled *Memorandum on the Buddha's Relics* submitted to Emperor Xian Zong (778–820). According to Han Yu, the Buddha, a foreigner unable to speak Chinese and wearing bizarre robes, should not be worshipped in China where ancient sages taught people to speak Chinese full of elegance and wear proper clothes. Buddhist monks, in emulating the Buddha, did the same by tonsuring their heads and donning ecclesiastical robes, engaging not in any agricultural productivity but depending their life on others. Furthermore, Buddhism originally from India encourages people to abandon the relationship between the emperor and subject, the father and the son, and ignoring the blessing of birth and upbringing given by parents, which were deeply appreciated in the moral system of protocol of Confucianism. In response to the criticism posed by Confucian scholars such as Han Yu, Buddhists would normally attempt to reconcile the differences between the two. Qi Song found the conformity of the two by comparing the five precepts of Buddhism with the five constant virtues of Confucianism: no killing to humanity, no stealing to righteousness, no sexual misconduct to courtesy, no false speech to faithfulness, and no taking intoxicants to wisdom. By such comparisons, perhaps as he wished, Buddhism might find a legitimate position in society dominated by Confucian ideology. Unfortunately, such attempts rather accelerated the demise of Buddhism simply because Buddhist ethics would be no more needed if it was not different from that of Confucianism, which had already won political support and social foundation in China.

Han Yu's accusation against Buddhism was rejected by Buddhists and his proposal to burn the Buddha's relic was denounced by the emperor, yet his spirit of fighting against Buddhism exerted far-reaching effects on Buddhist history late on. About twenty years later, Emperor Wu Zong (814–846) launched a persecution nationwide against institutional Buddhism, which could never recover again as before. Buddhism in the Song dynasty had to withdraw from the upper class of society, gradually finding its way to integrate itself into the practice of popular religion serving the needs of ancestor worship through performing rituals for the dead. During the Ming and early Qing dynasties, some eminent monks continued to call for the union of Buddhism, Daoism, and Confucianism; such endeavor was, however, not to complement Buddhism with Confucianism but rather compromising Buddhist ethics or even surrendering Buddhism to Confucianism.

Neo-Confucianism, though its rise was associated with the anti-Buddhist movement, could not completely reject Buddhist ethics and the idea of sainthood. Before the introduction of Buddhism, a debate whether human nature is originally wholesome or unwholesome had already prevailed in China and no conclusion was achieved even among Confucian literati. Buddhism brought the doctrine of Buddha nature to China and thus expanded a vision for Chinese people to understand human nature. Buddha nature is within every sentient being and even icchantika who is incorrigibly evil beyond redemption will somehow attain Buddhahood. Such idea was readily inherited and developed by Neo-Confucianism that everyone can be a saint as Yao and Shun, two legendary sage kings in Chinese culture. Drawn from the doctrine of Buddha nature and in elaborating Buddhist ethics of karma, Buddhism also changed the attitude of Chinese people towards nature and other living beings such as animals, which would be equally valued as human beings. Not only should one not kill human beings but also should not harm animals, big or small. The idea of non-violence in connection with the cultivation of great compassion promoted the rise of vegetarianism in China that one should not consume animal meat. Such practice prevailed in Chinese society that not only monastics but also lay Buddhists and even non-Buddhists followed the tradition to show their compassion.

Buddhism and religious practice

A debate once occurred in modern China whether Buddhism is religion or philosophy. Although no conclusion is achieved no one will deny that Buddhism is religion even though it is different from others, especially monotheistic religion. As a religion, Buddhism not only offers Nirvana as the ultimate concern but also provides the path to attain Nirvana through Threefold Learning of Discipline, Meditation, and Wisdom, which are also often explained in terms of the Eightfold Path. Mahanaya Buddhism expanded religious practice to include almost all activities such as charity of benefitting not only fellow human beings but also other sentient beings in the six realms. Thus, besides religious practice of meditation, chanting sutras and expounding the Dharma, reciting Buddha's names, repentance rituals, and hand-copying Buddhist texts, traditional Buddhism in China also paid great attention to serve the need of the dead in collaboration with religious practices of Daoism and Confucianism such as ancestor worship and filial piety, and thus developed a variety of ritual culture and liturgical practice.

Meditation is major religious practice in Buddhism, which highlights the importance of mental training. In traditional monasteries, the Meditation Hall played a key role in the religious life of residents. Numerous methods for meditation were developed, such as one-pointedness of mind, meditation on four Brahmanvihara (compassion, loving-kindness, appreciative joy, and equanimity), mindfulness of inhalation and exhalation, etc. All these can be categorized into two: Samadha and Vipassana, or concentration and mindfulness. These forms of meditation, after being brought to and developed in China, collaborated with some meditative practice and spiritual cultivation of Zhuangzi, such as self-erasing in sitting, flavour of freedom, simplicity, and naturalness, while also producing more new forms of meditation such as practice of Gong'an. Meanwhile, Buddhist meditation also attracted great interesting of Confucian literati and gave rise to the spiritual cultivation of Neo-Confucianism in the Song and Ming dynasties. Neo-Confucianists, having inherited the traditional idea of "quietness" and "respect" in traditional Confucianism, practised them in collaboration with Buddhist idea of *dhyana* or concentration. To Confucianists, by sitting quiet in meditation, selfish desires would be eliminated. By eliminating one's selfishness, one would overcome the barrier between the small self and big self, and naturally conform to the Universal Law.

When Buddhism was brought to China during the Eastern Han dynasty religious Daoism was also at the initial stage of arising, and the Buddha was sometimes regarded not different from other sages. According to the *Biography of Chu Prince Ying*, Liu Ying, the Prince of Chu enshrined the statue of the Buddha together with that Huangdi and Laozi. This kind of practice continued and further developed in popular religion in which Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, the paradigm of compassion and wisdom in Indian Buddhism, were often worshipped as powerful deities for the worldly benefit, such as health and wealth. Bhaisajyaguru 藥師如來 or Medicine Buddha, for instance, was venerated for longevity and rituals dedicated to him would be performed when one is ill or on occasion of one's birthday. The worship of Amitabha Buddha and belief of the pure land almost became a religious norm in China after the Tang dynasty and dominated Buddhist activities in the Ming and Qing dynasty.

According to an ancient Chinese tradition, one who is dead would go to a place called an underground and live there depending largely on the offering of their offspring. It is therefore necessary for descendants to provide them with foods and other daily necessities through religious rituals. Buddhism, in collaboration with such traditional belief with its concept of karma and rebirth, as well as pure land, recreated a Buddhist tradition of new practices, such as funeral rituals, memorial services, rituals of sacrifice, festivals and holidays, amusement and entertainment, and witchcraft, etc. Buddhism thus transformed the religious tradition of China as sons and daughters who would patron such activities and transfer merits accumulated from them and other good deeds to their dead parents and ancestors, who, having received such merits would be born either into a pure land or win the birth of better realms.

Buddhism also changed the worldview of Chinese people and multiplied the dimensions of time and space that there are numerous world systems where different species of living beings exist. A man after

death may not necessarily go to the underground solely but any of six states depending on one's karma, and even be born in a pure land if his religious duty is fulfilled. Devotional practices and ritual performances in connection with the belief of the Western Paradise of Amitabha took a central position in popular Chinese religion. Buddhist clergy are invited and rituals performed to generate merits on behalf of dead relatives. A variety of rituals are also performed in temples daily, monthly, and annually, such as morning and evening services, rituals for hungry ghosts, Water-Land Festivals, Lantern Festival, Festival in honoring the Buddha's relics, vegetarian feast, etc. Meanwhile, temple festivals are organized in memorials of important days of Buddhas and Bodhisattvas, such as Bathing Buddha Festival on Buddha's birthday in April 8th of Lunar month. The reinventing of Buddhist rituals in association with the idea of merit-transferring generated enormous avenues for institutional Buddhism and material life of the sangha. Different from the practice in Indian Buddhism, the sangha in China had to support their own material life, and ritual performance therefore is considered both as religious practice and productive activities for self-reliance.

Chinese Buddhism inherited the idea of religious pilgrimage that existed in Indian Buddhism and popularized its practice through consecration of mountains in China. During certain periods or on certain occasions, devoted Buddhists would organize a pilgrimage either to temples nearby or to these sacred mountains, of which four are the most popular in connection with four great Bodhisattvas, namely, Wutai 五台山 with Manjusri, Jiuhua 九華山 with Ksitigarbha, E'mei 峨眉山 with Samantabhadra, and Putuo 普陀山 with Avalokitesvara, each embodied with wisdom, blessing, practice, and compassion respectively. Among these great Bodhisattvas, Avelokitesvara and Ksitigarbha are particularly popular among folk society as they are usually regarded as powerful yet compassionate deities, who not only bless the living beings but also release the dead from the suffering of hell.

Buddhism, art, and literature

Symbolism and metaphor play vital roles in almost all religions, particularly in Buddhism. On the one hand, symbols in the form of art and literature are necessary means to express religious ideas; on the other hand, religions produced great art and literature in their efforts of propagation and dissemination. Throughout a long history of 2,000 years, Chinese Buddhism produced great numbers of excellent arts and the first rate literature, which in return made great contributions to the development of Buddhism so that it could spread widely all over China and thoroughly prevail in all levels of society. When the first Buddhist missionaries arrived in Luoyan under the invitation of Emperor Ming as a legend goes, they brought with them Buddhist paintings and statues. Later on, the building used to house foreign guests was converted to a temple called White Horse Temple and its walls were depicted with paintings of chariots and horses circling the pagoda three times. Buddhist art from India as well as the Western Regions together with Buddhist philosophy and worldviews opened a new horizon for Chinese artists, transmitting new artistic styles and thus ushering a new era for the history of art in China. During the Southern and Northern dynasties, a new form of Chinese art emerged featured with simple shapes, bold lines, and unconstrained colour, clearly influenced by meditative and reflective themes of Indian Buddhism.

Religious truth usually unseen to ordinary eyes can only be expressed through symbolism, which may arouse mysterious imagination and religious passion of people. The propagation of Buddhism in China not only brought in Indian art but also transformed Chinese art that existed before in a variety of forms, such as caves, grottos, paintings, statues, murals, sculptures, etc. Buddhist monasteries in China emulate the typical layout of a royal palace, consisting of a series of halls, such as the Hall of Great Hero, Hall of Four Devas, and courtyards arranged symmetrically around a central axis with several ancillary buildings such as hall of patriarchs or Bodhisattvas on the two sides. Being the place of religious activity and spiritual cultivation, Buddhist temples in traditional China were often located in natural and glamourous environments, such as forests and mountains full of sense of serenity and awesomeness. In some large monasteries, pagodas, building of Three Pitakas, Pillars inscribed with Buddhist texts, and sculptures engraved in gold, stone,

jade, wood, porcelain, ceramics could often be seen together with Buddhist calligraphies, reflecting artistic beauty and religious themes. Paintings of mountain-water depicting natural scenes, such as lotus ponds, trees, and birds, influenced by Chan Buddhism, highlight simplicity, naturalness, and harmony. Buddhist chanting and music within such natural and peaceful environments would certainly soften people's heart and mind, enhancing spiritual cultivation. Also, the majestic beauty of Buddha statues and Bodhisattvas' images, as well as typical pagodas often command respect of ordinary visitors.

A Buddhist tradition goes that monastic disciples collected the words of the Buddha soon after he passed away, and orally transmitted his teaching for generations before they were first written down in the 2nd century BCE. For the sake of memory and recitation, the meaning of certain sutras is often summarized by gathas or poetry at the end of prose in spoken language. According to Theravada tradition, the Buddha might have spoken colloquial languages of the day and instructed his disciples to preach the Dharma in their own dialects. To Buddhism, words or texts are not essentially important but the meaning behind and any language could be used to transmit the meaning or the teaching of the Buddha, and such idea gave rise to the artistic recreation of Buddhist literature in different languages.

The translation of Buddhist cannons dominated Buddhist activities in the early history of Chinese Buddhism, leaving tremendous impacts on almost all aspects of Chinese literature, such as the composition with mixtures of prose and poetry or gathas, poetry, prose, novels, dramas, full of new literary style, symbolic expression, imaginative creativity, religious conceptions, and idealized reality. The texts translated by early missionaries such as An shigao, Lokaksema, Dharmaraksa, and Kang Senghui maintained such spirit and often showed distinctive Buddhist styles characterized with "using euphuistic words, plain yet not coarse to illustrate profound philosophy". This kind of translation set up a practical sample for the arising of popular literature such as novels, fiddle ballads, popular stories, dramas, etc. Some Buddhist texts such as Jatakas, hagiography of Bodhisattvas, and eminent monks are full of legendary tales, parables, and fables, as well as metaphors to illustrate Buddhist philosophy and ethics.

The translation and spread of Buddhist texts also enriched Chinese vocabularies; many new terminologies, classical allusions and idiomatic expressions, new words of artistic beauty were gradually produced. Some Buddhist texts themselves such as the translation of *Vimalakitī Sutra* by Kumarajiva and the *Heart Sutra* by Xuan Zang, are excellent literature works both in form and content. It is estimated that ninety percent of the foreign idiomatic expressions used in China were originally from Buddhist translation. In an effort to spread Buddhism among the populace, Chinese Buddhists further developed three popular practices, reciting and reading of Buddhist texts, chanting and singing Buddhist hymns and songs, and lecturing on Buddhist scriptures after the Southern and Northern dynasties. During Yuan and Ming dynasties, Buddhist creativity for the Dharma promulgation led to the emergence of narrative and singing literature, such as Bianwen—transformation of Buddhist text, Baojuan—Precious Text, fiddle ballad, drum verse, and novel, illustrating the great compassion and supernatural power of Bodhisattva and Buddha, pleasure of heaven, happiness of pure land, as well as suffering in hell and in the realm of hungry ghosts.

Due to the introduction and widespread of *Prajñā* or the doctrine of Emptiness, metaphysical poetry, once disappeared after the Qin dynasty, reemerged and prevailed in the Eastern Jin dynasty with the renovation of new styles of contented, quiet, and comfortable poetic expressions either for literary appreciation or for the Dharma propagation. During the Tang dynasty, a new kind of poems influenced by Chan Buddhism and Zhuangzi's philosophy gradually emerged and soon became popularized in Chinese society. Chan Buddhism, which devalued the importance of language that might rather distract and delude the mind, appreciated intuition into reality. Nevertheless, Chan Buddhism produced the bulk of literature in China, far more than that of any other individual school of Buddhism. Words may not truly reveal truth yet it is useful and sometime necessary for one to see through into the reality. Similarly, spiritual attainment cannot be expressed in words, yet they may lead a way to the realization of wisdom. Therefore, both Chan masters and Chinese intellectuals often made use of poems to express the state of enlightenment, or to provide religious instructions to disciples in didactic yet mystic ways.

Conclusion

Buddhism, full of cultural creativity, spiritual energy, and philosophical dynamism never stopped exerting its influence on ancient Chinese culture while voluntarily undertaking the process of Sinicization once it entered China, and thus joined with Confucianism and Daoism to produce new Chinese culture after the Tang dynasty. Chinese Buddhism was further brought to Japan and Korea and made great contributions to the development of national culture of these two nations. It is worth mentioning some texts of the origin of Chinese Buddhism were also brought back to India and Central Asia as well as Southeast Asia, playing a positive role for cultural exchange between China and the states in these regions. Although it declined after the Song dynasty largely due to revival of Neo-Confucianism and excessive confucianization of Buddhism, Buddhism continued to play a huge role in the popular religion of Chinese people. Thanks to the effort of some eminent monks such as Tai Xu 太虛 (1890–1947), Xu Yun 虛雲 (?–1959), and Yin Guang 印光 (1862–1940), Buddhism in the Republic Era (1911–1949) witnessed a short period of revival and rise of Humanistic Buddhism. Having almost disappeared from mainland China after the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976), Buddhism once again is experiencing a kind of revival and is reassuming a leading role in the religious life of Chinese people today.

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7
CHINESE CALLIGRAPHY

Xu Yangsheng and Chan Sin-wai

Introduction

Chinese calligraphy, or *shufa* 書法 in Chinese, is the art of writing Chinese characters, usually with a writing brush, in an aesthetically pleasing way. It has a long history in China, dating back to the middle Shang dynasty, about 3,600 years ago. It is generally regarded as the most ancient artistic form in the history of China, a unique art that is representative of China, and the most prized among the four major traditional forms of art, the other three being music, chess, and painting. Though calligraphy and painting emerged around the same time and sharing the identical tools of brush and ink, calligraphy was revered as a fine art long before painting. Through the art of calligraphy, the ideographic Chinese characters are presented in different styles and tastes, creating an aesthetic that is pleasing to the eye.

The impact of Chinese calligraphy cannot be overemphasized. Locally, it has led to the development of many forms of art in China, including seal carving, ornate paperweights, and ink stones. Internationally, Chinese calligraphy has, through the ages, built up a worldwide influence. It has also been introduced widely to the neighboring countries of China, such as Japan and Korea.

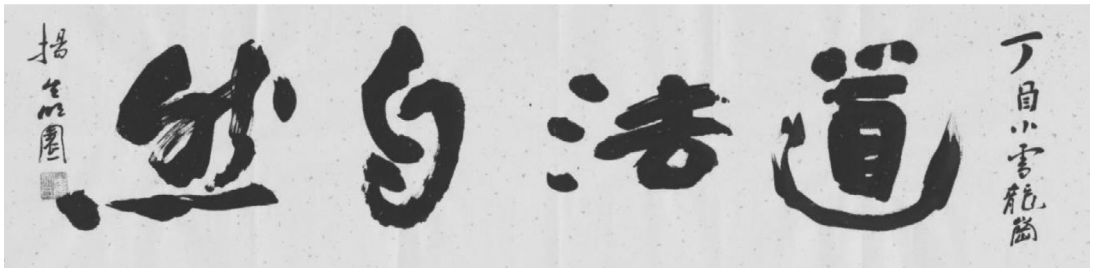

Figure 7.1 "The Way follows the nature"

Source: Professor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

Components of calligraphic creation: use of brush, structural combination and layout

The major components that create a piece of calligraphic work are the use of brush, structural combination, and layout.

The use of brush

The use of brush in writing Chinese characters determines the aesthetics of calligraphy. There is a complete set of rules of brush for writing the dots, horizontal strokes, falling strokes, vertical strokes, hooks, and others. There are also basic principles of stroke order and placement. The rhythm, flow, and speed of writing the lines of characters, control of the character size, and contrast between light and dark all play an important part in the production of a good piece of calligraphy.

The method of using the brush is also closely related to the script one is writing. For the formal scripts, the brush is moved with deliberation. For the informal scripts, such as the running script, the brush is moved with speed and spontaneity.

Structural combination

Calligraphy is about the art of combining characters. This refers to the structural relation between the strokes of each character. It is to be noted that setting out the components of each word requires deliberation on prioritization, concession, and coherence among the components, which lead to the structural symmetry and harmony of the characters.

Layout

This refers to the overall spatial arrangement for the whole piece of calligraphy through, among other things, the organization of the space between characters, the distance between the lines, and the allocation of characters. To be particularly well-arranged there must be a relation between the black and white colours on the whole artwork which is instrumental to producing the effect of void and concretion.

Styles of Chinese calligraphy

There are five main styles of calligraphy: seal script, clerical script, regular script, running script, and cursive script.

Seal script

Seal script (*zhuanshu* 篆書), originated in the Han dynasty, can be divided into the greater seal script (*dazhuan* 大篆) and the lesser seal script (*xiaozhuan* 小篆). The greater seal script, evolved from oracle-bone inscriptions, appeared in the Zhou dynasty. The neat structure of oracle-bone inscriptions lays the foundation for the form of modern Chinese character. The lesser seal script, which is simpler in form and more standardized in structure than the greater seal script, was collected, compiled, and prescribed by Li Si 李斯 (246 –208 BCE) after the unification of China by the Qin Empire, and is therefore known as Qin seal script (*Qinzhuan* 秦篆). The seal script is elegant in style and is widely favoured by people today in the creation of calligraphy works.

Figure 7.2 "Relaxed but diligent"
Source: Professor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

Clerical script

The clerical script (*lishu* 隸書) was originated in the Eastern Han dynasty, mostly used in the inscription of memorial steles. The emergence of the clerical script is another reform in Chinese characters, ushering in a new stage of the development of Chinese calligraphy. In fact, it was a transitional period in the development of Chinese characters, laying a solid foundation for the development of the regular script. The clerical script is of the flat, neat, and refined structure. At the beginning of the Eastern Han dynasty, the left-falling stroke and right-falling stroke bent upwards, and other strokes were characterized by the variations and beauty of calligraphy. The style of clerical script features diversification and it has a high value for appreciation.

Regular script

The regular script (*kaishu* 楷書), also called the true script and evolved from the seal script, is simpler in structure and square in shape, having more standardized horizontal and vertical strokes. The integral feature of the regular script is neatness and orderliness, for which it is widely used and favoured, and the regular script is commonly referred to as the standard script.

Running script

The running script (*xingshu* 行書), which was purportedly invented by Liu Desheng 劉德昇 of the late Han dynasty, is the cursive form of the regular script. Running script is less compact than the clerical script and less cursive than the cursive script.

Cursive script

The cursive script (*caoshu* 草書) has to be written according to certain rules. It has a concise structure with borrowed components. The cursive script might look irregular, but it has a high artistic value that goes beyond its practical worthiness.

The cursive script can be divided into three types: the script written with less abandon is the small cursive script (*xiaocao* 小草), with more abandon, the large cursive script (*dacao* 大草), with lots of abandon, the crazy script (*kuangcao* 狂草).

The evolution of different scripts in China

The preceding five types of scripts have evolved through a long period of time. The movement has been from the formal scripts to the informal ones. The formal scripts are standardized and used in most occasions, whereas the informal ones are used in less formal occasions, such as in the writing of personal notes or for appreciation.

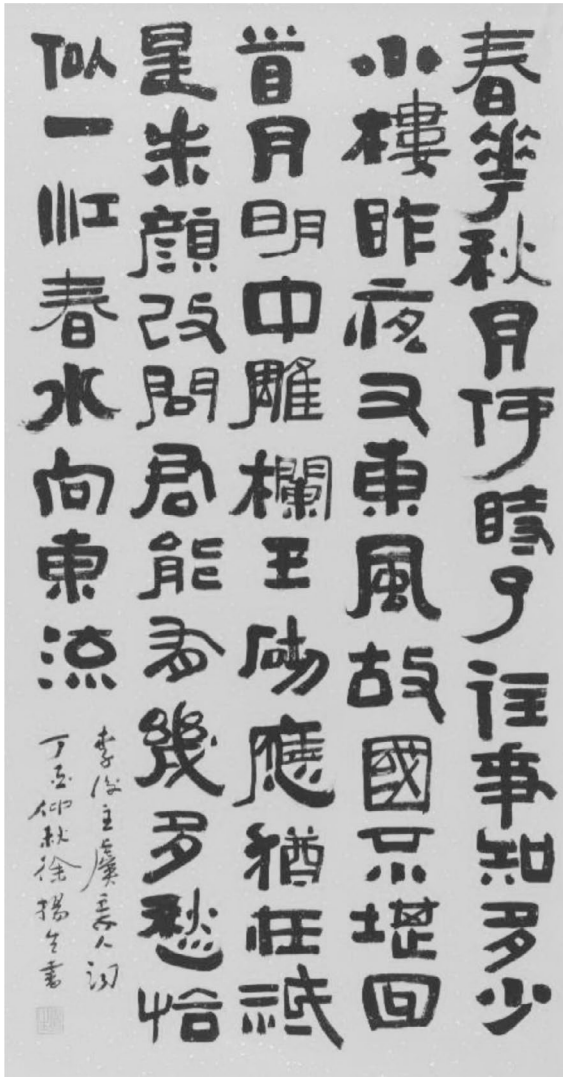

Figure 7.3 A *ci*-poem by Li Yu 李煜

Source: Professor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

Chinese characters, to begin with, are the major components of Chinese calligraphy, which can be traced to 4,000 BCE (Lu and Aiken 2004). Based on the findings from the site of Xiaoshuangqiao 小雙橋 discovered by archeologists in 2003, writing in China dates back to the Middle Shang dynasty.

The writing of Chinese characters probably begins with the "oracle" characters (*jiaguwen* 甲骨文) carved on ox scapulas and tortoise plastrons for pyromancy, which was a form of divination practised mainly during the late Shang dynasty (Lu and Aiken 2004). During the divination ceremony, after the cracks were made, characters were written with a brush on the shell or bone to be later carved (Keightley 1978). But examples of brushwork on bones are lacking as it could not stand the wear and tear of weather. Later, the "bronzeware script" (*jinwen* 金文) and "greater seal script" (*dazhuan* 大篆) were developed.

During the reign of the first emperor of the state of Qin (Qin Shihuang 秦始皇), he ordered his minister Li Shi to make several reforms, one of which was character unification. As a result, a set of 3,300 standardized "lesser seal script" (*xiao zhuan* 小篆) characters was created. Also regularized during the reform was the clerical script (*lishu* 隸書). Later during the Eastern Han dynasty, the "regular script" came into being, with Zhong Yao 鍾繇 as its first known master.

The "running script" (*xingshu* 行書) was originated in the late Eastern Han dynasty, reaching its prime in the Eastern Jin dynasty. As its style is free flowing, it has been widely used. Wang Xizhi is the most representative person for the prime age of running script, as shown by his *Preface to the Orchid Pavilion, which* has been commonly recognized as the best work of the running script. Another informal script is the "cursive script" (*caoshu* 草書), originated during the Han dynasty through the Jin dynasty. Cursive scripts are faster to write through graph omission, stroke merging, portion abbreviations, and stroke modification. Cursive scripts were highly appreciated during the reign of Emperor Wu of Han (140–87 BCE).

Tools for calligraphy

The brush (*bi* 筆), ink (*mo* 墨), ink stick (硯), and paper (*zhi* 紙), collectively known as the "four treasures of the study" (*wenfang sibao* 文房四寶) are essential implements of Chinese calligraphy. In addition to these four tools, a calligrapher also needs the water-dropper, desk pad, and paperweight.

Brush

A brush, or *maobi* 毛筆 in Chinese, has since its invention in China around 300 BCE been the traditional writing instrument for Chinese calligraphy. As different people, script styles, and writing skills require different types of brushes, a great variety of brushes is available. Brushes differ greatly in terms of size, texture, length, material, and cost. A detailed analysis could be made according to different parts of a writing brush.

Body of the brush: The body or handle of a writing brush is commonly made from bamboo. Other materials, such as porcelain, gold, silver, jade, ivory, horn, and wood are also used.

Hair of the head of the brush: The head of the brush is usually made from animal hair, such as weasel (especially Siberian weasel), rabbit, goat, mouse, buffalo, pig, tiger, and wolf, while exotic ones can be made from hair of the tiger, fowl, and deer.

Hair texture: The texture of the hair of the head of the brush is divided into three categories: soft hair, (軟毫 *ruanhao*), mixed hair (兼毫 *jianhao*), and hard hair (硬毫 *yinghao*).

Hair size of the brush: There are three different sizes of the writing brush: the large size (大楷 *dakai*), medium size (中楷 *zhongkai*), and small size (小楷 xiaokai). The largest-sized brushes are used only for writing very large pieces of calligraphy. The medium-sized brush, which is the most widely used, is for writing a variety of characters and lines. The small-sized brush is for very small pieces and seal-carving.

Hair length of the brush: The hair length of the tip of the brush can be divided into three types: long hair (長鋒 *changfeng*), medium hair (中鋒 *zhongfeng*), and short hair (短鋒 *duanfeng*). The long hair brush, which can hold ink longer than the other two, is for writing continuous long-stroke lines. The medium-length hair is commonly used in calligraphy, whereas the short-length hair is for writing very small and slender characters.

Prices of the brush: Prices of the brushes vary greatly according to quality. It could be less than one US dollar, but expensive brushes made of exotic materials could cost several thousand dollars. The finest and most expensive brushes are *Hubi* 湖筆 made in Huzhou of Zhejiang Province, *Xuanbi* 宣筆 of the Jingxian County in Anhui Province, *Dai Yuexuan bi* 戴月軒筆 in Beijing, and *Houdian maobi* 侯店毛筆 in Hengshui City, Hebei Province.

Today, calligraphy may also be done using a brush pen.

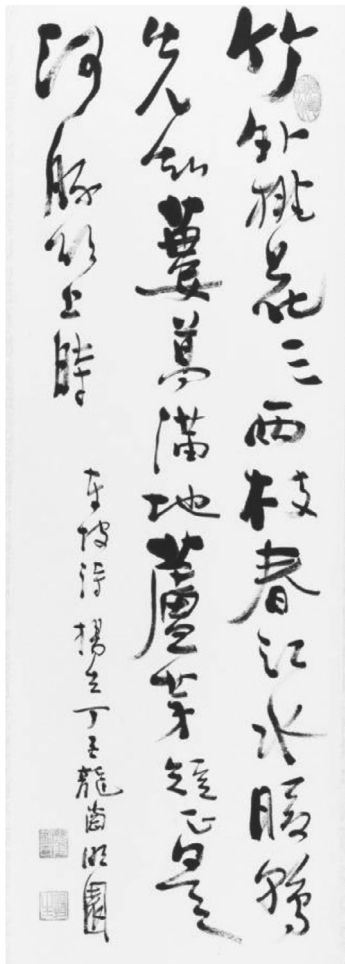

Figure 7.4 A poem by Su Shi

Source: Professor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

Ink

Ink (*mo* 墨), which combines the radicals of *hei* 黑 (black) and *tu* 土 (earth) in the Chinese character, can be dated back to 256 BCE, a history of over 2,000 years. It is made from burned palm twigs or the smoke from tar. As a writing implement, ink is made into an inkstick, which must be rubbed with water on an ink stone until the right degree of thickness for specific calligraphic purposes is achieved. Traditionally, Chinese calligraphy is written only in black ink, and the most highly regarded ink is Huimo 徽墨 (Anhui ink), which refers to ink from the Huizhou region 徽州 in history, part of which is in the present-day Anhui Province 安徽省.

Ink stick

Ink stick is a type of solid ink used in calligraphy and painting in some Asian countries, such as China, Korea, and Japan. Like ink, the use and making of inksticks in China has a history of over 2,000 years. This craft reached its heights in the Ming and Qing dynasties when new methods were invented and new ingredients added. According to ancient Chinese writings, a high-quality inkstick should be light, easy to grind, fresh, hard, quiet in grinding, and its colour should be long-lasting.

With the passage of time, different types of ink sticks have been produced to suit specific purposes or create special effects. The following is a list of ink sticks commonly used.

Oil soot ink (*youyanmo* 油煙墨): This type of ink stick is made from the soot of burnt tung oil or various other oils. It is sticky and the colour is warm, which is good for calligraphy and painting.

Pine soot ink (*songyanmo* 松煙墨): This type of ink stick is made from the soot of pine wood. It has less glue and gives a blueish-black colour.

Charcoal ink (*tanmo* 炭墨): This is made using standard wood charcoal. It has the least amount of glue and so spreads on paper more than other inks. It is mainly used for cursive calligraphy.

Blueish ink (*qingmo* 青墨): This is oil or pine soot that has been mixed with other ingredients to produce a subtle blueish-black ink for use in calligraphy.

Collectors ink (*shoucangjiamo* 收藏家墨): highly decorative and in odd shapes that are meant for collecting rather than for actual use in making ink.

Custom ink (*dingzhimo* 定製墨): ink that has been commissioned by an artist who may want a specific type of ink to suit their needs.

Within each type of ink there may be many variations regarding additional ingredients and fineness of the soot. An artist selects the best type of ink suited to their needs depending on discipline, what paper is used, and so on. The most prestigious representative would be Old Hu Kai Wen which still produces the best inksticks.

Ink stone

Ink stone is a stone mortar for the grinding and containment of ink when writing calligraphy. In addition to stone, inkstones are also manufactured from clay, bronze, iron, and porcelain. Ink stones made from stones of the highest quality can produce ink of the best kind. Chinese inkstones are also highly prized as art objects and appear in many varieties.

Paper

Paper, another important implement of Chinese calligraphy, is one of the four major inventions of China. In Chinese calligraphy, Xuan paper (*Xuanzhi* 宣紙) is the preferred type of paper. As this paper has been used for a long time, it has become the best-known paper by most of Chinese calligraphers.

Xuan paper was originally produced in the Tang dynasty in Jing County, which was under the jurisdiction of Xuan Prefecture (Xuanzhou 宣州), hence the name Xuan paper. During the Tang dynasty, the paper was made with a mixture of hemp and mulberry fibre. By the Song dynasty, the paper producing industries in Huizhou and Chizhou were gradually transferred to Jing County.

Xuan paper can be divided into three categories, according to the methods of production. The first type is *shengxuan* 生宣 (raw Xuan [paper]), which is not specially processed and has an ability to absorb water, thus causing the ink on it to blur. The second type is *shuxuan* 熟宣 (ripe Xuan [paper]), which has a stiff texture but a reduced ability to absorb water. The third type is *banshuxuan* 半熟宣 (half-ripe Xuan [paper]), which has an excellent ability to absorb water immediately. As the *xuan* paper has three different levels of water absorbability and therefore differences in their strength of ink absorption, the selection of *xuan* paper depends on the ideas a calligrapher wants to present and how to present it with the right *xuan* paper that suits his or her purposes.

Other than the four treasures, other implements of calligraphy, such as the paperweight, deskpad, seal, and seal paste are equally essential.

Paperweight

A paperweight is a small object placed on top of papers to hold down paper in a breeze, prevent a paper from slipping, or keep a paper from moving when writing with a brush.

Paperweights come in several types: some are oblong wooden blocks carved with calligraphic or pictorial designs; others are essentially small sculptures of people or animals. Like ink stones, paperweights are collectible works of art on their own right.

Desk pads

The desk pad (*huazhan* 畫氈) is a pad made of felt. Some are printed with grids on both sides, so that when it is placed under the translucent paper, it can be used as a guide to ensure correct placement and size of characters. Both desk pads and the printed grids come in a variety of sizes.

Seal

A seal in the context of Chinese calligraphy is a general name for printing stamps and impressions which serve the function of a signature, as a way of acknowledgement or authorship. Chinese seals are usually made of stone, sometimes of metals, wood, bamboo, plastic, or ivory, and are typically used with red ink or cinnabar paste (*zhusha* 朱砂. The character *yin* 印 specifically refers to the imprint created by the seal.

There are three types of seal: The first type is *zhuwen* 朱文 seal (red-character seal) are imprints of the Chinese characters in red ink, sometimes referred to as *yang* seals; the second is *baiwe* 白文 seal (white characters) are imprints with the background in red, leaving white characters, sometimes referred to as *yin* seals; and the third, *zhubaiwen xiangjianyin* 朱白文相間印 seal which is a "red-white characters combined seal" seal, using both the *zhuwen* seal and the *baiwen* seal together.

Calligraphic works are usually completed by the calligrapher applying one or more seals in red ink.

Seal paste

There are two types of seal paste, depending on what base material they are made of. The first type is silk seal paste, which has an oily appearance and is bright red in colour. The second type is plant seal paste, which is not oily but has a spongy appearance. The silk seal paste is bright, vivid, and long-lasting, but dries slower than the plant pastes.

The standard colour for the paste is vermillion red, but in general, dark red is for large-size seals and orange red is for the smaller ones. Other colours, such as green, black, brown, yellow, white, blue, silver, and gold are also used for specific purposes.

The paste is kept under cover in a container after use. It is kept in an environment away from direct sunlight or intense heat to prevent it from drying out.

Techniques of calligraphy

Anyone interested in the techniques of Chinese calligraphy must first learn how to hold the brush properly and grind the ink. Then they need to practice strokes and lines, copy exemplary calligraphy models, such as their master's or reputed calligraphers'. Later, they need to learn to write larger Chinese characters by raising their wrist and elbow. This is the method for writing medium-sized or larger characters. When they have practised calligraphy for years, they should be able to write correct strokes, follow the stroke order, master the character structure, and have balance and rhythm in their calligraphy.

What is most influential other than the basic skills they master is the way they use their brush, ink, and paper. The shape, size, stretch, and type of hair in the brush, the colour and density of the ink, and the absorptive speed and surface texture of the *xuan* paper determine the results of calligraphy. The pressure, inclination, and direction he or she gives to the brush, and the speed, acceleration, and deceleration of the writer's moves and turns all contribute to the success of a calligraphic work.

Evaluation and appreciation of calligraphy

It is true that the evaluation and appreciation of calligraphic work is subjective, depending on individual preferences. There are, nevertheless, some basic rules in evaluating calligraphy, which include the following:

Correctness in writing the characters. Calligraphic works often use variant Chinese characters, but they must be written correctly in the traditional stroke order.

Legibility of the characters. Calligraphic works must be recognizable as script by those familiar with the script style, which may not be legible to those unfamiliar with the script style.

Conciseness of the characters. Good Chinese calligraphy must be unadorned script written in black ink.

Context-suitability of the characters. A calligrapher has to know the meaning of the characters they write to produce good calligraphy.

Aesthetics of the characters. Characters that are written correctly, legibly, concisely, and in the correct context must also be aesthetically pleasing to some degree.

Notable calligraphers through the dynasties

Throughout the history of China, a number of famous calligraphers have emerged to shape the course of development of the art of calligraphy. The following is an introduction to the famous calligraphers by dynasties.

The Qin dynasty

The history of notable calligraphers begins with Li Si 李斯 (c. 280 BCE – 208 BCE), who was a politician of the Qin dynasty. He was the chief architect in systematizing the written Chinese language with the small seal script, which had been in use in the state of Qin, as the imperial standard.

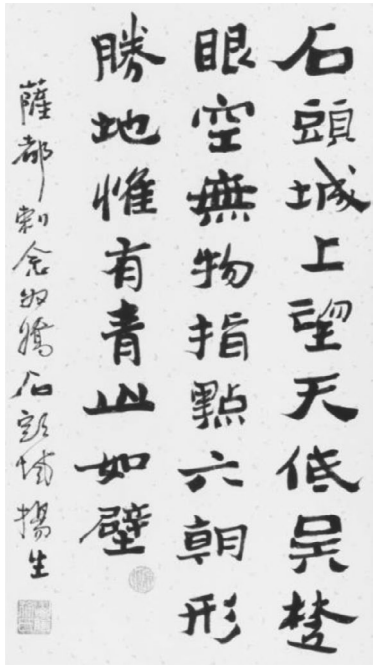

Figure 7.5 A poem by Sa Dula

Source: Professor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

The Han dynasty

By the Eastern Han dynasty, two calligraphers were of note. The first is Cai Yong 蔡邕 (132–192), an official and scholar who wrote a work on the aspects of the traditional seal script. The second is Zhang Zhi 張芝 (?–192), who was a pioneer of the cursive script (*caoshu* 草書) and is known as the "Sage of the cursive script" (*caosheng* 草聖). He is also known as one of the "Four sages in Chinese calligraphy" (*sixian* 四賢).

The Three Kingdoms Period

It was in the period of the Three Kingdoms that the regular script matured into a style of its own. And the person who made this possible was Zhong Yao 鍾繇 (151–230), a government official and the most important calligrapher of this period. A student of Cai Yong, he was talented in calligraphy and made great contributions to the development of the regular script (*kaishu* 楷書). For this, he is revered as the "Father of the regular script" and also as one of the "Four sages in Chinese calligraphy".

The Jin dynasty

The art of calligraphy reached its peak of splendor in the Jin dynasty, with the emergence of four prominent calligraphers, all related to Wang Xizhi 王羲之, the greatest calligrapher in the history of China.

The first calligrapher is Wei Shuo 衞鑠 (272–349), commonly addressed as Lady Wei 衛夫人, who was a calligrapher of the Eastern Jin dynasty and the teacher of Wang Xizhi. A student of Zhong Yao, she established the seven methods of holding the brush (*qishi* 七勢) in the writing of the regular script with her

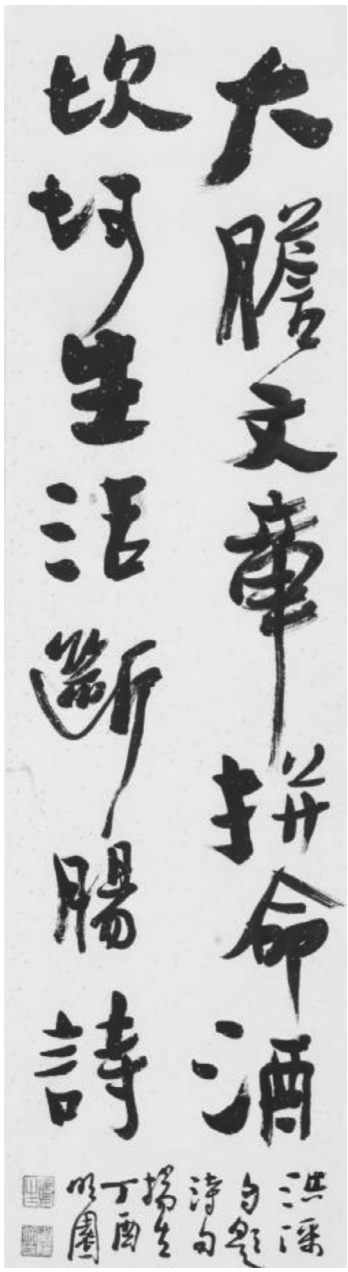

Figure 7.6 Lines by Hong Shen
Source: Professor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

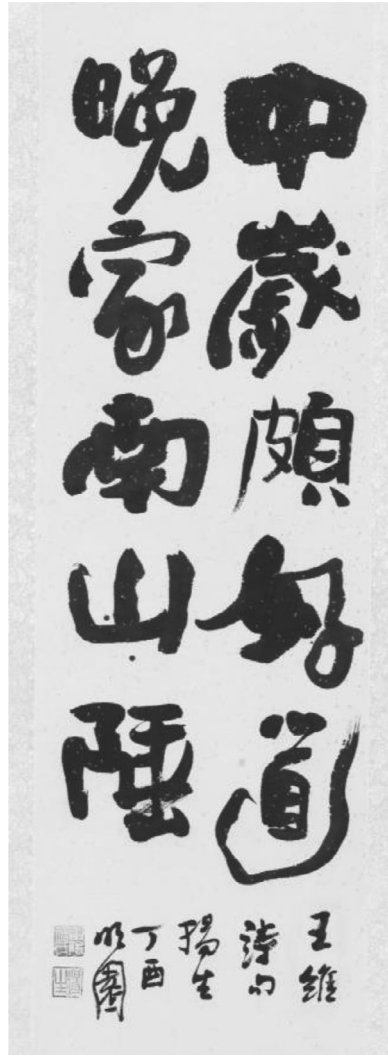

Figure 7.7 Lines by Wang Wei
Source: Professor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

work "A diagram of stroke disposition" (*bizhentu* 〈筆陣圖〉), which was a precursor to the famous "Eight principles of yong" (*yongzi bafa* 永字八法).

The "Eight principles of yong" refers to the order of writing the eight basic strokes: dot, horizontal stroke, turning stroke, vertical stroke, hook stroke, right-upward stroke, left-downward stroke, and right-downward stroke.

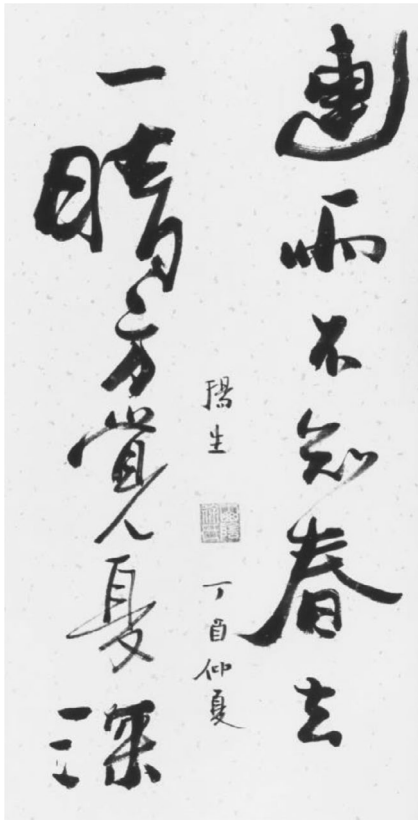

Figure 7.8 Lines by Fan Chengda
Source: Profesor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

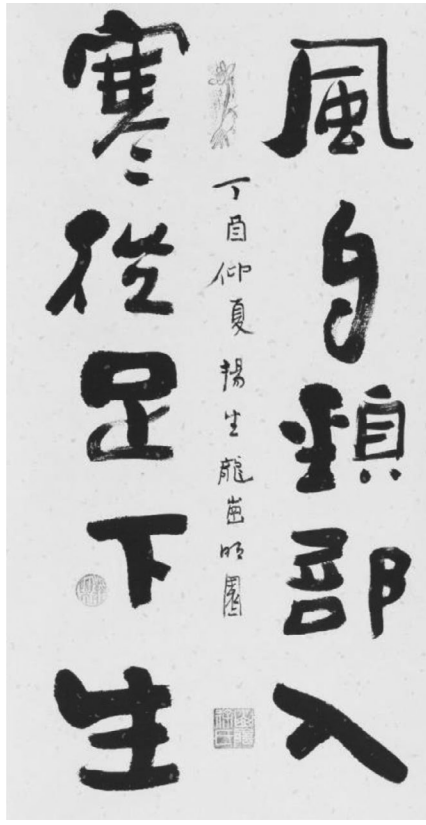

Figure 7.9 A couplet
Source: Profesor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

The second calligrapher is Wang Xizhi 王羲之 (303–361), who was a master of all forms of Chinese calligraphy, one of the "Four sages in calligraphy", and is generally regarded as the greatest Chinese calligrapher in history, and thus he is known as the "Sage of calligraphy" (*shusheng* 書聖). His most noted and famous work is "Preface to the poems composed at the Orchid Pavilion" (*Lantingxu* 〈蘭亭序〉), often referred to as the "premier work in the running script".

The third calligrapher is Wang Xianzhi 王獻之 (344–386), the seventh and youngest son of Wang Xizhi. The father and son were known as the "Two Wangs". He was greatly influenced by the calligraphic style of his father but made his own innovations. He is known for the one-stroke cursive script, blending all characters in the writing in a single stroke. He is crowned as one of the "Four sages in calligraphy".

The fourth calligrapher is Wang Xun 王珣 (349–400), who was a nephew of Wang Xizhi and a cousin of Wang Xianzhi. He was known for a letter he wrote to his friend Boyuan 伯远 (*shu Boyun tie* 〈書伯遠帖〉 ("A letter to Boyuan"), which is regarded as one of the "Three rarities of calligraphy" (*sanxi* 三希).

The Tang dynasty

The Tang dynasty was a period of power and prosperity. In the field of calligraphy, a considerable number of calligraphers emerged, eight of whom are introduced as follows.

Ouyang Xun 歐陽詢 (557–641), an early Tang scholar, was the Imperial Calligrapher who excelled at the writing of the regular script. Of the many steles that he inscribed, the best known is the "Stele in the Jiucheng Palace". He is one of the "Four great calligraphers of the early Tang", along with Yu Shinan, Xue Ji, and Chu Suiliang.

Yu Shinan 虞世南 (558–638), a Confucian scholar who was an Imperial Secretary during the reign of Emperor Taizong, is also one of the four greatest calligraphers in the early Tang dynasty.

Other prominent Tang calligraphers included Chu Suiliang 褚遂良 (596–658), who served as a chancellor during the reigns of the emperors Taizong and Gaozong in the Tang dynasty. He was an accomplished calligrapher of the Tang dynasty. Emperor Taizong of Tang 唐太宗 (598–649), personal name Li Shimin 李世民, also excelled in calligraphy.

Zhang Xu 張旭 (658–747), Chinese calligrapher and poet, was known as one of the "Eight immortals of the wine cup". He is known for his regular script and cursive script writing. He adopted the crazy cursive script style in calligraphy and is named "The sage of cursive script" (*caosheng* 草聖).

Yan Zhenqing 顏眞卿 (709–785) was a leading Chinese calligrapher and a loyal governor of the middle Tang. The period in which Yan lived was a time of daring innovations, typically represented by Yan. His artistic accomplishment in Chinese calligraphy is considered to parallel Wang Xizhi. He specialized in the regular script (*kaishu* 楷書) and running script (*caoshu* 草書), and the style he built up in the regular script, known as "Yan's style of the regular script (*Yanti* 顏體), which emphasized strength, boldness and grandness, brought the art of Chinese calligraphy to a new height.

The development of his personal style can basically be divided into three stages: before age fifty-five, before sixty-five, and before his death at seventy-six. The first stage was the foundation years, in which he learned calligraphy from famous masters Zhang Xu and Chu Suiliang. He also drew inspiration from the Wei steles. His best-known pieces during this period were "Duobao Pagoda Stele" (*duobao tabei* 多寶塔碑) and "Draft of a requiem to my nephew" (*ji ji wengao* 祭姪文稿).

The second stage of the development of his calligraphy, which goes from the end of the first period to age sixty-five, was a period of maturity for Yan, having gained more experience in life. He wielded his brush with more force, muscularity, uprightness, and control, and formed the "Yan style of calligraphy" by blending the seal and regular scripts.

The last stage his calligraphy was the peak of his accomplishment. He consolidated his style and completed his masterpiece "Yan Qingli Stele" (*Yanqinglibei* 顏勤禮碑).

Huaisu 懷素 (737–799), whose personal surname might be Qian 錢, was a Buddhist monk and calligrapher and is famous for his crazy cursive calligraphy (*kuangcao* 狂草). Huaisu is usually paired with Zhang Xu as the two greatest cursive calligraphers of the Tang dynasty, which is reflected by the popular saying: "the crazy Zhang and the drunk Su" (*dian Zhang zui Su* 顛張醉素).

Liu Gongquan 柳公權 (778–865), of the late Tang, is a great Chinese calligrapher. He was a famous regular script writer and is known as one of the four masters of regular script in China, along with Yan Zhenqing, Ouyang Xun and Zhao Mengfu.

The Song dynasty

Six calligraphers of the Song dynasty will be introduced, including the "Four masters of the Song" – Su Shi, Huang Tingjian, Mi Fu, and Cai Xiang.

Cai Xiang 蔡襄 (1012–1067), a scholar, official, and poet, was an excellent calligrapher who excelled in the regular and cursive script writing. His calligraphy was simple, vigorous, and virile. As a result of his calligraphic achievements, he was praised by his contemporary Su Shi 蘇軾 as "the best calligrapher of the generation", and he is one of the "Four masters of calligraphy of the Song dynasty". His most representative work is the "Wan'an Bridge Tablet" (*Wan'an qiaoji* 〈萬安橋記〉), which recorded the completion of the Wan'an Bridge.

Su Shi 蘇軾 (1037–1101), better known by his pen name Dongpo 東坡, was a major poet, ci-poet and calligrapher of the Song dynasty. His had excellent skills in calligraphy and is one of the "Four masters of calligraphy of the Song dynasty". He had a chequered official career, having ups and downs in his official service. His most famous piece of calligraphy, entitled "The cold food observance", was written when he was in exile in Hupei. It was a work to express his loneliness and utmost disappointment with the officialdom.

Huang Tingjian 黃庭堅 (1045–1105), a scholar, government official, and poet of the Song dynasty, is predominantly known as a calligrapher and as one of the "Four masters of calligraphy of the Song dynasty". He was a master in the semi-cursive script (*xingshu* 行書), generating a style of his own. He is best-known for his creativity in calligraphy, inventing the technique of "flying white" (*feibai* 飛白), as illustrated in his calligraphic piece entitled "Biographies of Lian Po and Lin Xiangru" (*Lian Po Lin Xiangru zhuanjuan* 廉頗藺相如傳卷).

Mi Fu 米芾 (1051–1107) was a painter, poet, and calligrapher of the Song dynasty. His style of calligraphy was greatly influenced by Wang Xizhi. He had an eccentric personality and his lunatic behaviour earned him the nickname of *Mi* dian, or "the lunatic Mi". He later developed his unique traits known as the "Mi Fu" style. He is regarded as one of the "Four masters of calligraphy of the Song dynasty".

Emperor Huizong of Song 宋徽宗 (1082–1135), personal name Zhao Ji 趙佶, was the eighth emperor of the Song dynasty, who was cowardly and fatuous but talented in calligraphy. In the world of calligraphy, Emperor Huizong was known for his invention of the "Slender gold style" (*soujinti* 瘦金體) style of calligraphy. "Slender Gold" refers to the style of the emperor's calligraphy which resembled gold filament. The "slender gold" calligraphy has been compared to "floating orchid leaves," "bamboo moving in the wind," or "the legs of dancing cranes", which are manifestations of an inner grace and tenderness.

The Yuan dynasty

Two calligraphers of the Yuan dynasty, Zhao Mengfu and Ni Zan will be introduced.

Zhao Mengfu 趙孟頫 (1254–1322), courtesy name Zi'ang 子, was a descendant of the Song dynasty's imperial family, and a Chinese scholar, painter and calligrapher during the Yuan dynasty.

In calligraphy, Zhao Mengfu did not follow the gentle brushwork of the Yuan dynasty but turned to the cruder style of the Jin and Tang calligraphers. When he was young, he studied Emperor Gaozong's style, but became more interested in following the calligraphic styles of Wang Xizhi and Wang Xianzhi. His writing of the regular script is considered one of the top four in the Chinese history, alongside with the three regular script masters: Yan Zhenqing, Liu Gongquan, and Ouyang Xun.

Ni Zan 倪瓚 (1301–1374) was a Chinese painter during the early Ming period. Along with Huang Gongwang, Wu Zhen, and Wang Meng, he is considered to be one of the Four Masters of the Yuan dynasty. His style of calligraphy has a painterly quality that is uniquely unsurpassable.

The Ming dynasty

Five prominent calligraphers of the Ming dynasty have been selected to illustrate the calligraphic achievements of the period. They include Tang Yin, Wen Zhengming, Dong Qichang, Huang Ruheng, and Wang Duo.

Tang Yin 唐寅 (1470–1524), courtesy name Tang Bohu 唐伯虎, was a Chinese scholar, painter, calligrapher, and poet of the Ming dynasty period whose life story has become a part of popular lore. Even though he was born during the Ming dynasty, many of his paintings, especially those of people, were illustrated with elements from pre-Tang to Song dynasty art.

Tang Yin perfected an admirable hand in semi-cursive script (also known as running script).

Wen Zhengming 文徵明 (1470–1559) was a versatile scholar of the Ming dynasty. He was talented in painting and was one of the "Four Masters of Ming painting" (*Ming sijia* 明四家). He was skilled in poetry and other literary pursuits and was one of the "Four literary masters of Jiangnan" (*Jiangnan sida caizi* 江南四大才子). In calligraphy, he is regarded as a great master of the regular and semi-cursive scripts. His calligraphic techniques were greatly influenced by Huang Tingjian.

Dong Qichang 董其昌 (1555–1636) was a famous scholar who excelled in both painting and calligraphy.

In calligraphy, he first patterned after Zhao Mengfu and Wen Zhengming, but eventually found the masters of the Jin and Tang dynasties more appealing. His calligraphy placed emphasis on the spirit of the work rather than its outward appearance, showing a high degree of simplicity, purity, and smoothness.

Huang Ruheng 黃汝亨 (1558–1626), courtesy name Zhenfu 貞父, was a noted Chinese calligrapher of the late Ming dynasty. He studied Su Shi and Mi Fei and combined the style of the two in his calligraphy. His best-known work in calligraphy was the reproduction of the painting-calligraphy album *Paintings of Tang Period Poems* (*Tangshi huapu*《唐詩畫譜》).

Wang Duo 王鐸 (1592–1652) was a Chinese calligrapher, painter, and poet in the Ming dynasty. Wang's calligraphy followed the style of Yan Zhenqing and Mi Fei, writing with refined strokes and perfect composition. He was one of the three greatest calligraphers of the late Ming, along with Huang Daozhou 黃道周 and Ni Yuanlu 倪元璐.

The Qing dynasty

Like all other dynasties, the Qing dynasty witnessed the emergence of a number of calligraphers of considerable standing. Due to space limitations, Zheng Xie is cited as an example to illustrate, in a small way, the level of achievement in calligraphy in this period.

Zheng Xie 鄭燮 (1693–1765), better known by his pen name Banqiao 板橋, was a Chinese painter from Jiangsu. Through the civil service examination, he became a magistrate at Shandong, but resigned after twelve years in service due to his disappointment with officialdom. He felt freedom and liberty in retirement and expressed himself in art, becoming one of the "Eight eccentrics of Yangzhou" (*Yangzhou baguai* 揚州八怪). He was noted for his drawing of orchids, bamboo, and stones. At fifty-five, he served for a short period as Emperor Qianlong's "official calligrapher and painter".

As a calligrapher, Zheng was famous for creating a style that is closely related to his drawing of orchids for more than fifty years.

Figure 7.10 "Unaffected by favour or insult"

Source: Professor Xu Yangsheng's calligraphy

Conclusion

Calligraphy has been an important part of Chinese culture and life. Calligraphy is seen everywhere in China. It has been compared to music with the dots and strokes moving with musical rhythms to express the emotions of the calligrapher. It has been compared to dancing as the neat movements of the brush on the xuan paper are like dancers on the stage. It has been compared to painting as the cursive strokes in calligraphy are like artistic lines and dots in a painting. Calligraphy, in short, is the quintessence of art in China.

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8
CANTONESE CULTURE

Chan Sin-wai

Introduction

This chapter explores the Cantonese culture through its dialect, mainly through its folk sayings. Cantonese dialect, to begin with, has to be studied from the perspective of the Chinese language. Chinese, or to be more exact Putonghua in its colloquial form, is a language spoken by about one fifth of the world's population as China is a vast country with a huge population. According to statistics, the number of Chinese language speakers exceeds 1.4 billion, which includes 50 million people who have Chinese as their second language. The case of English is more or less the same. Though the number of native speakers of English is much smaller than that of Chinese, English is ranked second in the world of languages in terms of speakers, totaling around 700 million in 2017. As for Cantonese, it is the major dialect in the southern part of China, with around 59 million speakers in 2017. Though Cantonese, by virtue of its designation, is the speech of Canton – present-day Guangzhou – its usage goes far beyond a city of Guangdong province. Cantonese nowadays generally refers to a dialect that is commonly used in Guangzhou, Hong Kong, Macao, and Cantonese-speaking communities in other parts of the world, such as Malaysia and Singapore in southeast Asia, Toronto and Vancouver in Canada, London in the United Kingdom, and New York and San Francisco in the United States.

Cantonese culture

Cantonese culture, as is the case with many other cultures, is best shown in the folk sayings, which reflect to a great extent the life philosophy of the Cantonese people. Cantonese folk sayings (熟語) include three major three types: idioms 成語, common sayings 俗語, and end-clippers 歇後語.

Idioms

According to *Webster's Third New International Dictionary of the English Language*, there are several definitions of "idiom" the understanding of which can help the work of translation:

1a the language proper or peculiar to a people or to a district, community or class;
b the syntactica, grammatical, or structural form peculiar to a language: the genius, habit, or cast of a language;

2 an expression established in the usage of a language that is peculiar to itself either in the grammatical construction or in having a meaning that cannot be derived as a whole from the conjoined meanings of its elements.
3 a style or form of artistic expression that is characteristic esp. of an individual, a period or movement, or a medium or instrument.

Cantonese idioms are usually four-character expressions whose meanings are more than the sum of the parts. The four-character idioms can be parsed into two groups of two. They are conventional and fixed and usually have hidden meanings between the lines. The major sources of idioms are allusions, literary quotations, and folk sayings.

Common sayings

Cantonese common sayings, which have no set length or form, also include proverbs 諺語, which in general have five or seven characters, and slang 俚語, which is a type of colloquial speech with dialectical characteristics, colloquialisms 口語, and wisecracks 俏皮語. Common sayings are usually complete sentences which express a kind of attitude one takes toward life, loss, love, etc., or the mentality of a person expressed in an old or metaphorical saying, such as

做一日和尚撞一日鐘
So long as I remain a bonze, I go on tolling the bell.

老虎頭上撲蒼蠅
Only fools will catch flies on a tiger's head.

End-clippers (Xie hou yu)

End-clippers, or *xie hou yu* in Putonghua, are metaphorical folk sayings, the first part of which will lead logically or phonetically to the meaning expressed in the second part. End-clippers are used to convey intended meanings in a vivid, jovial, or satirical way.

內包子打狗 – 有去無回
Pelting a dog with meat dumplings – one gone, never to return.

狗咬呂洞賓 – 不識好歹
Like the dog that bit Lu Dongbin – you bite the hand that feeds that.

Sources of Cantonese sayings

Cantonese sayings come from a number of sources, which include historical stories, such as 事後孔明 (be wise after an event); fables, such as 姜太公封神 – 漏咗自己 (leave out oneself); symmetrical structures, such as ABCD 甜酸苦辣 (all the sweet and bitter experiences of life) and 酒色財氣 (wine, sex, money, and power) and ACBD 七零八落 (in disorder); partially symmetrical structures, such as AABB 凹凹凸凸 (bumpy; full of bumps and holes; full of lumps; lumpy; rough; scraggy, uneven) and 混混噩噩 (ignorant; muddle-headed; without a clear aim), or such as AABC 官官相衛 (devils help devils) and ABCC 官仔骨骨 (well dressed); antithetical structures, such as 三長兩短 (die; unexpected misfortune that results in death) and 三衰六旺 (ups and downs of life); alliteration, such as 玲 (*ling*) 瓏 (*lung*) 浮突 (exquisitely carved);

assonance, such as 冇厘搭 (*daap*) 霎(*saap*); juxtaposition of synonyms, such as 知書識墨 (educated and polite person); juxtaposition of antonyms, such as 山高水低 (unexpected misfortune); similes, such as 穩如鐵塔 (as firm as it is founded on the rock); and quotable quotes, such as 天網恢恢, 疏而不漏 (justice has long arms).

Cantonese culture reflected by folk sayings

Cantonese culture is studied through folk sayings from two major perspectives: topics relating to the body and topics unrelated to the body.

Body: whole

There are many idioms that are related to the human body. In this section, idioms will be grouped according to the whole and the parts. The whole refers to the entire body, including ability, action, age, appearance, manners, movement, personality, and abilities, whereas the parts would be discussed in a top-down fashion from head to toe, or to be more exact, from hair to nail.

Ability

Ability is highly prized in Cantonese culture. A capable person is described as one who has 三頭六臂 (extraordinarily able person; very capable person). For people with comparable abilities, they are 半斤八兩 (as broad as it is long; as long as it is broad; fifty-fifty; half a pound of one and eight ounces of the other; much of a muchness; not much to choose between the two; nothing to choose between the two; six of one and half a dozen of the other; tweedledum and tweedledee; well-match in ability), or 你有半斤, 我有八兩 (six of one and half a dozen of the other). For people who have different kinds of ability to show off, they are described with the words 八仙過海 – 各顯神通 (each displays his ability; each has his merits; try to outshine each other; vie with each other). Those who are capable become leaders as 蛇無頭不行 (without a man in the lead, all the others move no farther) and it is also true that everyone vies to be leaders (行船爭解纜 take the lead) and the existence of more than one leader is not a desirable situation (一山不能藏二虎 at daggers drawn).

But there are also people who are not so capable and are known as 空心老倌 (a person without real ability and learning; gorgeous in appearance but inwardly insubstantial). They lack the ability to do anything (有心無力 be unable to do what one wants to do) or defend themselves (有招架之功, 無還手之力 can only ward off blows) as they do not have any special skills (周身刀冇張利 jack-of-all-trades, master of none).

Achievement

Achievers are always admired. People respect those who achieve through hardwork (白手興家 achieve success in life with one's own hands; start from scratch). They believe that if one works hard, one can be outstanding in any trade (行行出狀元), or they would become 高不成, 低不就 (neither fit for a higher position nor willing to take a lower one). Achievers respect achievers (英雄重英雄 like knows like), and offspring of achievers are equally outstanding (虎父無犬子 like father, like son).

Action

Action can be slow or quick, proper or improper, decisive or indecisive. If action is preemptive, then it is said to be 先下手為強 (catch the ball before the bounce), 先斬後奏 (act before reporting), or 先禮後兵

(a dog often barks before it bites). Some believe that perhaps it would be best not to 打草驚蛇 (wake a sleeping dog).

Things could be done quickly as it is believed that 執輸行頭, 慘過敗家 (it would be disadvantageous not to take an immediate action in time). There are idioms that describe hurried actions, such as 一扑一碌 (in a great hurry), 三扒二撥 (hurry through; in no time at all), 左騰右騰 (rushing about), 鈴鈴霖霖 (in a big hurry), 滾水淥腳 (go quickly; hurry off), 趕頭趕命 (in a great hurry), 頻頻倫倫 (in great hurry), 臨急臨忙 (in a great rush), 臨時臨急 (at the last moment; be hard pressed for time), 騰上騰落 (rush around), 頻倫唔得入城 (more haste, less speed), and 裙拉褲甩 (in a great hurry).

Thing could be done slowly (他他條條go easy; 咪咪嚟嚟 very slow and clumsy; 咪嚟咪嚟 very slow and clumsy; 姿姿整整 dally; dawdle; move slowly), instantly (打鐵趁熱 strike the iron while it is hot), promptly (撇撇脫脫 prompt in action), decisively (快刀斬亂麻 take decisive action). But actions may also be done recklessly like 冇頭烏蠅 (亂碰亂闖 act helter-skelter) or 盲頭烏蠅 (act in a chaotic manner), or 橫衝直撞 (collide in every direction), and stealthily (偷偷摸摸 act stealthily).

There are a number of expressions on clumsiness in action 論論盡盡 (very clumsy), usually with the metaphor of hands and feet, such as 笨手笨腳 (stumblebum), 粗手粗腳 (have clumsy fingers), 雞手鴨腳 (clumsy; have two left feet), 姐手姐腳 (clumsy because she is not accustomed in doing heavy work), and 陀手能腳 (clumsy).

Action in a negative form could result in fighting (五行欠打 deserve giving a beating; 五行欠炳 deserve giving a scold). Internecine fighting is described as 狗咬狗骨 (fighting among members of the same group; put up an internecine fight). Fighting is sometimes provoked (撩是鬥非 provoke a fight; stir up a quarrel; sow the seeds of discord). When there is fighting, the one who is beaten could be in a very bad shape, so much so that one could be 打到亞媽都唔認得 (get badly beaten up) or 打到豬頭咁 (be beaten severely). And there is a funny saying that comes out probably from the boxing circle: 後備拳師 – 聽打 (somebody who is waiting to be beaten by others).

Advantage/disadvantage

Advantages and disadvantage, or pros or cons, are of concern to people. There are naturally advantages and disadvantages, 有一利必有一害 (no rose without a thorn). One can gain an initial advantage (飲頭啖湯 gain the initial advantage), which should not be accompanied by a disadvantage (食砒霜土狗 at disadvantage before gaining an advantage). Or one can be at a disadvantage accompanied by an advantage (除笨有精 problems apart, there are still advantages to a particular activity).

It is thought that advantages can be obtained through a person, which is known as 借艇割禾 (make use of somebody to profit oneself). Proximity, however, is not the best guarantee of getting an advantage, which is expressed by the idiom 蛋家雞 – 見水唔飲得 (the person who fails to obtain an advantage in spite of being in a favourable position), and 幡竿燈籠 – 照遠唔照近 (丈八燈台 – 照遠不照近 benefit any other person than close ones).

Advice

People need advice from time to time. There are people who offer good advice (循循善導 good at giving methodical and patient guidance; lead one gradually into good practices; teach with skill and patience; lead somebody gradually and patiently on the right path). The elderly, with their rich experience, could also give good advice to people, which explains why there is an idiom 家有一老, 如有一寶 (an old-timer in the family is an advisor of rich experience). Good advice could be offered in a sincere way (苦口婆心 exhort somebody repeatedly with good intentions; words importunate but heart compassionate) and it could bring good results (一言驚醒夢中人 a person suddenly becomes clear-minded upon listening to a word of wisdom; give a wise word to a fool).

There are also people whose advice is not acceptable and they are known as 紅鬚軍師 (misadvisor; thoughtless advisor) and 蠶蟲師爺 (a person who always offers bad solutions to problems; a person who is caught in his own trap).

The decision to take or not to take advice from others rests with the recipients. When they do not take others' advice, it is 借吃聾陳隻耳 (turn a deaf ear to somebody) or 亞聾送殯 – 唔聽枝死人笛 (turn a deaf ear to somebody).

Age

It is noted that idioms on age have a lot to do with old age and little to do youth. Of all the six idioms on age, all are on the elderly people, which include 七老八十 (aged; elderly; in one's seventies or eighties; live to a great age; old), 恃老賣老 (act like a Dutch uncle; flaunt one's seniority) or alternatively 倚老賣老 (act like a Dutch uncle; flaunt one's seniority), 寧欺白鬚公, 莫欺鼻涕蟲 (a colt may make a good horse), 老人成嫩仔 (once a man and twice a child), and 人老心不老 (young in spirit for one's old age).

What deserves mentioning is that some elderly people attempt to learn new skills at an old age (臨老學吹打 an old dog begins to learn new tricks; an old man learning a new skill) without any concern to success or failure.

Appearance

Appearance refers to the way a person looks to other people. It could refer to the build of a person. A tall person is described as 牛高馬大 (stand like a giant; tall and big; well-grown), 神高神大 (well-built), or 肥屍大隻 (strongly-built man); a short person, 矮矮細細 (short and small); a strong person, 銅皮鐵骨 (iron constitution; brass muscles and iron bones; strong and solid body; tough and strong as iron and steel; with vigorous sins and bones and strengthened muscles); a fat person, 肥肥白白 (fair and plump) and 腰圓背厚 (plump), a skinny person, 奀挑鬼命 (extremely skinny and frail), 膊頭高過耳 (skinny person), 膝頭大過髀 (very skinny); and a woman with a good figure, 玲瓏浮突 (exquisitely carved).

Appearance also refers to how one looks. People who look alike are 一模一樣 (be exactly alike). People with devilish looks are 兇神惡煞 (fiendish and devilish; look furious). People who look miserable are 苦口苦面 (look miserable), or 苦瓜乾咁口+既面口 (a face of woe; a face shaded with melancholy; down in the dumps; down in the mouth; draw a long face; gloomy face; have a face as along as a fiddle; have a face like a fiddle; have a worried look; look blue; make a long face; pull a long face; put on a long face; wear a glum countenance; with a long face). People who look vulgar are 眉低額窄, 冇厘貴格 (person with low eyebrows and a narrow forehead looks vulgar). People who look out of sorts are 冇厘神氣 (looking out of sorts). People who look stealthy are 賊眉賊眼 (look like a thief).

There are also people who have impressive looks (係威係勢 look impressive; 大模厮樣 haughty) or affected looks (裝模作樣 pretend to be a know-it-all). What appears to be imposing may not be equally so inside, just like 繡花枕頭 (beautiful in appearance but lacking inner talents), 屎坑關刀 – 聞唔聞得, 武唔武得 (imposing looks but useless), or 屎氹關刀 – 又唔文(聞)得又唔武(舞)得 (imposing looks but useless). Some people are more concerned about looks than health (愛靚唔愛命 be more concerned about looking good than being healthy).

In Chinese society, much importance is attached to dressing up oneself to look impressive as people tend to focus on what one wears (先敬羅衣後敬人 people usually open doors to fine clothes), which explains the saying 人要衣裝, 佛要金裝 (fine feathers make fine birds; the tailor makes the man).

People who are dressed up are described as 身光頸靚 (dressed up and look sharp) and 官仔骨骨 (well dressed). When one wears shabby clothes, then one is 爛身爛世 (wear shabby clothes) and 賣花姑娘插竹葉 (a tailor makes the man but he clothes himself in rags). A dress does not always make the person, for there is a saying 着起龍袍唔似太子 (a beggar in a dress-suit still looks like a beggar).

Sometimes, a dressed-up person may not have anywhere to go (喺門角落頭燒炮仗 all dressed up and nowhere to go).

Behaviour

Behaviour is the way we act. When we act in a good way, it is good behaviour. When we act in a bad way, it is bad behaviour. We will classify Cantonese idioms into idioms on good behaviour and those on bad behaviour.

GOOD BEHAVIOUR

Idioms on good behaviour are few and far between.

(1) Behaviour by example Sometimes we act by following what others do (有樣學樣 follow a bad example; 入鄉隨俗, 出水隨灣 do in Rome as the Romans do), or what others own (年晚煎堆 – 人有我有 possess oneself of the same as others do). But what should be avoided is to follow a bad example (上樑唔正下樑歪 (those below will follow the bad example set by those above).

(2) Help It is always commendable to look after one's own business without seeking help from others (求人不如求己 applying to others for help is not as good as applying to oneself; ask another for help is not as good as to help oneself; better depend on oneself than ask for help from others; better do it than wish it done; better do it yourself than ask help from others; better to seek help from oneself than from somebody else; God helps those who help themselves; it is better to aid oneself than to depend on the aid of others; it is better to ask of one's own folk than of outsiders; near is my shirt, but nearer is my skin; relying on oneself is better than relying on others; self-help is better than help from others; the best answer is to roll up your sleeves and do the job yourself; turn one's own hand to do one's own business; 馬死落地行 have to get oneself through a difficulty without help). When offering help to others, sometimes we help them by 睇頭睇尾 (lending a hand), and we should 為人為到底 (when one helps others, help them to the end). What is to be avoided is to seek help in extreme urgency (臨急抱佛腳 seek help at the last moment; 急時抱佛腳 seek help at the last moment).

(3) Propriety We say one's behaviour is good when action is done in a proper way (有分有寸 know what to do; 行得正, 企得正 act in a totally proper manner; play fair and square; 安份守己 abide by laws and behave oneself well).

BAD BEHAVIOUR

Bad behaviour is abundant and is listed in alphabetical order for discussion.

(1) Bullying Forcing somebody to do something or the strong frightening the weak is bullying. Cantonese society, as with all other societies, is full of bullies, whose behaviour is described by idioms such as 恃勢欺人 (abuse one's power and bully the people; bully others because one has power; bully people on the strength of one's powerful connections; bully the weak on one's power; make use of one's position to bully others; pull one's rank on others; rely on somebody else's power to bully people; take advantage of one's own power to bully people; take one's position to lord it over and insult people; throw one's weight about; trust to one's power and insult people), 欺善怕惡 (bully the good people, fear the evil ones), 蝦蝦霸霸 (bully; bully and humiliate), 橫行霸道 (play the bully), and 聲大夾惡 (come the bully over somebody). Even strong people from other places will be bullied by the local people, as expressed by the idioms 龍游

淺水遭蝦戲 (no man is a hero to his valet) and 虎落平陽被犬欺 (out of one's sphere of influence, out of one's power).

(2) Cheating Deceiving people is bad behaviour. People who cheat others by 呃呃騙騙 (deceive; cheat), 呃神騙鬼(lure somebody into a trap), 招搖撞騙 (put on a good bluff), 偷呃拐騙 (steal, cheat, kidnap, and swindle), always relying on cheating to make a living (一味靠滾 always rely on cheating). Their tactics include 隻手遮天 (hide the truth from the masses; hoodwink the public; pull the wool over the eye of the public) and 掛羊頭賣狗肉 (hang out a sheep's head when what one is selling is dog's meat; hanging up a sheep's head and selling dog meat; he cries wine, and sells vinegar; offer chaff for grain; sell a pig in a poke; sell dog meat as mutton; sell dog meat under the label of a sheep's head; sell horsemeat as beefsteak; swindle others by making false claims). People who have been cheated have the feeling of being taken in by swindlers (畀人賣豬仔 be cheated and taken advantage of by others, 言+采鬼食豆腐 cheat somebody into the belief), but the fact is cheating can never last long as the truth will be revealed in time (風水佬呃你十年八年, 唔呃得一世 time can witness to a fact).

People who cheat will pick those who could be easily deceived, such as friends (黃皮樹鶏哥 – 唔熟唔食 the person who swindles money out of his familiar friends; 黃皮樹鶏哥 – 熟嗰個食嗰個 the person who swindles money out of his familiar friends) and the ignorant (低頭切肉, 把眼看人 choose a pigeon to cheat). What is most interesting is that sometimes swindlers swindle swindlers and they gain nothing from their cheating tactics (光棍遇着冇皮柴 a swindler takes in a swindler, 銅銀買病豬 – 大家偷歡喜 each of the two hugs himself on having cheated the other).

(3) Gambling Cantonese people, and the Chinese people on the whole, like gambling despite the fact it is considered a bad thing. One might 盡地一煲 (risk everything on one bet) and believe that it would be 有殺冇賠 (net profits without any loss). But in gambling, it is always 十賭九輸 (nine out of ten cases lose in gambling), like what is said in an end-clipper 秀才手巾 – 包書(輸) (stand to lose).

This is also the case with playing mahjong, a popular form of gambling for Cantonese people. It is said that 食頭糊, 輸甩褲 (first game winner in player mahjong will be the biggest loser in the end) and 衰家食尾糊 (the unlucky mahjong player wins the last game).

(4) Laziness Another behaviour which is considered bad is laziness. Idioms related to laziness are numerous, such as 死蛇爛蟮 ((1) too lazy to stir a finger; (2) lazy person), 懶到出汁 (be extremely lazy), 懶懶散散 (languid; lethargic; listless), 懶人多屎尿 (a lazybone cooks up many lame excuses), 眼眉毛長過辮 (not to stir a finger; very lazy), 好食懶飛 (eat but do nothing; eat one's head off; lazy), and the end-clipper 四方木 – 踢一踢, 郁一郁 (a wooden man never moves without a rush on it; lazybone).

(5) Lust Lust is strong sexual desire, often unrelated to love. Lustful men 滾紅滾綠 (lecherous), grope women (摸身摸勢 grope a woman) and show their lustful manner (飛擒大咬 show one's lustful manner). Lustful women are 姣到出汁 (appear to be highly sexually aroused), 姣屍扽篤 (coquette in a lustful manner), and 發姣發薹 (flirtatious; man-crazy).

Another aspect of lust is womanizing. Those who womanize are known as 花心大少 (playboy), 花心蘿蔔 (playboy), or 花花公子 (dandy; playboy).

Yet another aspect of lust is sexual attraction (神魂顛倒 be out of one's head; 暈晒大浪 fall under somebody's spell; 放路溪錢 – 引死人 very attractive).

(6) Obstructive behaviour There are people who act to obstruct others from achieving their goals. Their behaviour is 刁橋扭擰 (deliberately create obstructions for somebody), 阻頭阻勢 (decline with all sorts of excuses; fob somebody off with excuses; get in the way; give the runaround; make excuses and put obstacles in the way), or 阻手阻腳 (a hindrance to somebody; a nuisance to somebody; an encumbrance to

somebody; cumbersome; cumbrous; get in the way of somebody; hinder; impede; in the way; obstructive; one too many; stand in somebody's way; stand in the way of). People may even occupy a position just to stop others from getting it (生人霸死地 block the path of others).

(7) Pretence Pretence is to put on a false appearance in order to deceive people or as a game. There is no lack of idioms on pretence, such as 詐詐帝帝 (feign; pretend), 詐傻扮懵 (act stupid; play the fool), 裝傻扮懵 (play the fool), 賊喊捉賊 (a thief crying "stop the thief"), 整古做怪 (wrap something in mystery), 整色整水 (put on a show; put on an act), 扮豬食老虎 (feign ignorance; play the fool; pretend to be a fool but to be actually very clever;), 貓哭老鼠 – 假慈悲 (shed crocodile tears), 豉油撈飯 – 整色整水 (put on a show; put on an act).

(8) Stealing Stealing, which is to take or get without permission, is bad behaviour. Stealing may be done secretly, as in 順手牽羊 (go on the scamp; make away with something), or become a habit hard to kick off, as expressed by the idiom 細時偷針, 大時偷牛 (young pilferer, old robber). Cantonese have idioms about stealthy behaviour, such as 鬼鬼鼠鼠 (furtive; sneaky; stealthy). We should, however, note that 若要人不知, 除非己莫為 (there are eyes even in the dark; what is done by night will appear by day).

Character

The character of a person is determined by birth (三歲定八十 the child is father to the man), unless there is a change of character due to some reasons (亞崩養狗 – 轉性 have a change of nature). Otherwise, there is no way to change a person's character (死性不改as stubborn as a mule; not change for the better). And there is a saying that when one becomes rich, one should start to cultivate one's character (發財立品 cultivate one's character when one becomes rich).

There are several traits in one's character which are considered to be good, including forgivenness, good temper, honesty, integrity, patience, and straightforwardness. People who are forgiving are generous (大人有大量 an important person is forgiving). People who are good-tempered can easily get along with people (隔夜油炸鬼 good-tempered person). Honest people are those who remain honest in whatever situation they are in (擔屎都唔偷食 very honest), but they might end up in poverty (忠忠直直, 終須乞食 an honest person will end up begging for livelihood). People with integrity could stand severe tests (真金不怕洪爐火, 石獅不怕雨滂沱 a person of integrity can stand severe tests). Patient people are praiseworthy (百忍成金patience is a plaster for all sores). People who are straightforward do not mince their words (該釘就釘, 該鐵就鐵 call a spade a spade). What is so special about people with good character is that they remain composed in spite of what happens (修游淡定 calm and composed; 脂油淡定 calm; 滋油淡定 calm; not panic; slow coach; 滋滋油油 unhurriedly; and 定過抬油 be completely composed; have full confidence in; have the game in one's hands).

People with bad character, on the other hand, refers to those who are cowardly (縮頭烏龜 coward), ferocious (惡死能登 ferocious; harsh; vicious; 狼過華秀隻狗 very ferocious), hot-tempered (炮仗頸 – 一點就着 hot-tempered), immoral (唔三唔四 immoral in character; neither fish, flesh nor fowl), stubborn (死牛一便頸 stick to one's guns; stubborn; 死雞撐飯蓋 shabby-genteel), and unreliable (生蟲拐杖 – 靠唔住a rail made of rotten rushes – a broken reed; unrealiable)

Death

Human beings know that life will come to an end when death knocks at the door. Since some Cantonese people still regard death as taboo, a number of end-clippers have been used to make indirect references to death, which explains why death idioms are somewhat different from other idioms.

The Cantonese dialect has idioms expressing the idea of death as being the end of a life journey, such as 大限難逃 (meet one's fat; pay one's debt to nature) and生死有定 (every bullet has its billet), 三長兩短 (unexpected misfortune that results in death), and 賣鹹鴨蛋 (die; pass away). People may die one following another, which is like 豬欄報數 – 又一隻one more has died, or a long time ago (骨頭打鼓 died a long time ago), but no one can 死過番生 (be saved from death; be snatched from the jaws of death; close call; close shave; escape by a hairbreadth; escape by the skin of one's teeth; escape death by a narrow margin; escape with one's bare life; hairbreadth escape; have a close bout with death; miss death by a hair's breadth; narrow escape from death; narrow shave; near thing), saving the ritual of 擔旛買水 (carry the hearse and escort a funeral).

For people who are about to die, they are described as 聞見棺材香 (at the death's door; have one's foot in the grave), 條命凍過水 (be in danger), 劏豬樣 – 上嘅就死 (a fat pig going to the butchery – sure to die), and 浮頭魚 – 死梗 (taking poison and hanging oneself – sure to die), 老虎頭上釘蝨乸 – 自尋死路 (bread the lion in his den; defy the mighty; offend the powerful people; provoke a powerful person; provoke somebody far superior in power), 雞春砍石頭 (like an egg dashing itself against a rock – courting destruction), and 獵狗終須山上喪 (he who plays with fire will get burned at last).

There are also situations in which people court death, such as 激死老豆搵山拜 (unfilial son who infuriates his father to death is only looking for a tomb to sweep), 壽星公吊頸 – 嫌命長 (tempt one's fate), 閻羅王探病 – 問你死未 (drive somebody to his death; like the King of Hell dispatching invitation cards), 棺材舖拜神 – 想人死啫嘛 (gritting one's teeth in a coffin shop – laying a curse upon all who are not dying), 水浸眼眉 – 唔知死 (a tortoise eating croton-oil seeds – unaware of the death ahead), and 老鼠拉魚+廉魚 – 一命搏一命 (risking life in eating puffer fish).

People can end their lives in different ways, such as 攬住一齊死 (end in common ruin), 送羊入虎口 (a lamb to the slaughter; put somebody to death), and 借刀殺人 (murder with a borrowed knife), 食咗人隻車 (take the wind out of somebody's sails), and 橫死掂死 (it doesn't make any difference either way). People may die in discontent, such as 死唔眼閉 (die discontent; die dissatisfied; die with an everlasting regret; die with injustice unredressed; die without closing one's eyes; turn in one's grave), 剝皮田雞 – 死都唔閉眼 (die without closing one's eyes). But surely death would expiate their crimes, if any (死有餘辜 death would not expiate all one's crimes).

Education

Education in China and likewise in Guangdong has been based on Confucian teachings. People are trained to be educated and polite (知書識墨 educated and polite person), and it is believed that education would be instrumental in changing one's destiny (一命二運三風水, 四積陰功五讀書 education can change one's destiny).

Education must start young, like 初歸心抱, 落地孩兒 (bend a tree while it is still young), and there are people who simply could not be changed through education (爛泥扶唔上壁 people of bad character will not be able to change). Home education is also important, otherwise it would become 有爺生無嫲教 (have parents but have no parental guidance; lack home education). Lastly, no matter how educated one is, one should never 喺孔夫子面前賣文章 (teach one's grandmother how to suck eggs).

Efforts

People make enormous efforts to get what they want (出盡八寶 have exerted one's utmost skill). Sometimes, one needs to make very little effort (慳水慳力 shoddy) to achieve one's goal, as easy as turning over one's hand (易過借火 as easy as ABC; as easy as child's play; as easy as damn it; as easy as falling off a log; as easy as pie; as easy as turning one's palm over; as easy as turning over one's hand;

as easy as winking). At other times, much effort is needed, like 拉牛上樹 (a vain attempt to do something), 拉拉扯扯 (prevaricate), 沫水舂牆 (go through fire and water), and 二叔婆養豬 – 夠晒好心機 (sitting on a pit to count sesame seeds – it requires meticulous work). With such efforts, we can 鐵杵磨成針 (little strokes fell great oaks) and 燈芯擰成鐵 (a straw shows its weight when it is carried a long way).

If anything goes wrong, sometimes it would be impossible to make changes (船到江心補漏遲 it is too late to mend) and all our efforts will be lost (前功盡廢 all efforts go down the drain; all former achievements are nullified; all labour's lost; all one's earlier achievements are in vain; all one's labour is thrown away; all one's merits count for nothing; all one's previous efforts are wasted; all one's work is wasted; back where one started; forfeit all one's former achievements; have one's previous efforts wasted; labour lost; nullify all the advantages of a series of victories; nullify all the previous efforts; one's previous efforts have proved to be useless; turn all the previous labour to nothing; waste all the previous efforts; waste the efforts already made). Or others can enjoy what we have achieved without sweating (開埋井俾人食水 do pioneering work with labour but let somebody sit with folded arms and enjoy the results), which can be compared to 牛耕田馬食穀 – 父賺錢仔享福 (the father earns, the son spends).

Experience

Experience is closely related to age. One who has seen much of the world (經風雨, 見世面 brave the storm and face the world), 食鹽多過食飯, 行橋多過行路 (have seen more elephants) has experience, which explains why 人老精, 鬼老靈 (experience teaches).

Experience has to be gone through, just like 唔同床唔知被爛 (no one knows what the other side of the world looks like) and 唔見過鬼都唔怕黑 (a burned child dreads the fire). We should bear in mind, however, that experience can fail, which is described by the idiom 老貓燒鬚 (a good horse stumbles; even Homer sometimes nods; somebody who has had a bad experience with something) and the saying 盲拳打死老師傅 (a poor hand may put the old master to death).

Family

Family is an important pillar of a society. Harmony in a family is essential (家和萬事興 harmony makes a family prosperous). Family life centres around home, and people feel strongly attached to home (龍床唔似狗竇 there is no place sweeter than home). When there is any dispute between or among members of a family (相見好, 同住難 it's nice to see each other from time to time; but to live together is difficult; familiarity breeds contempt), even a judge could not help, for 清官難審家庭事 (outsiders find it hard to understand the cause of a family quarrel; 家家有本難唸的經 each and every family has its own problems). And when one is away from home, one always wants to return home, for 樹高千丈, 落葉歸根 (no matter whether it is east or west, home is the best).

Family background is also crucial. Some are born rich (身嬌肉貴 come from a rich family) and they are considered to have come from a good family (條命生得正 born in a good family). When one is successful in a career, people always say 英雄莫問出處 (not every great person was born with a silver spoon in his mouth), for talents do not have to come from a rich family.

A house is where a family lives (有瓦遮頭 have a place to live). If there is not enough space for everyone to have a room to stay, then a foldable bed would be used (朝行晚拆 a bed set up in the morning and dismantled at the evening; 朝拆晚行 (a bed set up at the evening and dismantled in the morning). There are all sorts of things needed to run a family, including pots and bottles (砂煲罌罈 pots and bottles) and other necessities (柴米油鹽醬醋茶 daily household necessities). And there are all sorts of things to do (家頭細務 household chores).

Fortune/misfortune

Fortune is synonymous with luck, and misfortune, bad luck. It is believed that fortunes change (世界輪流轉 everybody has the turn of the wheel; fortunes change; 風水輪流轉 every dog has his day; fortunes change). Fortune will not be with one forever (人無千日好 no person is fortunate forever and ever; 人有三衰六旺 a person suffers misfortunes and other times strokes of good fortune). Sometimes, you have fortune (行運一條龍 a person in luck; 神主牌都會郁 meet with one's fortune). At other times, you have misfortune (山高水低 unexpected misfortune; 冬瓜豆腐 die; 行運一條龍, 失運一條蟲 a man in luck walks heavy but a man out of luck cowers with humility; 黑過墨斗 have bad luck; 風吹芫荽 – 衰(垂)到貼地 reach the pitch of bad fortune). And misfortune never comes singly (行路打倒褪 fortunes never come singly; 屋漏兼逢夜雨 it never rains but pours; misfortunes never come singly), and everybody has their fortune and misfortune (同遮唔同柄, 同人唔同命 the same group of people have different lot; 同人唔同命, 同遮唔同柄 no man has the same fortune; no two people's fate is the same).

As fortune or misfortune is with one all the time, it is the way one deals with it that matters. Nobody likes misfortune (唔怕米貴, 至怕運滯 not afraid of the price of rice going up, but afraid of being unlucky; 亞駝賣蝦米 – 大家都唔掂 all play in hard luck). The sooner one overcomes misfortune, the better (大步躐過 escape from misfortune). It would be good if one has others to stand against misfortune (有福同享, 有禍同當 for better or for worse; go through thick and thin together; happiness and joy we shall share in common and loyally help each other in suffering; share bliss and misfortune together; share happiness as well as trouble; share joys and sorrows; share weal and woe; stick together through thick and thin; we will cast our lot together, all or none). People believe that when misfortune goes, fortune will come (終須有日龍穿鳳every cloud has a silver lining; every dog has his day; 大難不死, 必有後福 one's escape from death will certainly bring one good fortune), and one might have an unexpected stroke of good fortune (跛腳鵝哥自有飛來蜢 God tempers the wind to the shorn lamb; 冷手執個熱煎堆 have an unexpected stroke of good fortune). But one's good wishes would not apply to one's enemies (幸災樂禍 chuckle at somebody's discomfiture; crow over; delight in the misfortunes of others; derive pleasure from others' misfortune; exult at the misfortune of others; exult in the misfortune of others; exult over the misfortune of others; exult when another meets with mischance; glad when other people are in difficulties; gloat over others' misfortune; laugh at others' troubles; make game of others' calamities; make merry over another's mishap; mock at others' woes; rejoice in the misfortunes of others; Roman holiday; schadenfreude; take pleasure in the calamity of others; take pleasure from the misfortune of others; 攞景定贈慶 take advantage of one's vulnerability; 頭髮尾浸浸涼 gloat over an enemy's misfortune).

Friends

A person is judged by the company he keeps. This is very much the case with the Cantonese people (未觀其人, 先觀其友 you can judge a person by the friends he keeps). Friends with similar interests get together easily (物以類聚 birds of a feather flock together) and closely (筲箕冚鬼一窩神 be hand and glove with each other). This is particularly true with bad companions (豬朋狗友 bad companions; bad friends; friends of bad characters; friends with bad habits or low morals) and when you have money to spend (有酒有肉多兄弟 a heavy purse makes friends come).

Strangers (三九唔識七 be stranger to each other; 三唔識七 strangers) can become friends easily due to one's character (單料銅煲 the person who instantly makes friends with a stranger; 人夾人緣 whether people get along with one another or not depends on the compatibility of their characters; 曹操都有知心友, 關公亦有對頭人 a devil has friends for support and a saint has foes worthy of his steel), and through discord (唔打唔相識 no discord, no concord; no fight, no acquaintance; 不打不相識 build up friendship after an exchange of blows). Friends are to be treasured as they could help one when one is in predicament

(患難見真情 a friend in need is a friend indeed) or away from home (在家靠父母, 出外靠朋友 at home, you rely on parents; away from home, you rely on friends).

Gains and losses

Cantonese people take gains and losses rather philosophically. It would certainly be ideal if both or all parties win (一家便宜兩家着 both sides benefit; win-win situation), everything comes off well (掂過碌蔗 come off well; really good; 實食冇齲牙 sure win), with everyone getting what they want (得償所願 attain one's end; obtain one's heart's desire; 盤滿鉢滿 full to the brim).

People certainly know that efforts are needed to get what one wants (力不到不為財 no pain, no gain). One might be able to do that because of one's favourable position (近廚得食 in a favourable position to gain advantage). One might have to lose before one gains (小財唔出, 大財唔入 an empty hand is no lure for a hawk; nothing venture, nothing gain; 跌咗個橙, 執番個桔 lose at sunrise and gain at sunset; 未見官先打三十大板 suffer a loss before the gain; 未見其利, 先見其害 suffer a loss before an uncertain gain) and one should be content with what one can get (邊有咁大隻蛤蜊隨街跳 good cheap is dear; 得些好意須回手 stop before going too far; 密食當三番 a lot of small gains is as good as one big gain).

It is not advisable to be too aggressive (得寸進尺 give him an inch and he will take an ell; give him an inch and he will take a mile; much will have more; reach out for a yard after taking an inch; the more one gets, the more one wants), for very often, one's loss is much greater than one's gain (因小失大 spoil a ship for a halfpenny worth of tar; 賺粒糖, 蝕間廠 while seeking a small gain, one could suffer a big loss; 執到襪帶累身家 lose a pound for gaining a penny; 滾水淥豬腸 – 兩頭縮 become less; lose out on both sides; 水瓜打狗 – 唔見咗一撅 half of something is lost; 盲佬貼符 – 倒貼 not getting but giving away money). What is most undesirable would be to suffer a great loss (損手爛腳 suffer heavy losses; 鈴鈴鎟鎟都丟埋 meet with a crushing defeat; 箕箕打水 – 一場空 draw water with a sieve; 亞聾燒炮仗 – 散晒 meet with a failure; 坑渠浸死鴨 fail miserably in a very easy task).

It may offer one some comfort to call the person who incurs losses 倒米壽星 (person who causes others to suffer losses; person who stands in his own light), or console oneself with the words 羊毛出在羊身上 (whatever is given is paid for), 針冇兩頭利 (one cannot have it both ways; there's no rose without a thorn), 留得青山在, 哪怕冇柴燒 (life is safe and gains will surely be safe), 一眼針冇兩頭尖 (sugar cane is never sweet at both ends – one cannot have it both ways). To others, what one is actually doing is 跌倒揦番手+查沙 (put one's fault in the right side) or 偷雞唔倒蝕手+查米 (end up with nothing; go for wool and come back shorn).

Health

Everyone wants to enjoy good health (身壯力健 have a strong body; in good health; in vigorous health). Illness, nevertheless, is unavoidable. If one has a chronic disease, it will make one a doctor (久病成醫 prolonged illness makes a doctor of a patient).

Symptoms of illness include vomiting and diarrhea (又嘔又嘔 suffer from vomiting and diarrhea; vomit and have a water stool; vomiting and purging), head aches (頭痛發燒 minor diseases), and pain in the neck and shoulder (頸梗髆痛 stiff neck and pain in the shoulder). In treating these illnesses, a doctor should not cure only the symptoms, but also the illnesses (頭痛醫頭, 腳痛醫腳 a defensive stopgap measure; cure only the symptoms; sporadic and piecemeal steps; take only a stopgap measure, not a radical one; take only palliative measures for one's illness; treat symptoms but not the disease; treat the head when the head aches, treat the foot when the foot hurts).

In treating illnesses, patients would be unlucky if they are treated by a doctor who treats them slowly (急驚風遇着慢郎中 be too impatient to wait). Doctors would be lucky if they cure a patient who has almost recovered before treatment (行運醫生醫病尾 a lucky doctor cures a patient who is in the last stage of recovery).

Job

A job is needed to maintain one's livelihood. When one is employed, one has to work hard to complete one's tasks (受人二分四 work as an employee; 受人二分四, 做到一條氣 one has to work hard as an employee in order to get one's pay; 受人錢財, 替人消災 one must be committed to complete the task for which one has been paid; 食君之祿, 擔君之憂 do one's duty as one is paid). If one does one's job well, one gets promotion (矮仔上樓梯 – 步步高升 climb up step by step in one's career).

If one is unhappy with one's job, one could look for another job while having one (騎牛搵馬 seek for the better while holding on to one; work in one job but look out for a better one) or simply quit one's job (劈炮唔撈 give up one's job) as jobs are always available in other places (東家唔打打西家 lose employment on one but get a job in another). One tends to think that the work situation in another place could be better (隔籬飯香 the grass at the other side of one's own fence looks greener).

Life

One is the master of one's own life. The kind of life one leads very much depends on one's viewpoint. Some people think that since it is 人一世, 物一世 (you only live once), they should enjoy life as much as possible (自斟自酌 in the enjoyment of one's own life all by oneself; 火燒棺材 – 大(炭)歎 enjoy life as much as possible; 火燒旗竿 – 長炭(歎) enjoy life as long as possible; live in clover forever). Other people may hold the view that since their life is worthless (爛命一條 live a worthless life and have nothing to lose), and life is full of ups and downs (三衰六旺 ups and downs of life; 甜酸苦辣 all the sweet and bitter experiences of life), the best course to take is to lead an aimless life (胡胡混混 live an aimless life; 做慣乞兒懶做官 get used to living in idleness) as you have only a life to live (一世流流長 as long as one lives) and you might not be able to live long enough to spend all your money (有錢冇命享 have a lot of money but no life in which to spend it).

Livelihood

To earn a living is important and that is why people have to work (為口奔馳 work hard to make a living; 抛頭露面 make a living in the public eye; show oneself to make a living) for if people do not work, they have no food to eat (手停口停 if a person doesn't work he/she has no food to eat; no work no food), or they will eat up what they have stored up (坐食山崩 sit idle without work and the whole fortune will be at last used up).

Most of the idioms on livelihood are about people failing to earn enough to make a living, such as 餐搵餐食 (live from hand to mouth), 攞朝唔得晚 (live from hand to mouth), 飽唔死餓唔嚫 (earn no more than what one needs), 搵朝唔得晚 (live from hand to mouth), 朝種樹, 晚界+刀板 (live from hand to mouth), 睇餸食飯 (live within one's means), 睇餸食飯, 睇蠋喃嘸 (live within one's means), and 手搵口食 (live from hand to mouth).

The situation people face is that they fail to make both ends meet (十個甕缸九個蓋 fail to make both ends meet) and have to tighten their belts (勒緊褲頭 tighten one's belt), failing to have a family (餓死老婆燻臭屋 cannot earn enough bread to get married). This is why there is a saying 冇咁大嘅頭就唔好戴咁大頂帽 (don't live beyond one's means).

Mistakes

To err is human. People make mistakes (行差踏錯 make a mistake; 人有失手, 馬有失蹄 there's always many a slip-up in a person's job; 撞板多過食飯 (keep making mistakes), at times serious ones (撞晒大板 make a serious mistake). Sometimes mistakes are made even before work begins (落筆打三更 begin with

a wrong move; make mistakes when starting to do something; ruin something as soon as it starts; 落手打三更 begin with a wrong move; make mistakes when starting to do something; ruin something as soon as it starts).

There are various ways to handle mistakes. Other than shedding tears over mistakes one has committed (膝頭哥撬眼淚 commit a gross error and shed tears) one can shift the blame to others (屙屎唔出賴地硬 blame others for your own mistakes), or make the best of a mistake (將錯就錯 make the best of a bad job; make the best of a mistake; over shoes over boots), believing that mistakes could offer a lesson to the maker (錯有錯着 have a fault on the right side; mistakes can turn out to be useful).

Marriage

Socially speaking, marriage is the relationship that exists between a husband and a wife, and a wedding is an important event in a couple's life. When a man is single, he is a bachelor (單身寡仔 a man who is still unmarried; bachelor). In traditional China, arranged marriages through matchmakers were commonplace, and hence there is a saying 唔做中唔做保, 唔做媒人三代好 (he that does no business of a middleman and the like will have worthy descendants).

When a man and a woman get married, they are expected to marry in a matching manner (門當戶對 let beggars match with beggars). In some cases, men and women had shotgun weddings (奉旨(子)成婚 shotgun wedding) when the women were pregnant before weddings were held. After the wedding, the wife is expected to become a subordinate to her husband (嫁雞隨雞, 嫁狗隨狗 become a subordinate to one's husband once married).

Matter

Matters can be big or small (可大可小 it may be either serious or unimportant), serious (講笑搵第樣 this is no laughing matter) or trivial (雞毛蒜皮 trivial matter).

Matters are dealt with in different ways. Matters can be left undealt with (兩個和尚擔水食, 三個和尚冇水食 everybody's business is nobody's business; 不了了之 allow something to remain unresolved; conclude without conclusion; end up with nothing definite; settle a matter by leaving it unsettled; 一三五七九 – 無傷(雙) (一二三五六 – 沒事(四)) one, two, three, five, and six – nothing goes amiss; 一棟都冇cannot do anything). Matters can be dealt with according to prioritization (大雞唔食細米 care naught for trifles; important person does not bother with trivial matters; not want to do of little remuneration; 妹仔大過主人婆 have one's priority wrong; put the trivial above the important; the tail wags the dog). Matters can be dealt with seriously based on their importance (大蛇痾尿 important deal; 大蛇痾屎 important deal). Matters can be dealt with openly (明人不做暗事 make no secret of everything), separately (一件還一件 things should be dealt with separately), and instantly (煮到嚟就食 deal with things in due course; submit oneself to the circumstances). And there are people who want to get to the bottom of the matter (打爛砂盆問到篤 go to the bottom of the matter).

Popularity

Popularity refers to how well artists in the entertainment business are received. Artists who are very popular are said to be 大紅大紫 (at the height of one's power and influence; at the zenith of one's fame; enjoy great popularity; extremely popular; extremely successful in the show business), 紅到發紫 (enjoy great popularity; extremely popular; extremely successful in the show business), or 當時得令 (in season; win popularity). Artists who are neither popular nor unpopular are said to be 唔紅唔黑 (not enjoying popularity in the show business). For artists who are no longer popular, they are said to be 過氣老倌 (actor who past his prime).

Power

Power is what people are after for power allows one to fulfil one's wishes (要風得風, 要雨得雨 be able to get what one wants). A person in power could make a show of his power (也文也武 flaunt one's power; make a show of power).

But power is not absolute as there is always one who is above the person in power (斧頭打鑿鑿打木 the axe strikes the chisel, and the chisel strikes the wood – everything has its vanquisher; there is always one thing to conquer another). A person who does not use his power is sometimes regarded as a powerless person (老虎唔發威當病貓 mistake a sleeping wolf for a dead dog), and there are powerless people who pretend to be in power by stealing the show of an authority (手+查住雞毛當令箭 steal the show of an authority).

Practice

Practice makes perfect (工多藝熟 practice makes perfect; 曲不離口 practice makes perfect; 熟能生巧 practice makes perfect). A person learns skill through practice (熟讀唐詩三百首, 唔會吟詩也會偷 skill comes from constant practice; 一次生兩次熟 clumsy at first but skillful later on; people get used to things quickly).

Relationship

Relationship has been highly emphasized in China, and Guangdong is no exception. Cantonese people attach great importance to human relationships, holding the view that blood is thicker than water (切肉不離皮 blood is thicker than water; 打死不離親兄弟 blood is thicker than water; 一世人兩兄弟 we're brothers all our lives). Father's sisters and mother's sisters 姨媽姑姐 in a family and relatives on one's mother's side are to be highly respected (天上雷公, 地下舅公 brothers of the mother has a high status in human relations). According to tradition, it is absolutely wrong to turn one's back on all one's relations (六親不認). Sometimes, disputes between one's relatives and non-relatives put one in a difficult position (手板係肉, 手背又係肉 difficult to decide in taking sides as both parties are on good terms; have friendly relation with both parties). If one sides with outsiders, one is considered to be improper (手指拗出唔拗入 help outsiders at the expense of insiders).

Other kinds of relationships, which could be rather entangled (藤扔瓜, 瓜扔藤 get entangled with each other), could be divided into close and hostile. Close relationship is one that is tight (打風都打唔甩 very tight) whereas hostile relationship can be applied to enemies (貼錯門神 at odds with each other; become hostile; 督眼督鼻 a thorn in one's eye; eyesore; irritate to the eyes; 前世撈亂骨頭 be hostile to each other), but one should avoid making enemies (冤家宜解不宜結 it is better to bury the hatchet). It is said that enemies are bound to meet (冤家路窄 enemies are bound to meet; 不是冤家不聚頭 dogs and cats are sure to meet). When enemies meet, it would be advisable not to push them too hard (窮寇莫追 not to try to run after the hard-pressed enemy).

Responsibility

Cantonese people consider responsibility important (一人做事一人當 one is responsible for what one does; 萬大有我 even if the sky falls down, I'll hold it up).

Responsibility could in some context be burdensome (砣手口+能腳 burdensome) as burden could become heavy (落雨賣風爐 – 越擔越重 one's burden becomes greater), drag in others (亞蘭嫁亞瑞 – 大家累鬥累 drag in one another), and be lifelong (一生兒女債, 半世老婆奴 a wife and children are a man's burdens).

Retribution

The majority of Cantonese people are Buddhists who believe in the Buddhist idea of retribution, or karma, meaning that what one does will be rewarded accordingly. When things do not go well, people would say 前世唔修 (pitiful; suffer retribution for all ill deeds done in the previous existence). People are therefore reminded that good will be rewarded with good, evil, with evil (惡有惡報 curses come home to roost; sow the wind and reap the whirl-wind; 惡人自有惡人磨 devils devil devils; 善有善報, 惡有惡報 get what's coming to one; fortune is the good man's price, but the bad man's bane; good has its reward and evil has its recompense; good will be rewarded with good and evil with evil; if you do good, good will be done to you, but if you do ill, the same will be measured back to you).

Resources

Things cannot be achieved without resources (鳳凰無寶不落 draw water to one's mill). When there is a lack of resources (山窮水盡 at the end of one's rope; 萬事俱備, 只欠東風 ready to the last gaiter button), one can only obtain them from other sources (拉上補下 make up for the deficit in one area by using resources from another), which is like 人哋出雞, 你出豉油 (while the larger part of the expenses is borne by others, one still has to bear a small part of the expenses).

Trouble

Everyone has to deal with all sorts of troubles as there are people who are keen to make troubles (攪是攪非cause trouble between people; make trouble; 攪風攪雨 make trouble; stir up troubles; 無事生非 make trouble out of nothing; 煽風點火 stir up troubles; whip up waves; 無風三尺浪 make trouble out of nothing; 掘尾龍 – 攪風攪雨 the person who stirs up strife). Sometimes, troubles are created by oneself (唔衰擺嚟衰ask for trouble; borrow trouble; bring on trouble; encourage trouble; look for trouble; make a rod for oneself; prepare a rod for one's back; seek trouble for oneself; 惹屎上身 ask for trouble; invite trouble). At other times, troubles may be caused by loquacity (是非只為多開口 loquacity leads to troubles), busy work (是非皆因強出頭 a busybody often invites troubles), or fame (人怕出名豬怕肥 fame brings trouble). Troubles might also come unexpectedly (唔食羊肉一身臊 invite unexpected trouble; miss the goat meat and just get the smell of the goat; 白蟮上沙灘 – 唔死一身潺 get out of distress but into trouble), and they come one after another (一波未平, 一波又起 troubles come one after another)

As a result of troubles, everything is in a mess (家嘈屋閉 cause trouble at home; 頭都大埋 addle one's head; 攪出個大頭佛 put all the fat in the fire). The course to follow is to settle troubles. When troubles are over, things will get better (一天光晒 all is bright and clear; the trouble is over). Otherwise, there will be troubles in future (放虎歸山 lay trouble for the future).

Wealth

Wealth refers to the monetary resources one has or does not have. People want to make a lot of money or get rich (發過豬頭 make a lot of money; very rich; 發過豬蹄 make a lot of money; very rich; 風生水起 get rich; 盆滿缽滿 make a lot of money; 豬籠入水 have lots of money pouring in; have many different ways to make money; hit the jackpot; make wads of money; one's financial resources come from all directions; 大把世界 have many chances to make money). That, however, depends on how one makes money. Some are born rich (家肥屋潤 well-off family; 老豆大把 one's father is loaded); others accumulate wealth through frugality (死慳死抵 pinch and screw; tighten one's belt; 知慳識儉 (1) eat sparingly and spend frugally; economical in everyday spending; go slow with; live frugally; pinch and scrape; practice austerity; save money on food and expenses; scrape and screw; skimp and save; stint oneself; (2) careful calculation

and strict budgeting; 袋袋平安acquire and keep safe a sum of money). When one gets rich, one has power (財可通神 money makes the mare go; money talks; 有錢使得鬼推磨 money makes the mare go; 有錢佬話事 money talks; 見錢開眼 be moved at the sight of money; be tempted by money; care for nothing but money; open the eyes wide at the sight of money; one's eyes grow round with delight at the sight of money; 跪地餵豬嗰 – 睇錢份上 money makes the mare go; suffer disgrace and insults in order to get money).

One, nevertheless, may not be rich forever as one's wealth may come and go (三更窮, 四更富 one's poverty or wealth fluctuates; 搵得嚟使得去 easy come, easy go; light come, light go; 左手嚟, 右手去 in at one hand and out at the other). When one is rich, one should also avoid flaunting one's wealth (財不可露眼 don't flaunt your wealth; opportunity makes the thief) and one should pretend to be poor (禾稈冚珍珠 hide one's true wealth; rich people pretending to be poor). People have the general impression that most bald men are rich (十個光頭九個富 nine out of ten bald men are rich), rich people are not healthy (財多身子弱 rich but in poor health), and money only goes to the right person (唔係你財唔入你袋 money goes to the right person).

To stay rich, one should not overspend. But this is certainly not the case with many rich people as they feel more comfortable to spend a lot, sometimes unnecessarily (風吹雞蛋殼 – 財散人安樂 pay a price for one's safety; 財散人安樂 when money is spent, peace of mind is possible; 有錢就身痕 money burns a hole in one's pocket; 倒吊荷包 invite losses for oneself; 洗腳唔抹腳 spend lavishly; spend money extravagantly; splash one's money about; squander). This leads to the reduction of their wealth in an unclear way (神前桔 – 陰乾 (said of money) become less and less slowly; the longer the sum of money is saved, the smaller and smaller it becomes).

The poor, not the rich, are the majority. Many people are short of money (五行欠水 in need of money; 五行缺水 no money; 五行欠金 – 冇錢 broke; in need of money; penniless; 乾時緊月 hard up for money; 仙都唔仙吓 very poor). Some borrow money from people (船頭尺 – 度水someone who is always asking others for money). Many borrowers, however, do not settle debts with their lenders (劉備借荊州 – 有借冇回頭 money or things borrowed are never returned; the loan once given never comes back; 財到光棍手 – 有去冇回頭 give a bone to a dog; 財到光棍手 – 易放難收 once money goes to the hands of a conman, it's difficult to get it back from him) and make the excuse that debts could be settled in the long run (長命債, 長命還 a lifelong debt is to be settled by a lifetime). It should be realized that debts are to be settled, regardless of one's relationship with the lender (數還數路還路 balance accounts with somebody in spite of intimates) and the clearance of debts will bring peace of mind (無債一身輕 feel relieved if one is not in debt; out of debt, out of burden).

Work

Cantonese people are hardworking (做牛做馬 do hard work; 捱生捱死 work extremely hard; 捱更抵夜sit up all night to work; work night and day; 死做爛做 tire oneself out through overwork; work oneself to death; 輕枷重罪 be burdened with the work of a moment; 日捱夜捱 work hard night and day), and they are so busy that they do not have time to take a rest (得閒死, 唔得閒病 as busy as one can possibly be; awfully busy; have one's hands full; have one's work cut out; have too much on one's plate; not to have a moment one can call one's own; terribly busy; up to one's ears in work; up to one's eyes in work; up to one's neck in work; 鐵腳馬眼神仙肚 energetic person who can work long hours without sitting, sleeping, and eating; 忙到七個一皮 frantically busy). A rest, nevertheless, is always desirable (吊頸都要透氣 need to have an opportunity to relax no matter how busy one is; need to take a rest).

There are people who do not take work very seriously (做日和尚唸日經 wear through the day; 做又三十六, 唔做又三十六 one gets the same pay whether one is hardworking or lazy). They just fool around, idling away their time (行行企企 at a loose end; an idle end; at loose ends; be engaged in nothing; be occupied with nothing; dilly dally; do nothing; eat one's head off; fool about; fool around; goof; goof off; hang about; hang around; have nothing to do; idle about; idle along; idle away one's time; kick

one's heels; loaf; lost and bewildered; mess about; mess around; moon about; not to do a hand's turn; not to do a stitch of work; not to lift a hand; play about in a foolish way; saunter; stroll; twiddle one's thumbs; twirl one's thumbs).

Team work enhances efficiency (夾手夾腳 cooperate closely with each other; work well together; 人多好做作 many hands make light work), but at the same time it might cause problems (人多手腳亂 too many cooks spoil the broth; 人多熠唔焗 too many cooks spoil the broth).

Body: parts

In this part, idioms relating to the functions of different parts of the body are arranged alphabetically and discussed in detail.

Brain

Idioms on the brain are not to be taken clinically or physiologically. Brain to the Chinese people is the same as mind, which has a set of faculties or functions, including attitude, consciousness, imagination, perception, reasoning, recognition, thoughts, thinking, judgement, and memory. Brain is to be distinguished from heart, which has the functions of feelings and emotions.

Brain as mind is illustrated by a large number of Cantonese idioms: 十五十六 (in two minds; indecisive), 三心兩意 (dilly dally; in two minds), 心大心細 (hesitate to do something; indecisive), 心中有屎 (have a guilty conscience), 心中有數 (know what is what), 密底算盤 (penny pincher), 幫理不幫親 (fair-minded), 寡母婆咁多心 (in two minds), 知人口面不知心 (be familiar with somebody but ignorant of his true nature), 五時花六時變 (change one's mind easily; changeable; have an unstable temperament), 事不關己, 己不勞心 (mind one's own business).

Other functions of the mind follow, in alphabetical order.

(1) ATTENTION

Attention could be concentrated (埋頭埋腦 all attention all ears; all eyes; all eyes and ears; apply the mind to; be absorbed in; be deeply engrossed in something; be engrossed in; be occupied with; be preoccupied with; be utterly concentrated in; be wholly absorbed in; be wrapped up in; complete mental concentration; concentrate on; concentrate one's attention on; concentrate the whole energy upon; give one's whole attention to; have something on the brains; have something on the mind; in complete absorption; pay undivided attention to; very attentive; with absorbed interest; with all one's mental faculties on the stretch; with all one's soul; with breathless attention; with one's heart and soul; with rapt attention; with undivided attention; 迷頭迷腦 indulge oneself in; immerse oneself in), distributed (一眼關七 attend to several things at the same time; keep one's eyes open; on the alert), lost (神不守舍 absence of mind; absent-minded; in an absent way; in brown study; in the clouds; inattentive; jump the track; nobody home; one's heart is no longer in it; one's mind is not in it; one's mind is occupied with other things; one's wits go woolgathering; out to lunch; preoccupied with something else; with an abstracted air; with one's mind wandering; with one's thoughts elsewhere; woolgathering), lacking (粗心大意 careless; inadvertent; negligent; remiss; scatter-brain; slipshod; thoughtless; want of care; 老虎都會瞌眼瞓 even a watchful person will fall asleep), or negligent (顧得頭嚟腳反筋 attend to one thing and neglect another).

(2) ATTITUDE

One of the functions of the brain is attitude. Attitude covers *arrogance* (沙塵白霍 consider oneself a world above others; consider oneself unexcelled in the world; insufferably arrogant; on the high ropes; ride the

high horse; swagger like a conquering hero; think oneself supreme in the world; 招搖過市 be fond of showing oneself in the streets); *carelessness* (唔理三七廿一 regardless of the consequences; 唔理得咁多 cast all caution to the wind; 有理冇理 forget about it and let it rip); *fence-sitting* (豆腐刀 – 兩便面 a bean curd knife is sharp on both sides – a fence-sitter); *indifference* (隔岸觀火 show indifference towards somebody's trouble; 關佬懶理 not interest; not to bother with others; won't bother to heed it); *ingratitude* (有事鍾無艷, 無事夏迎春 once out of danger, cast the deliverer behind one's back); 打完齋唔要和尚 kick down the ladder; *middle-course* (亞駝行路 – 舂舂地 take a mean course); *non-involvement* (企喺城樓睇馬打 keep oneself out of the affair; make oneself stay out of the matter); *selfishness* (潮州音樂 – 自己顧自己 (老西兒拉胡琴 – 自顧自) Chaozhou music – everyone for themselves; pay one's bill for oneself; 田雞過河 – 各有各足+耕 each goes his own way; each takes to his legs); *sloppiness* (是是但但 anybody will do; as you like it; anything is alright; anything will do; 馬馬虎虎 not serious; perfunctory; sloppy; 唔嗲唔吊 careless; casual; 得過且過 muddle along; 點話點好 as you please); *snobbery* (見高就拜, 見低就踩 (軟的欺負硬的怕) flatter those above and bully those below; snobbish); *Take-it-easy attitude* (天跌落嚟當被冚 take it easy; 大安旨意 choose to ignore any risk or danger);

(3) CLARITY OF MIND

To have a clear mind is important. When one's mind works fast, one is said to be clear-headed (挑通眼眉 clever person) or smart (眉精眼企 know a trick or two; smart; 精乖伶俐 clever and quick-witted; clever and sensible; intelligent and smart; quick on the uptake; 話頭醒尾 able to take a hint). When one's mind works in a clever way, one is said to have wit (眼眉毛雕通瓏 sharp-witted; up to snuff; 靈機一觸 a flash of wit; a sudden inspiration; hit on a bright idea; suddenly have a brain wave). Wisdom has to be gained through time and experience (事後孔明 be wise after an event; 靈神不用多致燭, 好鼓不用多槌 a word is enough to the wise; 薑越老越辣 the older, the wiser; 唔信命都信吓塊鏡 it is wise to know oneself; 多一事長一智 by every affair a person transacts; in doing, one learns; one learns from experience; wisdom comes from experience; 人急智生 have quick wits in an emergency).

To have a confused mind is undesirable. When one's mind is unclear, one is said to be insane or crazy (神神經經 crazy; 癲癲痱痱 crazy; 癲癲得得 crazy; 阿駝都俾你激直 you make somebody crazy). When one's mind is muddled, one is said to be muddle-headed (見山就拜 taking A for B without making sure; 混混噩噩 ignorant; muddle-headed; without a clear aim; 壽頭壽腦 muddle-headed; 瘟瘟沌沌 lose one's consciousness; 騎牛搵牛 look for an ox while sitting on one; 南嘸佬遇鬼迷 an old horse loses its way; 聰明一世, 蠢鈍一時 clever all the time but become a fool this once; 精埋一便 clever only at ill doings). When one's mind works unwell, one is said to be dumb (吽吽豆豆 very dull and boring), stupid (人頭豬腦 as stupid as a pig; stupid; 肥頭耷耳 stupid; 頭大冇腦 stupid; 頭大冇腦, 腦大生草 stupid person without intelligence; 薯頭薯腦 stupid; 獻醜不如藏拙 it is wiser to conceal one's stupidity than it is to show oneself up; 傻傻庚庚 foolish; 人蠢冇藥醫 there's no remedy to cure the stupidity of a person; 笨頭笨腦 block-headed).

To have a wicked mind is in general not acceptable (老奸巨猾 as cunning as an old fox; 陰陰濕濕 cunning; treacherous; vicious; 精到出骨 act cleverly from selfish motives; 蛇頭鼠眼 as crafty as a fox; 有心裝冇心人 set a trap for somebody; 明槍易擋, 暗箭難防 better to suffer an attack by overt than by covert).

(4) INTENTION

Intention is sometimes hard to gauge (生仔唔知仔心肝 it is hard to know people's hidden intention) and likely to be misunderstood (捉錯用神 misunderstand somebody's intention). Evil intention has, nevertheless, received more attention (端端度度 have evil intention; 鱸魚探蝦毛 – 冇好心 a weasel giving new year's greetings to a hen has ulterior motives; a yellow weasel goes to pay New Year's call to a hen – not with the best of intentions; the weasel goes to pay its respects to the hen – not with the best of intentions);

墨魚肝肚雞泡心腸 – 黑夾毒 the belly and intestines of a cuttlefish and the liver of a pufferfish: they are all black and poisonous).

(5) PERCEPTION

Perception is about how one sees things. It is therefore related to one's views (同聲同氣 of the same opinion; 同一鼻哥窿出氣 breathe through the same nostrils; have the same opinion; in tune with; sing the same tune; talk exactly one like the other).

Perception is about one's assessment of things. One's assessment could be biased (先入為主 have a prejudice against), critical (有彈冇讚 just criticism without praise; 有彈有讚 criticize and praise; 濕水棉胎 – 冇得彈 above criticism; beyond reproach), fussy (奄尖聲悶 choosy; fussy; 婆婆媽媽 womanishly fussy; 腌尖腥悶 hard to please).

(6) REASONING

There are idioms expressing things happening without reasons (無情白事 without reason or cause; 無端白事 without any reason; without reason or cause; 橫蠻無理 savage like a beast), people losing their reasons (唔係人咁品 lose one's reason; 秀才遇着兵 – 有理講唔清 be unable to persuade somebody with reason), and people clinging to their own reasons (公說公有理, 婆說婆有理 each clings to his own view).

One of the important functions of reasoning is to provide an excuse for something, which is otherwise known as pretext. Idioms on pretext include 借頭借路 (cook up a lame excuse; use any pretext), 借題發揮 (make use of the subject under discussion to put across one's ideas), and 推三推四 (cook up a lame excuse; reluctant to do something; stall).

Another function of reasoning is bargaining, which is to haggle over price. Idioms on bargaining include 打死狗講價 (fish in troubled water), 開天索價 (ask a sky-high price; ask an exorbitant price), 聽價唔聽斗 (care for whether the price is cheap or high but neglect the quality or quantity), 開天索價, 落地還錢 (drive a hard bargain over something), and 亞蘭賣豬 – 一千唔賣, 賣八百 (bargain away something; be forced to devalue something).

(7) RECOGNITION

Recognition is related to knowledge and understanding. Cantonese idioms on knowledge include 知子莫若父 (no one knows a boy better than his father) and 知其一不知其二 (have a smattering of something or somebody). Idioms on understanding include 知己知彼 (it needs to understand both oneself and others), 帶眼識人 (know a person with one's own eyes), 對牛彈琴 (sing to a mule; speak to the wrong audience), 又聾又啞 (can neither understand or speak the native language when in a foreign country), 唔使劃公仔劃出腸 (it goes without saying), 雞啄放光蟲 – 心知肚明 (a turtledove eating up a firefly – bright in the belly – have a clear understanding of things), 牛皮燈籠 – 點極都唔明 (thick-headed), 半夜食黃瓜 – 不知頭定尾 (make neither head nor tail of something), 一理通, 百理明 (once one has mastered the basic idea, the rest is easy); 日久見人心 (time makes one understand a person) and 水洗都唔清 (the misunderstanding is beyond repair).

Recognition is related to one's ability to distinguish differences so as one would not be confused (一頭霧水 be confused; be puzzled; become lost; cannot understand; can't make the head or tail of something; in bewilderment; in confusion). Examples of confusion are evident in the idioms 顛倒是非 (confound right and wrong; confuse truth and falsehood; distort truth; give a false account of the true facts; invert justice; lead people's error; reversal of right and wrong; reverse right and wrong; stand facts on their heads; swear black is white; the perversion of truth; turn right into wrong; turn things upside down; twist the facts), 唔湯唔水 (neither fish nor fowl), and 捩橫折曲 (swear black is white).

(8) THINKING

One of the most important functions of a human brain is thinking, which generates confusion, decisions, determination, imagination, strategies, and actions such as cunningness and madness.

Thinking could be imaginative or wishful, which is expressed by the idioms 妙想天開 (a flight of fancy; a stretch of the imagination; ask for the moon; come out with most fantastic ideas; cry for the moon; expect wonders; fanciful; fanciful ideas; get fancy ideas into one's head; give loose to the fancy; given run to fancy; have a maggot in one's head; have bats in the belfry; have bees in the brain; have bees in the head; have fantastic notions; have one's head full of bees; indulge in the wildest fantasy; indulge one's fancy; lend wings to one's imagination; let one's imagination run away with one; one's head is full of bees; vagarious; whimsical; wild hopes; wish for the moon; wishful thinking) and 痴心妄想 (fond dream; wishful thinking).

One's thinking could be shown by one's facial expression (眉頭眼額 one's thinking being revealed by one's facial expression). When one thinks long-term (從長計議 give a matter further deliberation and discuss it later), one may have to weigh the pros and cons (患得患失 be swayed by considerations of success and failure) and its significance (嗒落有味 the significance of something becomes clear after careful consideration). Attention must be paid to its results in future (落雨擔遮 – 顧前唔顧後 pay no regard to the future).

Decisions have to be made after thinking. There might be the case where one does not have the right to make a decision (杉木靈牌 – 唔做得主 manage a family but without the right to make any decisions). One might incline to make a decision based on preference (獨沽一味 have a strong preference for only one thing). There might be too many choices for one to make a right decision (千揀萬揀 select carefully; 花多眼亂 have a dazzling array of choices before one; there are too many to choose; too many choices), and one might end up with a bad decision (千揀萬揀, 揀着個爛燈盞 the most careful choice is often the worst choice; 打錯算盤 make a wrong decision). When one has grown-up children, they could make their own decisions (仔大仔世界 children who are grown-up should make their own decisions).

Strategies are schemes that come from thinking. One might think out a strategy by oneself (山人自有妙計I've an excellent solution; 眉頭一皺, 計上心頭 have a sudden inspiration; hit upon an idea). Generally, it is believed that two heads are better than one when it comes to working out strategies (一人計短, 二人計長 two heads are better than one), short persons are good at working out strategies (矮仔多計 a short person has many strategems), and thieves are good strategists (賊公計, 狀元才 know a trick worth two of that).

One might hammer out a strategy that takes things as they come (見步行步 deal with things one step at a time; take things as they come), achieves two goals at one go (一弓射兩箭 kill two birds with one stone), plays safe (穩打穩紮 play safe; take no risk), matches the strategies of one's player (棋逢敵手 nip and tuck; well-matched; 你有張良計, 我有過牆梯 be evenly matched; 棋高一着 be a stroke above somebody), or outplays one's counterpart (將計就計 turn somebody's tricks against him). One might run out of wit in working out strategies (三十六度板斧都出齊 at the end of one's wits). One tactic that could be considered is to run away (三十六着, 走為上着 of all the thirty-six tactics, to "run away" is the best one). If one makes a bad move, things will fall apart (一子錯滿盤皆落索 a wrong step causes a messy tumble; one careless move loses the whole game; 棋差一着 lose a move to somebody).

Ear

The only idiom on ear is 左耳入, 右耳出 (go in one ear and out the other).

Eye

Eyes are for looking at things. There is a small number of end-clippers on taking a glance (單眼仔睇老婆 – 一眼見晒 clear at a glance; see with half an eye; 單眼佬睇榜 – 一目了然 clear at a glance; see with

half an eye; 單眼佬睇榜 – 一眼見晒 clear at a glance; see with half an eye; 亞單睇榜 – 一眼睇晒 see with half an eye), and a small number of idioms on gazing (走馬看花 take a scamper through something; 眈天望地 glance this way and that way; 睇東睇西 gaze this way and that; stare about; watch out furtively to the east and west; 擔天望地 gaze this way and that; stare about; watch out furtively to the east and west; 二叔公割禾 – 望下截 look back on).

Other eye idioms are related to blindness (有眼無珠 blind; misvalue somebody; 隻眼開, 隻眼閉 shut one's eyes to; turn a blind eye to), red eyes due to overwork (金睛火眼 (1) eyes tired from intense concentration; very attentive eyes; (2) have red eyes due to overwork), eye sores (眼唔見為伶俐 out of sight, out of mind; 鞋底沙 – 拎乾淨至安樂 you won't feel comfortable until the sting in one's eyes is pulled out), carelessness in seeing things (眼大睇過籠 be too careless to see anything), and things to be seen at a later stage (好戲在後頭 there will be something interesting to see a little later).

Face

Idioms on face could be related to colour of the complexion (紅光滿面 one's face glows with health; 面紅面綠 as red as a turkey-cook; blush to the roots; blush up to the ears; colour up; crimson with rage; flush red in the face; flush to the ears; flush with shame; get red in the face; one's face reddens to the ears; red in the face; red with anger; 黃泡髮熟 a swollen face with yellow complexion), conditions of health (面青心紅 apparently weak but actually strong and loyal), expression of one's mental state (木口木面 expressionless; slow-witted; wooden-faced; 嗱口嗱面 look upset; 面不改容 not to change colour; one's countenance betrays nothing; one's face is untroubled; remain calm; undismayed; without batting an eyelid; without changing countenance; without turning a hair; 灶君老爺 – 黑口黑面 fierce demon and devils), face-to-face situation (二口六面 face to face; 三口六面 face-to-face; two parties and witness confront in court), appearance (熟口熟面 familiar face; 面黃骨瘦 skinny and look pale; 面懵心精 appear to be stupid but is actually very smart; play the fool), authority (睇人口面 be dependent on other's pleasure; 賣鹹酸菜 – 畀面 give face to somebody; 人要面, 樹要皮 a person needs face just like a tree needs bark; 唔睇僧面, 都睇吓佛面 not for everybody's sake but for somebody's sake).

Foot

Idioms on foot are related to ways of walking, including 大搖大擺 (swagger about), 行路唔帶眼 (jaywalk), 冷巷擔竹竿 – 直出直入 walking in a lane with a plank on one's shoulder – taking an arrow-straight course), and 出出入入 coming in and out; in and out; shuttle in and out) or 行出行入 (come in and out; in and out; shuttle in and out).

Hand

A notable characteristic of idioms on hands is that most of these idioms mention hands and feet together instead of just mentioning hands (手多腳多 touch things when one should not; 手忙腳亂 all in a hustle of excitement; be thrown into a panic; be thrown into confusion; in a great flurry; in disarray; 乾手淨腳 (1) (乾淨利落) crispy; dapper; efficient; neat; neat and tidy; neatly; smooth and clean; trim; very efficient; (2) finished and done with, once for all; and 毛手毛腳 inappropriate fondling or touching).

In this dictionary, the only exception is 手急眼快 (quick of eye and deft of hand).

Head

Literally, head is always mentioned together with tail, while figuratively, head is interpreted as a beginning and tail, an ending. This is why there is a number of idioms containing head and tail being translated as

beginning and end, such as 一頭一尾 ((1) both ends; (2) here and there; 由頭到尾 all the way; at both the end and the beginning; from A to Z; from beginning to end; from end to end; from first to last; from hub to tire; from soup to nuts; from start to finish; from stem to stern; from the egg to the apple; from the head to the tail; from the sole of the foot to the crown of the head; from tip to toe; from top to bottom; from top to toe; the whole way; through and through; through the whole length; 好頭好尾 a good beginning and a good ending; 頭頭尾尾 (1) odd pieces; (2) altogether; and 有頭威, 冇尾陣 (a brave beginning and weak ending; a brave beginning but a poor ending; a tiger's head and a snake's tail; begin well but fall of towards the close; begin with tigerish energy but peter out towards the end; come out at the small end of the horn; do something by halves; fine start and poor finish; in like a lion, out like a lamb; start out well but not continue; with a fine start but a poor finish).

In this dictionary, there are three idioms on hands that do not have tails, including 頭重腳輕 (top-heavy), 萬事起頭難 (it is difficult to begin a new business); and 頭崩額烈 (be scorched by the flames; badly battered; beat somebody's head off; be bruised and battered; be scorched and burned; in a sorry plight; in a terrible fix; smash heads and scorch brows; utterly exhausted from overwork).

Heart

In contrast to brain, or mind, which is about thinking, heart is about feelings and emotions. There are twenty idioms which are about heart, including 人面獸心 (a wolf in lamb's skin), 入心入肺 (take something to heart), 心服口服 (be sincerely convinced), 心知肚明 (know in one's heart), 死心不息 (as obstinate as a mule), 佛口蛇心 (a beast in human shape; a brute of a man; a brute under a human mask; a fiend in human shape; a man's face but a the heart of a beast; a wolf in sheep's clothing; bear the semblance of a man but have the heart of a beast; gentle in appearance but cruel at heart; have the face of a man but the heart of a beast; kind-mouthed but vicious-hearted; with a human face and the heart of a beast), 死心塌地 (hell-bent on somebody), 扶心扶肺 (break somebody's heart), 將心比己 (measure another's foot by one's own last), 提心吊膽 (have one's heart in one's mouth), 開心見誠 (open-hearted), 好眉好貌生沙蝨 (a fair face hides a foul heart), 良心當狗肺 (be ungrateful for a favour and regard it as a disservice), 芋頭點糖 – 心淡 (one's heart sinks), 狗咬呂洞賓 – 不識好人心 (not know chalk from cheese), 人心肉做 (have a good conscience; people are by nature compassionate), 好心有好報 (a good act will be well rewarded; fortune is the companion of virtue; good will be rewarded with good; goodness will have a good reward; kind deeds pay rich dividends to the doer), 好心唔怕做 (not afraid to do good deeds; have one's heart in the right place), 好心唔得好報 (recompense good with evil), and 好心着雷殛 (bite the hand that feeds one; recompense good with evil).

Feelings and emotions related to heart have been arranged alphabetically and discussed separately.

(1) ANGER

There is a large number of expressions on anger as a human emotion, which include 佛都有火 (it would try the patience of a saint), 慶過火屎 (very angry), 慶過辣雞 (very angry), 激到一把火 (a stomachful of anger). Sometime, it is not possible to withhold one's anger (剋住度氣 be compelled to hold back one's rage; be forced to submit to humiliation; be forced to swallow the leek).

Anger can be expressed through body movements, such as 七竅生煙 (fly into a rage), 頭殼頂出煙 (get very angry), 嚇到彈起 (hit the roof), 激到生蝦咁跳 (tremble with anger), 吹鬚碌眼 (blow a fuse; blow a gasket; fall into a rage; foam with rage; froth at the mouth and glare with rage scowl and growl; snort and stare in anger), or through facial expressions, such as 黑口黑面 ((1) very angry; (2) look displeased; pull a long face), 口黑面黑 ((1) very angry; (2) look displeased; pull a long face), and 黑埋口面 ((1) very angry; (2) look displeased; pull a long face).

(2) COURAGE

Courage is interchangeable with audacity, which carries with an appreciative connotation (膽大心細 bold but cautious; courageous and cautious; 膽大心細面皮厚 bold, cautious, and thick-skinned).

Courage could be monstrous (狗膽包天monstrous audacity). People who are monstrously audacious do not care for their own lives (膽正命平 have too much spunk to care for one's own life) and would come with ill intentions (來者不善, 善者不來 來者不善, 善者不來 he could not have come with good intentions; he that fears the gallows shall never be a good thief; he who has come, come with ill intent, certainly not on virtue bent; he who has come is surely strong or he'd never come along; the one who is coming surely has bad intentions; with good intent he would not come).

There are naturally people who are not so audacious (生人唔生膽 as timid as a hare; be intimidated).

(3) DESIRE

Desire is what one is after. It can be achieved through the power of others, just like what is said in the end-clipper 黃大仙 – 有求必應 (one who always accepts others' requests). The fulfilment of desire is without limit (坐一望二 hope for another after gaining one) and without self-knowledge (癩蛤蟆想食天鵝肉 overestimate oneself; overreach oneself). But one's desire may not be fulfilled, just like 寡母婆死仔 – 冇晒希望 (be driven to despair), or simply 冇釐聲氣 (beyond hope).

(4) FEAR

Fear is a negative human emotion. Extreme fear could make the sufferer 鼻哥窿冇肉 (be extremely terrified), 魂魄都唔齊 (be entranced with fear; be frightened out of one's wits; be scared out of one's wits; be scared to death), 三魂唔見咗七魄 (be entranced with fear; be frightened out of one's wits; be scared out of one's wits; be scared to death) or 有得震冇得瞓 (tremble with fear).

People who experience fear, fear fear, as expressed by the idioms 見過鬼就怕黑 (once bitten, twice shy), 一朝俾蛇咬, 三年怕草繩 (a burnt child dreads the fire; once bitten by a snake, one shies at a coiled rope for the next three years; once bitte, twice shy; the scalded dog fears cold water). These people become timid and overcautious (船頭慌鬼, 船尾慌賊 get into a hobble; timid and overcautious). Regrettably, there is no cure for fear (人嚇人冇藥醫 there's no remedy to cure a person horrified by others).

Fear gives rise to nervousness or panic (慌慌失失nervous; 失驚無神 be seized with panic). One trembles when seized with fear (手騰腳震 tremble all over), becoming nervous (踩着芋莢都當蛇 take every bush for a bugbear) and a nervous person (緊張大師 nervous person).

(5) FEELINGS

Feelings are complicated. It is said that empathy is universal (人同此心, 心同此理 everybody feels the same). There are bad feelings, such as 牽腸掛肚 (feel deep anxiety about somebody), 週身唔自然 (feel uneasy all over), 週身唔聚財 (uneasy all over), and 針唔拮到肉唔知痛 (no one but the wearer knows better where the shoe pinches). There are also good feelings (關公細佬 – 亦得(翼德) as you like; 千里送鵝毛, 物輕情意重 the trifling gift sent from afar conveys deep affection).

(6) GREED

Greed carries the derogatory connotation of having a strong desire to have a lot of things out of selfishness or which are unfair to other people (恨到發燒 want something desperately).

Cantonese idioms on greed are 貪得無厭 (too greedy for gains) and 食人唔舌+累骨 (greedy for gains). Greed could end in poverty (貪字得個貧 being greedy will lead one into poverty; grasp all, lose all; greediness leads to poverty), and the advice is 光棍佬教仔 – 便宜莫貪 (don't be covetous of things on the cheap).

(7) HATE

Hate is not greatly emphasized in Cantonese culture. A typical idiom that expresses hate is 神憎鬼厭 (accused target; person who is hated by all), or in the form of an end-clipper 神枱貓屎 – 神憎鬼厭 (accused target; person who is hated by all).

(8) JEALOUSY

Jealousy, or envy, is a desire to have what others have. People tend to envy those who are rich (憎人富貴厭人貧 envy the rich people and despise the poor), famous (樹大招風 a person of reputation is liable to become the envy of others), which explains why they become the envy of others (恨死隔離 become the envy of others; object of great envy). Lovers, moreover, are also jealous (打爛醋醒 lovers getting very jealous).

(9) JOY

People believe that joy or happiness is not limited to any class of people, for 辣撻人有辣撻福 (happiness often comes to mediocre persons). And when it comes to making a choice between wealth and happiness, people prefer happiness (寧食開眉粥, 莫食愁眉飯 had rather be poor but happy than become rich but anxious), and they will burst with joy when they have happiness (鬆毛鬆翼 burst with joy; sing and dance for joy).

(10) LOVE

Love can be between a man and a woman. A man could be attracted by a woman at first sight (生滋貓入眼 love at first sight), for love is essentially blind (情人眼裏出西施 beauty exists in a lover's eyes; love is blind) and 寃豬頭都有盟鼻菩薩 (a lover has no judge of beauty). Lovers could have amorous behaviour (依依挹挹 amorous behaviour) and they should be loyal to each other like 栀榔樹 – 一條心 (love somebody heart and soul; single-minded in love) or 枋榔樹一條心 (love somebody heart and soul; single-minded in love). But this might not be the case. People could have two or more than two lovers (一腳踏兩船 (1) attempt to make profits in two ways; seek benefits from two sides; (2) have two lovers at the same time; and 一腳踏幾船 have several lovers at the same time), and a woman could have a few lovers (勾三搭四 (said of a woman) have many lovers).

Love can be between parents and children. Parents dote the youngest son (孻仔拉心肝 parents lavish most affection on their youngest son) or youngest daughter (孻仔拉心肝, 孻女拉五臟 parents lavish most affection on their youngest son, but they lavish just as much affection on their youngest daughter), and the youngest sons and daughters could be spoiled (生骨大頭菜 – 縱(種)壞晒 be spoiled).

(11) LOYALTY

Loyalty is faithful to someone or something. Idioms on loyalty seem to be giving a negative impression, which include 樹倒猢猻散 (rats leave a sinking ship), 義氣搏兒戲 (take the risk of being loyal to a potential traitor), and 食碗面, 反碗底 (betray a friend; ungrateful).

(12) MOOD

Mood refers to feelings one has at a particular time. Idioms on mood are generally negative (六神無主be thrown into confusion; 攰吓攰吓 swaying; unstable; 耷頭耷腦 listless; 要生要死 hysterical; 悭口悭面 in a bad mood; 有神冇氣 breath is present but vigour is absent; faint; feeble; listless; slack; weak; wearily).

(13) REGRET

Life is full of regrets. One might regret on what one did long time ago (早知今日, 何必當初 it is too late to ask oneself why one has gone astray when one knows the consequence to be so serious; 早知今日, 悔不當初 it is too late to repent for having gone astray so when one knows the consequence to be so serious), regret at having to sell one's favourite (賣仔莫摸頭 express regret at being forced to sell one's favourite), and regret at having paid for something worthless (擸到樹葉都落埋 express one's repentance for having paid for something worthless).

No matter how deep is one's regret (抌心抌肺 (很後悔) deeply regret), there is no point to bang one's head against the wall to show one's repentance for having been so foolish (坎頭埋牆 bang one's head against the wall; show repentance for having been foolish).

(14) SATISFACTION

People could not be satisfied easily (人心冇厭足 one is never content; one is never satisfied; 到喉唔到肺 be half satisfied; insufficient; not enough to satisfy one's appetite; unsatisfying). They always want more (人心不足蛇吞象 human beings are never satisfied with what they have; no man is contented with his own possessions). When they are not satisfied, they move in a certain way (郁身郁勢 show discontent with one's position). When they are satisfied, they nod their heads in self-approbation (擰頭擰髻 nod one's head – assume an air of self-approbation).

(15) SORROW

Sorrow seems to be a synonym for suffering. There are two idioms that express sorrow in terms of suffering, which include 貼錢買難受 (get bad service; pay for troubles) and 啞仔食黃蓮 – 有苦自己知 (swallow the leek).

(16) SPIRITS

One's spirits could be high or low. When one's spirits are high, one is said to be 精神爽利 (brisk and neat; full of spirit and energy; in good feather; in great feather; in high feather), 龍馬精神 (as vigorous as a dragon or a horse), 龍精虎猛 (full of energy; full of strength), 打醒十二個精神 (raise one's spirits), and鬼打都冇咁醒 (be on the alert). When one's spirits are low, then one is said to be 冇厘精神 (a cup too low; disheartened; dispirited and discouraged; have a fit of blues; in low spirits; in the blues; in the dumps; lackadaisical; listless; out of humour; out of sorts; out of spirits; seedy; spiritless; with little enthusiasm; with the wind taken out of one's sails), and 頭耷耷眼濕濕 (become dejected and despondent; blue about the gills; bury one's head in dejection; down at the mouth; down in the chops; down in the dumps; down in the hips; down in the mouth; hang one's head; have one's tail down; in low spirits; in the dumps; look downcast; mope oneself; one's crest falls; out of heart; out of spirits; out of sorts; sing the blues; take the heart out of somebody).

(17) TOLERANCE

Tolerance tests one's ability to accept things or people one disagrees with (忍無可忍 be out of patience with; 抓頸就命 patient with the current situation; 手+查頸就命 bear and forbear to save life; have no

choice but to comply). Very often, one has to put up with the situation in order to achieve one's goal (食得鹹魚抵得渴 since one has the courage of one's convictions, one must be prepared to accept the consequences; 食得鹹, 就要抵得渴 since one has the courage of one's convictions, one must be prepared to accept the consequences).

Beard

There is an idiom on the beard, which is 鬍鬚勒特 (much-bearded).

Lung

A lung is a breathing organ. There are two idioms related to lung: 氣羅氣喘 (gasp for breath; out of breath) and 上氣唔接下氣 (be out of breath; pant).

Mouth

One uses one's mouth to do a lot of actions: drinking, eating, smiling, speaking, talking.

(1) DRINKING

Drinking in Cantonese idioms refers to drinking wine. This dictionary has three idioms related to wine drinking, including 花天酒地 (attend a dinner with sing-song girls; be in the world of wine and women; be on the loose; be on the tiles; be out on the tiles; go on the loose; go on the racket; go on the tiles; guzzle and carouse to one's heart content; guzzle and have a good time; have one's fling; indulge in fast life and debauchery; led a decadent and dissolute life; lead a fast life; live in the world of wine and women; sow a large crop of wild oats), 酒醉三分醒 (be in wine but still a little conscious), and 酒後吐真言 (truth is exposed in wine).

(2) EATING

Chinese people in general and Cantonese people in particular are fond of eating good food. People believe in working hard and eating in leisure (辛苦搵嚟自在食 work hard in order to eat at leisure). Life is about eating and drinking (飲飲食食 eat and drink; wine and dine with somebody). People are choosy in eating (揀飲擇食 be particular about one's food; choose one's food; fussy about food; fussy eater) and know how to enjoy good food (識飲識食 enjoy life to the full; have a good palate for food; know how to enjoy food and drinks; 飲飽食醉 good meal and many drinks).

For ordinary people, a home meal with simple food is good enough (粗茶淡飯 plain tea and simple meal; 家常便飯 homely food; ordinary meal; 鹹魚白菜 humble meal; simple meal). With a good appetite, they eat up all the dishes (食七咁食 eat and drink as much as one can; gorge oneself; have a good stomach; 美人照鏡 eat up all the food on the dish) despite the small size of their stomach (眼闊肚窄 bite off more than one can chew), just like a hungry ghost swallowing up everything (餓鬼投胎 devour like a hungry tiger pouncing its prey). They would like to have more to eat the next time around (食過翻尋味 would like to try once again) though the food might not be healthy (利口唔利腹 good for mouth but bad for health).

When one's appetite is poor (翳翳滯滯 have a poor appetite; one's appetite is poor) or they have no food to eat (食西北風 have nothing to eat; live in poverty), the situation would be different.

(3) SMILING

There is a number of idioms on different ways people smile. One could smile in a stupid way (烚熟狗頭 smiling stupidly), broadly (熁熟狗頭 on the broad grin), in a radiant way (笑口吟吟 a face radiating with smiles; a smile lit up one's face; all smiles; grin from ear to ear; have a broad smile on one's face; with a beaming face; with a face all smiles), constantly (笑口常開 beam with smiles at all times), mischievously (笑口騎騎 behave in a noisy, gay and boisterous manner; grinning and smiling; grinning cheekily; grinning mischievously; smiling and grimacing; with a cunning smile; with an oily smile), uproariously (笑口噬噬 roar with laughter; uproarious laughter), sweetly (蓮子蓉咁口 very sweet smile), and insincerely (皮笑肉不笑 put on a false smile; insincere smile).

Speaking

The contents of what one speaks are varied. Included in this topic are arguing, badmouthing, chattering, command, complaint, contradiction, demand, empty talk, exaggeration, gossiping, hesitation, innuendo, lying, nagging, oath, praise, promise, ready tongue, repetition, scolding, stammering, straight talking, talking, and vulgarism.

(1) ARGUING

Arguing is quarrelling with others in disagreement. When one argues over nothing, this is 口同鼻拗 (argue over nothing; it's useless to argue). When one argues unreasonably, this is 死人都要拗番生 (argue that the dead is still living).

(2) BADMOUTHING

Badmouthing is American English, meaning to speak badly of something or somebody. Badmouthing in Cantonese is 煮人一鏟 (badmouth others).

(3) CHATTERING

To chatter is to talk about something unimportant or trivial for a long time. Chattering in Cantonese is 囉囉嚟嚟 (chatter) and 吱吱喳喳 (chattering; noisy; talkative). When women get together, they talk a lot (七嘴八舌 all are talking at once) and chatter without stopping (雞啄唔斷 keep chattering on; rattle on without stopping), which explains why there is a saying 三個女人一個墟 (when women get together they make a lot of noise chattering).

(4) COMMAND

There are occasions when one makes commands to others, such as 躝屍趌路 or 躝屍跕路, both meaning "get out" or "go away".

(5) COMPLAINT

There are people who frequently complain something (呻呢呻嘮 always complain about something; if not complaining one thing, one complains about another), often with a murmur (嘟神咁聲 murmur indistinctly; 拜神唔見雞 bustle in and out with a murmur; complain with a murmur).

(6) CONTRADICTION

People may say something which contradicts with what they say, this is 前言不對後語 (one's remarks are incoherent; one's words do not hang together) or 自打嘴巴 (contradict oneself).

(7) DEMAND

When one makes a huge demand, it is 獅子開大口 (over-demanding) and demands without reasonable awards is described as 一句語該使死人 (make excessive demand on somebody without offering reasonable reward).

(8) EMPTY TALK

Empty talk means when people say something without substance, they just talk but no action will follow. Cantonese idioms for empty talk are空口講白話 (all mouth and no action; boasting; words pay no debts), 口水多過茶 (all mouth and no action; shoot off one's mouth; talk too much; very talkative; wag one's tongue), 見雷響唔見雨落 (all talk but no action), and 煲冇米粥 (all talk; discuss something that will never amount to anything; make an idle talk).

The Cantonese end-clipper for empty talk is冇柄士巴拿 – 得棚牙 (a teapot without a handle – only the spout is left).

(9) EXAGGERATION

Exaggeration is to say something is more than it is. Cantonese idioms have 加鹽加醋 (exaggerate; lay on thicker colours) and 死人燈籠報大數 (pull a long bow).

(10) GOSSIPING

People like to gossip, talking about others' behaviour and things which may not be true. Cantonese idioms for gossiping are搬是搬非 (tell tales), 講三講四 (gossip), and 嗡三嗡四 (chatter away; gossip). People are warned against gossipers 來說是非者, 便是是非人 (the person who speaks ill of others will speak ill of you).

(11) HESITATION

When one halts in speech, one shows one's hesitation. Idioms on hesitation include 半吞半吐(hesitate in speaking), 吞吞吐吐 (hem and haw; hesitate in speech; hum and haw; mince words; mutter and mumble; prunes and prism; say hesitantly; seak in a halting way; speak of things with scrule; speak with reservation; stumbe over one's words; tick over), 依依哦哦 (hem and haw; hesitate in speech; hum and haw; mince words; mutter and mumble; runes and prism; say hesitantly; speak in a halting way; speak of things with scruple; speak with reservation; stumble over one's words; tick over); 而倚哦哦 (shilly-shally).

(12) INNUENDO

Making unpleasant remarks without saying something directly is innuendo. Cantonese idioms are full of insinuating remarks, such as 單單打打 (criticize somebody with strong language; make oblique accusations at somebody).

(13) LYING

Idioms on lying include 禀神都冇句真 (live a lie) and 講大話, 甩大牙 ((to a child) if you lie, your molar will fall off).

(14) NAGGING

Nagging means annoying others or causing others with what one says or complains about, such as 開口及着腳 (annoy others as soon as one starts talking; talk at somebody as soon as one starts talking), 窒頭窒勢 (interrupt with discouraging comments), 頂心頂肺 (be hurt by others by what they say about one; pain in the neck), 含血噴人 (smite with the tongue), and 日鵝夜鵝 (nag day and night).

(15) OATH

Oaths must not be interpreted in a legal sense, for they are made as promises to God. When one takes an oath, God is called to witness it (誓神劈願 swear solemn oath; take an oath and call God to witness). When an oath is realized, one has to thank God for being able to achieve it (還得神落 can redeem a vow to a god).

There are people who take oaths lightly and their attitude is described as誓願當食生菜 (take an easy oath).

(16) PRAISE

When one sings one's own praises, it is 賣花讚花香 (make a boast of oneself; sing one's own praises) and 老鼠跌落天平 – 自己秤自己 (sing one's own praise), believing that one is like 扁鼻佬戴眼鏡 – 冇得頂 (without equal).

When praise is followed by criticism, it is 一啖砂糖一啖屎 (praise is followed by criticism).

(17) PROMISE

Promises are to be kept, not to be broken. When one keeps one's word, it is 牙齒當金使 (always true in word and resolute in deed; as good as one's words; keep one's promise; keep one's word), 講咗就算 (one means what one says), and 講過算數 (a verbal promise has to be kept; as good as one's word; honour one's own words; keep one's word; live up to one's word; one means what one says; true to one's word). When one promises without conditions, one is 托塔都應承 (promise without conditions).

Those who break their promises are said to be 反口覆舌 (break one's promise; inconsistent with what one says), 出爾反爾 (go back on one's words), 打退堂鼓 (back out one's promise), and 三口兩腳 (play fast and loose).

(18) READY TONGUE

People with a ready tongue say something smoothly and easily. Idioms describing ready tongues include 出口成文 (keep a civil tongue in one's head), 出口成章 (keep a civil tongue in one's head), 利口便辭 (have a ready tongue), 倒掛臘鴨 – 滿嘴油 (have a glib tongue), and 倒掛臘鴨 – 嘴油 (just by talking).

A ready tongue is sometimes synonymous with a sweet tongue, which is口甜舌滑 (oil one's tongue; sweet talk) and 花言巧語 (fine words; have a sweet tongue).

(19) REPETITION

To say something again and again is repetition (三番五次 again and again; many a time; over and over again; repeatedly; time after time; time and again; time and time again). It is rather boring to hear something being

said repeatedly (講嚟講去都係三幅被 sing the song of burden; 講明就陳顯南 it is tiresome repetition to make oneself clear; 開口埋口 always talk about; 人講你又講 parrot what other people say).

(20) SCOLDING

Scolding is to speak angrily to somebody who has done something wrong. Cantonese idioms on scolding add finger pointing to them: 篤口篤鼻 (scold somebody with the finger pointing at him) and 篤眼篤鼻 (scold somebody with the finger pointing at him).

(21) STAMMERING

When people say with pauses, they are said to be stammering. Idioms on stammering include 勒勒卡卡 (hesitate in speaking; stammer; stammer out; stumble over; stutter) and 窒口窒舌 (stammer nervously).

(22) STRAIGHT TALKING

When one says something in a direct, honest, and frank manner, one is said to be 快人快語 (a person of straightforward disposition is outspoken; a straight talk from an honest man; a straightforward talk from a straightforward person; an outspoken man speaking his mind; somebody who does not mince his words), 單刀直入 (come straight to the point; speak out without beating about the bush), 開門見山 (come straight to the point; not to mince one's words; put it bluntly), 開明車馬 (open-hearted; state one's intention openly), 心嗰句, 口嗰句 (say what one thinks), 好話唔好聽 (frankly speaking; to be blunt), 灶君上天 – 有句講句 (be frank with one's opinions; outspoken; say whatever one likes), 有碗話碗, 有碟話碟 (call a spade a spade), 直腸直肚 (straight talking), 直腸直腦 (straight talking), 知無不言, 言無不盡 (say all what one knows), and 食齋不如講正話 (it is better to have straight talking).

(23) TALKING

According to grammarians, there is not much difference between "talking" and "speaking" as they carry the same meaning in most situations. In Cantonese, talking, which is rendered as 講, is less formal than speaking, which is 說. This is well illustrated by the idioms beginning with the character "講", such as 講多無謂 (talk is cheap), 講多錯多 (the least said, the soonest mended; the more one says, the more mistakes one makes), 講咁易咩 (it's easy to talk so), 講到做到 (do what one says), 講唔埋欄 (unable to reach a consensus), 講得口響 (fine words; make an unpleasant fact sound attractive; says you; talk fine; use fine-sounding phrases), 講開又講 (by the way), 講就易, 做就難 (easier said than done), 講得出就講 (have a loose tongue), 講起嚟一疋布咁長 (it is like telling a long story), 嘢可以亂食, 說話唔可以亂講 (watch what one says), 冇咁衰講到咁衰 (paint somebody/something in dark colour), and 見人講人話, 見鬼講鬼話 (speak to a saint like a saint, to a devil like a devil), 一講曹操, 曹操就到 (talk of the devil and he will appear), and 吐口水講過 (take back words that are unlucky).

There are other idioms about talking which deserve our attention. When one says something that one does not mean, it is 口不對心 (speak with one's tongue in one's cheek). When one talks at random, it is 紙紮下扒 – 口輕輕 (talk at random). When one says things which are superfluous, it is 老人院都唔收 (one's remarks are too superfluous). When one does not want to mention something, it is 黃腫腳 – 不消蹄(提) (make no mention of something), and when one is forced to keep silent, it is 亞崩劏羊 – 咩都冇得咩 (be forced to keep silence; hold one's tongue).

Talking back is not infrequent, and the idioms for this behaviour are 駁嘴駁舌 (talk back) and 阿吱阿咗 (argue; moan; talk back; whine). And when people talk nonsense, Cantonese people would say that

they are 指天篤地 (sheer rubbish; talk nonsense), 亂嗡廿四 (talk nonsense; talk rubbish), 亂嗡無為 (talk nonsense; talk rubbish), 亂講廿四 (talk nonsense; talk rubbish), 嗡得就嗡 (bullshit), and 聲大夾冇準 (much cry and little wool; talk nonsense).

(24) VULGARISM

The Cantonese dialect is known for its vulgarism. The dialect has a large number of swear words that are used commonly in social discourse, such as conversations, dialogues, and colloquial writings.

The vulgar language used is described as 炒蝦嚓蟹 (use vulgar language), 粗口爛舌 (speak coarse language; use a lot of bad language), and 粗口橫飛 (use a lot of bad language).

Nose

A nose is an organ of smell. All the three idioms related to the nose carry derogatory meanings, including 寃崩爛臭 (smelly; stinking), 臭坑出臭草 (a smelly ditch grows smelly grass), and 唔埋得個鼻 (make a long nose).

Skin

People with smooth skin are well liked and this is reflected in the two idioms on skin, including 青靚白淨 (young, handsome, and have a fresh complexion) and 皮光肉滑 (smooth skin).

Throat

From the throat comes voice and the ability of singing. Voice can be strange (怪聲怪氣 in a strange voice; 鬼聲鬼氣 (1) (陰陽怪氣) speak in a strange voice; strange-sounding voice; (2) speak with a foreign accent), alluring (嗲聲嗲氣 alluring voice), effeminate (𠸏聲𠸏氣 effeminate voice), and soft (陰聲細氣 have a buzz of talk; in a whisper; speak softly and tenderly).

Singing, on the other hand, can be terribly awful, and this is described as 劏豬咁聲 (sing in a terrible way, like a pig being slaughtered).

Tongue

The tongue is for tasting food and producing speech. Cantonese idioms on the tongue include 翻渣茶葉 – 冇釐味道 (as insipid as water) and 牛口+趙牡丹 – 唔知花定草 (cannot appreciate good food; not know chalk from cheese; pigs eating ginseng fruit – no flavour).

The tongue for producing speech is described by the idiom 牙尖嘴利 (have a caustic and flippant tongue; have a caustic tongue; have a sharp tongue).

Tooth

Though teeth serve the important function of biting food, there is only one idiom on tooth, which is 依牙鬆槓 (clench one's teeth).

Womb

An idiom related to womb in a woman's body is 粗身大細 (pregnant).

Non-body topics

Bureaucracy

In traditional China, officials were powerful people who could say whatever they liked (官字兩個口 officials can say whatever they like; speak in bureaucratese) and they protected each other to gain benefits (官官相衛 devils help devils). The officials who were one's immediate superiors were most fearful (唔怕官至怕管 a mouse fears nobody but the cat that would catch it; one's immediate superior is more fearful than the person in charge). Since officials were so powerful, a friend in court could help enormously (近官得力 it is much more convenient to have a friend in court).

Politics, nevertheless, is not an easy game to play. A new official would remove the old staff and replace them by his trusted followers (一朝天子一朝臣 a new chief brings in his own trusted followers). When a new official took his post, he would put in strict measures to exert his authority (新官上場三把火 a new broom sweeps clean; a new official applies strict measures; new brooms sweep clean; 新官上場整色水 a new broom sweeps clean; a new official applies strict measures; new brooms sweep clean). Some officials might be fed up with bureaucracy and wanted to withdraw from it to regain their freedom (無官一身輕 free from office, free from care; without burden, without worriment).

Business

In business management, cost is an important factor. The overheads of a company are known in traditional China as 燈油火蠟 (overheads; running costs of a business). If business is very poor, it is 水靜河飛 (have no business; the market is dull). Some companies would close down, and new companies would be set up (一雞死一雞鳴 successors come forth one after another; when one person leaves a business, another will take it up).

Chances

Chances could be small (大海撈針 look for a needle in a bottle of hay; 萬中無一 most unlikely; 陪太子讀書 bear somebody company; some not given much chance of winning; 年三十晚有月光 it's impossible; 老糠搾出油 get oil out of rocks), great (萬無一失 as sure as a surefooted horse; 穩如鐵塔 as firm as it is founded on the rock; 坐定粒六 be sure about something; have full confidence), or rare (十年唔逢一閏 a chance of lifetime; once in a blue moon; 好水冇幾多朝 there is not much of such a good opportunity in one's life).

People should make the most of an opportunity that comes along to achieve one's goals (無孔不入 seize every opportunity; 順水推舟 make use of an opportunity to win one's end; 順風駛巾+里 avail oneself of an opportunity; trim the sails; 打蛇隨棍上 capitalize on one's opportunity; grasp an opportunity; leap at the chance; leap at the opportunity; seize an opportunity; seize the right time; take advantage of an opportunity; take advantage of the tide; take an opportunity that comes along; take opportunity; use opportunity; 有風駛盡巾+里 avail oneself of an opportunity to the fullest extent; take advantage of an opportunity to the full extent). Otherwise, an opportunity that is missed might not come back (蘇州過後冇艇搭 opportunities never come twice; the opportunity once missed will never come back), and one lets the opportunity slip (捉到鹿唔識脫角 fail to make the best use of an opportunity; let the opportunity slip; miss the boat).

Changes

Things constantly undergo changes. Though things could be fickle (一時一樣 fickle), yet they are based on their origin (萬變不離宗 myriads of changes base themselves on the origin).

People should not adhere to the old ways (一本通書睇到老 adhere to the old ways; be stuck in a groove; cling conservatively to the old system; devote to conventions; follow a stereotype routine; get into a groove; get into a rut; go round like a horse in a mill; inflexible; move in a groove; move in a rut; run in a rut; stay in a rut; stick in the mud; stick to accustomed rules; stick to conventions; stick to established practice; stick to outdated ways and regulations; stick to the old ways) and believe that and nothing is unchangeable (二四六八單 – 冇得變 it is unchangeable).

To make changes, resources are needed; otherwise, changes are impossible (無氈無扇, 神仙難變 no one can make bricks without straw; no one can make changes without resources).

Colour

Idioms on multicolour include 五顏六色 (a riot of colour; colourful; play of colours) and 花花碌碌 (colourful). Idioms on other colours include bright red (紅粉花緋 bright red) and black (黑古勒特 very dark).

Comparison

No comparison would be possible if things are two of a kind (姣婆遇着脂粉客 two of a kind; 一個願打, 一個願捱 well-matched couple; 你唔嫌我籮疏, 我唔嫌你米碎 be two of a kind; 叮噹馬頭 difficult to tell which one has outdone the other; very hard to tell which one is better). Since nothing is the same, comparisons are odious (十隻手指有長短 every bean has its black; 比上不足比下有餘 be worse as compared with the best but better as compared with the worst; 人比人, 比死人comparisons are odious; it is harmful to compare oneself with others; 你走你唧陽關路, 我過我嘅獨木橋 each goes his own way).

When comparisons are made, the difference could be huge (蚊髀同牛髀 by long chalks; no comparison between; one cannot be compared to the other; pale into insignificance by comparison; the moon is not seen where the sun shines; when the sun shines, the light of stars is not seen; when the sun shines, the moon has naught to do; 唔係我嗰皮 not my match).

Competition

The outcome of a competition depends on a number of factors, one of which is strength (石地堂鐵掃把 – 硬打硬 a tortoise pounding a slabstone – a case of the tough confronting the tough). When things are on a par, there is no competition (你有乾坤, 我有日月 be on a par with). There will be competition as soon as new things are created (瘦田冇人耕, 耕嘅有人爭 once a wasteland is inhabited, a rush for an occupation is insisted; 餓狗搶屎 compete against each other for something; 好食爭崩頭 grab it when something is cheap; 多個香爐多隻鬼 the more the competitors, the keener the competition).

The results of a competition sometimes are hard to predict as it is always the tough against the tough (強中自有強中手 catch a tartar) and the locals might lose out to outsiders (猛虎不及地頭蟲 a mighty dragon is no match for the native serpent). Winning a complete victory is 羅通掃北 (make a clean sweep of everything). When one comes out last, it is 包尾大番 (come out last), or 番鬼佬睇榜 – 倒數第一 (the first from the bottom).

Control

Control is not possible if things or people are remote from the authority (山高皇帝遠 run one's own affairs without interference from a distant centre of authority). Nevertheless, everything has its superior (一物治一物 everything has its superior; one thing is always controlled by another; there's always one thing to conquer another; 一物治一物, 糯米治木蝨 one thing is always controlled by another). Sometimes, a

mastermind is in control of everything behind the scenes (幕後主腦 mastermind; 幕後黑手 person who controls everything from behind the scenes).

Dilemma

People are often in a dilemma where decisions are hard to make (兩頭唔到岸 in a situation where whichever way one turns one will lose out; neither sink nor swim in the middle of the sea; on the horns of a dilemma; 兩頭唔受中間受 feather one's nest). People would be in an awkward predicament (左右做人難 be stuck between a rock and a hard place; between the devil and the deep blue sea; between two fires; get into a fix; in a bind; in a box; in a dilemma; in a quandary about; in an awkward predicament; in the middle; on the horns of a dilemma; stand at a nonplus; torn between) and find it difficult to remain impartial (順得哥情失嫂意 find it hard to be partial to either side of the two).

Dirtiness

There are two idioms on dirtiness: 又鹹又臭 (dirty and stinky) and 污糟辣撻 (dirty; soiled) or 污糟邋遢 (dirty; soiled).

Goods

People prefer goods which are cheap but good (又平又靚 cheap but good). But it is always one gets what one pays for (一分錢一分貨 one gets what one pays for). If the name of a piece of goods does not match what it claims to be (貨不對辦 the name does not match the reality; the title and the reality do not tally; unworthy of the name), nobody would buy it (閻羅王手+查攤 – 鬼買 nobody buys).

Rare goods are expensive (物以罕為貴 precious things are never found in heaps). One should not buy goods without seeing them (隔山買牛 buy something without seeing it first) and it would be safer to buy goods from a familiar shop (買生不如買熟 feel secure to make a purchase in a familiar shop).

Order

All Cantonese idioms on order are actually about disorder, which include 七國咁亂 (chaotic; in a disorderly situation; in a very confused and messy situation; messy; very messy), 七零八落 (in disorder), 四分五散 (be rent by disunity; be smashed to bits; be split up; be torn apart; break into pieces come apart at the seams; come to pieces; fall apart; fall to pieces; scattered and disunited; split up), 倒瀉籮蟹 (in a muddle; messy; troublesome), 烏喱馬扠 (illegible and sloppy; in a mess), 烏喱單刀 (chaotic; disorder; get everything mixed up; in a mess; muddled), 烏煙瘴氣 (all in a muddle; foul atmosphere), 鬼五馬六 (messy), 亂晒大籠 (in great chaos; in great disorder), 零星落索 (all in a hideous mess; all upside down; at sixes and sevens; chaotic; everything is upside down; fall apart into seven or eight pieces; in a state of confusion; in disorder; in great disorder; in ruin; in scattered confusion; scatter about in all directions; scattered here and there; scattering), 攕頭撒尾 (always getting things; always losing this and forgetting that; forget this, that, and the other; forgetful; miss this and that), 揦手唔成勢 (be tied up in knots due to lack of preview), and 單筷箸手+化豆腐 – 攪喎晒 (make a mess of things).

People

There are all sorts of people (一樣米養百樣人 many men, many minds; there are all kinds of people in the world; 木蝨狷入花生殼 – 硬充好人(仁) chewing melon seeds with the appearance of a bug – there are all sorts of people): the young and the old (有老有幼 there are the young and the old), famous and titled (有

頭有面 (1) be famous and titled; (2) person with social status), and people on the street (亞保亞勝 every Tom, Dick and Harry; 阿福阿壽 any person in the street).

There might be many people crowding together (人頭湧湧 a mass of people; 人山人海 a sea of faces; huge crowds of people; 聯羣結隊 band together; in crowds; in flocks; in groups; in throngs). There might be people grouping together (三群五隊 in groups; 蛇鼠一窩 a bad group of people; act in collusion with; collude in doing evil; conspire for illegal ends; gang up for evil purposes; gang up with each other; join in plotting reason; play booty; work hand in glove with somebody for evil doings). There might be only a few people (三九兩丁七 only a few people). Regardless of the ways of crowding or grouping, there are good and bad people in every group (樹大有枯枝 there are good and bad people in every group; 樹大有枯枝, 族大有乞兒 there's a black sheep in every fold).

Place

A remote place is said to be 冇雷公咁遠 (remote place), a cool place, 風涼水冷 (cool and comfortable), and a place where people are free to come and go is known as 冇掩雞籠 (a coop without a flap; a place where people are free to come and go).

Quantity

There are different ways to express quantity in Cantonese. A small quantity is expressed by 濕濕碎碎 (miscellaneous and trifling things; miscellaneous trifles; odds and ends; scattered and disorderly), 雞碎咁多 (a few; a little; a small amount of something), 做薑唔辣, 做醋唔酸 (it is far from sufficient for the purpose), and 老鼠尾生瘡 – 大極有限 (there's a ceiling for something). Increases in quantity are expressed by 小數怕長計 (carelessness with small amounts leads to big money problems in the long term), 山大斬埋有柴 (achieve a lot by proceeding in small steps; many a pickle makes a mickle), and such increases are well received (韓信點兵 – 多多益善 the more, the better). Approximation is expressed by 大大話話 (estimate approximately; roughly).

Situation

To the Chinese people, a favourable situation is important to the accomplishment of goals (近水樓臺先得月 in a favourable situation).

Situations may be bad (雞毛鴨血 in a bad situation), acceptable (阿駝行路 – 中中哋 the state of being in the middle), desperate (上天無路, 入地無門 in desperate straits), chaotic (六國大封相 chaotic situation), urgent (風頭火勢 at full throttle; in the state of full blast), or worsening (一蟹不如一蟹 become worse and worse; get increasingly worse; go downhill; go from bad to worse; make bad trouble worse; on the decline; steadily deteriorate; take a bad turn; take a turn for the worse; worse and worse).

When the situation is urgent, illegal means might have to be used (事急馬行田 use illegal means in urgent situations). Very often, a situation is determined by fate (人算不如天算 circumstances often defeat human expectation; man proposes, God disposes; the fate decides all).

Time

Time is precious as even gold cannot buy time (寸金難買寸光陰 gold cannot buy time). Punctuality therefore is much treasured (依時不誤 on time; 依時依候 on schedule; on time; punctual). When one is late, try one's best to make it up, for it is rather late than never (遲到好過冇到 rather late than never; 有心唔怕遲 do something even though they are late; 有心唔怕遲, 十月都係拜年時 it's never too late to do something if you really want to do it; you can pay New Year visits to your friends even in the tenth month

of the year). Sometimes, the latecomer may become a forerunner (遲嚟先上岸 the last comer becomes the first goer).

Weather

Weather in southern China is capricious. It has myriad changes (翻風落雨 when there's any change in weather) and much is under the mercy of God (摩囉差拜神 – 睇天 (小碗吃飯 – 靠天(添)) it depends on the weather; under the mercy of God).

When it is cold, it is known as 幾係幾係, 五郎救弟 (it is considerably cold today). People are advised not to put aside one's winter clothes before the fifth month of the year as weather is so unpredictable (未食五月糉, 寒衣不入櫬 don't put one's winter clothes into the chest before the fifth month of the year).

Women

Women who get together to gossip are referred to as 三姑六婆 (a bevy of shrewish women; gossipy women). Men who are attractive to women, on the other hand, are known as 女人湯丸 (lady's man) or 女人湯圓 (attractive man with many female admirers).

Conclusion

The preceding analysis shows that the Cantonese dialect truly reflects Cantonese culture in terms of what they do and think and how they eat and speak. The relationship between other dialects and other cultures should likely be more or less the same.

9
CANTONESE OPERA

Chan Sau-yan

Introduction

Cantonese opera is a regional genre within the Chinese opera genus that comprises 348 regional styles.[1] Before 1949, the year the People's Republic of China was established, it was the most popular form of performing entertainment among the pan-Cantonese population spreading over the areas encompassing the Pearl River Delta, Guangzhou (formerly Canton), Macau (the Portuguese colony until 1999), Hong Kong, and part of Guangxi Province. Since then, Cantonese opera in Guangzhou has been tied to the political ebbs and flows of the Mainland, and its counterpart in Macau has declined despite it having had a short-lived boom during WWII. In Hong Kong, the Crown Colony until July 1997, the genre has been flourishing since the five years or so preceding the handover of its sovereignty to China. All in all, though ploughing through different paths in the three cities, the overall development of Cantonese opera has been shaped by cultural and political forces.

The evolution of Cantonese opera in the changing identity of Hong Kong

With a current population of about 7.5 million and an ever-growing economy, Hong Kong, among other things, is well-known for its rich variety of performing arts. Professional art bodies like the Hong Kong Philharmonic Orchestra, Hong Kong Sinfonietta, Hong Kong Ballet, Hong Kong Repertory Theatre, Hong Kong Chinese Orchestra, Hong Kong Dance Company, Zuni Icosahedron, and suchlike, all subsidized by the government[2] and together with visiting groups from overseas, jointly present hundreds of productions yearly. Despite that there has never been any government-supported company of Cantonese opera, according to the present writer's estimation, in the 2010s perhaps up to 2,000 Cantonese opera and operatic singing shows are being staged every year[3], which probably outnumber the total deliverables of all eleven government-subsidized groups. In this fashion, Cantonese opera, though receiving grants[4] from a few government bodies, manages to prosper while, up to a certain extent, maintaining its unique identity as a "genre of the people" and proudly surviving on its own feet.

In a nutshell, having forged its modern form and enjoyed its first heydays during the 1920s and 1930s, Cantonese opera suffered a setback due to the Japanese occupation from 1942 to 1945, renewed its vitality in the 1950s, and endured a decline from 1960s to 1980s, but has been flourishing since the mid-1990s. When dealing with the development of Cantonese opera, the present chapter takes into consideration all forms of its dissemination, including commercial and ritualistic performance, research and education, film production, and sound recording.[5]

A number of factors account for the persistent vitality of Cantonese opera. By using Cantonese, the everyday dialect spoken by over ninety percent of the locals, the genre is intelligible to most people and thus touches the core of their cultural identity. Through maintaining its essential role in traditional religious and ritualistic activities, it continues to serve as a functional form of performing arts. By constantly adapting itself to the ever-changing cultural environment, it keeps its tabs on the pulse of its audiences. Above all, when Hong Kong is guided by the central government to evolve into a Chinese city, Hong Kongers uphold their identity by fostering Cantonese opera, a genre unique to Hong Kong. And Cantonese opera together with operatic song are practised and enjoyed by the diaspora of Cantonese-speaking Hong Kong people who now live in many major cities around the world.

1. Brief history and musical evolution

Little is known regarding the early history of Cantonese opera. According to Mak Siu-haa[6] (1904–1941), the esteemed film director, renowned opera playwright and first historian of the genre, in the greater Guangzhou area during the 1850s a certain imported regional style of Chinese opera, probably the predecessor of Cantonese opera, was going native while absorbing influences from regional operas of Hubei and Anhui provinces.[7]

According to the Cantonese opera historian Cheng May-bo, Cantonese opera might have taken its early shape in the 1850s, which saw the emergence of a number of elements that contributed to the identity of Cantonese opera. They included the appearance of native Cantonese artists and local troupes, the use of the Cantonese dialect, the performance tours in the San Francisco area, the incorporation of Western musical instruments, and the use of a singing known as "Canton style".[8]

Having suffered from suppression during and after the Taiping Rebellion of 1851 to 1865, it was not until 1871 that the Manchu government lifted its official ban against the genre, which by then, was known to be sung in a stage dialect close to Mandarin by male and female roles who had nurtured their individual vocal styles.[9]

Like Beijing opera but in a simplified manner, two sub-genres of contrasting dramatic styles, Bong-zi and Ji-wong, each having its repertoire independent of the other, were performed by the same actors in the same troupe. Whereas Bong-zi operas specialized in portraying comical, hilarious, and agitated moods, Ji-wong operas inclined towards melancholy and lamenting sentiments. Nowadays, Bong-zi is essentially a pentatonic scale while Ji-wong is heptatonic; their tonal centres are respectively *saang* and *ho*.[10]

Taking advantage of the tonal inflections of Cantonese words that formed the lyrics, the vocal forms of Bong-zi and Ji-wong derived their melodies, *hong* in Cantonese, from the inflections, and regulated them by modal constraints. Other structural constraints managed to create further unity from regulating the number of syllables in each vocal phrase and line. Apart from a few non-metrical forms that were sung almost in *tempo rubato*, a variety of "pulse patterns" rendering permutations of strong and weak pulses known respectively as *baan* and *ding*, served as the metrical regulator. As a result, all these vocal forms featured the functional and structural elements of "pulse patterns" and "melodies as per inflections" and were collectively known as *baan-hong* (highlighting the roles of *baan* and *hong*) or *bong-wong* (an abbreviation of Bong-zi and Ji-wong).

Since the two strings of the leading fiddle used in the accompanying ensemble were respectively tuned to "*si*" and "*gung*" in Bong-zi passages, Bong-zi and Si-gung were used interchangeably. Similarly, Ji-wong was also known as "*ho-ce*", referring to the tuning.

By the turn of the century, as the growing genre called for new operas that in turn called for new music, the two sub-genres started to merge, probably in two stages. The first saw a new Bong-zi opera written with insertions of Ji-wong acts among the Bong-zi ones, depending on the dramatic situation. The second saw Ji-wong passages inserted into all the Bong-zi acts. In both cases, while the mode of Bong-zi formed the "default" base of the entire opera, vocal forms using the Ji-wong mode must be

specified. For example, with the lyrical form *maan-baan* ("slow strokes on the *baan*") that featuring ten-syllable lines with one-*baan*-three-*ding* cycles, the cue "*maan-baan*" as appeared in a libretto denoted "*Bong-zi maan-baan*", but the passage to be sung in *maan-baan* with the Ji-wong mode must be specified as "*Ji-wong maan-baan*".

A new mode, *faan-sin* ("reversed tuning"), came into use when *Ji-wong maan-baan* was transposed to a register approximately a perfect fourth lower than usual. This new form, entitled *faan-sin ji-wong maan-baan*, also featured highly melismatic setting and extra phrases added to the originally ten-syllable lines that respectively had 3, 3, 2, and 2 syllables in each of the phrases. Subsequently, *faan-sin* mode was also applied to a number of *baan-hong* forms other than *maan-baan*, and to the singing of Tune passages.[11]

With the Bong-wong or Baan-hong Family well established, two more vocal families were added to Cantonese opera at the same time. The Tune Family, composed of tunes from folksong, instrumental pieces and other regional operatic genres, all requisitioned to become vocal passages via the setting of Cantonese operatic lyrics to them, is marked by the unlimited number of syllables in each phrase and line, and by using a variety of modes other than Bong-zi and Ji-wong. The Storytelling Family, comprising a number of traditional Cantonese vocal forms of narrative then borrowed for operatic portrayals, has structural constraints close to that of Baan-hong. With such storytelling forms, the mode of *ji-faan*,[12] which is also known as *fu-hou*, "sorrowful voice", was introduced to Cantonese opera.

2. The 230-year tradition of ritual performance

Nowadays, full-scale and professional performances of Cantonese opera are enjoyed in more than fourteen government halls, a commercial theatre, the Grand Theatre and Teahouse Theatre located in the Xiqu Centre of the West Kowloon Cultural District, and in the temporary theatres built for the ritual series. Ritualistic operas, known as *san gung hei* ("dramas as sacred merits"), are traditionally held in bamboo and tin-sheet structures comprising a stage (and backstage), an auditorium and sometimes a "sacred shed" for housing the statues of the deities concerned. The exceptions are found in the few communities that either hold their ritual series within their local town halls or build marquees with steel beams and fibre canopy for such occasions.

Rarely would a community celebrate its temple festival by staging a single opera; ritual performances invariably come in series, known as *toi* ("stage") lasting from two to six days, featuring one or two operas in each day. Typically, when a fishing community hires a troupe to perform for the celebration of the birthday of their patron deity, the Queen of Heaven, the series start two days before the main day on the twenty-third day of the Third Moon of the lunar calendar, and last for another two afterwards. While the opening day only accommodates an evening show, the following four days respectively feature an afternoon and an evening opera, enabling the series to abide by the tradition of "5-day-9-opera", which only counts the main operatic items but excludes the ritualistic playlets and the overnight shows.

According to Tanaka Issei, the first series of ritual opera in Hong Kong were staged in 1786,[13] probably in front of the Queen of Heaven Temple at Under the Big Tree Village in the Yuen Long area. The troupe hired by the community was most likely not a local one, and the genre it performed was certainly not yet called "Cantonese opera". The main items it staged probably included a number of "abstract opera", which did not have librettos, but were improvised by the actors who referred to an "abstract" that outlined only a story framework. During the performance, they were required to apply singing, acting (including stage movement), reciting and fencing (including martial arts), and had to compose the lyrics extemporaneously. Other than the main items, the troupe had probably staged a number of ritualistic playlets. Required by the locals as essential routines that carry specialized ritualistic functions, nowadays they include *Sacrificial Offering to White Tiger*, *The Prime Minister of Six Kingdoms*, *Birthday Greetings from Eight Immortals*, *Dance of Promotion*, *The Heavenly Maiden Delivers a Son*, and *Sealing the Stage*.

White Tiger is a solemn ritual reserved for initiating a piece of land that has never been used for building an opera stage;[14] *Prime Minister* is intended for showing off the cast and costume of the troupe and for creating a festive bustle;[15] *Birthday Greetings* pays respect to the deities on behalf of the locals; *Promotion* and *Heavenly Maiden* both pray for prosperity and productivity; and *Sealing* closes the operatic series by thanking the deities and spirits.

In 2017, some 230 years later, seventeen communities around Hong Kong staged operatic series for celebrating the Queen of Heaven's birthday, each lasting from two to six days, totalling eighty-one "days" of performance and 144 main operas. Elsewhere, another eight patron deities whose birthdays were celebrated similarly included Hung Sing (God of Sea and River), Tou Dei (Village God), Bak Dai (Lord of the North), Hau Wong (God Marquis), Saam Saan Gwok Wong (Kings of Three Mountains), Gwaan Dai (God of War), Gwun Jam (Goddess of Mercy) and Taam Gung (Lord Taam). Within this year, a total of thirty-four series were staged for celebrating the birthdays of all these deities, totalling 154 days and 270 operas.[16]

In 2017, the birthday of a deity was only one of the four ritual occasions where operas were staged. In Hong Kong, about thirty communities hold elaborate series of Taoist rituals as thanksgiving to the deities and ancestors, and as purification for the neighbourhood, and together with operas as entertainment for the gods, spirits, and fellow folks. Such series, known as Purification Rituals for Peace, are held yearly or once every two, three, five, seven, eight, nine, ten, or sixty years, depending on the local tradition.[17] In 2017, five communities held such ritual and opera series, totalling twenty-three days and forty-one operas.

The other two ritualistic occasions included Purification Rituals for the Ghosts held during the Ghost Festival (one series of 2-day-2-opera) and Thanksgiving to the Queen of Heaven held once a decade (one series of 5-day-9-opera). In short, in 2017, a total of forty-one series, totalling 184 days and 322 operas, were staged by sixteen troupes within the *san gung hei* context.[18]

The regular actors of a ritual troupe are divided into three tiers according to the parts they play. Take a 4-day-7-opera series as an example, the main cast, comprising the six major actors collectively known as Six Pillars, only perform five operas including all the evenings' main items and the matinee of the main day, and two ritualistic playlets including *Prime Minister* and *Heavenly Maiden*. The second cast, comprising another six actors, would support the Six Pillars' performance but take the main roles in the other two afternoon main shows when the Pillars are resting. The "base", comprising usually four female and eight male mute roles, play minor characters like maids, soldiers, and suchlike in all the main and ritualistic items whenever they are needed. An extra tier, the martial artists, only perform in *Prime Minister*; only troupes of a grand scale would require them to stay to take part in the main items that feature martial scenes.

Another important troupe component is the accompanying ensemble. Depending on the scale of the company, the melodic musicians range from four to six with the main cast but only two to three with the second cast. Another three to four percussionists are involved in all main items.

Compared with the seventy-four series with 304 days and about 534 operas staged in 1990,[19] one notices a forty percent drop of *san gung hei* in contemporary Hong Kong within less than three decades. One might attribute this diminution to factors such as the migration and emigration of the local population, the weakening of local traditions, and the increasing costs of hiring operatic troupes and of building the temporary theatres. In some ways, as shows of Cantonese opera and operatic song singing are booming in government halls and the commercial theatres within the urban areas, troupe impresarios often find difficulties in recruiting actors and musicians for ritual productions. Often being held in the countryside or outlying islands and requiring the artists to travel and even overnight at the site, older artists would find such performances tiresome. Yet, some actors and musicians of the younger generations are enthusiastic since ritual series offer them more exposure. For decades, only one single actor from the "base" was assigned to perform in the overnight shows when they were needed. Nowadays, young actors often volunteer themselves for such occasions.

Other than some thirty or so stars who can afford to make a good living without taking up other jobs, the rest of the actors often need other part-time employments, like driving a taxi, giving opera tuitions, offering clerical services, and suchlike for enhancing their income. Comparatively, the average musician often earns more than the average actor as he or she is more sought-after due to limited supply. In 2018, a superstar actor (or actress) makes up to HK$20,000 (about US$2,500) for a day's performance and might be hired for up to more than 100 days. The average star makes about half of that but with up to 200 days; an actor in the second cast makes about HK$800 to $1,000; and a mute actor makes from $400 to $500. As of the musicians' wages, with every four-hour session, a head melodic or percussion instrumentalist makes from $2,000 to $5,000, while the average player is paid from $600 to $800.

3. The 150-year heritage of theatre performance and internationalization

A. Early commercial theatres

About a decade into the British colonization of Hong Kong, and almost seventy years after the first ritual series were staged, the urbanization of Cantonese opera saw the emergence of the first batch of commercial theatres located up the hills from, and in the urban area west of, Victoria, now known as Central District. Daai Loi, Sing Ping, Tung Hing, and Gou Sing theatres inaugurated their business from 1852 to 1870, followed by Pou Hing, Taai Ping, Gau Jyu Fong, and Wo Ping from 1902 to 1919. But it was not until the 1920s that several substantial theatres entered the scene. The Hong Kong Grand Stage (1924), Lee Garden (1924) and Lee Theatre (1925), together with the newly refurbished Gou Sing ("Rising High"; 1928) joined Taai Ping ("Peace") to become the key commercial venues where Cantonese opera would entrench itself from the 1920s to 1950s.[20]

With the infrastructure now ready, and ideologically spurred by the New Culture Movement sparked by the May Fourth Incident of 1919, Cantonese opera, following the footsteps of Beijing opera, would undergo a revolution, partly for winning over the urban, Westernized, and educated audiences, and mainly for proving that the genre is a worthwhile contribution to the new republic. The fledgling Republic of China was then in a life and death struggle against encroaching foreign powers.

To a great extent, what master Mei Lan-fang (1894–1961) had introduced to Beijing opera for improving its scriptwriting, make-up, costume, stage setting, subject matter and patriotism would be copied by the new generation of Cantonese opera stars. Among them, Sit Gok-sin (1904–1956) was the key figure in forging the modern style of Cantonese opera. Even up to the present day, the popular saying "Sit of the south, Mei of the north" highlights the two masters' lasting legacy and contribution to Chinese opera.

B. Sit Gok-sin: founder of modern Cantonese opera

Born and educated in Hong Kong, Sit, unlike Mei, specialized in the young male role. And unlike most opera employees of his generation who entered the profession as pre-teens, he joined his first troupe at the age of sixteen or seventeen. Driven by the imminent dissection of his motherland by the world powers, he was determined to invigorate Cantonese opera as a powerful political tool of disseminating to his compatriots patriotism, anti-British colonialism, anti-economic manipulation by foreign trade consortiums, and anti-Japanese aggression.[21]

To begin with, in order to reach the general public, Sit, by refining the experiments of masters Baak Keoi-wing (1892–1974) and Zyu Ci-baak (1892–1922), fostered a new style of male role singing which featured the Cantonese dialect replacing the traditional Mandarin, and the natural voice replacing the falsetto, with less melismatic text-setting, and in a lower pitch level. In collaboration with his wife, Tong Syut-hing (1908–1955), Sit founded their own company in 1929, and performed operas and made films to promulgate their political causes until the Japanese invasion in late 1941.

C. New role types

Although Cantonese opera was then growing rapidly, the stiff competition among operatic companies had probably resulted in the elimination of quite a number of them.[22] In order to cut the cost of production to stay in business, and for renovating the traditional role types, stars and impresarios joined hands to found the Six-pillar Convention to supersede the traditional Ten-role System, within which old male, painted-face, young male, young female, comic, supporting old male, supporting young male, maid, old female, and the general mute roles would no longer be specialized by any single individual or groups of actor. Partly inspired by Hollywood filmmaking that featured the omnipotent male lead, the foremost Pillar was named Civil-military Male or Principal Male, followed by five more pillars respectively known as Principal Female, Supporting Female, Supporting Male, Comic, and Old Male. As the traditional Chinese operatic system of role types had facilitated past scriptwriters, writers of new operas would now unfold their plots based on these six pillars, who would be supported by the minor roles. However, to live up to their titles, actors of the first four pillars would take up personages who would be young or ageing, serious or comic, civil or military, and heroic or wicked, depending on the dramatic context. Similarly, actors of the comic role would play comical personages who would be young or ageing, civil or military, heroic or wicked, and male or female, and the old male role would play a variety of ageing characters and would even impersonate a female one.[23] The year 1933 saw another major change in troupe organization. Following the Hong Kong government's formal approval, actors of both sexes were allowed to perform together in the same troupe. As a result, the tradition of male actors impersonating female roles began to decline.

D. Script-based operas

As late as in the 1920s, many troupes still lived on a repertoire of "abstract operas". The urbanization and modernization of Cantonese opera would not have been possible without a revolution in scriptwriting. While itinerant troupes, specializing in ritual series held in the countryside, could survive with a small number of script-based operas and a large number of "abstract operas", both enriched by dexterous improvisatory elaborations, the urban audiences frequenting the same theatres increasingly desired new and more sophisticated works. Educated and resourceful playwrights thus came into demand when improvisatory shows were giving place to script-based performance.

The 1930s saw Hong Kong people starting to embrace their unique identity. As Hong Kong Chinese under British colonial rule, they enjoyed territorial security,[24] social stability, and economic prosperity as much as they endured political, social, and racial inequalities, which above all were ubiquitous in the Mainland. As Chinese, they were free to express their patriotism as long as they stifled their anti-British and anti-Japanese sentiments. Culturally, Hong Kong as a melting pot of East and West had become their ideal niche for gleaning and cultivating their values and ways of living. In Cantonese opera, artists had easy access to Western cultural elements that would inspire their revitalization of their art.

According to Mak, the special features of those newly created operas of the 1920s to 1930s included the portrayal of Chinese historical uprisings, as in operas about the Taiping Rebellion and Xinhai Revolution of 1911; adaptations from international masterpieces, like *A Rosy Smile* (1938) from *Romeo and Juliet* and *The Three Earls* (1922) from *Le Comte de Monte Cristo*; adaptations from historical plays of foreign countries, like *Richard the Lionheart*; adaptations from famous films, like *Romance at the Splendid Palace* (1930) from *The Love Parade* (1929); operas in Western costume, like *Platinum Dragon* (1929) adapted from *The Grand Duchess and the Waiter* (1926); and operas in contemporary costume, like *Poisonous Rose* (1935).[25]

E. Combined innovations

The productions of new operas of new subject matters would go hand in hand with musical innovations. Sit, together with Maa Si-zang (1900–1964) and a number of other stars, succeeded in introducing several

Western folk, orchestral, and jazz instruments to the Cantonese opera ensemble; they included violin, saxophone, both the slide and acoustic guitar, trumpet, banjo, piano, and trap set, to be used side by side with traditional Cantonese instruments like *ji-wu* (two-string fiddle) and *dek-zi* (bamboo flute), and with percussions borrowed from Beijing opera. Hence, to this day, a Cantonese opera ensemble is composed of two sections, respectively known as "Western music" and "Chinese music". Moreover, Western tunes were assimilated, new tunes composed and new forms of Baan-hong created. Further enriched by three-dimensional stage setting, electric lighting, the improved face-paintings and costume designs, and martial art and dance movements adopted from Beijing opera and Western drama, Cantonese opera in Hong Kong had reinvented itself. The budding industries of phonograph and filmmaking managed to tap into this rich and popular source of materials, hence hundreds of Cantonese operatic records and movies were made. Cantonese opera of the 1930s had won tremendous support and had reached its unprecedented culmination until the advent of WWII.

F. Tong Dik-sang's legendary success

Once the cousin, brother-in-law, and student of Sit Gok-sin and the script-copyist and disciple of Mak Siu-haa, Tong Dik-sang (1917–1959) emerged in the 1950s to become the hottest playwright, at the time when a number of leading scriptwriters like Fung Zi-fan (c.1907–1961), also one of the mentors of Tong, had resettled in Guangzhou to contribute themselves to the newly founded People's Republic of China. Notwithstanding he only had a two-decade creative career due to an abruptly shortened life, Tong had created over 440 operas with around 100 of them surviving up to the present day. His later works, about twenty of them, having become the core of the contemporary repertoire, have been repeatedly staged. More than eighty films adapted from his operas are re-screened from time to time. Recordings of his pieces sell unnoticeably well, and his masterpieces, *The Floral Princess* and *Purple Hairpin*, both of 1957, are synonymous with Cantonese opera. His representative works, being adaptations from classical Chinese operas, are marked by literary refinement in the lyrics, the intricate but convincing plots, the impressive personages, and the musically enriched vocal passages. Undisputedly, the performance of Tong's works is regarded nowadays as the Rite of Passage for serious artists.

The elevation of Cantonese opera from a mass entertainment to an art form was a mission initiated by Sit, Mak and their contemporaries. Having been interrupted by the Japanese invasion and occupation from late 1941 to August 1945, it was drastically pushed forward by Tong, whose unexpected early demise in 1959 again interrupted the process.

Tong's prolific career would not have been possible without his adoption of an eclectic creative endeavour. In brief, his sources of subject matter included films of both Hollywood and Chinese productions, like *Mount Fuji Romance* (1953) from *Madonna of the Seven Moons* (1945); novels by both Chinese and foreign writers, like *Dreams of the Red Chamber* (1956) from the classical Chinese novel of the same title; dramas East and West, like *Heart Broken When Cherries Are Ripe* (1954) inspired by George Bernard Shaw's *Pygmalion* (1913, adapted into its first film in 1938); other Chinese operatic genres, like *Sylph from the Ninth Heaven* (1958) from a Min opera of Fujian Province; traditional and pre-existing repertoire of Cantonese opera; Chinese storytelling genres; his own earlier works; folktales; and classical works of the Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties, which account for about ten of his best-known works including *The Floral Princess* and *Purple Hairpin*.[26]

G. From Jam-Baak to Co Fung Ming

Notwithstanding that all star actors of the 1950s had benefitted from Tong's works that they commissioned, his operas tailor-made for Sin Fung Ming (Voice of the Celestial Phoenix) Company led by Baak Syut-sin (born 1928) and Jam Gim-fai (1913–1989) are more sophisticated and thus have become more popular.

Baak, daughter of the renowned master Baak Keoi-wing and once the disciple of Sit Gok-sin and Tong Syut-hing,[27] was one of the key figures in the 1950s in uplifting Cantonese opera to becoming a refined artistic genre. Not only is she credited for her persistent demands for quality scripting and painstaking revamps from Tong Dik-sang, but her ingenious premieres of Tong's works, her impressive roles in Tong's films, her exquisite recordings of Tong's masterpieces, and her unflinching efforts in passing on Tong's legacy to her disciples have all brought her unprecedented respect from Cantonese opera fans of Hong Kong and around the world.

Fong Jim-fan (born 1926), another superstar prima donna of the 1950s, had also premiered a substantial number of Tong Dik-sang's works. The Fong Style of singing she founded has become the paragon of female singing among both professional and amateur singers and actors of Cantonese opera in Hong Kong.

Not long after Tong's demise in 1959, Jam and Baak and Fong respectively announced their early retirement. As a result, Cantonese opera suffered its darkest days in the 1960s, which were aggravated by the riots of 1967. In 1965, a band of Jam and Baak's disciples formed Co Fung Ming (Voice of the Fledgling Phoenixes) Company for carrying out their masters' unfinished mission. From 1973 to 1992, led by Lung Gim-sang (year of birth unknown) and Mui Syut-si (year unknown), Co Fung enjoyed sensational success in Hong Kong, Southeast Asia and some American cities. It was the leading troupe in preserving and developing the legacy of Tong and of Sin Fung Ming and was the major force in keeping Cantonese opera alive during its difficult era. At Lee Theatre where they were then based, it was not uncommon to see queues overnighting and bivouacking outside the box office. Though now performing separately, both Lung and Mui are still being embraced as icons and idols.

H. Grand Dragon, New Sound and Cantonese opera in English

Two other glittering stars of the 1960s were Mak Bing-wing (1915–1984) and Fung-wong Neoi (Phoenix Donna; 1925–1992) whose vernacular and comical style had cheered up countless hearts of the grass roots. With their Grand Dragon and Phoenix Company, and later Grand Courting Phoenixes Company, they premiered a series of popular operas such as *Love, Hatred and Endless Love at the Phoenix Chamber* (1962) and *Glamorously Returning to Court the Phoenix* (1965), both deploying amnesia and double identities to unfold the drama, and were adorned by plenty comical improvisations.

Lam Gaa-sing's (1933–2015) Singing the New Sound Company was another leading troupe from the 1960s to 1980s. Featuring abundant martial-art episodes and tuneful vocal passages, his masterworks included *Battling Amidst Thundering Drumming and Airs of Barbaric Pipe* (1962) and *Merciless Swords Under the Merciful Heaven* (1963), among many others. Lei Bou-jing (year of birth unknown), a former partner of Lam and a follower of the Fong Style, is highly respected for her singing that features a refined voice and clear elocution.

In 1947, led by Father Terence Sheridan (1908–1970), staff members and alumni of the renowned Wah Yan College inaugurated their productions of English Cantonese Opera (sic), which features the fitting of English speech and lyrics into the traditional idioms of Cantonese operatic plots, singing, acting, reciting, fencing, and both melodic and percussive accompaniment. Subsequently, with Mr. Wong Chin-wah (1919–2019) serving its artistic director, it has become an iconic genre for charitable fundraising, invariably starring amateur actors who are but socialites, tycoons and government grandees. Strictly speaking, while unique to Hong Kong, it should better be recognized as a genre of English opera bearing strong Cantonese operatic flavours.

I. Global dissemination of Cantonese opera

The signing of the Sino-British Joint Declaration on 19th December 1984 revealed to the people of Hong Kong that their home city would become part of China from 1st July 1997. During the subsequent years,

while many were looking forward to greeting this date, many others chose to resettle in Western cities such as Vancouver, Toronto, Sydney, Perth, London, San Francisco, New York, and in Asian cities like Singapore and Kuala Lumpur. Later, the student upheavals in June 1989 in Beijing also kicked off wave after wave of emigration.[28]

As the Hong Kong general public were facing an identity crisis, the 1980s also saw Cantonese opera employees struggling for survival. With an average of about 420 "days" of annual performance within which about sixty to eighty percent were ritualistic shows,[29] the profession experienced a scarcity of new members and young talents, and many artists had to seek additional jobs or to leave the circle for better income.

As of those who had left Hong Kong for a new world, many of them brought along with them records of Cantonese opera pieces, often those by Tong Dik-sang, as if through them they would cling to their Hong Kong identity. They also organized singing clubs in their new home cities. As a result, the diaspora, continuing up to the present,[30] has enabled the dissemination of Cantonese opera to a number of cities around the globe. For examples, there are about twenty clubs in New York City accommodating about 200 singers of Cantonese operatic song; in Vancouver, around 150 singers are active in fifteen clubs.[31] Though Cantonese opera remains a sub-culture exclusively enjoyed by the Hong Kong community within these cities, it has nonetheless entered the international arena.

J. 1990s to 2010s

As soon as the discourses on the future of their home city had sunk in, especially for those commoners who could not afford a new political identity, Hong Kong people turned their attention to their cultural identity, as if the fostering of Cantonese opera, Cantopop,[32] Cantonese films, and television soap operas would compensate what they would lose after the handover.

A number of government bodies also felt the urge to promote Cantonese opera for meeting the growing demand. Set up in 1995, the Arts Development Council (ADC) is now supporting 10 art forms including Cantonese opera. Under the Home Affairs Bureau, the Cantonese Opera Advisory Committee was established in 2004 to coordinate the efforts of all government and NGO bodies that are involved in the development of Cantonese opera. Founded in 2005, the Cantonese Opera Development Fund has joined ADC to give out one-off project grants to finance the performance, scriptwriting, research, publication, and preservation of Cantonese opera and the training of Cantonese opera artists.

Since 2009, Cantonese opera has been recognized by United Nations Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) as an Intangible Cultural Heritage. The recognition has spurred the Hong Kong government to step up the promotion of Cantonese opera. Also administered by the Home Affairs Bureau, the Lord Wilson Heritage Trust also funds public projects that study and preserve Cantonese opera.

Established in 2000, the Leisure and Cultural Services Department (LCSD) has been the major operational arm of the Home Affairs Bureau in producing Cantonese opera performances and providing rehearsal and performance venues for both professional and amateur bodies. Other than its flagship theatres in Hong Kong City Hall and Hong Kong Cultural Centre which only host Cantonese opera occasionally, another dozen of LCSD's venues regularly present Cantonese opera and operatic song singing. The major ones include Ko Shan Theatre and its New Wing Auditorium where nowadays most of the professional companies hold their shows; and Yau Ma Tei Theatre where since 2012 a training-via-performance programme for nurturing young talents is being run in collaboration with the Bar Wo association. As the work union of Cantonese opera employees in Hong Kong and officially known as The Chinese Artists Association of Hong Kong, Bar Wo, literally "eight harmonies" referring to its original eight member-guilds, was founded in 1889[33] and formally established in Hong Kong in 1953. Currently it also runs a four-year training programme at its Cantonese Opera Academy of Hong Kong.

The theatre at Shatin Town Hall and Kwai Tsing Theatre respectively located in the southern and western New Territories are another two popular venues of Cantonese opera administered by LCSD.

Productions of a grand scale featuring the brightest stars such as Lung and Mui are usually held at the Grand Theatre of Hong Kong Cultural Centre and at the Lyric Theatre of Hong Kong Academy for Performing Arts. The Grand Theatre and Teahouse Theatre in the Xiqu Centre of the West Kowloon Cultural District, both specially designed for Chinese opera performances, are now in use since December 2018. In the future, the Xiqu (literally Chinese opera) Centre will systematically carry out its long-planned programmes of promoting Cantonese opera via productions, training of young performers, preservation of operatic scripts and public education. As of the preservation of Cantonese opera materials, the Chinese Opera Information Centre and University Library of the Chinese University of Hong Kong, together with LCSD's Hong Kong Museum of History, Hong Kong Heritage Museum and Central Library, and the Cantonese Opera Script Archive of Xiqu Centre are housing valuable collections of librettos, costumes, and related historical archives and artefacts. Regularly screening Cantonese operatic films and holding related exhibitions, the Hong Kong Film Archive under LCSD also houses a large collection of Cantonese opera films and documentary files of such movies.

The Sunbeam theatres, opened in 1972 and now comprising a grand and a smaller auditorium, are the only remaining commercial venues devoting themselves to the "revitalization of Cantonese opera", in the words of Li Kui-ming, the famous playwright of thirty-four operas and their entrepreneur since 2012. Other than featuring performances of his own works, Li also hosts Cantonese opera artists from mainland China and rents out his venues to local opera and drama groups and to Cantopop stars.

Throughout the past few decades, the constantly booming property market has torn down the commercial theatres one after one, with the last premium venue, Lee Theatre, being closed in August 1991 and redeveloped into an impeccable mall in 1995. The remaining two, Yau Ma Tei and Sunbeam, have respectively become a government venue and a venture struggling for survival. Should Sunbeam's entrepreneur fail to pay the monthly rent of about HK$1 Million, the theatre complex would probably be turned into a shopping mall or a residential building. In short, the rise of government venues and the decline of commercial theatres, as witnessed, has succeeded in delimiting Cantonese opera and reducing it to a government-dominated mass medium, which will gradually undermine Cantonese opera's traditional identity of being a people's genre.

K. Contemporary training and education

Ever since the British colonization of Hong Kong, its people's identity has become a complicated issue. To the people whom the Manchus handed over to the British, they, as Han Chinese, had become British subjects. On the one hand, while many of them resented the British for having stolen their land, some were pleased that the annexation had spared them from the corrupt Manchu rule. On the other hand, no matter how much they hated or liked the British, few locals would give up their Chinese identity though their China was then ruled by an impotent foreign power. In short, the double identity of Chinese-British was equally liked and hated. It was during the 1930s that a uniquely Hong Kong culture and a unique Hong Kong identity emerged in tandem. Relishing the protection under the British wing, they were spared from the rows between the Communists and Nationalists, and from the Japanese aggression.

During the 1950s, the land reform taking place in China, which led to mass appropriation of private land, properties, and assets, aroused much fear in Hong Kong. Similarly, the Opera Reform that banned the portrayal of emperors, kings, generals, ministers, scholars, and belles from Cantonese opera in Guangzhou scared Hong Kong opera practitioners and fans. In fact, without the freedom of expression as then allowed in Hong Kong, Tong Dik-sang could not have brought Cantonese opera to its second culmination.

During the 1960s, that endless series of devastating political campaign, famine and exodus across the borders of Hong Kong restored complacency among Hong Kong people. In the wake of the Great Riots of 1967, the Education Department discouraged the teaching of Chinese music in schools to avoid it being manipulated as political propaganda.[34] This prejudice was only revoked in the early 1990s when the

Sino-British Joint Declaration had sunk in. As Hong Kong was going to become part of China, and to align with the public's growing interests in Cantonese opera, a revolution in the school curriculum was about to take place.

The first CD-ROM of Cantonese opera, *Cantonese Opera Windows*, was jointly produced in 1997 by Radio 5 of Radio Television Hong Kong and the Music Section of the Advisory Inspectorate under the Education Department. Covering the general history and artistic characteristics of the genre, it was designed for primary and secondary school teachers who would teach Cantonese operatic music in the music lessons. Two years later, with support from the music inspectorate, the Hong Kong Schools Music and Speech Association launched its first Cantonese operatic singing contests in its 51st Music Festival, which attracted hundreds of entries. Since then, this annual event has stayed popular and become the hotbed of cultivating budding talents in Cantonese opera.

As the result of eight years' preparation, the Arts Education Section of the Education Bureau in 2004 published the first Cantonese operatic music teaching kit for primary and secondary school teachers and students. It covers the rudiments of the traditional *gung-ce* notation, the major forms of speech, some well-received tunes taken from the existing repertoire, a number of commonly used stage movement and percussion patterns, and an introduction to the musical instruments, and is supplemented by transcriptions of the selected pieces in both *gung-ce* and staff notations, suggested curriculum designs and classroom work sheets, a glossary of technical terms and a CD-ROM. A second volume, published in 2017, contains eleven short pieces of Cantonese operatic song specially commissioned for the teaching of four commonly used forms of Baan-hong.

The Music Department of the Chinese University of Hong Kong was the first tertiary institution that offered courses on Cantonese operatic music. From 1976 to 2007, its curriculum covered operatic song singing, and the history and theory of Cantonese opera. From 1990 to 2007,[35] the Cantonese Opera Research Programme in the department conducted several research projects and published a series of monographs on a variety of Cantonese opera subjects. Founded in 2000, the Chinese Opera Information Centre in the same department houses a large collection of research materials. Elsewhere, a team of research staff at Lingnan University have been working on a series of substantial projects including the forthcoming publication of *Annals of Chinese Opera (Hong Kong Volume)*, the translation of librettos and a compilation of Cantonese operatic music. In May 2018, the Education University of Hong Kong established Research Centre for Transmission of Cantonese Opera. Currently, the Division of Humanities of the Hong Kong University of Science and Technology is offering the course Cantonese Opera in Hong Kong Culture. In the Chinese University of Hong Kong, the Music Department is offering The Appreciation of Chinese Opera, and the Cultural Management Programme is teaching Cantonese Opera as a special topic.

From 1996 to 1998, the Hong Kong Academy for Performing Arts had offered part-time courses for the training of Cantonese opera actors, before it founded its full-time programmes in 1999. Since then, the part-time and full-time courses ran in parallel until the former's phase-out in 2015. In addition to the pre-existing full-time certificate, diploma and advance diploma programmes for actors and musicians at the Academy, its School of Chinese Opera in 2013 launched the first degree programme with specializations in performance or music accompaniment.

The ups and downs of Cantonese opera in Guangzhou

1. One opera, two styles

As mentioned previously, the 1920s and 1930s were the heydays of Cantonese opera in Hong Kong, Macau and Guangzhou. In 1925, over forty grand troupes were based in Guangzhou, each having over 150 members.[36] The popular ones, known as Canton-Hong Kong Grand Companies, would tour around the theatres in the three cities, while the rest would travel to smaller towns and villages by means of Red Boats.

The 1930s also saw cinemas rising to draw audiences away from the opera auditoriums. In Guangzhou in 1933, twenty cinemas were in operation while only around five opera theatres were actively in business.[37]

Having enjoyed its first heyday during the 1930s when Cantonese opera was like a pair of twin brothers entwining into a single body and were embraced by the pan-Cantonese population of the Pearl River Delta area, the twin brothers in the post-1949 era bid farewell to each other to settle respectively in Guangzhou and Hong Kong to live their individual new lives and to raise their children and grandchildren. In reality, a significant number of Hong Kong practitioners, who aligned themselves with the new China, resettled in Guangzhou. They included a number of leading playwrights like Fung Zi-fan and several prominent star actors and musicians. Especially in the wake of the outbreak of the Korean War (1950–1953) that put China and Britain in antagonism, the embargo against China and closure of the borders between Hong Kong and the Mainland had cut off the exchange between Cantonese opera practitioners of the two places. And for similar but different reasons, another batch of influential figures like Sit Gok-sin, Tong Syut-hing, Maa Si-zang, Hung-sin Neoi (1925–2013), and Gwai Ming-joeng (1909–1958) also left Hong Kong for Guangzhou from 1954 to 1957.

2. Leaving the market for government subsidy

From 1949 to 1950, in Guangzhou and among the Cantonese-speaking towns and villages in the provinces of Guangdong and Guangxi, Cantonese opera was staged by a large number of troupes active in ritual series and by a small number of commercial troupes in the city area. The famous ones were Sing Sau Nin (Year of Longevity), Sing Lei (Victory) and Wing Gwong Ming (Everlasting Brightness). By late 1952, at least twelve self-financed troupes were still actively performing in Guangzhou. The larger ones were Wing Gwong Ming, Sun Sai Gaai (New World), Zyu Gong (Pearl River) and Taai Joeng Sing (Rising Sun), respectively hiring 149, 144, 137, and 117 practitioners.[38]

Following the establishment of the Guangdong Provincial Cultural Bureau in early 1953, two government-supported bodies were founded: Guangdong Provincial Company of Cantonese Opera and Guangzhou Working Troupe of Cantonese Opera. Having requisitioned some of the best artists from the market-based troupes, they staged works in accordance with government guidelines but were independent of the audiences' demand. They were then known as the "elite", "professional" and "national troupes".

3. The opera reform and Anti-Rightist Campaign

Before the 1980s, the Communist Party of China always valued Chinese opera as a powerful tool of disseminating propaganda. The Opera Reform campaign kicked off in 1950 in Beijing soon led to nationwide reforms in the personnel, repertoire and institutional practice among all operatic bodies of all regional genres. In Guangzhou, compulsory reforms had not taken place until 1953. As traditional works highlighting emperors, kings, generals, ministers, scholars, and belles were branded "feudalistic scum" and "poisonous weeds", playwrights were encouraged to create new works for glorifying the new republic, its leaders and workers, soldiers and farmers. This resulted in a whole series of operas that portrayed successful harvests in farming communes, heroic deeds of historical revolutionaries, the defeats of the Nationalists, valiant exploits performed by members of the People's Liberation Army, and suchlike. However, at the time when no draconian measures were enforced by the reform, it was still the traditional plays that drove most of the scriptwriters and drew the majority of the audiences. Yet those audacious playwrights who had defied the reform guidelines were to pay their dues during the Anti-Rightist Campaign in 1957. Among them was Fung Zi-fan. Convicted as an Ultra-Rightist, he was sentenced to labour in a quarry and died there in late 1960 or early 1961.[39]

From 1957 to 1958, as a result of the combined policies derived from Opera Reform, Anti-Rightist Campaign and Great Leap Forward Movement, the various government-supported Cantonese opera

troupes in Guangzhou underwent merges and re-structuring. The reshuffle culminated in the establishment of Guangdong Institute of Cantonese Opera in November 1958, which merged all such troupes into four grand companies and an experimental group, and into another five self-financed companies independent of the Institute.[40]

4. The cultural revolution

The early 1960s also saw a nationwide ban of "ghost operas" and an enforced prohibition of traditional plays. When the film *Untold Story from the Manchu Palace* (released in 1948 in Hong Kong, in 1950 in Beijing), and the Beijing opera *Hai Rui Dismissed* (early 1961), among other operas, were ruled by Green River (Jiang Qing 1914–1991) to be satires against some top leaders of the central government, the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution erupted for removing those deemed recalcitrant.[41]

In order to push ahead her agenda of implementing Modern Revolutionary Beijing Opera to supersede all regional styles, Green River recruited her pawns nationwide. In Guangzhou, at the outset of the revolution, the Red Guards and Rebels raided Guangdong Institute of Cantonese Opera, assaulted the artists and incinerated a majority if not the entirety of the files, librettos, musical instruments, costume and stage sets and props, and the veteran star Hung-sin Neoi was abused severely before being sent to labour in a farm. But she was pardoned and "liberated" by Green River in 1969 to become her agent in overseeing the opera scenario in Guangzhou.[42] Under Hung from 1971 to 1976, many defiant Cantonese opera artists were let go, persecuted or sent to correctional labour in farms and quarries. Since the traditional role types, personages, formulaic stage movement sequences, subject matters, instrumentation, singing, acting, reciting, and fencing were forbidden in the revolutionary operas she promoted on behalf of Green River, what left in the reformed music drama was only the Cantonese dialect. Cantonese opera had literally ceased to exist.[43]

In late 1970s, in the wake of the arrest of the Gang of Four who included Green River, Hung was dismissed, as hundreds of practitioners who had suffered from Anti-Rightist Campaign and Cultural Revolution were reinstated. The open policies fostered by the new leaders at once urged back the traditional plays in Cantonese opera. The genre enjoyed a rebound; citizens of Guangzhou once again packed the auditoriums of the theatres from 1977 to 1980.

5. The post-revolution era

But the rebound was short-lived. From the 1980s, the post-revolution open policies also ushered in China a wide spectrum of imported popular culture. Films, popular song recordings and live shows, karaoke singing, disco dancing, television shows, electronic games, and radio broadcasting were fanatically pursued by the public as the fashionable and "hi-tech" media. At the same time, as the market economy was picking up its momentum, opera companies that used to rely on government subsidies were encouraged to remodel themselves. Now with dwindling financial support, such companies found their survival within a competitive market an onerous task. And as the older generations of audiences had passed away, the auditoriums failed to find their successors. Cantonese opera practitioners faced a painful dilemma: while experimental plays alienated the older ones, traditional plays scared away the youngsters. This resulted in the departure of many veteran artists, some seeking other jobs, some going into a variety of businesses, and some emigrating to Hong Kong and overseas countries. Once again, not only Cantonese opera, but all Chinese operatic genres faced a crisis.

6. The new millennium

From 2000 onwards, inasmuch as the ritualistic opera troupes, about 100 of them,[44] have still been prospering in the countryside around Guangdong, all Cantonese opera shows within the urban areas suffer a

deficit.[45] Though the Guangdong Institute of Cantonese Opera still retains a couple of "national" companies, they are encouraged to compete in the market. The Guangzhou Institute of Cantonese Opera and its opera company, used to receiving subsidies from the municipal government, have become a commercial enterprise since 2009. Among the half dozen privately owned companies now active in the Guangzhou area are Workers' Cantonese Opera Company and Cantonese Opera Company of Young Artists, respectively having forty-five and fifty-seven troupers. Through a downsize of their personnel, quality assurance of their shows, and above all their proactive marketing strategies, they manage to maintain an edge over their competitors.[46]

As the young consumers of cultural products are attracted to the fashionable, international and "hi-tech" forms of popular culture like film, television, pop song and social media, games and other facilities found in the internet, young performing-art talents regard traditional opera as their last priority. Veteran opera artists who passed away and retired have not been succeeded by qualified neophytes, who found the art too demanding and their future career too uncertain. The two government-funded schools of Cantonese opera, Guangdong Vocational Institute of Dance and Drama in Guangzhou and Zhanjiang Institute of the Arts located in the south-western end of the province, both suffer suboptimal admissions.[47]

Since 2009, UNESCO's recognition of Cantonese opera as a form of Intangible Cultural Heritage has urged the provincial and municipal governments to enforce measures to stabilize, preserve, and develop Cantonese opera. As a result, the Chinese Web of Cantonese Opera was inaugurated in 2010, the Museum of Cantonese Operatic Art opened in 2012, the Hatching of New Drama Scheme launched in 2012, and the municipal government kicked off its Cantonese opera revitalisation campaign in 2014. Among all the government and NGO bodies that devote themselves to the promotion of Cantonese opera, the Guangzhou Research Institute of Literature, Art and Creative Works is currently taking a leading role through running the Chinese Web of Cantonese Opera and publishing the bi-monthly *Nan-guo Hong-dou* (Red Beans of the South, the genre's epithet awarded by Premier Zhou En-lai in 1956). Yet, to say the least, it seems such bodies are at a loss in finding effective means to carry out their mission. Many attribute the predicament to the fact that ever since Cantonese opera has been requisitioned by the government to become a channel of propaganda, it has lost its survival skills.[48]

To add one more hurdle to the battle for the preservation and development of Cantonese opera, as a result of the migration of Cantonese-speaking people from Guangzhou to other parts of China, and of the influx of Mandarin-speaking immigrants to Guangzhou from all parts of China, the roots of the genre – its audiences – are being undermined.

If the success of Cantonese opera in Hong Kong could offer any hints, the key to victory in Guangdong perhaps lies in identity. If Cantonese opera could play a sustaining role in the cultural identity of the people of Guangzhou, it would maintain its functional status and would thus be embraced by its people. In order to achieve so, it must be transformed into a refined art form, and its practitioners must be educated and trained to become artists.

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Notes

1 "Findings of the National Survey of Chinese Regional Operatic Genres", uploaded on 26th December 2017, see http://caifang.china.com.cn/2017-12/26content_40120293.htm?f=pad&a=true.

2 Via Leisure and Cultural Services Department under the Home Affairs Bureau, the Hong Kong government currently subsidizes and provides long-term administrative, rehearsal, and performance venues for three orchestras, three dance companies, three theatre companies, a multi-media and cross-genre group, and a company of Western opera. Totalling eleven, these bodies are commonly known as the "professional art groups".
3 Take 2014 as an example, the present writer, based on data recorded in *Hong Kong Xiqu Yearbook 2014* and provided by the Hong Kong Hikers' website that lists schedules of ritual performance, counted a total of 1,256 Cantonese opera shows, excluding operatic song concerts, fully or partly staged by professional artists.
4 Only non-profit-making Cantonese opera companies are entitled to such subsidies. Hence most commercial troupes refrain from the application for such grants.
5 The historian Ng Wing-chung points out that the decline in Cantonese opera performance, due to over-expansion of some of the grand troupes, started as early as from 1928 to 1932; Chan Fei-nong suggests 1938 was the onset of the downturn. Taking into consideration that the setback in theatrical performance was compensated by the boom in Cantonese opera phonograph recordings and films, the present writer maintains that the 1930s were still the heydays of Cantonese opera. See Ng 2015: 62–71; Ng and Chan 2007: 176–81.
6 The Romanization of most of the Cantonese names in this chapter is based on the system designed by Linguistic Society of Hong Kong.
7 See Mak 1940: 10.
8 See Cheng 2008: 125–28.
9 See Mak 1940: 10.
10 The scale of Bong-zi mode is "*saang, ce, gung, ho, si, saang*" while that of Ji-wong is "*ho, si, ji, saang, ce, gung, faan, liu",* where "*ji*" can be slightly lower than "*ti*" and "*faan*" slightly higher than the "*fa*" of the Western major diatonic scale. In both modes, *saang* is tuned as C. Generally speaking, while most vocal forms in both modes are pentatonic, *kwan-faa* ("rolling flower") in Ji-wong stands out to be heptatonic.
11 Nowadays the scale of *faan-sin* mode is "*ho, si, ji, saang, ce, gung, faan, liu*", where "*ji*" can be slightly lower than "*ti*", "*faan*" slightly higher than the "*fa*" of the Western major diatonic scale, and *saang* is tuned as G.
12 Nowadays the scale of *ji-faan* mode is "*ho, ji, saang, ce, faan, liu*", where "*ji*" can be slightly lower than "*ti*", "*faan*" slightly higher than the "*fa*" of the Western major diatonic scale, and saang is tuned as C.
13 As quoted in Chan et al. 2008: 6.
14 *White Tiger* is also required for the initiation of any new theatre; see Chan et al. 2008: 55–73.
15 Unlike the rest, *Prime Minister* had once been as elaborate as a full-scale "main operatic item". Nowadays only shortened versions are performed in ritualistic series.
16 See Chan and Cham 2018:10–13.
17 Other than these thirty communities, it is estimated that around another ten that hold Purification Rituals do not at the same time offer opera.
18 See Chan and Cham 2018:10.
19 See Chan et al. 2008: 162–163.
20 See Cheng 2013: 1–31; Judith Ng 2015: 98–117. While both authors note that the first theatre came into business in 1865, Ng points out there was probably another one built in as early as 1852.
21 See Lai 1993: 6–15.
22 See Ng Wing-chung 2015: 73–77.
23 The titles of the first three pillars were then new inventions. Though using titles borrowed from traditional role types, the supporting male, comic, and old male also take up additional artistic duties. For example, known as *siu-sang* (young male) in Cantonese, Supporting Male was a de facto "deputy principal male".
24 Throughout the 1930s and up to the British surrender in late 1941, many locals assumed the Crown Colony was impregnable.
25 As quoted in Chan 2016: 13–14.
26 See Chan 2016: 115–21.
27 The disciples of Tong Syut-hing all bore the syllable "Syut" ("snow") in their stage-names, and so do the disciples of Baak Syut-sin.
28 It is estimated that around 800,000 had left Hong Kong during the period from 1984 to July 1997. See "Emigration Generation: Will Hong Kong Experience Another Brain Drain?" posted in the internet on 8th November 2016. The figure accounted for over ten percent of the total population of about six million by then.
29 See Chan 1991: 4.
30 According to the Security Bureau, around 6,500 people left Hong Kong in 2017. According to a survey conducted by the Chinese University of Hong Kong, in 2011, over sixty-five percent of the Hong Kong permanent residents desired to migrate to other countries. See Wikipedia.

31 The present writer wants to thank Mr Preston Lai and Ms Suk Lee, respectively noteworthy singers of Vancouver and New York City, for their preliminary surveys and estimations.
32 In fact, the first generations of Cantopop were excerpts from Cantonese opera of the 1950s.
33 See *Introduction to the Vocal Music of Cantonese Opera*, 1999: 4.
34 As told by Dr Cham Lai Suk-ching, formerly Principal Inspector of Education Department, which has been renamed as Education Bureau.
35 The resignation of Prof. Chan Sau-yan in January 2008 prompted a short suspension of the courses and research on Cantonese opera.
36 See Ng and Chan 2007: 157.
37 See Ng 2015: 66.
38 See Leung 2006: 40–44.
39 See Ho 1993: 245.
40 See Leung 2006: 101–104.
41 See Li 1993: 181–96, 221–22.
42 See Hung 1985 (Book I): 165–168; 1985 (Book II): 2–15.
43 See Hung 1985 (Book II): 44–46.
44 As no conclusive data is yet available, this was told by Wen Ru-qing, a leading young actor of the Second Company of Guangdong Institute of Cantonese opera in an interview on 23rd June 2019.
45 See Luo 2016: 100.
46 See Luo 2016: 104–5.
47 As told by Wen Ru-qing; see note 44.
48 See Luo 2016: 98, 103. This also suggests that Cantonese opera artists of Hong Kong should not over rely on government subsidies.

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10

CHINESE CULTURE IN POPULAR SAYINGS AND FAMOUS QUOTES

Chan Sin-wai

Introduction

Chinse culture can be reflected, to a great extent, by Chinese popular sayings and famous quotes as it is generally acknowledged that the richness and beauty in the popular sayings and famous quotes in Chinese literature and culture are most representative of the mind and spirit of the Chinese people.

As we know, sayings and quotes are used by people of all walks of life in China as a common way to express themselves with a kind of flavour. In the long history of Chinese civilization, a huge amount of sayings and quotes has been created by different people in different ages and by different authors in different genres of writings. This is well described by Larry Herzberg in his article that came out in 2016:

> China is the world's oldest continuous civilization, with over 3,000 years of history. It is, therefore, hardly surprising that the Chinese language is particularly a rich source of wisdom. Arguably no other language or culture has such a huge treasure trove of proverbs and popular sayings that comment on every aspect of the human experience. There are as many as 20,000 literary idioms and tens of thousands of popular maxims and sayings, in addition to the pithy and profound quotes to be gleaned from three millennia of Chinese philosophy and literature.
>
> *(Herzberg 2016: 295)*

This being the case, it is not surprising to find that the use of popular sayings and famous quotes has become a common occurrence in conversations and writings of the Chinese people and understanding them is an effective way to understand Chinese culture.

Definitions of "popular sayings" and "famous quotes"

It is perhaps necessary, at the outset, to define "popular sayings" and "famous quotes". In this dictionary, "popular sayings" refer to common sayings, proverbs, end-clippers, and slang. It does not include "idioms" (成語 *chengyu*), which usually have four characters and stories behind them, known collectively as "literary idioms" (e.g. 朝三暮四, originates from the chapter "On the equality of things" in *Zhuangzi*《莊子》, meaning "keep changing one's mind"). As Chinese idioms are easily found in general dictionaries, they have not been included in this dictionary. Common sayings (俗語 *suyu*) are sayings passed down through many generations by the "common people" and they have no set length or form (e.g. 說是一回事, 做是另一回事 To say is one thing, to practice is another). Proverbs (諺語 *yanyu*) are short pithy sayings that

express traditionally held truths or pieces of advice, based on common sense or experience (好頭不如好尾 A good beginning is not as good as a good ending). It can be seen that very often, common sayings are interchangeable with proverbs as their distinctions are sometimes hard to make. End-clippers (歇後語*xiehouyu*) are Chinese metaphorical folk sayings made up of two parts, with the first part leading to the intended meaning in the second, usually with the play of words or sound (e.g. 貓哭老鼠 – 假慈悲 The cat cries over a dead mouse – hypocritical). Slang is informal language or words used by a particular group of people or community (e.g. 狗吃屎，狼吃人 Dogs eat turds, wolves eat people).

"Famous quotes", on the other hand, refer to the most frequently quoted phrases, lines, and expressions from well-known works, famous authors, celebrities, or newsmakers, which are generally inspirational in nature (e.g. 萬般皆下品，惟有讀書高 All pursuits are base, book-learning is exalted, originated from 汪洙：〈神童詩〉 Wang Zhu: "Poem of a talented boy").

An analysis of Chinese culture

Chinese culture is analyzed through a dictionary that has been prepared by this author. It has popular sayings and famous quotes and 417 topics and 6,441 entries. The topics and entries provide an adequate basis to reveal how the Chinese people live, behave, think, and do things.

Topics

The following is a table showing the topics with more than 50 entries, in descending order.

Table 10.1 Topics of Chinese culture with more than 50 entries

Topic	*Number of entries*
Talking	99
Gentleman	83
Learning	75
Money	73
Official	69
Doing things	68
Wine	68
People	59
Heart	57
Knowledge	55
Family	54
Wealth	54
Good and evil	54
Governance	53
Life	53
Love	53
Reputation	53
Death	51
Effort	51
Flower	50

The table reflects the importance the Chinese people attach to these areas and it also shows that the preferences of the Chinese people may be different from people of other cultures, such as "Gentleman" 君子 being ranked second in the list. From the table, we understand that how people say things, behave in a

gentlemanly way, acquire learning, and make money are of great concern to the Chinese people. Perhaps we could discuss these popular issues more deeply.

Talking

The Chinese people place great emphasis on the way they talk, what should be talked about, how to avoid offending others in their talking, and how to judge a person by his speech. All these are to a certain extent illustrated by the following quotes.

How to talk

長話不可短說。
A long story cannot be told short.

俗語 Common saying

處世戒多言，言多必失。
In conducting yourself in society, do not talk more than is necessary, otherwise there will be slips in what you say.

朱用純：《朱子家訓》Zhu Yongchun: *Percepts of the Zhu Family*

打開天窗說亮話。
Not to mince one's words.

俗語 Common saying

對啥人說啥話。
Say the right thing to the right person.

俗語 Common saying

What should be talked

粗話無害，甘言無益。
Hard words are harmless and fine words are of no benefit.

諺語 Proverb

多言數窮，不如守中。
Talking much is exhaustive, and it would be better to keep things to oneself.

老子：《道德經》Laozi: *Daodejing*

多嘴討人厭。
Loquacity is disgusting.

俗語 Common saying

逢人且說三分話，未可全拋一片心。
When you talk to people, you tell them a small part of what you want to say, don't tell them all what is really on your mind.

《增廣賢文》*Words that open up one's mind and enhance one's wisdom*

可與言而不與之言，失人；不可與之言而與之言，失言。
If you don't talk to somebody whom you can talk to, you lose the person; if you talk to somebody whom you cannot talk to, you waste your words.

孔子：《論語.衛靈公篇第十五》Confucius: Chapter 15, *The analects of Confucius*

Not to offend others in speech

說者無心，聽者有意。
The speaker has no particular intention in saying something, but the listener reads his own meaning into it.

俗語 Common saying

喜時之言多失信，怒時之言多失體。
One often breaks his promise that he makes when happy, and he often speaks in inappropriate terms when angry.

鄭瑄：《昨非庵日纂.卷一二口德》Zheng Xuan: Chapter 12, "Propriety in speech", Daily records of Zheng Xuan

Judge a person by his speech

不以言取人，不以言廢人。
Don't accept a person by his words or reject a person by his words.

孔子：《論語.衛靈公篇第十五》Confucius: Chapter 15, *The analects of Confucius*

Gentleman

"Gentleman" (*junzi* 君子) is a central concept in Confucianism. According to Confucius, Mencius and other Confucian scholars, a gentleman, in stark contrast to a "petty man" (*xiaoren* 小人), is one who is courteous, dignified, prudent, honest, virtuous, fearless, loyal, obedient, learned, forgiving, supportive, well-disciplined, and can live with poverty. Popular quotes related to some of the above characteristics of a "gentleman" are given below.

Courteous

君子敬而無失，與人恭而有禮。
A gentleman maintains reverence without errors, and is courteous and polite to others.

孔子：《論語.顏淵篇第十二》Confucius: Chapter 12, *The analects of Confucius*

Dignified

君子不重則不威。
If a gentleman does not behave with dignity, he will not command any respect.

孔子：《論語.學而篇第一》Confucius: Chapter 1, *The analects of Confucius*

君子矜而不爭，群而不黨。
A gentleman is dignified and not quarrelsome. He is sociable but not cliquey.

孔子：《論語.衛靈公篇第十五》Confucius: Chapter 15, *The analects of Confucius*

君子泰而不驕，小人驕而不泰。
A gentleman is dignified but not proud whereas a petty man is proud but not dignified.

孔子：《論語.子路篇第十三》Confucius: Chapter 13, *The analects of Confucius*

Fearless

君子不懼不惧。
A gentleman neither worries nor fears.

孔子：《論語.顏淵篇第十二》Confucius: Chapter 12, *The analects of Confucius*

君子不憂不懼。
A gentleman does not worry about or be afraid of anything.

孔子：《論語.顏淵篇第十二》Confucius: Chapter 12, *The analects of Confucius*

Forgiving

君子不念舊惡。
A gentleman forgives the past wrong doings of others.

孔子：《論語.公冶長篇第五》Confucius: Chapter 5, *The analects of Confucius*

Honest

君子不宛言而取富，不屈行而取位。
A gentleman does not get wealth by blandishing words nor get an official position by dishonest acts.

戴德：《大戴禮記.曾子制言中》Dai De:"Zengzi about behaviour, Part 2", *Records of rites by Dai the Elder*

Learned

君子博學於文，約之以禮。
A gentle is widely versed in culture and bound by the rites.

孔子：《論語.雍也篇第六》Confucius: Chapter 6, *The analects of Confucius*

君子不羞學，不羞問。
A gentleman is not ashamed to learn from or consult with others.

劉向：《說苑.卷十六談叢》Liu Xiang: Chapter 16, "The thicket of discussion", *Garden of persuasion*

君子好學不厭，自強不息。
A gentleman is eager to learn and not tired of learning and makes ceaseless efforts to strengthen himself.
司馬光：《司馬文正公集》Sima Guang: *Collected works of Sima Guang*

Live with poverty

君子安貧，達人知命。
A gentleman can be contended with poverty and a discerning person knows his lot.

《增廣賢文》*Words that open up one's mind and enhance one's wisdom*

君子固窮，小人窮斯濫矣。
A gentleman stands firm in poverty while a petty man will lose his self-control in poverty.

孔子：《論語.衛靈公篇第十五》Confucius: Chapter 15, *The analects of Confucius*

君子憂道不憂貧。
A gentleman is worried about the Way but not poverty.

孔子：《論語.衛靈公篇第十五》Confucius: Chapter 15, *The analects of Confucius*

Prudent

君子食無求飽，居無求安，敏於事而慎於言。
A gentleman does not seek for a full stomach when eating, comfort in living, but he is earnest in doing things and cautious in what he says.

孔子：《論語.學而篇第一》Confucius: Chapter 1, *The analects of Confucius*

君子於其言，無所苟而已矣。
A gentleman is concerned about there being no slips in what he says.

孔子：《論語.子張篇第十九》Confucius: Chapter 19, *The analects of Confucius*

Supportive

君子成人之美，不成人之惡。
A gentleman helps others to achieve their goals and he does not help others to achieve what is bad.

孔子：《論語.顏淵篇第十二》Confucius: Chapter 12, *The analects of Confucius*

君子莫大乎與人為善。
The greatest attribute of a gentleman is his helping people to do good deeds.

孟軻：《孟子.公孫丑上》Meng Ke: Chapter 2, Part 1, *Mencius*

君子周急不繼富。
A gentleman helps those in urgent needs but does not add wealth to the rich.

孔子：《論語.雍也篇第六》Confucius: Chapter 6, *The analects of Confucius*

Virtuous

德勝才，謂之君子。
He whose virtue is better than his talent is known as a gentleman.

司馬光：《資治通鑒.周紀》Sima Guang: "Annals of the Zhou dynasty", *Comprehensive mirror to aid in government*

君子懷德，小人懷土。
A gentleman cherishes virtue, whereas a petty person, land.

孔子：《論語.里仁篇第四》Confucius: Chapter 4, *The analects of Confucius*

君子以果行育德。
A gentleman acts resolutely to nourish virtue.

《易經.蒙.象》"Image", Hexagram *meng*, *The book of changes*

We can gather from the preceding that of all the Confucian concepts related to the "gentleman", which must be numerous, the virtues mentioned are of the greatest concern to the Chinese people.

Learning

Learning is greatly revered in China. Learning is considered by the Chinese people as one of the most effective ways to cultivate one's personality, climb the ladder of success through the civil service examination, and gain fame and status through one's literary writings. It is generally believed that diligence in learning and devotion to study will help one attain one's goal in life.

This mentality is manifested to a great extent by the following saying, which is:

書中自有黃金屋，書中自有顏如玉。
In books there are houses made of gold and women as beautiful as jade.

趙恒：〈勵學篇〉Zhao Heng: "Encouragement to learning"

Other popular quotes related to learning are given in the following.

Breath in learning

博學而不窮，篤學而不倦。
Learn extensively and never end; practice resolutely and never feel tired.

《禮記.儒行第四十一》Chapter 41, "The conduct of a Confucian scholar", *The book of rites*

學不必博，要之有用。
Learning does not need to be comprehensive, for what is important is that it is useful.

羅大經：《鶴林玉露.學仕》Luo Dajing: "Learning and officialdom", *Jade dews of the Crane Forest*

Devotion to learning

凡學，必務盡業，心則無營。
In learning, one must make one's utmost efforts to progress and one's mind should not go astray.

呂不韋：《呂氏春秋.勸學》Lu Buwei: "Exhortation to learning", *Master Lu's Spring and Autumn Annals*

Difference between learning and not learning

苟不學，曷為人。
If you do not learn, how can you behave like a decent person?

王應麟：《三字經》Wang Yinglin: *Three-character classic*

好學者如禾如稻，不學者如蒿如草。
A person who is fond of learning is like a grain of rice, and a person who does not like learning is like wormwood or weed.

《增廣賢文》*Words that open up one's mind and enhance one's wisdom*

人學始知道，不學亦枉然。
A person who begins to learn knows what is the proper way and a person who does not learn will live a life in vain.

《增廣賢文》*Words that open up one's mind and enhance one's wisdom*

Diligence in learning

古人學問無遺力，少壯工夫老始成。
The ancient people spared no efforts in learning because the efforts they made when young would begin to materialize when old.

陸游：〈冬夜讀書示子聿〉Lu You: "For my son when reading books on a night in winter"

人不學，不如物。
He who does not learn is not as good as an animal.

王應麟：《三字經》Wang Yinglin: *Three-character classic*

學問勤中得。
Learning is acquired through diligence.

汪洙：〈神童詩〉Wang Zhu: "Poem of a talented boy"

Goal of learning

大學之道，在明明德，在親民，在止於至善。
The way of great learning lies in displaying enlightened virtue, loving the people, and coming to rest in the utmost goodness.

《禮記.大學第四十二》Chapter 42, "The great learning", *The book of rites*

古之學者為己，今之學者為人。
Scholars in ancient times studied for self-improvement whereas scholars today study to serve other people.

孔子：《論語.憲問篇第十四》Confucius: Chapter 14, *The analects of Confucius*

Process of learning

夫學者猶種樹也，春玩其華，秋登其實。
Learning is like planting trees, allowing us to enjoy their flowers in spring and harvest their fruits in autumn.

顏之推：《顏氏家訓.勉學》Yan Zhitui: "Exhortation to learning", *Family instructions of Master Yan*

君子之學也，入乎耳．箸乎心。
The learning of a gentleman is such that it enters through his ears and stored in his mind.

荀況：《荀子.勸學第一》Xun Kuang: Chapter 1, "Exhortation to learning", *Xunzi*

學而不己，闔棺乃止。
Learning is ceaseless and it ends when one is encased in coffin.

韓嬰：《韓詩外傳.卷八》Han Ying: Chapter 8, *The outer commentary to the Book of songs by Master Han*

Teachers and learning

古之學者必有師。
Those who learned in ancient times must have teachers.

韓愈：《昌黎先生集.師說》Han Yu: "On teaching", *Collected works of Han Yu*

Money

It is true that Buddhism and Confucianism warn people of the evils of desires, particularly desires of wealth, yet from the quotes in this dictionary, it is found that the Chinese people truly know that without money,

one cannot get what one wants. Money has always been an important part of their life. Some view money negatively, others, positively.

Attraction of money

青酒紅人面，財帛動人心。
Good wine reddens the face of a person while money excites one's heart.

諺語 Proverb

西周生：《醒世姻緣傳.第十二回》Xi Zhousheng: Chapter 12, *Stories of marriage to awaken the world*

Contempt on money

財物糞土輕，仁義泰山重。
Money and property are light as refuse whereas benevolence and righteousness, heavy as Mount Tai.

西周生：《醒世姻緣傳.第三十四回》Xi Zhousheng: Chapter 34, *Stories of marriage to awaken the world*

多金非為貴，安樂值錢多。
Much money is of little value, peace and contentment are worth great wealth.

佚名：《名賢集》Anonymous: *Collected sayings of famous sages*

銀錢如糞土，臉面值千金。
Money is but dirt but the sense of shame is worth one thousand taels of gold.

崔復生：《太行志.第二十四章》Cui Fushen: Chapter 24, *Records of Taixing*

Evils of money

金錢為萬惡之源。
Money is the source of all evil things.

俗語 Common saying

Greed for money

人心節節高於天，越是有錢越愛錢。
Man is insatiably greedy; the more money one has the more one wants.

諺語 Proverb

Happiness with money

有錢萬事足。
One is satisfied with everything when he has money.

茅盾：《霜葉紅似二月花.第五章》Mao Dun: Chapter 5, *The frosty leaves are red as flowers in the second month of the year*

有錢像條龍，無錢變條蟲。
When one has money, one is like a dragon. When one does have money, one is like a worm.

諺語 Proverb

Necessity of money

燈裏無油點不亮，手裏無錢難煞人。
A lantern without oil cannot be lit bright. A person without money in his hand is hard pressed.

俗語 Common saying

Power of Money

可以使鬼者錢也，可以使人者權也。
It is money that can make the mare go and it is power that can order people about.

楊慎《丹鉛總錄.卷七》Yang Shen: Chapter 7, *Complete records of proofreading*

錢聚如兄，錢散如奔。
When you have money, people treat you as an elder brother; when you don't, people run away from you.

諺語 Proverb

佚名：〈來生債.第一折〉Anonymous: Scene 1, "The debt in the future life"

天下道理千千萬，沒錢不能把事辦。
There are thousands of hows and whys, but without money you can do nothing.

俗語 Common saying

崔復生：《太行志.第七章》Cui Fusheng: Chapter 7, *Records of Taixing*

瞎子見錢眼也開，和尚見錢經也賣。
Money will open a blind person's eyes and will make a monk sell his prayer book.

諺語 Proverb

曹玉林：《蘇醒的原野.第二章》Cao Yulin: Chapter 2, *The awaken plain*

有錢道真語，無錢語不真。
What is said by the rich is believed and what is said by the poor is not.

《增廣賢文》*Words that open up one's mind and enhance one's wisdom*

Spending of money

錢要花在刀刃上。
Money should be used on where it is needed most.

俗語 Common saying

使錢容易賺錢難，莫把銀錢作等閒。
It is easy to spend money but difficult to earn it, so you should not make light of money.

諺語 Proverb

張三有錢不會使，李四會使卻無錢。
Some have money but they do not know how to use it; others have no money, yet they know how to use it.

諺語 Proverb

錢希言：《戲瑕.卷三》Qian Xiyan: Chapter 3, *Jokes about flaws*

Sources cited

The sources of all the entries of the popular sayings and famous quotes are listed and translated in this dictionary. The task of tracing and translating the sources of all the entries is daunting. It needs considerable efforts in researching and re-searching the sources and putting them into the target language.

There are 2,576 entries of popular sayings, and 3,865 entries of famous quotes, which means that around forty percent of the entries are sayings, and the remaining sixty percent, quotes.

A breakdown of the sources of popular sayings is given below:

Table 10.2 Sources of popular sayings

Sources of popular sayings	*Number of entries*
Common sayings	1,544
Proverbs	923
End-clippers	101
Slang	8

It can be seen that there are 2,467 entries from common sayings and proverbs, making up ninety-six percent, whereas end-clippers and slang take up just four percent. In other words, most of things people in China say are common sayings and proverbs and they seldom use end-clippers and slang to express themselves.

For famous quotes, they come from a large number of sources, involving a large number of authors and a wide range of works in different ages. There are, nevertheless, some works which are more frequently quoted than others, which are given in the following table.

These twenty-six works with over twenty entries in the dictionary show that Confucian concepts shape the thinking and behaviour of the Chinese people in a great way. A brief study of the five top-listed works would allow us to have a better understand of the listing.

Table 10.3 Sources of famous quotes

Sources of famous quotes (Works)	*Number of entries*
《論語》*The analects of Confucius*	216
《增廣賢文》*Words that open up one's mind and enhance one's wisdom*	205
《孟子》*Mencius*	133
《道德經》*Daodejing*	112
《紅樓夢》*A dream of the red chamber*	110
《禮記》*The book of rites*	97
《史記》*Records of the Grand Historian*	88
《莊子》*Zhuangzi*	82
《左傳》*Zuo's commentary on the Spring and Autumn Annals*	68
《水滸傳》*Outlaws of the marshes*	55
《西遊記》*Journey to the West*	52
《易經》*The book of changes*	51
《金瓶梅》*The plum in the golden vase*	49
《三國演義》*Romance of the Three Kingdoms*	46
《荀子》*Xunzi*	44
《醒世恒言》*Stories to awaken the world*	41
《淮南子》*Huainanzi*	38
《詩經》*The book of odes*	37
《孫子兵法》*The art of war by Sunzi*	33
《戰國策》*Strategies of the warring states*	32
《尚書》*The book of history*	30
《韓非子》*Hanfeizi*	27
《後漢書》*History of the Later Han*	26
《警世通言*Stories to caution the world*	23
《儒林外史》*An unofficial history of the world of literati*	23
《三國志》*Records of the Three Kingdoms*	22

The analects of Confucius

The Analects of Confucius《論語》, which has 216 entries, is the most cited work in this dictionary. It is a collection of sayings and ideas attributed to Confucius and the work was compiled and written by his disciples. Central to Confucianism are concepts of moral cultivation through benevolence (*ren*仁), respect for others, and behave in the way of a gentleman (*junzi*). Some of the popular quotations from *The Analects of Confucius* are given here as examples.

己所不欲，勿施於人。
Do not impose on others what you yourself do not desire.

孔子：《論語.衛靈公篇第十五》Confucius: Chapter 15, *The analects of Confucius*

志士仁人，無求生以害仁，有殺身以成仁。
People of ambitions and benevolence do not harm benevolence for life, but sacrifice life to accomplish benevolence.

孔子：《論語.衛靈公篇第十五》Confucius: Chapter 15, *The analects of Confucius*

非禮勿視，非禮勿聽，非禮勿言，非禮勿動。
Do not look if it is not in accordance with the rites; do not listen if it is not in accordance with the rites; do not speak if it is not in accordance with the rites; and do not move if it is not in accordance with the rites.

孔子：《論語.顏淵篇第十二》Confucius: Chapter 12, *The analects of Confucius*

有朋自遠方來，不亦樂乎。
Isn't it a pleasure to have friends coming afar to visit you?

孔子：《論語.學而篇第一》Confucius: Chapter 1, *The analects of Confucius*

君子博學於文，約之以禮。
A gentle is widely versed in culture and bound by the rites.

孔子：《論語.雍也篇第六》Confucius: Chapter 6, *The analects of Confucius*

君子求諸己，小人求諸人。
A gentleman makes demands of himself whereas a petty person makes demands of others.

孔子：《論語.衛靈公篇第十五》Confucius: Chapter 15, *The analects of Confucius*

Words that open up one's mind and enhance one's wisdom

Words that open up one's mind and enhance one's wisdom《增廣賢文》is second on the list. This work, which was compiled during the Ming period, contains many aphorisms that came from the wisdom of ancient sages. It helps children to develop their personality in the right direction. The following are examples from this work.

兩耳不聞窗外事，一心祇讀聖賢書。
One turns a deaf ear to what is happening in the outside world but concentrates on one's studies of books by the sages.

入門休問榮枯事，觀看容顏便得知。
When you enter into a house, do not ask about that things that thrive or wither, just look at one's facial expressions and you know how the things are.

有意栽花花不開，無心插柳柳成蔭。
To grow flowers purposely, you get no flowers; to plant willows casually, you get shade.

饒人不是痴漢，痴漢不會饒人。
One who forgives other is not a stupid person and a stupid man does not forgive others.

相識滿天下，知心能幾人。
You may have friends all over the world, but only a few of them are intimate ones.

Mencius

There are 133 entries from the *Mencius*《孟子》, written by Meng Ke, generally known as a second sage who was an exponent of Confucius's concept. He believed in innate goodness of the individual, saying that "human nature is good". He also held the view that people are more important than the ruler and that righteousness should be valued over benefits. Some of his ideas cited in the dictionary are given below.

盡信《書》，不如無《書》。
If you trust *The book of history* without reserve, it would be better for you not to have it.

孟軻：《孟子. 盡心章句下》Meng Ke: Chapter 7, Part 2, *Mencius*

生亦我所欲也，義亦我所欲也，二者不可得兼，捨生而取義者也。
Life is what I want and righteousness is also what I want. If I cannot have both, I would give up my life to accomplish righteousness.

孟軻：《孟子.告子章句上》Meng Ke: Chapter 6, Part 1, *Mencius*

以不忍人之心，行不忍人之政，治天下可運之掌上。
When you use a commiserating heart to run a commiserating administration, then governing the country can be controlled in one's hand.

孟軻：《孟子.公孫丑上》Meng Ke: Chapter 2, Part 1, *Mencius*

惻隱之心，人皆有之；羞惡之心，人皆有之；恭敬之心，人皆有之；是非之心；人皆有之。
Everyone has a heart for compassion; everyone has a heart for the dislike of shame; everyone has a heart for respect; and everyone has a heart for right and wrong.

孟軻：《孟子.告子章句上》Meng Ke: Chapter 6, Part 1, *Mencius*

民為貴，社稷次之，君為輕。
People are most valuable, next are the national altars of the soil and grain, and the ruler is insignificant.

孟軻：《孟子. 盡心章句下》Meng Ke: Chapter 7, Part 2, *Mencius*

故天將降大任於斯人也，必先苦其心誌，勞其筋骨，餓其體膚，空乏其身，行拂亂其所為，所以動心忍性，曾益其所不能。
Thus, when Heaven is going to give a great responsibility to someone, it first makes his mind endure suffering, his sinews and bones experience toil, and his body to suffer hunger. It inflicts him with poverty and disrupts everything he tries to build. In this way Heaven stimulates his mind, stabilizes his temper and enhances his weak abilities.

孟軻：《孟子.告子章句下》Meng Ke: Chapter 6, Part 2, *Mencius*

Daodejing

Daodejing《道德經》by Laozi, more commonly known by his original name Li Er 李耳, has been extremely popular with the Chinese people. It came as no surprise when the table shows that this Daoist

classic is the fourth most-quoted work. This work has around 5,000 characters, divided into eighty-one chapters. The following quotations serve to illustrate the ideas expressed by Li Er.

天下之至柔，馳騁天下之至堅。
The softest in the world can freely control over the hardest in the world.

老子：《道德經》Laozi: *Daodejing*

無為無所不為。
One does nothing and yet everything is done.

老子：《道德經.第四十八章》Laozi: Chapter 48, *Daodejing*

上善若水，水善利萬物而不爭。
The highest goodness is like water, which benefits myriad things but does not contend with them.

老子：《道德經.第八章》Laozi: Chapter 8, *Daodejing*

治大國若烹小鮮。
Running a large country is like cooking a small fish.

老子：《道德經.第六十章》Laozi: Chapter 60, *Daodejing*

無名天地之始，有名萬物之母。
The unnamed is the beginning of heaven and earth and the named is the mother of myriad things.

老子：《道德經.第一章》Laozi: Chapter 1, *Daodejing*

天下萬物生於有，有生於無。
All things in the world are born of something and something is born of nothing.
老子：《道德經》Laozi: *Daodejing*

It should also be noted that a considerable number of quotes come from the four great classical novels i.e.,《紅樓夢》*A dream of the red chamber* (110 entries),《水滸傳》*Outlaws of the marshes* (55 entries),《西遊記》*Journey to the West* (52 entries), and《三國演義》*Romance of the Three Kingdoms* (46 entries). Taken together, these popular novels have 263 entries. A brief discussion of these works and a provision of quotes from these works therefore seem in order.

A dream of the red chamber

A dream of the red chamber《紅樓夢》was written in vernacular Chinese by Cao Xueqin 曹雪芹 of the Qing dynasty. Later, Gao E 高鶚 added forty more chapters to the original eighty, so the novel has 120 chapters. It is believed that the work is Cao's semi-autobiography, describing the rise and decline of his family. It is a novel of remarkable achievement in terms of the number of characters and his observation of the life and structures of eighteenth-century China. Some of the well-known quotes are given below.

爾今死去儂收葬，未卜儂身何日喪。
Now you are dead and I come to bury you, and nobody can tell when I will die.

曹雪芹：《紅樓夢》Cao Xueqin: *A dream of the red chamber*

一朝春盡紅顏老，花落人亡兩不知。
One day spring will go and beauty will fade; and without knowing it, flowers will fall and people will die.

曹雪芹：《紅樓夢.第二十七回》Cao Xueqin: Chapter 27, *A dream of the red chamber*

世事洞明皆學問，人情練達即文章。
A thorough understanding of the affairs of the world is knowledge, and rich experience in human relationships is literature.

曹雪芹：《紅樓夢》Cao Xueqin: *A dream of the red chamber*

滿紙荒唐言，一把辛酸淚。
Pages full of idle words, brushed with bitter tears.

曹雪芹：《紅樓夢》Cao Xueqin: *A dream of the red chamber*

假作真時真亦假，無為有處有還無。
When false is taken for true, true becomes false; if non-being turns into being, being becomes non-being.

曹雪芹：《紅樓夢》Cao Xueqin: *A dream of the red chamber*

字字看來皆是血，十年辛苦不尋常。
Every character that you read is labored by my blood. Ten years of hardship is not all that simple.

曹雪芹：《紅樓夢》Cao Xueqin: *A dream of the red chamber*

Outlaws of the marshes

Outlaws of the marshes《水滸傳》was written by Shi Nai'an 施耐庵 *(1296–1371), a novelist of the early Ming*. It is a story about a group of 108 outlaws who gathered at Mount Liang to form an army, which was later granted an amnesty and sent by the government to fight against foreign invaders and suppress rebel forces. Some quotes from the novel are listed next.

有緣千里來相會，無緣對面不相逢。
With fate, people will come to meet from a thousand miles away; without fate, though people face each other, they never meet.

施耐庵：《水滸傳》Shi Nei'an: *Outlaws of the Marshes*

殺人可恕，天理難容。
If killing people can be forgiven, this is against the law of heaven.

施耐庵：《水滸傳.第十回》Shi Nei'an: Chapter 10, *Outlaws of the marshes*

聞名不如見面，見面勝似聞名。
To know someone by his repute is not as good as meeting him face to face.

施耐庵：《水滸傳.第三回》Shi Nei'an: Chapter 3, *Outlaws of the marshes*

十八般武藝，樣樣精通。
One is skilled in using each and every one of the eighteen weapons.

施耐庵：《水滸傳.第二回》Shi Nei'an: Chapter 2, *Outlaws of the marshes*

世事有成必有敗，為人有興必有衰。
In mundane affairs, there are successes as well as failures. In human life, there are rises and falls.

施耐庵：《水滸傳.第一百一十四回》Shi Nei'an: Chapter 114, *Outlaws of the marshes*

酒不醉人人自醉，色不迷人人自迷。
It is not wine that intoxicates people but people intoxicating themselves and it is not women who beguile men but men beguiling themselves.

施耐庵：《水滸傳.第四回》Shi Nei'an: Chapter 4, *Outlaws of the marshes*

Journey to the West

Journey to the West《西遊記》is a novel written by Wu Cheng'en 吳承恩 (1506–1582) of the Ming dynasty. It is an account of the pilgrimage of Xuanzang to India to obtain Buddhist sutras and his return to the Chinese empire and the journey was fraught with many trials and suffering. In the journey, Xuanzang had Sun Wukong, Zhu Bajie, and Sha Wujing as his protectors who helped him as a way to atone for their sins. Quotes from this novel include the following.

既在佛會下，都是有緣人。
All in the Buddhist community are brought together by the same lot.

吳承恩：《西遊記.第三十六回》Wu Cheng'en: Chapter 36, *Journey to the West*

孫悟空跳不出如來佛的掌心。
Be unable to escape from another person's control however clever and capable one may be.

吳承恩：《西遊記.第七回》Wu Cheng'en: Chapter 7, *Journey to the West*

道高一尺，魔高一丈。
When virtue rises one foot, vice rises ten.

吳承恩：《西遊記.第五十回》Wu Cheng'en: Chapter 50, *Journey to the West*

Romance of the Three Kingdoms

Romance of the Three Kingdoms《三國演義》is a historical novel attributed to Luo Guanzhong 羅貫中 (1320–1400). It is a story that takes place in the last days of the Han dynasty when warlords struggle for

supremacy and eventually three kingdoms, Shu, Wei, and Wu, take shape. The three kingdoms contend with each other until the empire is finally reunified. The following are quotes from the novel.

良禽擇木而棲，賢臣擇主而事。
Clever birds choose their trees when they perch and wise ministers choose a king to serve.

羅貫中：《三國演義.第三回》Luo Guanzhong: Chapter 3, *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*

三個臭皮匠，勝過一個諸葛亮。
Three cobblers with their wits combined is better than Zhuge Liang the mastermind.

羅貫中：《三國演義.第七十五回》Luo Guanzhong: Chapter 75, *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*

既生瑜，何生亮。
Since heaven has given birth to me, Zhou Yu, why heaven still gave birth to Zhu Geliang?

羅貫中：《三國演義》Luo Guanzhong: *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*

賠了夫人又折兵。
Lose a lady and suffer a defeat.

羅貫中：《三國演義.第五十五回》Luo Guanzhong: Chapter 55, *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*

蜀中無大將，廖化作先鋒。
In the kingdom of the blind, the one-eyed is king.

羅貫中：《三國演義.第一百一十三回》Luo Guanzhong: Chapter 113, *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*

說曹操，曹操就到。
Speak of the devil, and he is sure to appear.

羅貫中：《三國演義.第十四回》Luo Guanzhong: Chapter 14, *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*

天下大勢，分久必合，合久必分。
The general trend under heaven is that there is bound to be unification after prolonged division and division after prolonged unification.

羅貫中：《三國演義》Luo Guanzhong: *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*
It can be seen that a considerable number of famous quotes have come from the four great classical novels.

Authors quoted

The number of authors quoted in this dictionary is exceedingly large, totalling 703 and it is found that there are authors whose works are more frequently cited than others, as shown in the following table.

It can be seen that the four most-quoted persons are Li Bai, Su Shi, Du Fu, and Bai Juyi. It would be interesting to look into the reasons for their popularity.

Table 10.4 Authors cited in famous quotes

Sources of famous quotes (Authors)	*Number of citations*
李白Li Bai	71
蘇軾Su Shi	64
杜甫Du Fu	61
白居易Bai Juyi	46
陶淵明Tao Yuanming	36
韓愈Han Yu	31
陸游Lu You	28
王維Wang Wei	24
屈原Qu Yuan	22
歐陽修Ouyang Xiu	21
毛澤東 Mao Zedong	19
關漢卿Guan Hanqing	16
杜牧Du Mu	15
劉禹錫Liu Yuxi	14

Li Bai

The fact that Li Bai (701–762), a poet of the Tang dynasty, is top on the popularity list is no mere coincidence. He is probably the best-known poet in China, whose poems on the pleasures of friendship, the depth of nature, solitude, and the joys of drinking wine win the hearts of the Chinese people. Poems that show these traits of Li Bai's works are given below.

Friendship

桃花潭水深千尺，不及汪倫送我情。

The Peach Blossom Lake is one thousand feet deep, but it is not as deep as the parting sorrow that Wang Lun expressed to me.

李白：〈贈汪倫〉Li Bai: "To Wang Lun"

Nature

孤帆遠影碧空盡，惟見長江天際流。

The lonely boat and its shadows in the distance have gone to the end of the blue sky and all I could see was the waters of the Changjiang River flowing to the edge of heaven.

李白：〈黃鶴樓送孟浩然之廣陵〉Li Bai: "Seeing off Meng Haoran to Guangling at the Yellow Crane Tower"

Solitude

桃花流水宛然去，別有天地非人間。

The peach blossoms flow silently away with the running water, This is a world of its own, unlike the world of man.

李白：〈山中答問〉Li Bai: "Conversations in the mountain"

Wine

人生得意須盡歡，莫使金樽空對月。
When one has one's way in life, one must enjoy it to the full. The golden wine cup must not face the moon unfilled.

李白：〈將進酒〉Li Bai: "About to drink wine"

且樂生前一杯酒，何須身後千載名。
It is better to enjoy a cup of wine while you're still alive, for what is the use of gaining a thousand years of glory when you're dead?

李白：〈行路難〉Li Bai: "Moving forward on the road is difficult"

Su Shi

The second most-quoted person is Su Shi (1037–1101), also known by his pen name Su Dongbo 蘇東坡, who was a writer, poet, painter, calligrapher, and statesman of the Song dynasty. The poems and *ci*-poems of Su Shi have enjoyed a long history of great popularity and exerted huge influence on the intelligensia in China. Themes of his *ci*-poems are related to the natural phenomenon and his disappointment at officialdom. Some of his well-known lines are given below.

Friendship

千里送鵝毛，物輕情意重。
A goose feather sent from a thousand miles away may be light in weight, but the feelings it conveys are deep.

蘇軾：〈揚州以土物寄少游〉Su Shi: "Sending local products from Yangzhou to Qin Guan"

Life

泥上偶然留指爪，鴻飛那復計東西。
On the mud it by chance leaves a footprint. When the goose flies away, how can you reckon the east or west?

蘇軾：〈和子由澠池懷舊〉Su Shi: "Meditating on the past with Ziyou at Pond Nian"

人有悲歡離合，月有陰晴圓缺。
In human life, there are joy and sorrow, parting and reunion. For the moon, it has darkness and brightness, fullness and wane.

蘇軾：〈水調歌頭〉Su Shi: "To the tune of prelude to the melody of water"

Things

人似秋鴻來有信，事如春夢了無痕。
People are like wild geese who come faithfully in autumn, and things are like dreams in spring without a trace.

蘇軾：〈正月二十日與潘郭二生出郊尋春，忽記去年是日同至女王城作詩，乃和前韻〉Su Shi: "I went to spring outing with scholars Pan and Guo on the twentieth of the first month and recalled suddenly that we went to the Empress City to write poems on the same day last year, I therefore write this poem to respond, in the same rhyme"

Du Fu

The third most-quoted person is Du Fu (712–770), a prominent Tang poet, who, along with Li Bai, has been generally called the greatest of the Chinese poets. His poems have a strong sense of history and moral engagement, and he exhibited excellent skills in poetry writing. Some of his popular lines are given below.

Friendship

花徑不曾緣客掃，篷門今始為君開。
My flowered path has not been swept for any guests. My thatched gate for the first time opened just for you.

杜甫：〈客至〉Du Fu: "A visitor arrived"

正是江南好風景，落花時節又逢君。
This is just the time when the scenery of the south of the Yangzi River is beautiful, and I meet you again at the time when petals fall.

杜甫：〈江南逢李龜年〉Du Fu: "Encountering Li Guinian in the south of the Yangzi River"

Livelihood

安得廣廈千萬間，大庇天下寒士俱歡顏。
If only there were thousands of spacious houses, to shelter all the people in the world, much to the joy of the poor.

杜甫：〈茅屋為秋風所破歌〉Du Fu: "Song of my thatch house torn down by autumn wind"

Music

此曲祇應天上有，人間能得幾回聞。
This piece of music should only exist in heaven above, how rare can it be heard in the world of men?

杜甫：〈贈花卿〉Du Fu: "To the goddess of flowers"

Patriotism

出師未捷身先死，長使英雄淚滿襟。
But Zhuge Liang died before he succeeded, and this made heroes after him shed tears that wetted their sleeves.

杜甫：〈蜀相〉Du Fu: "The Premier of Shu"

Poetry writing

讀書破萬卷，下筆如有神。
When you have read more than ten thousand books, you can write like being helped by a god.

杜甫：〈奉贈韋左丞丈二十二韻〉Du Fu: "A twenty-two-line poem presented to Minister Wei Ji"

Bai Juyi

Bai Juyi (772–846), the last of the top-four most-quoted person, was a renowned poet of the Tang dynasty who for a time served as a government official. His poems are mainly on his career and observations made about everyday life. His best-known poems are 長恨歌 (Song of everlasting grief) and 琵琶行 (Song of a *pipa* player) and most of his best-known lines come from these two poems. Four lines are given below to illustrate this point.

回眸一笑百媚生，六宮粉黛無顏色。
When she turned back and smiled, so much charm was generated, making all the ladies of the Six Palaces lose their lustre.

白居易：〈長恨歌〉Bai Juyi: "Song of everlasting grief"

在天願作比翼鳥，在地願為連理枝。
In heaven, we hope we are birds flying with wings entwined; on earth, we hope we are intertwined branches on a tree.

白居易：〈長恨歌〉Bai Juyi: "Song of everlasting grief"

同是天涯淪落人，相逢何必曾相識。
As we both are losers in this world, does it matter whether we have met before?

白居易：〈琵琶行，並序〉Bai Juyi: "Song of a *pipa* player, with a foreword"

千呼萬喚始出來，猶抱琵琶半遮面。
We hailed and urged her many times before she would rise and come, Still half-concealing her face with the *pipa* she carried.

白居易：〈琵琶行，並序〉Bai Juyi: "Song of a *pipa* player, with a foreword"
He was also known for his *ci*-poetry, from which some popular lines come.

思悠悠，恨悠悠，恨到歸時方始休，月明人倚樓。
My thoughts are endless, so is my grief. My grief would not cease until my husband comes back. The moon is bright, and I lean on the balcony.

白居易：〈長相思〉Bai Juyi: "To the tune of everlasting longing"

More observations can be made from the table given earlier. First, three of the four most popular persons were poets, which shows to a great extent that people like lines from poems most. Second, of the fourteen popular persons, nine of them were of the Tang dynasty, which implies that works of the Tang poets have

a great influence on the Chinese people. Third, the popularity of the poems of Tao Yuanming is perhaps a reflection of the proclivity of the Chinese people to withdraw from the hustle and bustle of a city life to seek serenity in the remote rustic areas. Fourth, Mao Zedong stands out as the most-quoted person of the contemporary period, due partly to his political status in China and partly to his excellent skills in poetry writing.

Concluding remarks

Putting together and translating the most popular sayings and famous quotes from the best-known works of the best-known poets and writers throughout the ages is both a great challenge and a source of great enjoyment. What is most important is that these sayings and quotes provide a means of understanding Chinese culture in a way that has never been possible before.

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11
THE ART OF CHINESE PAINTING
Hong Kong perspective

Tang Hoi-chiu

Prelude: the Chinese painting legacy

In the world of arts, the art of Chinese ink painting has its unique national identity as well as cultural and artistic characteristics. Chinese ink painting utilizes the media of Chinese brush, paper or silk, ink and water, and Chinese pigments to pursue the Chinese philosophical ideas and aesthetics, which has become a specific artistic spectrum amongst oriental arts. If we trace the origin of Chinese ink painting to the silk painting depicting dragon, phoenix, and lady dated back to the Chu Kingdom of the Warring States period (475–221 BCE) and the *feiyi* burial banner depicting mythical scenes of heaven, life, and underground world of the wife of lord Dai of the Western Han dynasty (206 BCE – 25 CE) unearthed at Tomb no. 1 of the Han dynasty at Mawangtui, Changsha, Chinese painting has a long history of over 2,000 years.

In the Jin (265–420 CE) and Sui (581–618 CE) dynasties, figure and landscape painting had already reached a considerable state of maturity represented by works such as "*Admonitions of Court Ladies*" by Gu Kaizhi (345–406 CE.) and "*Touring in Spring*" by Zhan Zhiqian (dates unknown) of the Sui dynasty, which are masterpieces of Chinese painting.

The Tang dynasty (618–907 CE) envisaged the bloom of landscape painting in the *gongbi* (fine-line) and heavy colours style such as the works depicting court ladies by Zhou Fang (dates known) and Zhang Xuan (dates unknown); flower-and-bird painting and figure painting; and Wang Wei (692–761 CE or 699–759 CE), a great poet of the time, who began to paint landscapes with only ink and water, marking the emergence of the later literati school of painting.

From the Five Dynasties and Ten Kingdoms (907–979 CE) to the two Song dynasties, including Northern Song (960–1127 CE) and Southern Song (1127–1279 CE), landscape painting had become the mainstream of Chinese painting with renowned masters such as Dong Yuan (? – 962 CE), Ju Ren (dates unknown), Fan Kuan (950–1032 CE), Li Cheng (919–967 CE), Guo Xi (dates unknown, Northern Song dynasty), Mi Fu (1051–1107 CE), Ma Yuan (dates unknown, Southern Song dynasty), Xia Gui (dates unknown, Southern Song dynasty), and others pursuing landscape paintings with consummate ink and brush techniques to create either heroic and majestic monumental landscapes or charming and lyrical landscape scenes of lakes and rivers, and their works were masterpieces to be studied and followed by painters of the later dynasties.

Genre paintings also appeared to be an independent painting category in the Song dynasty, such as the monumental masterpiece "*Travelling along the River in the Qingming Festival*" by Zhang Zeduan (dates unknown, Northern Song dynasty), who renders portrayals of cityscapes, daily life, and people's activities at the capital Bianjing (present Kaifeng) in a meticulous and realistic manner.

Then came the first cradle of the Chinese literati landscape painting in the following dynasties of the Yuan (1271–1368 CE) and the Ming (1368–1644 CE), with painters in pursuit of harmony of nature in landscapes for the literati to dwell and stroll in a mindful journey, reflecting the quest of tranquility and loftiness in the artistic realm. Prominent literati painters of the Yuan dynasty include the four masters: Wu Zhen (1280–1354 CE), Huang Gongwang (1269–1354 CE), Wang Meng (1308–1385 CE), and Ni Zan (1301–1374 CE), whereas the descendant of the Song royal family Zhao Mengfu (1254–1322 CE) was prolific in painting landscapes and figures with the blue-and-green style as well as ink tradition that exuded a touch of archaism calling for a return to antiquity.

Various schools of literati painting also flourished in the Ming dynasty, such as the Wu School with masters Shen Zhou (1427–1509 CE), Wen Zhengming (1470–1559 CE), and others as leading masters. Dong Qichang (1555–1636 CE), who was the master of the Huating School, advocated a return to antiquity by copying and studying ancient masters, and also provoked the theory of categorizing landscape painters of the preceding dynasties into the Northern or Southern School of Chinese landscape painting. Painting in the *gongbi* (fine-line) style also attained a significant status at the time, as represented by Tang Yin (1470–1523 CE) who painted court ladies and beauties with a subtle palette in the Tang dynasty style, and Qiu Ying (circa 1478–1552 CE) who was prolific in depicting landscapes in the blue-and-green style with subtle colour tones, as well as ladies and court life with delicate and refined brushwork.

In the early Qing dynasty, there were the acclaimed "Six Masters of the Early Qing period" or the "Four Wangs", including Wang Shimin (1592–1680 CE), Wang Jian (1598–1677 CE), Wang Hui (1632–1717 CE), and Wang Yuanqi (1642–1715 CE), who were closely associated with the court and also leaders of the painting circle, as well as Wu Li (1632–1718 CE) and Yun Shouping (1633–1690 CE).

These six painters, who were collectively known as the Six Masters of the Orthodox School, favoured copying and assimilating the stylistic essence of past masters to achieve synthesis and had become leading figures of the literati school of painting. On the other hand, there were also creative masters who transformed ancient stylistic legacy to achieve their own unique styles, including Zhu Da (1626–1705 CE) – also known as Bada Shanren, Kun Can (1612–1673 CE), Hong Ren (1610–1664 CE), and Shitao (1642–1707 CE).

They were also leftovers of the Ming dynasty and collectively known as the "Four Monks" whose paintings were marked with sophisticated and dense brush work and ink, exuding a sense of purity or simplicity. Other noted painters and schools at the time include Mei Qing (1623–1697 CE) of the Huangshan School and Gong Xian (1618–1689 CE) of the Jinling School, who successfully developed their distinctive landscape paintings by manipulating classical but innovative brush styles. The emperors of the imperial Qing court had a preference to record their achievements, military successes, and luxuriant court life and such practices had brought court painting to a new cradle. Accomplished court painters such as Tang Dai (1675–1752 CE), Dong Gao (1740–1818 CE), Zou Yigui (1686–1772 CE), and others were also recognized for their landscape or flower and bird paintings with meticulous styles and bright colours, conveying an aura of realism. From the late Ming dynasty, foreign missionaries started to come to China to preach. One of the most talented missionaries was the Italian Jesuit priest Giuseppe Castiglione (1688–1776, Chinese name Lang Shining), who came to China in the early Qing period and had served as a key court painter from the Kangxi (1662–1722 CE) to the Qianlong period (1735–1796 CE). He excelled in painting dogs, horses, birds, and flowers with brilliant colour schemes and Western painting techniques that carried a strong tint of realism and perspectives.

He also worked together with other Chinese court painters and their cultivations show the assimilation of Western and Chinese painting styles that marked a new page in Chinese painting. Since the mid and late Qing period, the market economy began to flourish and various commercial cities such as Yangzhou, Shanghai, and Guangzhou had become prosperous trade centres. The aesthetic favour of the wealthy merchant class motivated a group of painters to complete their works with commercial taste and popular appeal, and these notable painters include the so-called Eight Eccentrics of the Yangzhou School such as Jin

Nong (1687–1764 CE), Li Shan (1686–1762 CE), Luo Ping (1733–1799 CE), and others, who moved away from the orthodox tradition of literati painting to pursue a rather eccentric artistic path. They also painted works with ironic connotations showing their discontent with the social conditions and sympathy for the layman. Such a change was also represented by the emergence of the Shanghai School with leading figures including the four Rens: Ren Xun (1835–1893 CE), Ren Yi (1840–1895 CE), Ren Xiong (1823–1857 CE) and Ren Yu (1853–1901 CE) and others who painted subjects of landscapes, figures, flowers, and birds with fluent brushwork and soft charming colours.

However, the late Qing period faced political instability and foreign invasion, as well as a decline in artistic development where many painters only copied the past masters without creative ideas, which stimulated artists to re-assess the Chinese painting tradition with a view to open new realms in the century to come.

The twentieth century: new pursuits in Chinese painting

The success of the 1911 revolution brought Chinese imperial rule to an end. Political and economic turmoil, as well as the suffering of people and the penetration of foreign powers called for new trends of revival and thinking to save the nation. Under such a climate, painters proceeded to a transformation of the tradition, or sought new artistic ideas from the West and the East, in order to give fresh blood to the rotten Chinese painting tradition. With a firm training in the Chinese ink and brush styles, painters such as Qi Baishi (1863–1957), Huang Binhong (1864–1955), Wu Changshuo (1844–1927), and others tried to assimilate the past legacies in their new ways of explorations to revisit and revitalize the ink painting tradition.

Gao Jianfu (1879–1951), Gao Qifeng (1889–1933), and Chen Shuren (1884–1948) were collectively known as the "Three Masters of the Lingnan School". All of them had gone to Japan to study painting, alternatively got into touch with Western and Japanese painting styles, and championed a modernization of Chinese painting by picking up new concepts, subjects, and techniques. They had also taught a large number of students who spread the Lingnan School of Painting in Guangzhou, Hong Kong, Macau, and overseas and created significant impacts. Other masters such as Liu Haisu (1896–1994), Xu Beihong (1895–1953), Wu Zuoren (1908–1997), Lin Fengmian (1900–1991), Wu Guanzhong (1919–2010), and others pursued art studies in Europe and were influenced by Western modernism and artistic concepts.

Their early works were realistic and imbued with social and political messages whereas in their later years, they returned to ink painting by adopting diversified Chinese painting techniques, subjects and styles, or turned to be more abstract in representation. Prior to the political transition in 1949, Zhang Daqian (1899–1983) had already been regarded as an accomplished painter who had a profound knowledge of the Chinese painting tradition and the Dunhuang murals and excelled in painting figures, landscapes, and flowers both in a free and spontaneous manner as well in a meticulous style. He later moved to the United States and Brazil but subsequently settled in Taiwan in his late years, where he founded his creative "splashed ink" and "splashed colors" endeavours and became one of the most influential masters of the twentieth century.

A descendant of the Qing imperial family, Pu Ru (1896–1963) settled in Taiwan after 1949 and engaged himself in artistic creation and art education. He was noted for painting landscapes, figures, flowers and birds, and animals in a delicate and lyrical style reminiscent of the Chinese literati tradition and had a profound impact on the Taiwan art circle. The Guangdong painter Huang Junbi (1898–1991), who also moved to Taiwan, mastered traditional techniques in painting landscapes, in particular waterfalls, with a modernistic approach, establishing himself a master in the Taiwanese art horizon.

Since the transition of political power in 1949 with the founding of the People's Republic of China, painters had to comply with the Communist summons that art should serve the people and be utilized as a vehicle for political and propaganda purposes for the Communist regime. Various painters including Wu Zuoren (1908–1997), Qian Songyan (1899–1985), Guan Shanyue (1912–2000), Li Xiongcai (1910–2001), Lu Yanshao (1909–1993), and their contemporaries turned to painting a great number of landscape and figure paintings that praised the majestic scenery of China, social infrastructures, life of the minorities and

people, merits of political leaders with a realistic approach, yet still were able to retain their personal styles and ink and brush tradition with traditional essence. They also taught at various national art colleges and universities and produced significant contributions in art education for bringing up young talents. With a policy of reformation and openness implemented since the 1970s, painters were released from the Communist dogmatism and they also responded to the rising art market. These contemporary ink painters are devoted to new experiments and innovations, and even utilize new media and multi-media in order to create a contemporary spirit and open new artistic vocabularies. The painting subjects also go beyond traditional categories of landscapes, figures, flowers or birds. As a result, various new art trends such as "city ink painting", "experimental ink painting", "design ink painting", "conceptual ink painting" or even "digital ink art" emerge from one to another, which inject freshness and new visions to contemporary ink art.

Early Hong Kong ink painting: the traditionalists' transformations and the Lingnan School

Compared to the history of China that spans over thousands of years, art and culture in Hong Kong are still young. It was only a barren island prior to the takeover by Britain to become a British colony in 1842. The origin of its painting and calligraphic art could only be traced to Guangdong art in the Qing dynasty, as observed from the wall paintings and calligraphic engravings extant in old temples and historical sites and records in historical documents. However, Hong Kong is located at the south gate of China and enjoys a favourable geographical location and distinctive political and economic environment, which enabled it to develop into an international metropolis where art and culture flourished at a rapid pace within a hundred years. Under the British colonial rule and comparatively open-minded policy, Hong Kong art and culture were open to a free and embracing ambience. In the early to the mid-twentieth century, customs control between the mainland and Hong Kong was quite loose, and painters such as Qi Baishi, Huang Binhong, and others were free to visit Hong Kong easily or temporarily stay in this city, spreading the seed for the inception of Hong Kong art. Although Hong Kong ink painting has only a short history of just 100 years, it is still not possible to comprehensively describe its development in detail in the present short chapter of a few thousand words. Therefore I only elaborate the mainstreams of its development and quote some prominent artists as examples for exemplification of the uniqueness, role played, and positioning of Hong Kong ink painting in the context of Chinese painting tradition.

Notable Guangdong painters active in Hong Kong in the early twentieth century include Gao Jianfu, Gao Qifeng, and Chen Shuren, the three masters of the Lingnan School of Chinese Painting, who often travelled between Guangzhou, Hong Kong, and Macau. In their early years, these masters had apprenticed with Ju Lian (1828–1904) and Ju Chao (1811–1865), the two masters of the Keshan School of Chinese painting in Guangdong. The three Lingnan masters used to paint in the "boneless style" with light and subtle colours and soft brush work, as well as the special techniques of fusing water and white powder in their colour schemes in their early works. They then all went to Japan to pursue studies in painting, where they got into touch with Western painting and the essence of Japanese schools such as Rimpa and Kano School as well as masters including Takeuchi Seiho (1864–1942), Yokoyama Taikan (1868–1958), Hishida Shunso (1874–1911), and others; as a result, the later works of these masters were tinted with the atmospheric ambiance, themes, and bright colours of Japanese painting. The three masters were active revolutionaries to overthrow the Manchu rule, who also pioneered a revolution of traditional painting by incorporating Western life sketching and shading techniques in their works and that all subjects could be employed for creating art, other than only traditional themes. Painting should also serve social and educational functions for the masses. The three masters were prolific in painting landscapes, birds and flowers, and animals; they extended to cityscapes and war themes with eminent realism and bold brushwork, and their artistic cultivations had laid important impact on the painting circles of Hong Kong and Macau. Another group of painters who came from the traditional arena were members of the Research Society of Chinese Painting in Guangdong

founded in 1926. After they resided in Hong Kong, they founded a branch of the Society to promote the traditional school of ink painting and revisited the tradition, such as Huang Boruo (1901–1968) who was devoted to painting Buddhist and Daoist figures in a delicate style with strong colours in his early artistic career, but turned to a free and spontaneous style in depicting Hong Kong landscapes after he settled in Hong Kong. Another representative painter was Deng Fen (1894–1964) who was a rather eccentric and unrestrained artist. Deng was born in a literati family; however, he chose to indulge in a carefree life and was active in the Cantonese opera circle and acquainted himself with many well-known Cantonese opera and music performers. Deng Fen was known as a prolific artist noted for composing opera music, calligraphy, painting, poetry and verses, and even miniature Chinese olive seed carvings. In the art of ink painting, he was acclaimed for painting Buddhist figures, Daoist deities, and beauties in a meticulous and delicate manner with manipulation of brush work as well as ink washes and a lyrical palette, giving his traditional style a sense of modernity. He was a talented artist rather ignored by the academic sector and historians.

Other painters of this group include Li Yanshan (1898–1961), who was noted for painting landscapes in the traditional style of the Northern School, and Li Fenggong (1883–1967), who was noted for painting figures, flowers, and birds in the *gongbi* (fine-line) style. These two groups of painters from the Lingnan School and the traditional school laid the foundation of the future development of Hong Kong ink art.

The change of political power from the rule of the Nationalist government to Communist government forced many artists to leave mainland China for settlement in Hong Kong and as a result, they activated the progressive development of culture and art there. Ding Yanrong (1902–1978) had taught at a number of art colleges and schools in Guangzhou before his move to Hong Kong in 1949 and afterwards he served as a tutor at the Department of Fine Arts, the Chinese University of Hong Kong. In his early years, Ding pursued oil painting with influence from various Western masters such Henri Matisse (1869–1954), Pablo Picasso (1881–1973), and others. In his late years, Ding returned to ink painting and assimilated the stylistic legacies of Bada Shanren, Xu Wei (1521–1593 CE), Shitao, and others to render his own painting subjects of figures, birds, animals, flowers, rocks, and figures with free play of modulating ink tones and abstract brush work, showing success in assimilating Western and Chinese painting styles, and his works are often imbued with a sense of humour. He was also a noted seal-carver and significantly contributed to art education with his career in the university.

Painters Zhao Shao'ang (1905–1998) and Yang Shanshen (1913–2004) were representative of the second generation of painters of the Lingnan School and both came to Hong Kong in 1948. Zhao was a student of Gao Qifeng, who founded his "Lingnan Art Association" and Yang was both a friend and apprentice of Gao Jianfu, who founded his "Spring Breeze Art Society" in Hong Kong. Zhao was an accomplished painter prolific in painting landscapes, flowers, insects, and animals, and particularly noted for painting kapoks, lychees, and cicadas with swift and free brush work, as well as bright colours, capturing the lively resonance of nature and pictorial subjects.

Yang excelled in painting landscapes, flowers, and figures and was particularly noted for painting animals such as tigers, cats, and the twelve celestial animals. His landscapes and figures were depicted with stern and rustic brush work whereas his flower paintings exude the charm of Japanese painting with brilliant and subtle colours. In painting animals, Yang paid close attention to life sketching, observing the postures and spirits of respective animals and conveying a naturalistic and enlivened flavour in his works. His works depicting cats, tigers, cocks, hens, and birds were most acclaimed. Both masters nurtured a great number of students of the third and fourth generation of the Lingnan School of Painting in Hong Kong, maintaining the vitality of the Lingnan School for sustainable development.

The rise of the new ink painting movement and modern ink painting in Hong Kong

From the 1950s to 1960s, the political and economic environment of Hong Kong had become stabilized for leaping forward, and artists began to have opportunities to get in touch with modernistic art trends in

the West. On the other hand, the colonial government adopted a rather free and open policy and did not interfere much with culture and art, facilitating artists to attain the freedom to pursue artistic explorations from diversified sources. The painter Lu Shoukun (1919–1975) settled in Hong Kong in 1948. His father, Lu Canming (1892–1963), was a noted ink painter and with tuition from his father, Lu Shoukun had mastered the essence and brush style of the Chinese painting tradition. He was also inspired by schools and masters of dynastic China, such as the Northern and Southern School of Chinese painting, the *gongbi* fine line and heavy colour flowers, birds, and animal paintings of the Song dynasty, Bada Shanren, and Shitao to achieve a synthesis. After his move to Hong Kong, Lu often toured various Hong Kong scenic spots and painted Hong Kong cityscapes and landscapes in a realistic manner with a touch of naturalism. From the late 1950s to the mid-1960s, Lu started to look into Western realism and abstract art, initiating his new style of semi-abstract painting by using bold calligraphic strokes and ink and colour splashes to depict abstract forms. Since then, Lu embarked to create his unique series of "Zen Painting" with philosophical connotations from Confucianism, Daoism, and Buddhism. He used large bound brush to splash and paint calligraphic lines as expressive forms such as lotuses, earth, red flames, lotus buds or butterflies, which are icons of Daoism or Buddhism. At the same time, Lu also created another series of "Zen Painting" by using chemicals to dilute and diffuse ink and colours which flow freely on the pictorial plane, resembling transformations of the cosmos to suggest the realm of the state of Buddhist enlightenment or the Daoist's ideas of returning to nature. In his artistic career, Lu Shoukun cultivated in parallel traditional Chinese brush work, realism and spontaneity as well as abstract Zen painting. Lu had taught at the Department of Architecture, The University of Hong Kong, and the Extra-mural Studies Department, the Chinese University of Hong Kong and nurtured a large number of creative painters to initiate the so-called Hong Kong New Ink Painting Movement. He was acclaimed as a great innovative master in the history of Hong Kong ink painting.

In teaching, Lu Shoukun paid close attention to the study of traditional ink and brush techniques, but he never encouraged his students to merely copy works of the past masters or himself. He placed emphasis on theories and practices at the same time to inspire his apprentices. As a result, his students enjoyed much freedom in cultivating their own styles, never resembling their teacher. Wucius Wong (Wang Wuxie) (b. 1936) was one of the earliest artists who introduced Western modernism into Hong Kong. As early as 1958, he founded the Modern Art and Literature Association with his art colleagues. Wong is an accomplished graphic designer who had taught at the School of Design of the Polytechnic University of Hong Kong (formerly known as Polytechnics) for many years. In his artistic cultivation, he blended graphic forms, Chinese scripts and interweaving spatial planes with Chinese ink and brush techniques, successfully injecting design elements to ink art. In his late years, he dedicated himself to painting majestic mountains, rivers and cityscapes with massive lines, dots, and splashes that swiftly flow across the pictorial plane and often from an aerial view. His artistic endeavors of seeking from the East and West made him one of the masters of Hong Kong new ink painting.

Kan Tai-keung (b. 1942) is also an international renowned designer who had won numerous awards. In his early years, Kan disseminates graphic planes on his works with the incorporation of landscape elements such as peaks, trees, and rocks rendered in abstract curves and lines. In his late years, he establishes his distinctive style by blending calligraphic strokes and Chinese script forms with landscape elements such as peaks, rocks, trees, and streams, revealing the new explorations of Chinese calligraphy and painting. Leung Kui-ting (b. 1945) had also worked as a designer who opened himself to Western modern expressionism, hard-edge painting and other art trends in his early years but reverted to ink painting later. He manipulates short and long brush lines of different lengths and reconstructs landscape elements and spaces, and he is also fond of manipulating swift and drifting lines amongst landscapes to present the "breath" in nature.

With inspiration from virtual and digital experiments, Leung successfully assimilates traditional brush work with virtual linear configurations and cityscapes. He is also a versatile artist who works on print making, Western painting, sculpture, installation, and others throughout his artistic career. These artists who had

studied with Lu Shoukun are examples of incorporating design approaches and Chinese ink and brush to open new horizons in ink art. Another outstanding student of Lu is Chu Hing-wah (b. 1935), who was a nurse in mental hospitals and felt deep sympathy for the patients. He painted figures with gloomy forms and dark ink and colour tones in his early career. However, after his retirement, he felt released and turned to a new style of portraying city scenes, daily life, and people in a transcended and romantic manner, which are also representative of city landscapes in Hong Kong.

The 1970s marked another new wave of modern ink painting in Hong Kong. The Taiwanese master Liu Guosong (b. 1932) arrived at Hong Kong in 1972 at the invitation of the Department of Fine Arts, the Chinese University of Hong Kong to serve as a professor for over twenty years. As early as in the 1950s when he was in Taiwan, he had founded the avant-garde Five Moon Painting Society with his fellow artists, which became a new force of artistic movement in Taiwan. He published his first compilation of art articles *The Road of Modern Chinese Ink Painting* in 1965, in which he pronounced his proactive ideas to revitalize ink painting. He was consistently devoted to promote modern ink art and his theoretical slogans such as "we have to conduct an unprecedented revolution on Chinese painting. To whom should we overthrow? That is we have to overthrow the principle of 'holding the brush upright (in painting)', we have to get rid of the bondage of using only the brush" and such ideas had provoked critical debates in the art circle and earned him a name as a revolutionary in ink painting. In the early 1960s, Liu founded his new repertory of using bold calligraphic brush work, abstract forms, paper textures, and the contrast of empty and solid spaces on the pictorial plane to paint landscapes. He produced his unique paper known as "Liu Gusong paper" and tore away the thick fibres on the paper to create landscape textures reserved in white, resembling the *cun* textual strokes in Chinese landscape painting. Liu also experimented with various new techniques such as employing cursive calligraphic strokes, collage, ink rubbing, and paper folds to create textures. In the late 1960s, Liu saw the American astronauts travelling to space to land on the moon. The distinctive scenes in space posed new inspirations for the master to develop a series of new works with themes of sun, moon, and earth, which are noted for various techniques of ink and colour splashes, spraying, application of acrylic and other pigments, collage, and torn away paper fibres with bright colour treatments and abstract forms.

He does not confine himself to any designated format and all kinds of formats of hanging scroll, vertical scroll, joint panel, and lozenge or cross pictorial plane are within the hands of the master. This new series of "space paintings" brought a new horizon to modern ink painting. Since the late 1980s, Liu created various autonomous and semi-autonomous painting techniques, such as dripping ink and colour in water to create diffusions and then dipping paper in the water so to create abstract landscape motifs and distinctive visual effects. The accomplishments of Liu Guosong are not only confined to his breakthroughs in terms of concepts and techniques, but also his revolutionary theories, pursuance of modernity, and educational approaches that lifted modern Chinese ink painting to a new arena in the international world. During his teaching career in Hong Kong, he introduced the first diploma course on modern ink painting and founded the "Modern Ink Painting Society" with his fellow students, who include Chan Shingkau (b. 1952), Li Junyi (b. 1965), Guo Hanshen (b. 1947), Yang Kwok-fen (b. 1962), and others, who all later become instrumental figures in the ink art circle, and Liu Guosong himself is also acclaimed as "the father of modern ink painting".

Independent pursuits in the Hong Kong context

The senior master Luis Chan (Chan Fushan 1905–1995) was a pioneer who introduced Western painting into Hong Kong. He came to Hong Kong in the 1920s and later founded the "Chinese Contemporary Artists' Guild". Chan was a self-taught artist who excelled in painting oils and acrylics, watercolors, and collages. In the 1970s and 1980s, he began to use Chinese ink lines in his works to create child-like and naturalistic works with brilliant colours and bold treatment. He was open to the influence of Western masters

such as Salvador Dali (1904–1989) and Pablo Picasso (1881–1973) and painted eccentric and distorted figures and landscapes that exude a sense of humor and fantasy. Although Luis Chan was not solely devoted to ink painting, his blending of ink painting elements and Western painting provokes a new repertory of modern ink painting in Hong Kong.

Fang Zhaoling (1914–2006) was an acclaimed woman painter in Hong Kong who had established her unique painting styles. She was born in Wushi, Jiansu and studied at various colleges in China, and later pursued further studies at the University of Manchester and Oxford University in the United Kingdom and The University of Hong Kong in Hong Kong. Fang has studied with various Chinese painting masters, including Zhao Shao'ang (1905–1998), Qian Songyan (1899–1985), and Zhang Daqian (1899–1983). Her early works show the legacy of the flower painting of the Lingnan School of Painting, the simple and rustic style of the master Qi Baishi, the realistic rendering of landscapes of Qian Songyan, and the versatility of Zhang Daqian's splashed ink and colour techniques. After 1948, she moved to Hong Kong and dedicated herself to painting. Fang was a prolific painter noted for landscape, flower, and figure painting that were often imbued with the artist's genuine passion for her home country, good wishes for people, and care of the surrounding affairs in a social context. Since 1961, Fang often travelled to her home country and has in particular fond favour of the Yellow River and the Yangtze River, the origin of Chinese civilization, the yellow-earth highlands in Northwest China, and Shaan'xi. Her works show the artist's care and attention to the people's life in these desolate regions. She painted distinctive sceneries of mountains and rivers in northwest China with blue, green, red, and brown pigments and simple, free, and bold abstract brush work to depict people living in caves, the dry and rustic mountains, running rivers and boatmen who sails on rivers that suggest the hardworking and difficult living conditions there. However, the innocent faces of children, the steps for climbing up high mountains, and the red lucky slips posted on doors of caves are all suggestions for best wishes for people to enjoy a peaceful and happy life. Motivated by the suffering of the Vietnamese refugees who sailed on broken boats to flee to Hong Kong during the Vietnam War, many of them having died on the sea, Fang rendered her famous "Boat People" series, depicting refugees flooding on boats for their life and reveal the artist's sympathy for the refugees and mourning for their sad destiny, as well as her response to the cruelty of warfare. During the period when Hong Kong returned to Chinese sovereignty, she painted a number of works titled "Ode of Peace" that are marked with bright colours, spontaneous calligraphic strokes, and optimistic pictorial subjects to show her best wishes for the bright future of Hong Kong and people to enjoy peace and happiness after the reunion. Fang was also fond of writing bold and casual calligraphic inscriptions on her works for explaining her ideas and statements, as well as to what was happening in a social context. The art of this renowned woman painter fully illustrates her unique creativity, unrestrained character, and passionate realm and represents a new face of Hong Kong ink painting in the hands of an accomplished woman painter.

Post-1980: individuality and city identity

A number of painters in the mainland came to settle in Hong Kong in the late 1970s to the 1980s and their artistic endeavors deserve special attention. Hung Hoi (b. 1975) moved to Hong Kong in 1978. He had a solid training in the mainland to master the Chinese painting tradition before he came to Hong Kong. Hung then apprenticed with the Lingnan School master Yang Shansen and also experimented with abstract painting for a short while; however, he returned to traditional painting to open his new realm. Hung excels in manipulating delicate and precise brush work and gradation of ink tones to paint landscapes in either monumental works or small works such as album leaves, which exudes the lyrical resonance of the landscape painting of the Song and Yuan dynasties. He was in particular noted for painting large works or handscrolls with the "plain outline" technique by just using fluent and swift brush strokes without application of colour so that the contrast between the black and the white, as well as the void and empty spaces, suggest the momentum of landscape elements and give his works a unique identity.

Ou Dawei (b. 1947) had studied calligraphy with the noted traditional Guangdong calligrapher Wu Zifu (1899–1979) and began to paint by self-learning and practising without apprenticing with any master since 1970. He was much inspired by masters such as Huang Binhong and his modulation of dense and dark ink and brush strokes; he also traces back to the styles of past masters including Shitao, Cun Can, and Gong Xian who were acclaimed for their consummate brush styles and use of ink. Ou is a prolific artist excelling in painting landscapes, either exuding a pure and lyrical resonance, or rustic and heroic favour, with his distinctive mastery of layered ink, dry ink, and breaking ink techniques, as well as precise and stern brush work and dense ink tones. He also injects the essence of calligraphy and seal carving into painting to transcend his art beyond tradition. These artists represent a group of painters who successfully transform the Chinese painting tradition since the 1970s and 1980s.

Since 1980s to 1990s, a generation of locally born middle and young age painters came into being with significant accomplishments that illustrate the unique identity and fresh vocabulary of Hong Kong ink painting. Raymond Fung Wing-kee (b. 1952) is a noted architect. He resides in Sai Kung, Hong Kong, which is a place with charming misty landscape scenes. By mastering wet ink and colour washes and folding paper textures, Fung captures the tranquil mood of Hong Kong scenery with glittering effects of sunshine on sea and misty mood of cloudy and rainy landscapes with soft brush work and subtle palette. He also folds papers to create special visual effects that resemble the *cun textural* strokes in ancient Chinese landscape painting. Fung is also engaged intensively in public building projects, art education, and art advisory profession.

Another group of artists need special mention because they have successfully reshaped and revitalized the Chinese painting tradition. Wilson Shieh Ka-ho (b.1970) graduated from the Department of Fine Arts, the Chinese University in 1994 and later obtained his Master of Fine Arts Degree. He studied painting with the artist Chan Tak-hei during his university years and was much inspired by the *gongbi* (fine-line) and heavy colours style and the plain outline style of the figure paintings from the Tang to the Qing dynasties. Inheriting the line drawing and application of colour techniques of ancient Chinese figure painting, Shieh gives a fresh outlook to his works with creative pictorial subjects and interpretations. He painted a series of works to re-creat landmark buildings in Hong Kong, such as the Central Plaza, Bank of China, Shun Tak Centre, ICC, and IFC, personifying these buildings with the forms of ladies in the contemporary era. The forms and structures of these building have become costumes of the figures, and their hand and body postures suggest different messages and personal characters. The traditional portrayals of court ladies in the past are now transformed into modern buildings that are the iconic cityscape of Hong Kong. He also explores the trans-sexuality, homosexuality, and dubious relationship between the two sexes in his paintings. The characters and role of the figures also shifted in his creative works, such as using figures of film stars and singers like Leslie Cheung, Chow Yun-fat, Teresa Teng, Maggie Cheung, and others, and depict these characters in different dresses and settings with meticulous brush strokes and strong colours of ink painting, as well as pencil drawings to symbolize social messages and characters of contemporary Hong Kong. His achievements and new attempts to reconstruct traditional Chinese figure paintings have provided fresh inspiration for a group of young fellow painters who explore contemporary issues, humorous interpretation, toys, and folklores as themes that bring new repertories to the tradition of figure paintings in the *gongbi* (fine-line) and heavy colour styles.

Koon Wai-bong (b.1974) graduated from the Department of Fine Arts, The Chinese University of Hong Kong in 1996. He has briefly studied with the accomplished senior traditional painter Johnson Chow Su-sing (b. 1923) who served as a visiting fellow at the invitation of the Department. With tuition from Chow, Koon mastered the techniques in painting landscapes, bamboo, and rocks with traditional essence. He does not merely confine to describe his pictorial subjects in a narrative manner, but also modulates the formats of works by giving them alternative formats and composite elements, and even manipulates multi-media and cross-media techniques in his works to re-interpret ink and brush. For example, in one of his works titled "Motifs and Ideas" (2009), he drew pictorial illustrations of clouds,

water, mist, and landscapes from the classical painting manual *Painting Manual of Mustard Seeds* in light ink and with void spaces and recorded the sounds of blowing wind and flowing water from nature to complement his paintings, so that viewers would experience a realistic journey to mountains and waters through his works, which echo the ancient literati pursuit of conducting a mindful journey to nature. His monumental work "Luxuriant Greenery" utilizes a special format by joining panels together as a large composite picture, which depicts luxuriant greenery of bamboo groves with the poetic mood from a poem that praises lofty bamboos in the *Classic of Poems*, which later became an icon for the loftiness of scholars and literati, as viewers actually feel a comfortable breeze blowing across the bamboo grove. Koon often combines panels in different formats, for he thinks that they are like windows through which we will see various scenes and subjects. He also uses mechanics to activate Chinese painting formats, such as to drive the painted Chinese round fans to create a breeze, or experiments with alternative vocabulary such as painting pictorial subjects on *changsan* (Chinese long gown for man) or *qibao* (Chinese woman's robe for ladies). The creative spirit and pictorial treatment of Koon reveals that he captures the traditional literati aesthetics but transforms them into contemporary visual language, showing a direction of contemporary painters who reshape traditional ink art.

In conclusion, when we survey the development of ink painting in Hong Kong in the past hundred years, we would recognize that the grand tradition of Chinese painting in the past paved a firm foundation for further evolution. The arrival of painters of the traditional school laid the ground for assiduous cultivation in Chinese ink and brush techniques. The emergence of the Lingnan School of painting and the revolution it brought to Chinese painting injected new forces of flourishing to this school in Hong Kong. From the 1950s to the 1970s, ink painters in this locality opened themselves to Western modernism and successfully blended Western and Chinese art in the melting pot of Hong Kong, among whom Lu Shoukun introduced the "New Ink Painting" and Liu Guosong proactively pronounced "Modern Ink Painting" movements. With the efforts of these two masters and their large number of outstanding students, new faces of ink painting emerged, even earlier than in the mainland or Taiwan, and raised ink art to the international arena. From the 1970s, artists from the mainland and local-born painters in Hong Kong continuously quest for revitalization and reshaping of traditional Chinese ink painting to establish contemporary trends that show the artistic and cultural identity of Hong Kong. A glimpse of the development of ink painting in Hong Kong in these hundred years tell the story of the progressive sustainability of Chinese ink painting, its vitality and new transformations that shaped the new faces of the contemporary ink art in the metropolitan city Hong Kong.

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12
CONFUCIANISM

Cheung Yu-kit

Introduction

Confucianism is arguably the most influential local philosophy based on the teachings of Confucius – a Latinized name literally meaning Master Kung (*Kong fuzi* 孔夫子)[1] – in the history of China.[2] Whilst this school of thought is named after the master, his teachings were not developed *ex nihilo* – they were, to a large extent, based on the ancient literature of his days and the exemplary conduct of ancient sagacious rulers, for instance, Emperor Yao, Emperor Shun, King Wen of Zhou, and Duke of Zhou. Therefore, it is documented in *The Analects* that Confucius considered himself a transmitter rather than an innovator (A 7.1; Lau tr. 1979: 86).[3]

Confucianism is a broad concept. The term itself could be liable to confusion without a context, giving rise to the question "which". There are at least two reasons. An immediate one is logically the temporal factor, for it is only to be expected to see evolution in a system of thought over a space of 2,500 years, not least after tumultuous times. Ames (2011) remarks that this philosophy "has been appropriated, commented upon, reinterpreted, and reauthorized by each of some eighty generations of Chinese scholars and intellectuals" who have contributed to this philosophy "as a continuous, living tradition" (1).

> Loosely speaking, there are three major periods of development, namely Traditional Confucianism in pre-Han China, Neo-Confucianism in the Song Dynasty and New Confucianism in the twentieth century. There have been attempts at more precise periodisation. For instance, Berthrong (1998) puts forward that there were six epochs of the Confucian tradition[4] – the rise of the classical tradition in Shang and Zhou China, the canonisation of the Confucian classics in the Han dynasty, the defence of the doctrine amidst challenges from Neo-Taoism and Buddhism from the Wei-Jin to the Tang dynasties (220–907), the rise of Neo-Confucianism in the Song dynasties and its development in the Ming, the evidential research of the Qing dynasty, and finally New Confucianism after the 1911 Chinese Revolution.

Another reason contributing to the ambiguity is probably the content. According to Liu Shu-hsien (1998), the term can be understood on three levels: Politicized Confucianism, Popular Confucianism and Spiritual Confucianism (13–14). Politicized Confucianism, by definition, is concerned with governance, a stream of Confucianism championed by Dong Zhongshu 董仲舒 of the Han dynasty. Popular Confucianism concerns the major concepts, for instance, filial piety (*xiao* 孝), which are syncretically transferable with

Taoism and Buddhism.[5] Spiritual Confucianism refers to the philosophical exploration of this traditional thought by some "eighty generations of Chinese scholars and intellectuals" as aforementioned – one first put forth by Confucius, expanded by Mencius, then interpreted by Zhu Xi (朱熹 1130–1200), Lu Jiuyuan (陸九淵 1139–1193), and Wang Shouren (王守仁 1472–1529). This philosophical lineage "has been revived by contemporary Neo-Confucians as their ultimate commitment" (Liu 1998: 13; Mou 1963: 57, 74). It is Spiritual Confucianism – the "Confucianism proper" – that this chapter is mainly concerned with.

> Despite efforts of periodisation or categorisation, denotational ambiguity may not be entirely eliminated. Take a classic debate over human nature between two pre-Qin Confucians for example. Whilst Mencius (孟子 ?BC 385 – ?BC 304) – the only other Confucian who has been given a Latinized name in the West – argues ardently that humans are kind by nature (*xingshan* 性善), Xunzi (荀子 ?BC 316 – BC 237) counters him that man is evil at birth.
>
> *(xing'e* 性惡*; Cf. Book XXIII of the Xunzi, in Wang 1988 rpt.: 434–49)*

Nonetheless, the broadness and richness of the term may not necessarily render our discussion unmanageable. Over the centuries, a corpus of texts – beginning as six classics in the pre-Qin[6] and culminating in the Thirteen Classics (*Shisan jing* 十三經) by the Qing[7] – have come to emerge as the canon of Confucianism. It includes the *Book of Changes* (*Zhouyi* 周易), the *Book of Songs* (*Shijing* 詩經), the *Book of Documents* (*Shangshu* 尚書), *The Rituals of the Zhou* (*Zhouli* 周禮), *The Book of Etiquette and Ceremonial* (*Yili* 儀禮), the *Book of Rites* (*Liji* 禮記), *The Zuo Commentary on the Spring and Autumn Annals* (*Chunqiu Zuoshi zhuan* 春秋左氏傳), *The Gongyang Commentary on the Spring and Autumn Annals* (*Chunqiu Gongyang zhuan* 春秋公羊傳), *The Guliang Commentary on the Spring and Autumn Annals* (*Chunqiu Guliang zhuan* 春秋穀梁傳), *The Analects* (*Lunyü* 論語), *Classic of Filial Piety* (*Xiaojing* 孝經), *Mencius* (*Mengzi* 孟子), and the first quasi-thesaurus in Chinese history *Erya* 爾雅. This is somewhat comparable to the Bible, which consists of a good number of books and epistles, etc. Much as doubts are cast time and again over their authorship, and therefore as to how far they are truly representative of the teachings of Confucius, it must be remembered that, as rightly pointed out by Dawson (1981), it was "the myth rather than the reality which was important" (7). It is the totality of the canon that has shaped Confucianism as it is today.

More importantly, there are some keywords, the enduring concepts – regardless of the period or the category – in the Confucian ethos which make the chassis of the philosophy. Apart from filial piety, they include morality (*de* 德), honesty (*cheng* 誠), benevolence (*ren* 仁),[8] rightness (*yi* 義), rituals and the proprieties (*li* 禮), wisdom (*zhi* 智), respect (*jing* 敬), faithfulness (*xin* 信), and the middle (optimal) way (*zhong* 中), to name but a handful. Our discussion in the ensuing pages will centre upon these core values. More attention will be given to the complex ones such as *ren*, *yi*, *li*, etc. Substantial reference will be made to the Thirteen Classics, together with some other relevant works such as the *Xunzi*. Before proceeding to these staple values, let me have a word on my approach.

There have been a plethora of works on the subject, but the core values are very often not explored in their own right. There are two lines of approach. The first is discussion of them in an historical survey of the development of Confucianism, for instance, Smith (1973), Liu (1955), Chai and Chai (1973), Berthrong (1998, 2010), Littlejohn (2011), Rainey (2010), Goldin (2011), etc. Another approach is exploration of Confucius's teachings from various perspectives – self-cultivation, governance, to name but two, for instance, Dawson (1981) and Ding (1997). Many of them are an amalgam of the two. Examples include Kaizuka (1956) and Gardner (2014).

There are two works, however, specifically dedicated to the fundamental ideas in Confucianism in English discourse, namely Hall and Ames (1987) and Ames (2011). What is not least commendable is that these two works are aimed at exploring Confucianism in its own right by having it contextualized and by means of Chinese etymology where appropriate. However, there seems to be hardly any analysis of the *summum bonum* of the Confucian philosophy, not to mention an overview of the core values with reference to this

ultimate goal. Moreover, due light, if not little, is as often as not been given to how the major concepts *relate*. Therefore, the desideratum that the present author hopes to fulfil is to *connect* the major Confucian concepts with reference to its *summum bonum* so that it not only enables the reader to get to grips with the subject matter, but also provides them with a solid basis for further reading and research, serving a complementary role to the existing literature, in particular Hall and Ames (1987) and Ames (2011).

Part A: *Summum Bonum* of Confucianism – *an* 安

In order to have a firm grasp of Confucianism, there is probably no better way than coming to grips, *inter alia*, with its very final goal in the first place. In Chinese, a Confucian is known by the term *ru* 儒, a term that had come into existence before the times of Confucius. The ultimate goal of the philosophy is likely to be located if one can ferret out the aim of a *ru*.

The *summum bonum* of Confucianism in Chinese is "*an* 安", roughly meaning "peace". This is shrewdly and concisely summarized in the definition of '*ru*' in *Shuowen jiezi* 說文解字 (Xu 1963: *juan* 8a, p. 162; Jao 1954), one of the earliest Chinese dictionaries by Xu Shen (許愼 58–148):[9]

> The aim of a *ru* is *an* [peace]. They are students of the *Way*. 儒，柔也。術士之偁。
>
> *(Xu 1963: juan 8a, p. 162)*

In the definition, "*an*" is polysemic, taking on more than one part of speech, for Chinese is an uninflected and therefore context-dependent language. There have been academic explorations into the concept of "*an*", for instance, Tang (2009), and one will with little doubt be aware that the word "*an*" has different senses when it is put into context, in particular it is cast in the light of different human relationships and different levels of society, in as much as Confucianism, in the words of the *Zhuangzi* 莊子, is a philosophy aimed at being "sagely within and kingly without" (*neisheng waiwang* 內聖外王) (Watson tr. 1968: 364) – a moral philosophy for one as a human being and a political philosophy for one as a ruler (leader). In other words, every single thing concerned with human beings is on the radar of Confucianism. In general, there are three levels in the *summum bonum* "*an*":

(a) no mistakes (*wujiu* 无咎/ *wuguo* 無過);[10]
    (i) safety (including health);
    (ii) good reputation (or no humiliation);
(b) peace of mind;
(c) stability under one's leadership.

The most primary interpretation of "*an*" is to prevent mistakes, ensuring one's physical safety (including health) and more importantly, one's moral character and hence good reputation as a human being. Therefore, Confucius said that "enter not a state that is in peril; stay not in a state that is in danger" (A 8.13; Lau tr. 1979: 94). To be sure, Confucianism is logically more concerned with the moral character, for it is, as mentioned, a moral philosophy, though physical safety should be of no less importance because both physical safety and moral integrity are filial responsibilities according to the *Classic of Filial Piety*,[11] a distinctive concept to which we shall return in Part B.

When physical safety and personal integrity are assured, it is natural to see one's heart put at ease, attaining peace in mind. Nonetheless, the Confucian *summum bonum* goes well beyond that. The perfect state of mind is that one's mind is independent of his surroundings – you are at ease irrespective of wealth, social status, political environment, and others' understanding of you. Therefore, according to the *Book of Change*, a gentleman (*junzi* 君子) "is not depressed when one is not in the political scene, when one's value is not

given due recognition 遯世无悶，不見是而无悶” (Ruan ed. 1980 rpt.: 15).[12] As a matter of fact, one would and *should* choose to stay out of the game when the political environment is unfavourable, a concept known as “*qiong* 窮” in Chinese because there is potential danger in terms of both personal safety and reputation. Similar quotes are seen in *The Analects* and *Mencius*.[13] Yan Hui (顏回 521–481 BCE), the most eminent disciple of Confucius, is famous for being undisturbed in penury, where he “liv[ed] in a mean dwelling on a bowlful of rice and a ladleful of water” (A 6.11; Lau tr. 1979: 82).

Much the same as other religions or rival teachings, namely Taoism and Buddhism in China, Confucianism is not confined to self-cultivation. It places enormous emphasis on how one gets on well with others in order to achieve harmony in a community. In this regard, self-cultivation serves dual purposes, which is as much an end in itself as a means to an end. We shall look into greater detail why self-cultivation is an end in itself in Part B when we explore the avenues to the *summum bonum*.

With others in mind, more importantly, the Confucian ethics attaches much importance to the role of a leader. A gentleman[14] – the sort of person that one should be committed to be – should take on leadership in both moral cultivation and the government, assuming a dual role of an exemplar and educator, making a gentleman of others by helping them “to take their stand” in virtue (A 6.30; Lau tr. 1979: 85) and where permitting, as a leader, ruling not only a state, but the entire empire – the Middle Kingdom, bringing stability to his land and happiness to his subjects.

That Confucianism devotes much attention to statecraft obviously has much to do with the era that Confucius lived through. It developed against the backdrop of tumultuous years of the Eastern Zhou known as the “Spring and Autumn 春秋” and “Warring States 戰國” when the Middle Kingdom was split into various states and there was incessant warfare against neighbouring states.[15] This largely explains in part the Chinese craving for “*an*”. As pointed out by Jao (1954), the word *“an”* is omnipresent in all the greeting expressions corresponding to “good morning”, “good afternoon”, and “good night” in Chinese (121).

Let us return to the role of a gentleman as educator and as leader in the government. One must note that these two roles are complimentary and equal in weight. One takes up a governmental post when the political environment is favourable to do so. Otherwise he would retire from the political scene, helping others to cultivate their personal integrity whilst he spares no effort to cultivate his in the meanwhile.[16]

To the Confucians, social stability is not achieved by force, but as mentioned, by ensuring the subjects’ peace in mind and happiness in the land through the exemplary conduct of the leader. It is believed that a land of happiness and stability will slowly but surely induce migrants from neighbouring states, so irresistible like water going downwards (M 1A: 6), eventually meeting the target of unification of states in the Middle Kingdom.[17]

Part B: making way to *“an”* the *summum bonum*

After outlining the three levels of *“an”*, the next questions to address are *how* this final goal can be achieved and *how* the conventional core concepts of Confucianism *relate* to it. These two questions bring us to two groups of core concepts, which open up the pathway to our destination. The first group is more general and is applicable to all human activities whereas the second is mainly aimed at Confucianism as a moral philosophy, making a subset of the first group of concepts.

I. The first group of concepts

The first group of concepts include *prescience* (*zhiji* 知幾), *timing* (*shi* 時), *position* (*wei* 位), and *the optimal way* (*zhong* 中). Personal safety (including health) being the most primary meaning of our *summum bonum*, it hinges upon two aspects: (1) one’s prescience and therefore awareness of danger, which is known as *zhiji* in Chinese, a concept emerging from the *Book of Change* and (2) sound judgement of (a) timing and (b) position.

To ensure safety, the best way is, as a matter of course, to avoid danger. This rests upon one's prescience and hence the ability to identify danger in the very first place and nip it in the bud. *Ji* 幾 in *zhiji*, prescience, literally means "infinitesimalness" (Xu 1963: *juan* 4b, p. 84).[18] It refers to a process of development in its infancy. Whilst the word *ji per se* could be neutral in value, it is potentially perilous when the topsy-turvy background against which the Confucian ethics took shape is taken into consideration. Early detection of danger means early avoidance of it, thus bringing about safety.[19] In other words, Confucianism is a philosophy that teaches one, in Mencius's words, how to "survive in adversity 生於憂患" (M 6B: 12.15; Lau tr. 1970: 143).

The ideas of preventing danger and righting the wrong as early as possible take an important place in the *Book of Change* and *The Middle Way* (*Zhongyong* 中庸), which is more commonly known as the *Doctrine of the Mean* to English readers. Therefore, the latter reads at the outset that "a gentleman is vigilant of things that go beyond his eyes and ears a gentleman stands on guard over the evil ideas when being alone 君子戒愼乎其所不睹。恐懼乎其所不聞 . . . 故君子愼其獨也". From the idea of steering clear of danger comes a famous saying in Chinese which grows out of *Mencius*: "one 'does not stand under a wall on the verge of collapse'" (Cf. M 7A: 2; Lau tr. 1970: 182).[20]

In addition to being aware of danger *ab initio*, one does not make mistakes if one can make the right decision with reference to his own position and timing – a decision that is the most ideal, an equilibrium, an optimal decision, a mid-point between two extremes, a happy mean known as ***zhong*** 中 in Chinese, a concept so important that to which a chapter entitled "The Middleway" is devoted in the *Book of Rites*. This piece of work, along with another chapter entitled "The Great Learning (*Daxue* 大學)" in the *Book of Rites*, *The Analects*, and *Mencius*, later comprised the "Four Books" (*Sishu* 四書), an anthology first put together by Zhu Xi of the Song dynasty as a textbook for the imperial civil service exam.

In determining the optimal point with reference to time and position, one is arriving at *the* decision – the best decision, a decision measured against the yardstick as to whether it is in tune with the Way of Heaven and Earth (*tiandi zhi dao* 天地之道), which is also known as Tao, the laws of the universe, the patterns that one finds in this universe, for human beings are part of this world. Therefore, keeping oneself in step in every aspect of life with the Tao is a guarantee against mistakes and harms.[21] As a matter of fact, as an aside, ancient sobriquets may also cast light on the reverence of the Chinese for Heaven. A notable example is Sun Wukong 孫悟空, the monkey protagonist in *The Journey to the West* (*Xiyou ji* 西遊記), who is often known as "Qitian dasheng 齊天大聖" (The Great Sage in par with Heaven). Ancients would only look to Heaven but there does not seem to be anyone in Chinese history who claimed to be able to put Heaven in the shade.

Closely associated with *zhong* the optimal point is the concept of adjustment (*bian* 變). Inspired by the fact that the Earth revolves around the sun, giving rise to four seasons, the Chinese world view holds that everything in this world is in constant movement (cf. A 17.19; Lau tr. 1979: 146). As a result, one has to make constant adjustment in order to ensure that the optimal point or state is achieved in every moment. This is known as *shizhong* 時中 in Chinese. A convenient analogue is the driver's manoeuvre in order to keep a vehicle in the middle of a meandering lane.

To the Confucians, staying in the optimal point or state is crucial as a means to achieve *"an"*, thereby ensuring sustainability and longevity,[22] examples that fall into the box of Yang 陽, for Confucianism is an ideology that promotes Yang, the positive shaping force, but suppresses Yin 陰, the negative shaping force (*fuyang yiyin* 扶陽抑陰). Sustainability means the potential to ensure completion (*youzhong* 有終), a concept which Chinese culture holds dear.

II. The second group of concepts

Compared with the first group of concepts, the second group are more specific, concentrating on the moral subjectivity of mankind and all Confucian moral virtues.[23] Moral subjectivity is the defining

distinction between human beings and animals (*renqin zhi bie* 人禽之別), a cornerstone of Confucianism, a precept that the entire Confucian ethos is predicated upon. According to the *Oxford English Dictionary*, subjectivity refers to the "consciousness of one's states or actions" ('Subjectivity,' 2012). Moral subjectivity, therefore, means one's consciousness of being moral. Confucianism holds that human beings are able to act virtuously at will whereas animals are unable or unconscious of the need to do so. Under this distinction comes the household concepts in the Chinese-speaking communities such as benevolence 仁, rightness 義, rituals and the proprieties 禮, etc. The line "benevolence is what constitutes human beings 仁者，人也" in *Mencius* and *The Middle Way* is perhaps a succinct and mnemonic summary of this distinction.

It has been argued in the previous section that keeping oneself in tune with the Way of Heaven and Earth is a guarantee of *"an"*. Given the natural conferment of moral subjectivity, being virtuous is part of the effort and a necessary condition to keep oneself in parallel with the Tao. This has been summed up intelligently in the traditional gloss of the word "virtue (*de* 德)" with a homophone – homogenous both in pronunciation and in tone – "to secure (*de* 得)":[24]

> Virtue is what one has obtained [from Heaven] 德者得也.

That means, in other words, immorality will bring about trouble, inevitably, with regard to the ingredients of *"an"* put forward in Part A, inviting humiliation to one as a human being and compromising one's authority as a leader. Therefore, the *Xunzi* reads that "virtues such as benevolence and rightness are paths to constant peace ('*an*') 仁義德行，常安之術也" (Wang ed. 1988 rpt.: 62).

After establishing the relationship between virtue and *"an"*, the next step I intend to take is to give shape to the idea of Confucian virtue. What does it consist of? What are the moral values behind it? A quote from *The Analects* may furnish us with some clues:

> The Master said, 'I set my heart on the Way, base myself on virtue, lean upon benevolence for support and take my recreation in the arts 志於道，據於德，依於仁，游於藝'.
>
> *(A 7.6; Lau tr. 1979: 86)*

According to Confucius, he based himself on virtue and leant upon benevolence in order to obtain the Way. In this quote, the relationship between virtue and benevolence has been highlighted. Benevolence here is a generic word in which all moral qualities in Confucianism crystallized. In the remainder of this chapter, I have singled out five moral concepts for detailed discussion. The first is *ren* – benevolence.

i. Ren 仁

So far, we have adopted "benevolence" as the translation of *ren*. In fact, as we shall see, "benevolence" or other translations only represent a fraction of its senses (Chan 1955; Cheung 2012). By no means is it competent as a generic word for all Confucian moral qualities. Therefore, I shall hereinafter adopt the transliteration *ren* to refer to this umbrella term, except in quotations.

Ren being an all-embracing term of all moral values, it has never, however, been treated with a precise definition by Confucius. This could perhaps be attributed to the Chinese partiality for concreteness in its culture, at least traditional culture, which shies away from theorizing (Jao 1997: 177–8). One thing that is certain, nevertheless, is that not many in history, in Confucius's opinion, could live up to *ren*. Even Yan Hui (顏回 521–491 BCE), the most pre-eminent disciple of Confucius who passed away in his thirties, is said to be able to sustain without losing hold of the criteria for *ren* for merely a couple of months (A 6.7).

That said, it is possible to arrive at a tenable denotation of this very concept through informed induction, which is rightly pointed out by such scholars as the late Prof. Lao Sze Kwang (勞思光 1927–2012),

Yang Bojun (楊伯峻 1909–1992) in his short essay preceding his successful *Lünyu yizhu* 論語譯注 – the first translation of *The Analects* from Classical Chinese into Vernacular Chinese and D.C. Lau in his introduction to his translation of *The Analects* published in the Penguin Classics series. According to them, an episode in *The Analects* may throw light on the two aspects that *ren* comprises – the first focusing on one as an individual whilst the second on one as a social being (Lao 1965: 28; Yang 1979: 16; Lau tr. 1979: 15–16). It is quoted thus:

> The Master said, 'Tsan! There is one single thread binding my way together'.
> Tseng Tzu assented.
> After the Master had gone out, the disciple asked, 'What did he mean?'
> Tseng Tzu said, 'The way of the Master consists in doing one's best and in using oneself as a measure to gauge the likes and dislikes of others'.
>
> *(A 4.15; Lau tr. 1979: 74)*

This conversation reveals two elements running through Confucius's system of thought: (1) devotion – doing one's best (*zhong* 忠) and (2) fellow-feeling (*shu* 恕) – "using oneself as a measure to gauge the likes and dislikes of others". In other words, one side of the coin is on self-cultivation whilst the other on human relationship.

The traditional interpretation of *zhong* is doing one's best (*jinji zhi wei zhong* 盡己之謂忠), an interpretation by Zhu Xi (1983 rpt.: 72). Apparently Lau's translation was based on his glosses. Given the immense importance of virtue in Confucianism, needless to say, what one spares no effort to do is moral cultivation (*xiushen* 修身), though it should be noted that in no way does the term *zhong* rule out one's effort into other aspects, for instance, learning, an area we shall further delve into next.

The opening chapter of *The Great Learning* has afforded a four-step guide to self-cultivation:

Step 1: firm grasp of the nature of things (*gewu* 格物)[25]
Step 2: advancement of knowledge (*zhizhi* 致知)
Step 3: genuineness; i.e. do not be deceptive about the real understanding of the world (*chengyi* 誠意)
Step 4: right-mindedness; i.e. be incorruptible (*zhengxin* 正心)

The argument advanced in *The Great Learning* is that one is able to be incorruptible and behave morally when one can tell right from wrong. This relies on one's firm grasp of the nature of things, predominately the optimal way of how things work. Of course, this rests entirely upon the premise that one is genuine – he is not deceptive about right and wrong and upon the assumption that a gentleman would make a rational choice to bring himself close to positive things only.

In connection with genuineness is the concept of standing guard over evil thoughts in our privacy, which is known as *shendu* 愼獨 in Chinese. This goes back to the idea of prescience, of preventing danger (*zhiji*) discussed in the first group of core concepts. To foreground the importance of *shengdu*, Zeng Zi remarks in *The Great Learning* that one may imagine that "there are ten (i.e. an immense number of) eyes gazing at you and ten fingers pointing at you" when one is alone. For that reason Confucius said that "to return to the observance of the rites through overcoming the self constitutes benevolence 克己復禮為仁" (A 12.1; Lau tr. 1979: 112).

Compared with *zhong*, its counterpart *shu* is much more straightforward, for Confucius did on one occasion give a definition to it, that is, to restrain from being imposing (A 15.24). Upon consultation by his disciple Zigong, who was known for his rhetoric, for one single word that could serve as a guide throughout his life, Confucius replied thus: "Do not impose on others what you yourself do not desire 己所不欲，勿施於人" (A 15.24; Lau tr. 1979: 135). To cast it in a more positive light, this is to exercise one's fellow-feeling and to show your consideration and love for others. Therefore, when his disciple Fan Chi

樊遲 enquired about *ren*, Confucius's reply was to "love your fellow men" (A 12.22; Lau tr. 1979: 116). It must be pointed out that one's consideration and love for others should be rationally and duly expressed in relation to different relationships. We shall look into it in greater depth in the next section when we come to rituals and the proprieties (*li*).

Whilst *ren* is an all-embracing concept for all virtues in Confucianism, consisting of both *zhong* and *shu*, it is a virtue itself when attention is paid only to the second component. This is often known as the "narrower sense of *ren*" in Chinese academic discourse. As a matter of fact, etymologically speaking, the Chinese character speaks volumes about this narrower sense of the word. The modern character *ren* 仁 is composed of two parts: the radical 人 (human) on the left and 二 (two) on the right, which is a symbol of others. The whole grapheme, therefore, denotes that one goes beyond oneself for others. An archaic form of the character 忎 is even more evocative in this regard. The character for "thousand" 千 sits above the radical 心 (a heart), so to be *ren* is to extend your heart to thousands of people (Xu 1963: *juan* 8a, p. 161).

We have made an attempt to arrive at a definition of *ren* by making reference to the two aspects self-cultivation (*zhong*) and human relationships (*shu*) that Zeng Zi mentioned to his disciples in *The Analects*. Bearing in mind these two components, one may find that there could be various, if not unexhaustive ways to recast the definition of *ren* from the Confucian canon. For instance, the following quote from *The Analects* is also traditionally considered as another definition:

> A benevolent man helps others to take their stand in so far as he himself wishes to take his stand, and gets others there in so far as he himself wishes to get there 己欲立而立人，己欲達而達人.
>
> *(A 6.30; Lau tr. 1979: 85)*

The opening line of *The Great Learning* may serve the same purpose:

> The aim of the Great Learning is to manifest one's natural luminous virtue and to help others cultivate theirs. 大學之道, 在明明德, 在親民.
>
> *(R 43.1)*

Likewise, with extension of love for others in mind, the annotative text "The General Image (*Daxiang* 大象)" to the second hexagram *kun* 坤 in the *Book of Change* may be taken as a footnote to the narrower sense of *ren*:[26]

> The characteristic of the Earth [is that it does not leave out anything]. In view of this, a gentleman is kind and generous as a person 地勢坤，君子以厚德載物.
>
> *(See Ruan ed. 1980 rpt.: 18)*

Ren, albeit difficult to achieve and sustain, is a moral quality that every single person is born with. Therefore, Confucius said, "Is benevolence really far away? No sooner do I desire it than it is here 仁遠乎哉？我欲仁，斯仁至矣" (A 7.30; Lau tr. 1979: 90). If one is determined to live up to the expectations of *ren*, Confucius said that he had never "come across such a man whose strength proves insufficient for the task" (A 4.6; Lau tr. 1979: 72–73). Moreover, despite its difficulty, a gentleman does not for a second turn his back on *ren*. Therefore, Confucius said that a gentleman "never deserts benevolence, not even for as long as it takes to eat a meal. If he hurries and stumbles one may be sure that it is in benevolence that he does so" (A 4.5; Lau tr. 1979: 72).

Somewhat like Buddhism, there is a hierarchy of attainments with regard to one's self-cultivation. As mentioned in Part A, a gentleman is the sort of character that one should aspire to be, one who is able to achieve *ren*.[27] Moreover, he is a leader in moral cultivation in the hope to assert positive influence over the

moral standards of a community (*yifeng yisu* 移風易俗). Confucius compares in *The Analects* the virtue of a gentleman to wind and that of a small man – small in terms of moral status and mind – to grass and is confident that "[l]et the wind blow over the grass and it is sure to bend" (A 12.19; Lau tr. 1979: 115–16).

Above the gentleman, a man of *ren*, there is in fact a higher level – the "sage" level (*sheng* 聖). There does not seem to be clear criteria laid down by Confucius in the Thirteen Classics, but a dialogue between Confucius and the Duke Ai of the Lu State 魯哀公 documented in the *Xunzi* may throw light in this regard. It is paraphrased thus:

> The so-called Great Sage has a thorough understanding of the Way, a high level of flexibility, and a firm grasp of the nature of everything . . . The nature [of things] is the yardstick against which one measures right and wrong, guiding one what to take and what to leave out. Therefore, what the Sage does has an impact on the whole world. The Sage as an educator is comparable to wind and rain [which facilitate the running of the earth system]. What he does is beyond the common people.
>
> *(Wang ed. 1988 rpt.: 541–2)*

It can be seen that a sage and a gentleman are similar in their commitment to moral cultivation and education, but a sage is surpassing in the impact of him as educator, which knows no boundaries – he transformed his subjects from barbarians to civilized men and women. Moreover, he is unrivalled in his perfect grasp of the nature of things. In other words, he is in every way, every moment completely in accord with the Tao. He stands clear of mistakes, achieving successfully the *summum bonum* "*an*".

Before we bring this section to a close, let us return to fellow feeling – the second component of *ren*. When it is put into practice, expressing one's consideration and love for others in different human relationships, there will be various virtues which are familiar to the Chinese ears, representing different attitudes which are considered the ideal (achieving the status *zhong* the optimal point) to a specific target in the relationship. There is a good summary of these virtues in *The Great Learning*:

> An ideal ruler (leader) is one who loves his people (*ren* 仁); an ideal minister (subordinate) is one who is reverent *(jing* 敬); an ideal son (child) is one who treats his parents well (*xiao* 孝); an ideal father (parent) is one who is kind to his children (*ci* 慈). In dealing with his fellow countrymen, one holds faithfulness dear (*xin* 信).
>
> *(R 43.1)*

In addition to them, there are some other virtues, for instance, a younger brother should ideally be respectful of his elder brother, which is known as *ti* 悌 in Chinese. To achieve these various ideals so that love in each and every single relationship is duly expressed, *li* 禮, which comprises rituals and the proprieties, is called into play.

ii. Rituals and the proprieties (Li 禮*)*

We are now aware of the importance of virtue, a unique bestowment from Heaven, which sets us aside from any other creatures on earth and enables us to take up the highest position on the biological scale. Given our natural moral subjectivity, we are able to show our consideration and love for others in the hope to achieve harmony in society.

The sum total of the means we put across our consideration and love, spoken or written, linguistic or extra-linguistic, in cash or in kind, is known as *li* in Chinese. Therefore, one of the traditional glosses for *li* is the alliterative *lü* 履, literally meaning "to put into practice" (Xu 1963: *juan* 1a, p. 7). In other words, the *raison d'être* of rituals and the proprieties is to get our consideration and love for others across, and *ren* is the *sine qua non* (A 3.3).

Having established that *ren* is a unique bestowment upon man and *li* the realization of one's consideration and love for others, we may, following this line of thought, come to the conclusion that *li* provides the means to act in accordance with the Tao,[28] thus putting us at ease as a human individual, and ensuring all coming into contact with us harmony as a social being. This is explicitly spelt out in the *Book of Rites:* "There is peace in those with *li*. Otherwise, one will be in peril人有禮則安，無禮則危' (R 1.7). Moreover, *ren* being a unique bestowment upon man, *li* enables man to be "self-conscious about their superiority over animals 知自別於禽獸" (R 1.6).

More importantly, as pointed out by Jao Tsung-i (2009), given the correspondence between *li* and the cosmic patterns, *li*, as actualization of the heavenly bestowment of moral subjectivity, enables one to live their lives to the full not only as a mere human being, but more importantly, as a complete man (*chengren* 成人) – complete in the archaic sense being perfect ('Complete,' 2012).[29] This is known as gracefulness (*wen* 文) (cf. Jao 1996: 20).

There is, in the *Book of Etiquettes and Ceremonial*, the *Rites of the Zhou*, the *Book of Rites*, together with miscellaneous documentations to varying degree in some other works of the Thirteen Classics, meticulous detail as to how one should behave under different circumstances. *The Middle Way* reads that there are 'three hundred maxims of the ritual code, and the ten times more on discipline in conduct 禮儀三百，成儀三千" (R 32.25; Hughes tr. 1942: 135). It is out of the question to go into every single detail. Nevertheless, there are some aspects which are considered more important than others, thus receiving more attention in the Confucian canon, for instance, funerals, music etc. (Cf. R 45.4).[30] More importantly, it is the spirit and rationale of *li* that matter (A 17.11; R 11.24).[31]

An important function of *li* is to regulate the emotions and desires of man, which are essentially atavistic. As mentioned in the first group of concepts, it is crucial to achieve the optimum, that is, "we should look neither for multitude nor for paucity, but for the due relative proportion 不可多也，不可寡也，唯其稱也" in rituals and the proprieties (R 10.18; Legge tr. 1976 rpt: vol. 3, p. 402). Otherwise man's health and dignity (i.e. the ingredients of *"an"*) might be at stake.

From the ideal "due relative proportion" may one infer that there is differentiation in *li*. This could be attributed to the kind and nature of activities and human relationships. In the rest of this section on *li*, we shall concentrate on the link between *li* and human relationships.

As pointed out in the previous section, consideration and love for others should be consonant with a relationship. In other words, it is not equal for everybody. Rather, there is a hierarchical order of consideration and love in proportion to one's relationship with others and one's status in a community, which is duly reflected in the complexities of the rituals and the proprieties.

The hierarchy is not meant to create inequality, but to ensure that social activities are in tune with the Tao in order to secure *"an"*, for it is faithful replication of the Way of the universe – everything can be pinned down along the continuum of degree according to size, distance, relationship, etc.

There are two kinds of hierarchies. The first is a horizontal one, where differentiation is realized in accordance with relationship. In imperial China, there were five major kinds of relationships, which are indicated in the following table:

Table 12.1 Hierarchical order of five major relationships

Ruler (leader) and Minister (subordinates)	Father and Son	**Man and Wife**	Elder Brother and Younger Brother	Friends

"Man and Wife" takes the central position in human relationships, for it is the starting point of other relationships.[32] Generally speaking, the farther away from "man and wife", the less intimate is the relationship, which has been indicated by both the font size and the darkness of the background colour in the table. This hierarchy in relationship can be revealed in the following quote from "Quli shang 曲禮上", the first book of the *Book of Rites*:

> With the enemy who has slain his father, one should not live under the same heaven. With the enemy who has slain his brother, one should never have his sword to seek (to deal vengeance). With the enemy who has slain his intimate friend, one should not live in the same state (without seeking to slay him).
>
> *(R 1.38; Legge 1976 rpt.: vol. 3, p. 92)*

We are told that the greatest importance has been attached to the father and son relationship, for this is, together with the relationship with brothers (and sisters), given by birth – parents are even the source of life of every human being. Therefore, they are always the first receiving end of one's love, which radiates in a declining degree as the level of intimacy in a relationship descends. Therefore, it is said in *The Analects* (Book One) – right after the first quote on the importance of learning – that "the Way will fall in place when the basis has been established 本立而道生" and that "filial piety and brotherly respect are the point of departure of *ren* 其為仁之本" (A 1.2). This provides an explanation to why the mourning period should be as long as three years when parents have passed away (A 17.21).

Another kind is vertical hierarchy, where differentiation is made in accordance with status. For instance, the ruler is more superior to the minister and the elder brother enjoys a higher position than the younger brother. The *Book of Rites* has given us numerous examples as to how *li* varies with status. For instance, "Quli xia 曲禮下", the second book of the *Book of Rites*, stipulates how one should hold a thing in the presence of others. The general rule is that the higher the status an article belongs to, the higher that one should hold it:

> An article belonging to the son of Heaven should be held higher than the heart; one belonging to a ruler of a state, on a level with it; one belonging to a Great officer, lower than it; and one belonging to an (inferior) officer should be carried lower still.
>
> *(R 2.1; Legge tr.1976 rpt.: vol. 3, pp. 99–100)*

Despite our dichotomic distinction, both hierarchies, together with some other factors such as the kind and nature of an activity which has been mentioned are at play in real practice. A case in point is that there are different prescriptions for different classes of people to measure up to the moral quality *xiao* in the *Book of Filial Piety* (See Ruan ed. 1980 rpt.: 2537–62). One may find that, however, there is one thing that runs through the factors to be considered in *li*, which is appropriateness. After all, *li* is all about achieving appropriateness in the various factors under consideration. This brings us to the next virtue, "rightness".

iii. Rightness (Yi 義)

Sitting between *li* and *ren* is rightness (*yi*). It is – in modern parlance – the mechanism which ensures that one's consideration and love for others is effectively expressed. It informs one how much has to be done in order to optimally bring across one's consideration and love. It is the moral dimension of the idea of *zhong* the optimal way, which has been thoroughly discussed in the first group of concepts.

Yi is the mechanism that advises the application of *li* – it is the moral compass. It has been traditionally defined as "appropriate 宜也" in Chinese classics, for instance, *The Middle Way*. In fact, to be precise, *yi* means to do the most appropriate thing, which is the right thing (*shì* 是) at the right time (*shí* 時) – all three characters "*yi* 宜", "*shí* 時", and "*shì* 是" are phonetically connected. As a matter of fact, they could even be interchangeable in a sentence when they are used as adjectives.

Etymologically speaking, the Chinese character for rightness is, in fact, 誼. According to *Shuowen jiezi*, the character means "what is appropriate as a human being 人所宜也" (Xu 1963: *juan* 3a, p. 53). A crucial point here is by what yardstick do we measure "appropriateness (*yi* 宜)" against. If we look up "appropriateness" in *Shuowen jiezi*, it will be found that "appropriateness" means "what puts one at ease 所安也" (Xu 1963: *juan* 7b, p. 151), corresponding to the *summum bonum* under discussion.

Rightness often goes hand in hand with *ren*. Given that one of the aspects of *ren* is to show one's consideration and love for others in a reasonable way, one has to act appropriately in *every* relationship in order to achieve *ren*. The relationship between rightness and *ren* is best captured in Wen Tianxiang's (文天祥 1236–1283) words, "*ren* is attained when rightness is fulfilled in every single act 惟其義盡，所以仁至" (Xiong *et al* ed. 1987: 394).

Whilst rightness means what is appropriate and therefore what puts you at ease, as a human being, by no means is it effortless. The most taxing thing is to strike a delicate balance and get to grips with the middle (optimal) way. Therefore, it is said in *The Analects* and *The Middle Way* that the middle (optimal) way being a moral virtue "has long been rare amongst the common people" (A 6.29), according to Confucius. That the Master himself was not able to achieve this until the age of seventy is a testament to its difficulty:

> at seventy I followed my heart's desire without overstepping the line.
>
> *(A 2.4: Lau tr. 1979: 63)*

Here one's wisdom (*zhi* 智) is brought to bear upon arriving at the best decision.[33] It also directs one to make moral discretion where necessary, which will be explored in greater detail following our discussion on learning below.

iv. Learning (xue 學)

There are two sources of wisdom. Certainly, the ideal is that wisdom comes by birth. Therefore, Confucius said that "those who are born with knowledge are the highest" (A 16.9; Lau tr. 1979: 140). But Confucius was not amongst them, as he remarked (A 7.20; Lau tr. 1979: 88). One is still appreciated if one "attain[s] knowledge through study", or "turn[s] to study after having been vexed by difficulties" (Ibid). Those who refuse to study even after being "vexed by difficulties" are considered the lowest class of people (Ibid).

Confucianism attaches immense importance to learning. As mentioned, *The Great Learning* lays down "*gewu* – a firm grasp of the nature of things in the world" as the first step towards self-cultivation. Moreover, editorial arrangement in some Confucian classics is good proof of the importance of learning in Confucianism. *The Analects*, *Xunzi*, and *Fayan* 法言 by Yang Xiong (揚雄 53 BCE–18 CE), to name but three, start off respectively with learning. There is even a book dedicated to learning and education in the *Book of Rites* entitled "On Education (*Xueji* 學記)", where there is a comprehensive scheme of education for children. In the previous sections, we have explained the contribution of *li* to the *summum bonum "an"*. After highlighting the function of *li*, the first Book of the *Book of Rites* carries on to aver that "the rules of propriety should by no means be left unlearned" (R 1.7; Legge tr. 1976 rpt.: vol. 3, p. 65).

Confucius himself was eager to learn. He said that he could "learn without flagging" (A 7.2, Lau tr. 1979: 86), and his determination to learn was beyond compare "in a hamlet of ten households" (A 5.28, Lau tr. 1979: 80). He set his heart on learning (the Way) at the age of fifteen (A 2.4; Lau tr. 1979: 63). He foregrounds the importance of learning when addressing the disproportion between learning and thinking:

> If one learns from others but does not think, one will be bewildered. If, on the other hand, one thinks but does not learn from others, one will be in *peril*.
>
> *(A 2.15; Lau tr. 1979: 65, my italics)*

The master further elaborated on the perils of not eager to learn in *The Analects* (A 17.8), which are not to be reproduced here.

One should be eager not only to learn, but also to learn extensively (A 19.6, Lau tr. 1979: 153). This notion of extensive learning appears also in the *Book of Change* and *The Middle Way*. The reason behind this is, according to Confucius, that a gentleman is expected to be versatile and "is no vessel" (A 2.12, Lau tr. 1979: 64). That means, a polymath is much more preferable to a professional, and as a matter of fact of course, the Chinese strong preference for wholeness plays a significant part in this regard.

The subjects that Confucius taught may also cast light on the importance of versatility in Confucianism. Apart from the six traditional items, namely rituals and the proprieties, music, archery, horse-riding, writing, and arithmetic as well as six classics, which are put under the Chinese term "*liuyi* 六藝", there are four subjects known to be taught by Confucius according to *The Analects*, which are virtuous conduct, speech, government, and culture and learning (A 11.3; Lau tr. 1979: 106), or "culture, moral conduct, doing one's best and being trustworthy in what one says 文行忠信" (A 7.25; Lau tr. 1979: 89), according to another Book in *The Analects*.

Amongst various subjects, the most crucial skill to learn is the middle way. As mentioned in the foregoing explication of *ren*, self-cultivation can be achieved by taking "recreation in the arts' (A 7.6; Lau tr. 1979: 86). To be more precise, the purpose of taking recreation in the arts, or of developing a disinterest in everything is to come to grips with, amongst others, the middle (optimal) way as to how things work, thereby eventually contributing to your moral cultivation as aforementioned.

v. Moral discretion (quan 權)

We have by far looked into various Confucian moral verities, which are important as yardsticks against which to measure whether one lives up to the expectations as a human being, thereby achieving the *summum bonum* "*an*". One may question, nonetheless, whether the Confucian ethics and the gargantuan details on rituals and the proprieties prescribed in the classics are compatible with the contemporary world, given the collapse of the old imperial social order, the substantial progress in every possible aspect of lives, and the all-the-more fast-paced globalization. It is time that the concept *quan* 權 entered the scene, which, again, requires one's wisdom.[34]

According to *Shuowen jiezi*, "*quan*" means "going against the norm (*fanchang* 反常)" (Xu 1963: *juan* 6a, p. 117). As a matter of fact, whilst one may feel that Confucianists are pedantic about behaviour, it is important to be aware of the fact that the rituals and proprieties are not strictly adamantine. This is well supported in the Confucian canon. For instance, Zixia remarked that

> if one does not overstep the bounds in major matters, it is of no consequence if one is not meticulous in minor matters'.
>
> *(A 19.11; Lau tr. 1979: 154)*[35]

The possibility of moral discretion is even clearly documented in *The Analects* as the highest rung on the ladder of attainment in learning:

> The Master said, 'A man good enough as a partner in one's attempt to learn need not be good enough as a partner in the pursuit of the Way; a man good enough as a partner in the pursuit of the Way need not be good enough in a common stand; a man good enough as a partner in a common stand need not be good enough as a partner in the exercise of *moral discretion*'.
>
> *(A 9.30; Lau tr. 1979: 100, my italics)*[36]

A classic illustration can be found in a reply by Mencius as to whether one should give a hand – literally – to rescue a drowning female relative, for the *Book of Rites* stipulates that there shall be no physical contact between a male and a female in giving and taking (R 1. 24). Mencius said,

> 'Not to help a sister-in-law who is drowning is to be a brute. It is prescribed by the rites that, in giving and receiving, man and woman should not touch each other, but in stretching out a helping hand to the drowning sister-in-law one uses one's discretion'.
>
> *(M 4A: 17; Lau tr. 1970: 124)*[37]

It must be remembered that whilst the Confucian maxims, to a certain degree, can be violated, it must be done with the utmost caution. *The Gongyang Commentary of the Spring and Autumn Annals* provides a clear guide in this regard:

> What is moral discretion? It means violating the moral norm thereby bringing about positive impacts. . . . The principle of moral discretion is that one may exercise it at his own expense, but never in a deleterious manner to others 權者何？權者反於經，然後有善者也 . . . 行權有道，自貶損以行權，不害人以行權.
>
> *(Ruan ed. 1980 rpt.: 2220)*

Conclusion

In the previous pages, it has been argued with reference to *Shuowen jiezi* that the *summum bonum* of Confucianism is "*an*". From this essential goal have branched out a myriad of concepts, which may broadly fall into two groups. The first include prescience, timing, position, the middle (optimal) way, and adjustment, which have universality in their application. Confucianism being as much a moral philosophy as a political philosophy, the second group of concepts are concerned with morality, upon which should one's leadership rest. They include *ren* (both the broad sense and the narrow sense), rightness, rituals and the proprieties, wisdom, filial piety, learning, and moral discretion etc., which all contribute to man's superiority over animals. If Confucius were a coeval of Shakespeare, he would perhaps join Miranda in *The Tempest* to cry "how beauteous mankind is" (Shakespeare, Kermode ed. 1964, 5.1.184)!

To be sure, Confucianism is part of traditional Chinese culture. How far is it applicable to our lives today? Whilst there were chants of "Down with Confucianism" in iconoclastic 1920s China, there is an exponential growth in the number of Confucius Institute round the world in the twenty-first century. The question is, how far are the Confucian concepts compatible with contemporary values, for instance, democracy? Are they out of date? Apparently some are, not least some of the correctitude laid down in the classics.

Nonetheless, that some ritual requirements are out of sync with the times does not nullify the entire philosophy, for amongst the virtues we have looked into, the middle way is of essence – it weaves its way into nearly every one of them. Without it, "*an*" the *summum bonum* would be will o' the wisp. By definition, the middle way implies flexibility. As mentioned, it means that one can always hold on to the equilibrium, arriving at the most optimal decision in whichever hat he wears. In other words, it is obvious that Confucianism is timeless and is applicable to every community. The *Book of Rites* even clearly spells out that time as a factor comes to the fore as far as *li* is concerned (R 10.4).

The twenty-first century is an era that finds security all the more important, not least after the 9/11 attack when many nations have stepped up measures to ensure national security. The essential goal of Confucianism being peace, can this ancient but timeless system of thought be looked to for enlightenment?

Notes

1 The tone is not indicated in the Romanization unless where necessary.
2 Buddhism is from India, despite its far-reaching impact on literally every aspect in China. For a succinct account of the impact of Confucianism on China, see Dawson (1981: 79–85). Incidentally, please note that philosophical categorization into Confucianism and Taoism etc. did not come into existence until the appearance of "A Critical Bibliography (*yiwenzhi* 藝文志)" in the *History of the Han* (*Hanshu* 漢書) in the second century, the first surviving book catalogue in China.
3 As *The Analects* (*Lünyu* 論語) and *Mencius* (*Mengzi* 孟子) will be substantially cited in the ensuing pages, the letter "A" is to indicate *The Analects*, "M" *Mencius*, and "R" *Book of Rites* (*Liji* 禮記). For the convenience of the reader, versions where the full text is numbered consecutively have been adopted. Reference to the Chinese version of *The Analects* and *Mencius* is to Yang Bojun's (楊伯峻 1909–1992) *Lünyu yizhu* 論語譯注 (1980) and *Mengzi yizhu* 孟子譯注 (1960), which are easily accessible. Reference to the *Book of Rites* is to Lau and Chen (1992).
4 Included, too, in Berthrong's discussion is the development of Confucianism in East Asia, which is beyond the scope of this chapter.
5 For detail, see Jao (1974/2015).
6 In fact, there were just five, for *the Classic of Music* (*Yuejing* 樂經) had already gone missing by the pre-Qin period. For the significance of these six classics to Confucianism and to Chinese culture at large, see Guo (2007).
7 For a more detailed account of the development of the Confucian canon into the present "Thirteen Classics", please consult Zhang (2013).
8 There have been over sixteen translations of the concept *ren* (Chan 1955), but none of them seems to be an adequate one without leading to distortion. "Benevolence" being one of the most popular translations of *ren*, I might as well adopt it until I home in on this very concept in the next section.
9 Whilst Xu Shen is considered the forefather of Chinese etymology today, he was in fact held in high esteem for his expertise in the Five Classics in his times.
10 *Wujiu*无咎 is a term unique in the *Book of Change*, where 无 rather than 無 has been adopted throughout.
11 The book sets out right at the beginning the criteria of filial piety. Assuring personal safety is the initial step – bringing pride and a good name to parents is the ultimate goal: "身體髮膚。受之父母。不感毀傷。孝之始也。立身行道。揚名於後世。以顯父母。孝之終也". See Ruan ed. (1980 rpt.: 2545).
12 We shall look into greater detail the Confucian gentleman and his political ambition two paragraphs later.
13 For the timing in participation in politics, see A 8.13; M 7A: 9. For serenity despite under-recognition of one's value, see A 1.16, 4.14; 7.11 and 14.30.
14 Etymologically speaking, *jun* 君 means a leader who commands. See Xu (1963: *juan* 2a, p. 32).
15 For detail, please consult Roberts (2011: 8–20).
16 "On Leadership Inspired by the Hexagram *Qian* (*Qian wenyan* 乾文言)" of the *Book of Change* reads: '樂則行之，憂則違之'. For an elucidation of 'wenyan', see Tang (2002).
17 The idea of attracting immigrants is also documented elsewhere, e.g. *The Middle Way* (*Zhongyong* 中庸). See R 32.16.
18 *Shuowen jiezi* reads: '幾、微也。殆也。从　从戍。戍、兵守也。而兵守者危也" (Xu 1963: *juan* 4b, p. 84).
19 The original in the *Book of Change* reads: "幾者，動之微也，吉之先見者也".
20 The original reads: "君子不立巖牆之下". Another quote from the *Book of Rites* serving a similar vein is "a gentleman is cautious to avoid danger 君子愼以辟禍" (R 33.4).
21 In this regard, Li Shen (2009) has put together excerpts from dynastic works ranging from the pre-Qin China to the Qing dynasty.
22 Note that securing the optimal point or state is only one of the means to achieve sustainability. There are some other ways, for instance, being exceedingly humble.
23 The term "moral subjectivity" is borrowed from Mou (1963: 73).
24 The original form of 德 is in fact 悳, but I do not wish to go into it as it sheds no further light as far as the relationship between morality and "*an*" is concerned. For detail, please see Xu (1963: *juan* 10b, p. 217).
25 For a penetrating elucidation of the concept "*gewu*", please consult Jao (1989).
26 There are ten pieces of annotative texts in total to the main body in the *Book of Change* known as "Ten Wings" (*shiyi* 十翼).
27 "Biaoji 表記" of the *Book of Rites* reads that "it has been a long time that it is difficult to achieve *ren*. Only the gentleman is able to achieve it 仁之難成久矣，惟君子能之" (R 33.9).
28 It is explicitly indicated on various occasions in the *Book of Rites* that *li* is part of the cosmic order, e.g. R 9.31, 10.3, 19.4, 50.1 etc.
29 I have followed D.C. Lau's translation of *chengren*. See Lau tr. (1979: 135).

30 "Ceremonies (might be said to) commence with the capping; to have their root in marriage; to be most important in the rites of mourning and sacrifice; to confer the greatest honour in audiences at the royal court and in the interchange of visits at the feudal courts; and to be most promotive of harmony in the country festivals and celebrations of archery. These were the greatest occasions of ceremony, and the principal points in them 夫禮始於冠，本於昏，重於喪祭，尊於朝聘，和於射鄉，此禮之大體也" (R. 45.4; Legge tr. 1976 rpt.: vol. 4, p. 430).
31 Confucius said, "surely when one says 'The rites, the rites', it is not enough merely to mean presents of jade and silk . . . 禮云禮云，玉帛云乎哉？" (A 17.11; Lau tr. 1979: 145).
32 Cf. See "The Meaning of Marriage (Hunyi 昏義)" in the *Book of Rites* (R. 45.3).
33 The usual character for wisdom in the Chinese classics is 知, which is the more archaic form of 智 and is the same character for the sense "to know".
34 Cf. Book 50 of the *Book of Rites*: "權者知也" (R. 50.2).
35 The original reads: "子夏曰。大德不踰閑。小德出入可也".
36 The original reads: "子曰。可與共學。未可與適道。可與適道。未可與立。可與立。未可與權".
37 The original reads: "嫂溺不援。是豺狼也。男女授受不親。禮也。嫂溺援之以手。權也".

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13
EDUCATION IN TRADITIONAL CHINA

Thomas H.C. Lee

Introduction

The history of Chinese education is among one of the longest in the world, comparable to that of the Jewish and of the Indian. The Chinese experience is usually and rightly considered to have begun with Confucius, as his influence is still seen as pervasive in the Chinese thinking and personality. Although in speaking of the formation of the Chinese tradition, one could also go beyond Confucius, there is no denial that Confucius was the first Chinese thinker to articulate comprehensively on the purpose, content, and even institution of formal education.

Confucius and the formation of traditional Chinese education

Confucius was born in a time of rapid social change. He proposed an educational content based on the kind of noble education he himself received. It was comprised in the so-called six arts: rite, music, archery, charioteering, history, and mathematics. The education of these arts, according to Confucius and his followers, were found primarily in the "Six Classics". They are *Book of Poetry*, *Book of History*, *Book of Change*, *Book of Rites*, *Book of Music* (This one has been lost from very early on), and *Annals of Spring and Autumn*. The five books constituted the core of education in Confucius' view and by the fifth century BCE were already accorded the name and status of the canonical "jing" (commonly translated as "classics"). Generations of Chinese students learned them, recited them, and internalized their scriptural teachings which are mostly moral-ethical in nature and content.

His dialogue with disciples, recorded in the *Analects*, had been always important in the education of China's children. Both it and the *Mencius* (believed to be a collection of anecdotes and conversations of Mencius, a Confucian follower in the fourth to third century BCE), acquired canonical status after the thirteenth century.

Central to Confucius' educational ideal for a person is "humanness" (*ren*). In Confucius' view, moral perfection and aspiring for it are the most important parts of an individual's upbringing. A perfect human is one who plays correctly the role in which he finds himself in the world. The hierarchical society conceived by Confucius consists primarily two classes of humans, the ruling and the ruled. Education is the mark of the ruling class; though entrance into the ruling class is based on educational success. Meritocratic selection is thus an important part of Confucius' philosophy of social mobility, a thinking that influenced the practice of China's civil service examination system for 1,300 years, beginning with 605 CE.

It is also important to say that in Confucius' vision, although education was the mark of the ruling class, the way to that status is to learn for the individual's own self; the ultimate purpose of education was not to distinguish oneself in being recognized of his education, nor of his social status. Rather, one should learn in order to accomplish himself as a "human". This idea of "learning for the sake of oneself" would inform generations of Chinese pupils, students or intellectuals of their purpose of education, at least as justification.

It took about four centuries before Confucius' thinking was sanctified as a state orthodoxy. Before that, various other schools of thought also contributed to the formation of China's education. Of them, the most important were Daoism (represented by Laozi, sixth or fifth century BCE and Zhuangzi, c. 369–286 BCE), Mohism (represented by Mozi, fifth century BCE) and Legalism (represented by Shen Bu-hai, 420–337 BCE, Shang Yang, 390–338 BCE, and, above all, Han Fei, c. 280–233 BCE) also contributed in between the fifth and the first centuries BCE, significantly to the formation of China's educational system and institutions.

The rise of Confucianism as state ideology and the canonization of Confucian classics

By the mid-second century BCE, the Chinese government, under the Han, began to seek for a state ideology, and this was accomplished by the Han Wudi Emperor (r. 141–87 BCE) at the recommendation of Dong Zhongshu (179–104 BCE) whose version of Confucianism, an amalgam of various trends of thought, especially that of the "sympathetic interaction between heaven and man" cosmology (*yin-yang* and "Five Phases" theories), became the standard and orthodox understanding of Confucianism. The influence lasted throughout Chinese history.

Starting with the fourth century BCE (or slightly earlier), various states had begun to establish intellectual advisory institutions; of them the most widely mentioned and approved was the so-called Jixia School, which attracted many respected scholars, including Xunzi (c. 313–238 BCE), a Confucian thinker, whose thinking stressed the importance of education that could correct the evil nature humans were born with.

By the Qin dynasty (221–207 BCE), appointment of eminent scholars to the "erudite" positions began, and they were trusted with giving instructions to elite young men, aside from providing advisory service to the Emperor. This grew into the important Han institution of "Imperial University" (*taixue*), which, as a formal school, became the centre for not only education but also studying and standardizing the text and interpretation of the Confucian classics. Boys of fifteen years old from "good families" were admitted to the school, each studying one designated classic of the "Five Classics" mentioned earlier. The names of "erudite of 'the Five Classics'" and the "Imperial University" continued to be used for many centuries, during which the number of classics gradually increased to include, most importantly, the "Four Books", namely, *Analects*, *Mencius, The Great Learning*, and *The Doctrine of Mean*.

By the Later Han Period (25–220 CE), classical learning was becoming so important that different schools of commentaries competed to be listed as the recognized version of the five classics: a total of fourteen were accepted in the early first Christian century. However, beginning with the middle of the Former Han, several "old text" classics began to appear, which differ from the officially adopted ones not only in text and script, but also in interpretative emphases. These "old text" classics had by the second century become widely studied and even competed favourably with the "new text" in popularity, if not in officially sanctioned status. The "new text" classics and their interpretations had become excessively so preoccupied with exegesis, especially its cosmological and interactive implications, that it became obscure or even obscurant, and began to lose their educational significance. Finally, at the end of the second century, Zheng Xuan (127–200) succeeded in winning the support of the majority of classical scholars, and his versions of the classics, mostly based on the old text versions and interpretations, with intelligent incorporation of the new text opinions, became the basis of most officially adopted texts. Wang Su (195–256) was his intellectual opponent and was able also to secure the support of the then-Western Jin (266–420) government officially to sanction some of the commentaries he notated. The two schools competed for orthodoxy during the

next nearly four centuries, until the early Tang, when the Court ordered a comprehensive compilation that effectively became the sanctioned orthodoxy (see ahead).

From even before the Han, private country and village schools had come into existence. Information about them is sporadic, and little could be said about them except for occasional utterances from thinkers about their importance in teaching moral values: the educated have the responsibility of providing morally edifying examples for the commoners, and that local officials were responsible for moral uplifting of the people. The earliest primer or elementary text that still is extant, *Jijiu* (Quick Access), appeared in the late first century BCE. The work was designed to teach a basic vocabulary useful for managing daily life. It does not have a noticeable ideological orientation.

Buddhism and its influences

Buddhism spread to China as early as the first century CE, although its influence became only visible after the third century. Through the Period of Disunity (roughly 220–589) and Tang, it became the second most dominant intellectual force in China, affecting the worldview, ways of life, and religious life of the Chinese people.

Buddhism provided inspirations for temple architecture, improvised religious rites (these two influences are most visible in shaping the Daoist philosophy into also a religion). Buddhist works, through translation, introduced a broad range of vocabulary that enriched Chinese thinking and led to the beginning of phonological studies of the Chinese language. Buddhist ways of proselytizing believers by holding public lectures became a preferred method for the Chinese intellectuals when propagating their ideas. Until conversations or dialogues were revived to replace oratory lectures around the twelfth century, Buddhist lectures were the preferred method for teaching. Confucius' *Analects* which was a collection of dialogues between Confucius and his disciples was also a method for knowledge transmission or exchange that Zhu Xi favoured. In the Disunity Period, however, public lectures were widely practised, and were elaborate and said to be very effective.

Monastic rules were another aspect of Buddhist influence. Most rules were introduced into China via translation. The *Vihara* ideal shaped the Chinese tradition of retreating to quiet and isolated mountain area for study, a custom not as widely practised before the end of the Han. The so-called *jingshe* (literally, the house of spirit) had been used in the Han times as a study or room classical scholars or Daoist believers used for study, it did not mean exclusively an isolated, remote place. In due course, as it began to be used to translate *vihara*, that is, literally, the residence of a Buddhist abbot (specifically the stone cave of Vimalakirti), it started to carry the connotation of isolation and remoteness for meditational purpose. After the Period of Disunity, the idea of a sacred space, especially in an isolated and remote mountain resort for spiritual meditational purpose, gradually became a cherished notion widely held by the Chinese intellectuals. It reached a height towards the end of the Tang and was then continued by the founders of Neo-Confucian thought (especially the *taoxue* trend) in their educational program of academies (*shuyuan*).

Unlike in the area of economic activities, the Buddhist establishment did not take on founding formal schools as its conversion project. Its influence on Chinese education was found mainly in temple and monastic activities as these were aimed above all at the commoners. Composing and distributing "morality books" that became widespread after the fourteenth century received inspiration from the Buddhist practice, and their contents likewise. Some rituals in Confucian intellectual life, such as "self-accusations" (*zisong*) and "Ledgers of Merits and Demerits" (*gongguo ge*) are common among scholars in the Ming times and could trace their origins, at least in terms of the religiosity, to Buddhism. I shall return to this later.

Finally, Buddhist influence on popular theatre had been very significant. Most plays staged during religious festivals were based on Buddhist or popular beliefs. These stories made up the core of common people's knowledge of the universe, society, history, the afterworld, and indeed, the moral worldview and its parameters.

The formation of the state school system and teachers as transmitters of the Dao

The Imperial University that was founded in the early Former Han dynasty continued to function through the Later Han and the Period of Disunity. During its height, at the brief interregnum between the two Han's, under the usurpation of Wang Mang (23 BCE – 23 CE), the university admitted as many as thirty-two thousand students, and it is said that inside the university campus there were even markets. The number of students declined afterwards, though not significantly. However, its educational content changed markedly once the Han order collapsed. In the south, although the successive states continued the higher educational institution, and cherished in its splendor, it taught, besides Confucian classics, also "mysterious learning" (*xuanxue*, studying the *Book of Change* and the Daoist *Laozi* and *Zhuangzi*), histories and literature, and, later, law. Other ancillary schools were added to the Imperial University in different times, and of them the most important one is the School of National Youth (*Guozixue*), which was designed explicitly to admit scions of noble families (the number of the students in the Imperial University remained large; more than 7,000 in 272, for example).

The same development in higher education was also seen in the north, which was mostly controlled by non-Chinese peoples: new School of National Youth and Imperial University, and other ancillary schools were founded to afford aristocratic young men with higher education. The curriculum was broader in range, although intellectually it was more conservative than in the South, especially in terms of Confucian classical learning.

The northern states experimented in establishing various technical or "professional" schools, open to aristocratic young men. The educational content included such as calligraphy, painting, arithmetic, and law. This kind of schools continued in the Tang and Song but had by the Mongol Yuan dynasty (1279–1368) ceased to operate formally.

Other significant developments included the establishment of the School of Imperial Relatives (*Zongxue*) and Elementary School (*Xiaoxue*). Their purposes need no comment. An attempt to establish a local school system was undertaken first in the north and then in the south, also during this period. The system was haphazard at the beginning, but by the Tang dynasty had become quite active and began to work functionally with the developing civil service examination institution.

The gathering of so many aristocratic young men in the nation's capital naturally led to student activism and even political movement. The activities and the ideology they advocated often reflected Confucian moral thinking and so the couple of student demonstrations in the late Later Han times received approval from contemporary Confucian scholars, and became some kind of a legacy reappearing from time to time throughout Chinese history, even though there is no record of student activism in the Period of Disunity.

In all, the northern states all but established a comprehensive state educational system. It was a first extensive effort in China's long history to do so. Be that as it may, the rise of the civil service examination system eventually brought an end to such an educational tradition.

Before concluding this section, words must be added that there is no evidence that Buddhist thinking was officially inducted in the state school curriculums. The intellectual influences of Buddhism were primarily found in the life of commoners, and in their worldview, but not in government schools.

Family education, literacy education, and the broadening of educational imagination

A significant development in education during the Period of Disunity is the formal appearance of "family instruction", although systematic treaty on the education of children already appeared in the Han times, and was incorporated into the *Book of Rites* (*Liji*, in its "Neize" and "Quli" chapters) which was one of the "Five Classics", and therefore was widely accepted as the best guideline to the subject. By the fifth century, and

as aristocratic society matured, family education and composition of "family instruction" grew in popularity, and the latter, represented by the *Family Instructions of the Yan Clan* (*Yanshi jiaxun*) became an important genre of writing. *Family Instructions of the Yan Clan*, however, adopted views that are not strictly Confucian; there are certain Buddhist influences (moral causation, for example). It also adopts a more or less fatalist approach to the philosophy of life.

Family education during this period was characterized by transmission of knowledge special to aristocratic families: classical knowledge, religious rites, state law, historical writing, calligraphy, astronomy, and medicine were among those kept very strictly within the family and were transmitted through generations. This social practice clearly began in this period, and seems to have become ingrained in Chinese mentality, and remained so through history, and was even codified in the Ming times when certain technical skills were designated as hereditary and were transmitted only within the family.

One of the ancillary schools of the Imperial University was an elementary school designed to teach children of noble birth, as mentioned previously. The books they studied included traditional primers, such as *Quick Access* already mentioned. Other books they studied and recited included Confucius' *Analects* and *Book of Filial Piety* (*Xiaojing*). The latter was composed around the beginning of the Han dynasty, and consisted of only about 1,800 words, stressing the moral precepts of "filiality", which one should uphold towards not only one's parents, but also family and ruler.

By the Disunity Period, the primer *Quick Access* had already become dated and the need to replace it compelled the state to compose new ones. The most famous one in answer to the need is the *Thousand Characters Essay* (*Qianzi wen*). A collection of 250 four-characters idioms (sentences), this essay pretty much defined for later students the most "useful" one thousand words (characters) in the Chinese language. Children were required to recite the essay which contains many idioms that were, at least at the time, not readily comprehensible. They also learned to write them. The *Thousand Characters Essay* was to become one of the few standard primers for the next centuries until the late nineteenth century when new texts began to replace them. There were also several new primers that imitated the same principle of using four-character idioms to teach a basic vocabulary.

Another development in educational thinking in the Disunity Period is the formulation of "correct line of transmission" as the touchstone of true knowledge. Early in the Former Han times, when the classics were made the base of all knowledge, dispute arose because of the challenge of the "old text" versions as well as because of competing commentaries. It became necessary to devise a standard to determine which ones to adopt as orthodox. As mentioned earlier, eventually there were as many as fourteen versions in the officially accepted curriculum. The state is the arbitrator of such competing claims, and it legitimized its decision based on demonstrable transmission from teachers to disciples (*jiafa*, lit., transmitted with the "family"; here, family to read "school", or, *shifa*, lit., doctrine [transmitted] by the teacher. Distinction between the two *fa* is negligibly slight). The line of transmission as a conception grew in time, and by the fourth century, the role of teacher had become so important that its definition and ideal became intertwined with the idea of transmission of moral knowledge or *dao*. Early founders of Daoist religion called themselves "teacher" (*shi*, "master"); and "libationers" (*jijiu*) were used to call lesser leaders who were trusted with the responsibility also of giving instruction on religious doctrines. "Libationers" originally was the ranking official of Imperial University of the Han, and head in later dynasties.

Although later on, newer touch-stones were designated as a measuring standard, the idea of correct and reliable line of transmission remained central to Chinese imagination of moral "truth", and even influenced Buddhist idea of "transmission of lamps" (*chuandeng*) and Neo-Confucian "lineage of *Dao*" (*daotong*, sometimes translated as "repossession of the Dao").

This section summarizes the many new and meaningful developments in educational thinking and practice during the Period of Disunity. It is not wrong to refer to this period as one of foundation-laying of education in the Chinese civilization.

Sui and Tang education: the rise in importance of the *keju* examination system, further development of state educational system, and the height of Buddhist influences

The end of the Disunity Period in China in 589 did not bring an end of the aristocratic social structure immediately. That would take at least another two centuries. However, the most important institution, that of the civil service examinations (*keju*), which helped to bring down the structure, was started in 605, shortly after the founding of the Sui dynasty (589–618). The examination system was one of the longest employed recruiting systems in the world. It was undoubtedly based on the Confucian meritocracy ideal. Its influence on China's educational practice cannot be overly exaggerated.

The system as designed was mainly to test the candidates for their aptitude in classical learning; the subject is called "Knowledge of the Classics" (*mingjing*). Other candidates could elect to take other subjects, of them the "Distinguished Talent" (*xiucai*) which required composition of "discussion" questions (*ce*), was the most competitive. The "Distinguished Talent" subject was soon replaced by "Advanced Scholar" (*jinshi*) subject, which tested, besides the composition of discussion questions, also classical knowledge, and miscellaneous literary composition, culminating in the ability to compose poems. The *jinshi* subject was the most competitive, and graduates in this subject enjoyed the brightest future in the officialdom. In addition to the two para-general type of subjects, there were also other more professionally oriented subjects: law, calligraphy, and arithmetic. Graduates from the latter three subjects were appointed to technical offices.

Candidates must first register in local government offices to be examined, including interview and showing proof of candidacy qualification, and then were sent, together with other candidates (graduates from state Imperial University and related schools), to take formal written examination administered by the State Affairs Department (*shangshu sheng*). Those who passed the department examinations then were presented to the emperor who would then test them in the palace. The successful candidates from the palace examinations were then eligible for entering the officialdom. This three-tier examination system became by and large the basic structure of later examination practices that, with occasional modifications, lasted to the early twentieth century.

Based on the state educational system that was formed during the Period of Disunity, the Tang system consisted in maintaining a comprehensive higher educational system headed by the Directorate of National Youth, the Imperial University, and the School of Four Gates for both aristocratic young men and distinguished commoner students. These schools taught a curriculum of classical learning in preparation for regular official positions, and various technical and professional schools that offered instruction in law, astronomy-mathematics, calligraphy, etc. Graduates from the technical schools would take on technical offices. On the local level, schools were in theory to be founded in the prefectural and sub-prefectural seats, and although the system was not uniformly established, evidence does show that some were even found in as far out a border region like Dunhuang. In addition, local schools were founded not merely to teach general state ideology subjects; some also included facilities for giving instructions in, e.g., medicine. At its height, according to one statistic, there were a total of 63,070 students nationwide. The state paid for the tuition and room and board of all the students studying in these state schools.

In the area of literacy education, it is useful to point out that a number of new primers were composed in the Tang period. Of them the following were the more noteworthy: *Important Lessons for Enlightenment* (*Kaimeng yaoxun*), *The Family Teachings of the Great Great Grandfather* (*Taigong jiajiao*), *The Miscellaneous Notes* (*Zachao*), *Ignorance and Inquiry* (*Mengqiu*), and, finally, *The Hundred Surnames* (*baijia xing*), etc. These works often maintained the distinction of using four-characters idioms, but the content now was more focused on ethical lessons, often taken from historical stories. Of those listed above, *Ignorance and Inquiry* was very popular, though the arid *Hundred Surnames* eventually survived as one of the three most long-lasting primers.

Buddhism was the most influential religion (and hence ideology) in the Sui and Tang times, when its intellectual and economic influences actually surpassed Confucianism. The most noteworthy is the rise of

the so-called *bianwen* (lit., transformation texts). The *bianwen* style of writing, often with illustrations, was inspired by Buddhist teachings for proselytization, and therefore usually were based on stories taken from Buddhist texts. The *bianwen* stories formed a big part of children's education. It also helped to shape the Chinese popular education, in that the storytelling widely used in marketplaces became a chosen way of spreading ideology or orthodoxy to the commoners. Song dynasty writers of urban life left us with vivid memories of storytelling in nation's capitals (Kaifeng and Hangzhou). Similarly, their works also showed the rising popularity of theatre, although drama as an independent literary genre came only in the thirteenth century. By the thirteenth century, there is no doubt that theatres had begun to play a big role in the dissemination of all kinds of information or ideology that shaped common people's life.

Han Yu, Neo-Confucian thinking, and the broadening of private learning

By the end of the ninth century, China's educational content and practice began to become more and more geared to the study of the official commentaries to the "Five Classics" (*Standard Commentaries to the Five Classics*, *Wujing zhengyi*, compiled in the early Tang times), and this was a result of the rise in importance of the *keju* examinations.

The development resulted in the ultimate dominance of Confucianism. By the eighth and ninth centuries, calls for renewed elevation of Confucianism began, led by two thinkers: Han Yu (768–824) and Li Ao (772–841). They called to re-assert the leading position of Confucianism in Chinese intellectual life and worldview, by way of attacking the dominant position of Buddhism. Although the influences of the two and their compatriots were not immediately visible, Ouyang Xiu (1007–1072) and then Zhu Xi (1130–1200) re-edited Han Yu's collected works and broadened his narrowly focused anti-Buddhist stance to incorporate the idea of *dao* as the core concern of knowledge and the idea that its transmission be the central mission of education. The originally *Daoist* near-monopoly of the *dao* as the universal naturalist truth was taken over by Confucianists who now defined it as the cosmological origin or foundation of all personal and political moral conceptions, sanctioned by Heaven. (See next section for a fuller discussion.)

Towards the tenth century, and as the *keju* examinations expanded, at a time when aristocratic social structure declined, education went through a transvaluation: the revival of Confucianism challenged the domination of Buddhism, as mentioned previously; the evident rise of the degree holders in social status; and, finally, the expansion of a literate and educated population. The last point is the most important and affected the composition of examination candidates and thus also of the successful of them who eventually became members of the officialdom.

The civil service examination system was from the beginning open to all young men of "good families" (meaning, generally, families without criminal records). This meant the ultimate collapse of the aristocratic structure and the rise of a more broad-based population who were educated and who started to make up a significant portion of officialdom. The increase in the number of people seeking education towards the end of the Tang dynasty and the Five Dynasties interregnum (the ninth and tenth centuries) resulted in the building of private libraries or school rooms for learning from private teachers or for individuals studying on their own. This became trendy for students, especially if they were preparing for the civil service examinations. Mountain areas were attractive to them for their advantage for mental concentration, and Buddhist monasteries often opened doors to the students. This kind of study practice eventually prepared for the rise of academies which we will soon discuss.

The increase of the educated population, the completion of the *keju* examination system, and the Neo-Confucian educational programs

The tenth century saw the appearance of mass-printing of books. Although printing in the sense of duplicating documents and even paintings (on papers) had been practised since at least the fifth century, printing

an entire book could be said to have become common or in need only by the tenth century. The use of printing technology resulted in or reflected the rise of a widened reading populace, and it would have significant consequence for the *keju* examination system, which was becoming the sole most important channel for social mobility by the time the Song dynasty was founded (960). The broadened readership meant also for the need for new primers, and of course an ever more complicated vocabulary. The last development is seen in the state attempts to issue not only a series of comprehensive "encyclopedia" or "compendia" (or reference books) of information, such as *Imperial Perusal in the Taiping Era, the Treasure of Collections of Primary Oracles* (*Cefu yuangui*), and *Imperial Perusal of the Taiping Era* (*Taiping yulan*), etc., but also dictionaries of words and their standard pronunciation, such as *Broad Rhymes* (*Guangyun*) and *Collected Rhymes* (*Jiyun*). Both were edited to serve as the standard for use by examination candidates. All of these reference works were designed to provide "orthodox" and "reliable" information in a time when more and more people had access to knowledge through printed materials and for candidates of the *keju* examinations. All of these works appeared in the first few decades of the founding of the dynasty.

Printing of comprehensive Buddhist works were also taken up by some Buddhist authorities, primarily in Southeast China; of them the most famous was the *Kaibao Tripitaka*, a huge work that took more than a decade to complete printing. The first comparable undertaking for printing Daoist scriptures appeared about 100 years later. Although not part of the examination culture, Buddhist and Daoist works rode high on the increased use of the printing technology, to satisfy the need of the reading public, seeking to broaden their intellectual horizon.

Literacy education likewise became more available to the commoners. While few new primers had appeared in between 900 and 1100, two of them joined the *Thousand Characters Essay* to become the three most popular primers with the longest staying power: *The Hundred Surnames* (*Baijia xing*) and *The Three-Character Essay* (*Sanzi jing*; there are some disputes over its provenance, but all agree that by the Southern Song, it had already appeared). The former is dry, but meaningful, and was used over an impressively long time probably because it reflected the Chinese preoccupation with family, while the latter had the double advantages of easy recitation, because of its use of "three-character" idioms, and moral indoctrination. These two, together with the *Thousand Characters Essay,* were the three most widely used primers in Chinese history.

The increase in the educated population meant the intensification of competition in the examinations. A series of reforms took place in between the founding of the dynasty and 1066. These included the practice of ensuring anonymity of candidates so as to guarantee impartiality; the modification of the three-tier selection so that the last tier, the palace examination, became pro forma and only for ranking, without any further exclusion of any candidates; and the use of regional quotas to enhance quasi-equal distribution of successful candidates from every local examination districts. This made it possible for the state to maintain some semblance of "geographic equality" in the final distribution of officials. The number of successful candidates also gradually settled at around a few hundred in each examination cycle, adjusted from time to time in according to the number of young people admitted to service through other channels. These would include imperial relatives (usually only a handful, although this increased as time went on), graduates from the Imperial University (and its affiliated schools), and specially decreed examinations for candidates from distant or war-ravaged areas, etc. The proportion between the two varied: successful candidates from regular examinations would make up invariably between twenty and eighty percent of the total. Another important policy was adopted in 1066, when the government decided that henceforth there would only be one examination every three years. This, together with the three-tier structure would remain for the next nearly 900 years, with only very few interruptions. One last but no less important reform in the system was the decrease in subject matter and graduate degrees. The "advanced scholar" degree was now made the only one after 1069. The examination was now focused only in testing candidates' knowledge of the Confucian classics. It was a generalist selection process, and degree holders who would then enter the officialdom were thus looked upon as *shiren* (lit., officials; "scholar-officials" in modern English writings).

The last point is important. While in the Tang times, the *keju* examinations might also include questions taken from Daoist (though not Buddhist) canons, this was no longer true once the system reached maturity, especially after the fall of the Northern Song (1126). Thereafter, even if some non-Confucian texts were tested, they were few and sporadic. This would remain the same henceforth. The Confucian domination of China's social or state ideology was now complete.

Intellectuals who had ridden high on this development were mainly from the Northern Song, and especially those who had championed the writing of a liberated "old-essay" (*guwen*) style. The *guwen* style writers usually included such as Han Yu, Ouyang Xiu, and a few others. They derided the Tang style of prose which stressed literary excellence, especially the heavy use of rhymes, and sought to write with an aim to expound on Confucian *dao*, they believed that the style of Confucian classics was the best for achieving this aim. In their views, therefore, Confucian ideology of moral truth determines the quality of all writing and indeed "culture" (*wen*). In Ouyang Xiu's view, this new literary style goes back to Han Yu. Joined by other staunchly Confucian ideologues, such as Zhou Dunyi (1017–1073), Zhang Zai (1020–1077), and the brothers Cheng Hao (1032–1085) and Cheng Yi (1033–1107), these people rose in intellectual eminence in the eleventh and twelfth centuries. Their agenda was the formation of a new, or better, revivalist, Weltanschauung that was primeval Confucian, especially its moral and political philosophy, and to incorporate, here and there, semi-Buddhist metaphysical imagination of the universal foundation of truth. This new worldview was led above all by Zhu Xi, although his contemporary, Lu Jiuyuan (1139–1193) also shared a similar intellectual agenda, with some different philosophical emphases. The former stressed study and investigation as the route to comprehending the fundamental "principle" (*li*). This is in distinction from the latter's stress on the pre-eminence of one's "mind-and-heart" (*xin*) as the seat of that "principle". For Lu, therefore, rectifying one's mind-and-heart is the way to accomplishing moral perfection and enlightenment.

Commonly labeled as "Neo-Confucianism", this new intellectual perspective lay the foundation of the Chinese thinking that affected the educational developments in the next several centuries. Zhu Xi's philosophy was the more influential of the two: the rise of academies (*shuyuan*), the stress on the priority of moral lessons in elementary education, Confucian classical learning as the core and foundation of education, and ultimately, the official adoption of his version on the so-called Four Books (*Sishu*; see ahead) as the very core curriculum used in the civil service examinations.

The rise of academies

This is one of the most important chapters of China's traditional education. The academies started to appear, both in name and in reality, in about the eighth century, and by the tenth century, during the turmoil of the late Tang and especially the Five Dynasties Interregnum (902–960). With the decline of state schools, most wealthy families elected to establish private schools within the family or lineages. A lineage usually is a locally based cognate group of families with demonstrable genealogical relations. These families or lineages often called their private schools "academies". Most of these academies appeared in the mid- and lower Yangzi Valley area. After the Song unified China in 989, these family schools declined somewhat, but still thrived on the over-supply of students now competing to acquire education.

The need of these academies caught Zhu Xi's attention, who looked upon academies as a good ground for promoting his educational ideas. He openly championed the widespread building of them, admonishing the students to abide by the belief of "learning for one's self". He criticized the severely civil-service-oriented education that was aimed at preparing students to take the *keju* examinations. By the time he died, there were possibly over several hundred academies spread over all China, including the North that was under the successive rule of non-Chinese Jurchen and Mongol realms. Zhu Xi wrote a much celebrated "Exhortations [to the Students of] the White-Deer Grotto Academy". It has remained as one of the most influential "school regulations" in China and remained the archetype of almost all later "school rules".

Towards the end of the nineteenth century, there were perhaps more than 3,000 academies in China alone, according to some estimates. With so many schools in existence at one time or the other, there were of course many that would become the so-called *keju* academies: academies founded privately or by the government whose primary purpose was to prepare students to take the examinations. This is often called a process of "officialization". The ideal of "private" or "personal" education for one's self remained nonetheless a high-flown ideal that continued to inform even modern Chinese educational thinkers.

Zhu Xi's concern for education was thus not focused narrowly on state schools and its purpose-driven pedagogy. He was also concerned about the method of learning. It is clear that he concentrated above all in the study of important classical works, the Confucian "Five Classics" and "Four Books" in particular. Rote memory was part of the learning method, and while he always championed broad learning, he nonetheless also stressed the so-called comprehension (*tong*). His pedagogy notwithstanding, the Chinese seemed to have adhered more to rote learning and unarticulated acceptations of textbooks. He also occasionally acknowledged the different levels of difficulty of books and advised studying them according to the needed effort for comprehension, from the easier ones to the more difficult. One of his followers, Cheng Duanmeng (1143–1192), eventually proposed a study guide on the books required for study by students and arranged them according to the degree of the difficulty of them for yearly advancement. This guide influenced generations of teachers who adopted it, if with occasional modifications, for their students to follow.

New primers and their Neo-Confucian inclination

Zhu Xi and his disciples were attentive to the compilation of primers. Their idea of literacy was more predicated on moral lessons than word-recognition, and, in his view, the best moral precepts came from Neo-Confucianism. The new principle of primers compilation determined the course of development in the Chinese history of the compilation of elementary texts. Zhu Xi himself authored the *Elementary Learning* (*Xiaoxue*), and the less difficult *Knowledge to Learn for Children's Enlightenment* (*Tongmeng xuzhi*). Both works proved too hard for children, but the Neo-Confucian emphasis on moral indoctrination affected the philosophy of primer compilation in later times. A more widely used text is compiled by Cheng Duanmeng. This work, entitled *Meanings of Words of Human Nature and the Universal Principle* (*Xingli zixun*) consisted of 428 words in rhymed four-character idioms, and was perhaps the most successful primer after Zhu Xi. Cheng actually included this work by himself in his graded curriculum.

Neo-Confucian emphasis on moral education echoed the generations of the Chinese views of the importance of teachers. From very early on, teachers were the transmitters of truth, and knowledge learned from one's teacher is guaranteed its purity and reliability. Teachers therefore were often compared to one's parents. In the famous Tang primer, *The Family Teachings of the Great Great Grandfather*, one finds this sentence, "One morning your teacher, your father the rest of the day". The same adage then reappeared as "One day your teacher, your father the rest of your life" in the famous sixteenth century drama, *The Peony Pavilion* (*Mudan ting*) by Tang Xianzu (1550–1616), the acclaimed "Chinese Shakespeare". This shows how teachers' status rose over time. In fact, by the Northern Song times, the phrase, "heaven, earth, ruler, parent (father), and teacher" had appeared for the first time, and it was consecrated in the eighteenth century by the Qing Court. The authoritarian nature of the Chinese education is unmistakably reflected in the Neo-Confucian obsession with moral discipline, and their belief in the "lineage of dao" and the five entities as the base or guarantee of the "truth", or the "truthfulness" of any knowledge.

The rise of the "Four Books"

The ancient "Five Classics" had received an authoritative and thorough annotation in the early seventh century. They were considered standard and used in the civil service examinations for grading and ranking through the Tang and Song dynasties; additional books such as *The Classic of Filial Piety* and the Daoist

Laozi, were also sometimes used in the examinations. However, by the Southern Song times, *Analects* and *Mencius* were rising in importance, thanks to their widespread use also as elementary readers once a young person had acquired the preliminary literacy. Seizing on their popularity, Zhu Xi began to promote their significance for his educational agenda, and composed commentaries on these two books, as well as *The Great Learning* (*Daxue*) and *The Doctrine of the Mean* (*Zhongyong*). These four books, according to him, contained most faithfully the original teaching of Confucius and Mencius. He called them the "Four Books" and suggested that students study them as the very cornerstone of Neo-Confucian education.

The "Four Books" were accepted by his followers as the quintessential teachings of Confucian education, although Confucius was actually not the author of *Mencius*. Both *The Great Learning* and *The Doctrine of the Mean* were taken from the "Five Classics", interpolated with Zhu Xi's own writings, and could not be indisputably accepted as in line with Confucius' own teachings. Still, Zhu Xi's followers by the end of the thirteenth century were very eager to accept them as orthodox and authentic at face value. One disciple, Xu Heng (1209–1281), was so whole-heartedly committed to promoting them that he suggested to the Mongol Yuan ruler, the Kublai Khan (r. 1271–1294), to promote them. In 1313, when the Yuan emperor ordered restarting the *keju* examinations, these "Four Books", together with the traditional "Five Classis" were decreed as the standard texts for the candidates to study. This decision enormously influenced later educational development. Henceforth all Chinese students would take the "Four Books" and the "Five Classics" as their core curriculum. Until the last day of the *keju* examinations, this practice had not changed.

Further developments of the state schools from Song to Yuan

The Song state school system was by and large a continuation of the Tang. The single most important issue in terms of the system's operation was what its proper role should be in the examination-dominated society. Clearly, the government could not hope to staff all educated people in the officialdom, neither could it offer all of them leadership positions in society. The Imperial University (including the so-called School of National Youth) admitted on average about 1,000 students through the Northern and Southern Song, while overall, the state maintained a public educational system that could admit as many as around 200,000 students in the early twelfth century. Thus, whether state schools were to remain only to train an elite group of potential officials or to indoctrinate as many young people as possible for the society at large became a point of contention. It seems that through the Northern Song, the government was willing to invest in the latter, and there were a series of active efforts to set up local schools, which sometimes even required students to stay at school for a period of time before they could register to take the civil service examinations. The activism reached its height in the turn of the twelfth century, under the so-called Three-hall System. It sought to set up a hierarchical system to promote the best graduates from the various local schools to study in the Imperial University, and then eventually to enter service. The system would then replace the *keju* examination system. The "Three-hall" system as such did not outlast the Northern Song, and the civil service examination system remained the recruitment machinery. By that time it had become customary that, on the local level, each administrative unit (usually prefectures and sub-prefectures) would have a state school and local government offices were responsible for financing these local schools. In fact, state schools started to rely on the government to appropriate reserved, deserted or confiscated lands to support them. The so-called school field system thus came to fruition in the eleventh century and would remain a feature in China's funding method in local state schools.

Local schools would also teach technical subjects, such as medicine, law or mathematics, although information about this is scanty. Basically, these schools taught knowledge that the *keju* examinations tested. Students who failed to win admission to state schools naturally turned to "private" schools, and of them academies were the choice. By the late Song times, it was evident that some academies were designed now to teach subjects tested in the examinations.

The last development was a part of the "officialization" as mentioned earlier, a process of integrating the academies into government's educational hierarchy, and many academies were treated in the same way as part of the examination mechanism and were eventually assigned, along with state local schools, with local examination quotas of successful candidates.

It is useful also to add one final note concerning the institutionalized education of children. The Song saw the increased attention to children's education and almost all state schools had an affiliated "elementary school" in preparation of youngsters (usually between eight and fifteen years old of Chinese age) for official admission into the state schools. These graduates were not permitted to take the civil service examinations directly. The government, however, occasionally decreed the examination of children as part of its *keju* examination system. However, the child-examination as such was only nominal; successful candidates did not enjoy any formal recognition from the state.

Student life and student political movements

One thing that was distinct in the Song higher education is the rich records of students' life and their political activism. It is therefore useful to make a few remarks about them, for comparative education's sake, and for providing a context to the student movements in twentieth-century China.

Imperial University students numbered in the thousands and, during the Southern Song, were given a generous quota in the second-tier (Department) examination, along with other privileges. They therefore left a wealth of reports of their sometimes frivolous life, reflecting the way the students, mostly from powerful and rich families, conducted their study life in the nation's capital (Hangzhou), at the time already renowned of its beautiful scenery and lavish socio-economic life, vividly recorded by Marco Polo and a few Chinese writers. At the same time, because of their access to power, they often found themselves involved in political struggles in the Court. Overall, Chinese historians, perhaps because of Neo-Confucian influence, wrote about them with approval and even praise. After all, Neo-Confucian thinkers were still distant from the power centre and found it easier to sympathize with the students, if the latter took a critical attitude towards the powers that be. During the final days of the Northern Song, when the Song capital (Kaifeng) was under siege and the state on the verge of collapse, students went out to demonstrate against the government for its political as well as military failures. Education was important; the educated were potential officials. Students of Imperial University therefore looked upon themselves as shouldering the responsibility of leading the nation. Their vehemently critical attitudes were only natural in the time when the nation was going through multiple hardships: foreign invasion (the late Northern Song) or severe social and economic inequality (late Southern Song when the State was forced to adopt the so-called public-field policy after more than 100 years of debate, resulting in tense political struggle). The student activism was seen in the arena of political struggle, as mentioned, but it was also found in students' often blatant abuse of power for personal gains. All of these, however, were often condoned because of their young age, and the more they were forgiven, the more they would look upon themselves as representing the public opinion that was ignored by the authorities.

Students' political activism was not lost to Zhu Yuanzhang, the founder of the Ming dynasty (1368–1644). He therefore took steps to suppress it. The despot was quite successful in his strictures. For the next 500 years, indeed, student demonstrations or protests were all but completely wiped out.

The transmission of science and technology knowledge, 960–1644

Science and technology were never the central concern of Chinese intellectual life, and the development of them was haphazard. However, from our modern viewpoint, some of the leading inventions or discoveries in the history of Chinese science and technology were made in the Song times. These included the first mentioning of movable type printing, significant improvements in the design of astronomical clocks,

and the ability to name more than 2,000 stars, as well as the earliest observation, in world history, of the existence of "magnetic declination". The Song astronomical officials were also the first to observe the famous supernova, Crab Nebula, in 1054. The application of the magnetic compass in navigation is also first recorded in Song China, in 1080. Another achievement in military technology, of explosives in battle fields, is another Song contribution (though some scholars argued that the Jurchen people who were battling the Song first perfected its use). The knowledge recorded or developed by such as Shen Kuo (1031–1095), Su Song (1020–1101), Li Ye (1192–1279), and Qin Jiushao (1208–1261) indicates an incipient attempt at conducting objective exploration into nature, beyond inheriting the accepted truth. However, science and technical education, interestingly enough, never succeeded in becoming a part of serious concern and actually was banned from time to time, so much so that the founding emperor of the Ming, the Taizu Emperor (r. 1368–1398) had to order Imperial University students to study it. Therefore, it is conceivable that most renowned "scientists" acquired their knowledge not through formalistic school institution training, but rather within their own families as a "family tradition" (particularly in medicine), or because their official duties were related to various technical offices in charge of technological services, such as iron-work, horticulture, textile-making, carpentry, etc. Access to imperial libraries accounted for yet another channel through which some officials acquired their knowledge.

By the mid-Ming dynasty, perhaps because of practical needs, a number of encyclopedic compilations on subjects ranging from medicine to agriculture, to military engineering, to the design and manufacturing of tools for daily use appeared. These works far surpassed the similar works of the previous centuries in excellence. Their usefulness was as broad as the need in society was more complicated. It suffices to mention only a few outstanding authors here: Li Shizhen (1518–1593), Xu Guangqi (1562–1633), Song Yingxing (1587–1666), and Mao Yuanyi (1594–1640).

For all their private learning and contributions, it is well known that the Chinese did not consider that science and technology had any intrinsic value, and therefore, while basic technical knowledge was transmitted from masters to disciples, there was no consciousness of how such technical knowledge could be generalized into "science" in the modern sense. Not even private academies, let alone state schools, had developed any systematic pedagogy for teaching science and technology.

The educated class: their social status and their world of knowledge

The collapse of the aristocratic social order by the ninth century, and the rise of the *keju* civil service examination system after the eleventh century resulted in the appearance of the so-called scholar-official class, consisting mostly of successful candidates of the examinations, who were well learned in Confucian thought and ideology. They were given the power to rule and occupied the top positions of a hierarchical social structure. Passing the examination was almost the single most reliable route to climb the social ladder. It was during the Qing (1644–1911) that purchase of lower ranked offices became widespread.

The source of their power to rule came from their education and was guaranteed by a stable government. Confucian scholars as *status quo* understandably were allies of the ruler and assisted in maintaining control and stability of the empire. These people possessed the lion's share of the government's power and the nation's wealth, and were naturally wont to seek self-perpetuation. Successfully producing graduates from the examinations (and hence officials) over generations had to rely on the effort and ability to continue to afford education to their descendants, or to relatives' young sons. This resulted in the organization of lineages that incorporated relatives who resided in the same locality into a quasi-communal kinship organization. Lineages became especially developed in the south and grew to become a social custom. Lineages usually took the corporate form and would as a rule establish schools for educating young boys of the lineage, or at the least, provide scholarship funds for the same purpose. Elementary education thus was largely shouldered by such lineage schools after the Song. The academies, in contrast, were open to more advanced and older students.

The social life of the educated, as mentioned earlier, was distinctly "amateurish", in the sense of using "culture" to defend their self-identification as "intellectuals". Amateurism was manifested in their Confucian studies, and their distinguishing themselves, in moral terms, from the despotic polity, notwithstanding their cooperation with it. On the surface, then, the literati "pastime" was amateur alright; it carried with it a distinctive political undertone.

Thus, academies as a quintessential Confucian institution became the most visible space for intellectuals to compose their amateurish narratives. Throughout the Ming dynasty, there were a few times when academies were ordered shut down nationwide or in specific places because of their assertion of their self-identity. However, for all the attention on academies as centres for political protests, the truth is that such political significance was more a normative ideal than a reality.

Be that as it may, political protests as a form of political participation did begin to inform Chinese intellectuals, because by the late sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, educational thinking among Neo-Confucians, especially those following Wang Shouren's (also known as Wang Yangming 1472–1529) philosophy, proposed the universal "educability" of all humans. It was considered that moral truth is inherent to every individual, and the traditional social class built on "educational" success became blurred. Every person cum "potential intellectual" should shoulder the responsibility of restoring everything in their proper natural and moral order. Thinkers associated with the famous Donglin Academy stressed the philosophy of "everything is my concern" (*shishi guanxin*), particularly in the political context, and articulated this conviction in the context of revived Zhu Xi thinking, and not entirely in that of Wang Shouren. The new educational thinking and the political philosophy associated with it were religiously embraced by the Chinese intellectuals for the next few centuries and are continuing to inform even today's Chinese people.

Since these aforementioned ideas were perpetuated by schools organized by the state that used the examination mechanism to sustain its effectiveness in indoctrination (as well as recruiting officials), it is totally understandable that competition was severe to say the least. And the demand for impartiality in grading the scripts led to the use of a highly stylistic form of writing, the stultifying "eight-legged essays" (*baguwen*) as it was called, which could be easily marked. Many Chinese interpreters consider the writing style detrimental to the development of intellectual freedom or, at least free choice of communication styles.

In short, the idea of involvement in all affairs was a result of the new belief that all humans were equally educable, and that, ipso facto, all people's livelihood and moral rectification were the responsibility of all educated person had matured by the end of the sixteenth century (when the *bagu* writing style was firmly established by the government as the preferred style in the examinations). One may say that the foundational belief in the purpose of education as "learning for one's self" had become "everything is an intellectual's concern". This is the ironic response by seventeenth-century Chinese intellectuals to the "horizontal tablet" erected by the Ming founding emperor in the Imperial University and later in all state schools, admonishing students against airing their opinions about government affairs, much less meddling in political struggles.

Further developments in state and popular education, the final stage

Towards the end of the Song dynasty, China proper was largely conquered and occupied by foreign peoples, first the Jurchen Jin (1122–1234) and then the Mongol Yuan (1279–1368) regimes. Although they adopted some Chinese educational ideas (especially Neo-Confucianism) and institutions (almost the entire state school system, and academies), they also established special schools to teach their own languages, reserving seats in these schools for their aristocratic members and put aside a certain quota in the examinations for their own candidates.

Interestingly, there was a mass restoration or building of Confucian temples under the Yuan, and this was why local state schools under the Yuan were often also referred to as "temple schools". Nonetheless, the Mongol Yuan rulers were actually followers of shamanism, and were not genuinely committed to

promoting Confucianism. Neither were they supportive of Buddhism and Daoism. During the brief period of the Mongol rule, therefore, state schools were managed without a consistent ideological direction.

The Ming dynasty strengthened Confucian curriculum in state education, as already noted. The Imperial University had as many as 15,272 students at one point (1422), even if the grandeur lasted only a short while. The entire student body enjoying the state's subsidy and exemption from labour service numbered at about 62,500. This was a significant reduction from the number at the peak of Song national educational development, but the educated population as a whole had expanded during the Ming and is probably the basis for thinkers to believe that all humans were educable.

Starting with the Ming dynasty, local governments were required also to fund the so-called community schools (*shexue*) which taught by and large the same kind of rudimentary literacy and Confucian knowledge as in local elementary schools. "Community schools" then became also a permanent feature of state local education and were perpetuated into the early twentieth century, almost indistinct from elementary schools. In a broader sense, the community schools were trusted, more often than not, with the work of the state's ideological control.

A couple developments in popular education need to be mentioned here to conclude this section. The first is the increasing importance of novels in commoners' education. This is a climax development of using elementary texts to teach historical stories, of the *bianwen* genre of writing, narrative literature in the Song, and then the composition of dramas and novels after that. The Ming novels contributed significantly to the fascination of the Chinese students with China's long history. Ultimately, one may also say that history and its multifarious manifestations became the very defining element of the Chinese self-identity; novels would not succeed if there was no history as its reference. A reading of such as *Journey to the West* (*Xiyou ji*) or *The Water Margin* (*Shuihu zhuan*) would show how *bianwen* literature and moralist views of history affected the rise of popular novels.

The second is the continuation in writing "school regulations" and "family rules" and the effect they had on the extremely severe personal ethical discipline. Zhu Yuanzhang personally composed a series of regulations for the Imperial University students and engraved them on the "horizontal tablet", laying down such detailed and ludicrous behavioural rules as how many lashes a student should receive if he quarreled with the cook in students' dining hall. He singled out eight modes of behaviour and required that all people observe them: filial piety, love of brothers and sisters, loyalty, faithfulness, propriety, righteousness, incorruptibility, and sense of shame. He even issued *Grand Proscription* (*Dagao*) and required that it be distributed to every household; the Court even held competitions and awarded those who could best recite it. Though the work was quickly forgotten once the Emperor deceased, however, it did leave a mark on how to influence the common people. Many similar works were composed and published; many of them took advantage of the popular "morality books" (*shanshu*) style to propagate the imperially sanctioned ideology. Even the increased circulation of the so-called ledgers of merit and demerit (*gongguo ge*) also reflected the government's control method: good behaviour would receive reward, now, from Heaven. The priority of ideological control and rectification, through mass use of those institutions, continued through the next 400 years until the final day of imperial China, and even today.

By the mid-sixteenth century, Western missionaries had begun to come to China. When Nicolas Trigault (1577–1628) arranged to ship 7,000 European books to China, and when debates whether Chinese civil service examination candidates who had converted to Christianity could be exempted from participating in Confucian rituals, the narrative of Confucian Chinese education began to change, taking on a totally new challenge. The end of that challenge has yet to complete, even though this essay should properly stop at this point.

Concluding remarks

There are a few characteristics that are evident in the long history of China's traditional education. They serve to complete this brief essay. They are:

1 From the beginning, the Chinese have considered the purpose of state education as preparation of officials. Confucius' "meritocracy" ideal was the basis of the *keju* civil service examinations.
2 Most thinkers stressed the importance of "learning for one's self", and "academies" were considered the primary mechanism for its realization.
3 The core of education was the study of Confucian classics.
4 Commoners' education was found mainly in proverbs, theaters, family rules, morality books and Confucian rituals.
5 Students are usually put in the same class room, irrespective of their ages; academic advancement did not constitute an important issue.
6 The *keju* examinations were from the beginning (Sui dynasty, 589–618) written examinations. The importance of "writing" (written exposition, as well as calligraphy) had significant influences on the Chinese articulation and practice of education.
7 Chinese pedagogy has contributed to the Chinese personality that was markedly authoritarian.

In sum, traditional Chinese education started with the normative value of "learning for one's self", even though in practice it had been markedly affected by the state's need to recruit officials for government and ideological control. By the seventeenth century, the narrative began to change, and the new conviction is shaped by the demographic reality of broadened educational population and the need to effect a mass participation in all affairs of the "all under heaven", so much so that "everything is my concern" now became the foundation of education. The arrival of Western educational ideas challenged further the Chinese rethinking of their traditional ideal and practice.

14

EIGHT CHARACTERS, FIVE ELEMENTS, AND CHINESE FORTUNE TELLING

Li Chao

1. Introduction

Among all early civilizations, ancient Chinese appeared to have placed a great emphasis on development of a systematic view of the universe as well as the meaning and value of life. Comparing with many other schools of thoughts over the world, mainstream schools of Chinese philosophy value highly the application side of abstract thoughts rather than theoretical derivations. To a certain degree, this might have led to a culture which values more overall general understanding rather than rigorous analysis for individual parts. On the other hand, it also encourages expression of the philosophical thoughts by concrete examples, as can be shown later by application of eight characters in fortune telling.

Confucius' teaching, as in *The Analects of Confucius* (论语 *Lun-Yu*), for instance, at the application level consists of much everyday life advice which is readily implementable to both educated and less educated people. Even though a deeper level wisdom is claimed by students of Confucius, common people can understand and appreciate the analects from perspectives of everyday life.

Another example of such preferences for application in real life can be observed in philosophical schools, which are founded on a common theoretical basis, *I'Ching* (易经,Yi Jing), also known as *The Book of Changes*. As a most important Chinese philosophical work, *I'Ching* for a long time has been regarded as a backbone of traditional Chinese philosophy. Most traditional philosophical schools make direct or indirect references to I'Ching and its interpretations. I'Ching uses key concepts of Yin (阴,Yin) and Yang (阳,Yang), and has developed a delicate system of sixty-four Hexagram (卦, Gua) for the simulation and interpretation of changes. While depth and complexity of *I' Ching* being not the focus of this chapter, the application of I'Ching in various circumstances has become the key background text and even the essential guideline to many branches of studies including Chinese astronomy, Chinese musical theory, Chinese medicine, Chinese martial arts (武术, *Wu Shu*) or *kungfu* as well as Chinese fortune telling, to name a few. The essence of eight characters profile as part of fortune telling also relies heavily on I'Ching for its theoretical basis.

While the practice of fortune telling itself can be quite complex and may involve a large school of drastically different thoughts, this chapter primarily focuses on one of the most common and popular ones, the so-called *eight characters*, which claims to be able to "tell the fortune" of a person based on his or her **birth time** as described in eight Chinese characters. Having said that, the fortune-prediction itself is not as rigid and fixed as "**fate**"; the prediction actually involves a certain degree of flexibility and allows an interpretation of greater depth: instead of predicting what may happen, Chinese fortune telling predicts the natural tendency of the subject (person whose fate is to be told), with the strength and weakness, and thus gives

a general direction for one's life. Under certain scenarios, the predicted "fate" may actually change toward different directions. Hence eventually "fate" is not fixed and can change. Also in terms of narratives, instead of saying what will happen, a prediction made by Chinese fortune telling normally consists of a number of what-if statements; in other words, there are still plenty of choices a person could make during his or her lifetime despite the prediction; it is acknowledged that such choices can shape one's fortune/destiny together with the profile of eight characteristics.

To the author, the term "fate**"**, in contrast, demonstrates a stronger sense of prediction, and allows less deviation and variation. On the other hand,"**fortune/Destiny"** appears to correspond to Chinese fortune telling more appropriately. Such usage of 'fortune' is also consistent with the term 'fortune-telling' itself. Therefore in this chapter, for clarity and convenience, **fortune** shall be primarily used synonymously with **destiny**. The common meaning of 'fortune' in terms of wealth or riches shall not be used unless otherwise clarified.

The idea of linking time and fortune together does not appear particularly intuitive or intellectually convincing to modern generations. Time is often regarded as a label or framework to record activities or events and thus appears to lack any solid or definite meaning to modern time readers. In Chinese fortune telling, however, time (particularly the birth time) is endowed with a more concrete and special meaning and hence has become linked with a lot more additional information, including the spatial existence of surroundings.

How does the linkage happen? In the following, the reader is invited to start a journey of discovery to see how such understanding was formed such that fortune telling can become possible.

2. Significance of birth time

Although there is still no unanimously accepted theory on the linkage between birth time and one's destiny/fortune, numerous *Eight Characters* books have tried to offer certain reasonable explanations. Such explanations, however, can be found to be at best as plausible; since most of the time they reflect the writers' intuitive understanding of what appears to be reasonable, without fully explaining the fundamental reasons or using strict logical language. Particularly, due to the apparent mystic tradition of the fortune-telling practice, there is little open discussion for debating such explanations.

Universal connection

Ancient Chinese people commonly accept that all things in the universe are widely connected, which includes plants, animals, and people, as well as their surroundings (in earth and heaven). Such belief in **Universal Connection**, for which one perhaps could find its counterparts in modern physics particularly quantum mechanics, is however not originated from scientific method. This is more like an intuitive belief from the perspective of philosophical speculation without much worry on proof or disproof. Generations of Chinese thinkers appear to have unanimously accepted such connection as a fundamental assumption since pre-historic times. Widespread of such belief is quite evident from the commonly used terms "the union/oneness of heaven and people" (天人合一, Tian Ren He Yi), which is not only a key concept in Chinese philosophy, but also an important goal for self-improvement of Chinese intellectuals, even a lifetime goal in both Taoism and Confucianism tradition.

State of mind

If existence of Universal Connection can be taken as given, then the next big task is to discover the form and nature of such connection; as well as any pre-conditions and procedures required for such connection to take place. Many oriental philosophy schools believe that such connection can be observed only by a

very sensitive mind. In other words, if the observer's mind can enter a certain ***state of mind*** , the **truth** of world shall present itself to the observer; which is analogous to "***enlightened mind*** " in religious sense. Such truth is of course subjective and not scientifically replicable, as the state of mind of one person cannot be uniquely defined or described, not mentioning to be reproduced and presented to a second observer. Because of this, for the same event, the second observer has no clear way of exactly recording or replicating the state of mind of the first observer. Many types of Chinese fortune telling techniques require the practitioner to first achieve a high level state of mind before being able to make reliable predictions; to enter such state of mind, for instance, the practitioner may need to purify his mind first, with a process which is close to a religious ritual.

Comparing with these fortune telling techniques, the **Eight Characters** method is much less dependent on the observer's *state of mind*. Instead, main/core parts of eight characters prediction, involve only recording information and follow-through of pre-established procedures.

Eight characters fortune telling method does depend on the *universal connection* as one key assumption; although it does not explicitly require any particular interpretation of such universal connection. In other words, it only requires the practitioner to acknowledge existence of such connection. In-depth knowledge of the exact nature of such connection is not a prerequisite for practicing eight characters fortune telling. Instead, by practicing the established procedures, it is believed that such connection can be approached.

Objectivity from facts and procedures

Due to the aforementioned reliance on procedure and established rules, one can say that the major portions of eight characters fortune telling depend on "**facts**" which are actually **objective**. Given the same eight characters, a group of randomly chosen masters in the art of eight characters shall in general find much agreement in basic interpretations of most people's fortune; such interpretation at least shall differentiate good/bad fortune among other general characteristics. Such interpretation is possible primarily due to the fact that the Chinese way of recording the time actually also records certain time-related matters, which are used in the derivation and diagnosis of one's character and therefore the fortune, or the likely destiny. Such derivation is possible as it actually is in line with the idea of universal connection.

Oftentimes, a perfect or nearly perfect eight characters profile is hard to find. And hence, a number of diagnoses would follow, which shall not only predict how one's fortune varies in time and space, but also give hints on what enhancement measures, when combined with one's eight character profile, can make one's fortune better. Note that the suggested enhancement measures can be quite different depending on subdivisions of eight characters school. Nevertheless, the differences are mostly due to philosophical or academic reasons and are actually not entirely subjective.

Given *birth time* and gender of the person, his or her eight characters can be uniquely determined/reported; a large part of meanings and implications can be interpreted without actually knowing the person and without requiring the observer to be enlightened (in certain state of mind), thus make the practice of *eight characters* much more "objective" than many other fortune telling techniques in China and other parts of world, primarily in the sense that *eight characters* prediction cannot be easily manipulated or disguised.

Self-world interaction and birth time

One can also regard the birth time as the **first encounter** of the world by the newly formed identity – **Self**. Before the birth time, the person (Self) lives inside mother's body and has never been exposed to the outer **world**. The birth time is a starting point and naturally a transition point for a person's life.

Hence it appears reasonable to think that one's likely *destiny* is related to the interaction between Self and the outer **world**, for which birth time serves as the starting point. Also at such point, the life is at its most primitive state and is deemed much more susceptible to influences of outer world than any other

time. Therefore among all moments or instants of time, if there is any moment that is most critical to one's fortune or destiny, it "must" be one's birth time. (Again, the author acknowledges that such deduction is not strictly logical but appears to be natural.)

The eight characters theory indeed goes well beyond above very simplified postulations. A closer look will reveal an abstract representation of the status of the universe in terms of both **time** and **space**. Such representation also would involve quite a complex process of derivation, which despite the inherent complexity can still be performed in a step-by-step manner, following a set of established rules. The involved derivation process is considered as logical and repeatable, and hence objective. Next we shall explore the system that makes such derivation possible, i.e. the system of heavenly stems and earthly branches.

3. Theories on the heavenly stems, earthly branches

The heavenly stems (天干 Tiangan) and earthly branches (地支 Dizhi)

To understand what *time* (particularly *birth time*) means when recording in the traditional Chinese way, one has to first have a basic understanding of the *making of a calendar* in Chinese tradition. Since more than 2,000 years ago, by recording time with "the Heavenly Stems" (天干, Tiangan) and "the Earthly Branches" (地支, Dizhi), linkage has been established between the spatial arrangement of stars/planets and an embedded sequence of order.

The Chinese have maintained a longest history of observation of astronomy events. A calendar is made to record the periodical behaviour among the moon, the earth and the sun. The heavenly stems primarily consist of ten Chinese characters, which can be regarded as corresponding to number 1 to 10; the earthly branches consist of twelve Chinese characters roughly corresponding to number 1 to 12. Any time (year, month, day or hour) can be recorded using a pair of Chinese characters with one heavenly stem and one earthly branch. Since any birth time (actually any moment of time) can be expressed by year, month, day, and hour; to record all information, four pairs of heavenly stems and earthly branches will be needed. Each pair is also called a Pillar. Therefore, there would be the four pillars for eight characters fortune telling: namely the Year Pillar (年柱, Nian-Zhu), the Month Pillar (月柱, Yue-Zhu), the Day Pillar (日柱, Ri-Zhu), and the Hour Pillar (时柱, Shi-Zhu).

The heavenly stems and the earthly branches have become the main coordinates to record both historical and astronomy events. They also have become a basic language in eight characters fortune telling. In the following we shall explore their meanings and characteristics.

Yin and yang of the heavenly stems and earthly branches

In Chinese culture, yin (阴) and yang (阳) form a well-known couplet of concepts; yin and yang are relative to each other and together shall form an entity. The concepts of yin and yang are well explained in a number of philosophical works and are therefore not explored in great details in this chapter. Still it might be useful and intuitive to give a few examples: yin represents the front, the downside, the passive etc, and associated with above; yang commonly represents the back, the upside, the active etc. Yin and yang are also commonly linked with female and male respectively.

As believed by Chinese traditional philosophy, everything has its yin and yang. The heavenly stems and earthly branches are no exception. Actually each of the stem or branch possesses its own yin and yang characteristics, which are expressed in Tables 14.1 and 14.2.

The first row of each table shows the Chinese names of the heavenly stems and earthly branches. The second rows shows the corresponding Pin Yin. In the third row, the corresponding numerical value is given for each stem/branch. It should be noted that the use of Arabic numbers 1–12 are for the reader's easy reference and understanding only. In Chinese fortune telling the system is directly referred to by each of the names in the first row (Chinese name).

Table 14.1 The heavenly stems

Chinese Character	甲	乙	丙	丁	戊	己	庚	辛	壬	癸
Pinyin	Jia	Yi	Bing	Ding	Wu	Ji	Geng	Xin	Ren	Gui
Number	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Yin/Yang	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin

Table 14.2 The earthly branches

Chinese Character	子	丑	寅	卯	辰	巳	午	未	申	酉	戌	亥
Pinyin	Zi	Chou	Yin	Mao	Chen	Si	Wu	Wei	Shen	You	Xu	Hai
Number	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Yin/Yang	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin	Yang	Yin

4. Introduction to the five elements (五行 Wuxing) and logical relationship

The five elements

The five elements are what make the heavenly stems and earthly branches distinctive from a set of coordinates or mathematical time labels. Alternatively, the five elements can also be regarded as another tribute of the heavenly stems and earthly branches. In some philosophical schools, they can even be seen as an independent system which is commonly used in explaining how the world works.

What is particular to the eight characters fortune telling system is the linkage between the heavenly stems and the five elements; the earthly branches are also connected to the five elements in a likely manner yet with an additional layer of complexity.

The five elements consist of Wood, Fire, Metal/Gold, Water and Earth/Soil. Just from its name, this might appear to be a static system of characterization for the physical/material world. But indeed, the five elements are a lot more than that; in a sense, they can actually be regarded as "dynamic elements", which refers to not only materials as the name suggests, but also the intrinsic nature of such materials and their functions. For instance, Wood is associated with not only tree and wood materials; it is also associated with growth, and the nature of a tree. In addition, wood itself can be divided into a Yin-Wood, and Yang-Wood; where Yang-Wood is stronger but stiff, and Yin-Wood weaker but flexible. Classical works in Chinese fortune telling such as "*Qiong Tong Bao Jian"* (穷通宝鉴, *Qiong Tong Bao Jian*) spend great efforts in explaining the details of the five elements.

How does the linkage take places? This can be a vivid example of application of idea of Universal Connection. Below we show the general correspondence or linkage among four seasons and five elements, and four directions.

Spring – Wood（木 Mu）– East
Summer – Fire （火 Huo）– South
Autumn – Metal/Gold（金 Jin）– West
Winter – Water（水 Shui）– North

The linkage is again of intuitive nature and can be regarded based on an assumption that the observer is located in Central China. The "reason" for such linkage can go as follows. Spring sees temperature increase

from the coldest season and the plants' growth and therefore associated with **Wood,** with the direction of east. Summer is linked with **Fire** due to the heat and has the orientation of South. **Autumn** is a season of death for the plants and a season of gathering fruits from crops and has the orientation of West. **Winter** is commonly linked with snow and ice and hence water and orientation of North.

One year is therefore divided into four equally divided seasons, which are linked with East, South, West and North, respectively. A fifth element, **Earth/Soil** (土, Tu) is now not yet linked with any direction. It is actually linked with the centre, with a meaning of medium/foundation of everything, as a platform and the scene of things happening. In time **Earth/Soil** is linked with one fifth of each season (about 18 days) to resemble its general connection. With the above system, each element has about four-fifth of one season and one-fifth of a year's time, which is seventy-two days considering a 360-day year (there are five or six days left every year, which is again distributed into the four seasons and five elements in a supplicated mathematical way). Although such division may appear arbitrary, it does place a central consideration of balance and even distribution, and thus contains sufficient plausible explanations in traditional eight characters texts. The theoretical background and basis of such division can be linked deeper into the mainstream Chinese philosophy, however, such details are not the focus of this chapter and shall not be reproduced here for reason of simplicity.

Similarly, the ten heavenly stems are assigned their five element characteristics as in Table 14.3. In general all assignment of mappings can be understood of under the principle of **Universal Connection**.

Readers may notice that the five element characteristics of the earthly branches are not yet given. Do they also have the five element characteristics? The answer is "yes, but . . .", as there are some additional complexity. A mapping has been established among ancient Chinese which relates the earthly branches and the heavenly stems. In this mapping each earthly branch corresponds to 1 to 3 heavenly stems; in Chinese language, it is said that each branch actually hides one or more heavenly stems under its umbrella. Details of this mapping are provided in Tables 14.4a and 14.4b; in Chinese fortune telling they are called as "the containment of heavenly stems among earthly branches" (地支藏干图, Di Zhi Cang Gan Tu).

Table 14.3 Five elements characteristics for heavenly stems

The Heavenly Stems	甲 Jia	乙 Yi	丙 Bing	丁 Ding	戊 Wu	己 Ji	庚 Geng	辛 Xin	壬 Ren	癸 Gui
Five Elements	木 Wood	木 Wood	火 Fire	火 Fire	土 Earth	土 Earth	金 Metal	金 Metal	水 Water	水 Water

Table 14.4a The containment of heavenly stems in earthly branches (1)

子 *Zi*	丑 *Chou*			寅 *Yin*			卯 *Mao*	辰 *Chen*			巳 *Si*		
癸 Kui	己 Ji	癸 Kui	辛 Xin	甲 Jia	丙 Bing	戊 Wu	乙 Yi	戊 Wu	乙 Yi	癸 Kui	丙 Bing	戊 Wu	庚 Geng

Table 14.4b The containment of heavenly stems in earthly branches (2)

午 *Wu*		未 *Wei*			申 *Shen*			酉 *You*	戌 *Xu*			亥 *Hai*	
丁 Ding	己 Ji	己 Ji	乙 Yi	丁 Ding	庚 Geng	戊 Wu	壬 Ren	辛 Xin	戊 Wu	辛 Xin	丁 Ding	壬 Ren	甲 Jia

How the mapping is formed and the underlying reason for such correspondence cannot, however, be traced to a unanimous source. Such correspondence is not always intuitive but appears necessary due to the need of matching ten heavenly stems and twelve earthly branches. The mapping is knowingly difficult to remember and poses significant difficulty for the practitioners of fortune telling. As a result, most of them have developed memory tools or would need to bring a chart for use when practicing fortune telling. It is useful to remember that not every earthly branch shall correspond to one single element, and each heavenly stem also can be found in the containment of multiple earthly branches.

Interactions among five elements

As briefly mentioned earlier, the five elements are far from static. The interaction between any two of the five elements can be classified into 2 categories.

(1) One "assists/leads to" another (相生 ***Xiang-Sheng***)
(2) One "conflicts/overcomes" another (相克 ***Xiang-Ke***)

A simple diagram such as Figure 14.1 can be used to describe the relationship of ***Xiang-Sheng*** among the five elements.

The Relationship of Xiang-Ke can be described similarly. Instead of two diagrams, more cleverly, another form of diagram can be used to present both Xiang-Sheng and Xiang-Ke in a same figure as Figure 14.2, where the solid line represents Xiang-Sheng, and the dotted line represents Xiang-Ke.

It is interesting to observe from Figure 14.2 that any element is now always connected to any other element. Therefore ***Xiang-Sheng*** and ***Xiang-Ke*** relationship can fully describe any one-to-one interaction relationships between any pair of five elements.

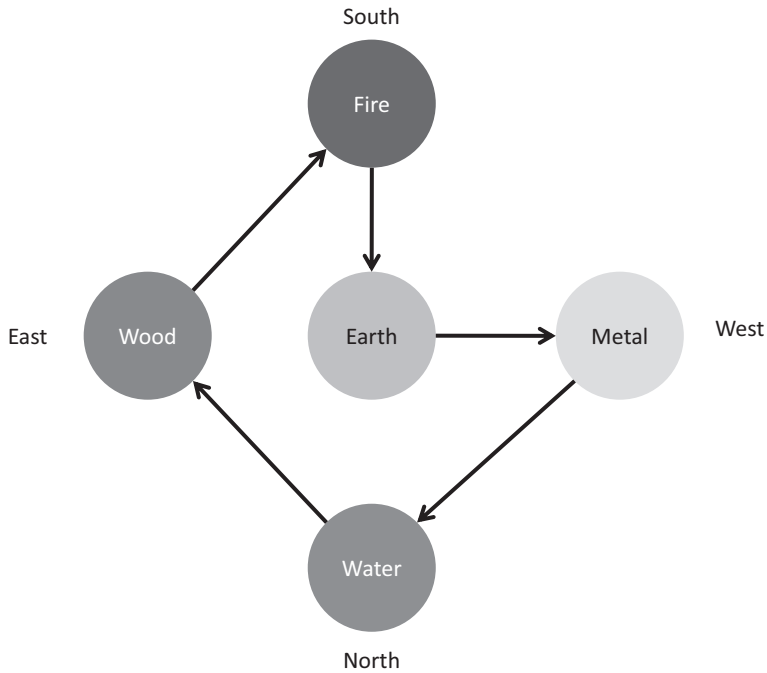

Figure 14.1 Diagram of Xiang-Sheng among the five elements with reference to orientations

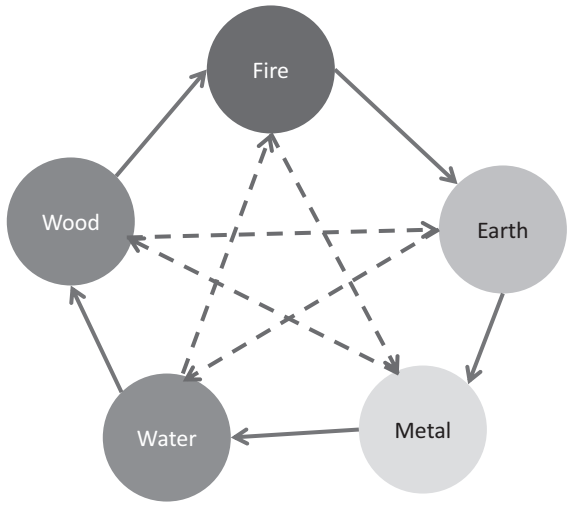

Figure 14.2 Diagram of Xiang-Sheng and Xiang-Ke among the five elements

Now the situation is getting more complex, but the interactions also do not stop here: when more than two elements are present, more interesting pattern can arise, and there can be complex group effects and directional effects. More group effects can happen for instance when a certain combination of three earthly branches comes together, terminologies are used to describe such complex logical relationships in languages not easily understandable to non-professional fortune tellers. Such interactions and laws of interactions will not be explored in great details but shall be further explained in Section 5.

5. Structures of eight characters

Four pillars: first step in structualization

With above preparation of concepts and terminologies, now we can start to look at the structure of an eight characters profile. All of the aforementioned applies to individual Chinese character (which is only one eighth of the profile). To understand an eight characters profile in totality, our first step is to look at the characters in pairs. The eight characters literally correspond to eight Chinese Characters, in four pairs. Each pair is pictorially described as one Pillar. For this reason, the eight characters are also commonly referred as **Four Pillars** (Si Zhu, 四柱).

Each pillar consists of one Chinese character to represent the heaven element (one of the heavenly stems), and another to represent the earth element (one of the earthly branches). These four pillars when arranged sequentially as "year", "month", "day", and "hour". Correspondingly the four pillars are named the Year Pillar (年柱 Nian-Zhu), the Month Pillar (月柱, Yue-Zhu), the Day Pillar (日柱, Ri-Zhu), and the Hour Pillar (时柱, Shi-Zhu). With Four Pillars established, one can start to refer to the eight characters in a more speedy way. For instance, Table 14.5 refers to a sample description of relationship, which is not based on the five elements, but on pillar to pillar relationships.

Day Stem (Ri-Yuan,日元) and Month Branch (Yue – Ling, 月令)

With four pillars established, the four heavenly stems and four earthly branches can be more conveniently referred to. In this chapter, the four heavenly stems shall be referred as Year Stem (年干, Nian Gan), Month

Table 14.5 Structure of eight characters

Year Stem	Month Stem	**Day Stem (Ri-Yuan)**	Hour Stem
Year Branch	**Month Branch (Yue-Ling)**	Day Branch	Hour Branch

A sample eight character profile is given below:

甲 子	甲 子	甲 子	甲 子
Year Pillar	Month Pillar	Day Pillar	Hour Pillar

Stem, Day Stem, and Hour Stems respectively; and the four earthly branches, shall be referred as Year Branch, Month Branch, Day Branch, and Hour Branch respectively. A typical profile of eight characters shall look as in Table 14.5, where each cell will be exactly occupied by one Chinese character, which can come from any ten heavenly stems and twelve earthly branches.

The structure of eight characters can be further analyzed through a process of derivations due to the rather complicated interactions among these eight characters, which shall be explored in this section.

First, one can take a perspective from **Self-world** interaction; there is one character out of totally eight characters, which represent the person's **Self**. This is the heavenly stem of the Day Pillar, which is often called ***Ri-Yuan*** (日元) or ***Ri-Gan*** (日干) in Chinese. In this chapter we shall continue to call it as the ***Day Stem*** , primarily for easy understanding of English readers. However, it is useful to be familiar with the terminology ***Ri-Yuan*** , due to its widespread use in Chinese fortune telling.

The second most important Chinese character of the profile comes from the Month Pillar. It is the earthly branch of the Month Pillar, with a name of Yue-Ling (月令), which has the literal meaning of "month" and "command". In this chapter we shall continue to call it as the ***Month Branch*** , primarily for English readers' easy understanding. **Yue-Ling** shall also be used in an interchangeable way with ***Month Branch*** .

There is quite a significant reason for putting much emphasis on ***Month Branch*** or the earthly element of Month Pillar. Given the birth month, its four season characteristics is also evident, significant amount of information and interpretation can be made about the environment, giving a strong indication of the general environment of one's Self. Therefore, ***Month Branch*** (Yue-Ling) can be regard as a representation of the environment or the World. The **Self-World** relationship therefore can be simulated by studying the relationship between Day Stem (Ri-Yuan) and Month Branch (Yue-Ling).

Practically, this is done by the following steps:

Step 1: Determination of the five element characteristics of **Day Stem** and **Month Branch** (Ri-Yuan and Yue-Ling) according to Table 14.3.

Step 2: Determination of the relationship according to Table 14.4, Table 14.1 and Figure 14.2

- 2.1 Use Table 14.4 to convert earthly branches to heavenly stems
- 2.2 Use Table 14.1 to find the relevant Yin-Yang Characteristics and Table 14.3 to find the five elements characteristics corresponding to the converted heavenly stems
- 2.3 Use Figure 14.2 to analyze the logical relationship, Xiang-Sheng or Xiang-Ke, relationship between the five elements determined from last step

It can be seen that Steps 1 and 2 follow a set of predetermined rules. The process so far is deterministic and does not rely on the fortune-teller's own interpretation; even though the complex relationship in Table

Table 14.6 Four Pillars and family relationship

Year pillar	Grand Parents
Month Pillar	Parents
Hour Pillar	Children
Day Pillar	Husband – Wife

14.4 can be confusing for the newcomers in this practice. Overall speaking a nearly fixed interpretation (therefore objective) has been formed up to this point. In reality, for easy use in practice, a recommended set of interpretations can also be found in practical eight characters books that table the correspondence between all likely Ri-Yuan (Day Stem) and Yue-Ling (Month Branch) combinations.

The remaining characters

Besides Day Stem (Ri-Yuan) and Month Branch (Yue-Ling), there are still other six Chinese characters out of the total **eight characters**. In general, these six characters together with Yue-Ling can be viewed as representing the outer environment or the world. If we take this view, then the Yue-Ling can be viewed as a closest part of the environment relative to one's Self. In this sense, **Self-World** interaction can be regarded as the relationship between Ri-Yuan the other seven characters. To further differentiate, practitioners also create the following correspondence in Table 14.6, as an analogy to family relationship.

Such correspondence can be used as analogy and purely as ways of making things memorable; in which case, the logical relationship can be studied without using them and by resolving all heavenly stems and earthly branches into five elements. Then analysis can then be made primarily by analyzing five elements. Some practitioners therefore will analyze percentage of five elements in one's eight characters' profile and based their further interpretations on whether there is a dominant element or whether certain elements is missing. Such practices can be considered as a simplified way but not a tradition way of doing fortune telling.

Up to now, most practitioners are not used to doing such simplification and derivation mathematically. Instead they make use of as much information as they can get and considers all structures including Four Pillars and their understanding of heavenly stems and earthly branches. They often take one step forward by taking things more literally and often refer to family relationship in Table 14.6 also as guidance whenever there is need to make more detailed interpretations. Such extension oftentimes has created mystic feelings among the practitioners and the ones for whom fortune telling is performed. Here we can say that the introduction/addition of Table 14.6 starts to make the derivation/interpretation process less objective and more subjective. And they actually have formed a part of the tradition of actual practice of fortune telling.

The "ten gods" (Shi-Shen, 十神)

The interactions between Day Stem (Ri-Yuan) and the three remaining characters of the heavenly stems can be derived based on **Table 14.3**. But for historical reasons, for easy understanding and memory, it is also presented in a more personified language. There comes the so-called "Ten Gods" (十神, Shi-Shen), with one "God" assigned to one relationship between any given heavenly stems and accounting for one yin-yang combination. Note that the "gods" are not personalized and to be worshiped. To the practice of fortune telling, they are merely a term for a logical relationship. But to the outsiders and those who want to know about their fortune, such terminologies can create a significant level of mysterious feeling.

Expression of logical relationships between two entities (heavenly stem entity) can be organized from the perspective of Self-world relationship as Table 14.7, where all "ten gods" are defined based on the relationships.

Table 14.7 Self-world relationship and ten gods

Entity A	*Relationship*	*Entity B*	*Relationship Nature (Chinese name and Pin Yin)*	*Ten Gods with Yin-Yang Characteristics*	
				Same Yin-Yang	*Opposite Yin-Yang*
Self	Same	World	同我 Tong Wo	Bi-Jian 比肩	Jie Cai 劫财
World	Xiang-Sheng	Self	生我 Sheng Wo	Pian-Yin 偏印	ZhengYin 正印
Self	Xiang-Sheng	World	我生 Wo Sheng	Shi-Shen 食神	Shang Guan 伤官
World	Xiang-Ke	Self	克我 Ke Wo	Qi-Sha七杀	Zheng Guan 正官
Self	Xiang-Ke	World	我克 Wo Ke	Pian-Cai 偏财	Zheng Cai 正财

In Table 14.7, the first three columns show all logical relationship between Self and world, it should be noted that these relationship are one-directional. Column 4 shows a short form name in Chinese and pinyin. And Columns 5 and 6 show the name of the corresponding "ten gods".

In terms of correspondence, Self is deemed represented by Day Stem (**Ri-Yuan**) and world represented any other heavenly stem within the eight characters profile. Note that in such relationships world can be directly associated with remaining heavenly stems; or indirectly represented by any heavenly stem that is contained within any earthly branch according to Table 14.4. Terminologies of the "ten gods" are commonly used in fortune telling.

By nature of such relationship, the ten gods can be classified into five groups. Note that due to the fact that fortune telling uses the first-person perspective, i.e. all relationships are centered around "Self" or the Day Stem (Ri-Yuan). Table 14.7 contains essentially the same amount of information as in Table 14.4. But Tables 14.5 to 14.7 have led to a quite unique set of language for fortune telling.

By assigning one of the "ten gods" to the relationship between any given heavenly stems, the rather simple logical relationship in Table 14.5 appears to have been transformed to a social map of an individual in the entire universe. It is worthwhile to pay attention to the Chinese characters used to describe ten gods, as they actually have subtlety further enriched and increased the meanings of the relationship. For instance when "Self**"** has a "Xiang-Ke" relationship to the "**world**", and the yin-yang characteristics are opposite, the Chinese word has the exact meaning of "wealth that is officially obtained" (Zheng-Cai), which in Chinese refers to lawfully normal income, such as salary or wage; even though the logical relationship has no such meanings. Such ambiguity in language use therefore has also paved the way for interpretations in a social culture circumference.

From here we can say that introduction of family relationship (initially by making analogy) as well as introduction of "ten gods", have rendered layers of **new meanings** to eight characters even though they **should/could be** a mathematical language describing rather logical relationships. The Chinese wordings for describing these relationships have essentially created a distinctive set of language, which make the eight characters fortune telling more attractive to its audience and make possible more connections to one's daily life. Such new meanings to a certain way would undermine objectiveness of the internal logic of the eight characters system; but at the same time they certainly draw significant interest among common people due to some added dimensions and room for using imagination.

More advanced relationships in eight characters structure

Year Stem	Month Stem	**Day Stem (Ri-Yuan)**	Hour Stem
Year Branch	**Month Branch (Yue-Ling)**	Day Branch	Hour Branch

Here we have explored the relationship between Day Stem (Ri-Yuan) and other heavenly stems and, as well as between Month Branch (Yue Ling) and Day Stem (Ri-Yuan). It might appear that Self-world relationship can thus be eventually determined. This is largely true except that there are other factors to consider.

The principal relationship between Day Stem and Month Branch can also be affected by existence of other stems and branches as well as interactions among the earthly branches. Sometimes such interactions become so strong that the relationship between one Day Stem and one Month Branch can be transformed to a new type. Therefore we can say that Month Branch is the most important character among the seven characters representing **world.** The existence of other branches and stems has caused **additional complexity**.

Now how can such additional complexity be analyzed?

Two methods exist for such purpose.

The first type of methods is mathematical/logical and straightforward, which is to leave all the structures and substructures behind and come to the fundamentals. It will involve dissolving the structures (including four pillars, and eight heavenly stems and earthly branches) into the five elements. As the heavenly stems are directly linked to the five elements, but earthly branches are not, such dissolving action also involves explicitly unfolding all the hidden heavenly stems under each earthly branch. By doing that one could analyze the entire profile of eight characters purely by examining the five elements contained.

The second type of method takes up the derivations at a higher level. Instead of relying on five elements, this method puts more emphasis on the group effects of earthly branches. For instance, if a combination of three earthly branches, 申 (Shen), 子 (Zi) and 辰 (Chen), is involved, a very strong presence of water element shall exist. In addition the Month Branch is susceptible to have other interactions with year, day, and hour branches; some of them may increase or decrease power of Month Branch, some interactions may lead to a complete nature change, such as the creation of water from a combination of 申 (Shen),子 (Zi) and 辰 (Chen). These complexities have been an intrinsic part of determining the structure of one's eight characters, only a highly skilled person can achieve a great level of confidence in his or her analysis of structures of eight characters.

It should be noted that although the first method is now being used, it is still not the dominant one. The second method has rather high requirements on the practitioner in terms of knowledge and experience, and at the same time renders power to the practitioner. It enables the practitioner to consider other elements of fortune telling, even borrowing other theoretical knowledge from other schools of fortune telling, which shall not be explored in detail in this chapter due to limited space.

No matter which method we use, we now can perform analysis on the eight characters profile. Then the next natural question is:

What is a good eight characters profile?

The eight characters profile enables one's fortune to be described in eight Chinese characters, and thus enables a logical analysis of the relationship among the characters, which centres around the relationship between Month Branch (representing "world") and Day Stem (representing "Self").

Now, regarding the preceding question, there is no simple and direct answer, but there are a set of rules which help the analyst to make judgment on the profile.

What is good? The ancient Chinese believes the following types are good

- Balance maintained among five elements
- **Self** is assisted by the **world**
- Profile with simplicity and clarity
- One that is harmonic

Correspondingly there are bad eight characters

- Unbalanced five elements distribution
- Intense Self-world relationship
- One that has significant flaws
- Critical element missing from the five elements composition
- One that is full of tension and conflicts

The preceding standards obviously have reflected traditional Chinese values, which may not fit expectations of Western readers. Balance is always considered a good thing, for instance if one's eight characters profile contains all five elements evenly and without significant conflicts, it is considered a good one. Normally the first sentence in diagnosis of eight characters comes from the relationship between Day Stem (Ri-Yuan) and Month Branch (Yue Ling), which as we discussed previously is representing Self and world. Is Self "assisted" by the world or is the Self "obstructed" by the world? "Assisted" might mean good and "obstructed" might mean bad. But the judgment cannot be simply made by only two characters out of eight. Given the Day Stem and Month Branch, and their relationship provided by one of the "ten gods", what are the effects by the remaining six characters and are they helping or are they obstructing? One must also note the principle of harmony. Too strong assistance from others might not do much good to "Self".

Indeed, a balanced eight characters profile is not easy to find. But it is interesting to see that certain very famous persons are regarded as having very good eight characters profiles. Numerous examples can be found from internet or traditional eight characters literatures.

6. Yun – the time dimension for eight characters profile

According to what we have explored, an eight characters profile has been expressed in the heavenly stems and earthly branches, which in turn can be further analyzed in terms of five elements. By considering the logical relationships among the five elements, one's eight characters profile can be critically reviewed.

But does this mean that a fixed "prediction' is made?

The answer is ***No*** . As any "time" can be expressed in terms of the heavenly stems and earthly branches, throughout the life span of one person, the five elements of the time change periodically, which in turn may increase the power of certain elements and reduce the power of some others periodically. This phenomenon in eight characters fortune telling literature is commonly referred as effects of Yun (运, Yun), which has a similar meaning to "Luck" in common English language.

In Chinese, fortune or destiny is often also called as **"**Ming Yun" (命运). This phrase contains two dimensions, the first dimension, **Ming (**命**)**, largely corresponds to the eight characters profile; the second dimension **Yun** (运), also contains same meaning as "luck", is related to the **time** dimension, or the periodical time effects during one's life span.

Ming largely dictates one's internal characteristics, and therefore plays a dominant role, but it cannot include everything regarding prediction. **Yun**, on the other hand, spells out the other environmental effects in terms of time that have not been fully captured by the eight characters profile. In simple terms **Yun** relates to **Ming** by adding two additional Chinese characters – one heavenly stem and one earthly branch.

As a result, one's **"**Ming Yun" or fortune at a given time period, shall depend on not only the eight characters profile but also the relationship and interaction between "fortune" (**Ming** 命) and the "luck" (Yun, 运).

Here "luck" or **Yun** is not due to probability and uncertainty, instead it is mainly due to the predictable fluctuation of time. Such fluctuation is similar to *fortune telling* according to the Western horoscope; except that to determine the interaction between Ming and Yun, one need to look the five elements logic as shown in Figure 14.2.

A convenient analogy is that of a car and the road. **Ming** (eight characters profile) describes the quality of a car, and **Yun** (luck) describes the road for the car to run on. Whether the car shall run smoothly or not depends on both the car and the road. Therefore one's fortune, the actual ups and downs of life experience, is deemed to be dependent on both **Ming** (eight characters profile) and **Yun** (luck).

7. Interpretations of predictions of eight characters

With the eight characters profile given and with a basic set of rules for interpretation, the reader may form judgment for him/her own regarding the Chinese fortune telling by eight characters. In this section, we shall further analyze the objective and subjective parts of the process for the reader's reference.

7.1 The objective part

First we can see the recording of birth time and expression of birth time by eight Chinese characters are quite objective. As with one's birth time given, only one set of eight Chinese characters is possible. In addition, further interpretation on the part of the heavenly stems and earthly branches, particularly decomposition into the five elements characteristics are also objective such that a mathematical analysis can be performed to tell the relative distribution and hence power of the five elements within one's eight characters profile. Some fortune tellers even use quantitative techniques to show the percentage of each element.

After that a judgment needs to be made regarding the quality of composition of eight characters. One can tell whether the existing composition of five elements are harmonic or not and if not, whether there are certain enhancements can be done to make it better. It should be noted that the determination of enhancements will be more subjective.

7.2 The subjective part

7.2.1 Necessary subjective

For the purpose of telling one's fortune, a tool/bridge is needed to link those eight characters with one's social life. Such tool/bridge has been made possible by use of "ten gods" and other personalized language which correlates eight characters profile with social relationships. As discussed earlier, terminologies such as "ten gods" and "four pillars" not only can make the rather mathematical relationships memorable and approachable to people with less math skills but also can provide a possible mapping between one person's eight characters and his or her social status. Particularly the use of "ten gods" Chinese name is linked with common things such as workplace relationships as well as family relationships such as those between husband/wife, brothers/sisters, parents/children, and grandparents/children. Such connection is more linked with the double meanings of Chinese words instead of an internal logical relationship. And thus this process is acknowledged as subjective. The author also acknowledges that such subjective way is perhaps necessary to "tell fortune".

7.2.2 Random elements and arbitrary correlations

There are many other elements that are not an essential part of eight characters fortune telling theory but can nonetheless be used together with eight characters. Such correlations are in general based on the idea of "universal connection", which is an abstract philosophical idea and has become rather concrete by established rules. For instance, the connection of four directions and five elements has made it possible to try to form a judgment on where a person should go for his or her career development. Many fortune tellers also will link different career types with five elements and try to predict whether an individual shall perform well with his

or her career, and even when someone can make a job change. A banker or computer engineer may be linked to the five element of "Gold", and a seaman may be linked with "Water". Such correlations can enable the fortune tellers to give detailed predictions regarding one's career, family or relationship, making eight characters fortune telling widely welcomed among people before modern times. These elements and correlations are rather random and are not essential in the theory but are nevertheless used by many.

7.2.4 Components from other Chinese cultural sources

There are other branches of Chinese fortune telling. Actually for ancient Chinese, different schools of fortune telling are not entirely separate. Most commonly they borrow ideas from each other. Purple Star Astrology (Zi Wei Dou Shu, 紫微斗数), for instance stands for another major school of Chinese fortune telling. Zi Wei Dou Shu, stands in parallel to eight characters fortune telling and has many knowledge bases in common. The major influence from **Zi Wei Dou Shu** is perhaps the many predetermined patterns, which basically gives a piece of information regarding a certain combination of heavenly stems and earthly branches, and tells whether they are favourable or not. Such components are often also utilized by eight characters fortune tellers, although it is not essentially required.

7.2.5 Superstitious components

As explained previously in this section, there are quite distinctively objective and subjective components in the process of eight characters fortune telling. Many times for the receiver of fortune telling, the emphasis is placed on the subjective parts and correlation with others. Such conditions can be illustrated in a simplified example as follows. Let us say that we know a person whose eight characters profile is dominated by **fire**, and by analyzing his eight characters profile, we have decided that his or her profile would be better if the element of **water** is avoided. And then one may guess that he may not get along with person with high **water** element, since water will "conflict/overcome" or "Xiang-Ke" fire.

Such derivations may neither be all truthful nor objective. The eight characters theory actually hasn't prescribed that people with opposite dominating element shall conflict with each other. And should the "fire" person avoid the 'water" person (that perhaps can be just fairly called as superstitious), as such belief is based on an extension of the ideas outside its original scope. But superstition is actually part of life as well, it is perhaps fair to simply acknowledge that it is also possible in eight characters fortune telling process, even though it is perhaps not necessarily linked with the theoretical basis of eight characters fortune telling.

8. The big picture in social culture

8.1 Post interpretations actions

An eight characters profile is given, and interpretations made, and what is next? Should the person simply accept the fortune? Or should he/she make efforts to make some changes?

Since the eight characters profile has an important perspective of five elements characteristics, simply by trying to change the balance within one profile, the fortune itself may be affected. The issue is what can affect the balance, and to what degree.

So indeed there are actions that can be done to help to enhance ones' fortune. This can involve increasing "power" of certain elements or decreasing those of certain other elements. For instance, for a person with an eight character profile which lacks "Soil", he/she may try to put "Soil" in his or her name; or perhaps he can use certain "Soil" type devices, such as ceramic items; or he/she could wear yellow colour clothes (colour of Soils). All such measures could help, but there is no definite literature than can quantify how effective such measures may be. All these efforts that aim to change destiny also partially lead to the

accusation of superstition from outside observers. But we should say that existence of such enhancement efforts are not part of the essence of the eight characters profile theory, instead those are extensions which deserves more justifications and verifications.

Actually, it is generally believed that the amount of things a person can do is deemed relatively minor when comparing with those things determined by "heaven".

The person is facing a "reality/fact" in terms of fate when his eight characters profile is given. As we said previously, minor superstitious belief may not have any significant effects on one's fate except for some psychological comfort. So the following up question may be: what are the choices one person can make; and how would this person be affected by his/her choices?

Contrary to many fortune telling practitioners' sales techniques, a more orthodox way is, for the person whose fortune is predicted, to **accept** his/her fortune in a general sense; but he or she should simply be aware, and take the moral lessons to be a good person. For instance, Chinese fortune telling can easily prove one person of no leadership quality; therefore the person is expected to give up efforts to grab power as such efforts could be useless. In this sense, the eight characters profile actually tells people to live within their destiny/fortune, not to seek excessive things, as those simply do not correspond well with their eight characters profile.

8.2 Influences/connections to social culture

Once the eight characters profile is given, mostly the actions are simply belief or non-belief. It should be noted that even among those believers, there are actions that counter acting; even the non-believers will be subconsciously affected. In a certain eight characters fortune telling book, an author has claimed that he is interested in fortune telling simply because as he found out that his eight characters profile indicates that as his character is not suitable for power or wealth, he has decided to devote his life to the real things he is interested in.

The fortune telling itself is a fun practice, and people enjoy talking about it. It has included many traditional values of Chinese culture and has essentially formed a noticeable part of ancient Chinese's cultural life.

8.3 Values or meanings in modern times

In summary the practice of eight characters can be regarded as a window to a deeper understanding of Chinese philosophy as well as to the vast background of Chinese culture. It gets people familiar with the heavenly stems and earthly branches, yin-yang characteristics, and five elements characteristics, all of the above being essential part of Chinese culture. With its essential value based on harmony, and its fundamental assumption on existence of universal connection, eight characters fortune telling had become an art that links one's fortune with one's surroundings and reflects the deep interference between one's self and the world surrounding him or her. Such viewpoints may have long been forgotten in an intensive modern world where people focus on short term commercial/financial perspectives.

In addition, eight characters fortune telling has also offered a framework for one to rationalize fortune. And it offers a set of language to discuss it. It might be quite meaningful as a psychological condolence to the unprivileged, as they shall tend to accept that all the undesirable living conditions are due to their birth time. Things are constantly changing and improvements may happen.

According to the philosophy of eight characters, it is crucial to maintain internal balance in an ever-changing world. One needs to think about the important matters such as, life, fortune, wealth, etc. Modern science, on the other hand, normally keeps people's attention on outside matters rather on one's Self. In this regard, it can be seen as an interesting diversion from busy life in modern society.

In the author's point of view, there is no harm to treat eight characters profile lightly or even as an entertainment. Actually, this may be the viewpoints already taken by many respectable history figures or

intellectuals (who are often called as "Shi-Da-Fu", 士大夫 in Chinese tradition) in Chinese History. As many of them are Confucius' followers, these people are not expected to care too much about his or her individual personal interest, money and social status. Instead, they are expected to care more about the society and social justice, for instance. They therefore oftentimes take a light view toward fortune telling; nevertheless, their intellectual curiosity oftentimes draws their attention to the mechanism of interaction of five elements and among heavenly stems and earthly branches. After all, it is "Tao" (道, Dao) or the truth, which they are looking for, not a short-term prediction of ups and downs over a lifetime.

In summary the practice of eight characters can be regarded as a window to a deeper understanding of Chinese philosophy as well as to the vast background of Chinese culture.

15
EMBROIDERY IN CHINA

Margaret Lee

Introduction

Embroidery – the word evokes images of patterns or designs on fabric embellished with threads and other decorative material. Throughout the recorded history of mankind, embroidery has had a wide-ranging role. At its most fundamental, embroidery is a handicraft applied to decorate apparel and items of daily use to beautify the surroundings. It was also variously used as a conduit to express personal feelings and aspirations and to fortify social, political and religious beliefs, philosophy, and principles (Chung 2005: 14). While it is still viewed as a handicraft in many parts of the world, embroidery, at the top end of the spectrum, has achieved the status of high art in its own right alongside other visual arts mediums.

Nowhere else in history are the multifaceted aspects of embroidery more evident than in Chinese culture where embroidery's long history has resulted in a very rich and colourful tradition that, over time, permeated into every aspect and echelon of Chinese society. It provides a perfect study of the unique relationship between a handicraft and a nation's economic, political, spiritual, and societal development. Although there are many different types of embroidery in China, silk embroidery is the focus of this chapter.

The transition of embroidery in China into a cultural heritage cannot be viewed in isolation. It is closely interwoven with the history of the nation, its fortunes and the political, social and religious developments prevailing at different periods.

For this purpose, the history of China can broadly be segmented into three parts:

1 Pre 221 BCE: The Neolithic period and pre-Imperial China prior to unification and the establishment of a centralized system of Government.
2 221 BCE – 1912 CE: Imperial China.
3 1912 CE to present: Post-Imperial China.

Silk in pre-Imperial China: (Neolithic-1600 BC)

The story of silk is said to have begun in the Neolithic period. Popular Chinese legend credits the discovery of silk to the 15-year-old concubine Lei Zu (from the "country" of Xi Lingshi) of the legendary Yellow Emperor. As the legend goes, she was sipping tea under a mulberry tree one day when a cocoon dropped into her cup of tea. The hot tea melted the sericin and the silk thread unravelled, leading to its discovery.

Figure 15.1 Statue of Lei Zu at the Suzhou Silk Museum

Source: Charistoone-travel (Alamy photostock)

Lei Zu is credited with initiating sericulture in China and is, to this day, revered as a silk goddess. Legend or otherwise, it is undisputed (Finlayson 2002) that the earliest known reference to silk and its production points to China and its existence established before the middle of the 3rd millennium BCE.

The background writing translates as: Leizu (嫘祖). According to tradition, she discovered sericulture and invented the silk loom. She was from Xi Lingshi and was the wife of the Yellow Emperor. She introduced sericulture to her people and the Emperor provided the necessary equipment. She was given the status "Silk Goddess" (mother of silk) since the era of Bei Zhou (557–581 CE)

Professor Gao Han Yu, eminent Chinese scholar in the field of textile technology, has also traced the history of sericulture back to this period. He noted that a small ivory cup, identified as a Hemudu culture relic and dating to at least 4000 BCE, had carvings of a silkworm design (Hanyu 1992: 8). The Hemudu was a major Neolithic culture (*c.* 5000–4750 BCE) settled in the lower Yangtze basin in modern Zhejiang province. Other relics since discovered from this culture have included a wooden weaving shuttle. Also of significance is a piece of silk fabric discovered in Henan province dated from around 3500 BCE and silk fibres and silk artefacts dated to 2800 BCE from Zhejiang province (Hanyu 1992: 8). These findings would suggest that silk production was well in existence in this period.

By the Neolithic period (c.7000 – c. 1600 BCE) (Hanyu 1992: 7), small communities were established either in nomadic existence or in some form of simple settlement involving agriculture and animal husbandry. This led to the spinning and weaving of simple cloth from natural materials such as plants and animal fur. With the discovery of silk and the establishment of a sericulture industry, weaving skills developed with the production of silk textiles and a greater sophistication in embroidery using silk threads also emerged (Hanyu 1992: 8).

The oldest written texts in China indicated embroidery started 4200 years ago during the period of the legendary Emperor Shun c. 2000 BCE (Lan 2007: 3). This is considered the beginning of embroidery as it was used for the first time in some form of official capacity. By process of deduction, embroidery must

therefore have been in existence before this period. This is augmented by writing in the ancient texts, the 書经 *Shujing* (*The book of documents*), where Emperor Shun was cited:

> I wish to see the emblematic figures of the ancients-the sun, the moon, the stars, the mountain, the dragon and the flowery fowl, which are depicted on the upper garment; the temple-cup, the aquatic grass, the flames, the grains of rice, the hatchet, and the symbol of distinction, which are embroidered on the lower garment. I wish to see these displayed with the five colours, so as to form the official document.
>
> *(Chung 2005: 120)*

The spiritual beliefs of the people during this period were steeped in nature and elements of the cosmos. Shamanism was commonly practised and specific totems associated with these beliefs were adopted by the different tribes and communities. From archaeological records, it appears that embroidery with design detail was initially used to decorate clothing. This custom may have developed from body tattoo techniques when people started wearing clothing and was likely the source of embroidery. (UCLA Fowler Museum of Cultural History 1999: 21).

The ancient embroidery patterns in themselves were largely derived from totems associated with the spiritual beliefs and worship of the period. This close linkage is supported by archaeological findings from succeeding eras.

Silk embroidery in pre-Imperial China (1600–221 BCE)

This period covers the Xia (c. 2100–c. 1600 BCE), Shang (c. 1600–1027 BCE), and Zhou dynasties (c1027–256 BCE), The Spring and Autumn Annals period (770–476 BCE) and the Warring States period (475–221 BCE) (Hanyu 1992: 7), spanning the epoch described as the Great Chinese Bronze age. Information on the era of Xia and Shang dynasty is somewhat vague although records of sorts from bone and shell inscriptions were discovered. It was not until the Zhou dynasty that formal written records are found. Notwithstanding the lack of written records, archaeological findings show evidence of a slave-owning society, widespread silk production, and development of a wide range of crafts. Silk was already an item involved in trade and by the time of the Shang period, its use in trade extended to an extent that an official position, Head of Sericulture, was set up to oversee the production and management of silk and related products (Hanyu 1992: 11).

By the period of the Zhou dynasty, a feudal system was firmly established and written records became more detailed and reliable. Embroidery by then was already firmly established as the domain of the "ruling class" and considered a luxury item (Lan 2007: 4). Sericulture was strictly controlled and only designated senior officials were permitted to wear silk. A colour system was also instituted that further reinforced rank and status of the "ruling class" (Hanyu 1992: 11). As the "ruling class" continued to amass wealth, this stimulated a desire for an even more luxurious lifestyle, which in turn, created a demand for more sophisticated craftsmanship and increasingly more lavish and sophisticated designs. Of necessity, division of labour crept into the silk production process.

This is supported by the 周礼 *Zhou Li* (*The rituals of th Zhou*), and its section of 礼记 *Li Ji* (section of protocol/rites) from this period. It included instructions such as: (Hanyu 1992: 23, 28)

- Dyers are masters of dyeing silk thread and fabrics;
- In summer months, the ladies of rank wore officially dyed elegant designs;
- All embroidery is stitched according to paintings; and
- The painter and the embroiderer share their task.

This implies a subtle shift from embroidery being a handicraft for mere practical decoration to a handicraft that embodies elements of painting, i.e. art.[1] A further indication of the raised esteem for embroidery in this period can be inferred from the fact that, according to the *Kagongji* (a Zhou dynasty historical record), skilled embroiderers were accorded a high social status (Chung 2005: 20).

Confirmation of this shift comes also from an archaeological discovery in 1974 of silk with actual embroidery intact in the tomb of the wife of a senior official of this period. The design was outlined in chain stitch with painting within the shape in four shades of brown, red (from cinnabar), and yellow (from sulphur) (Lan 2007: 6)

By the period of the Warring States, embroidery was highly developed and regarded as a status symbol of the highest degree. Its usage extended beyond clothing to other items of practical usage including covers for horses and cows where its high visibility showed off the wealth and status of the user. It was also during this period that the ruling class instigated the practice of including embroidered funerary articles and attire in large quantity and variety at their entombment.

In 1982, in Hubei, another discovery of twenty-one pieces of silk embroidery was found dating to the later period of the Warring States relating to the people of Chu, an important regional state of the period (Lan 2007: 9). The material was well preserved and the colours used were vibrant and more numerous, not only in variety but in tones. The designs of the embroidery were considered innovative and artistic even by modern standards. Chain stitch was the main stitch technique, using two-ply threads in thickness ranging from 0.1–0.5 mm, applied in a creative manner. A total of twelve different colours were used and each embroidered line had between three and five colours. Pattern lines were stitched variedly with single and/or multiple lines. Together with the artistic use of colour, dimensional and linear perspective was created within the overall pattern. There is also evidence that the design was originally painted on the fabric before the embroidery as opposed to the earlier practice of embroidering first, followed by painting (Lan 2007: 10).

The subject matter of the design comprised mainly of dragons and phoenix (Hanyu 1992). Of great interest is the fact that the individual images differ from each other. This suggests that the creative and innovative ways in which the chain stitch is applied were reaching a high level of maturity.

Of the twenty-one pieces of embroidered items, seventeen have the phoenix as the main design. The use of dragon and phoenix designs is significant as they were considered auspicious creatures of that period. The dragon personifies magical powers, nobility, and authority while the phoenix, a heavenly bird and a feminine symbol, is gorgeous, classic, pure, and peaceful. The people of Chu worshipped the phoenix and had adopted it as their totem. Their belief extended to the idea that this heavenly bird guides the spirit to heaven (Lan 2007: 13).

The techniques gleaned from more than 2,000 pieces of embroidery from the Chu State during the Warring States period have significantly added to our knowledge of China's rich cultural heritage.

Imperial China (221 BCE–220 CE): Qin and Han dynasties

The dynasties, names of emperors and dates of their reign in Imperial China, can vary from different sources. For consistency, those used in this document are all drawn from the "Chronicle of The Chinese Emperors" by Ann Paludan (Paludan 1998).

This period heralded the beginning of Imperial China that was to last for over 2,000 years. Qin Shihuang, the first emperor of Imperial China, unified the country and introduced a centralized system of government, administered by officials drawn mainly from the scholar class. He established the short-lived Qin dynasty (221 BCE–207 CE) which lasted only fourteen years and saw three emperors installed over the period. Qin Shihuang ruled for eleven years, during which his focus was wholly on state matters concerning the unification of China, building the Great Wall, and the building of his tomb in Xian. Although there is no evidence, it is reasonable to assume that embroidery did not progress much during this period of harsh

rule. There is an interesting allusion in a reference that the Qin "devoured their enemies as a silkworm devours a mulberry leaf" (Hanyu 1992).

Following the downfall of the Qin dynasty, the Han dynasty was established with Gaodi as its first emperor. This dynasty lasted over 400 years and was presided over by twenty-six emperors. It was divided into Western Han dynasty, with its capital in Chang'an (modern day Xian), and Eastern Han dynasty, which variously had its capital at Luoyang (in Western Henan), and Chang'an (Xian) and Xuchung in central Henan (Paludan 1998). The Han dynasty is considered the Golden Era in Chinese history. Confucianism, a philosophy that places emphasis on loyalty, appropriate behaviour, and obedience to hierarchy in both family and government, was largely adopted as the system of ethics for most of this period.

Five years of war preceded the official establishment of the Han dynasty by Gaodi, who became the first emperor (206–195 BCE) of the Han dynasty (206 BCE – 220 CE). He focused on rebuilding the country and making peace with their northern traditional enemies the Xiongnu. A Han princess was offered in marriage and annual tributes were sent which included embroidered silks, considered the highest class of imperial gifts (Hanyu 1992: 29).

Political and economic stability was eventually restored during the reign of Emperor Wudi (180–157 CE) and trade prospered. Emperor Wudi had one of the longest reigns in Imperial China and under his stewardship it was an age of economic prosperity and advancement in science and technology. In this environment of continued improved productivity, handicraft and embroidery also developed. Silk production not only increased its spread in area but the variety of embroidered items also expanded and became, increasingly, a valued item of trade along the silk route. In addition, embroidery techniques became more sophisticated and embroidery took another big step forward. No longer restricted to decorating apparel and items of practical usage, large wall hangings and scrolls filled with rich and beautiful embroidery became popular. These embroidered wall hangings were used extensively to decorate the palace walls (Hanyu 1992: 29). Citing Ban Gu in the *Xi du fu (Prose Poem on the Western Capital)* Professor Gao Hanyu wrote that the embroidered decorations in one of the palace halls were to the point that "the timbers of the room could not be seen at all" (Hanyu 1992: 29). The luxury and extravagance of Wudi's court was renowned and officials were increasingly required to wear embroidered clothing to depict status. His administration included "Embroidered Axe officers" who were imperial legal officers with the authority of life and death (Hanyu 1992: 29).

Although embroidery had extended to large wall hangings, its use during the Han dynasty period was still very much considered decoration for items of practical purposes. It had not, as yet, reached the stage where it was considered to be "for appreciation".

Despite the tributes to the Xiongnu, they continued raids on Chinese territory. Wudi eventually brought them under control with crippling damage to the state coffers. His conquest of the Xiongnu, however, brought security to the silk route and trade and traffic to the West flourished (Paludan 1998).

To better manage the production of silk and embroidery, specific departments were established. Professor Gao Hanyu identifies important production centres in four different prefectures. During this period, the division of labour between weaving and embroidery was formalized and became two separate professions. Embroidery was considered the more valuable of the two due to the amount of time involved in producing a finished item (Hanyu 1992: 29). It is valid to assume that some form of training in the skills of embroidery was also in place to keep pace with growing demand. Its increase in value also indicates that the numbers taking up the activity increased. At this time too, embroidery crossed from the realm of formality and officialdom into more general use. Gao Hanyu found that writings from the latter Han period noted "there is not a woman in Qi (one of the main silk production centres) who is not able to embroider" (Hanyu 1992: 29).

With the emphasis on embroidery, the variety of embroidered items expanded, as did embroidery skills and innovation in design. Designs during the early Han period continued to include mystical themes but with the addition of other animals such as the peacock and the deer. Chain stitch was still the main technique used but its application became highly intricate.

During this period, satin stitch, which gives coverage to a design element from edge to edge, was introduced. This technique can be applied in different orientations vis-à-vis the design, thus facilitating greater expression and "movement" in the finished design. From the basic satin stitch technique, colour shading within the shape was later introduced, allowing for even greater creativity and realism.

The introduction of satin stitch laid the foundation for the highly realistic images that are produced in Chinese embroidery today. Innovation in the basic satin stitch technique and rudimentary shading continued over time, evolving into a modern usage today. The key lies in "innovation" where the previous technique is not discarded, but improved on. Any innovation to a technique is usually introduced to overcome a perceived shortcoming to achieving visual realism in the design. This practice has given Chinese embroidery a repertoire of techniques that can be drawn on for any given design situation.

Another significant development that had a great impact on embroidery was the introduction of Buddhism from India – a new idea that made its way into China via the silk route. The first Buddhist settlement, the White Horse Temple, was established in Luoyang around 148 CE (Paludan 1998: 78). It was, however, not until the fall of the Han dynasty that Buddhism became a strong influence in the next dynastic era in the third and fourth centuries CE. Its influence on embroidery would have a far-reaching and long-lasting impact.

Archaeological findings from the Han dynasty, both within China and along the silk route, support the richness of design and the progress made in embroidery during this period. In 1972, a Han grave in Mawangdi, Changsa in the province of Hunan revealed a treasure trove of embroidered items. Apart from embroidered apparel, a variety of embroidered items of daily use such as fragrance pouches, gloves, mirror cases, and pillow cases were found (UCLA Fowler Museum of Cultural History 1999: 22). All these items featured the traditional chain stitch but at a high level of sophistication. The chain stitches were intricate and meticulous and applied in an apparent innovative manner in combination with other stitch techniques, including a previously unseen seed knot. The colours were rich and varied and even incorporated feather applique (Hanyu 1992: 29).

Other important archaeological discoveries of Han embroideries have been made in sites along the silk route, the most notable of which are:

the Han ruins at Wuwei in Gansu province which is the western end of
the Great wall of China;
the Han tombs at Niya and LopNur in Xinjiang province;
Xiongnu burial complex in NoinUla in Mongolia;
Palmyra in Syria – Chinese silk embroideries and their designs were noted to have directly impacted on Syrian indigenous textile craft (Finlayson 2002).

Silk embroidery in imperial China (220–589): Three Kingdoms

Toward the end of the Han dynasty, power struggle and chaos were rife. The dynasty ended in 220 and central authority evaporated. The country was left with a struggle for power between three generals. It was a period of confusion, disunion, and continual warfare. This period is also known as the Three Kingdoms period. The war zone was generally towards the northern part of the country, near two of Han dynasty's centres of silk production in the prefectures of Qi, Jun, Xiang, and Yia. As a result, the economy was damaged and embroidery activity in these areas declined for much of this period.

In contrast, the southern part of the country remained relatively stable and embroidery increased in popularity. Migration of people fleeing unrest in the north to the south saw a merging of regional cultures. This included aspects of foreign influence that had infiltrated the northern areas through the silk route and served to stimulate new ideas and patterns for embroideries.

More significantly, the rise of Buddhism during this period saw embroidery being used to decorate the halls of temples. Embroidered images of Buddha or Bodhisattva and embroidered items used in temples

soon became popular and gave rise to patterns for embroidery that were heavily influenced by Buddhist teachings such as the lotus, canopy, fish, endless knot, wheel, etc.

Of particular note is the influence of Liang Wudi who was ruler of the Southern dynasties from 502–549. During a period of chaos, his reign in the south was the longest and most stable. His beliefs encompassed both Confucian and Buddhist virtues. As a devout Buddhist, he did much to promote Buddhism and it was on his instruction that the envoy, Song Yuan, was sent to India to collect new Buddhist texts (Paludan 1998: 73).

With the strong patronage of the emperor, Buddhist-inspired design imagery found its place in embroidery designs from this period on. Because of the nature of these representations, embroidery was brought to a new phase beyond embellishment for clothing and practical items. These embroideries now appealed to the senses and their designs had inherent messages. This is considered to be the commencement of embroidery being elevated to the level of painting. A silk embroidery of Buddha from this period, found in Dunhuang, in the Mogao caves, is the considered the earliest known embroidery done for appreciation (UCLA Fowler Museum of Cultural History 1999: 22).

There is also an account that Sun Quan (182–252), founder of the State of Eastern Wu during the Three Kingdoms period, wanted a map of China. Lady Zhao, sister of his Prime Minister Zhao, who was adept at calligraphy, painting, and embroidery not only drew the map for him, but also presented him with an embroidered version. This embroidered map included details of rivers and lakes of nine regions and their mountains, seas and cities and placement of troops (D.K. Yee 140–42). Embroidery had taken a step into state affairs.

Silk embroidery in imperial China (618–907): Tang dynasty

The 300-year Tang dynasty is one of the most important in Chinese history in terms of political, military, economic, arts, and cultural development and is commonly referred to as the Golden Age. Silk cultivation and embroidery also experienced significant improvement and its sphere of influence underwent dramatic changes.

Silk and embroidery production centres were set up under the auspices of the palace and in Chang'an alone, twenty-five textile workshops were established. For the first time, an official title, 绣師 (embroidery teacher) was given to the person responsible for the embroidery activities at these centres (Lan 2007: 26).

It was also during this period that demand for silk reached new levels. Apart from silk's traditional role as an item of tribute, political exchange, and a status symbol, its unique economic role as a commodity for trade, store of value, medium of transaction, and usage as tax increased and became firmly established (Chung 2005: 102).

By now, embroidery was extensively used for adornment of items of daily use and to fortify religious ideals and teachings. Embroidered sutras, or religious texts, were not uncommon. Spiritual and religious beliefs continued to have a strong influence not only on embroidery, but on painting, poetry, and literature as well. Embroidered images of Buddha were elevated to the highest level and donations of these to temples by the aristocratic and merchant class were deemed an act of worship. On a personal level, embroidering pictorial images of Buddha, narrative banners and related items of worship and religious rituals was no longer a mere technical expression; it also took on the role of meditation, reverence, an act of devotion and, in the extreme, an act that earned merit points toward the afterlife for both the donor and creator of the embroidery. These embroideries were done by professional embroiderers and also privately as by then, silk cultivation, weaving and embroidery had flowed down to the general populace.

Figure 15.2 shows a pair of clothing bands with embroidery depicting the legendary pilgrimage of the Tang dynasty monk Xuan Zang who travelled to India to collect sutras before returning after many trials and sufferings along the way.

In terms of design and technique, there was a general move away from the more mystical designs of the Han dynasty. Flowers and bird designs, as well as foreign designs introduced by immigrant artisans and

Figure 15.2 Clothing bands depicting the pilgrimage of Xuan Zang
Source: Courtesy of the Embroiderers Guild of Victoria

imports, became popular and led to greater creativity. The use of gold thread was one such import that impacted Chinese embroidery and is believed to have come from Persia through the silk route.

Embroidery techniques soon became more refined as new ways to achieve colour shading advanced from those used in previous eras, the object being to create even greater realism to the broadened design base. Embroideries thus became more realistic, dimensional, and richer in colour application and set the foundation for embroidery gaining the status of "embroidery for appreciation". Much of this was due to the influence of women.

Empress Wu Zetian (the first empress who ruled Imperial China in her own right) was reputed to have once instructed one embroidery centre to produce well over 400 pieces of screens and Buddhist pictures as gifts to various temples and neighbouring nations. She was also attributed to presenting a robe embroidered with gold characters to her prime minister, Di Renjie, following which the inclusion of metal thread in embroidery became fashionable. Prior to the Tang dynasty, metal thread was not used for embroidery (Lan 2007: 26).

Another royal identity who did much for embroidery was the concubine, Yang Gui Fei (died 756). She had over 700 silk artisans dedicated to providing her clothing and embroidery requirements (Lan 2007: 26).

Spearheaded by palace example, demand for silk embroidery, especially among the aristocratic families, rapidly expanded. Its development rose to new heights and appreciation for silk embroidery, likewise, took on new dimensions.

Apart from Buddhist-related images, designs were expanded to include images deemed to be auspicious or that which convey an underlying meaning in a personal capacity. Officials began to adopt designs which included the Qilin, dragons and mountains that convey imagery of authority and power, while military personnel used designs including tigers, buffaloes and eagles, representing strength and bravery (Lan 2007: 27).

The Tang dynasty saw an elevation in the status of women which, in turn, led to a growth in their education, particularly in areas of painting and poetry. This was especially the case in the families of the elite and it was inevitable that these subjects and embroidery would eventually overlap.

There are many examples of embroidery being featured strongly in poetry or with poetry, much of which was written by noted embroiderers or respected personages expressing their thoughts and desires. Consider the famed poem written by Lady Hou in 841. History recorded that her husband, General Zhang Kui was assigned to protect the Northern Chinese border. He was stationed there for ten years and, Lady Hou, pining for him, focused on embroidery for consolation. On one of her embroideries, she wrote the following poem:

> You have now left me for more than 10 years
> I can hardly face the mirror to groom
> When I hear the migratory birds, I prepare the materials
> When I see the snow, I weave the cloth
> When I open the storage box, tears flow even before the cloth is folded,
> My heart is breaking even as I make preparations
> I embroider this turtle shaped image to present to the emperor
> And pray that he will allow the defender to come home early[2]

The 'turtle shaped image' is significant as the turtle is a symbol of longevity and it is practice in Imperial China to refer to the emperor as 万岁 (ten thousand years of life) and, in court, the emperor is greeted officially with wishes of 万岁万岁万万岁 ('tens of thousands of years of life' or, more colloquially, 'Long Live Your Majesty')

The Emperor, Tang Wuzong, was touched when he saw the piece and gave instructions to recall the general home. Additionally, he presented Lady Hou with 300 bolts of silk in public acknowledgement of her intellect and "cultural beauty".

Another famous embroiderer from the Tang dynasty was Lu Mei Niang, who was from a southern province and of commoner background. From a young age, she was reputed to possess a keen mind and adept with her hands. She stitched seven scrolls of sutras on one foot of material with each distinct character no larger than a head of wheat. Another embroidery that she completed was on a fabric length of ten Chinese "*feet*" (1 Chinese foot is equivalent to approximately ten inches), on which she stitched a design comprising an island, a palace, an angel, a phoenix, and more than 1,000 little boys. On completion, the fabric weighed less than three Chinese oz (approximately 150 grams) (Lan 2007: 35).

Emperor Tang Shunzong (805) was so impressed with her work that he conferred on her the title "Heavenly Lady". Subsequently, Emperor Tang Xianzong (805–820) also lauded her and awarded her a gold bracelet. She was also allowed to return to her home province with the formal title "Freedom" (Lan 2007: 36).

These accounts provide us with an understanding of the prominence given to embroidery, its emotive persuasion, and the status accorded to it.

Many embroideries belonging to the Tang dynasty were discovered from the beginning of the twentieth century. In 1907, a joint British/Indian archaeological team led by Marc Aurel Stein (1862–1943) discovered a cache of Buddhist artefacts from the Mogao caves in Dunhuang, also known as the Caves of the Thousand Buddhas. The significance of the location lies in the fact that it is a sacred Buddhist site strategically located at a religious and cultural crossroad on the Silk Road. A major part of this discovery, apart from embroideries of a religious nature, included manuscripts and thousands of fragments, as well as paintings and other artefacts. The embroideries include images of Buddha or Bodhisattva, patterns significant to Buddhism as well as flowers, birds and animals (Kuang 2012). More information and visual images from this important historical discovery can be obtained from the International Dun Huang Project (IDP). This project was established in 2007 as an:

> international collaboration to make information and images of all manuscripts, paintings, textiles and artefacts from Dunhuang and archaeological sites of the Eastern Silk Road freely available on the Internet and to encourage their use through educational and research programmes.[3]

Silk embroidery in imperial China (960–1279): Song dynasty

Between the Tang and Song dynasties, the nation was again in limbo as another period of warring states emerged, referred to as the Five Dynasties (907–960). This period was one of the darkest in Chinese history as chaos reigned until the Song dynasty was established by Emperor Taizu in 960 and a centralized imperial system was again restored. Being militarily weak, the Song emperors opted for peace with neighbouring states and nations through negotiated treaties and diplomacy. Under the able leadership of different emperors, internal peace and political stability was largely restored and, overall, another period of extraordinary expansion in economic activity and prosperity as well as technological advancement occurred.

In particular, under the patronage of various emperors of the Song dynasty who were themselves scholars or had strong personal interests in the arts, the imperial court attracted scholars, painters and philosophers. This was augmented by their reorganization of government and administration based on Confucian principles, with underlying attitudes of tolerance, benevolence, intellectual debates, and appreciation for the arts. It ushered in an era in which "the scholar's brush replaced the warrior's steed" (Paludan 1998). From a society ruled largely by the aristocratic or warrior class, this was transformed to an administration of literati officials who were selected through a centralized examination system.

As with any dynasty that survived over a long period, the Song dynasty had its ups and downs but these were largely resolved without any adverse impact on the continued development of the arts.

It is of note that, during the turmoil of the Five Dynasties period, some painters retreated into the mountains and found a new outlet for their artistic visions. A new genre of painting emerged and became, to this day, an important category in Chinese Brush Painting. This category of painting is collectively referred to as "San-Sui Paintings" (literally Mountains and Water paintings) or in modern terms "landscapes". It is, however, more than a mere painting of landscape. It represents the natural order of things in the universe and presents a powerful imagery amid the turmoil of the period.

The emperor Huizong, who came to the throne in 1101 and was himself a skilled artist and calligrapher, founded the first Academy of Painting in 1104 (Paludan 1998: 134). Under his patronage and direction, artistic development took on new directions as artists from different parts of the nations served the needs of the court. In due course, out of the traditions and cross-fertilization of ideas, there emerged a distinct style

of painting, which, like the San-Sui paintings, had close affinity with the natural world. This new genre of painting was referred to as "Flower and Bird Paintings"; a category that encompasses flowers, fish, birds, and insects. While these images had already emerged in the Tang dynasty, the genre reached maturity in the Song dynasty where the ideal of a painting being true to nature was considered fundamental. This led to a greater emphasis on colour and realism.

Painting was soon included as one of the scholastic subjects and a painter could become an official through the scholastic examination system. This, in turn, provided further impetus for painting. This new order of things would have far-reaching impact on embroidery.

From the Tang dynasty, embroidery for appreciation had made its first appearance. Women were exposed to and increasingly educated in painting and poetry; embroidery designs were influenced by and evolved with developments in society and the arts. The San-Sui and Flower and Bird paintings and the pursuit of realism flowed on naturally into embroidery, in terms of inspiration for designs and colour usage. This underpinned embroidery being increasingly done "for appreciation".

By the Song period, embroidery techniques had also progressed and, in particular, the "*souhechern"* (souhe stitch), which uses long and short stitches, facilitated more harmonious blending of colours. Embroiderers were also using finer threads for their stitches and, collectively, these developments facilitated a richer, lustrous, and more delicate piece of embroidery that is highly realistic. A skilled practitioner with needle and thread was (and still is) as effective as a painter with paint and brush. The result produces a piece of work that not only reflects the cultural and artistic thoughts of the period but showcases also the technique and individuality of the embroiderer. These embroideries were referred to as "embroidered paintings".

Embroidery within the palace, likewise, experienced a lift in demand and palace embroidery emulating that of the Tang dynasty continued and became more elaborate and luxurious. The number of embroiderers catering solely for the imperial family and palace requirements grew and a special embroidery office was established purely for the imperial family and officials (Lan 2007: 37). In addition to embroideries stitched with silk, gold, and silver thread, embroidery with pearls was added to embellish apparel and items of practical usage (Lan 2007: 37).

From this period on, embroidery for practical usage and embroidery for appreciation moved in parallel and each influenced the other in design and technique, whilst drawing inspiration from paintings, calligraphy, and religious themes. More importantly, embroidery done for appreciation soon competed with painting and calligraphy and came into a class of its own. These embroideries were done by literate women of the gentry as a leisure activity and popularly referred to as "*Guige Xiu"* (embroideries of the inner chambers).

Silk embroidery in imperial China (1279–1644): Yuan and Ming dynasties

Following the fall of the Song dynasty, China fell under foreign power when the Mongols, led by Genghis Khan, captured Peking (modern day Beijing). In 1260, Kublai Khan, grandson of Genghis Khan, claimed the Khanate and declared himself Emperor of China and adopted the Chinese dynastic name "Yuan" (Paludan 1998: 150). The Mongols would rule China for a century.

Kublai Khan established his capital in Peking but, given the contrasting lifestyle and history between the two peoples, a cultural gap was unavoidable, particularly with the populace in the South where dealings with the invaders from the northern plains were limited. Kublai Khan and his successors adopted a general policy of segregation with the Chinese populace, establishing a class system with the Chinese as the underclass. Strict political control over the Chinese was maintained and to reaffirm this, Kublai Khan deviated from Chinese imperial tradition and recruited into his palace administration foreign advisers and experts. A firm control over artisans and availability of raw materials was put in place and this greatly affected the development of handicrafts, including embroidery.

Whereas the palace had previously set the standards, this was not the case in the Yuan dynasty. In general, embroidery techniques and quality stagnated and the status of "embroidery for appreciation" took a step

Figure 15.3 Clothing items embroidered with flowers and birds

Source: Margaret Lee

backwards although there were isolated pockets where the effects were not as adversely felt. This disparate development in embroidery in the different geographical areas would set the foundation for the way embroidery would develop from the Ming dynasty.

The Mongols were defeated by a Chinese revolution, led by Zhu Yuanzhang, following a series of natural disasters and poor political decisions. The Ming dynasty was established in 1368 by Zhu Yuanzhang who took on the reign title of Hongwu. Chinese Imperial traditions were re-established as Hongwu set about restoring and reviving many of the traditions and customs of the Tang and Song dynasties. This policy was generally adopted by subsequent Ming emperors and the 300 years under the Ming dynasty was overall one of peace, prosperity and progress.

Figure 15.4 A "San Sui" (landscape) of the embroidered painting genre
Source: Margaret Lee

Table 15.1 Military rank badges represented by specific animals

Military			
Rank	*Ming (1391–1526)*	*Ming and Qing (1527–1662)*	*Late Qing (1662–1911)*
1	Lion	Lion	Qilin (after 1662)
2	Lion	Lion	Lion
3	Tiger or leopard	Tiger	Leopard (after 1664)
4	Tiger or leopard	Leopard	Tiger (after 1664)
5	Bear	Bear	Bear
6	Panther	Panther	Panther
7	Panther	Panther	Rhinoceros (after 1759)
8	Rhinoceros	Rhinoceros	Rhinoceros
9	Rhinoceros	Sea horse[9]	Sea horse

As in the Song dynasty, a centrally administered department was established for silk dyeing and embroidery, where embroidery activities were focused on embroidery for the apparel of government officials (Lan 2007: 53). It was under the Ming dynasty that an official ranking system, denoted by embroidered rank badges, was formally introduced. The exact date of implementation is unclear but by 1391, the system was well in place (Chung 2005: 190). These rank badges were worn on the front and back of the robes of the imperial family, nobles and officials. The badges were classified into two categories – one for the military represented by specific animals and the other for the civil service represented by specific birds (Chung 2005: 191). The rankings and specific animals and birds used would continue for more than five centuries right through to the Qing dynasty with only small variations.

Embroidery, once again, regained its premier position of prestige. Moreover, it now had formal official status. Entrepreneurship soon appeared and the commercialization of embroidery flourished particularly in the Jiangnan region (the original stronghold of Hongwu). This area, which encompasses lands immediately south of the lower Yangtze River, is today, arguably, the most prominent silk production area in China.

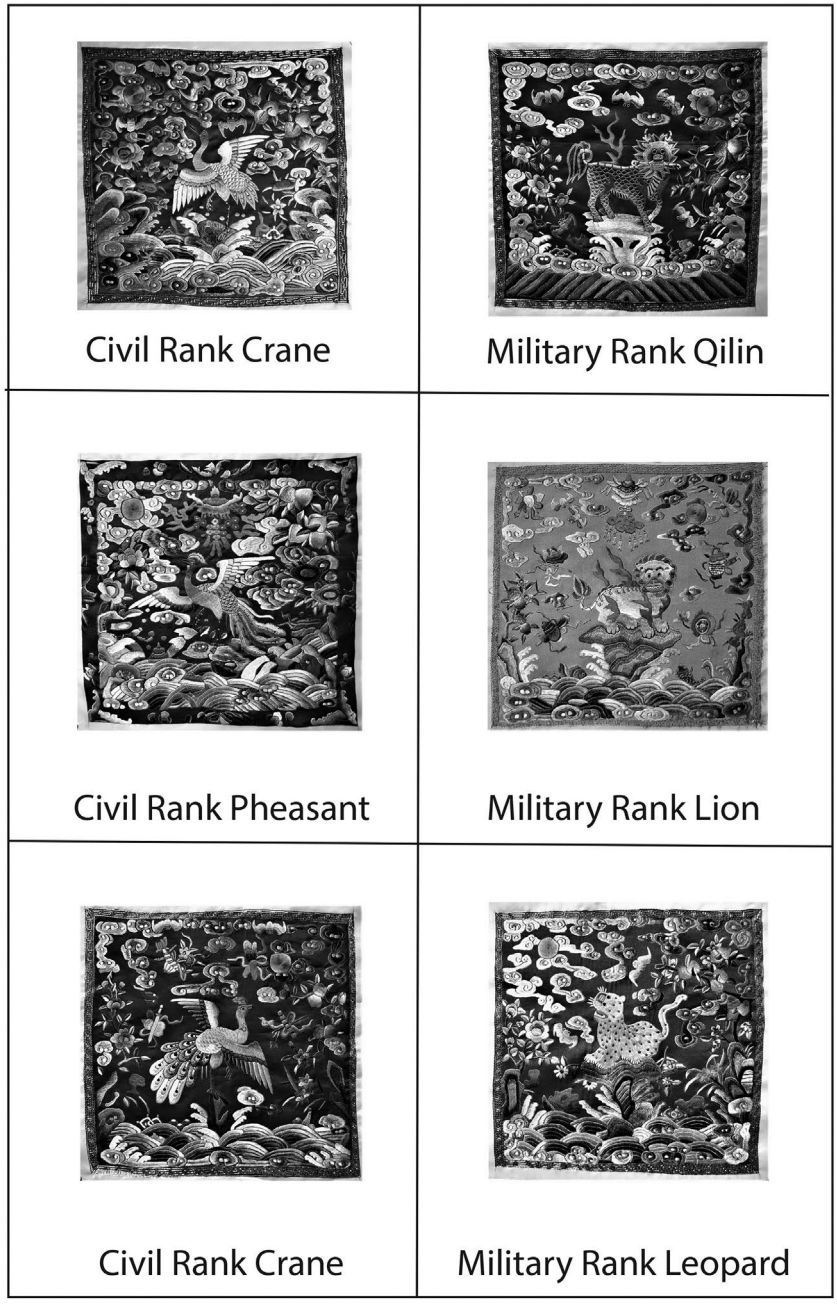

Figure 15.5 Rank badges

Table 15.2 Civilian rank badges represented by specific birds

Civilian[4]			
Rank	*Ming (1391–1526)*	*Ming and Qing (1527–1662)*	*Late Qing (1662–1911)*
1	Crane or golden pheasant	Crane	Crane
2	Crane or golden pheasant	Golden pheasant	Golden pheasant
3	Peacock or wild goose	Peacock	Peacock
4	Peacock or wild goose	Wild goose	Wild goose
5	Silver pheasant	Silver pheasant	Silver pheasant
6	Egret or Mandarin Duck	Egret	Egret
7	Egret or Mandarin duck	Mandarin duck	Mandarin duck
8	Oriole, quail or paradise flycatcher	Oriole	Quail
9	Oriole, quail or paradise flycatcher	Quail	Paradise flycatcher

Embroidered paintings became increasingly popular and a precious commodity following new and further development in this period.

During the Ming dynasty, distinct embroidery styles made their appearance, each of which had their unique characteristics. This was likely the result of the disparate development of embroidery in the different regions under the Yuan dynasty. Notable among the embroidery styles that emerged were:

1 Beijing's "ShaXian Xiu" or counted stitch embroidery (author's descriptive term based on modern Western embroidery terminology). This embroidery style was devised by artisans in the embroidery department of the palace where the number of embroiderers increased from just over 100 in the early Ming period to well over 700 by the mid-Ming period (Lan 2007: 55).
2 Shandong's "Lu Xiu". This is a traditional embroidery style from the Shandong area whose origin dated back to the Han dynasty when three administrative areas were set up for embroidery. Overtime, embroidery from this origin, with its own distinctive style, was referred to as "Lu Xiu". It is usually used for practical embroidery as the finished product was comparatively more durable.
3 Shanghai's "Gu Xiu", also known as Luxiangyuan embroidery. This embroidery style was so called after the "Gu" family whose womenfolk pioneered it. Its innovation elevated embroidered paintings, which started in the Tang and Song dynasties, to yet another level.

   In1556, Gu Minxia was appointed a minor court official after passing the imperial examinations. The prominence of "Gu Xiu" started with the eldest "daughter-in-law", the concubine Nee Miao, who was well known for her silk-embroidered portraiture of Buddha, but it would be Han Ximeng, the wife of the second grandson of Gu Minxia, who would firmly establish "Gu Xiu" in embroidery history. Initially, embroidery in the family was practised, as often in that period, as a leisure "female activity". It was used sometimes as gifts for family and friends and not as a commodity for sale. This frequently meant the quality of these items was considerably more refined as it was "art for art's sake".

   Following the demise of Gu Minxia, the family fell on harder times and, for the women of the Gu family, embroidery was no longer just a leisure female activity, it became a source of income for the family; as a commodity for sale and from teaching the art through a female school of art which they established. The fame, and more significantly, the style of Gu Xiu began to spread and became a generic term referring to embroideries done in their particular style.

   What is Gu Xiu and what distinguishes it from other silk embroidery? While it is evident that Gu Xiu had its foundation in embroideries from the Tang and Song dynasties, innovations they employed brought their embroideries to another new level of realism and, more importantly, acceptance by the male literati of the period.

Firstly, the subject matter adopted for embroidery was quite extensive and incorporated all aspects of traditional Chinese Brush Painting (国画 "Guo Hua") to date.

Secondly, the Gu Xiu technique was very rich and the ways in which the Souhe technique of long and short stitches was applied resulted in areas of varied stitch density, producing different textures for the various elements. It created more subtle colour gradations and dimensional perspective in the finished work, emulating the brush strokes and colours of a traditional painting.

Thirdly, stitches were smooth and even and the range of colours used was extended, made possible by the increased palette of colours available by this period from advancements in dyeing techniques.

Fourthly, due to new innovations in the textile industry, the silk floss used could be split down to a finer thread than before. Use of the thinner silk floss resulted in embroidery that was more refined and delicate than before. Out of this, new embroidery techniques such as Shi Zen (Wispy stitch)[5] emerged. This particular stitch is an innovation that would become one of the key embroidery concepts that underpin the highly realistic embroideries produced in the twentieth century and beyond.

Fifthly, the embroidery often integrated painting and embroidery in a complementary manner. These were done in one of three ways:

i Creating a painting and embroidering over it either in part or fully. In areas where part embroidery is done, the colours of the background painting show through, harmonizing with the embroidery. Skilful application and choice of techniques, thread thickness and colour gives it a dimension and perspective that has been described as "surpassing painting";
ii Adding paint to the completed embroidery images to enhance colours and dimensional perspective; and
iii Painting a background around a completed embroidery design.

One of the most unique features of Gu Xiu is that the embroidery innovations associated with it were all developed within the one family. Their work not only brought "embroidered paintings" to a new level but broke the "glass ceiling of painting". The form was well received and accepted by painters, art critics, and male literati of the period, who endorsed these embroideries as "high art" and deemed them serious collectors items.

The spread of Gu Xiu had a significant influence on embroideries around the area of Jiangnan which includes today's key areas of Jiangsu, Shanghai, the northern part of Zhejiang province, and around the south eastern part of Anhui.

4 Suzhou's "Su Xiu". During the Ming dynasty, Suzhou was a key silk manufacturing area. Its soil and climatic conditions were ideal for sericulture and, following the renewed interest in silk embroidery, the silk industry thrived. Every family in the Zenhu prefecture was said to be involved with silk embroidery or the silk industry in some way (Qiu Ping 2011). Given Suzhou's close physical proximity to Shanghai, embroidery of this area was also greatly influenced by the developments of Gu Xiu. Moreover, the people of the area were reputed to be gentle and cultured and the surrounding areas featured picturesque mountains and clear water. All these combined to present a conducive environment for embroidery.

Embroidery from this area gained its own unique identity and became renowned as being *Jing* 精 (precise), *Xi* 细 (fine), *Ye* 雅 (elegant) and *Jie* 洁 (pristine); four words that are considered to provide the most complete description for technique and painting in the Chinese art world (Lan 2007: 62).

5 Guangdong's "YueXiu". Guangdong is a province located near the coast of South China. It is famed for its embroidery using gold and silver threads and also other more exotic materials like peacock feathers and horsetail hair. The embroidery is primarily on items of apparel and for practical use with designs patterned after nature or images of an auspicious nature. This was attributed to the spiritual and superstitious leanings of the people from the area.

The Ming dynasty was the dawn of a new era not only for embroidery but for women overall as embroidery, seen previously as a traditional virtue of "*nugong*" (womanly work), took on new meanings. It provided an avenue through which personal creative and artistic expression was recognized as a sophisticated art form, not merely a means to supply decorations for the family and daily use.

Of note is the new approach taken by the Gu family and other embroiderers of the period. They approached their development as an embroiderer and their embroidery as would a traditional painter. They studied the paintings and styles of notable painting masters of previous dynasties and applied the lessons and knowledge derived to their embroidery.

Consider the "Six Canons of Painting" written in the sixth century CE, by *Hsieh Ho*, writer, art historian and critic. These still apply and form the basic standards of all Chinese Brush Painting, be it used in the training of a Chinese painter or in art critique. Each of these six canons[6] is easily transposed to embroidery with the paper, paint and brush replaced by silk, needle and silk floss.

i "Circulation of the Ch'i": (Breath, Spirit, Vital Force of Heaven) – producing "movement of life". This is in the heart of the artist.

ii "Brush Stroke Creates Structure": This is referred to as the bone structure of the painting. The stronger the brush work, the stronger the painting. Character is produced by a combination of strong and lighter strokes, thick and thin, wet and dry.

iii "According to the Object, Draw Its Form": Draw the object as you see it! In order to do this, it is very important first to understand the form of the object! This will produce a work that is not necessarily totally realistic but as you "see" it. Thus, the more you study the object to be painted, the better you will paint it.

iv "According to the Nature of the Object Apply Colour": Black is considered a colour and the range of shadings it is capable of in the hands of a master painter creates an impression of colours. If colour is used, it is always true to the subject matter.

v "Organize Compositions with the Elements in Their Proper Place": Space is used in Chinese Brush Painting the same way objects are used. Space becomes an integral part of the composition.

vi "In copying, seek to pass on the essence of the master's brush and methods": To the Chinese, copying is considered most essential and only when the student fully learns the time-honoured techniques, can he branch out into areas of individual creativity

Silk embroidery in imperial China (1644–1911): Qing dynasty

Following the collapse of the Ming dynasty, the Qing, non-Chinese Manchus originally from Manchuria occupied Beijing and declared the six-year-old Shunzi Emperor of China. Nearly four decades of warfare followed before the Qing conquest of China was completed in 1683 under the rule of Emperor Kangxi (Paludan 1998: 191). The economy and cultural development were adversely affected during this turbulent period but soon settled. For over 100 years under the reign of three successive Qing emperors, Kangxi (1661–1722) to Yongzheng (1723–1735) to Qianlong (1736–1795), China was relatively stable and flourished economically. By the mid-seventeenth century, China became the wealthiest nation in the world (Collins 2004). Despite being the ruling ethnic group, the Manchus were the minority and never made up more than two percent of the population (Paludan 1998: 190). They embraced Chinese traditions, promoted Confucian culture, and incorporated these in their political strategies.

From the beginning, embroidery had a highly visible role in the courts of Imperial China where regulations on its use were established and dictated; a visual opulence that separated the aristocracy from the general populace. This was no different in the Qing Court where embroidery reached even greater heights from both political and cultural stimuli.

Under the Qing dynasty, both the variety and usage of court embroidery reached their zenith. Embroidery became even more luxurious and lavish in response to the Manchu "taste" for opulence. In Beijing, an

Imperial Palace workshop was established where the best artisans were gathered under the supervision of a dedicated department which sole purpose was the production of apparel and decoration for the Imperial family (Lan 2007: 74). This was augmented by the establishment of three textile and embroidery centres in Nanjing, Suzhou and Hangzhou which also came under court supervision (Hanyu 1992: 35). The Grand Canal, completed in the Yuan dynasty, passes through these areas and was a main carriageway for the transportation of these items to Beijing.

The living quarters inside the Forbidden City and the Summer Palace in Jehol (modern day Chengde) were lavishly decorated and furnished with a large variety of embroidered items. On this, Professor Gao Hanyu wrote that "the collection of embroidered goods to be found in the palaces were so vast that they could not all be listed" (Hanyu 1992: 35).

The variety of embroidered items for practical usage increased greatly during this period and embroidered small items for personal use were especially popular. These included personal items such as money purses, mirror cases, fan cases, slippers, perfume bags, ear muffs, tobacco pouches, and many more. This practice was said to have developed from the Manchu's traditional practice of carrying small personal items such as a knife, sickle or needle and thread (Lan 2007: 79).

Money purses, in particular, were extremely popular with the Imperial family setting an example. On the occasion of the marriage of Emperor Qianlong's youngest daughter, the Princess Xiao, fifty-six embroidered perfume purses, thirty-six mirror covers and eighty-eight little purses were among the items of her dowry (Lan 2007: 78). The Empress Dowager Cixi was also reputed to have presented a small embroidered purse to each official who paid personal respect to her during Chinese Lunar New Year celebrations (Lan 2007: 78).

Manchu dress styles, reflecting their nomadic and hunting roots were incorporated into the designs of Chinese traditional clothing, giving rise to the lavishly embroidered Dragon robes from this dynasty. The designs of these robes, the embroidery decorations and colours were dictated by rigid court regulations which also extended down the hierarchy to court officials, their families and the general society. The transformation in Qing costume regulations, while started in the early establishment of the dynasty was formalised in the reign of Emperor Qianlong (1736–1795) after several revisions (Shwu-Shin 1988: 15) and was the pinnacle of embroidered court robes in the history of Imperial China[7]. It was highly prescriptive in nature and the system of classification gave rise to 48 categories based on sex, status, rank, office, and occasion: Imperial family (6), King (35), Aristocrat (5), Official's family (1) and commoner (1). This was further divided into two seasons (summer and winter) and four nominated circumstances (formal court garment, ordinary court garment, informal wear outside court and travel garment) (Shwu-Shin 1988: 15–16). The system also extended to furnishings and decorations which changed with the seasons and at parity with personal rank.

The dragon motif had been in existence since the Neolithic era, appearing in various forms and shapes. Written records of its association with rank appeared in the Zhou dynasty where the dragon and eleven other motifs were deemed imperial symbols within the Zhou court hierarchy (Chung 2005: 122).

The Zhou dynasty *Li Ji* (*The book of rites*) refers to the ceremonial dress of the emperor stating: "The son of Heaven, when sacrificing, wore the cap with the 12 long pendants of beads of jade hanging down from its top before and behind, and the robe embroidered with dragons" (Chung 2005: 122). The association of the dragon with the Imperial family was cemented when Emperor Wudi, founder of the Han dynasty, proclaimed himself descendant of the dragon, and was recorded accordingly by historian Sima Qian (145–89 BCE) (Chung 2005: 128).

The twelve imperial symbols were adopted by succeeding dynasties over the 2,000 year history of Imperial China, spectacularly displayed in embroidery to show imperial authority. History also recorded a tradition of giving a garment with dragons and imperial symbols as a way of showing imperial favour – a practice dating back to the age of the mythical emperors. (Chung 2005: 128).

In the Qing dynasty, the dragon image was formalized to comply with the ideal of "nine likenesses": "horns like a deer, head like a camel, eyes like a demon, crown like a snake, belly like a crustacean, scales

like a fish, claws like an eagle, soles like a tiger and ears like an ox" (Hanyu 1992: 35). There were also strict protocols to identify rank in terms of design and colour. For example, only the king was permitted to wear a primary yellow garment with nine five-clawed dragon images while the crown prince's colour was an "apricot yellow". Colours of robes, the permitted use of the dragon image and the number of claws on the dragon were all carefully scripted to indicate the rank and status of an individual within the imperial court.

The dragon robes also featured a band of embroidery at the lower edge of opposing images of mountains (symbolizing longevity) and waves (symbolizing happiness). Other spaces were filled with either the imperial symbols or, for those not permitted to use these, by other auspicious symbols.

In addition to court robes, the ranks of officials were also identified by rank badges. In this respect, the animals and birds formal system of rank denoted by embroidered or woven badges from the Ming dynasty were adopted by the Qing court with only slight modification. While the animals and birds denoting rank was maintained, the accompanying images that were included in the badges as part of the overall design registered a change. Diana Collins, independent researcher and textile conservator, notes:

> Badges from the 18th century bear scant symbolism when compared to badges made in the 19th century. Reflecting a strong belief in the supernatural to overcome strife, these later badges typically contain at least a selection if not all the eight Taoist precious objects and Eight Buddhist emblems of good fortune and other auspicious symbols often involving complex puns while endeavouring to invoke long life, happiness and prosperity. These were dispersed throughout the composition around the bird or beasts representing rank, eventually resulting in a surfeit of motifs and meanings.
>
> *(Collins 2004: 3)*

It is of interest to note that the change in design and the adoption of protective and auspicious symbolism coincided with the start of the decline of the Qing dynasty and the problems it encountered.

The tradition of embroidery being used as acts of worship and devotion continued to be evident in the Qing dynasty. During this period, a Lamaist form of Buddhism emerged which had their own monastery workshops producing embroidery for monastic use. Lamaist embroideries surviving from this period bear testimony to the incredible skills involved in creating these items (Mailey 1978: 15).

In the earlier period of the dynasty, the embroideries also reflected Manchu's cultural love of colour and dynamism as opposed to the more refined scholarly and artistic traits of the previous dynasties under the Han Chinese. As time passed, there was a noticeable shift in focus towards more harmonious blending of colour schemes and designs. The influence of two key members of the Imperial family could be attributed to this. The first is the Emperor Qianlong (1736–1795) who is well known for his scholarship and patronage of the arts. Proficient in painting and calligraphy, he attracted and retained skilled artists and architects for the many temples and places that he built (Paludan 1998: 198).

The second is the Empress Dowager Cixi who was also an embroiderer. She was the power behind the throne for 50 years, albeit in a declining Imperial China, under the reign of Emperor Tong Zhi (1862–1874) and Emperor Guangxu (1875–1908). The designs and embroidery for her clothing took on a new and different dimension and set the trend for the period. She was particularly fond of designs with large branches of flowers (Lan 2007). Peonies decorated her clothing in spring, lotus in summer, chrysanthemum in autumn, and plums in winter. In addition to silk threads, expensive and exotic materials were added for decoration. These included pearls, metal threads of gold and silver, peacock feathers, gemstones, and coral. The embroideries were of the highest quality and highly extravagant. For the wedding of the Emperor Guangxu, the Empress's embroidered robe was recorded to have included 21,013 pearls, 3,354 pieces of coral, 208 fresh water pearls, and 125 gold knots (Lan 2007: 82).

It was during this period of the Empress Dowager Cixi, that Shen Shou (born ShenYun Zhi 1874–1921), embroiderer extraordinaire from the Suzhou area, came to prominence. She would pave the next

step for the tradition and future practice of Chinese embroidery. She exhibited a talent for embroidery from a young age and later married a well-connected official, Yu Jue, from a highly cultured family. Surrounded by literati paintings and objects of scholarly art and culture following her marriage, she developed further artistically, also now having both the luxury of time and financial means to provide the best materials for her work. In 1904, on the occasion of the seventieth birthday of the Empress Dowager Cixi, eight pieces of her embroidery were presented to the Empress. These embroideries so impressed and pleased the Empress that she reciprocated with praise and a gift of calligraphy, written personally, of the words "*Shou"* ('Longevity') and "*Fu"* ("Good Fortune"). Following this, she adopted the name Shen Shou (UCLA Fowler Museum of Cultural History 1999: 41).

This event paved the way for her future. Shen Shou went to Beijing where she held a teaching position in the Imperial embroidery workshop. Sponsored by the Qing government, she later spent a year in Japan researching and studying embroidery and painting. Here, she discovered Western art and oil painting, in particular, the principles of perspective and the artistic use of light and shade. Combining her embroidery skills (applied innovatively), experience and new knowledge gained from Western painting techniques, Shen Shou set a new standard for Chinese embroidery creating realistic masterpieces which she referred to as *Fang Zhen Xiu* (imitation of reality embroidery) (UCLA Fowler Museum of Cultural History 1999: 42).

In 1911, the Qing government presented an official gift of a portrait of the Italian Empress Ailina, embroidered by Shen Shou, to the Italian government. The work so impressed the Empress Ailina that she gifted Shen Shou a gold watch. She also submitted the embroidery to Italy's Turin International Fair where it won first place. Shortly after, another of Shen Shou's embroideries, "Portrait of Christ", won first prize at the Panama Pacific International Exposition held in the United States of America. These events brought Chinese embroidery and its potential for creating realistic depiction of images and colour gradation to the world. They also created a subtle shift in perception of embroidery from traditional "embroidered paintings" to the elevated status of "Art Embroidery".

Shen Shou's enhanced techniques for creating realistic and lifelike embroidery raised fine silk "Su embroidery" to the pinnacle of Chinese Embroidery where it has remained. More importantly, her work in education provided a platform from which women from all echelons of society could attain training in an activity which by then had become a formal profession. Shen Shou established the Independent Women's Training Institute in Tianjin in 1911 (UCLA Fowler Museum of Cultural History 1999: 25) and, later, in 1914, she was appointed director of Jiangsu's Nantong Needlework Learning School (UCLA Fowler Museum of Cultural History 1999: 42). Here, she shared her knowledge and skills, not only in Jiangsu province but in other parts of China as well. She later dictated an embroidery manual on the practice of the art which is still followed by practitioners in the twenty-first century.

The Qing dynasty ended in 1911 and, with it, imperial China came to an end. While much focus was given to embroidery and textile centres in Nanjing, Suzhou, and Hangzhou, embroideries were also being made in many other regions of the empire. A great number of embroidery workshops were set up and their products were distributed, domestically and internationally, through the four main city centres of Suzhou (Jiangsu province), Guangzhou (Guangdong province), Changsa (Hunan province), and Chengdu (Sichuan province) (Gao Hanyu). Embroideries from these regions are popularly referred to as the "four famous embroideries of China" and have been designated Chinese Intangible Cultural Heritage. Embroidery became a significant export item for China.

Guangzhou, in particular, benefitted from being a port of call for trading ships from Europe and Asia and handled the largest export volume of embroidery in China. By 1793, embroidery associations and trading shops with formal working specifications, such as working hours, wages, materials used, colour, and other guidelines were established to cater to the expanding trade in embroidery (Lan 2007: 97). According to a 1913 publication, The Nanyang Expo Report, the export of embroidery from the port of Guangzhou to the rest of the world in the year 1900 amounted to 496,750 of silver taels (Lan 2007: 98).

The decline of the Qing Empire became apparent towards the end of the nineteenth century, with invasions from alien forces and political unrest within. As part of a reform process, austerity measures were imposed including visible austerity in the rank badges and attire of officials. By 1904, the army was reorganized and Western-style uniforms replaced the traditional robes (Collins 2004: 136).

Embroidery in society in Imperial China

Written records and archaeological findings have provided us with evidence of the many roles of embroidery through China's long history up to the end of Imperial China. These roles have clearly pointed to its status of prestige and value and have included

- political tools in the form of tribute, ransom, reward and gifts;
- status symbols for the Imperial family and aristocracy;
- religious and spiritual devotion and rituals;
- decorations for apparel, furnishings and items of daily life;
- expressions of personal aspirations and feelings;
- fortification of social and political ideals;
- as an asset and means for economic returns; and
- art and culture.

In its varied roles, little is written on embroidery's role among the general populace, especially women, although much can be drawn (LaFleur 2002) from social practices of the respective period. Other than embroiderers who were recruited and trained in textile workshops and centres, embroidery was generally considered the domain of women and passed on traditionally from mother to daughter irrespective of the family's social status. This was considered crucial in the cultural philosophy for the times given the importance and value placed on silk and its associated activities of weaving and embroidery.

In the family context, embroidery could add to the family's financial situation, as well as providing clothing and decoration for the family home and items of daily use. One of the more important social aspects, which is often lost in the end product, is the intangible value system that is embedded in this tradition. When daughters are instructed by their mother in embroidery, they are in the process developing the virtues of conscientiousness, diligence, organization, patience, respect for labour, dignity of being a wife, and responsibility to family and the empire (LaFleur 2002: 212). This led to the view that the quality of a girl's embroidery was a reflection of her value and virtue (Fowler 36), an important aspect given that "sight unseen" matchmaking was the order of the day. Assessment of her embroidery was often considered sufficient in assessing her personal qualities and hence, her suitability as a wife and potential worth to the family. In such context, it is not difficult to see the role embroidery plays in setting the gauge for "a woman's sense of identity and self-worth" (Fowler 39). It is an avenue for expressing "*emotional, intellectual, aesthetic, or spiritual feeling"* and also "*connotes female friendship and bonding"* (LaFleur 2002: 259).

In some regional cultures, it was also the practice for a bride to bring with her embroidered items as part of her trousseau. Additionally, she would produce three pairs of embroidered shoes for her future husband and his parents, a demonstration not only of her usefulness but also her willingness to undertake menial work (Fowler 37).

Among the family of the literati scholars and aristocracy, embroidery was considered "a worthy occupation for a woman" and not "just a way to pass time" (Fowler 36). The tradition of passing on embroidery skills from mother to daughter has other subtle emotive undertones in that "Embroidery was more than a

skill that daughters learned from mothers; it is a conduit for a female culture that one generation of gentry women passed on along with their emotions and dreams" (Ko 2001: 87).

In both the written and spoken word, embroidery also found a distinctive position in contemporary language, in literature and poetry and there are many extant examples of its use in these fields. For example, in language, the Mandarin word for embroidery 绣 "Xiu", in itself means "elegance", "luxurious" or "of the highest quality". Reflecting this is the use of the term "Xiu" in the following Chinese idioms:

- *Jin Xiu He Shan:* 锦绣河山

  The grandiose and magnificent land (rivers and mountains) of our nation.

- *Jin Xiu Qian Cheng*: 锦绣前程

  A brilliant or bright future likened to a beautiful embroidery

- *Xiu Xin Jin Kou* 绣心锦口

  Eloquent and charming

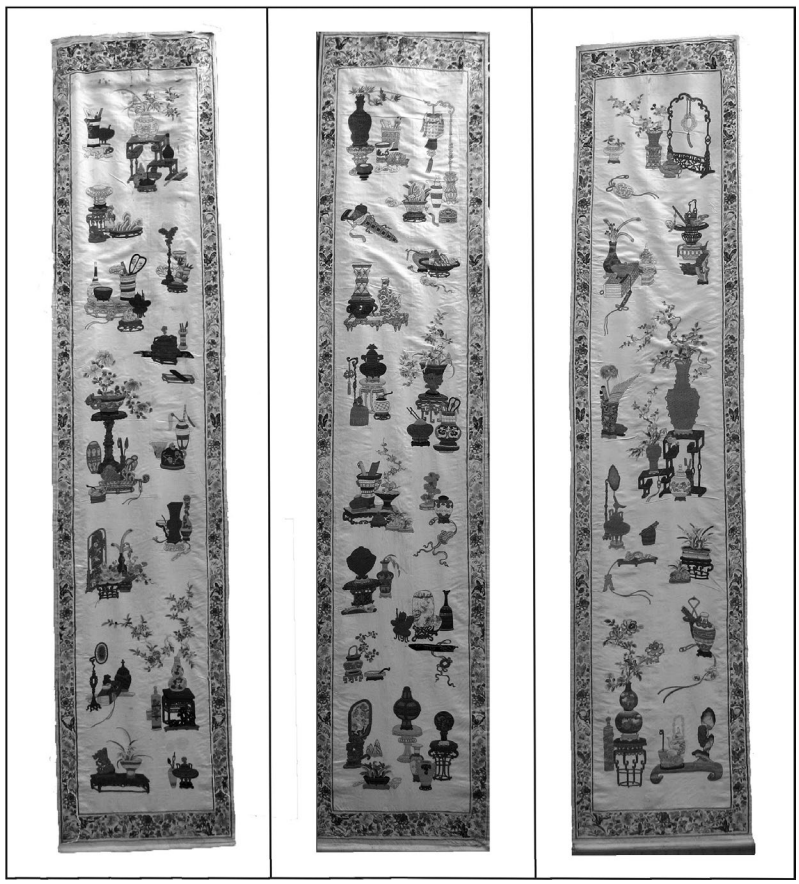

Figure 15.6 Wall hangings

Source: Courtesy of the Embroiderer's Guild of Victoria

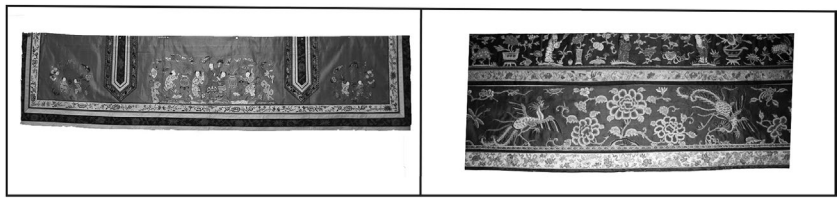

Figure 15.7 Embroideries of bed hangings and an altar cloth as examples of home decorative items
Source: Courtesy of the Embroiderer's Guild of Victoria

Post-imperial China

The Qing dynasty came to an end in 1911. The Republic of China, led by Dr Sun Yat Sen was established on 1 January 1912 and Yuan Shikai, a high-ranking ex-Qing military commander, was appointed its president. Yuan Shikai attempted to set up a new dynasty of his own in late 1915, with an imperial style dress code and rank badges based on the Ming dynasty. This was short lived. Faced with a revolt, he abdicated in 1916 (Dianne Collins 137). There followed a period of deep political unrest from internal civil strife between different political and regional factions and war aggression from Japan.

Embroidery was greatly and adversely impacted during this period. No longer was there an imperial court or a system with a voracious appetite for all things embroidered. Overall, the continued civil unrest and war with Japan left the general populace with little means or will to indulge in such luxuries as embroidery. An exception to this was Yang Shouyu. Yang Shouyu came from a highly cultured family and was traditionally schooled in painting, poetry and calligraphy besides embroidery (Fowler 43). Widowed young, she took on a teaching role and, in 1928, as the director of embroidery at Danyang Women's Vocational, she created a new way of stitching which is today referred to as "Random Stitch Embroidery". (The literal translation from the Mandarin version "luanzhenxiu" 乱针绣 has the more incongruous term "Chaotic needle embroidery"). In the words of Zhang Mei Fang, director of Suzhou Embroidery Research Institute (SERI), she created this embroidery technique "out of frustration with the tedium and discipline of traditional embroidery" (Fowler 43). This attitude seems to coincide with the mood for change of the period and the emerging socialist ideology. Instead of the traditional method of building up the embroidery with individual parallel stitches, this technique involves replacing the traditional stitch with cross stitches. Through strategic placement of layered cross stitches and colour choices, a highly realistic effect with great dimensional perspective and depth of colour is achieved. This technique also facilitates embroidery to emulate oil painting which was not possible before and, skilfully applied, renders lifelike images on any subject. Today, random stitch embroidery is a fully entrenched branch of Su embroidery, with whole embroidery artworks stitched principally with this technique or in combination with traditional methods. It provides an embroidery artist with great flexibility and the ability to replicate, in embroidery, a design in any desired visual art medium. This innovation brought Art Embroidery, started in the era of Shen Shou, to a level not experienced before.

Surprisingly, Yang Shouyu's classes remained uninterrupted through the turmoil of the period (LaFleur 2002: 225) and, in 1954, she helped set up SERI where the continuing story of Su embroidery lives on.

In 1949, the Communist Party prevailed and won political power establishing the People's Republic of China. The new government set a direction for China with policies that were patterned after the Socialist Soviet Union's models for education, religion, economics, and culture whilst encouraging a move away from many of the established traditions of the past (Collins 2004: 140). Propaganda posters were one of the effective tools of communication used during this period to disseminate information to the populace.

It was generally a period of austerity where traditions of the past and Western influences were discouraged. Amidst the turmoil of building a new nation and, even against the initial dictum that embroidery was not in line with the vision of the new regime, embroidery soon found its place.

Quiet Waters

Random Stitch Embroidery Replicating Ink Wash Painting

Australian Blue Wren

Combined Traditional and Random Stitch embroidery replicating oil painting (original painting by Jeremy Boots)

Figure 15.8 Random stitch embroidery

Firstly, as a propaganda tool, embroidered posters portraying socialist ideals and revolutionary events were created alongside embroidered portraits of Chairman Mao and other noted socialist leaders of the period, including Karl Marx, Lenin, and Stalin. The portraitures were produced at SERI and stitched by modern China's acclaimed embroidery master, Ren Huixian, personally or in cooperation with her colleagues. These works were received with great acclaim and from this, Suzhou's embroidery portraiture experienced a revival following a period of decline after Shen Shou.

Secondly, as a unique cultural heritage, embroidery was often the item of choice for diplomatic gift exchanges with foreign countries. Thirdly, as a source of foreign exchange in the export trade, embroidery continued to make contributions to the country's balance of trade. Fourthly, in the arena of visual arts, Chinese Art Embroideries are increasingly making its presence known and felt.

The People's Republic of China is a major economic power on the world stage. Embroidery continues a strong and visible role in an enduring tradition that has evolved with the country and its people over its thousands of years history, morphing but maintaining its relevance with the times. Citing Diana Collins, embroidery has provided "*dimension to past and present daily events"* (LaFleur 2002: 264) and will, undoubtedly, continue to do so into the future. It epitomizes the words of Ren Huixian, "Life is limited but art is unlimited".

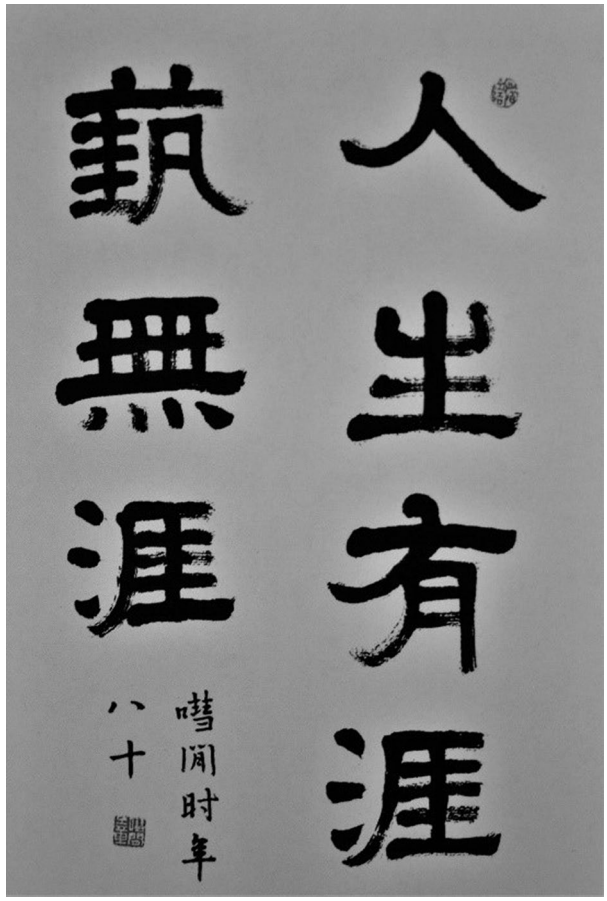

Figure 15.9 "Life is limited but art is unlimited" (Ren Huixian)

Notes

1 In the Chinese language there is no explicit equivalent to the Western term for "art". The term used instead (*Hua*) translates as "*painting*".
2 Author's adapted translation from original Mandarin text (Lan 2007: 35).
3 International DunHuang Project, retrieved from http://idp.bl.uk/.
4 Even general lowly ranked officials had an insignia officials e.g., The official who held a lower position or did odd jobs used the magpie during the Ming dynasty; musicians used the oriole and supervising officials used xiezhi (a mythical animal with the ability to distinguish right and wrong translation, original Mandarin text) (Lan 2007: 35) International DunHuang Project.
5 Wispy stitch is the author's terminology used in her teaching. It is also referred to as "hairy stitch" in other translations.
6 Source Nan Rae*:* http://nanrae.com/
7 For additional interest: (Mailey 1978) 'Decoding Dragons: Status Garments in Ch'ng Dynasty China' by John E. Vollmer (Publisher: University of Oregon, Museum of Art).

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16

AN OVERVIEW OF CHINESE FORTUNE TELLING IN TRADITIONAL TIMES

Richard J. Smith

莫道文王卦不靈, 只怕先生斷不真
"Do not say that King Wen's hexagrams are ineffective; fear only that the diviner's reading is untrue".

– *Chinese proverb*

I. Preliminary remarks

From earliest times, fortune telling (*suanming* 算命, *zhanbu* 占卜, *fangshu* 方術, etc.) has played an important role in Chinese history. One indication is the attention given to it in each of the traditional Chinese dynastic histories, as well as in reference works of all kinds. A striking example from late imperial China is the massive Qing dynasty encyclopedia known as the *Qinding gujin tushu jicheng* 欽定古今圖書集成 (*Imperially approved complete collection of writings and illustrations, past and present*; 1726), which devotes well over 2,000 pages to fortune tellers and mantic techniques.[1] Another index is Yuan Shushan's 袁樹珊 monumental *Zhongguo lidai buren zhuan* 中國歷代卜人傳 (*Biographies of diviners in China by period*; 1948), which consists largely of excerpts from local Chinese gazetteers, official histories, and other such sources, and contains more than 3,000 biographical entries.[2]

Yet it has only been during the last forty years or so that Chinese fortune telling has become a legitimate topic for scholarly study in the People's Republic of China (PRC). The reasons have much to do with the comparatively liberal policies of the PRC following the so-called Open Policy declared in 1978. Prior to that point, fortune telling in China was condemned and even outlawed as "feudal superstition" (*fengjian mixin* 封建迷信). But gradually after 1978, new and spectacular archaeological finds dating from the Shang (c. 1600–c. 1045 BCE), Zhou (c. 1045–256 BCE), Qin (221–206 BCE), and Han (206 BCE to 220 CE) dynasties, coupled with an increasingly favourable attitude toward traditional Chinese culture in general, has encouraged a huge outpouring of both scholarly and popular writing about divination in China.

Archaeological findings have been particularly important in promoting a scholarly interest in Chinese divination. These discoveries have inspired new interpretations of the Chinese past, and encouraged Mainland scholars to produce a wealth of encyclopedias, collections of documents, and secondary studies.[3] These efforts, in turn, have made it easier for scholars outside of China to play an active role in the interpretive process.[4] But problems remain.

One obvious difficulty in discussing Chinese divination in Western languages is the wide variety of possible translations for Chinese terms. Another related challenge is grouping fortune-telling techniques into meaningful categories. As we shall see, many Chinese divinatory theories and practices are based on the same spatial, temporal, astrological, numerical, and "spiritual" variables. Given this sort of conceptual and practical overlap (see, for example, Yates 2005, esp. 31–34), even Chinese scholars cannot agree on a single typology for mantic methods (some breakdowns number in the dozens; see Kalinowski 2004, 2005, 2010, 2013).

For the purposes of this chapter, I have divided Chinese fortune telling into the following broad categories: (1) astrology, numerology and fate extrapolation (*xingbu* 星卜; *xingming* 星命; *xingzhan* 星占; *zhanxing* 占星, *shushu* 數術, *tuibu* 推步; *tuiming* 推命; *tuisuan* 推算 etc.); (2) divination by lots (*shubu qiaosuan* 數卜巧算); (3) dream interpretation (*jiemeng* 解夢; *mengzhan* 夢占; *zhanmeng* 占夢, etc.); (4) geomancy (*budi* 卜地; *dizhan* 地占; *fengshui* 風水; *kanyu* 堪輿 *xiangzhai* 相宅; *zedi* 擇地; *zhanzhai* 占宅, etc.); (5) the interpretation of written characters (*cezi* 測字; *chaizi* 拆字; *xiangzi* 相字, etc.); (6) meterological divination (*fengjiao* 風角; *houqi* 候氣; *wangqi* 望氣; *shanhou* 占侯, etc.); (7) the use of oracle bones (*jiagu* 甲骨) and prophetic texts (*chenwei* 讖緯; *chenyao* 讖謠, etc.); (8) physiognomy (*kanming* 看命; *kanren* 看人; *kanxiang* 看相; *kanzhang* 看掌; *xiangshu* 相術, etc.); (9) the selection of auspicious dates and times (*xuance* 選測; *xuanze* 選擇; *zeri* 擇, etc.); and (10) shamanism (*wushu* 巫術) and spirit-writing (*fuji* 扶乩 (or 扶箕); *fuluan* 扶鸞, etc.).

II. Chinese divination: a brief historical overview

Among the legendary achievements of China's earliest culture hero, Fuxi (伏羲 or 伏犧), was the invention of the famous three-line symbols known as trigrams (*gua* 卦), which were devised, we are told, to aid in prognostication, to promote invention, and to facilitate communication and classification. According to one well-known version of the myth:

> When Fuxi ruled the world in early antiquity, he looked up and contemplated the images (*xiang* 象) in Heaven, and looked downward to contemplate the patterns (*fa* 法) on Earth. He contemplated the markings of birds and beasts and their adaptations to the various areas. He proceeded directly from himself and indirectly from objects. Thus he invented the eight trigrams in order to enter into communication with the virtuous power of the spiritual intelligence (*shenming* 神明) and to classify the conditions of all things.[5]

Other myths credit either Fuxi, his successor, Shennong (神農), or the fully historical King Wen (文王) and the Duke of Zhou (周公) with developing a system of sixty-four hexagrams (also *gua* 卦) based on the eight trigrams. These hexagrams, like the trigrams, were used to classify and explain phenomena as well as to promote inventiveness and to serve as oracular symbols (see ahead).

The Fuxi myth suggests several distinctive features of Chinese divination that persisted for at least 3,000 years. The first is that the practice had a distinguished pedigree and enjoyed abundant classical sanction. The second is that the symbols used in divining – whether abstract, naturalistic or numerical – were assumed to represent heavenly images and earthly patterns that reflected, in turn, a unified and harmonious cosmic order. A third distinctive feature of traditional Chinese divination is the belief that the cosmos contained an active spiritual presence or intelligence that could assist human beings in discerning patterns of change and in elucidating meaning. The exact nature of the spirit world was, however, a matter of much debate.

A. Divination in early China (c. 1600–221 BCE)

By the fourth millennium, at the latest, specialists in reading stress cracks in the bones of deer, sheep, pigs, and cattle had already emerged as a distinct occupational group in north China's neolithic cultures. During

the Shang dynasty (c. 1600–1045 BCE), the use of oracle bones (*jiagu* 甲骨) reached a high degree of sophistication, since this form of divination became the principal means by which the Shang kings were able to establish communication with their supreme deity, Shangdi 上帝 ("Lord on High"). By applying intense heat to the dried plastrons of turtles and to the scapulae of cattle – a technique known as pyromancy or pyro-plastromancy – the Shang kings and their priestly diviners were able to produce cracks in the bone, which yielded answers to questions both trivial and weighty. Such "questions," which modern Chinese scholars describe as "charges" (*mingci* 命辭), were inscribed in the bones and normally phrased as prayers, declarations, and desired outcomes. (Keightley 1985; Kory 2012)

Shang divination practices reveal patterns of conceptualization and categorization that lasted for several millennia in China – for example, the early use of sexegenary cyclical characters ("stems" and "branches;" *ganzhi* 干支) for marking time. This practice continued in all subsequent dynasties and can still be seen today in traditional Chinese almanacs and many divinatory practices. There is also growing evidence to support the view that the Shang Chinese developed a numerical system or systems capable of producing the trigrams (*gua* 卦) and hexagrams (also *gua*卦) that became the foundation of the legendary *Yijing* 易經 (Classic of changes) – arguably the single most important work in China's entire imperial history. (R. Smith 2008b, 2012)

Oracle bone divination did not, of course, remain static during the seven centuries of Shang rule. We know, for example, that by the end of the dynasty, pyromancy lost much of its mystique; prognostications tended to be brief, formalized, and almost invariably auspicious, and mantic techniques became ever more accessible to non-royalty. Meanwhile, other forms of divination, including the use of milfoil stalks (*shi* 蓍) to divine, seem to have gained in popularity. By the ninth century CE at the latest, oracle bones were seldom, if ever, used for mantic purposes (Kory 2012: 407–20).

Divination in the early Zhou dynasty (c. 1045–256 BCE) followed the basic contours of late Shang practice, including the employment of professional diviners who held royal and bureaucratic positions. But their supreme deity was now known generally as Tian 天 or ("Heaven"); indeed the Zhou kings justified their conquest of the Shang by reference to the so-called Mandate of Heaven (*Tianming* 天命). This explicitly moral concept gave Heaven responsibility for determining if earthly government was benevolent and just. If so, there would be harmony in nature and peace on earth; if not, then Heaven's displeasure would be expressed through various anomalies, including natural disasters. Rebellions would arise, and the existing government's mandate would be withdrawn. Oppressed people, it came to be believed, had the right to rebel, and heavenly signs pointed the way. For this reason, the Zhou state, and all subsequent Chinese regimes, sought to divine Heaven's will with every mantic tool available (R. Smith 1991: 18).

During the early Zhou, as had been the case in Shang times, divination remained primarily a royal prerogative. By the Spring and Autumn era (722–481 BCE), however, it had become more diversified and widespread, practised by private individuals as well as the court, women as well as men.

Moreover, although oracle bone divination continued to be practised in China for nearly a thousand years into the imperial era, increasingly it was supplanted by milfoil divination, which involved the manipulation of milfoil stalks (and perhaps bamboo) rather than reading cracks. The most common use of milfoil divination during the late Zhou period, and indeed throughout the entire imperial era (221–1912 CE), was in conjunction with the legendary *Zhouyi* (周易). The basic text of this fascinating document, which evolved gradually over several centuries during the Zhou dynasty (on this complex process, see Shaughnessy 2014; R. Smith 2008b: 7–30; Cook and Lu 2017), consisted of sixty-four six-line hexagrams, each with a name that referred to a physical object, an activity, a state, a situation, a quality, an emotion or a relationship. Thus, Ding 鼎, "The Cauldron"; Dun 遯, "Retreat"; Meng 蒙, "Youthful Ignorance"; Yu 豫, "Enthusiasm"; Song 訟, "Conflict"; Tongren 同人, "Human Fellowship"; and so forth.

In addition, each hexagram possessed a short, cryptic description of several characters called a "judgment" (*tuan* 彖 or *guaci* 卦辭), and a brief, one-sentence reading for each line (*yaoci* 爻辭). The hexagrams also contained a pair of trigrams which, like the hexagrams themselves, had individual names and various

symbolic associations. According to the theory of the *Zhouyi*, the hexagrams represented symbolically the images (*xiang* 象) and patterns of change in the universe, and as such, they had explanatory value, if correctly interpreted.[6]

Parallel to the growing popularity of the *Zhouyi* as a device for knowing the future in the late Zhou era (the Warring States period, 453–221 BCE) was a burst of interest in other divination systems. In addition to various inherited Shang and Zhou approaches to astrology, dream interpretation, and the use of oracle bones and milfoil stalks, new mantic systems arose, involving the employment of almanacs 日書 (lit. "day-books"), geomancy, physiognomy, and various computational arts – all to be discussed at greater length below (for Chinese terms, see Table 16.1). (Fodde-Reguer 2014; Harper 1999a, 1999b; Harper and Kalinowski 2017; Kalinowski 2004, 2005, 2009; Li Shenglong 1993; Raphals 2013; Wang 2000; R. Wang 2012; Z. Wang 2016).

At the core of virtually all of these forms of divination was a highly refined correlative cosmology, marked by the following major variables: *yin* 陰 and *yang* 陽, the five agents (*wuxing* 五行; aka the five phases, five elements, five qualities, etc.), the ten heavenly stems (*tiangan* 天干) and the twelve earthly branches (*dizhi* 地支), the twenty-eight divisions of the sky known as "lodges" (*xiu* 宿), each identified with different constellations of stars, and a great many spirits – some beneficial (*shen* 神) and some harmful (*sha* 殺 or 煞; also *gui* 鬼). (For other cosmic variables, see Harper 1999a; Harper and Kalinowski 2017).

These tangible forces, which were dynamically related and constantly interactive, operated in a universe suffused with different kinds of *qi* 氣 (variously translated as life breath, ether, energy, pneuma, vital essence, material force, primordial substance, etc.) – the stuff of which all things, visible and invisible, were constituted. Taken together, these concepts became virtually indispensable in late Zhou, Qin, and Han discourses of all sorts – from philosophy, religion, psychology, divination, food, and medicine to art, music, ritual, law and military affairs.

B. Divination in early Imperial China (c. 221 BCE – c. 960 CE)

Correlative cosmology reached maturity in the Han dynasty (206–220 CE) (Csikszentmihalyi 2000; Pankenier 2013; A. Wang 2000; R. Wang 2012). During the reign of Emperor Wu (141–89 BCE), the *Zhouyi* – now amplified by a number of commentaries known collectively as the "Ten Wings" (*shiyi* 十翼), had become a bona fide Confucian classic, often referred to from that point onward as the *Yijing* 易經 (Classic of changes). Together, the Ten Wings transformed the *Changes* into a document of correlative cosmology par excellence (R. Smith 2008b: 57–88).

Trigrams, for example, came to be known not only by their primary attributes, but also by new associations involving different family relationships, animals, directions of the compass, seasons, parts of the day, parts of the body, social roles, numbers, and colours. Meanwhile, other "wings" helped to explain the cryptic *tuan* and line readings of the basic text, and, through the use of colorful analogies, metaphors and other forms of visual imagery, they elucidated the structure and significance of the hexagrams in terms of their individual lines and constituent trigrams – as well as their relationship to other hexagrams and natural phenomena. In short, the Ten Wings clarified and amplified the symbolism of the *Changes*, suffusing the *Yijing* with Confucian ethical judgments, and articulating its fundamental principles, including the idea of *yinyang* complementarity and the unity and interaction of the "three cosmic powers" (*sancai* 三才): Heaven, Earth, and Man.

In addition to giving rise to a great many new interpretive approaches to the *Changes* (see R. Smith 2008b: 57–88), the Han period also witnessed the emergence of a number of derivative works. Some were simple prognostication texts (*chenwei* 讖緯, *chenyao* 讖謠, etc.), designed primarily for "determining good or bad fortune". Others, in the tradition of Han apocrypha (*weishu* 緯書), sought to explain and amplify the numerology and trigram correspondences of the *Yijing*, and to link them with popular astrology. An anonymous work titled *Yiwei Qianzuodu* 易緯乾鑿度 (Apocryphal treatise on the *Changes*: a penetration of

the laws of Qian), provides a good example of such a compilation (see Nielsen 2009–10, 2017). Still other Han works were elaborate "imitations" of the *Yijing* – notably Jiao Yanshou's 焦延壽 (c. 70–10 BCE) *Jiaoshi Yilin* 焦氏易林 (Forest of *Changes* of Mr. Jiao), Yang Xiong's 揚雄 (53 BCE – 18 CE) *Taixuan jing* 太玄經 (Classic of great mystery) and Wei Boyang's 韋伯揚 (fl c. 140 CE) Daoist-oriented *Zhouyi cantong ji* 周易參同契 (Token for the agreement of the three according to the *Zhou Changes*).

Although most imitations of the *Yijing* employed trigrams and hexagrams, the *Taixuan jing* was based on eighty-one "tetragrams" (*shou* 首) with a total of 729 lines, each with various commentaries patterned loosely on the line statements and the Ten Wings of the *Changes*. Yang also invented a method of milfoil divination for the work in which the manipulation of thirty-three stalks provided three possibilities for each line. In Yang's scheme, an unbroken line (like a *yang* line in the *Yijing*) represented Heaven; a line broken once (like a *yin* line in the *Changes*) represented Earth; and a line broken twice represented Man. For hundreds of years after its creation, the *Taixuan jing*, like the Han apocrypha, served the interests of diviners, but after the Song dynasty both diminished greatly in importance, never to fully recover. (Nylan 1993; Zheng Wan'geng 1989)

The wide circulation of Han divination texts of the sort described above attests to the growing appeal of fortune telling at all levels of Chinese society. Occult specialists (*fangshi* 方士), who had emerged as a distinct occupational class in the late Zhou period, proliferated in the Han, attracted by the prospect of obtaining wealth, eminence and power by virtue of their ability to tell the future, heal illnesses, and/or restore cosmic harmony by magical means. So influential were these specialists that from Han times onward, every official dynastic history, as well as many local gazetteers and other official sources, contained special sections devoted to biographies of *fangshi*, usually called "technicians" (*fangji* 方技). (Kalinowski 2004, 2009).

Experts in divination were especially valuable to the throne, since imperial legitimacy depended to such a significant degree on the correct interpretation of heavenly signs, the creation of an accurate state calendar based on astronomical and astrological calculations, and the determination of auspicious days and times for royal and official ceremonies as well as for empire-wide rituals, festivals, and other activities. From the government's standpoint, the more predictable life was, the better. At the popular level, too, predictability was a virtue. For this reason, the use of almanacs that indicated days that were auspicious (*ji* 吉) or inauspicious (*xiong* 凶) for various rituals and more mundane activities became ever more widespread (for details, see Harper and Kalinowski 2017).

The fall of the Han dynasty in 220 CE brought an extended period of division in China known as the Six Dynasties (220–589 CE). One of the most important developments during this period was the rapid spread of Buddhism, and the inspiration it provided for the rise of another institutionalized form of religion based on Daoism (known as *Daojiao* 道教) (R. Smith 2015: 251–62). The Religious Daoist worship of personified forces of nature, which included not only heavenly bodies such as stars and asterisms, but also deified individuals such as Laozi, was designed primarily to tap the vast energy of the cosmos, and to direct it toward the eradication of sickness and disaster and the achievement of longevity and immortality. Naturally it fit well with inherited Chinese divinatory practices of nearly all kinds (Kalinowski 1990, 2005, 2003).

Buddhists and Religious Daoists saw fate (*ming* 命) primarily as a consequence of one's thoughts and deeds in past and/or present lives. Confucians, however, acknowledged that rewards did not always come to the virtuous nor was evil always punished, but they relentlessly stressed the need for moral behaviour regardless of the circumstances. Matters such as sickness and health, life and death, poverty and prosperity, seemed ordained by Heaven and beyond human control, but other things were not. To Confucians, the important point was to know what could be known and to do what could be done. "Knowing fate" (*zhiming* 知命) in the standard Confucian view, involved making the best of a situation by devising an appropriate moral strategy for dealing with it, thus "establishing fate" (*liming* 立命) (Li Xinlin 2011; Lupke 2005; Raphals 2014).

Throughout the Six Dynasties period and thereafter, despite criticism from their superiors, we find a number of Buddhist and Daoist clerics, as well as lay adherents, who were experts in the mantic techniques described earlier, from astrology, oracle bones, milfoil manipulations, and the selection of auspicious days

and times, to geomancy, physiognomy, and various numerical calculations. But *fangshi* and other divination specialists retained their prominent place in Chinese society, serving the state and the public (De Woskin 1983; Ngo 1976; Kalinowski 1991, 2003, 2004).

Geomancy in particular came into its own during the Six Dynasties era, thanks to a pair of well-known diviners: Guan Lu 管輅 (210–256) and Guo Pu 郭璞 (276–324). Guan Lu was celebrated not only for his skill as a *fengshui* specialist, but also for his effective use of oracle bones, milfoil divination, astrology, physiognomy, and meteorology – in particular the interpretation of "wind angles" (*fengjiao* 風角). He was also famous for his influential theories on "fate calculation" (*tuiming* 推命, *tuisuan* 推算, *tuibu* 推步), sometimes known as "emolument fate" (*luming* 祿命), which placed special emphasis on the numerological and astrological variables associated with the year, month and day of a person's birth. Guo Pu, for his part, was not only a famous classical scholar, but also the putative author of an extraordinarily important geomantic text known as the *Zangshu* 葬書 (Book of burials), still used by Chinese geomancers to this day (De Woskin 1983; Ngo 1976).

Unity was restored to China under the Sui dynasty (581–618) and its successor, the Tang (618–907). Calendrical science, undertaken during the Tang with the help of foreign (especially Indian) astronomers and foreign astronomical texts, became ever more precise, and ever more carefully guarded as a sphere of imperial responsibility and control (Smith 2017). Fate calculation enjoyed unprecedented popularity during the Tang, championed by Li Xuzhong 李虛中 (fl. c. 790–835). Li built on the theoretical foundations established by Guan Lu and Xiao Ji to become the most illustrious exponent of fate extrapolation in the Tang. His highly influential *Mingshu* 命書 (Book of Fate), still extant, emphasized the day of birth as the most important single factor in determining one's destiny (Chen Jiujin 2007; Li Shenglong 1993).

Tang divination techniques not only became ever more sophistication over time; they also spread across space – as far west as the city of Dunhuang in present-day Gansu province. Evidence can be found in a pioneering book titled *Divination et sociéte dans la Chine médiévale: Un étude des manuscrits de Dunhuang de la Bibliotheque nationale de France et de la British Library* (2003). This impressive work catalogues some divinatory 250 items in a way consonant with traditional Chinese bibliographical categories, but it also does a great deal more. Its various authors show, for example, how diviners operated at the lower levels of Chinese government in this remote area, and how local traditions of divination differed from those operating in the metropolitan bureaucracy and imperial court. These authors also explore the ways divinatory theories and practices were transmitted at the local level and how mantic traditions intersected with institutional Buddhism and Religious Daoism (Kalinowski 2013).

C. Divination in late Imperial China (960–1912)

The Song dynasty (960–1279) is justly famous for a tremendous surge of intellectual creativity, provoked in part by dramatic economic changes and the rapid spread of printing, a Tang invention. The Song period is especially well known for a tremendous outpouring of creative scholarship on the *Yijing* by such diverse "neo-Confucian" authors as Chen Tuan 陳摶 (872–989), Shao Yong 邵雍 (1011–1077), Zhou Dunyi 周惇頤 (1017–1073), Zhang Zai 張載 (1020–1077), Cheng Hao 程顥 (1032–1085), Cheng Yi 程頤 (1033–1107), Su Shi 蘇軾 (1037–1101), and Zhu Xi 朱熹 (1130–1200) (K. Smith et al. 2014; R. Smith 2008b, esp. 112–38).

At the same time, a number of other Song scholars and mantic practitioners explored and/or refined long-standing techniques of astrology, geomancy and numerology (H. Liao 2005; Liu Xiangguang 2013; Nickerson 1994). In the closely related realms of astrology and numerology, for example, we see a burst of interest in the sophisticated arts of prediction known as *dunjia* 遁甲 ("evasive stems"), *liuren* 六壬 ("six waters;" aka *Taiyi liuren* 太乙六壬), and *qimen* 奇門 ("wonderous gates" aka *qimen dunjia* 奇門遁甲). (For details on these and related techniques, see P.Y. Ho 2003.) Similarly, a new school of siting emerged and

flourished during the Song, based on the invention of a sophisticated geomantic compass, the *luopan* 羅盤 (Feuchtwang 2002).

In the tenth century, a Chinese diviner named Xu Ziping 徐子平 developed a highly influential system of fate calculation that took into account not only the year, month, and day of birth, but also the hour. These "four pillars" (*sizhu* 四柱), each designated by two characters, came to be known as a person's "eight characters" (*bazi* 八字) – a common term in Chinese divination to this day. This refinement, together with the addition of certain variables derived from popular astrology and the notion of decennial periods of fate (*yun* 運), produced a system, still in widespread use, that has close connections to foreign-influenced forms of fate calculation such as *ziwei doushu* 紫微斗數 (astrological numbers), which exists in both ancient and modern forms (see P.Y. Ho 2003, esp. 69–82, 139–64).

Meanwhile, a heightened awareness of the Chinese written language through the medium of printing seems to have been at least partially responsible for the popularity of a form of divination known as "dissecting" or "fathoming" characters (*chaizi* 拆字 or *cezi* 測字), identified closely with the eleventh-century savant Xie Shi 謝石 (Yang and Song 1992; Song and Yang 2004; Vance 2017). Printing also contributed to the mass production of popular almanacs and the widespread appeal of divination by "spiritual sticks" (*lingqian* 靈籤; also 靈簽), which, like many fortune-telling techniques in the late imperial era, came to be practised in or near Buddhist, Daoist and other religious temples (Strickman 2005; Wang Bugui 1993).

Yet another enduring innovation in Chinese divination dating from the Tang–Song period was "spirit-writing" (*fuji* 扶箕 or *fuluan* 扶鸞), a practice in which "possessed" images, objects, and individuals conveyed messages about the present and future. Early spirit possession in China did not generally involve literacy, but by the eleventh century CE it had come to be associated closely with the scholarly elite. Over time, the *fuji* tradition merged with the "morality book" (*shanshu* 善書) and "precious scroll" (*baojuan* 寶卷) traditions of popular religion, with the result that entire volumes came to be written by deities on ethical themes (Clart 1996, 1997, 2003). Similarly, the ancient practice of dream divination rose in popularity with the distribution of various printed manuals and reference works. (Lin 1995).

Throughout the Yuan dynasty (1271–1368), few significant changes took place in either the theory or the practice of Chinese divination. All of the mantic techniques previously discussed were regularly employed at various levels of society by official diviners, professional fortune tellers, Buddhist and Daoist clerics, and shamans, both male and female. The Yuan state drew upon Mongol and other non-Chinese traditions in its divinatory and calendrical affairs and used an Arabic calendar from 1267 to 1281. It also patronized Tibetan lamaism, which provided its own rich store of divining lore (R. Smith 2012: 160–6).

The establishment of the Ming dynasty in 1368 brought a reassertion of native Chinese rule, but the syncretic spirit of the Yuan remained, and in fact intensified. The first emperor, Zhu Yuanzhang (Ming Taizu, r. 1368–1398), placed special faith in Daoism as a faith, and in divination as a means of receiving spiritual and practical guidance. Most of his successors held similar views. As a result of imperial patronage, the "occult arts" and the beliefs of Religious Daoism were "never more powerful or pervasive among all social strata than during the Ming" (T. Liu 1971, esp. 70 ff.; also T. Liu 175, 108 ff.).

Western missionary accounts of the late Ming period attest to the nearly universal prevalence of astrology and other forms of divination in China. Matteo Ricci (1552–1610), the pioneering Jesuit scientist and official Ming court astronomer, wrote, for example, of the deeply-held conviction among his colleagues in the Board of Astronomy that "everything happening on this terrestrial globe of ours depends on the stars". He also remarked disparagingly on the common practice of choosing auspicious and inauspicious days (*zeri*) for various activities and events, manifest in a variety of ways, including the daily stipulations of both state calendars and popular almanacs (R. Smith 1991: 45).

Written records from the Qing dynasty (1636–1912), both in Chinese and in Western languages, are especially rich in materials related to divination as practised by emperors, officials, scholars, and commoners.[7] Let us now take a brief look at some of the most prevalent mantic systems that were practised at that time.

III. Divination in Qing times

A. Astrology, numerology and fate extrapolation

Individual "horoscopes" assumed a variety of forms in Qing dynasty China. Some looked like dodecagonal "spider-webs," above which rested a group of squares and rectangles with information regarding the sex and status of the subject of the horoscope, the cyclical characters of his or her birth (see below), general indications of happiness (*xi* 喜) and misfortune (*ji* 忌), as well as several dozen specific "star spirits" identified with one of the five "agents," the sun or the moon, or one of four malevolent influences linked to the planets Mars, Saturn, Venus and Mercury (R. Smith 1991: 173–87; Li Shenglong 1993).

Other horoscopes had different shapes – octagonal, rectangular or circular – but they all took into account the same basic set of cosmic variables – including *yin* and *yang*, the five agents, the ten heavenly stems, the twelve earthly branches, and various other astrological and/or calendrical markers (Yuan Shushan 1919, 1928, 1947, n.d.). During the Qing, and in fact well before, most exponents of fate calculation employed the Ziping system, based on the year, month, day, and hour of a person's birth (i.e., the "four pillars" or "eight characters"). They often compared these "four pillars" metaphorically to a plant, in which the year was the root, the month was the sprout, the day was the flower, and the hour was the fruit. Thus, the first two decades of one's life were subsumed under the year, the next two under the month, and so on (for details see Mr. Chao Li's chapter in this book; also R. Smith 1991: 174–87).

The divinatory techniques known as *dunjia*, *liuren* and *qimen*, briefly discussed earlier, were closely linked to the correlative logic, cosmological variables (especially stems and branches) and numerical symbolism of fate extrapolation. However, they were usually applied to discrete slices of human experience rather than entire lives (P.Y Ho 2003). Many applications of *dunjia*, *liuren,* and *qimen* techniques were military, especially regarding strategy and tactics (see also below). Among their more general uses were: determining the proper time and place for constructing homes, buildings and gardens; forecasting weather events; predicting success in the examination system; providing guidance for various official and domestic rituals; facilitating farming and silkworm production; capturing escaped slaves and bondservants, apprehending robbers; finding lost objects, generating wealth; and offering advice on travel, litigation, marriage, raising children, etc. (Yates 2005: 34).

As Peng Yoke Ho as shown in his illuminating book, *Chinese Mathematical Astrology* (2003), the elaborate calculations connected with *dunjia*, *liuren,* and *qimen* required a high degree of skill, and often involved the consultation of *Yijing*-related diagrams such as the "nine palaces" (*jiugong tu* 九宮圖), the Luo River Writing (*Luoshu* 洛書), and the Yellow River Chart (*Hetu* 河圖), as well as devices known as "cosmic boards" (*shi* 式). But, as with a great many other Chinese divination systems, they could be simplified. Qing almanacs, for example, describe a *liuren* technique by which even illiterates could determine the proper timing of a given enterprise by counting on their finger joints. Another simple *liuren/qimen dunjia* procedure involved rolling a red ball around a wooden tub until it landed in one of twelve holes marked by the earthly branches. The diviner then combined the selected branch with one of the ten stems and consulted a guidebook for the appropriate reading.

Similarly, complicated horoscopes might be reduced to simple astrological "signs," comparable with, and apparently related to, the zodiac of the Western tradition. In traditional China, each person's birth came to be identified with one of twelve animals correlated with the twelve earthly branches: the rat (branch *zi* 子), ox (*chou* 丑), tiger (*yin* 寅), rabbit (*mao* 卯), dragon (*chen* 辰), snake (*si* 巳), horse (*wu* 午), sheep (*wei* 未), monkey (*shen* 申), rooster (*you* 酉), dog (*xu* 戌), and pig (*hai* 亥). According to popular belief, each of these animals had its own personality or character and was either compatible or incompatible with other animals in terms of marriage and other human relationships. In one scheme, for example, the horse and the ox were bad for each other, as were the sheep and the rat, the rooster and the dog, the tiger and the snake, the rabbit and the dragon, the pig and the monkey.

Another system of fate calculation involved a simple chart titled "Emperor of the Four Seasons" (*Siji huangdi* 四季皇帝), which displayed a figure with a head, body, arms, and legs that bore cyclical characters indicating one of the twelve two-hour segments of the twenty-four-hour day. These characters were explained by fifty-six accompanying verses of five characters each. When a child was born, the parents consulted the appropriate figure for the season in order to discover what the future held for anyone born in any particular two-hour time period. On the whole, a birth time located on the head, hand, shoulder, belly, and groin were fortunate, while one on the leg or foot was less auspicious.

B. Divination by lots

At one level, divination by the casting of lots, also known as cleromancy, was a matter of statistical probabilities. But in China, as in many other parts of the world, cleromantic techniques almost invariably implied some sort of spiritual or supernatural agency. Moreover, as with most other forms of Chinese divination, personal sincerity (*cheng* 誠) and moral rectitude were viewed as factors conducing to favourable outcomes.

It would be impossible in a short chapter such as this to give attention to all or even most of the prominent cleromantic traditions in Qing China. But the following three types are certainly worth at least some attention: First, the ancient and highly venerated *Zhouyi* (aka *Yijing*). Second, works inspired directly by the *Changes* – from the *Jiaoshi Yilin* and the *Taixuan jing* in the Han to the *Lingqi jing* 靈棋經 (The spiritual chess classic), and the *Meihua Yishu* 梅花易數 (Plum blossom numerology of the *Changes*) of later periods. The third genre, involving the use of "spiritual sticks" (*lingqian*), had comparatively little to do with abstract symbols like trigrams and hexagrams, but many authorities linked this form of cleromancy with the *Yijing* nonetheless.

1. The classic of changes

For most of the late imperial era, the elaborate rituals known as "milfoil etiquette" (*shiyi* 筮儀), devised by the great Song dynasty scholar Zhu Xi, were considered orthodox. So were his complicated rules of hexagram interpretation. The process began with the division of fifty milfoil stalks in such a way as to yield odd and even numbers, which were then converted into four types of hexagram lines: solid (*yang* 陽) lines that were considered either at rest (with a numerical value of 7), or in movement (with a numerical value of 9), and broken (*yin* 陰) lines that were considered either at rest (with a numerical value of 8), or in movement (with a numerical value of 6). Interpretation involved a great many variables – including whether lines were moving or at rest and what the relationship of the constituent trigrams of the hexagram might be – all this in addition to careful consideration of the hexagram's name, judgment, and individual line statements (R. Smith 2008b: 16–18, 26–28, 227–32).

But, as with most other forms of Chinese divination, there were shortcuts. Hexagrams could be created quickly with a set of three coins, for example. Moreover, not all of the variables identified by Zhu Xi had to be considered. In fact, many diviners chose to emphasize only one major interpretive variable – for instance, a judgment, a trigram relationship, or individual lines and line statements – at times in rather idiosyncratic ways. The late Qing scholar Chen Maohou 陳懋侯, for example, invariably emphasized the fifth line in each hexagram, while Chen Shirong 陳世鎔, another Qing dynasty scholar, claimed to be able to evaluate three-year segments of time based on paired hexagram lines, two lines for each year (R. Smith 2008b: 228–32).

2. Changes-related derivative works

By Qing times, and in fact well before, the use of *Yijing*-related apocrypha and the *Taixuan jing* for divination, like oracle bone divination, had waned almost completely. The *Jiaoshi Yilin*, however, continued to be

employed. For each of the hexagrams of the *Yilin*, which appear in the received order of the *Changes*, there are sixty-four interpretive possibilities – one based on a hexagram's relationship with itself (e.g. "the Qian of Qian [#1]" 乾) and one with each of the other sixty-three hexagrams (the Kun [#2] of Qian 坤之乾, the Chun [#3] of Qian 屯之乾, etc.). There are thus 4,096 predictive possibilities (64 × 64) in the *Yilin*. Most of the verses are four characters in length, and they generally appear in sets of four, although a number of predictions in the received version consist of as few as twelve characters altogether and some have as many as thirty-two.

Divination with the *Yilin* involved the selection of a hexagram by one or another standard method (usually milfoil stalks or coins but sometimes trigram images drawn from nature), followed by the choice of a text appropriate to the time of the divination. Thus, if one selected the hexagram Gou 姤 (#44) during a period marked by the hexagram Kui 睽 (#38), the Kui set of verses would be consulted, and the appropriate reading would be found in the verse pertaining specifically to Gou. Although much of the work's imagery is naturalistic, many verses deal primarily with human affairs, sometimes expressed as historical and classical allusions. The tone of the work is often moralistic, emphasizing Confucian virtues (Gait 2016).

According to the preface of one well-known edition of the *Lingqi jing*, "The *Lingqi* [*jing*] was made to imitate the *Changes* . . . [because] the Way of the *Changes* is abstruse and difficult to understand". In other words, the *Lingqi jing* was designed to make at least some of the mantic content of the *Yijing* more readily accessible. As with the *Yijing*, divination with the *Lingqi jing* generally involved elaborate preliminary rituals, including fasting, bathing, the burning of incense, and a petitionary prayer. But its procedures for divining were far more straightforward.

Twelve wooden discs ("chess pieces") are used in *Lingqi* divination, each of which has an inscribed side and one that is uninscribed. Four of these pieces bear the character for *shang* 上 (upper), four have *zhong* 中 (middle), and four have *xia* 下 (lower); these three types of pieces correspond respectively to Heaven (and the ruler), Man (and officials), and Earth (and the common folk). When thrown together, they yield a total of 125 divinatory possibilities, each of which corresponds to a set of written texts connected with images (*xiang* 象), trigrams, directions, and hexagrams (Zhang Yongfang 1993; Sawyer 2004).

The divinatory system known as *Meihua Yishu* 梅花易數 (Plum blossom numerology of the *Changes*) is generally associated with the great Song dynasty philosopher Shao Yong. This particular approach to the *Changes* required neither stalks nor coins – only mental manipulations of one sort or another. One common method consisted of creating an upper primary trigram by assigning numerical value to a given situation or problem according to the numbers of the "Former Heaven" (Xian Tian 先天) sequence of the *Yijing*, and then choosing the lower primary trigram on the basis of numerical values associated with the year, month, day, and hour in question. Related methods included basing both of the constituent trigrams on different aspects of a situation or problem and composing the two trigrams on the basis of time variables alone. In these and most other popular forms of divination, trigram correlations and five agents correlations played significant roles. (Shao Yong 2003)

3. Spiritual sticks

The pervasiveness of *qian* divination in Qing times, which extended to all areas of the empire, including Tibet, gave rise to the cliché, "If anything happens, seek [advice from] *qian* slips" (*you shiqing qiuqian* 有事情求籤) [94]. Qian divination tended to be undertaken primarily by unlettered women – for whom trips to religious temples, where *qian* could invariably be found, constituted one of the few forms of non-domestic recreation available to them. But members of the literate elite also resorted to spiritual sticks (R. Smith 1991: 235–42; on women and divination, see R. Smith 1992b).

Spiritual sticks came in sets that varied in number from twenty to more than 100. Sets of fifty, sixty-four, and 100 seem to have been most popular in Qing times, as they are today. The sticks, each about twelve to eighteen inches in length and numbered consecutively, were contained together in a bamboo tube. When

a person (let us presume a woman) was ready to divine, she would burn incense, supplicate the god of her choice in a reverential spirit, and shake the container until a single bamboo stick emerged further than the others. After the spiritual stick had been selected, the petitioner determined with divining blocks (jiao 珓; also *jiaobei* 珓杯 or *beijiao* 杯珓) whether it was an appropriate one.

C. Dream interpretation

The interpretation of dreams has been a prominent feature of Chinese divination since the Shang dynasty, and by the Qing period it was highly refined in both theory and practice (see Chen Meiying 1995; Huang Yilong 1998; Liu Wenying 2000; Strassberg 2008; Yao Weijun 1994). Among the most popular dream works in late imperial times were the *Mengzhan yizhi* 夢占逸旨 (Guidelines for dream divination; 1562) and the *Menglin xuanjie* 夢林玄解 (An explication of the profundities in the forest of dreams; 1636). One common approach to dream divination was to "pray for dreams" (*qimeng* 祈夢) in religious temples and other sacred sites, where supplicants spent the night in hopes of receiving clues to the future. In some cases, the supplicants used divining blocks (see below) to attest to the authenticity of the message. The well-known work *Qingbai leichao* 清稗類鈔 (Classified anecdotes from the Qing) contains a number of anecdotes that focus on temple dreams, many of which involved high-ranking scholars and officials (QBLC, *mixin* 迷信, 75, 79, 86, 87, 89, 95, 96, 106, 119, 120).

Another approach, discussed at length in the *Mengzhan yizhi* and the *Menglin xuanjie*, was to submit dreams to word analysis (Strassberg 2008, Vance 2017). One example from the *Qingbai leichao* should suffice. Zhang Ying 張英 (1637–1708), a well known and highly regarded scholar, went to the Guandi temple (關帝廟) outside the city gates of Beijing in order to seek dream-inspired information about his prospects for having sons, since at the time he had none. In this dream, Guandi gave Zhang a bamboo pole (*gan* 竿) that had no leaves or branches. Zhang was quite disappointed, since the lack of any offshoots seemed to indicate no progeny. But a dream interpreter explained that the meaning of this episode was in fact quite propitious. The bamboo (*zhu* 竹) at the top of the pole represented two sons, he said, for when the character *zhu* was "split" according to the methods of word analysis, it yielded two *ge* (个), numeratives of sons (ge nanzi 个男子) in this particular instance.

Yet a third approach, well-suited to commoners, was to consult a chart titled *Zhougong jiemeng* 周公解夢 (The Duke of Zhou's interpretation of dreams). These charts were commonly found in popular almanacs and encyclopedias, and usually consisted of about a half dozen categories of dreams (heavenly patterns, earthly configurations, spirits, the body, sorrow and joy, hitting and cursing, etc.). Within each category there were a dozen or more descriptions of specific dreams, each explained by seven-word sentences. The most elaborate versions of these charts, like the *Zhougong jiemeng quanshu* 周公解夢全書 (Comprehensive [edition of] the *Duke of Zhou's Interpretation of Dreams*; c. 1700) were published separately, and might be divided into nearly thirty categories with almost one thousand individual seven-word explanations (for details, see R. Smith 1991: 245–57).

D. Geomancy

A heightened attunement to physical forms (*xing* 形) and symbolic images (*xiang* 象), whether perceived in the sky, on earth, in writing or even in the shape of everyday objects, influenced many Chinese divination techniques, including geomancy, or "siting" – the art of selecting auspicious locations for tombs, houses, and other structures. The best-known modern term for the practice in Chinese is *fengshui* 風水 (lit. "wind and water"), but advocates in late imperial times generally favoured names with an older and more distinguished pedigree, such as *kanyu* 堪輿 (lit. "cover and support"). Regardless of the term used, geomancy was an extraordinarily important feature of life in late imperial China, with official practitioners at every level of government, and professional experts in every stratum of society (for overviews, see Bruun 2008;

Feuchtwang 2002; Harper 1999b; R. Smith 1991: 131–71 and esp. R. Smith 2019; see also Wang Yude 1994a, 1994b).

As with traditional Chinese medicine, geomancy was concerned with maintaining a harmonious *yin-yang* equilibrium in the midst of constant change. A given location, like the human body, represented a microcosm of the universe, which naturally required a balance of cosmic energy or *qi* for proper functioning. The primary focus of geomancy in China was on the deceased. Specialists in "tomb divination" (*yinzhai* 陰宅; *xiangmu* 相墓 or *zhanmu* 占墓) were ubiquitous. Sanction for a concern with the proper place and time for burials may be found in several Confucian classics, including the *Xiaojing* 孝經 (Classic of filial piety): "[The filial son] determines the burial place [of his parents] by divination and puts them to rest" (*bu qi zhaizhao er ancuo zhi* 卜其宅兆而安厝之).

By late imperial times there were two main schools of *fengshui*. One, known generally as the Fujian School (福建派), was identified with the theory of "directions and positions" (*fangwei lun* 方位論), also known as the theory of "principles and energy" (*liqi lun* 理氣論). Its focus was primarily on cosmological variables and use of the geomantic compass. The other, widely designated the Jiangxi School (江西派), was generally identified with the theory of "forms and configurations" (*xingshi* 形勢論). Its focus was primarily on landforms. Over time, a great many sub-schools developed, including the well-known Eight Halls Bright Mirror (八宅明鏡) School, also known as the Nine-Star Auspice 九星命理) School. This approach to *fengshui* placed primary emphasis on *Yijing*-style trigram symbolism and was extremely popular in Qing times.

But lines drawn sharply in theory tended to blur in practice, even among sub-sects, and exponents of geomancy in the Qing period drew freely upon the vocabulary and techniques of both major schools in a characteristic display of Chinese eclecticism. The ultimate aim in all geomantic calculations was to find a site where there was a harmonious conjunction between the forces of *yin* and *yang*, the five agents and other cosmic variables. These variables could be revealed not only by reading a geomantic compass but also by identifying landforms that had auspicious shapes and directional orientations (see the excellent discussion in Feuchtwang 2002: 155–89). Above all, *fengshui* specialists sought to find concentrations of "vital *qi*" (*shengqi* 生氣), in spots identified as "dragon lairs" (*longxue* 龍穴). Significantly, if the cosmological or topographical features of a given site were less than optimal, modifications might be made in the surrounding landscape, such as planting trees, redirecting water, or building "geomantic pagodas" (*fengshui ta* 風水塔).

Not surprisingly, geomantic calculations involving homes and graves often entailed consideration of the "eight characters" of the primary individual(s) involved. These calculations might be undertaken by *fengshui* masters, by specialists in the selection of auspicious days and times (*xuanji* 選吉 or *zeji* 擇吉) or by non-specialists who took into account the stipulations of popular almanacs (see below).

E. Interpretation of written characters

As indicated in the earlier section on dream interpretation, and as will be also apparent in the following sections on prophetic texts and spirit-writing, the practice of "fathoming words/characters/graphs" (*cezi* 測字), also known as glyphomancy, had many applications in late imperial China. One reason, as mentioned previously, was an acute cultural attunement to shapes. Another was the unique structure of Chinese characters, most of which had a combination of semantic and phonetic elements (*xingsheng* 形聲; lit. "forms and sounds") that lent themselves particularly well to plays on words, and disaggregation (generally known as "dissecting characters," *chaizi* 拆字 or "breaking characters," *pozi* 破字). For instance, a character like *yan* 燕, (a kind of bird and also a place name) could be divided into four components – grass 艹, north 北, mouth 口 and fire 灬 – which could be used to fashion any number of prophetic narratives.

Qing texts such as *Zichu* 字觸 (Handling characters), *Cezi bizhi* 測字祕旨 (Secret guide to fathoming characters), and *Cezi shifa* 測字十法 (Ten methods of fathoming characters), describe at length various

types of word analysis, including not only the "dissection" of characters, but also visual and aural plays on words, the manipulation of characters by adding or subtracting strokes, relating a character or a component of a character to another character, and so forth. Other glyphomantic texts linked written characters to cosmological variables, including *yin* and *yang*, the five agents, stems and branches, and trigrams and hexagrams (R. Smith 1991: 201–5; for details, see Song Chuanyin and Yang Chang 2004; Zhan Xuzuo and Zhu Liangzhi 1993; Führer 2006).

In most forms of word analysis, clients were asked to write a character themselves, or to choose from a list of possibilities. As one example, let us take the case of Fan Shixing 范時行, a professional fortune-teller from Suzhou who lived during the Qianlong era (r. 1735–96). When a soldier-client selected one of two possible versions of the character for "chess piece" (*qi* 棋 or 碁), Fan first discussed the implications of the man's choice (a version of the character that contained the "wood" 木 semantic indicator (*bushou* 部首) rather than the "stone" 石 semantic indicator). He then went on to interpret the man's past life and future prospects based primarily on the style of play characterizing the two main kinds of Chinese chess – *xiangqi* 象棋 ("elephant chess"), in which pieces are subtracted from the board as the game progresses, and *weiqi* 圍棋 ("surrounding chess"), in which pieces are added over time. Fan's basic conclusion was that the man had suffered the loss of a close family member in the past (the *xiangqi* metaphor), and that in the future he would have to proceed gradually and cautiously, a step at a time (the *weiqi* metaphor) (Yuan Shushan 1948: 8, 26–27).

F. Meteorological divination

As with astrology, geomancy, and word analysis, meteorological divination, known generally as *zhanhou* (占候), involved shapes, images and cosmological variables. According to popular works such as the *Xiangyu shu* 相雨書 (Book on observing rain), the *Yunqi zhanhou* 雲氣占侯 (Divination by cloud vapors), and *Tianwen zhanyan* 天文占驗 (Predictions based on heavenly patterns), *zhanhou* exponents relied not only on the direct observation of natural phenomena (the sun, the moon, the planets, stars, comets, clouds, lightning, rain, rainbows, mists, the behaviour of animals and so forth), but also on five agents and stem-branch configurations and correlations, and the interpretation of trigrams and hexagrams. Furthermore, the category *zhanhou* included a number of non-visual nature-related divination methods, such as the analysis of thunder and the sound of wind (*fengjiao* 風角; lit. "wind corners") (R. Smith, 173–4, 187–8, 201–4; Yates 2005: 22–23).

Quite naturally, meteorological divination, like *dunjia*, *liuren* and *qimen* techniques, was often connected with the military divination (*bingzhan* 兵占). Chinese military leaders not only made prayers and sacrifices to propitiate various deities, they also made predictions based on the shapes, colours and behaviour of natural phenomena (indicating how, where and when to fight), organized their camps and formations according to the patterns of the stars, decorated their flags with astrological symbols – including the images of astral deities and the eight trigrams – and employed five agents symbolism in the colouring of their flags and the uniforms of their soldiers (Yates 2005, esp. 33).

G. Physiognomy

Since many Chinese considered the human body to be a microcosm of nature, it is hardly surprising that physiognomy – the "reading" of body parts, especially faces and hands – offered insights into the fate of individuals. The Ming dynasty compilation titled *Shenxiang quanbian* 神相全編 (Complete guide to spiritual observation) remains to this day the single most important Chinese reference work for "body divination". In some respects, it looks and reads like an enormous *fengshui* manual, a "geomancy of the person," so to speak. Like works from the Jiangxi School, the *Shenxiang quanbian* reflects a preoccupation with physical forms and features. It identifies several dozen different body types, and all manner of individual

parts – nearly forty kinds of eyes, thirty kinds of eyebrows, twenty-four kinds of noses, and so on. The logic of interpretation involved visual cues ("a thick hand with a soft red palm without wrinkles is a sign of much good fortune"), as well as various numerical categories, cosmological correlations (*yin* and *yang*, the five agents, trigrams and hexagrams, stems and branches, and so forth) (for details, see Kohn 1986; Shen Zhian 1995; R. Smith 1991, esp. 187–201; Weng Naijian 1993; Xiao Ai 1996).

One system of interpretation involved linking body types with five agents correlations such as the "Five Constant Virtues," *wuchang* 五常 of Confucianism; another linked body types with the twelve animals of the Chinese zodiac. Yet another, known as "yearly fortune" (*liunian yunqi* 流年運氣), provided a "facial horoscope," analogous to the charts of fate extrapolators. It correlated parts of the face with phases of life up to the age of ninety-nine, each marked by one of the twelve earthly branches. And, of course, in practice, physiognomers employed a wide variety of individualized techniques. Li Xuan 李璇, a colonel in the Green Standard army, reportedly required only one look at a person to decide his or her fate. Li Liuming 李六名, apparently a professional, told fortunes with remarkable accuracy based solely on a client's complexion. Liu Lu 劉璐, a scholar, used both "appearance and speech" (*rongmao yanyu* 容貌言語) to determine whether a person would be rich or poor, lucky or unlucky, long-lived or not. Liao Chunshan 廖春山, an examination failure, compiled a book in the early 1860's titled *Xingshen xiangfa* 形神相法 (Methods of evaluating shape and spirit), which argued that physiognomy required attention to the inner spirit as well as the outer form of a person (R. Smith 1991: 200–1).

One other point should be made about physiognomy: Regardless of the specific divinatory methods employed, the stereotypical descriptions and images of "good" and "bad" faces that appear in works such as the *Shenxiang quanbian*, their equivalents in popular almanacs and simple divination handbooks, and the illustrations that adorned the stalls of fortune tellers unquestionably influenced the way people responded to one another in their daily interactions. There is also a great deal of evidence to indicate that bureaucratic hiring practices involved evaluations in which physiognomy (and sometimes professional physiognomers) played a part (R. Smith 1991: 199–200).

H. Prophetic texts

From the Han period onward, prophetic documents have played a significant role in Chinese politics, sometimes in the service of the dynasty and sometimes in opposition (Strickmann 2005; Wang Bugui 1993; Xie Guian 1998). Most such documents relied heavily on word play of the sort associated with the dissection of characters, and by the Qing dynasty there were a number that seemed to pass judgment on the ruling Manchus. One, the "Eternal Song of the Universe" (*Qiankun wannian ge* 乾坤萬年歌), appeared to contain oblique references to the rebellion of Li Zicheng that toppled the Ming dynasty and allowed the Manchus to invade and rule China for more than 200 years. Another, based on Zhuge Liang's "Before the Horse" (*maqian ke* 馬前課) method of divination, predicted the founding of the Qing by foreign invaders from an analysis of lines that included the characters for "water, month, and ruler" (shui yue-zhu 氵月 主), which together formed the word Qing 清, and the characters "ancient and month" (gu yue 古 月), which together formed the word "barbarian" (*hu* 胡; i.e., the Manchus).

Shao Yong's "Plum Blossom Poems" (Meihua shi 梅花詩) also proved to be a popular source of prophetic wisdom in the Qing. Of the ten poems in this collection, one in particular seemed to apply to the reigning dynasty. It read:

> The barbarians rode by horseback into Chang'an,
> Opening the Central Plain up to the borders [關] of the sea.
> The vast [洪] waters receded and then rose up again,
> And the pure light could readily be seen in the midst of the Han 漢.

According to the interpretation offered in the *Qingbai leichao* (清稗類鈔), this poem refers to (1) the Manchu invasion of China, specifically, through the strategic pass of the Great Wall on the coast known as Shanhai guan 山海關; (2) the tumultuous Taiping Rebellion under Hong Xiuquan 洪秀全 ("Hong" 洪 can mean "vast"); and (4) the fall of the Qing dynasty after a revolutionary uprising of Wuchang (Wuhan 武漢) led by a Han 漢 Chinese (Xu Ke 1928, *fangji* 方技, 3–4 and *mixin* 迷信 46).

Perhaps the most famous book of political prophecy in Qing times was the *Tuibei tu* 推背圖 (Chart of extrapolation from the back), attributed to the famous diviners Li Chunfeng 李淳風 (602–670) and Yuan Tiangang 袁天罡 (?-627) of the Tang dynasty. Although officially prohibited, it circulated widely. The work is organized into sixty parts, each indicated by a hexagram. Much of its interpretive logic revolves around the use of stems and branches, and the principles of word analysis discussed above. Most versions were handwritten rather than printed, with a number of inconsistencies in the number and order of verses and illustrations, the number of characters per line, the particular characters used, and the illustrations used. The format, however, was basically the same (for an overview and analysis, see R. Smith 1991: 216–18).

During the 1880s, other prophetic documents were unearthed which, in cryptic passages decipherable only through word analysis, conveyed messages about the future. The most famous "discovery" of this sort was the so-called Baked Pastry Song (Shaobing ge 燒餅歌), attributed to the famous scholar diviner Liu Bowen 劉伯溫 (aka Liu Ji 劉基; 1311–1375). Although undoubtedly written in the late Qing dynasty and amplified after its fall, this document purports to record an intimate conversation between Liu and the first Ming emperor, chronicling in obscure language the history of the Ming and Qing dynasties. As usual, the names of people and special terms are derived in large measure from word analysis as well as five agents and stem-branch correlations.

I. The selection of auspicious dates and times

Specialists in selecting auspicious dates and times were in great demand in imperial China, because nearly every activity required them, whether sacred imperial rituals at the capital or modest marriage arrangements in isolated villages (on Qing ritual, see R. Smith 2013a: 89–110). As with virtually all forms of Chinese ritual, the key to success was doing the right thing, at the right time, in the right place, facing the right direction. And, of course, taking into account all the relevant cosmological variables. Many specialists in selecting appropriate days and times employed techniques such as *dunjia*, *liuren* and *qimen*; others consulted astrological charts and individual horoscopes; still others relied upon complex calendrical works, geomantic manuals, and ritual handbooks of all kinds (Liu Daochao and Zhou Rongyi 1994; Yuan Shushan 1961a, 1961b). For non-specialists, popular encyclopedias (*riyong leishu* 日用類書) and almanacs (*tongshu* 通書, *rishu* 日書, *huangli* 皇曆, etc.) provided a great deal of practical divinatory advice (R. Smith 2015: 6, 16, 39–40, 214, 267, 345–6, 357–8, 419–23; see also R. Smith 1988, 1992a, 2017).

Official calendars (*shixian li* 時憲曆 or *shixian shu* 時憲書 in Qing times) reflected the state's preoccupation with political legitimacy and the regulation of all activities "under Heaven" (Martzloff 2000; Arrault 2002, 2011). Manchu functionaries received Manchu-language copies of the document; Mongol functionaries, Mongol-language copies; and Han functionaries, Chinese-language copies. Chinese-language copies were also provided to tributary states, notably Korea and Annam (Vietnam), as tangible symbols of imperial sway over these areas. All Qing calendars set forth the number of days in each month and the total number of days in the year. In addition, they inserted intercalary months when necessary (and occasionally by mistake), and provided precise information concerning phases of the moon, the onset of each of the year's twenty-four solar divisions (*jie* 節), and times for sunrise and sunset. Days – identified successively by the names of lodges as well as by the sexegenary system of cyclical characters – were reckoned from midnight to midnight and divided into twelve equal parts (*shi* 時九宮), each denoted by one of the twelve branches.

Each official calendar displayed various charts, including a large, square, colour-coded "diagram of the position of the spirits for the year" (*nianshen fangwei zhi tu* 年神方位之圖) near the front of the book, and

a smaller version at the beginning of each month. These diagrams were marked by trigrams, stems and branches, designed to indicate the relationship of various stars to nine primary compass points. But the core of all state calendars in late imperial times was a month-by-month, day-by-day breakdown of the entire year, indicating the influence of positive and negative star spirits, the five agents and the twenty-four lodges. For every day – with only a few exceptions in any given year – there were a certain number of activities designated appropriate (*yi* 宜; i.e., auspicious) or inappropriate (*buyi* 不宜; inauspicious).

These activities, numbering perhaps 100 in all, ranged from imperial and official responsibilities (various forms of sacrifice and prayer, the submission of documents, the promulgation of edicts, the bestowal of favours and awards, personnel matters, and diplomatic and military affairs, etc.) to more mundane affairs (educational activities, domestic rituals (birth, capping, marriage, burials, etc.), medical treatment, business decisions, bathing and grooming, cutting out clothes, household cleaning and decoration, establishing a new bed, discarding things, moving things, travelling, breaking ground, well-digging, construction and repair, hunting, fishing, trapping, planting, cutting wood, and herding animals) (R. Smith 1991: 74–82; also 1988, 2017, esp. 336–53).

Popular almanacs had similar charts, columns, and categories of quotidian concern, but they were not sanctioned by the throne, and they generally included a great deal more divinatory material and practical advice concerning agriculture, business, health, family life, food, etiquette, travel, and weather. They also included morality tales such as the "Twenty-four Paragons of Filial Piety" (*Ershisi xiao* 二十四孝). The most common mantic systems contained in Qing almanacs, which were usually conveyed by means of charts and rudimentary illustrations as well as brief texts, had to do with protecting children, interpreting dreams, omens and spiritual sticks, geomancy, physiognomy, the "Emperors of the Four Seasons," and various ways of using one's hand(s) for different mantic purposes, from selecting trigrams to *liuren* calculations (R. Smith 1991: 82–91; also R Smith 1992a, 2017, esp. 353–67).

J. Shamanism and spirit-writing

Shamans (individuals who serve as intermediaries between humans and the spirit world), played a significant role in Chinese society for at least 3,000 years (Mun Yong-sŏng 1999). As seers, healers and advisers, spirit mediums fulfilled a variety of individual needs in the Qing period – both social and psychological – overlapping and complementing the responsibilities of physicians and professional fortune tellers in a variety of ways. In Manchuria, at the Qing capital and in the provinces, shamanism was an essential feature of Manchu cultural identity and religious practice. Indeed, in the Forbidden City, the activities of shamans (mainly women) fell under the administrative jurisdiction of the Office of Ceremonial Affairs (see R. Smith 2015, esp. 50–60, 238–48). Elsewhere, among other ethnic "minorities," as well as the Han Chinese majority, shamans performed multiple roles not only as fortune tellers, healers, and advisers but also as exorcists and magicians. They communicated with the dead, undertook local community rituals (including drought prevention ceremonies), and sometimes officiated in religious pilgrimages (Michael 2011; Sutton 2004).

Shamans generally spoke for a local deity, and their pronouncements often had substantial oracular authority. The god in question usually inhabited a small local shrine or resided at the domestic altar of a shaman. At these venues, friends and neighbors, and even gentry and officials, gathered for, among other things, mantic advice – especially regarding questions about health.

The most authoritative oracular pronouncements by spirit mediums in the Qing period were those written down on a divining table or planchette (*jipan* 乩盤) with the blunt end of a two-pronged stick called a *ji* 乩 or *jibi* 乩筆. Spirit-writing altars (*jitan* 乩壇) were generally located either in a religious temple (usually Daoist but sometimes Buddhist), an association hall (*huiguan* 會館, etc.), or a domestic residence. Although the Qing government officially discouraged spirit-writing, it could not curtail the practice, even in urban areas. According to the major Chinese authority, Xu Dishan 許地山, spirit-writing altars could be found in virtually every prefectural and county capital during the Ming – Qing era; and the *Qingbai leichao*

tells us that in one (unnamed) urban centre, two or three thousand petitioners from Hunan, Hubei, Henan and Sichuan converged on a single *huiguan* altar (discussed in Smith 1991: 222–30).

The rituals of spirit-writing varied from place to place and time to time, but they tended to follow certain basic patterns. The planchette was covered with sand, ashes from incense, or some other loose substance that allowed the writing to be revealed. Prior to the actual descent of the spirit, the diviner and his assistants usually provided offerings of food or flowers, candles and incense, wrote charms, and engaged in other ceremonies of purification. The spirit was then "invited" to descend directly into the stick. A question from the petitioner followed. The stick communicated the spirit's "written" answer on the planchette, which was read to a scribe who put it down on paper.

The end product took many different forms. Whether lengthy or brief, the *fuji* revelation characteristically contained ethical advice. Thus, a student might be told that moral development was more important than literary proficiency; and an official might learn that maladministration would result in a shortened life. Some oracular responses were delivered poetically, in two or more lines, often of equal length, while others consisted of a longer prose statement. Still others took the form of a dialogue between the spirit and his interlocutor. Most *fuji* spirits (and diviners) in Qing times were male, although occasionally a female spirit would descend. The spirit's advice might be relatively straightforward or almost hopelessly obscure. Part of the appeal of spirit-writing, at least for the literati, seems clearly to have been its moral aura, its literary emphasis and its elaborate word play (Zeitlin 1998).

A great many *fuji* stories from the Qing period naturally revolved around the examination system. Here is one – the case of an unnamed *juren* degree holder who, prior to the metropolitan examinations of 1688, asked a *fuji* spirit for insight into the main theme. The spirit answered "[I] don't know" (*buzhi* 不知). Incredulous, the scholar wanted to know why he got this response. The spirit replied: "[I] don't know, [I] don't know, and again, [I] don't know" (*buzhi buzhi you buzhi* 不知不知又不知). The scholars who had gathered at the *fuji* altar for the occasion were amused by this response, but they remained unenlightened. Only later did they discover that the three-part examination theme was taken from the last chapter of the *Analects* (20: 3): "Without knowing [*buzhi*] fate it is impossible to be a gentleman; without knowing [*buzhi*] ritual it is impossible to establish [character]; and without knowing [*buzhi*] words, it is impossible to know men" (cited in R. Smith 1991: 229).

IV. A brief conclusion

The remarkable feature of divination in pre-modern China was its pervasiveness at all levels of society, in cities as well as the countryside, and in every corner of the empire. Why did divination last so long and penetrate so deeply into Chinese society? In brief, the most important reason was that it embodied and reflected many of the most fundamental features of traditional Chinese civilization: a common cosmology, common symbols, common myths, common moral concerns, a preoccupation with the written word, and a need for psychological comfort in a world without professional psychologists. The rituals of divination were satisfying and culturally familiar to all clients. Ceremonies such as the burning of incense, which invested divinatory procedures with an explicitly spiritual if not a magical aura, had a truly universal appeal. The use of writing by diviners not only enhanced their social prestige, but it also gave them cosmic leverage, since so many Chinese believed that written words had magical power. Moreover, the close link between divination and traditional Chinese medicine probably contributed to the tenacity of both. Despite the great diversity of medical and mantic theory in late imperial times, doctors and diviners shared many of the same cosmological assumptions about systematic correspondence as well as demonology.

Finally, by summoning up visions of orthodox culture heroes and urging clients to embrace conventional values, fortune tellers of all social classes reinforced the hegemonic literati culture. The Qing government, for its part, reinforced the inherited cosmology and sanctified orthodox mantic practices at all levels. Edicts and other official announcements constantly referred to auspicious and inauspicious dates, times, events and

omens; the state calendar institutionalized divination empire-wide by designating certain days as "appropriate" and "inappropriate" for various activities; and bureaucrats availed of divination in all kinds of civil and military situations. Without fully realizing it, the Qing government was as much in the grip of the future as it was of the past. For the emperor to dispense with divination would be to abandon his cosmological claim to kingship – an abdication of his role as mediator between Heaven and Earth (R. Smith 1991, esp. 49–91).

Notes

1 See Chen Menglei 1726, *yishu* 藝術 47: 5681–7854. The *Tushu jicheng* contains excerpts from a great many books on divination, as well as comments on divining practices from a wide variety of classical, literary, historical, and other sources. It also includes 348 biographical entries for diviners, organized under five major (and overlapping) categories: Oracle Bones and Milfoil Stalks (*Bushi* 卜筮; 112 individuals), Astrology (*Xingming* 星命; 24), Physiognomy (*Xiangshu* 相術; 46), Geomancy (*Kanyu* 堪輿; 115) and Computational Arts (*Shushu* 數術; 51). Of these individuals, the majority are from the Six Dynasties (45), Tang (55), Song (82), and Ming (108). Computational Arts seems to be a catch-all category, containing biographies that reflect not only calendrical and astrological skills, but also the practice of geomancy and divination by means of the *Yijing*, dreams, and even sounds and smells. See Smith (forthcoming a, forthcoming b).

2 Yuan's *Buren zhuan*, organized by provinces and provincial subdivisions, identifies 778 diviners by both name and specialization (twenty or so different techniques), and provides information on a total of well over 3,000 practitioners. Of the smaller sample, over 400 are pre-Qing – most of them, following the general pattern of the *Tushu jicheng*, from the Six Dynasties (68), Tang (58), Song (100) and Ming (164) dynasties. It may be added that these two sources overlap somewhat, and neither is by any means exhaustive. Although Yuan's bibliography includes several hundred local gazetteers, a spot check of the sections on *fangji* 方技 (technicians) in forty or so gazetteers from various parts of China reveals a number of significant omissions. Similarly, the TSJC does not include biographical entries for all diviners mentioned in the *fangji* sections of the dynastic histories. Furthermore, by personal inclination as well as by the nature of their primary sources, both Yuan and the editors of the *Tushu jicheng* ignore certain "unorthodox" types of divination, such as spirit writing (*fuji* 扶箕), and tend to emphasize individuals who exemplify conventional Confucian virtues.

3 For some examples of some Chinese scholarship on divination, see Chen Yongzheng 1991; Chen Yun'gen 1989; Gao Guofan 1999; Gao Huaping and Cao Haidong 1995; Hu Wenhui 2000; Hu Xinsheng 1998; Jin Liangnian 1994; Lao Gen 1999; Li Ling 2006a, 2006b; Li Ling and Liu Lexian 1993; Song Huiqun 2003; Wang Yude 1993; Wei Shaosheng 1992; Xie Lujun 2010; Yu Xiaoqun 1994; Zhang Ronghua 1991; Zhang Rongming 2000; Zhang Yongtang 1992a, 1992b; Zheng Xiaojiang 1993. For additional studies in Asian languages, see R. Smith 2008a and the notes that follow.

4 For a few general studies of Chinese divination in Western languages, see Chemla, Harper and Kalinowski 1999; Field 2008; Kalinowski 2004, 2010; Lackner 2017; Raphals 2013. For many other more specialized studies in Western languages, see R. Smith 2008a and the notes that follow.

5 Much of the material that follows has been drawn and updated from my now out-of-print book, *Fortune-tellers and Philosophers* (Smith 1991). Full documentation for sources that I used prior to 1990 can be found in the endnotes of that work. Most of the notes in this chapter reflect later sources and perspectives. See also Smith 2008, Smith 2018, Smith 2019, Smith forthcoming a and Smith forthcoming b.

6 The literature on the *Changes* is vast. In English, see Adler 2002, 2019; Davis 2012; Field 2015; Hon 2005; Lynn 1994; Nielsen 2003; Rutt 2002; Shaughnessy 2014; Smith 2003, 2006, 2008b, 2009, 2009–10, 2012, 2013b. In Chinese, see, for example, Li Xueqin 1995; Wang Shouqi and Zhang Shanwen 1990; Zhang Qicheng 1996, 2009; Zhang Shanwen 1992; Zhu Bokun 1995.

7 See the Asian and Western language sources cited in R. Smith 1991, 2008a, 2008b. The best overall study of Qing divination in Chinese is Gong Baoli 2009, although many of the sources cited in note 3 above contain at least some material on the Qing. For the astute observations of two longtime Western residents in late Qing China, see Doolittle 1865; Doré 1914–33).

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Note: This reference list includes only works cited in this chapter. For additional relevant works in both Asian and Western languages, see R. Smith, 2008a and 2009; also the Bibliographical Database (on divination) at www.ikgf.uni-erlangen.de/aigaion2/index.php/topics.

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Appendix

Categories	*Specific techniques*
Astrology and numerology	*dunjia* 遁甲 (also *qimen dunjia* 奇門遁甲); *liuren* 六壬 or Taiyi liuren 太乙六壬; *qimen* 奇門or *qimen dunjia* 奇門遁甲); *xingbu* 星卜; *xingming* 星命; *xingzhan* 星占; *zhanxing* 占星
Dream interpretation	*jiemeng* 解夢; *mengzhan* 夢占; *zhanmeng* 占夢
Divination by lots	*bugua* 卜卦; *bushi* 卜筮; *chouqian* 抽籤; *guashu* 卦數; *jiao* 珓 (also *jiaobei* 珓杯and *beijiao* 杯珓); *lingqi* 靈棋; *lingqian* 靈籤 or 靈簽; *meihua Yishu* 梅花易數; *qianbu* 錢卜; *shifa* 筮法; *shigui* 蓍龜; *taixuan* 太玄; *Wen wang ke* 文王課; *Yilin* 易林; *Yizhan* 易占
Fate extrapolation (see also "Astrology and numerology" above)	*bazi* 八字; *shushu* 數術; *sizhu* 四柱; *tuibu* 推步; *tuiming* 推命; *tuisuan* 推算
Geomancy (aka siting)	*fengshui* 風水; *fenye* 分野; *kanyu* 堪輿
Interpreting written characters	*cezi* 測字; *chaizi* 拆字; *xiangzi* 相字
Meterological divination (often connected with military divination, *bingzhan* 兵占)	*fengjiao* 風角; *houqi* 候氣; *wangqi* 望氣; *zhanhou* 占侯
Oracle bones	*jiagu* 甲骨
Physiognomy	*kanming* 看命; *kanren* 看人; *kanxiang* 看相; *kanzhang* 看掌; *xiangshu* 相術
Prophetic texts (oracles)	*chenwei* 讖緯; *chenyao* 讖謠; *meihua shi* 梅花詩; *qiankun wannian ge* 乾坤萬年歌; *shaobing ge* 燒餅歌; *tuibei tu* 推背圖; *weishu* 緯書
Selecting auspicious dates and times	almanacs (*tongshu* 通書, *rishu* 日書, *huangli* 皇曆 etc.); *xuance*選測; *xuanze* 選擇; dingjixiong 定吉凶; *zeri* 擇日
Shamanism and sorcery	*jitong* 乩童 (associated with spirit-writing; see below); *nüwu* 女巫; *wu* 巫; *wupo* 巫婆; *xipo* 覡婆
Spirit-writing	*fuji* 扶乩 (or 扶箕); *fuluan* 扶鸞

17

ROUQUAN – A MYSTERIOUS SCHOOL OF CHINESE MARTIAL ARTS

Devin Tam, Wang Ling, and Zhang Yaoting

Introduction

Chinese Martial Arts is generally known as a physical, mental, and spiritual practice with a history of thousands of years. It includes a series of disciplines which consists of specific systems developed out of the necessity of defending themselves from the harms of nature and attacks of other people. China has a long history of struggles and wars dating back to the tribal era like all other countries. In *A History of Chinese Martial Arts*, Zhang (1997) noted that Chinese martial arts originated from the battles in primitive society and started to take shape in the pre-Qin period when different schools of martial arts came into being. He pointed out that the art of attack and defense should be considered as one of the fundamental characteristics of martial arts.

There are several similar words in Chinese synonymous to martial arts: Kungfu 功夫, Wushu 武術, Wuxue 武學, Wugong 武功, and Wudao 武道, with slightly different meaning but all bearing an indispensable core word: Wu 武. The Chinese character Wu 武 is made up of two parts Zhi 止 and Ge戈 which could be literally translated as stopping the use of weapons or prevention of war. The exact meaning of *Wu* 武 originated from the great Chinese narrative history commentary Zuozhuan which furnished complicated and lively accounts of the Spring and Autumn period. Zuozhuan, King Zhuang of the State Chu said: "Real military accomplishment is the maintenance of peace and order".[1] Accordingly, the real spirit of Chinese Martial Arts is not to fight others or self-defense, but the seeking of peace, in particular inner peace, a mind-body exercise aiming at an uninterrupted tranquility and serenity of the soul.

Ancient Chinese sages like Lao Tsu (or Laozi in pinyin) and Confucius seek ways to end ceaseless conflicts and disputes. Tao Te Ching or Daodejing in pinyin written by the legendary Lao Tsu is exemplary in revealing the origin of the universe, the relationship between human and nature and how to gain power from the universe by finding the right way to maintain the harmony between man and nature. "The common word dao 道 is used as a stand-in for the ineffable source and ground of the universe, which is claimed to precede God or gods. Ziran 自然 (naturalness) is presented for the first time as the highest principle and core value embodied by Dao"(Liu 2015: 26).

Likewise, Confucian upholds relationship between people and nations, with a deep disregard for conflicts and wars. It thus requires a thorough understanding of the universe and human themselves to achieve this ideal. The Greek philosopher Aristotle and ancient religions like Hinduism, Buddhism, and Zoroastrianism share similar a perception towards the world, which in their understanding consists of four basic elements: earth, water, fire, and wind. Similarly, in Taoism, earth is perceived as the element of nature physically

tangible with form and appearance, while water and fire as physically tangible with appearance but without fixed form, and wind as physically intangible and formless. In the same vein, ancient Chinese sages believe that human themselves were also made up of these elements.

Both Confucianism and Taoism have their common roots in two most valuable ancient books: *The Book of Changes* (*I Ching* 易經) and *The Yellow Emperor's Classic of Internal Medicine* 皇帝內經, the former exploring the rule of universe and the reason of changes with sixty-four hexagrams and the concept of yin-yang and potential ways of predicting the changes in relation with human life, with the latter providing insights into the relationship between yin-yang Wuxing 陰陽五行 (Yingyang and Five elements), Qi 氣 and Jingluo 經絡 (the meridian system) and expounding how humans could acclimatize to the Heaven and the Earth, thus achieving the goal of "human and nature as a whole". The philosophical thinking revealed in Tao Te Ching, in particular, is rooted in the theories and insights put forth by the above two books. As a result, an important branch in Taoism is called the Learning of the Yellow Emperor and Lao Tsu 黃老之學, in which yin-yang, the circulation of Qi and the meridian system are all core concepts.

For many Taoists and martial arts practitioners, *The Yellow Emperor's Classic of Internal Medicine* and Tao Te Ching not only provide philosophical learnings about human and universe but most importantly, practical methods of acquiring energy from the universe. Analogically, inside human body we also have earth (bones and flesh), water (hydration status), fire (body temperature), and wind (Qi), the most intangible but crucial element which is deemed as the essence of energy. Five elements are further development on the basis of theory of elements. Drawing an analogy, objects or circumstances which bear apparent similarity in form, shape, colour or sequence of events are considered to be fundamentally related. Accordingly, coupled internal organs were classified into five elements and the theory of five elements is compared with various things like seasons, colour, tastes, emotions, etc. Thorough understanding of human body and its relationship with the universe determines how well one could absorb Qi and maintain life. The recognition of Qi as the essence of energy in human life and the universe could be illustrated by numerous terms in Chinese relating to Qi, for example, yuanqi 元氣 (vital energy), zhenqi真氣 (genuine energy), liqi 力氣 (strength), zhongqi (middle warmer energy), fuqi 福氣 (blessing), and duanqi 斷氣 (death, the ending of energy), evident of the crucial role that Qi played in a human's whole life.

In the view of the Yellow Emperor and Lao Tsu, the fundamental source of energy in the universe generated by Tao is also Qi. As a result, Raphals (2015) noted that:

> Early Daoist texts like Dao Dejing and Zhuangzi maintain health by nurturing life (yangsheng 養生), an area of common ground for Daoist and practitioners of traditional medical arts. . . . Texts on Nourishing Life include methods for absorbing and circulating Qi in the body – for example, breathing and meditation exercises, diet, drugs and sexual techniques . . . in all these texts a sage or numinous person achieves that status[2] through both meta-physical and physical means. This is the focus of Daoist 'Nurturing Life' techniques." . . . In Guanzi, similar views are elaborated in a chapter ". . . titled 'Inner Cultivation' (Nei ye), which describes the cultivation of qi, as well as vital essence (jing 精), and spirit (shen 神). It describes Dao as literally pervading the body or the person of a sage . . . The Zhuangzi clearly identifies qi as the basis of the physical constitution of the body: 'Human birth is caused by gathering together of qi' (22:733). The Zhuangzi also describes harmonizing or taking charge of the six qi".
>
> *(in Liu 2015: 542–3)*

This is a rather comprehensive and focused exposition of the belief of Qi in Taoist tradition. For Kungfu masters or martial arts practitioners, the key to gaining power is to find the right way absorbing Qi from the universe and circulating Qi in the body, thus the gathered Qi could become a powerful weapon to defeat

opponents. However, if an enemy was defeated and severely harmed, hatred and feuding will never end. The revenge continues. Though the highest ideal of martial arts is to Zhige 止戈 (stop fighting), it has remained an inextricable predicament for Chinese Kungfu masters.

Rouquan: origin and development

As discussed in the preceding section, Chinese martial arts are deeply rooted in Taoist (and to a lesser extent Buddhist) philosophy in which Tao is the everlasting and supernatural principles in the earth that could only be attained through Xujing 虛靜 (emptiness and quietness) and Wuwei 無為 (non-action). For the practitioners a thorough understanding of the theories before reaching the higher levels of the art is a prerequisite. The fundamental Kungfu spirit values the martial power but at the same time strives to transcend it to achieve a higher goal of virtue. If the real spirit of martial arts is to stop fight and seek peace, how to achieve this goal is the key problem. In other words, how to defeat the opponents without harming them?

In answering to the question, Rouquan 柔拳 (soft school boxing), a mysterious school of Chinese martial arts exactly observes the aforementioned ideals and principles. In this chapter, Rouquan 柔拳 is a specially coined term for the purpose of disambiguation and clarification, referring to any school of Kungfu which could subdue the opponents without causing body damage. Three major schools of Chinese martial arts fall under this category: Liangyiquan 兩儀拳 (yin-yang two-force boxing), Tanglangquan 螳螂拳 (mantis boxing), and Yingzhaogong 鷹爪功 (eagle claw boxing). They share a common character in aiming at defeating the enemy in a moment by attacking the his or her acupoints. However, the difference lies in distinct attacking methods and techniques. Liangyiquan is renowned for a unique skill called Yiyangzhi 一陽指 (one-finger death touch) which is called dianxue 點穴 (touch the acupoint) while in Tanglangquan it aims at daxue 打穴 (hit the acupoint) and in Yingzhaogong it aims at naxue 拿穴 (grapple the acupoint), all mastering the skills in transforming Qi into the most powerful attacking strength. The opponent will consequently lose the ability to resist and attack without suffering actual body injuries. By this way, the genuine purpose of Wu (stop fighting) is achieved.

Chinese martial arts or Kungfu, an anglicization of gongfu 功夫, meaning "hard-won achievement" was developed to serve primarily as a defense against a one-on-one, hand-to-hand attack from an opponent, originally in the context of military combat, where the opponent may or may not be armed. Ross (2017) provided a comprehensive historical account of Chinese martial arts and dispelled some mythological presentation by pointing out that Chinese fighting arts were once developed from military arts and spread through the civilian population. In his study, particular attention was also paid to the evolution of the concept of using "Qi" in Chinese martial arts. It is generally acknowledged that Chinese martial arts could be classified as two major kinds: waijiaquan 外家拳 (external or hard boxing) and neijiaquan 內家拳 (internal or soft boxing). The most well-known external boxing is Shaolin school, originating from the Shaolin Temple, emphasizing the training of physical strength and brute power. Most of the martial arts found in the West are the "external" or "hard" boxing, encouraging strenuous training, development of strength, and an aggressive nature. As a contrast, "internal" or "soft" boxing is based on the belief of Qi or internal energy, thus requiring physical fitness but not large muscles. By cultivating and harnessing the Qi for eventual martial application, it also utilizes leverage and balance to dissipate or redirect the strength of an attack. Renowned internal boxing include: Wudang school 武當拳 (wuang boxing) which are well presented by Taichi 太極, xinyiquan 形意拳 (form and intention boxing) and baguazhang 八卦掌 (eight diagram palm), and Xiangxingquan 象形拳 (imitative style boxing), which imitates the movements of some animal's preying and self-defense.

We could clearly see that the preceding discussed three schools of Rouquan belong to neijiaquan 內家拳 (internal boxing) as they all observe the ideas in the Book of Changes and follow the traditional learning of the Yellow Emperor and Lao Tsu 黃老之學, taking yin-yang, the cultivation of Qi, and the

meridian system as their theoretical presuppositions. Through strenuous training, practitioners could master the skills of circulating the Qi in the body and eventually transforming it into martial strength by attacking the opponent's acupoint. However, the traditional way of martial arts training was confined to one-on-one teaching and attached too much importance to master-disciple relationship. For thousands of years, knowledge skills and arts have been passed down from generation to generation, father to son, master to disciple in a considerably secretively way. As a result, genuine martial arts knowledge and skills are lost. This is the case with the two schools of Rouquan 柔拳 (soft boxing): Tanglangquan 螳螂拳 (mantis boxing) and Yingzhaogong 鷹爪功 (eagle claw boxing) where the original martial arts of hitting and scratching the opponents' acupoints failed to be handed down to this day.

As a researcher and practitioner in Rouquan, Devin Tam observed that the only surviving school of Rouquan in China is Liangyiquan 兩儀拳 (yin-yang two-force boxing), which is our focus of study in this paper. Liangyiquan that is renowned for the unique skill called Yiyangzhi 一陽指 (one-finger death touch) which overpowers the enemy by touching and hitting the acupoints. The legendary founder was Duan Yinzi 段印子 in the Spring and Autumn Period, then it was passed from generation to generation including the royal family Duan in Dali 大理皇家段氏 in Song and Ming dynasty and Duan Shengtang 段聲堂 who moved from Dali to Henan province in late Qing period (in Duan, Preface). There are several existent families of Liangyiquan such as hanshi liangyiquan 韓氏兩儀拳 in Henan and songshi liangyiquan 宋氏兩儀拳 in Shandong. However, most of the Liangyiquan masters came from shenduan village in Henan province, where Duan Baohua 段保華 was born and trained to be one of the successors of Liangyiquan. He is now a widely recognized master and established his martial arts institute in Beijing in 1997 with around 100 disciples and 3,000 students to this day. Zhang Yaoting, the former president of Chinese Martial Arts Association and member of Chinese Olympic Committee noted that the training of Liangyiquan attached great importance to the actual combat function. Zhang noted that he archived in excitement the once-thought-lost unique Chinese Kungfu in the Chinese Martial Arts Records as File No. 136 (In Duan, 2001, preface). Liangyiquan represented by Duan Baohua was certified as the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Henan province in 2009 in P.R.C.

The philosophy of *Rouquan*: the meridian system and practice of *Qi*

In the context of this research, Rouquan in particular refers to the only existing school of Liangyiquan, which deeply bases its philosophy in I Ching and the learning of the Yellow Emperor and Lao Tsu. The name of Liangyiquan (yin-yang two-force boxing) is manifest of its tradition and philosophical foundation. In this regard, Yun (2012) clarified the key concepts of I (the Change), taichi, yin-yang and four images:

> Undoubtedly, yin and yang exemplify the two primary aspects (forms) of ch'i-creativity which find empirical bases. Yin-yang activities (e.g. opposite and complementary forms) can be found in the things of the world . . . Chapter XI, section 5 clarifies the relationship between I and other crucial Chinese categories. It says in Chinese: It can be translated as follows: "In I (the Change), there is the tai-chi (the Great Ultimate). This begets the two forces (yin and yang). The two forces beget the four images. The four images beget the eight trigrams. One can infer from the above that I and Tai-chi remain interchangeable terms in the I Ching. Moreover, the four images signify 1) old yang, 2) old yin, 3)young yang, and 4) young yin. The eight trigrams are 1) Ch'ien, 2)K'un, 3) Ch'en, 4) K'an, 5) K'en, 6) Sun, 7) Li, and 8) Tui.
>
> *(p. 59)*

Yin-yang as two primary forms of Qi creativity thus lay a sound foundation for the practice of Liangyiquan for which the learnings of Huang-Lao are also important theoretical basis. The major contents of Huang-Lao thoughts are: the connection between humans and Dao, the importance of personal cultivation,

"qingjing wuwei" (quiescence and inaction) etc. (L. K. Chen and H.C.W. Sung in Liu ed. 2015: 258). For Schwartz (1985), the Tao of Yin-Yang was rather elusive and mysterious as he put:

> Here we have something that might be called a mystical 'cosmorphism' in which a finite human being comes to embody the essence of nonbeing and is able to use his gnosis to establish the [Dao-shu], 'the methods of the dao,' which control the human world.
>
> *(249)*

In *The Yellow Emperor's Classic of Internal Medicine*, the change and significance of ying-yang as the fundamental Tao of the universe was clearly presented. In Suwen5: Great Discourse on the Responsive Manifestations of Yin and Yang in the Yellow Emperor said: "Yin-Yang is the Tao of heaven and earth, the law and principle of all the living, the father and mother of alterations and metamorphoses, the root and beginning of giving and taking life, and the palace of deities".[3] Most importantly, it expounds on the meridian system of human body and cultivation of Qi as a basis for acupuncture. As Raphals (2015) stated:

> As Nathan Sivin (1990) has argued, Chinese accounts focused on specific sciences, rather than a unified notion of science. These sciences were both quantitative and qualitative. Most important for our purposes are the qualitative fields of astronomy or astrology (tianwen 天文) and medicine (yi 醫) . . . Medicine included "nurturing life (yangsheng 養生), what Needham termed macrobiotics". This broad category included a wide range of self-cultivation techniques. In later periods it also included materia medica (bencao 本草) and internal (neidan 內丹) and external (waidan 外丹) alchemy.
>
> *(In Liu ed. p. 541)*

We could see that *The Yellow Emperor's Classic of Internal Medicine* not only provides philosophical framework but also scientific application for nurturing life and practicing medicine. Researchers in traditional Chinese medicine acknowledged the theoretical and empirical basis of yin-yang wuxing (five elements), the meridian system and actual usage of acupuncture to treat a variety of diseases. As Medical Doctor Marcelli (2013) elaborated:

> Traditional Chinese Medicine incorporates both yin-yang and the five elements theory, called Wu Xing. Yin-yang are mutually opposing forces, such as hot and cold, that are normally in balance with each other, i.e., homeostasis is present. Disease occurs when there is an excess or deficiency of either yin or yang. Our universe is composed of the five elements, including wood, fire, earth, metal and water, and these speak, in part, of the interaction between our body and the surrounding environment. Each of the 12 regular or principal meridians is associated with a Chinese organ, such as the heart, pericardium, lung, spleen, liver, kidney (the yin organs) and stomach, gallbladder, large and small intestine, urinary bladder and tri-heater or triple burner (the yang organs) . . . Oriental medicine is well over 3000 years old since its earliest descriptions originated during the reign of the Yellow Emperor in 2697 BCE in his Inner Classic (200 BC) [1]. In practice, oriental medicine includes both herbal remedies and acupuncture. Acupuncture is based on a meridional theory, which incorporates a system of channels through which vital energy, or Qi, flows.[4]
>
> *(p. 1)*

He also pointed out that despite further research needed to be substantiated to "investigate the role of some of the structures identified, it seems clear that the peripheral and central nervous system can now be considered to be the most rational basis for defining meridians. The meridian maps and associated acupoints located along them are best viewed as road maps that can guide practitioners towards applying acupuncture

to achieve optimal clinical results" (2013: 1). This also provides a strong support for the theories advanced in the *Book of Changes* and the learnings of Huang-Lao. As for actual practice, Chang (2012) stated:

> Acupuncture is an important and integral part of traditional Chinese medicine (TCM). It has proved itself to be clinically effective for more than 2500 years and remains an energetic and vibrant treatment. It is fair to say that the widespread use of acupuncture in the East and West has helped millions of patients worldwide. This is perhaps one of the main reasons that in 1980, the World Health Organization (WHO) recommended acupuncture as an effective alternative therapy for 43 different disorders. In October of the same year, the WHO Regional Office for the Western Pacific attempted to develop standard international acupuncture nomenclature.
>
> *(p. 506)*

Previous research identified the function of the meridian as the circulation channel of Qi and acupuncture as the effective way of disease treatment. The renowned doctor and Qi practitioner of Ming dynasty Lishizhen noted that only a self-observing persona could detect the interior channels of Qi. The manuscripts excavated from Mawangdui Han Tombs and bamboo manuscripts from Zhangjishan Han Tomb documented the guides to breathing exercises. Based on Devin Tam's research and practice, we observed that the meridian system, acupuncture and the practice of Qi are believed to be the guiding principles for Rouquan practitioners. There are twelve main or regular meridians 十二經脈, twelve internal paths of main meridians 十二經別, eight extraordinary or curious meridians, fifteen secondary meridians or major collaterals 十五絡脈 (twelve for main meridians, two for extraordinary meridians Renmai 任脈 and Dumai 督脈 and a"great" collateral of the spleen (in addition to ordinary collateral) twelve muscle tendon regions 十二經筋, twelve skin areas surface and tertiary meridians 十二皮部 (Marcelli 2013: 2). Along the twelve main meridians and two extraordinary meridians Renmai and Dumai are 361 acupoints in total, among which there are 36 lethal acupoints. For Rouquan practitioners, a thorough understanding and memorization of the major and minor meridians and acupoints is the prerequisite. They are trained to cultivate Qi and harness the circulation of Qi through the multiple pathways of meridians and acupoints along head, chest, four limbs and the whole body. The training, in particular, is focused on cultivating and circulating Qi in preparation for real combat along the twelve main meridians and two extraordinary meridians Renmai and Dumai and thirty-six lethal acupoints within them.

The practice of *Rouquan*

Similar with other schools of internal boxing, Rouquan practitioners value Qi as the basis of life, the vital energy or force that is fluid and constantly changing form. Qi can be used to attain equilibrium and the flow of Qi can be regulated through the use of acupoints along the meridians to not only enhance health and wellbeing but most importantly generate actual combat power to fight against an enemy. The fundamental trainings of Rouquan thus include meditation and the Jingluogong 經絡功 (the Meridian Qigong).

Meditation is an integral part of martial arts system of self-defense. It is believed that when people stand, half of our Qi and blood is taken away and consumed by the lower part of the body. Sitting meditation forces the Qi and blood to move up to the brain. In Rouquan training, sitting meditation serves three major functions: first, as a mind-body training technique, it brings awareness, calm, and centeredness crucial in chaotic situations and real-life combat. By enhancing these capabilities, one could make sound judgments in movements and catch the opportunities to strike or defend. Secondly, it trains the reverse abdominal breathing techniques. It is believed that the real energy of the body is

generated from the lower Dantian 下丹田 in the abdomen region, in contrast with upper Dantian 上丹田 in the brain. Vital energy needs to be stored at the very first place in the lower Dantian and supply it to the whole body. The reverse abdominal breathing helps build the Qi and energize the muscle. The breathing should be deep, long, tender, and well balanced 深長細勻. Like omphaloskepsis, the mind and breath is concentrated on the lower Dantian which will be suffused with Qi with practices. Thirdly, it trains the skills in manipulating the Qi in the lower Dantian through the meridians and acupoints. In the training of Liangyiquan, the Qi in the lower Dantian will be distributed and eventually transformed into hitting power, taking advantages of the meridians and acupoints to give full play to the strength of the fingers. The unique martial skill in Yiyangzhi 一陽指 (one-finger death touch) is to transmit the Qi in the lower Dantian to the fingertips to attack the enemy's acupoints.

It usually takes years of practise to harness the Qi. While meditation trains skills in breathing and manipulation of Qi in stillness, the meridian Qigong is another important and efficient training in movement. Based on Devin Tam's years of practices, we noted that yin-yang Jingluogong 陰陽經絡功 (the yin-yang meridian Qigong)handed down within his traditional Chinese medicine family is one of the most effective among various types of meridian Qigong. It has six major forms named Jueyin 厥陰, shaoyin 少陰, taiyin 太陰, shaoyang 少陽, yangming 陽明, and taiyang 太陽, with each corresponding to a specific meridian called pericardium meridian 心包經, heart meridian 心經, lung meridian 肺經, triple energizer meridian 三焦經, large intestine meridian 大腸經, and small intestine meridian 小腸經 respectively. The practice will greatly increase one's focus control of breathing and effective use of Qi through the six meridian pathways and promote sound mental health and maximize inner strength and physical power. Eventually, the practitioner could transmit the Qi to the corresponding acupoints in the fingertips, namely, zhongchong 中沖穴 in the middle finger, shaochong 少沖穴 in the little finger, shaoshang 少商穴 in the thumb, guanchong 關沖穴 in the third finger, shangyang 商陽穴 in the index finder, and shaoze 少澤穴 in the little finger.

As Rouquan upholds the authentic Kungfu ethos in real combat, rather than for performance or entertainment. In addition to meditation and the meridian Qigong, the basics include stances, conditioning exercises such as breathing, stretching, striking, leaping, kicking, but all movement in fact is intimately linked to one's *Qi*. In the training of Liangyiquan, it is clearly stated:

> The two Qi of Yinyang converge and the vital energy is gathered in the Dantian . . . the essence of the Liangyiquan lies in leading the mind with heart and transmitting Qi with mind. By pushing down the Qi of yang and lifting up the Qi of yin, the two Qi converge in the Dantian and then transmitted to the palm. . . . The outburst of the vital energy in a moment is like nuclear fission. The energy is so enormous that the opponent will lose the ability to strike back.[5]
>
> *(Duan, foreword)*

Like other schools of internal martial arts, Liangyiquan also has various *taolu* 套路 (forms), i.e. various sets of movements, each set consisting of a series of predetermined, coordinated movements that must be practised until they can be executed in a single, fluid, multi-step sequence of uninterrupted segments. The apprentices will be trained in the sparring session where they learn to recognize instantly the opponent's movement and to immediately execute an appropriate counter movement, in particular, catch the opportunities to attack the opponent's acupoints. It demands that the attack movement, whether with fist, palm, fingertip, and tiptoe, needs to be done with extreme speed like swift lightning and thunder. The opponents' faces will show different red, black, blue or yellow colours when different acupoints are attacked with distinct strength. Consequently, the opponents will be overpowered, either fainting out, or falling mute or crashing to the floor (Duan, p. 1).[6] Therefore, the angle of attacking, the intensity of strength, and the accuracy of acupoints identification are crucial in the practice of Rouquan.

Conclusion

Bruce Lee, the Kungfu master succinctly summarized the yin-yang balance in martial arts:

> The techniques of Gung Fu emphasize not on power but in conservation of energy and moderation without going to either extreme (yin & yang 陰陽). That is why a true Gung Fu man never opposes force (which will create reaction) or give way completely; he is simply pliable, as a spring. He seeks to merge harmoniously with the oncoming force of the opponent – to be the complement, and not the opposite of the opponent's force".
>
> *(p. 6)*

He is insightful in realizing the importance of intangible Qi in human body, the yin-yang balance and mutual conversion. His Jeet June Do is a fusion of different martial arts incorporating wingchun, taichi, Western wrestling and karate, focusing on fluid movements and spontaneity. The one-inch punch based on wingchun is representative of the skills of attacking force in internal boxing, thus bearing resemblance in that of Rouquan. However, Bruce Lee fails to give a full play of utilizing the Qi to achieve the true spirit of seeking peace in martial arts as he cannot avoid causing body injuries to the opponents in real combat.

The bestselling Chinese martial arts novelist Jinyong 金庸, pen name of Louis Cha, depicted the mysterious and formidable Kungfu named Yiyangzhi 一陽指 (one-finger death touch) in Tianlong Babu 天龍八部 (the demi-gods and semi-devils), one of his most popular novels. In reality, this is exactly where Rouquan, a mysterious school of Chinese martial arts, fits into place. Liangyiquan, as the representative of Rouquan, by seemingly magical wielding of the power of Qi to attack the opponent's acupoints, causes no physical damage to the skin, skeleton or internal organs. However, it actually cuts off the transmitting channel of Qi and blood, disables the opponent's ability to strike back, and only the attacker could bring the crashed enemy back to normal by beating specific acupoints with his palm.[7] In this way, Rouquan fulfils the ideal of martial arts: Zhige 止戈, in other words, the end of war and seeking of peace.

Notes

1 In Zuozhuan: Duke Xuan 12th Year.
2 In this part, Raphals is discussing Daoist methods of preserving and increasing longevity.
3 The authors' translation. The original Chinese text is: 黃帝曰：陰陽者，天地之道也，萬物之綱紀，變化之父母，生殺之本始，神明之府也。黃帝內經素問《陰陽應象大論篇第五》
4 As for influential Chinese medicine books Marcelli introduced:

> One of the earliest descriptions of meridians and acupuncture points (acupoints) as well as technical aspects of acupuncture and moxibustion was written by Hangfu Mi in 259–282 AD [1, 2, 3]. 349 acupuncture points, or acupoints, which is more than the 160 contained in the Yellow Emperor's Inner Classic. Further description of acupuncture was provided in a text by Yang Jizhou (1520–1660) who mentioned 361 acupoints [1, 2, 4]. A French diplomatic scholar, George Soulié de Morant brought acupuncture to Europe in the early 1900 s after serving in China [5]. He coined the terms meridian and energy.
>
> *(2013: 1)*

5 The authors' translation. The original Chinese text is: 陰陽兩氣和，真能丹田聚 ….兩儀點穴武功的精髓就在於以心領意，以意導氣，將陽氣下壓，陰氣上提合於丹田之間，以氣摧力達於掌端 ….瞬間爆發二氣合壹的真氣，施之於人就如同核裂變，能量之巨足以使對方喪失還手能力。
6 兩儀拳是我國古老而神秘的拳種， 由於受壹代只傳壹日封閉古老的傳授方式的制約，領其真髓者極少。她宗法自然，招法奇特，式式生風，且動作極短、極快。快如閃電，疾入奔雷，浸透力極強，且不論壹拳壹掌，壹指壹趾，所擊之處皆人體要穴 ….以不同的勁，擊點不同的穴，對方可呈現不同的狀態，臉上可出現紅黑青黃等諸色 …或昏或啞或癱等 …必求擊點者壹掌救治，恢復原狀，因而制人不傷人。
7 兩儀拳的點穴是閉交通之道，斷運輸之功 ….經酪斷則缺氣運行之能，血脈斷則失去知覺之效。兩儀拳的勁，在人體表面沒有什麼沖擊力，但是向人體內部的傳導力增大，自然入內。

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18
HANDICRAFT IN TRADITIONAL CHINA

Wang Haiyan and Liu Yingchun

1. Introduction

Traditional China is known for its well-developed handicraft, and for many years the handicraft products have been exported to many parts of the world. The traditional Chinese handicraft achievements include the making of daily necessities such as paper to write on and to decorate houses with; yeast to brew wine, cook food with, and to use as medicine; tools of public transport such as boats and carts; ceramics and porcelain products such as jars and bowls to use, bricks to build walls and houses with, and so forth.

The present chapter is a brief introduction to the making of paper, carts and yeast; casting, forging, and ceramics and porcelain, achievements in six major sub-branches among the many marvelous handicraft achievements made in traditional China. It is the author's hope that this chapter can shed light on the academic studies of traditional Chinese culture by scholars both at home and abroad, and on the internationalization of traditional Chinese culture in the context of the global efforts for cultural diversity.

2. Achievements in six sub-branches

2.1 Making of paper

There are different types of paper. Bamboo paper is made from bamboo fibre. Bark paper is made from the bark of the paper-mulberry trees (called "grain trees"), silk-mulberry fibre, or cotton rose hibiscus. Refined paper is incredibly white and used for writing, printing and other purposes. The rough paper is used as paper of burnt offerings or as wrapping paper.

2.1.1 Bamboo paper

Bamboo paper making prevails in the south, mostly popular in Fujian province in southeastern China. People in southern China observe the growing of bamboo shoots and select those with branches and leaves as the best raw materials for paper making. Around Grain in Beard (around 6 June, the ninth solar term in China), they chop down bamboos in the mountains, dig a pool right on the spot, put the chopped bamboo sticks of 5 to 7 *chi* long into the pool and fill the pool with water for retting of the bamboo sticks. To prevent the pool from drying up, a bamboo pipe is used to conduct water flowing down from the mountain to the pool. After 100 days, the bamboo sticks are taken out from the pool for further processing, with the rind and green skins removed by washing (Figure 18.1).

Figure 18.1 Steeping and washing the chopped bamboo

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 392.

The cauldron for boiling the bamboo sticks should be 4 *chi* in diameter and its outer edges should be fixed with mud and lime. Its height and width are similar to the pan used for producing salt in Guangdong province, with a capacity of over ten *dan* of water (Figure 18.2). A big barrel containing chopped bamboo sticks is put into the cauldron, and the boiling is finished on the eighth day. Then wait one more day before the bamboo sticks are taken out to be washed with fresh water in a pool. The bottom and sides of the pool are well-built with wood planks without any gaps to protect it from mud coming in. But this process is not necessary when making coarse paper. After washing, soak the bamboo sticks in water mixed with firewood ash. Then put them neatly in the cauldron, spread haulm ash of about one *cun* thick on them. After boiling, put the bamboo sticks into another big barrel to be drenched by water mixed with ash. When the bamboo sticks cool down, repeat the boiling and drenching continuously for ten days. The bamboo will rot naturally and are then taken out to be pounded in a mortar until it becomes a dough of bamboo pulp.

The bamboo pulp is then poured into a square-shaped tank. The exact size of the tank is determined by the size of the paper-making screen used, which in turn is determined by the size of the paper sheets to be made. When the clear supernatant liquid in the pulp tank is three *cun* deep, a chemical solution is then added (which seems like leaves of peach-bamboo, with different names in different places). This chemical solution can bleach the paper sheets to a white colour after drying. The screen used for making paper sheets is made of a rectangular frame covered with a mat woven of finely split and polished bamboo. A worker holds the screen with both hands and submerges it in the fibre suspension of the pulp tank so that some of the pulp remains on the top of the screen. The thickness of the paper depends on the way the screen is manipulated: a shallow dipping results in thin paper, while a deeper dipping, thick paper. Water from the pulp will drain off around the screen's edges back into the tank, with the bamboo pulp left on the top. The screen is then inverted and a sheet of paper is dropped onto a wooden board. More such sheets of paper

Figure 18.2 Cooking the inner mass of bamboo in a cauldron

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 393.

are made this way. When all the water is squeezed out, each sheet of paper is lifted up by using a small brass tweezer and dried by baking.

The reason why the "burnt-offering" paper is so named is that in the Tang dynasty, people were much concerned about religious worship. They burned large amounts of sacrificial paper money instead of using the "burnt silk". The coarsest and thickest paper is called "wrapping paper", which is produced with a mixture of bamboo fibre and rice stalk fibre. The paper for invitations made in Qianshan area, Jiangxi province in southern China is all made from sliced bamboo and thickened in order to make more profit. The best of its kind, thick and solid, is called the "official invitation paper" used to make business cards by the rich. When reddened, it can be used for invitation card-making for happy occasions. It is first treated with alum water and then dyed red with safflower juice.

2.1.2 Bark paper

At the end of spring and the beginning of summer, people strip the bark from the trees. For an old tree, the bark is cut near the root and then the tree trunk is covered with mud. When the tree grows the next year, the bark will grow better. To make bark paper, sixty *jin* of paper-mulberry bark and forty *jin* of tender bamboo are immersed together in a pond, covered with lime juice, and finally boiled in a pot to turn it into pulp. In order to be economical, recently some people use seventy percent of bark and bamboo, and thirty percent of rice stalks to make bark paper. After suitable chemicals are added, however, white paper can still be obtained this way. Bark paper made from a mixture of bark, bamboo and rice stalks is called "document paper".

A more durable type of bark paper will show ragged ends like cotton fibres, therefore it is called "cotton paper". It is difficult to tear this paper crosswise. The superior grade is used to paper the windows of the Imperial Palaces and is thus called "window gauze" paper. This kind of paper, seven *chi* long and four *chi*

wide, is made in Guangxin Prefecture(Shangrao, Jiangxi province nowadays). It is dyed in various colours by adding colouring materials to the pulp tank. Dyeing is done before the paper sheets are formed.

Another kind of paper, made from the skin of cotton rose hibiscus stems, is called "small bark paper", but in Jiangxi province it is called "middle paper". The paper in Henan province, whose raw materials are unknown, are mass produced and sent to the capital city of Beijing for use. Still another kind of paper, a very thick type, made from cortex mori, is called "mulberry paper". Mulberry paper produced in the east of Zhejiang province is a must for collecting silkworm eggs in Suzhou, Changzhou, and Huzhou, Zhejiang province in eastern China.

When used for painting, bark paper is first sized with alum water to eliminate fluff from the surface. The sheet side that adheres to the screen is considered the right side, as the texture of the free side is inevitably rougher even though the pulp has been reduced to a state as fine as clay.

2.2 Making of carts

In constructing carts, long pieces of wood are chosen for axles and short ones for the hub. The best types of wood for these purposes are the locust, jujube, sandalwood, and elm. Sandalwood, though tough and durable, tends to become hot after continuous use in motion. Therefore the best material for making the axles and the hub is either jujube or locust trunk, which is so thick that a man has to use both arms to hold it. The other parts of the cart, the front and rear cross-boards, the body and the yoke, can be made of any kind of wood.

2.2.1 Types of carts

The horse-drawn and mule-drawn carts are built with either two or four wheels, and the axle is the base on which the superstructure of the cart is constructed. The four-wheeled cart has axles both fore and aft, on which rest short posts that support straight beams, and on the beams rest the cart body. When it is not in motion, with the horses or mules unharnessed, the cart is as level and secure as one's own living room. In contrast, the body of the two-wheeled cart remains level only when it is drawn by the horse or mule. When the horse or mule is unhitched, the cart must be propped up with posts, otherwise the front of the cart will touch the ground.

The wheel of the cart is called "yuan". The hub of a large cart, in the centre of a wheel, measures one and a half *chi* in diameter and supports the spokes all around itself while allowing the axle to come through the centre. There are spokes on each wheel. The inner end of each spoke is attached to the hub and the outer end, to the interior rim of the wheel. The part which inwardly holds the wheel together and connects outwardly to the felloe, thus making a complete circle, is known as the interior rim. When the cart is not in use, its composite parts are taken apart for storage. To assemble it, first mount the two axletrees, and then put the other parts together step by step.

Another type of cart is the ox-drawn cart, which is widely used for transporting grain and plant stalks in Shanxi province, northwestern China. Where the road becomes narrow, the ox will shake the bell hanging from its neck to alert the cart driver, hence the bell is called "herald bell", which serves the same purpose as the bell hung from the horse's or mule's neck.

2.2.2 Four- and two-wheeled carts

The four-wheeled cart has a capacity of carrying fifty *dan* of freight. As many as ten or twelve (at least eight) horses or mules are used to form a team to draw the cart (Figure 18.3). The driver stands on an elevated platform in the front of the cart. A long hemp rope is attached to the neck of each horse or mule, tied together and passed inside the front cross board, and then fastened to the cart. The driver wields a long hemp whip of seven *chi* with a handle of equal length. Two other persons in the cart, familiar with the

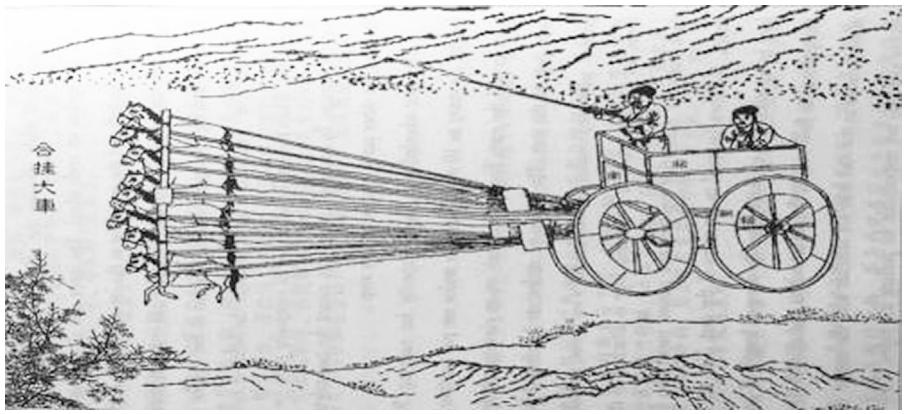

Figure 18.3 The four-wheeled cart drawn by eight horses or mules

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 458.

nature of horses or mules, are responsible for pulling the ropes. They step on the ropes to slow the cart down if the horses or mules are trotting too fast, otherwise the cart may overturn and crash. To avoid hurting pedestrians walking ahead the cart, the driver immediately calls out a loud command to stop all the horses or mules. All the ropes are passed through the front cross board, tied with ox-hide in a bundle and finally get to the centre of the cart. This is termed as "driving aid" in the *Book of Poetry*.

The ox-drawn enclosed wagons are used only in Henan province, central China. Two wheels are connected to the cart by an axle, keeping the cart in perfect balance. The boards are laid over the axletree, on which the body of the wagon is mounted. The empty wagon will not tilt even when the ox is unharnessed.

2.2.3 Single-wheeled carts

In northern China, there is the single-wheeled cart, also called the wheelbarrow, pushed by a man from the rear, and sometimes drawn by a donkey in front at the same time. Travellers who do not wish to ride on horseback often hire such a cart for their journeys. A semi-circle awning is erected overhead to serve as a protective cover against the wind and sun. Passengers must sit face to face, one on each side to balance the cart, otherwise it will tip over. These carts start their journeys from Chang'an (Xi'an nowadays), Shaanxi province, and Jining, Shandong province and travel all the way to the capital city of Beijing. When not carrying passengers, the carts can be used to transport merchandise, with each cart carrying four or five *dan*. The single-wheeled carts in southern China, pushed only by one man's strength, can carry two *dan* of freight. They have to be stopped when encountering an uneven section in the terrain, and they travel no more than a range of 100 *li* (Figure 18.4).

2.3 Making of yeasts

There are three main kinds of yeast, the wine yeast, medicinal yeast, and red yeast. When making yeasts, the essence of the five grains is changed. After the grains are ground, they are mixed with water and kneaded into solid forms, then they will become yeast in the breeze. "Wine yeast" is indispensable in the brewing process. The yeast used by physicians is called "medicinal yeast" and the red one, which can make food delicious, is called "red yeast". Since ancient times, the blending methods of the principal materials and

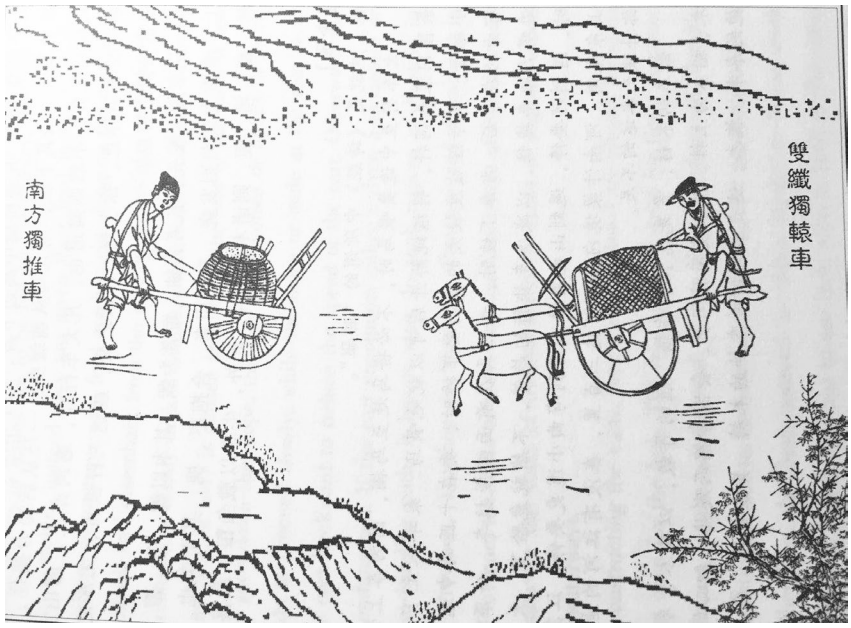

Figure 18.4 The single-wheeled cart (the wheelbarrow)

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 459.

supplementary materials in making medicinal yeast have been improved. Medicinal yeast is proven to be very effective in curing inveterate diseases.

2.3.1 Wine yeast

Wine yeast is a must in the brewing process. Without it, wine will not be brewed even with the best rice. In ancient times, the ordinary wine is made with yeast, and the sweet wine, with maltose. Afterwards, however, the method of brewing lost its popularity since the sweet wine is not considered strong enough. Consequently, the methods for making maltose and brewing sweet wine is lost, too. The raw materials for making wine yeast are mainly wheat, rice, and flour depending on the local conditions in southern and northern China, but the principles are the same. Both barley and wheat are appropriate for making wheat yeast. Wheat with hulls should be washed clean with water from a well and then dried in the sun, and this is better done in midsummer. The wheat should be ground and then kneaded into blocks with water used when washing the wheat. Then the blocks of wheat triturate should be bound up with mulberry leaves and hung in a draught. They should be covered with straw in order to grow yellow spores. They are taken out and used in forty-nine days.

"Flour yeast" is made by blending five *jin* of flour and five *sheng* of soybeans boiled with the polygonum hydropiper juice. Then five *liang* of *polygonum flaccidum* powder and ten *liang* of mashed almond are added and turned into cakes by blending and pressing. The yeast cakes are then wrapped up with mulberry leaves and hung high or covered with straw to grow yellow spores. The method is the same as the one explained above. When glutinous rice powder is used, marinate it in the natural *polygonum hydropiper* juice and make cakes out of it. It can be used after yellow spores have grown on it. The covering method and the

time required are the same as the method mentioned before. The number of principal and supplementary materials and herbal medicine added range from several ingredients to a hundred. In Ningbo and Shaoxing, Zhejiang province, eastern China, bean wine is made with mung beans and yeast, which is very famous throughout China and are considered as a vintage wine.

At the wine-yeast maker's home, if the culturing of molds is not properly done, or not well tended, or if the hands are not properly cleaned, a few pellets of the bad yeast can spoil a whole *dan* of the wine maker's grain. The wine maker must get reliable yeast from those who have a good reputation and are well known as wine-yeast producers. Yeast used in Hebei and Shandong provinces for making yellow rice wine is usually made in Huai'an, Jiangsu province, eastern China and transported to northern China by boats and/or carts. The yeast used to make the red wine in southern China is also produced in Huai'an. They are both called "fire yeast". However, the yeast from Huai'an is shaped into square blocks, while in the south, into cakes. Some old wine mash must be added to either kind of yeast to aerate it. If rice and wheat are used as the basic raw materials, yeast and wine mash must be added before they are fermented to the medium level.

2.3.2 Medicinal yeast

The objective of making medicinal yeast is to use it as medicine. Doctors refer to it as medicinal yeast in order to differentiate it from wine yeast used for brewing wine. The technique for making medicinal yeast can be traced back to the Tang dynasty. White flour is the special material used to make medicinal yeast. Every 100 *jin* of flour should be added with the fumet of *artemisia apiacea, polygonum nodosum,* and *anthium sibiricum* and kneaded into cakes which should be wrapped up or covered with hemp leaves or mulberry leaves. The method is similar to making yellow yeast for fermented bean sauce. After the cakes are covered with yellow mold, they are dried in the sun and stored. As for the addition of other drugs, follow the doctors' directions because there is no fixed prescription for it.

2.3.3 Red yeast

The method of making red yeast starts in more recent times. It involves the transformation of the essence of grains. Fish and meat go bad easily in hot weather. However, only a thin layer of red yeast coating fish will keep the fish fresh during hot summer days. Maggots and flies will stay away from the fish for as long as ten days, and the colour and taste of the fish remain the same.

Polished glutinous long-grained rice, whether the early- or late-ripening type, are both appropriate for making the red yeast. The rice should be pestled very fine. After being soaked in water for seven days, the strong odour could be unbearable. Then take the pestled rice out and wash it with water from mountain streams instead of that from great rivers (Figure 18.5). Even after washing, the odour will still exist. However, the odour will become pleasant if the pestled rice is put into a steamer and braised into cooked rice. The steaming process should be paused when the pestled rice is half-cooked. Next, pour some cool water onto it to cool it down. Then steam it until it is fully cooked. At last, pile several *dan* of rice together and put yeast into it.

The principal ingredient for making red yeast should be the high-quality red wine mash. The cooked rice is placed together, several *dan* to a heap, for the addition of leaven. In making the red yeast, the leaven must be made from the best red-coloured wine mash at a proportion of one peck of mash to three *sheng* of the natural juice of smartweed mixed in alum water. Two *jin* of this leaven is added to every *dan* of steamed rice when the latter is still hot, then mix quickly by several pairs of hands until it cools down. The mixture should then stay for a long time under constant observation, so that the rice can be sufficiently fermented by the leaven. Then pour the rice with the yeast into a bamboo tray and drench it with some aluminous water before finally spreading it out in a bamboo tray. In the end, put the tray in a draught. From this point on, the air will be important for culturing the yeast, while fire and water will serve no practical purposes (Figure 18.6).

Figure 18.5 Washing fermented rice in a mountain stream

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by SongYingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 510.

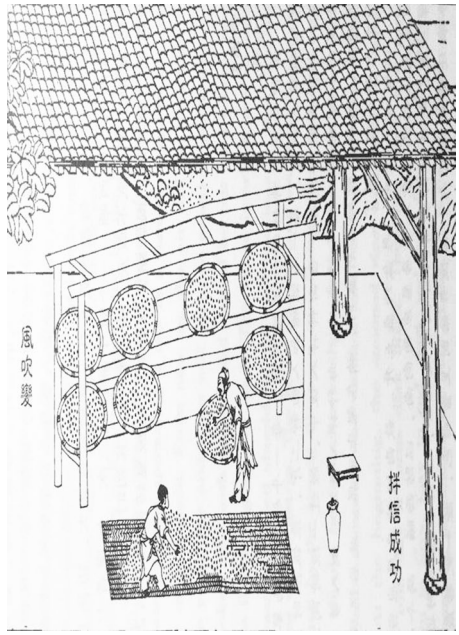

Figure 18.6 Fermenting steamed rice in bamboo trays under the sun

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by SongYingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 511.

The cooked rice with yeast added should be put onto plates, each of which has five *sheng* of rice on it. The house in which the steamed rice with yeast is placed, should be tall and spacious so that the heat from the tiles won't get in. The house should face the south so that it cannot be affected by the strong afternoon sun. During every two-hour period, the rice should be turned over three times. For seven days, there should always be someone observing the rice without any sleep. At the beginning, the steamed rice with yeast is snow white. In one day's time it turns dark black. Then the black rice turns brown, then from brown to foxy, foxy to red and dark red, and finally to light yellow. The colour changing process of the rice in the open air is called "cultivation of yellow yeast". The price, manpower, and the material resources required for producing yeast this way are twice as much as those for the regular yeast. Every time when the rice turns from black to brown or from brown to red, it is necessary to wash it with water. But no more washing is required after the rice turns red. Workers are required to wash their hands frequently and should also keep the bamboo trays, bamboo mattresses, and the surrounding equipment clean, since the slightest bit of dirt will bring the entire work to ruin.

2.4. Casting

Ever since the time of the Yellow Emperor, copper mining and casting of implements like tripods have been conducted in Shoushan (Xiangcheng nowadays), in Henan province . Metal is taken out from the earth in its natural state and made into implements for people to use. The implements vary in quality and size and people use them widely. A big bell, made from metal, is made into a hollow shape which creates harmonious sounds that can fill the air. Chiliasts create figures from metal so that the images of gods can be seen in this mortal world. Metal coins are circulated throughout the country. The uses of metal are so numerous that it is impossible to name all of them.

2.4.1 Bells

A bell is the foremost of all the metal musical instruments. A big ringing bell can be heard ten *li* away, and even a small one can be heard in a distance of more than one *li*. Bells are rung to assemble people when an emperor is holding court, or when officials are to be summoned to their government offices. The ringing of serial chime bells accompanies an official banquet. Bells are rung to touch the hearts of worshippers and also to remind their respect for gods. In the casting process, copper is the material used for making high-quality bells while iron is used for making low-quality ones. Now in the North-star Pavilion in the palace, bell metal is used to make the Audience Bells, each of which costs 47,000*jin* of copper, 4,000*jin* of tin, 50*liang* of gold and 120*liang* of silver. The finished bell weighs 20,000*jin* and measures 1.15 *zhang* in height, with a diameter of 8 *chi*. The double-dragon "*pulao*" (a kind of sea animal, symbolizing the loudness of the bell) cast on the bell is 2.7 *cun* in height. These are the specifications of the Audience Bells used at the present time.

When casting a 10,000-*jin* bell, first dig a pit of one *zhang* deep and keep the inside of the pit dry. A house-like construction should be built inside and an inner mould should be made from a mixture of lime and mortar, without even a single crack allowed. After the pit is dry, apply some ox fat and yellow wax of several *cun* thick, the proportion being eight tenths of ox fat and two tenths of wax. The function of the tall canopy above is to protect the mould from sunlight and rain (this should not be done in summer because oil does not congeal in summer time). Characters and images should be cast with great care after the oil wax becomes fixed. Next, very fine earth and charcoal powder are pounded and mixed into a mud paste, which is gradually spread on the surface of the engraved wax until it is several *chi* thick. When the pit is thoroughly dried, heat is applied from the outside so that the fat and wax will melt and flow out entirely through apertures at the base. The bell will then be cast in the cavity thus vacated between the core and mould (Figure 18.7).

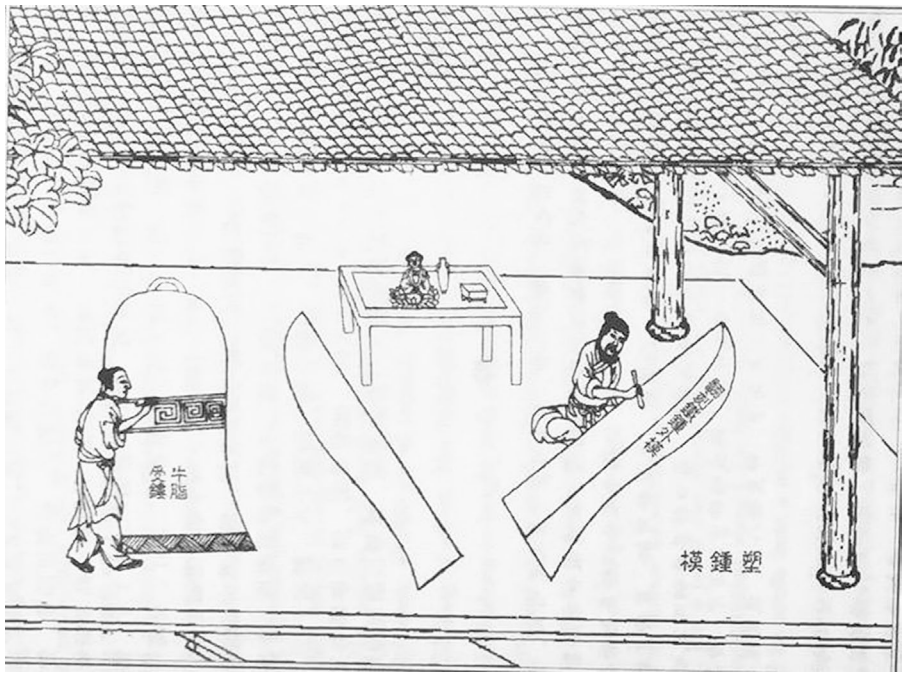

Figure 18.7 Mould for bell-making

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 277.

The vacated part made by one jin of wax can be filled with ten*jin* of copper. Therefore, when ten*jin* of wax is used to cast the mould, 100 *jin* of copper is needed. After all the wax in the mould is drained, the next step should be the smelting of copper. It is impossible for a man to manage the smelting of a thousand *jin* of copper with his own hands only. A smelter should be built surrounding the bell mould and mud should be used to make troughs connecting to the smelter outlets. The bottom of a trough tilts downward so that it can be connected to the copper-casting orifice. Around the troughs a charcoal fire is lighted to keep warm. After the copper inside the smelter is melted, unplug the orifice (which is plugged with clay). Then the liquid copper will flow along the troughs into the mould and then the casting of a bell will be accomplished.

The methods of casting an iron bell weighing around ten thousand *jin* and the casting of a censer or a large cauldron are much the same. The only difference lies in the method of making the mould, which can be changed according to certain conditions and requirements. Not too much tallow or yellow wax is needed to make the mould for the purpose of casting iron bells. The outer mould is made of clay. Then it is cut lengthwise or widthwise into two parts which are then connected by dowel pins. Characters and patterns are carved onto the inner surface of the outer mould in reverse. The inner mould should be slightly smaller than the outer one. There is a certain interspace between the two moulds created by careful calculation. The inner surface of the outer mould should be spread with tallow so that the bell won't adhere to the mould. After the two parts of the mould are joined, the cracks should be sealed together with mud before casting. The method of making big chimes and cloud-shaped musical boards is similar to this.

2.4.2 Copper coins

Copper coins are cast for civil use. One side of the coin is cast with four characters "xx tongbao", indicating that it is the currency of a particular historical period in a particular dynasty. A special bureau within the Board of Works is in charge of coin casting. Ten copper coins equal one *fen* of silver. The disadvantage of the big coins which equal five *fen* or ten *fen* is that they are easily counterfeited, thus harmful to the civilians. That's the reason why in all parts of the empire the circulation of coins is frequently stopped. An approximate proportion of six or seven *jin* of copper and three or four *jin* of zinc (called "water tin" in the capital city of Beijing) is needed to cast every ten *jin* of copper coins. At a high temperature, zinc will lose a quarter of its weight. The highly pure coins used in the Ming dynasty are only the yellow coins produced in the Baoyuan Bureau in Beijing. The black coins are made by the Gaozhou Prefecture (Maoming city nowadays), Guangdong province. The Gaozhou coins are used in Zhangzhou and Quanzhou, Fujian province. The yellow coins are of two kinds, with those cast with four-times purified copper called "golden-surface coins" and those with twice-purified copper called "sealing wax coins".

The cauldrons used for smelting copper in coin casting are made from extremely fine earth (with smashed dry adobes being the best) and charcoal powder. Every ten *liang* of raw materials for casting a cauldron include seven*liang* of earth and three*liang* of charcoal power. Charcoal powder preserves heat and the mixture of earth and charcoal powder makes it easier to smelt copper. The cauldron is eight *cun* tall and 2.5 *cun* in diameter, containing ten *jin* of copper and zinc. Copper is first smelted in the cauldron and then zinc is added. The smelted raw materials are then poured into the coin casting mould.

A coin mould is a frame made from four pieces of wood of 1.2 *chi* long and 1.2 *cun* wide. Extremely finely screened earth and charcoal power are put on the screen and pressed through the frame. The resulting powder is sprayed on top of a little charcoal powder made from fir or willow. Or the mould can be fumed with smoke of colophony or colza oil. Then 100 coin moulds made of tin are spread upon the surface. Press the earth and powder with a wooden frame onto the original frame so that the head and tail coin moulds are formed on the back frame. Then press, using another frame, the back frame again and turn it in the same way. After several repetitions, ten frame moulds or so will be produced. Later they should be tied up with ropes. There should be holes on the edges of the frames so that the smelted copper can be poured through them. Then a founder gets the copper-smelting cauldron out from the smelter with an eagle-beak clamp. Another clamp is then used to hold the bottom of the cauldron while the smelted materials are poured into the holes. After cooling, unbind the frames so that 100 coins appear like fruits on branches. The branches are formed because there are holes for the smelted materials to flow out into the moulds. After cooling, the smelted materials which form the branches will be broken by clamps and rasped away. The coins should be filed along their edges after casting. Hundreds of coins are bunched with bamboo or wooden bars so they can be rasped together. Next, the uneven part of every coin is rasped individually (Figure 18.8).

The purity of copper coins depends on the amount of zinc in them. Dropping onto the stone steps, coins with low purity sound like dropping wood or stone, while highly pure coins, containing nine-tenth copper and one-tenth zinc, sound like dropping metal. Copper coins cast with used copper utensils will lose one-tenth of their weight every time they are smelted and cast into coins. Because part of the zinc is lost, the resultant product will contain a higher percentage of copper.

2.4.3 Iron coins

Iron is so cheap that it has rarely been used to cast coins. The casting of iron coins can be dated back to the Tang dynasty in seigniorial towns like Weibo (part of Shandong, Hebei and Henan provinces nowadays) just because copper was unavailable. This was just makeshift. In prosperous dynasties, silver is used to make silver beans for entertainment, while in poor dynasties iron is used to cast coins.

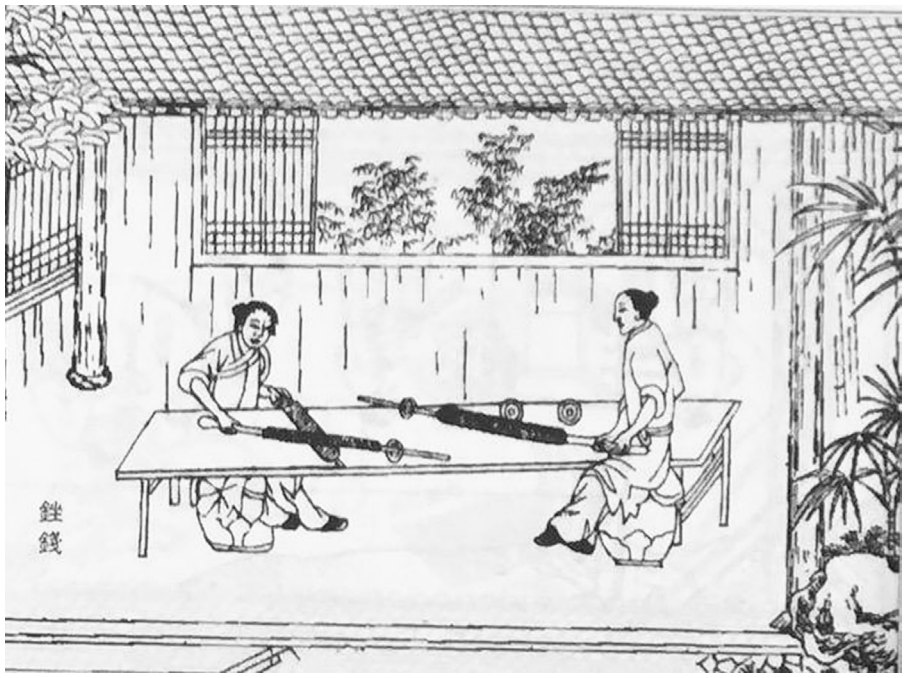

Figure 18.8 Filing coins

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 291.

China has a very long history of mining. In the time of Emperor Yu of the Xia dynasty, metals are presented to the Emperor for his Great Tripod by the magistrates of the nine provinces under his rule. Ever since then, the craftsmanship of metal casting by the use of fire has been improved with the passing of time.

2.5 Forging

Metals and timber are made into various implements through the use of machines. Without the right tools to use, artisans even like Luban, a master in carpentry in the Spring and Autumn Period (770 403 BCE), could not demonstrate their wonderful skills, and without clamps or hammers, the production of various weapons and metallic musical instruments and so forth could not be accomplished. All tools and implements are forged by blazes in smelters, but they vary in shape and size. Anchors as heavy as 3,000 *jin* can anchor big ships in raging waves; needles as light as a feather can embroider beautiful patterns on official uniforms. These wonderful arts and crafts even outshine those of casting bells.

2.5.1 Iron articles

Wrought iron is used in iron forging. First, cast iron is made into an anvil as the pedestal to sustain the hammering. The wrought iron that has just emerged from forging is called "unfashioned iron," which will lose thirty percent of its volume in the form of sparks and droppings after forging. Iron that is already used and not rusted yet is called "used iron" which can be changed to other implements as well as the original ones and will only lose ten percent when being forged. Coal accounts for seventy percent, and charcoal

thirty percent of the fuel used for heating the iron in forging. In places where no coal is available, ironsmiths burn hard wooden sticks into hardwood charcoal, with the resulting fire much stronger than that of the coal. If coal has to be used, it should be the kind of coal called iron coal (anthracite), which contains intense internal heat without being wasted in high flames. It has the same shape as the coal for cooking, but it is of a different type.

Before being burned red in the furnace and then hammered, pieces of wrought iron should be joined together by using yellow mud. Then the mud, only a linking agent, should be washed off. After being hammered, those iron implements can't be broken unless smelted again and cut by axes. The hammer-forged articles of wrought iron and steel are not very hard before the correct balance of water and fire has been achieved, and therefore should be quenched in clear water immediately after forging, which is called the hardening of steel and iron. Before this process, the soft properties of iron and steel are not yet entirely removed. In other words, before "being put into clear water," steel and iron still have the quality of mildness. In China, soldering paste for small items is cupronickel powder while for big items the joining can only be achieved by forceful hammering. Years later, however, the joints will not remain firm. As a result, though there are forged cannons in Western countries, in China cannons are made by casting only.

2.5.2 Knives and axes

Among the iron weapons, the thin ones are knives and swords, while the ones with thick backs and thin blades are axes of different size. Those admirable knives and swords are covered with steel tempered many times, while the frameworks are made of wrought iron. Otherwise the sword will break when it is used with vigor. The ordinary knives and axes are inlaid with steel on the cutting edge only. But the steel coating on even the costliest knife, which can chop nails and cut through ordinary iron, will disappear and the iron core will show up after the blade had been ground and sharpened a few thousand times.

All knives and axes produced by heating should be coated or inlaid with steel and should be put into water to be quenched after forging. The sharpness of the blades depends on the work spent on the whetstones. The cavities for wooden handles of axes and hammers used by ironsmiths should all have cold iron as framework called jimmies, and then be wrapped with hot iron. The cavities are made because cold iron does not adhere to hot iron. There will be hollow space in axes and mallets after they are worn out. They can be used again after being filled with smelted iron.

2.5.3 Hoes, files and awls

Hoes for ploughing fields and planting, and hoes with a broad mouth are forged from wrought iron. Sprinkle smelted pig iron onto the hoe blades so that the hoes will become hard and tough after being quenched in water. The best way is that every one *jin* of hoe (or shovel) should be sprinkled with three *qian* of pig iron; any less and the product will not be hard enough, and any more and the tools will be broken easily.

Files are made with pure steel. Before being quenched, the steel is soft. Then longitudinal and diagonal lines are curved by flat-mouth chisels of quenched steel on file flans. Only if the chisels advance diagonally when curving the lines could the edges take the shape of flame. Files will have rubdowns after being used for a long time. In this case, they should be annealed to make the steel softer and then be curved with new lines by flat-mouth chisels. To make saw-teeth with a file, the "straw-leaf" file should be used first, followed by the "arc-sharpening" file; to polish copper coins, the "square-long-pull" file; to polish locks, keys, and the like, the "square strip" file; to cut and fashion ivory and horns, the "sword-face" file; and to work on wood the file is marked with round holes instead of criss-crossed lines and is called the "incense" file. The powder of ram's horn, mixed with salt and vinegar, is applied to the file before the lines are marked on it.

Awls are hammered out of wrought iron without any steel. Round awls are used to bind books while flat ones are required to sew leather. Snake-head awls are used to make perforations into wooden pieces by woodworkers. The needles of snake-head awls are 0.2 *cun*, with one side being like an arc and the other being concave. On both sides, there are two ridges used to draw ropes. Chicken-heart awls are used to drill sheet copper. Those with three ridges are spiral awls, while those with four ridges and pointed ends are called boring awls (drills).

2.5.4 Saws, planes, and chisels

Saws are made of wrought iron, forged and hammered into slices without any steel or the quenching process. After being burned hot and cooled down, the slices should be hammered repeatedly to enhance toughness. Then make saw-teeth by using a file. When a saw is used, the two wooden handles at both ends of the saw serve as the gripes, and a crossbar in the middle serves as a girder. Then wring a thin bamboo strip to straighten the saw. Long saws are used to cut wood open. Those with thinnest saw-teeth can be used to cut bamboo. When the saw-teeth become blunt, they should be filed sharp for later use.

Put the one-*cun* wide sharp iron slice covered with steel into the slot of the plane diagonally. The blade should be exposed slightly to make the timber smooth. It is called "zhun" in ancient times. Big planes face reversely and show the blades upwards for timber to be pulled on top of them. They are called "push-planes" and are used by woodworkers to make barrels. Ordinary planes are installed with a bar as wings by which they are pushed forward by woodworkers. There are centipede planes which can scrape surfaces really smooth and slick. On the wooden body of such plane are laid about a dozen small blades which resemble the centipede's feet.

Chisels are forged with wrought iron and have blades embedded with steel. The body is circular and hollow inside so that it can be installed with a wooden handle. When making a chisel, an iron pipe should be made first as a mould called a "ram's head". The way of making a chisel is the same as that for making the handle of an iron spoon. Hit the end of the handle with an axe so that the chisel is embedded into the wood handle. The chisel blade can be as wide as one *cun* or as thin as three *fen*. When used to dig a round hole, the blade should be made into a columnar shape and it is then called scoop chisel.

2.5.5 Anchors and needles

When it is difficult for ships to berth in storms, their fates lie with the anchors. Anchors of warships and sea boats weigh as much as a thousand *jin*. When making an anchor, make the four flukes first and then connect each of them with the body of the anchor by forging. For anchors weighing less than 300 *jin*, put an anvil with a diameter of one *chi* beside the smelter. After the two ends of the anchor are burned hot, remove the charcoal. Then nip the item with sticks covered with iron onto the anvil to be hammered. If the anchor weighs around a thousand *jin*, a shed should be built first. Many workers stand on the shed holding iron chains which connect to the two ends of the anchor body. There is one big hoop around each end to connect the chains so that the anchor could be suspended and turned. Everybody in the team makes a concerted effort to hammer the flukes and the body together (Figure 18.9). Screened fine old calcimine instead of yellow mud is used as bond. One should spray the calcimine onto the interface constantly so that the pieces will be hammered together without any cracks. Anchors are the biggest items made in the hammering process.

When making needles, first hammer the iron into thin iron bars. Drill small holes through which iron threads can be drawn on a draw-bench. Then cut the iron threads by *cun* into needles. File one end into a sharp point and strike the other end flat with a small hammer. Drill the eye of the needle in the flat end with a steel awl and file the surrounding part slick. Then put the needles in a cauldron and roast them with slow fire. After roasting, cover the needles with earth, mixed with pine wood, hardwood charcoal, and bean jam, and heat the

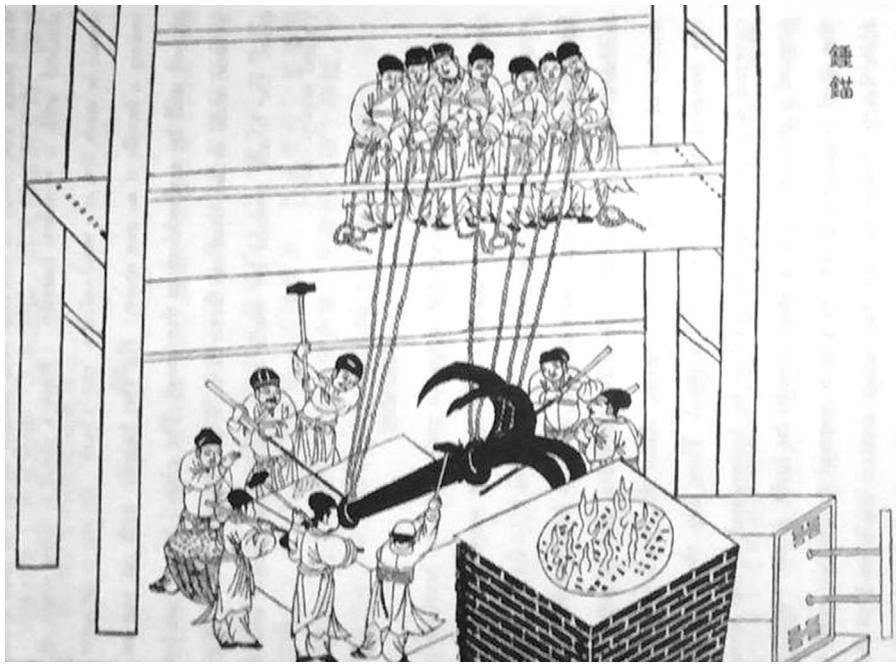

Figure 18.9 Making anchors

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 312.

cauldron from underneath. Use two or three needles to test the proper time and temperature of the roasting. When the needles for testing can be twiddled into powder by using fingers after cooling, it is time to take out the needles inside the cauldron and quench them in water. Needles for sewing clothes and embroidering are hard, but those for making hats by needle workers in Mawei Town, Fujian province are soft, called "willow-branch soft needles". The difference between the making of the hard and the soft needle lies in whether the red-hot needles are quenched in water or cooled slowly in a dying fire (Figures 18.10a and 18.10b).

2.6 Making of ceramics and porcelain products

Through the interaction of water and fire, clay can be turned into ceramics and porcelain products. Pottery is extensively used among the folk. Roofs should be covered with tiles to make them weatherproof. Walls and parapets should be made with bricks to keep the enemies out. Strong earthen urns can keep the wine fragrant. Clean goblets are suitable to hold offerings for sacrificial purposes. In the Shang and Zhou dynasties, sacrificial dishes were made of wood. With the techniques improved day by day, wooden ware is replaced by polished pottery. Some of the pottery is as thin as paper, and some is as white as white jade.

2.6.1 Tiles

When people knead clay to make tiles, it is necessary to dig two *chi* deep into the ground and choose clay without sand as the raw materials. Within a circumference of 100 *li* there must be clay suitable for building houses. Earthen bricks of tiles for ordinary people are all made from the quarter sections of a cylinder. A

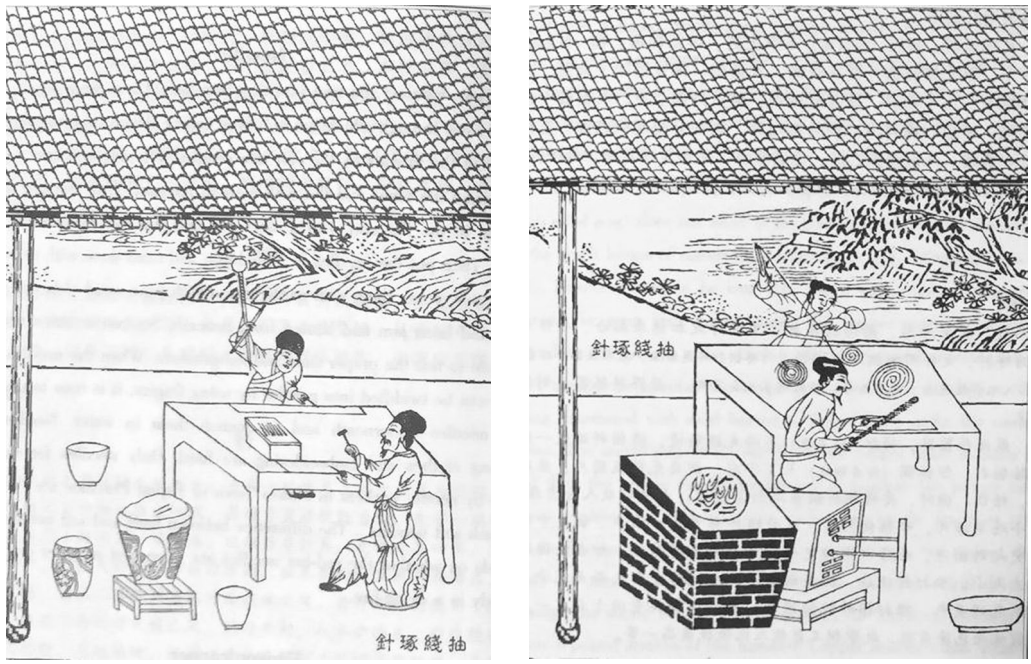

Figure 18.10a and Figure18.10b Final steps in needle-making

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), pp. 316–317.

cylindrical core mould is prepared, on the surface of which are four ribbed demarcation lines. The clay is mixed with water and made into a high rectangular pile. Then the moist clay pile is sliced by the iron wire of a bow, with the wire 0.3 *cun* away from the back of the bow. The sliced layer of clay is lifted like lifting a piece of paper and wrapped around the cylindrical core mould. When slightly dried, the sliced clay is removed from the mould, and naturally falls apart into four pieces. The size of tiles is not fixed; a large one can be nine *cun*, while a small one can be only three-tenths of the large one. The largest tile is made as the gutter of a roof for carrying off rainwater..

Tiles hanging on the eaves are called "drip tiles" (a kind of tile with drooping edge on one end); tiles beside the ridge are called "cloud tiles", while those covering the ridge are called "Baotong tiles". These tiles are all made by making semi-finished bricks first and then putting them in the kiln to fire to form different shapes as a result of the interaction between fire and water.

Tiles used for royal palaces are quite different from those used for ordinary people's houses. They are all glazed roof tiles. Some have the shape of boards; some have the shape of cylinders which are fired one by one by using round bamboo or polished wood moulds. Clay must be obtained from the Taiping Prefecture (Dangtu county, Anhui Province nowadays), which is called Taiping clay in the ancient time. After the semi-finished bricks are ready, put them in a glazed-tile kiln. Every hundred piece of tiles require 5,000 *jin* of firewood. Take them out to paint after firing. Water of decocting leaves of manganese black and palm can dye them green, while ochre, rosin, and aquatic grass can dye them yellow. Put the painted tiles in another kiln to fire; reduce the firewood and fire them slowly. Thus the tiles can have the beautiful colours of the glazed roof tiles. This kind of tile is used in the palaces of princes living in the provinces outside the capital city, and also used in the construction of temples and monasteries, although the raw materials and methods

of glazing may be a little different from one place to another. However, ordinary people are forbidden to use glazed roof tiles in the construction of their own houses.

2.6.2 Bricks

When people knead clay to make bricks, it is also necessary to obtain the right clay. Clay can be blue, white, red or yellow in clolour, and the clay in Fujian and Guangdong provinces is mostly red, and the blue clay, also called "good clay", is found mostly in Jiangsu and Zhejiang provinces. The superior clay is adhesive but not loose, fine and without sand. Draw water from a well and moisten the clay. Drive several cattle to tread on the clay until the clay becomes a thick paste. Fill the thick paste in a wooden frame, then scrape its surface with a wire-strung bow to form unbaked bricks.

Bricks used to build walls in towns and walls of ordinary people's houses are solid bricks and hollow bricks. The solid bricks are oblong, used to build rampart walls and walls of rich people's houses; bricks are placed solidly one upon another. But economical people lay a tier of hollow bricks between two tiers of solid bricks and they also fill the hollow bricks with earth and stone. Besides bricks used for building walls, there are bricks used to pave the ground, called "square frame bricks" and those used to hold tiles on rafters are called "Huangban bricks". Bricks used to build vaulted bridges, archways, and graves are called "knife bricks" or "*curved* bricks". One side of the knife brick is cut off wedgewise; when these bricks are packed closely together to form an arch, the structure will not collapse and can stand the great stress of chariots. When making square frame bricks, put clay in a frame and cover it with a flat board. Then two persons step on the board to pack the mass and ensure the solidity of the unbaked brick. Knife bricks are a little more expensive than wall bricks; Huangban bricks are ten times as cheap as wall bricks, while square frame bricks are ten times the cost of ordinary wall bricks.

After the unbaked bricks are made and dried, put them into a kiln to fire . It takes a day and a night to make every 3,000 *jin* of bricks, so if there are 6,000 *jin* in the kiln, it takes two days and two nights. Fuel for firing bricks can either be firewood or coal. Bricks fired by firewood will be bluish gray, while those fired by coal are white in colour. Make three holes on the top of the firewood kiln to let the smoke out. When the firing is finished and the fire is withdrawn, these holes are sealed with mud, and then water is used for the superficial glazing in the quenching of the bricks. If bricks are not fired enough, lacking of one-tenth time of firing, glaze colours will not be bright; if bricks lack three-tenths time of firing, the bricks are called slightly-fired bricks, which remain to be the colour of the original unbaked bricks. If bricks are fired one-tenth time longer, there will be cracks on the surface; if the bricks are fired three-tenth longer, they will be bent and shrunk. Such bricks can fracture and are easily smashed, unsuitable for any practical use. Clever people bury them under the walls as the foot of the walls, also having the function of bricks.

Open a hole on the top of the kiln, with its four sides a little higher, and pour water into the kiln. Four *dan* of water is needed for every 3,000 *jin* of bricks or tiles. Hydrosphere permeates into the kiln and interacts with fire inside the kiln. As a result of such an interaction, strong and durable bricks are made (Figure 18.11). A coal kiln is two times higher than a firewood kiln, with the upper arch contracting gradually, but not closed. Inside the kiln, lay coal cakes of one *chi* and five *cun* in diameter. Lay a tier of bricks between every two tiers of coal cakes. Lay reeds and firewood at the bottom in order to burn the firewood or coal more easily. Brickyards that produce big bricks and bricks for the royalty are located in Linqing, Shandong province.

Previously many different types of bricks were produced, such as "secondary brick," "tally brick," "flat-bodied brick," "lookboard brick," "axe-blade," "square brick" and so forth, but the production of half of these bricks stopped later. When shipping these bricks to the capital city of Beijing, each boat/ship carrying food supplies is allowed to carry forty bricks, and each privately-owned boat/ship, twenty bricks only. Fine-grained square bricks used for paving the main halls of the royalty are produced in Suzhou, in eastern China and shipped northward.

Figure 18.11 Superficial glazing of bricks and tiles by water-quenching

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 333.

2.6.3 Water jars and the like

Many utensils for daily use made by potters have a big paunch and a small opening. There are big utensils like heavy water jars, medium utensils like bowls, and small utensils like vases. The shape and size of the utensils are different from place to place, but all of them are round, not square.

The experienced potters can measure with their eyes the amount of clay needed for an article and are able to take almost the exact amount into his hands and place it on the revolving potter's wheel, with the help of another person; then with one single moulding a utensil is made. However, the large "dragon and phoenix jars" for the imperial court are made with a completely different method. That is why the price is fifty or one hundred times higher than that of ordinary jars.

The ears and mouths on bottles and utensils with big paunches and small openings are made separately and then affixed to the body by a liquid glaze. Pottery has a bottom, but that without a bottom is called a steamer which is used in Shanxi province, northwestern China to steam food; it is made with tiles, not wood. Refined pottery is glazed both outside and inside, while the roughly made ones are half glazed. Only pans made from clay and sand, and earthen bowls are not glazed inside to keep their inside rough and astringent, for easy grinding. Vats and jars made of clay and sand are also not glazed for them to conduct heat easily when cooking food (Figure 18.12). Glazes, made from *pleris serrulata*, are produced in Zhejiang, Fujian, and Guangdong provinces and many other places in southern China. *Pleris serrulata* is used as a fuel for cooking, which is less than three *chi* long, with its leaves looking like cedar leaves, but do not prick hands. The raw materials for glaze in northern China remain unknown, and those in Suzhou, which are used when making the yellow jars, are also different. However, glaze for the "dragon and phoenix jars" for the royal family is made from manganese black and palm for sure.

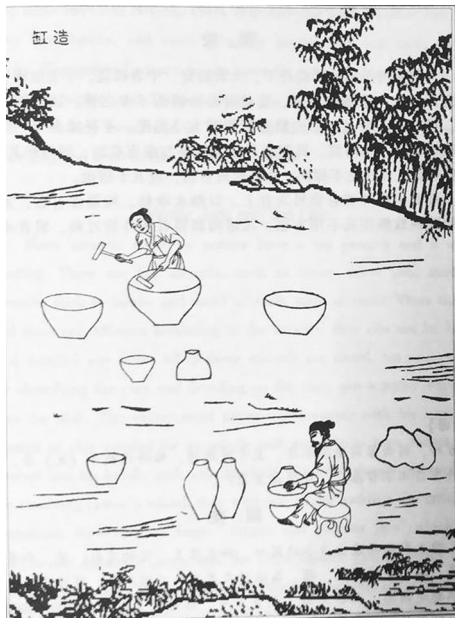

Figure 18.12 Making large jars

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 335.

A flask kiln is used to fire small utensils, while a vat kiln is used to fire big ones. When making a big opening vat, turn the wheel to divide the earthen bricks into two and connect them again later. Knock the inside and outside of the connection with a mallet. Divide earthen bricks into two as well when making jugs and urns with small openings; but there is no need to knock the connection inside. Fire the earthenware rings in another kiln at first to underpin the inside; knock the outside with the mallet, and the earthen bricks will stick together naturally.

Neither the vat kilns and flask kilns are built on level ground, but along hilly slopes, with twenty or thirty *zhang* as the longest and over ten *zhang* as the shortest. The kilns in different decades are connected together, with the new ones higher than the old ones. As kilns are built along the slopes, water can run down to avoid moisture while fire can climb up gradually. Pottery fired in these kilns is neither rare nor expensive, but it costs a lot of manpower and raw materials. When the brick kilns are completed, their tops are covered with a three-inch layer of fine earth. The walls of each individual kiln are equipped not only with windows every five *chi* to let the smoke out, but also with a two-piece double door that opens from the middle. Small utensils should be put in the bottom kilns and big utensils, like vats and urns, should be put in the top kilns. Light the kiln at the lowest position, with two men sitting opposite each other watching the fire to decide whether it is fired enough. One hundred *jin* of firewood is needed for about every 130 *jin* of pottery in the process of firing. When the fire is strong, close the doors. Then light the second kiln until the last kiln is lighted.

2.6.4 White porcelain products

White clay, mainly produced in five or six places, is the raw material used by porcelain makers for their finest wares. In the north, there are Dingzhou of the Zhending Prefecture (Ding county nowadays), Hebei

province, Pingding county of the Taiyuan Prefecture, Shanxi province, Yu county of the Kaifeng Prefecture, Henan province. In the south, there are Dehua county (the producing place is Yongding county, but the kiln is in Dehua) in Quanzhou Prefecture, Fujian province, Wuyuan county of the Huizhou Prefecture (Wuyuan, Jiangxi province nowadays) and Qimen county, Anhui province. White clay from other places is not sticky enough to make pottery with, but can be used to paint walls. Some porcelain wares made in the Zhending and Kaifeng Prefectures are a little yellow and dull. The aforementioned porcelain wares cannot match those made in the Raozhou Prefecture, Jiangxi province. Glazed cups and bowls are made in Lishui and Dragon Spring county of the Chuzhou Prefecture, Zhejiang province. During the Song and Yuan dynasties, there was the Zhang's kiln located at the foot of Liuhua Mountain in Dragon Spring, which produced precious porcelain products.

Jingdezhen porcelain produced in Fuliang county of the Raozhou Prefecture, Jiangxi province is the most famous and popular throughout the country. It has been producing porcelain products from ancient times, but the white clay, made into blocks, is transported there by boat from Wuyuan and Qimen because there is none in Jingdezhen.

There are no fixed moulds built for the making of cups and dishes. Place the clay paste over the mandrel that is made to revolve by turning the discs. The worker then presses his first finger over the bottom of the clay, while the thumb lightly shapes the clay body as the mandrel revolves. Thus a cup or a bowl is made.

In Jingdezhen the liquid glaze used for coating white porcelain wares is a mixture of water, clay from Xiaogangzhui, and ashes of the leaves from peach trees and bamboo, which looks like a clear rice broth. The liquid glaze is placed in a large jar. To glaze various types of wares, first put the liquid glaze into the inside of the wares and shake them so that the interior of the wares can be glazed. Then smear with fingers a certain amount of the glaze to the rim of each ware, and the glaze will come down itself and spread onto the entire surface (Figure 18.13).

Figure 18.13 Dipping clayware in liquid glaze

Source: *Tian Gong Kai Wu*, written by Song Yingxing, translated into modern Chinese by Pan Jixing, translated into English by Wang Yijing, et al. Guangzhou: Guangdong Education Publishing House (2011), p. 349.

Of all the glazing materials used in Jingdezhen of the Raozhou Prefecture, those produced in the mountains of Quzhou, Zhejiang province and Guangxin in Jiangxi province are the best. After being calcined, the glaze materials are ground into fine powders in a mortar (with a rough bottom without being glazed) and are then mixed with water. Make the glaze black when grinding it and make it blue when firing it. To make a "purple-cloud" colour crackled cup, first wet the ware with an aqueous solution of rouge, and then place it in a wire net and fire it over a charcoal fire. After that, brush the ware once with a pad of cotton wetted with rouge, and the colouring is obtained. This kind of coloured porcelain is called "Xuan red" ware. No cinnabar in the world can remain red after being fired. "Xuan red" was lost at the end of the Yuan dynasty and rediscovered when Emperor Zhengde (1506–1521) of the Ming dynasty was in power after many tests and trials.

3. Conclusion

In summary, the Chinese people made brilliant achievements in the field of handicraft in traditional China up till the Ming dynasty, contributing to the further development of the handicraft sector nationally and internationally. This chapter about the handicraft achievements in traditional China can serve as a research resource for the academic studies concerning the promotion of the Chinese historical heritage and the globalization of traditional Chinese culture in the era of global endeavours for cultural diversity.

Note 1: Equivalents of Chinese Units of Weight and Measure to Metric Units

zhang (丈) in centimetres	one *zhang* is 311 centimetres
chi (尺) in centimetres	one *chi* is 31.10 centimetres
cun (寸) in centimetres	one *cun* is one tenth of a chi, that is 3.11centimetres
dan (石) in litres	one *dan* is 107.4 litres
dou (斗) in litres	one *dou* is 10.74 litres
sheng (升) in litres	one *sheng* is 1.074 litres
jin (斤) in grams	one *jin* is 596.82 grams
liang (两) in grams	one *liang* is 37.30 grams
qian (钱) in grams	one *qian* is 3.73 grams
fen (分) in grams	one *fen* is 0.373 grams

(Ten *sheng* makes one *dou* and ten *dou* makes one *dan*.)

Note 2

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19

SOME MYSTERIES OF *KUNQU* MUSIC AND ITS MELODIC CHARACTERISTICS[1]

Lindy Li Mark

Introduction

Before 1907, spoken drama was basically non-existent in China. Certainly all the written dramatic genres dating from the Song dynasty (960–1279) contained both spoken and singing parts. Indeed, but for music, what we now think of as traditional Chinese theater would just not exist. Yet, throughout Chinese history, the music in Chinese drama has typically been seen as subservient to the poetic script, and not appreciated for itself, despite the fact that it is music that informs and organizes almost everything that takes place on the traditional Chinese stage. *Kunqu* 崑曲 is generally regarded as the performance mode in traditional Chinese drama that most perfectly united words and music, and it is also arguably the performance mode that has been most studied and written about. But even in the case of *Kunqu* music there remain many mysteries and imperfectly understood elements. In this chapter I will point out some of the former and try to improve our understanding of some of the latter.

The libretti written or adapted for *Kunqu* performance can be said to be the most literary of all Chinese drama genres and many have been read as works of literature. But I believe that it is the music of *Kunqu* that has sustained these libretti over the centuries since they were written and that is also behind their renaissance on the stage in recent years. Because music is perhaps the most abstract and intangible of the performing arts, and thus less amenable to verbal description, and also because the music of *Kunqu* is more complex than in most traditional Chinese dramatic performance modes, scholarship on *Kunqu* in English has tended to concentrate on the libretti to the neglect of the music.[2] In this chapter, I hope to try, to some extent, to redress this imbalance. We will see that in *Kunqu* the melody of the arias is much more than a mere amplification of the poetic language of the libretti, or an attempt to make the text more comprehensible for the audience. In fact, the twists and turns of *Kunqu* music actually make the text even more difficult to understand.

To provide context and to explain the traditional notion that music is subordinate to the words in *Kunqu*, I will begin by citing some orthodox historical pronouncements concerning the relationship of music to words that inform this kind of devaluation of music in Chinese culture both in terms of song in general and then specifically with regard to *Kunqu*. I will then show how this general subordination of music to words was intensified by the gentrification of *Kunqu* during the sixteenth century by the musicians Wei Liangfu 魏良輔 (c. 1522–1572) and Liang Chenyu 梁辰魚 (c. 1519? – 1591). Then I will discuss the specific prosodic/musical form that the arias in *Kunqu* take: *qupai* 曲牌 (tune matrices), and from there move on to describe the intrinsic musical characteristics and aesthetics of *Kunqu* music and finally illustrate them with an analysis of what is surely the most famous aria in all of *Kunqu*.

Words and music: some orthodox historical views

Chinese historical writings on music are replete with remarks extolling the human voice over the sound of musical instruments. Such remarks are found as early as the Jin dynasty (265–420). For example, in the biography of Meng Jia 孟嘉 (296–349) in the *Jinshu* 晉書 (*History of the Jin dynasty*), there is recorded this exchange, in which the voice is referred to as "flesh," string instruments as "silk," and wind instruments as "bamboo":

> Huan Wen asked: "When listening to performances, silk is inferior to bamboo, and bamboo is inferior to flesh. Why is that?" Meng Jia replied: "[Because the latter] is closer to that which is natural".
> 桓溫問: 聽伎, 絲不如竹, 竹不如肉. 何也? 孟嘉答: 漸近自然.[3]

The eight-character phrase in which Huan laid out the relative value of these three types of sound circulated very widely. Duan Anjie 段安節 (c. 830 – c. 900), for instance, included them in this statement:

> Singing is the [true] sound of music; that is why silk is inferior to bamboo, and bamboo is inferior to flesh. [It] is far superior to all other music.
> 歌者, 樂之聲也, 故絲不如竹, 竹不如肉,迥居諸樂之上.[4]

In the Yuan dynasty, when northern drama reached its zenith, Yannan Zhi'an 燕南芝庵 (fl. 1341), author of the first treatise devoted to the singing and diction of that theatrical genre, after quoting the same eight-character phrase, goes on to say, "To sing as a song is better than playing it on a flute" 取來歌裡唱, 勝向笛中吹.[5]

Whereas in the previous examples it is not possible to rule out the possibility that the voice is just being thought of as a musical instrument that produces sound, in the following quote there is no doubt that it is the voice's ability to transmit words that is being prized. In Xu Dachun's 徐大椿 (1693–1771) *Yuefu chuansheng* 樂府傳聲 (On the transmission of sound in song), a work on *Kunqu*, he wrote:

> For instance, as for the sound produced by a woodwind, even if it is played by the finest musician, and blown clearly and brightly, it can only distinguish the musical notes and make the listener instantly know what tune is being played, it can by no means reproduce the form of the words and let the listener know what the words are. Now the fact that woodwinds only produce musical notes and not the form of the words, this [the ability to do the latter] is what makes the human voice so precious.
> 譬如簫管之音, 雖極天下之良工, 吹得音調明亮者, 只能分別工尺, 令聽者一聆而知其為何調, 斷不能吹出字面, 使聽者知其何字也, 蓋簫管只有工尺, 無字面, 此人聲以所貴也.[6]

The preceding quotations were all written or recorded by educated men of letters who understandably would value the written word above music. Such valuation is hardly surprising as music is indeed difficult to discuss with words, spoken or written, even today. In a recent review in his column, "Sightings," Terry Teachout wrote:

> most writers aren't musicians (and vice versa). Music, after all, is the most profoundly nonverbal of art forms, so much so that it's difficult to describe or discuss in words without resorting to technical language.[7]

Teachout is writing about twentieth-century English language fiction that takes music as a significant topic, but his remark is nevertheless applicable to music of all times. Western music, however, has a relatively

long tradition of printed scores and music manuscripts, and composers of major works are by and large well-known and researched. Sheaves of drafts and revised scores have survived the ravages of time and can reveal much about the process of their composition. In contrast, the resources for the study of the composition of Chinese music, including *Kunqu* music, have been scant up until quite recently.

To begin with, the earliest extant musical scores for vocal music in China date back only to 1742. This does not mean that written scores were not used before then. We do, after all, have references to the titles of anthologies of vocal music from before that time that would seem to have included musical notation, but the anthologies themselves are not now extant. In fact, aside from exceptions such as musical notation for the seven-stringed zither, the *qin* 琴,[8] and notation for the four-stringed pear-shaped plucked lute, the *pipa* 琵琶,[9] examples of musical notation that predate the eighteenth century for even Chinese instrumental music are very rare.

It so happens that the oldest extant examples of musical notation for *Kunqu* are as old as the notation for any other kind of music for Chinese drama. They appear in the court-commissioned *Jiugong dacheng nanbei ci gongpu* 九宮大成南北詞宮譜 (Grand anthology of musical notation for northern and southern song-lyrics and music in nine modes[10] hereafter JGDC) of 1742–1746. This anthology contains melodic notation for 4,466 songs, of which roughly a third are identified as *Kunqu* melodies from specific plays; unfortunately, no information is given about the original sources from which the notated *Kunqu* melodies were taken.

The playwrights who wrote the plays that were performed in *Kunqu* style were often well-known and include in their number holders of the highest civil service examination degree and government officials. But the composers of the music, with a few exceptions, are largely unknown. There has also been precious little research and description of the specific characteristics of *Kunqu* music, and we do not know how melodies came to be associated with the specific texts in the hundreds of scenes that have been performed since the late sixteenth century and are still being performed today. With the exception of contemporary *Kunqu* music, that is, music composed since the 1960s, the music for only a handful of *Kunqu* plays can be attributed to any individual named composer. Even less is known about the method of composition or arrangement.

Why were musical composers in China, historically, not recognized and given credit for their creations? One reason was the lowly status of professional musicians, actors/singers in particular. These occupations were relegated to the lowest caste-like stratum of society that included undertakers, butchers, blacksmiths, landless laborers, and even criminals. They were barred from taking the civil examinations and generally looked down upon. A few professional musicians were able to rise to prominence among the elites of society and were mentioned by name in the writings of the literati. But, because the musicians themselves were probably not highly literate, and by and large the literati themselves did not tend to participate in music composition or record their participation in detail, we lack records that treat the actual process of the composition of *Kunqu* music prior to the twentieth century.

There are, however, two *Kunqu* musicians whose lives and work have been preserved in the historical literature: Wei Liangfu and Liang Chenyu. The accomplishments of these two people were critical to the transmission of *Kunqu* music up to the present time. Records of what they did, however, are sketchy and scattered among the notes and journals of various writers of the Ming (1368–1644) and Qing (1644–1911) dynasties. Since little has been written about them in English, I shall briefly summarize the process by which they elevated a local musical tradition (*Kunshan qiang* 崑山腔) into an elite dramatic performance mode that later become the predominant theatrical form of China until it was overtaken by *Jingju* 京劇 (Peking opera) in the nineteenth century.

The gentrification of *Kunshan qiang* into *Kunqu*

Wei Liangfu, a virtuoso vocalist in his day, is credited with the refinement of *Kunshan qiang*, the local *qu* 曲 (song lyric) singing style of Kunshan,[11] a town near Suzhou. Originally just one of several styles used to

perform drama in the lower Yangzi region, it was not held in high repute. The following passage by Zhu Yunming 祝允明 (1460–1562) can be considered representative:

> For decades the so-called *nanxi* (Southern drama)[12] has been popular for no particular reason. . . . Ignorant people and stupid musicians change [the tunes] at will, calling them *Yuyao qiang, Haiyan qiang, Yiyang qiang, Kunshan qiang*, and so on. They alter the voicing and cadences, making up things as they like, it is all really nonsense. If [such music] was set for woodwind and strings, the result would be laughable.
> 數十年來, 所謂南戲盛行, 更為無端 . . . . 愚人蠢工徇意更變, 妄名余姚腔, 海鹽腔, 弋陽腔, 崑山腔之類. 變易喉舌, 趁逐抑揚, 杜撰百端, 真胡說也. 若以被之管絃, 至失笑.[13]

Clearly Zhu, as well as other literati and musical conservatives of his day, did not find *Kunshan qiang* pleasing and objected to the way the music was created.

Based on my reading of a variety of sources, I have put together one version of Wei Liangfu's life and work here. Wei, a native of Yuzhang 豫章 (present-day Nanchang, capital of Jiangxi Province), came to Jiangsu and settled in Taicang 太倉, a city slightly north and east of Kunshan. During the Jiajing (1522–1566) and Longqing (1567–1572) eras, Taicang, Kunshan, and Suzhou, three cities along the lower Yangzi less than 100 miles of each other, were commercial centers inhabited by wealthy silk and salt merchants, powerful government officials who controlled monopolies of these commodities, and influential agents who procured luxury items for the court. The burgeoning commercial and political life of these urban centers supported vibrant cultural activities and entertainment industries from the sixteenth to the nineteenth centuries. Understandably, these cities became magnets for musicians, opera singers, artists, and craftsmen of all sorts.

Music, singing, play writing, and the consumption and production of musical theatre in this tri-city area and nearby Nanjing up the Yangzi, and Yangzhou up the Grand Canal, were popular as forms of entertainment and personal cultivation for wealthy patrons of the arts. It is not surprising that Wei Liangfu found his way there. That Wei was a virtuoso singer can be seen from a passage about him in Zhang Dafu's 張大復 (1554–1630) *Meihua caotang bitan* 梅花草堂筆談 (*Notes from Plum Blossom Cottage*):

> Wei Liangfu, styled Shangquan, lived near the southern gate of Taicang. He can harmonize with the musical modes and can "twirl a tune" [sing with a voice] like silk. [Aficionados such] as Zhang Xiaoquan, Ji Jingpo, Dai Meichuan, and Bao Langlang competed to study with him. . . . At that time in my hometown was a man named Lu Jiuchou who was also good at "twirling tunes." He was willing to take part in a competition with Liangfu. No sooner had he [Wei] mounted the platform [and opened his mouth] than Lu willingly agreed to become Liangfu's disciple.
> 魏良輔, 別號尚泉, 居太倉之南關, 能諧音律, 轉音若絲. 張小泉, 季敬坡, 戴梅川, 包郎郎等, 爭師事之 . . . . 時吾鄉有陸九疇者, 亦善轉音, 願與良輔角, 既登壇, 即願出良下.[14]

According to Yu Huai 余懷 (1616–1696), Wei Liangfu was originally a singer of tunes in the northern style (*beiqu* 北曲),[15] but found himself bested by a Northerner. So, he decided to devote himself to learning tunes in the southern style (*nanqu* 南曲). However, he found the southern style, which included *Kunshan qiang*, to be coarse and unmusical. Yu records that Wei spent ten years revising and refining *Kunshan qiang* without even venturing downstairs.[16] He found it especially unacceptable that the music did not conform to the tones of the words, making the lyrics unintelligible.

My interpretation of this situation is that Wei, being a native of Jiangxi and singer of the northern style, most likely found himself in linguistic difficulties when he ventured into the lower Yangzi region, which is Wu 吳 dialect territory. Wu dialect is among the most difficult of Chinese dialects: it has an unusually large number of vowels and vowel combinations, more tones than northern dialects (six), glottal-stopped final

consonants, and phonemes not found in northern dialects. Even today, northerners have great difficulty understanding Wu dialects such as Shanghai or Suzhou speech. Moreover, every sub-region, even different parts of the same town, has its own patois. Although Wei's home town Yuzhang is actually farther south than Kunshan, the *Gan* 贛 dialect that is spoken there actually has more in common with forms of Mandarin than Wu dialect. As a newcomer, Wei Liangfu would have been surrounded by Wu speakers who most likely did not speak any other dialect, just as he himself most likely spoke only Gan dialect. One can imagine that in the process of learning *nanqu*, Wei became acutely aware of relationships between the local language and the music used to sing it that would probably have been less apparent to native speakers of the Wu dialect, who dominated the writing of *nanqu*.

What resources might Wei have had to help him? Rhyming dictionaries have a long tradition in Chinese history, but they were typically compiled to provide information about standard rather than dialect pronunciations of characters. The rhyming dictionary with the closest connection to traditional Chinese theatre, Zhou Deqing's 周德清 (1277–1365) *Zhongyuan yinyun* 中原音韵 (Tones and rhymes of the Central region), was compiled to deal with a problem precisely the opposite of the one faced by Wei Liangfu. Zhou's work was written to help Southern Chinese unfamiliar with northern dialects write poems and arias in the *beiqu* style.

We shall never know what Wei Liangfu made of the differences between the official rhyming systems of the rhyming dictionaries and local Kunshan area pronunciation, or between literary and colloquial readings of characters, but he was probably pretty acutely aware of them. In any case, Wei devised a highly melismatic style of singing one word or syllable to multiple musical notes, later known as *shuimo qiang* 水磨腔 (water-milled melody). His treatise, *Qulü* 曲律 (On the rules of singing *qu*),[17] describes in detail how the voice should be used, the posture of the body, diction, melodic embellishments, and so forth. Most importantly, his treatise emphasizes adherence to the philological distinctions of vocalic and tone rhymes of the official system; he stressed the importance of ascertaining the phonetic features and tone rhyme categories and that articulation of these features should be clear; and that the music should bring out the vocalic and tonal contours of the syllables. Each syllable was divided into three parts (initial, medial, and final) and these parts were to be carefully distinguished whenever any melisma or extension was involved. For instance, in such circumstances a syllable such as *hui* 回 should be sung as *hu-wei-i*. Contrary to common belief, this practice often (I am tempted to say *always*) makes *Kunqu* lyrics even more difficult to understand; but *Kunqu* aficionados insist on the importance of the aesthetic effects of doing this (a point on which I strongly agree).

Unfortunately, not only is there not a single extant musical score whose composition or arrangement can be attributed to Wei Liangfu, we don't even have the title of such a piece. Although Wei cites quite a few *qupai* in his treatise, he does not name their composers or claim credit for them.

To complete the picture of Wei Liangfu's reform of *Kunshan qiang*, the contribution of his son-in-law Zhang Yetang 張野塘 (dates unknown) must be mentioned. Zhang Yetang was an exiled felon from Hebei. The crime that led to his banishment to Taicang is unknown, but it was probably not very serious, since being sent to Taicang, a prosperous city in the middle of a prosperous section of the country (the so-called land of fish and rice) was presumably not that great a punishment. Wei heard that Zhang was a great singer of northern style songs like himself, as well as a *sanxian* 三弦 (three-stringed plucked lute) player and went to visit him. Wei was so impressed that he stayed for three days and three nights, became fast friends with Zhang, and eventually gave Zhang his daughter's hand in marriage. Wei's daughter was also a fine singer and much sought after by many wealthy young men but Wei had declined to give her to any of them.[18] That Wei would be willing to give his daughter to a convicted felon instead is perhaps evidence that Wei's own social status was not high, although we don't know for certain whether the young wealthy men seeking his daughter's hand were in the market for a wife or a concubine (the latter is more likely, of course).

After Zhang Yetang married Wei's daughter, he studied *nanqu* with Wei. He redesigned the *sanxian* by reshaping the body and using special wood for its construction, making it more suitable for accompanying *Kunqu*. Other instruments that accompanied *Kunqu* singing during and since the lifetime of Wei

Liangfu include the following: *xiao* 簫 (vertical flute), *guan* 管 (pipe), *sheng* 笙 (mouth organ), *dizi* 笛子 (horizontal flute with vibrating membrane), *pipa*, *tiqin* 提琴 (a round-bodied two-stringed spike fiddle), *ruan* 阮 (four-stringed round-bodied plucked guitar), and *zheng* 箏 (bridged zither with thirteen to twenty-six strings, played with a plectrum).[19] Early sources on *Kunqu* music do not mention the use of percussion instruments, but as Wei Liangfu does mention the disruptive effects of percussion instruments in his *Qulü* 曲律, one can assume that they were certainly employed then, and they certainly became important after the *Kunqu* musical style was applied to theatrical performances (see the next section).

The type of *Kunqu* that Wei Liangfu and his cohort advocated was sung around a table or at banquets, not on stage, and with no costume or make-up and with only very minimal and restrained bodily gestures of any sort. Wei Liangfu referred to such singing as "cold singing" (*lengchang* 冷唱) or "cold benches" (*leng bandeng* 冷板凳), but it is more commonly referred to nowadays as *qingchang* 清唱 (pure singing). It is a style of performing and enjoying *Kunqu* closely connected to elite culture.[20] There is no definitive record of Wei Liangfu working on any play, or with any playwright. But it would not be surprising if he did on occasion collaborate with playwrights; certainly, playwrights knew of his work.

The *qingchang* tradition continues to the present in private homes, clubs, and on university campuses. The movement of *Kunqu* from the studio onto the stage is the single most critical step in the popularization and transmission of the genre to the present day. Virtually all of the items that are sung in present-day *Kunqu qingchang* clubs and private gatherings are from plays. The singing of non-dramatic songs in such venues is very rare today.

Kunqu on stage

The move for *Kunqu* from "pure singing" to the stage must be credited not to Wei Liangfu but to another musician, Liang Chenyu. One of the few *chuanqi* plays that can be attributed to an individual named composer is Liang's *Huansha ji* 浣紗記 (Romance of the silk washer), which was both written and set to music by Liang, probably with the help of other musicians. Zhang Dafu, continuing on in the passage from *Meihua caotang bitan* on Wei Liangfu quoted earlier, wrote this about Liang:

> Liang Chenyu heard [about Wei Liangfu] and emulated him. He researched and edited Yuan drama, and composed new works himself such as [his collection of *qu* poetry] *Jiangdong baizhu* [White ramie from east of the River] and *Huansha* [*ji*]. He also intensely investigated the principles of musical sound with Zheng Sili, and sang with Tang Xiaoyu, Chen Qiquan, and five or seven others. Like precious goods, his musical scores circulated in the aristocratic houses. When families of officials of "gold and purple" ranks wanted music they insisted on music in Liang's style, which was called "Kunqiang".
> 梁伯龍聞, 起而效之, 考訂元劇, 自翻新作. 作江東白苧, 浣紗諸曲. 又與鄭思笠精研音理, 唐小虞, 陳棋泉五七輩雜轉之. 金石鑑然, 譜傳藩邸戚畹. 金紫熠爚之家, 而取聲必宗伯龍氏謂之"崑腔".[21]

Huansha ji is the first play, ever, to be set to music by Liang Chenyu himself in the style of Wei Liangfu. Some scenes from this play are still performed today, but we have no details about how the music was composed, and whether or how the music might have been altered through the centuries.

Liang Chenyu, heir to a wealthy family, was quite a man-about-town, tall, handsome, and with a luxurious beard. He was a singer, composer, and writer of *qu* poetry. He disdained the civil examinations, devoting himself instead to, on the one hand, the family business, and on the other, to music, poetry, drama, and other cultural pursuits. He was known for throwing lavish banquets and staging his own plays. Courtesans vied to meet him and perform his works. His celebrity status and influence among society

elites was much greater than that of Wei Liangfu. This was surely because Liang was wealthy and not a musician by profession.

Liang's *Huansha ji* has forty-five scenes and treats the wars and intrigues between the ancient states of Yue and Wu (whose capitals were Hangzhou and Suzhou respectively). It was a huge success when it was first performed, and several scenes are still part of the *Kunqu* performance repertoire. We cannot be sure as to exactly what extent the later versions of the play that have come down to us reflect the music as Liang Chenyu composed it or had it performed.[22]

Liang's contribution to the transmission of *Kunqu*, both as text and music, cannot be overstated. Without exposure on the stage, *Kunqu* as a performing art would surely not have reached a wide audience and might not even have survived. As mentioned previously, virtually all of the *Kunqu* pieces performed today, whether on stage or at *qingchang* gatherings, are dramatic arias. As also already mentioned, the singing of non-dramatic *Kunqu* songs is virtually non-existent today, despite the fact that many examples are preserved in JGDC with musical notation.[23]

Musical drama was regularly featured at temple festivals, family celebrations of the wealthy, and most critically, for entertaining the emperor and other elites. However, it is not known which *Kunqu* play was the first to have been presented at court, or to which emperor. There is an anecdote from late in the Ming that has the first Ming emperor Zhu Yuanzhang 朱元章 (r. 1368–1398) asking a very ancient native of Kunshan about *Kunshan qiang*.[24] The fact that *Kunqu* became the national theatre during the late Ming and Qing dynasties was most likely the result of literati who favored this art form and brought it to the attention of the court.

The composition of *Kunqu* music

For practical purposes, next to nothing is known about the technical aspects of *Kunqu* composition, notwithstanding the following passage by the scholar of *qu* and translator of works on science Wang Jilie 王季烈 (1873–1952). In his essay "Lun gongpu" 論宮譜 (On musical notation), he wrote:

> In order to preserve *Kunqu*, musical scores are a necessity. Yet, as for all of the books on *Kunqu*, there are none about the making of musical scores. It is not a matter of secrets of the ancients that cannot be divulged. If you take several tens of versions of the same *qupai*, and sing them until you are extremely familiar with them, and then separate out the base text from the added words, and character by character carefully distinguish their tonal contours and voicing, as for the method of composition for that one particular *qupai*, you will be clear without being told. The reason that the ancients did not talk about their methods [of composition] is because they expected people to learn them as they learned to sing the *qu*. It is like teaching calligraphy, all you have to do is have the person copy lots of classical models; you do not have to tell them how to hold the brush, they will write well regardless. Yet I feel that, with regard to the methods of musical composition, to wait for people to sing the songs enough to realize them on their own is like having them grope in the dark, the wasting of time and effort is unavoidable. Therefore, I shall briefly describe the important points. The first is to establish the rhythmic structure; second is to distinguish the tone and voicing of the words; third is to recognize the primary melodic motifs; and fourth is to connect the musical scale tones. If these four aspects are understood, and you sing a lot and study the musical scores of previous musicians a lot, you will have learned more than half of what composition is.
> 宮譜為保存崑曲所不可廢. 然自來論崑曲之書, 絕無論及制譜之法者. 非古人之秘而不宣也. 苟能將一種曲牌之曲數十支, 唱之極熟, 而又分出正襯, 且逐字細別其四聲陰陽, 則於此種曲牌制譜之法, 已不待言而明. 古人所以不言其法者, 俟人自得之於度曲之際. 猶之教人習書者, 祇令人多臨古帖, 不必與論用筆之法. 而亦能善書也. 然余以為制譜之法, 待人多唱

> 而自悟, 究是暗中摸索, 未免多走迂途. 故將其緊要之端略述之. 一曰點正板式. 二曰辨別四聲陰陽. 三曰認明主腔. 四曰聯絡工尺. 明此四者, 再多唱, 多看前人所制宮譜, 則於制譜之法, 思過半也.[25]

This passage is, in reality, an admission that he, too, does not know how *Kunqu* music is composed and instead says that the keys to composition are in the text of the songs. No doubt it is possible to arrive at a melody by following the tonal contours of the words of a song; but I doubt there is any possibility that the multitude of exquisitely expressive melodies of *Kunqu* could have been produced by such mechanical operations. The complex *melismas* so characteristic of *Kunqu* are much too intricate to be created by amateurs, or even seasoned musicians, by such a process.

So, unfortunately, both the names of the bulk of the original composers of *Kunqu qupai* music, along with their methods of composition, seem destined to remain as mysteries. Or perhaps, the processes of creativity are simply not subject to description and analysis. The results of creativity can be analyzed, but the creative process itself, perhaps never. What I will do in the following sections instead is to analyze the characteristics of existing *Kunqu* music, more particularly, the melodies of the arias in the plays. Although these vocal melodies may seem a very limited part of *Kunqu* music, they are in fact the very foundation of what makes *Kunqu Kunqu*.

The musical scores

The expression *gongpu* 宮譜, in the context of *Kunqu*, denotes specifically song or play text, or an anthology of such, *with* musical notation written in small characters to the right of the lyrics either vertically as in JGDC, or diagonally in the so-called *suoyi* 蓑衣 (rain cape) style. To the best of my knowledge, JGDC is the only anthology that includes the word *gongpu* in its title. *Pu* 譜 by itself can refer to a collection of either dramatic or non-dramatic *qu* texts, with the *qupai* of the songs or arias specified, with or without musical notation, but usually *without*. *Qupu* 曲譜 can also mean a collection of texts with or without musical notation. The titles of all of the commonly used *Kunqu* anthologies with musical notation used for singing today have *qupu* in their titles (e.g., *Jicheng qupu* 集成曲譜 [Grand compendium of *qupu*; 1925], *Eyun ge qupu* 遏雲閣曲譜 [Stopping the clouds pavilion *qupu*; 1870], *Sulu qupu* 粟廬曲譜 [(Yu) Sulu *qupu*; first printed in 1945], etc.).

As mentioned earlier, JGDC contains the oldest extant notations for vocal music.[26] In the prefatory matter several sources for the material in the collection are mentioned. Some of the titles mentioned were published without musical notation and are readily available in that form, but so far, I have not been able to locate any versions of them that contain musical notation. Ye Tang 葉堂 (1736–1795) published a substantial series of *Kunqu* plays and scenes with musical notation from 1784–1795, but the *Kunqu* scores most in use today were first printed no earlier than the late nineteenth century, and are the products of the revision and rearrangements done by generations of professional and amateur singers.

Qupai and *qipai ti*: word and music in *kunqu*

When Wei Liangfu and Liang Chenyu gentrified *Kunqu* by refining the relationship between the tonal contours of the words and the music used to sing them, they also started 500 years of arguments over and preoccupation with that relationship to the almost complete neglect of the intrinsic aesthetics of *Kunqu* music. But to begin to address this lack, the expressions *qupai* and *qupai ti* must be discussed.

The arias of traditional Chinese theatre take one of two forms: *banqiang ti* 板腔體 or *qupai ti* 曲牌體. The texts of the arias in the former system are basically composed of couplets of lines of equal length in terms of the number of characters each line has.[27] The situation is very different when it comes to *qupai ti*. This is the case for a number of reasons but perhaps most fundamentally because of the very large number

of *qupai* that are used and how they can differ from each other in terms of such things as the number of lines and the length of individual lines, and how the lines are grouped into meaningful units, but also because of the great range of variation possible between arias identified as belonging to the same *qupai*.

I want to stress five constituent elements of *Kunqu qupai*: (1) the name of the *qupai*; (2) the prosodic formula or requirements associated with that *qupai* through that name, which include such things as the number of lines, the number of characters in each line, and the vocalic and tonal rhyme scheme; (3) fixed melodic motifs associated with and signifying individual *qupai*; (4) decorative motifs and cadence patterns shared among many *qupai*; and (5) tonality. The first two elements can concern only the text of the *qupai*;[28] the next three elements relate specifically to the musical aspects of *qupai* and are not normally mentioned, or even thought of, as part of the *qupai*.[29] As will become clear, I am particularly concerned to stress the part music plays in *Kunqu qupai*. Now for some discussion of these five elements.

(1) ***Qupai* names:** These (often referred to as "tune titles") are very imagistic and evocative. It is probable that most were originally programmatic and/or referred specifically to some aspect of the content of the music or lyrics of the song, but in *Kunqu* those kinds of connections between the title and the content of the song have largely disappeared. In *Kunqu* the name of the *qupai* signifies primarily the prosodic structure or *gelü* 格律 of the aria text. For example, in *Kunqu* any individual aria labeled "Lan hua mei" 懶畫眉 will typically have nothing to do with "being too lazy to paint your eyebrows,"[30] although you probably cannot rule out the possibility of some lyricist being influenced in some way by this title when he/she writes lyrics for this *qupai*, just as it is also possible for some reader to decide that there is some connection between tune title and content in a particular aria. But either example should be very rare. Such titles first and foremost stand for the meter and rhyme scheme of an aria text, and could just as well be a number, such as *qu* 1, *qu* 2, and so forth, all the way up to *qu* 2094 (the number of *qupai* names in JGDC).[31]

(2) ***Gelü*** : This refers to the prosodic formula of the *qupai*. This includes the number of lines, the number of base characters (syllables)[32] in each line, which lines have end-rhyme, and requirements for characters that appear in specific slots in the *qupai* to have a certain tone contour. Prior to *qu*, when Chinese poetic forms required that characters of a certain tonal contour be used in specific places in a line, for prosodic purposes the tones were divided up into only two categories, level (*ping* 平) and or oblique (*ze* 仄). In *qu* poetry, the formula for a *qupai* can also indicate, for instance, which oblique tone is required in a certain position in the tune matrix. An aria written for the *qupai* "Lan hua mei," for instance, should have a total of five lines, four of which (lines 1, 2, 3, and 5) have seven characters each, and one line (line 4) has five. All five lines must be end-rhymed with characters from the same general rhyme category, but the final characters of all of the seven-character lines should be level-toned and the one with five should end with a character with an oblique tone.

In modern Mandarin there are four tones. Tone one or the "high level" tone (*yinping* 陰平; e.g., *mā* 媽) and tone two or the "rising level" tone (*yangping* 陽平; e.g., má 麻) are considered even or *ping* tones, while tone three, the "rising" or the "dipping" tone (*shangsheng* 上聲; e.g., mǎ 馬) and tone four or the "falling" or "departing" tone (*qusheng* 去聲; e.g., mà 罵), are oblique or *ze* tones. The Chinese spoken in the north of China once also *had* a fifth tone, an "entering tone" (*rusheng* 入聲), but some time prior to the appearance of the *Zhongyuan yinyun* that tone fell out of usage there and characters that were originally pronounced with that tone were apportioned among the other "three tones" (*san sheng* 三聲).[33] At least one purpose for the compilation of the *Zhongyuan yinyun* was to help southern Chinese, whose dialects retained the entering tones, to deal with the "new" northern system that lacked it. The pronunciations of characters in the entering tone ending in unexploded glottal stops $^{-p,\,-t,}$ and $^{-k,}$ as in Wu dialect, the dialect used in the Kunshan area, retained the entering tone and has six tones divided between the level and oblique categories.

In addition, Wu dialect retains the voiced (*yang* 陽) and unvoiced (*yin* 陰) distinctions. I shall not deal with these factors in any greater detail and am just concerned at this point to just show how complicated things are. No wonder Wei Liangfu, a native speaker of a northern dialect, spent ten years sorting out the Wu dialect in which *Kunqu* is sung.

But what would an example of an aria written to the pattern for "Lan hua mei" look like? Following, I transliterate the pronunciation of the end-rhyme characters (in italics) according to how they are sung in *Kunqu*, *not* as they would be pronounced in Mandarin, but we can begin with a simple notation of how the lines scan: 7-rp, 7-rp, 7-rp, 5-rz, 7-rp (the Arabic numbers tell how many characters appear in each line, the presence or absence of "r" indicates the line is end-rhymed, "p" indicates that the tone of the final character is *ping* [level] and z indicates that it is *ze* [oblique]).

Here is a well-known example of the *qupai* "Lan hua mei". It is the first aria in the often performed *zhezi xi* 折子戲 (extracted highlight scene) "Qintiao" 琴挑 (Zither seduction):[34]

Translation:

Through light clouds, upon sparkling dew, brightly shines the moon,
By my pillow, from the four walls, crickets sadly croon.
Mourning the autumn season, Song Yu composed "Ode to the West Wind,"
Falling leaves shatter my lingering dreams.
Strolling the fragrant path, I count the fallen crimson.

月明云淡露華濃, 倚枕愁聽四壁蟲. 傷秋宋玉賦西風,
落葉驚殘夢. 閒步芳塵數落紅.

Each *qupai*, of course, has its own specifications as to how many lines, how many characters each line has, and where the rhyme falls. Some *qupai* can be very long. For example, "Shanpo yang" 山坡羊 (Sheep on the hillside) is a long *qupai* that also has many variant forms so that the number of lines can vary from fourteen to sixteen. A simple notation of the scansion for a version with sixty-seven characters reads as follows: 7-rz, 7-rz, 7-rp, 7-rz; 3-rz; 3-rp, 5-rz; 4-rz, 6-rz, 4-rz, 2-rp, 5-rp, 2-rp, 5-rp.[35]

(3) Fixed melodic motifs (*dingqiang* 定腔): The third element is the most important element from the musical standpoint. Each *Kunqu qupai* has several *fixed melodic* motifs or phrases or sequential features associated with it. These motifs are fixed in the sense that they do not change and are found within the same *qupai* in any play performed in *Kunqu*. In other words, these motifs are the *leit motifs* of the *qupai*. I consider these to be musical motifs (sequences of melodic notes in the same rhythmic order) rather than themes, or melodies, because they are relatively short, usually between two or two and a half measures (8–14 beats), and tagged onto a melodic phrase, and do not stand as independent phrases or melodies. Fixed melodic motifs also do not constitute the main theme of the song, but they do tend to appear in roughly fixed positions, say, with the last two characters of the first or second musical phrase of a *qupai*. In some cases, the fixed motif may simply be a feature, such as a wide upward leap of a major sixth or more, up to a ninth (14 semitones) at a given point of a *qupai*. Listeners new to *Kunqu* will not recognize these as fixed motifs until they have heard many versions of the same *qupai*.

These fixed melodic motifs are integral to the identity of *qupai*, but there is no traditional name for them. Scholars of *Kunqu* of the early twentieth century, such as Wang Jilie and Wang Shoutai 王守泰, recognized their existence but called them *zhuqiang* 主腔, which translates as "primary melody". But I feel that "primary melody" is misleading because it gives the impression that different compositions of the

same *qupai* name are variations on a given melody, or theme. In so far as they form only a minor part of a melody, I prefer to call them "fixed melodic motifs".

Now I should explain the distinction between "variant" and "version" as I use these expressions. "Variant" implies that there exists a known base melody that is fixed, or relatively fixed, and which has been altered to produce "variations" on the same melody. "Version" on the other hand means that there is no known *ur* melody, but instead there is a structure that serves as a template. To give a parallel Western example, Bach, Mozart, and Beethoven all composed pieces based on the dance form "minuet" and they are labeled as minuets; but they are neither variations on some known minuet, nor of each other's minuets. In a similar vein, different melodies with the same *qupai* name are versions based on the same prosodic formula, but not necessarily variants of any given melody. However, sometimes when the same *qupai* is repeated sequentially within the same scene, it is possible that one instance can be taken as a variant of an earlier one. But that is not necessarily so, as the following case illustrates.

In "Qintiao," four arias written to the *qupai* "Lan hua mei" open the scene and are sung alternately by the male and female leads. Each of the four instances of "Lan hua mei" has a different melody, *except* for the fixed motif at the end of their first lines – this fixed motif is repeated in each of the four versions of the *qupai* without change. I would venture that it would be difficult to argue that any one of the four melodies is the *ur* melody on which the other three are variations.

(4) Decorative motifs and cadences: The fourth element consists of decorative motifs and cadence patterns that are common to many *qupai*. Some of these are optional and some obligatory. In the traditional notation system, decorative motifs are not indicated, therefore, it would seem that they were all possibly optional at one time in the past. Since the twentieth century, however, most of these decorative motifs are included in the notation and have effectively all become obligatory.[36] It is the use of such embellishments that gives *Kunqu* its unique style or *yunwei* 韻味 (flavour).

(5) Tonality: Traditionally, *qupai* are associated with a complicated system that theoretically includes sixty-four musical modes. By the Ming dynasty, the number of modes that were talked about had dwindled to twenty-six: thirteen heptatonic (seven tone) scales and thirteen pentatonic (five tone) scales. As far as can be determined from extant musical scores, only six heptatonic and six pentatonic scales were in use: they are transcribed today as being in the "keys" of D, C, F, G, and E, in that order of frequency. Very limited use of was made of B flat below middle C. I believe that the reduction of the number of musical modes over time is related to the adoption of the bamboo flute as the obligatory accompanying instrument to the singing, and the limits of the human voice.

From the preceding five elements it can be seen, that *qu* is a form of song lyric with prescribed prosodic features, including a specific number of lines that contain *uneven* numbers of base characters, and vocalic and tonal rhyme. *Qu* writers have the liberty of adding *chenzi* 襯字 (extrametrical padding words or syllables). *Chenzi* are typically placed before the first basic character in a line, where it is comparatively easy to insert them, or sometimes before one of the pauses within a line. They are closer to prose than the rest of the line, which would typically be written with the kinds of allusions, ellipses, and indirectness expected in poetry. Their main function is to help clarify the meaning of the line in which they occur, or provide emphasis. Tang Xianzu 湯顯祖 (1550–1616), is notorious among the dramatists of his day or later for adding what critics felt to be too many *chenzi*.

In summary, the five elements of *qupai* discussed here serve to separate *qu* as a genre from other types of heterometric poetry. At the same time, they serve to distinguish individual *qupai* from each other and provide common elements that can be found in individual examples of the same *qupai*. I have avoided discussing rhythm in this section because I have not found any consistent rhythmic patterns associated with a given *qupai* but will address the role of rhythm in *Kunqu* melodies in the next section.

Some characteristics of *qupai* melodies in *kunqu*

The general characteristics of *Kunqu* melodies composed long ago in accordance with *qupai* prosodics have never been described beyond fairly vague descriptors such as "water milled" (*shuimo* 水磨; which refers primarily to the heavy use of melisma in the arias), or *wanzhuan* 婉轉 (delicately flowing), and so forth. Such descriptions are not very useful for trying to say anything very precise about the music. This does not help with the problem that individuals who have never heard, or only heard a little *Kunqu*, seem inclined to say, that *Kunqu* is too difficult to understand. Considering the longevity of *Kunqu's* popularity, it should be no more difficult to listen to than any other kind of music. However, *Kunqu* does have stylistic and structural characteristics that are different from the kind of Western and contemporary music that most people are familiar with today. Unfamiliarity and not knowing what to expect makes any music appear inscrutable. However, with some idea of what to expect, anyone can appreciate the genius of this music. To outline what to expect and thus make it more possible to appreciate the music, next I present seven general characteristics of it.

1 **Lack of thematic and/or motif repetition:** A piece of *Kunqu* music, with the exception of a few *qupai*,[37] has no easily recognizable thematic repeated motifs. Repetition makes a melody easier to remember and when a piece is composed of discrete segments or motifs that are repeated instead of heard just once, a sense of progression is created. Most *Kunqu* arias are thoroughly "through composed" from beginning to end, that is, nothing is repeated. Unless one has heard a piece many times, it is indeed difficult to grasp the direction of the melodic progression while you are in the middle of it. Perhaps this feature disturbs the uninitiated listener as much as contemporary *avant-garde* music, in that in both instances the listener does not know what to expect. The characteristic of the non-repetitiveness of internal elements within *Kunqu* arias makes them different from most kinds of music that we are familiar with today. Most, if not all music, whether Western or Asian, has extended themes, or rhythmic motifs, or harmonic progressions, that are heard again and again, repeated in different registers and keys, different tempi, with embellishments and variations, that are enough alike that the repeated elements are recognizably repetitions or variations of what has come before. *Kunqu* melodies have no such repeats; even fixed motifs that are repeated in different versions of the same *qupai* are not repeated within the same composition. In other words, the listener will not even hear the fixed motif unless or until he or she hears another example of the same *qupai*. This means that the listener must learn to remember, or tolerate, long sequences of melody without the familiarity that comes with repetition. Melodic memory (the ability to recognize the repetition of musical elements) would seem to be a unique human ability that is both partly innate and in need of "fine-tuning".[38] Through repeated hearings and being trained as to what to expect, a hearer learns the "logic" of the melody. As an exercise, listen to any piece of Western classical music or popular song and count the number of repetitions of a melodic phrase or motif. Then listen to a *Kunqu* melody and try to count, or even find, repeated elements.
2 **Uneven phrase length:** Because the text of a *Kunqu* aria contains lines with different lengths (numbers of characters), the melodic phrases also tend to be uneven in length. Thus, rhythmic symmetry as a result of melodic sequences of uniform length also tends to be absent. In addition, cadence patterns are unfamiliar to the uninitiated. *Kunqu* phrases and pieces often end on the second degree or a minor third below the dominant melodic tone, a tone that might seem like a bad choice for the logical tonic or tonal center. Listeners accustomed to hearing a piece end on the tonal center or tonic might lose their sense of direction within the tune.
3 **Linearity:** *Kunqu* music is linear, melismatic, and non-harmonic. Pre-modern *Kunqu* music had no harmonic or contrapuntal accompaniment, but the melody makes up for these lacks with highly complex and elaborated twists and turns. The singing of a single syllable may extend over several beats and include scores of musical notes.

Kunqu's linear propensity extends to instrumental accompaniment. Traditionally (pre-1955), accompanying ensembles would play in unison with the voice with some heterophony and slight differences in embellishment. The ensemble was quite small, consisting of the obligatory *dizi*, occasionally substituted by a *xiao*, plus three or four melodic instruments. A small percussion section featuring a single-skinned drum, a wooden clapper, gongs, and a pair of cymbals punctuate the melody and accompany dance and stage movements. Small ensembles of this kind are still used for intimate performances, but those used for large-scale public performances are typically vastly expanded.

The *dizi* is by far the most important instrument. The vibrating membrane gives this flute a bright, penetrating timbre that does not overpower the singing voice. The *dizi* cues the singer at the beginning of a piece or phrase with an embellishment and then follows the singing in near unison. In the hands of an expert the *dizi* supports and amplifies the singer's voice rather than competes with it. The remaining ensemble plays in unison with the *dizi* with simple heterophony.[39] The percussion section requires two to three players, marks the tempo, creates excitement where the action calls for excitement, and adds to the expression.

The ensemble is traditionally called the *ba da jian* 八大件 (eight big pieces), although in reality the number of instruments may vary. Seven or eight musicians are required, most of them are multi-instrumentalists. Traditionally, the ensemble was seated either at the back of the stage or on one side of the stage (the stage left side was preferred because they would be facing the actors when they made their entrances) where the players can see the actors and coordinate the music with their movement. This also allows the audience to see the ensemble as part of the show and to use visual information from watching the interaction between the ensemble and the actors to get a deeper and more concrete idea of how they work together to create a whole greater than the sum of the parts.

4 **Rhythm, metre, and tempo:** *Kunqu* has rather simple rhythmic patterns: free rhythm, duple rhythms of four (4) beat units, and twice four (4 + 4) or eight beat units are the most commonly used; two-beat units are used for fast and exciting passages. There are no triple (three beat) rhythms in *Kunqu*. A unit here is equivalent to a *measure* in Western notation and I shall use the term "measure" in this essay because modern Chinese musicians have adopted this concept and the practice of bar lining. Normally a piece begins with a phrase or two in *rubato* (i.e., unmetered rhythm), followed by a metered section with regular beats. The metered section of a piece may begin on the first or the third beat.

A peculiarity of *Kunqu* rhythm is the lack of strong contrast between strong and weak beats. Although beats are theoretically grouped into fours (4) or eights (4 + 4), it is often difficult to distinguish the beginning of a *measure* by a stronger stress of the first beat, as in Western music. That is because the clapping of the *ban* 板 (a wooden clapper made of slabs of hardwood that are "clapped" together), rather than stress, is used to signal the first beat of a measure (these first beats are also referred to as *ban*, which is also used to refer to the groupings of two [fast], four, or eight beats that make up a measure). The other beats are played on a small single-skinned drum, slightly lower in pitch than the clapper. A *ban* group of four beats is written as a 4/4 measure in modern notation; and a group of eight is written as two 4/4 measures with a broken bar line between the measures, or 4/4 + 4/4. Lack of stress contrast in rhythm and meter is another characteristic of *Kunqu* rhythm that may cause novice listeners to not be able to get a firm sense of the metric regularity that is in the music. Listeners can recognize the first beat of a measure by listening for the contrast in sound between the clapper and the single-skin drum. Lack of stress contrast in rhythm and meter is another reason why novice listeners lose the sense of metric regularity, in addition to the lack of repetitive motifs.

Those who read musical notation will note one consistent pattern, which is that the singer always begins to sing the end-rhyme character, that is, the final character at the end of a line that rhymes with the other lines in the aria, on beat one, or the *ban* beat. This is the case even where the melody does not dwell on the end of the line but goes immediately on to the next line of text.

There are no rules as to exactly how many measures of music a *qupai* must have, therefore different versions of the same *qupai* may have slightly different numbers of measures. There are two reasons for this: first, the melody may be more or less complex in different versions of the *qupai*; second, the author may have added extrametrical syllables that distort the asymmetry that the lines already have. The use of *chenzi* is also one of the features of *qu* that distinguish it from *ci* 詞 (another genre of heterometric poetry).

Singing tempo is generally slow compared to modern and Western music. A major aria with 36–46 beats per minute is very common (electric or mechanical metronomes often cannot be set to beat this slowly). A fast two-beat rhythm might go as fast as 48–50 beats per minute and there are percussion passages that are faster, but seldom singing tempi. The slow tempi allow for the accommodation of the highly melismatic melodies. Longer text lines will have more beats than short lines, but in some cases short arias can have very complex melismas.

5 **Articulation and phrasing:** Stylistic features of articulation and phrasing in *Kunqu* are subtle and sophisticated. Because *Kunqu* melodies are highly melismatic, separating one word from the next is done by placing a slight stress on the initial consonant of each word. This stress feature is produced by a fast on-the beat grace note on the flute, or a push from the singer's diaphragm, or an anacrusis (i.e., a "pickup" note). To unaccustomed ears this performance practice may make the melody seem "choppy," especially to those who are more attuned to the smooth Western classical singing style that emphasizes the ideal that sonority is better amplified by stressing vowels at the expense of consonants.

Let me elaborate on this difference between Western and *Kunqu* vocal style. Modern popular song and Western operatic singing are largely syllabic, that is to say, one musical pitch to each syllable, or perhaps two or three musical pitches, at the most. The *bel canto* style of singing projects the sonority of vowels, sloughing over consonants. As a result, it is often difficult to distinguish where one word ends and the next word begins.[40]

In contrast, in *Kunqu* each syllable is clearly demarcated by stressing the initial, and vowels are drawn out in long and complex melismas, sometimes with light glottal articulations and breath breaks. This sometimes makes one syllable sound like two or three. Also, in syllables with diphthongs and tripthongs, each vowel is fully drawn out in a way that further distorts the pronunciation. As noted previously, *hui* 回 might be sung as *hu-wei-i* over several musical notes. In my experience these stylized features make *Kunqu* lyrics hard to comprehend even when the listener has the written text in hand.

An additional feature of *Kunqu* melodic phrasing is its fine nuances of swells and *decrescendi*. Just as the strokes in Chinese cursive script can be curvaceous and vary in width and density and continuously flow at the same time that they are carefully articulated, so *Kunqu* melodies also flow up and down the scale smoothly and continuously but with contrast between sections and careful articulation at certain points. Dynamics are muted, as there are no big buildups of sonority. On sustained tones of three or more beats there is a swelling and *decrescendo* that is called *ganlan qiang* 橄欖腔 (olive melody).[41] Regrettably, this delicate vocal nuance that is part of the distinctive aesthetic of *Kunqu* singing is often overpowered by the use of modern orchestras with scores of instruments.

6 **Midpoint climax:** A *Kunqu* aria often reaches its high point near the middle of the piece rather than building towards a climax at the end. The highest pitch and most complex melodic turns are reached just before the middle of a piece. Of course, there are exceptions, but midpoint climax is a prevalent characteristic.

7 **Mode or key:** A common misconception is that all Chinese music is exclusively pentatonic (five tones with the intervals of the black keys on the piano). Actually, *Kunqu* has two modal categories: *beiqu*, which uses seven diatonic tones, and *nanqu*, which is primarily pentatonic but uses the fourth and seventh degrees of the scale sparingly in some decorative motifs. As should be amply clear

from above, *Kunqu* is a southern musical and dramatic tradition, but it preserved and made use of material from northern traditions as well.

In modern times *Kunqu* pieces are usually written with the designation of D, C, G, F, E, and B^b (below middle C), in that order of frequency. But it would be a mistake to think of the music as being in those keys. Insofar as melodies in pentatonic modes predominate, key signatures in modern scores function primarily to indicate pitch levels.[42] D is one step above middle C and is the most widely used pentatonic or heptatonic mode.

The characteristics of *Kunqu* music discussed previously can be summarized this way:

- Melodic linearity, or lack of triadic harmony and multiphonic treatment;
- Non-repetitiveness of melodic motifs, namely, *thoroughly* through-composed;
- Uneven length of musical phrases;
- Undifferentiated stress on beats. Duple metres only;
- Slow tempi: 36–60 beats/minute, rarely faster;
- Limited range of modal pitch levels, five modes/keys: D, C, F, G, E. Very limited use of B flat below middle C;
- Sparing use of the fourth and seventh degrees of the scale even in heptatonic modes;
- Highly melismatic and embellished melodic lines with stress on initials;
- Melodic highpoint toward the middle of the melody;
- Subtle nuanced dynamics, characteristic use of "olive melody".

A look at a famous aria

With the preceding outlined characteristics in mind, I shall analyze a *Kunqu* aria from the famous *chuanqi* drama *Mudan ting* 牡丹亭 (Peony pavilion) by Tang Xianzu. The iconic aria to the *qupai* "Zao luopao" 皂羅袍 (Dark silk gown), followed without interruption by "Hao jiejie" 好姐姐 (Good sister), is from Scene 10, "Jingmeng" 驚夢 (Interrupted dream). I shall refer to this two-part aria as one entity by the name of first *qupai*, "Zao luopao". To follow one *qupai* with another one in this fashion is a typical way to extend an aria, one that does not rely on repetition or variation of the musical material in the first *qupai*.

"Jingmeng" is the pivotal scene in the entire play and runs to forty to fifty minutes of singing and dancing when performed in its entirety. However, since the early nineteenth century this scene has been divided into two parts and is now commonly performed as two separate scenes: the first under the name "Youyuan" 遊園 (A stroll in the garden) and the second under the original name of the scene.

In "Youyuan," the heroine Du Liniang 杜麗娘 (Beautiful Lady Du), and her maid, go to visit a garden at the back of her father's official mansion. She did not know of its existence before her maid chanced upon it. The scene begins with Du Liniang entering languidly after being wakened by chirping orioles. Her maid comes in to coif her and help her get dressed to go into the garden. Upon entering the garden, Du Liniang is dazzled by the blooming flowers and lush greenery; at the same time, she is saddened that they are unseen and unappreciated (just as her own flowering beauty is hidden inside the mansion). In "Zao luopao" she sings of the beautiful springtime scenery and her melancholy:

Table

To hear how this aria is sung, readers can log on to any number of renditions available by searching for YouTube/Kunqu/peony pavilion online. My favorite version is the one in scene three ("Interrupted Dream") of the first part of the *Young Lovers' Edition Peony Pavilion*.[43] However, listeners should be aware that *Kunqu* is not sung in standard Mandarin and each performer's diction varies

slightly from the next. It might be useful, therefore, to have the provided transcription (Appendix B) in hand to follow the singing. The text in that transcription is Romanized more or less as sung, not as in Mandarin *pinyin*.

"Zao luopao" is the third major aria in "Youyuan". The melodic line rises gradually from the lowest note of the scale, forming arcs, and does not ascend to vocally difficult heights. Although the vocal range is not demanding, when combined with intricately choreographed movement the performance is physically challenging. This piece is the iconic *Kunqu* aria and almost always the first piece that every *Kunqu* novice learns, including music conservatory students.

In my opinion, the best way to appreciate the intrinsic musical quality of a *Kunqu* aria is to hear the piece as played on solo flute without the distraction of singing, costumes, and choreography.[44]

The transcription of the music for "Zao luopao" in staff notation is based on the version in *gongche* 工尺 notation in *Sulu qupu*, transmitted by Yu Sulu 俞粟廬 (1847–1930), who is recognized as the modern patriarch of the classical "southern" *Kunqu* style as it presently exists. His notations are considered the standard from which all modern arrangements have been derived, but his notations did not attempt to record all the embellishments that were known to him. It is perfectly natural, of course, that they also do not record the embellishments added or reinterpreted after his day. In the contemporary era, various singers and actors, including Yu Sulu's son and artistic heir, the late Yu Zhenfei 俞振飛 (1902–1989), have added or reinterpreted some of the embellishments, but even the embellishments that are associated with *Sulu qupu* are normally omitted in his notation.[45] The elaboration of embellishments has been spurred in contemporary *dizi* accompaniment by modern refinements in *dizi* construction and playing techniques. These refinements began with Yu Zhenfei, who, in addition to being the greatest singer, actor, and teacher of *Kunqu* in the twentieth century, was also a *dizi* virtuoso.

What can be heard in any flute solo performance is more than what is in the transcription provided here. This is especially true of the fast trills and on-the-beat grace notes. I have included some of the embellishments at the beginning of the piece to indicate their role in the accentuation of the initial consonants of syllables. To put in all of them would clutter the transcription beyond readability; the notation software is also not flexible enough to place them correctly. As I have indicated earlier, these embellishments are functionally related to the vocal aesthetics of *Kunqu* singing.

Now let me briefly explain the music of "Zao luopao" and "Hao jiejie".

Mode: "Zao luopao" belongs to the southern or pentatonic division of *Kunqu*. The original modal designation *xiaogong diao* 小工調, the most commonly used mode in *Kunqu*, is written with the key signature of D in cipher (*jianpu* 簡譜) notation[46] and I follow this custom in the staff notation. But this piece is not really in the key of D major because the 4th and 7th degree of the scale, G and C# respectively, are not used at all in "Zao luopao". A listener with Western music training might hear the piece as in B minor mode because of the frequent play on the minor third between B and D.

Melodic movement: Most of the phrases in this piece form rising and falling arcs, coming to rest on D or B (below middle C). The piece ends on B below middle C.

Uneven length of phrases: I have segmented the two-part melody into eighteen phrases based on caesuras in the text and, in some cases, on purely musical sense of cadence (see Appendix B). Phrasing segmentation here is, to be sure, subjective; another person might arrive at a different array, but they would be asymmetrical also, I believe. There are eleven phrases in "Zao luopao" and seven in "Hao jiejie," making a total of eighteen. By virtue of the difference in length of text phrases alone it can be surmised that there is no thematic repetition in this aria; even the three phrases that are equal in number of beats (phrases #7, 8, and 9) are quite different melodically. Even by closely listening to the entire piece the listener will not hear a recognizably repeated phrase. In fact, all six other pieces from "Stroll" on also have no repeated phrases.

Tempo and rhythm: The tempo of the sung parts in *Kunqu* is slow in general compared to instrumental, modern, and/or Western music. The first two characters of "Zao luopao" are sung in free rhythm or *sanban* 散板. The tempo begins slowly at about 32–36 beats per minute, gradually accelerating to 44–46 in "Hao jiejie". "Zao luopao" is set in four beat *ban*, written as 4/4 time (the two preceding *qupai* in the scene are set in 8/4 time); regular beat begins with the third character.

In this piece Du Liniang sings both of her surprise at the beautiful flowers in springtime and her regret over the unkempt state of the garden. The singing is livelier and the faster tempo accommodates the beautiful dancing as she and her maid circle each other and admire the flowers, pond, and rockery of the garden.

Embellishment and decorative motifs: When accompanying singing, the flute normally leads with a fast trill or grace note before the voice enters; then it follows the singing in close unison. On the first character of a poetic line, the anticipatory flute embellishments are especially noticeable, always preceding the singing by a fraction of the beat. As expected from the preceding discussion, if the reader compares the transcription with available recordings on YouTube, he/she will find many embellishments omitted in the transcription, as well as many other differences.

Instrumental *Kunqu* music: In this essay I have so far only focused on the music of the arias in *Kunqu*. *Kunqu* also has a body of purely instrumental pieces called *chuida qupai* 吹打曲牌 (blowing and striking *qupai*). These are instrumental pieces that accompany stage action without singing. An example is used in "Jingmeng" (Interrupted Dream) when Liniang and her lover, Liu Mengmei, first meet in her dream. Such *chuida* pieces are repeated again and again without change (or very little variation) for as long as the action requires.

In contemporary practice, *chuida* is sometimes replaced or augmented by newly arranged orchestral interludes using motifs or themes from preceding arias, a borrowing from the Western practice of using *leit motifs* to evoke associated moods. There are also some practical reasons for the adoption of this kind of incidental music. Modern theatre stages are frequently much larger than older venues and actors need longer time to reach their positions and complete their choreographed movements. Some productions also use stage scenery, which also takes time to put in place. Repeating the same *chuida* too many times would be rather boring.

Expansion of the instrumental ensemble: An innovation widely practiced since the 1970s is the employment of large orchestras of twenty or more instruments. In addition to multiplying the number of instruments traditionally used to accompany *Kunqu*, orchestras now include Western-style low-register instruments such as cello, contra bass, and a newly invented mouth organ with longer (lower pitched) pipes mounted on a stand. Cello-like round, bowed, lutes are another example of a newly constructed instrument used in expanded orchestras. Such large *Kunqu* orchestras are modeled after the *minzu yuetuan* 民族樂團 ("national orchestra"), which in turn are modeled after Russian style "folk" orchestras. *Kunqu* arrangers have also adopted Western musical techniques such as triadic harmony, counterpoint, and low base lines. These innovations require more instruments and newly modified instruments to increase the lower registers. Traditionalist *Kunqu* devotees (including this writer), and some listeners familiar with Western music theory find triadic harmonies incompatible with modal sensibilities. The "enriched" harmonies also tend to obscure the intricate melodic twists and turns and mask the subtle nuances of the singing.

In addition, because these large orchestras are louder and because they must be seated in the pit in front of the stage between the singers and their audience, the singers find it necessary to rely on electronic amplification to be heard throughout the theatre. *Kunqu* singers must execute complex and flexible dance movements that cannot be accommodated by the rigid body stance needed to project the voice in, for

example, Western operatic singing. Today a "classic" performance in a small theatre with "eight big pieces" and without the singers relying on microphones is a precious rarity.

Conclusion

The aesthetics of *Kunqu* singing are quite different from that of the vocal styles common in modern singing. The accented initial consonants sound "choppy" to unaccustomed ears; the tempo is too slow, the rhythm indistinct, the phrasing irregular, and lastly, even to Chinese audiences, the words are hard to understand. Yet this music has engrossed Chinese listeners and performers for 500 years. Since the mid-Ming dynasty until the late Qing times, *Kunqu* was the national theater of China, widely performed at court, in private homes of the wealthy, and in commercial venues, until its decline from the mid-nineteenth century. *Kunqu* is presently enjoying something of a revival. I would argue that both its past popularity and at least some part of its new prominence are intimately connected to the particular qualities of the music to which its arias are sung. Although that music is perhaps not immediately easy to understand or appreciate, it is amenable to analysis and I hope that the analysis of it that I have presented in this chapter will help more people to enjoy it.

Notes

1 The author wishes to thank the editor Prof. David L. Rolston whose patient advice and painstaking editing made this essay see print in CHINOPERL. Also, thanks to the editor of this volume Prof. Sin Wai Chan for willing to reprint the entire article, and also to Maney Publishing for granting permission to reprint the article."

2 "Technical" discussion of the relationship between music and words in *Kunqu* can be found in unpublished work such as Marjory Bong-Ray Liu's 1976 UCLA doctoral thesis, "Tradition and Change in Kunqu Opera" or Catherine Crutchfield Swatek's 1990 Columbia University doctoral thesis, "Feng Menglong's *Romantic Dream*: Strategies of Containment in His Revision of *The Peony Pavilion*"

3 Quoted in Koo Siu-sun (Gu Zhaoshen 古兆申) and Diana Yue (Yu Dan 余丹), trs. and eds., *Wei Liang-fu: Rules of Singing Qu* (Hong Kong: Oxford University Press, 2006), "The Supremacy of the Singing Voice – Aesthetic Judgement in Kun Qu Singing," p. xiii. This is a volume in the series *Kunqu yanchang lilun congshu* 崑曲演唱理論叢書 (*Writings on the Theory of Kun Qu Singing*), from the same press.

4 Duan Anjie 段安節, *Yuefu zalu* 樂府雜錄 (*Miscellaneous notes on songs*), in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng* 中國古典戲曲輪著集成 (*Collected writings on classical Chinese drama*), 10 vols. (Beijing: Zhongguo xiju, 1959), 1: 46.

5 Yannan Zhi'an 燕南芝庵, *Changlun* 唱論 (On singing), *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, 1: 159.

6 Xu Dachun 徐大椿, *Yuefu chuansheng* 樂府傳聲 (On the transmission of sound in song), *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, 7: 168–69.

7 Terry Teachout, "Fictional Musicians Rarely Ring True," *Wall Street Journal*, May 11, 2012, p. D10. In the first paragraph of this piece, Teachout writes: "I doubt there have been more than a dozen English-language novels of indisputable significance in which one or more of the central characters was a professional musician, and fewer still in which those characters were portrayed in a way that other musicians would find convincing".

8 See Bell Yung, "Music of *Qin*: From the Scholar's Study to the Concert Stage," in Joys H.Y. Cheung and King Chung Wong, eds., *Reading Chinese Music and Beyond* (Hong Kong: City University of Hong Kong, 2010), p. 13.

9 See Joseph S.C. Lam, "Pipa Stories as Cultural History of Chinese Music," in Cheung and Wong, eds., *Reading Chinese Music and Beyond*, p. 33.

10 There are actually more than nine modes in this work. Nine here is a figure of speech and means "all".

11 There is no direct evidence that Wei worked on dramatic texts.

12 *Nanxi* is generally used now to distinguish an earlier and cruder form of Southern drama that dates from the Song dynasty from the later, more refined form developed under literati input known as *chuanqi* 傳奇, but the use of the former term to include the latter in early writings was quite common and is presumably the case in this example as well.

13 Quoted in Hu Ji 胡忌 and Liu Zhizhong 劉至中, *Kunju fazhan shi* 崑劇發展史 (*The development of Kun opera*; Beijing: Zhongguo xiju, 1989), p. 47.

14 Quoted in Zhou Yibai 周貽白, "*Qulü* zhushi" 曲律注釋 (*Qulü* annotated and explicated), *Xiqu yanchang lunzhu jishi* 戲曲演唱論著輯釋 (Collected writings on the performance of musical drama explicated; Beijing: Zhongguo xiju, 1962), p. 67.

15 Yu Huai actually uses the equivalent term *beiyin* 北音 (northern sound).

16 Quoted from Yu's "Jichang yuan wen ge ji" 寄暢園聞歌記 (A record of hearing singing in Jichang garden) in Hu Ji and Liu Zhizhong, *Kunju fazhan shi*, p. 62.
17 See Koo and Yue, trs. and eds., *Wei Liang-fu: Rules of Singing Qu*. View all notes
18 Zhou Yibai, "*Qulü* zhushi," p. 68, quoting Song Zhifang's 宋直方 *Suowen lu* 瑣聞錄 (Record of the hearing of trivial matters), a Qing dynasty work.
19 Hu Ji and Liu Zhizhong, *Kunju fazhan shi*, pp. 62–68, quotes various sources for the development of *Kunqu* instrumental accompaniment. On Zhang Yetang's changes to the *sanxian* and the invention of the *tiqin*, see pp. 66–67.
20 For a detailed study of *qingchang* see Zhu Kunhuai 朱昆槐 (Chu Kun-huai), *Kunqu qingchang yanjiu* 崑曲清唱研究 (Studies in the pure singing of *Kunqu*; Taipei: Da'an chuban she, 1991). See also Ch'ung-ho Chang Frankel, "The Practice of *K'un-ch'ü* Singing from the 1920's to the 1960's," *CHINOPERL Papers* 6 (1976): 82–91 and Lindy Li Mark, "The Role of Avocational Performers in the Preservation of *Kunqu*," *CHINOPERL Papers* 15 (1990): 95–113.
21 Quoted in Zhou Yibai, "*Qulü* zhushi," p. 69.
22 A new version of the play in eight scenes was produced by the Suzhou Kun Opera Theatre of Jiangsu in 2008 under the name of the beauty who is the heroine of the story, *Xi Shi* 西施 (a.k.a., Xishi) Both the script and music was heavily revised and the result is a far cry from traditional *Kunqu*.
23 It is true that in recent decades there has been a movement to revive the singing of non-dramatic songs in the *Kunqu* style, which are referred to as *Kunge* 崑歌. I personally first heard *Kunge* sung at the Autumn *Kunqu* festival in Suzhou in 2004.
24 For the text of the anecdote, and a brief discussion of it, see Hu Ji and Liu Zhizhong, *Kunju fazhan shi*, p. 21.
25 Reprinted in *Jicheng qupu* 集成曲譜 (Grand compendium of *qupu*), 8 vols. (Taibei: Jinxue shuju, 1969), 5: 11.
26 See also Isabel Wong, "The Printed Collections of *K'un-ch'ü* Arias and Their Sources," *CHINOPERL Papers* 8 (1978): 100–29.
27 From this point of view, they are similar to the *shi* 詩 form in classical Chinese poetry.
28 Poets, for instance, can write *qu* poems which focus only on these two elements.
29 An exception, perhaps, is Wang Shoutai 王守泰, *Kunqu gelü* 崑曲格律 (Prosodic rules of *Kunqu*; Nanjing: Jiangsu renmin, 1982). Few *Kunqu* scholars deal as extensively with music as Wang does in this book.
30 Since *huamei* 畫眉, besides referring to painting eyebrows, is also the name of a kind of bird kept as a pet, the title of this *qupai* could also be transcribed as "Lan huamei," and it would then be the bird rather than the eyebrow painter who is lazy. The latter, however, seems a more likely topic for a song.
31 Some translators go to the trouble to translate the *qupai* names, while most, such as Jean Mulligan in her translation of the *Pipa ji* 琵琶記 (*The Lute: Kao Ming's* P'i-p'a chi; New York: Columbia University Press, 1980), just Romanize them. Some translators seem to feel that it is distracting to include even the Romanized titles in the translation, and either just cut them out, as is the case, for instance, with H. C. Chang's translations in his *Chinese Literature: Popular Fiction and Drama* (Edinburgh: Edinburgh University Press, 1973), or include them in an appendix keyed to roman numerals inserted in the text where the *qupai* names would normally appear, as Cyril Birch does in his translation of *Peony Pavilion* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, revised edition, 2002).
32 Extrametrical syllables/characters (*chenzi* 襯字) are not stipulated for *qupai*, and fewer are used in *nanqu* than in *beiqu*.
33 Here the other three tones are *yinping* and *yangping* (counted as one here), *shangsheng*, and *qusheng*.
34 This is scene 16 of *Yuzan ji* 玉簪記 (The jade hairpin) by Gao Lian 高濂 (1573–1620). The scene was originally named "Jinong" 寄弄 (Entrusting emotions to zither playing).
35 This is the scansion for the single instance of the *qupai* in scene 10, "Jingmeng" 驚夢 (The interrupted dream), in Tang Xianzu's 湯顯祖 (1550–1616) *Mudan ting* 牡丹亭 (Peony pavilion).
36 Richard Strassberg has translated the terms for and explained the application of the most common decorative motifs used in the Yu Sulu 俞粟廬 (1847–1930) school and also provided examples in staff notation in his "The Singing Techniques of *K'un-ch'ü* and Their Musical Notation," *CHINOPERL Papers* 6 (1976): 45–81.
37 An example of a *qupai* with repetition is an instance of the *qupai* "Chaoyuan ge" 朝元歌 (Morning song) in "Qintiao" (also known as "Jinong"). Here the first two phrases of eight measures (of 4/4) are repeated, and then repeated again in variation form. This is the only instance of the scores of *Kunqu* melodies that I have sung in many years that has a recognizably repeated theme.
38 I have argued for the human ability to remember melodic motifs or "melodic motif memory," 3M for short, in another article: Li Lin-de 李林德, "Qupai ti yinyue zhong 'xuanlü muti jiyi' zhi shenmei zuoyong – Yi 'Xuge' 'Zuihua yin' wei li" 曲牌體音樂中 '旋律母題記憶' 之審美作用 – 以《絮閣. 醉花陰》為例 (The aesthetic deployment of 'melodic motif memory' in *qupai* music: The case of the aria "Zuihua yin" in the scene "Xuge"), *Zhongguo wen zhe yanjiu suo tongxun* 《中國文哲研究通訊》 (*Newsletter of the Institute of Chinese Literature and Philosophy*) 11·1 (2001): 31–38.

39 Heterophony refers to a style of playing where two or more instruments play the same melody in synchrony but with added embellishments without disrupting the rhythm and tempo. Dixieland jazz uses heterophony extensively.
40 I personally often have difficulty following such singing even when the text is given in the program notes.
41 The metaphor of the olive is used because Asian olives are pointed at either end and full in the middle.
42 Here it should be mentioned that historically there is a complex theory of modes and pitches, but the modes are not utilized today. I believe that the adoption of the bamboo flute as the chief accompanying instrument, limitations of the spread of human fingers, and the range of the human voice (traditionally mostly male), precluded the use of microtonal distinctions.
43 Available on the DVD *Peony Pavilion: Young Lovers' Edition* (Hong Kong: Digital Heritage Publishing Ltd., 2008) or online. A bilingual version of the twenty-seven scenes of this production of the play, translated by Lindy Li Mark, is available in paper and eBook format from www.chinabooks.com and Digital Heritage Publishing Limited
44 "Master Kunqu flutist Prof. Zeng Ming's 曾明 solo flute rendition of this piece may be found on YouTube." (foot note #43) The sure source would be disc one #3 from his three CD set *Collected Kun Flute Compositions (performed) by Zeng Ming* 曾明崑笛集成 (ISBN 978-7-88409-987-0: 江蘇文化音像出版社 Chinese Language only.)
45 For details on the way that Yu Sulu annotated decorative motifs in his *gongche* transcriptions, see Strassberg, "The Singing Techniques of *K'un-ch'ü* and Their Musical Notation".
46 The actual flute pitch may vary as bamboo is extremely sensitive to ambient temperature and humidity. The precise pitch of the mode/key may also vary from singer to singer.

20

LEISURE IN TRADITIONAL CHINESE CULTURE

Ma Huidi and Liu Er

Introduction

In the five thousand years of its history, Chinese culture has nurtured a civilization with diverse cultural elements. The extensiveness and profundity of Chinese culture are shown in the philosophical ideas, the spiritual outlook, life aesthetics, and political institutions of China.

According to early historical records, the sage king Yao appointed Shun, who was later to succeed Yao, as regent and ordered him to systematize the system of rites; Shun, in turn, appointed Boyi to head the department of rites. Shun also put Kui in charge of music and musical instruction for young children, and Kui developed a theory of poetry and music stressing the function of poetry in helping people to express their will in words and that of music in accompanying those words and harmonizing relationships among humans and those between humans and gods.[1] By the Western Zhou Period (1046–771 BCE), the *liyue* (禮樂, rites and music) culture was already so well developed that Confucius, living in a later historical period, was to exclaim, "O, how culture flourished in (Western) Zhou times!"[2] Sons from aristocratic families were taught the *liuyi* (six arts) of rites, music, archery, chariotry, writing, and arithmetic as basic training to foster proper demeanor in them.[3] The rites were important for the boys to learn because that was how they could learn proper conduct for the aristocratic society. With the rites came the music played at various ceremonies and banquets. Archery and chariotry were useful arts for the aristocratic class with its military origins, helping the boys to become qualified soldiers. Writing, when developed into the art of calligraphy, would help the boys cultivate their minds; and training in arithmetic, with its logic and mathematical thinking, would broaden their scope and enrich their knowledge about the world.

From the preceding, it can be seen that leisure was intimately related to the *liyue* culture of ancient China, and to the social relationships in that society. Leisure of the ancients of China had profound meanings, with deep intellectual insights and distinctive forms. It is a path one enters through one's mind that helps to foster, imperceivably but surely, the virtues of benevolence, righteousness, courtesy, wisdom, faithfulness, cordiality, kindness, respectfulness, frugality, and humility. The profound meanings of leisure in traditional Chinese culture can also be seen through an etymological study of the Chinese word for the concept, *xiuxian*. The character *xiu* means quietude, in which one can undertake self-cultivation and reach high and noble goals, and *xian* means rectitude, or right speech and action. Leisure thus conceived was a very important part of the cultural tradition of China.

Leisure: an etymological interpretation

The Chinese writing system is, at its foundation, ideographic, having its origins in the totemic figures and paintings in the primitive society. It developed through several stages, from the recently discovered bone inscription of Lechang, Shandong, to the oracle bone inscription, the bronze inscription, the great seal script, and then the lesser seal script,[4] but has retained its essentially ideographic nature, closely associating the form with the meaning of the characters.[5] The characters *xiu* and *xian* both embody this distinctively ideographical nature of Chinese characters.

In *Kangxi Zidian*, an authoritative dictionary of Chinese characters compiled in the Kangxi Reign of Qing dynasty, *xiu* 休 is explained ideographically as "a person takes rest leaning against a tree". From the imagery of a person leaning against a tree, one can see the harmonious relationship between humans and Nature. But *xiu* can also mean auspiciousness, joyfulness, or blessing.

There are two ideographs for the *xian* 閒 in *xiuxian*, the one meaning a tree/plant in a courtyard, and the other, the moon (seen from) a courtyard, which vividly depict the leisurely moments one can spend "in front of flowers or in moonlight". There were many beautiful stories in ancient Chinese myths closely related to the moon, such as "Chang'e fleeing to the moon", with Chang'e being a beautiful goddess who, having stolen the elixir of her husband, had no choice but to flee to the moon. From this ancient myth, the Chinese envision the goddess dancing in the Moon Palace with her long sleeves fluttering in wind whenever they see the moon rising in the east, and the Moon Festival, celebrated on a mid-autumn night of full moon, has been instituted as a symbol of family reunion, since the Chinese word for reunion, *tuanyuan* (團圓), literally means "round". It is leisure life that brought into full play the ancients' imagination and ingenuity to yield such cultural creations. Mao Zedong, a poet with a romanticist spirit as well as a great political and military leader, alluded to this ancient myth in his lyric "Reply to Li Shuyi" (in the tune of "The Butterfly Lingers over the Flowers").

When studied etymologically and from the perspective of the intellectual history of China, the central meaning of *xiuxian*, as can be easily seen, has to do with the spiritual and the quality of life. As expounded by an ancient worthy, "the character *xiu* means quietude, in which one can undertake self-cultivation and reach high and noble goals, and *xian* means rectitude, or right speech and action".[6] In essence, the meaning of leisure was embodied in the life situation, the life aesthetics, and the spiritual outlook of the ancients.

Of course, leisure is first of all a necessity of life, as indispensable as clothes, food, shelter, and means of transportation. It is a physiological process, a state of life, a concept of time, and an aesthetical experience that allows for a resonance between body and soul in time, space, and life. The aesthetic act of leisure also provides a means by which one can come to understand the relationship between the subject and the object.

An important characteristic of leisure is that it helps to nurture the mind, the intellect, and the moral character of humans in an imperceptible way, which can be summarized as "getting into the path through the mind".

According to Professor Chung-Ying Cheng,[7] *xiu* and *xian* were interchangeable in meaning in classical Chinese. Each of the two characters can be an independent word in classical Chinese. The earliest usage of *xiuxian* as a word is found in the "Biography of King Si of Chen" in *Records of the Three Kingdoms*, in which is preserved Cao Zhi's poem "Xujie Pian":

> O, behold that fleabane fluff rotating in the air,
> How lonely it is in this world!
> Unrooted, it flies on aimlessly,
> Day and night without *xiuxian* (rest).

In *Juan* (Scroll) 100 of the *History of the Northern Dynasties*, we find the word *xiuxian* again: "Whenever he (Li Yanzhi) had some *xiuxian* (free time), he would stay home reading rather than go out to socialize with other people".[8] A search performed on relevant electronic sources shows that *xiuxian* appears 212 times in classical materials.[9]

From the pictographic nature of Chinese characters, the ancients' ideas about *xiuxian* may have been inspired by its antonym *mang* 忙 (busyness). *Mang* is a pictophonetic character, with the radical on the left being the pictographic element meaning "mind", and that on the right the phonetic element. The original meaning of *mang* is "hurry", or "being occupied" (thus antonymous to *xian*).[10] As shown in the common Chinese expression *mang si le* 忙死了 (too busy, literally "busy to death"), the mind is dead when one becomes too busy. Being busy for extended periods of time is not good for human development, as is implied in the following lines by the Tang poet Gao Pian,

> Being among the ant-like busy crowd of this floating world,
> I cannot complain about my hair having become white as snow.

Of course, *xian*, if understood only as free time, can also be detrimental to human development, as shown in another common Chinese expression "Idle to death", for one may simply idle away large amounts of free time, or begin to do bad things out of boredom. Yue Fei, a Song general, says in one of his lyrics, "Let not the hair become gray for naught, for then the fact would not change however one may lament". This is a warning that one should not waste time, for life would then be devoid of meaning as one idles on like a walking corpse.

How to balance between work and leisure has always been a difficult issue for each of us to address in life. Just because of that, "entering the path through one's mind" is the essence of leisure, for in leisure one's mind is in a carefree state. This is both a philosophical idea of the Chinese and the source of the aesthetics of life of the ancients.

Leisure: entering the path through one's mind

That entering the path through one's mind is the essence of leisure for the ancients can be seen from the *xinxue* ("mind" school) of Confucianism, which started with Mencius. According to this school of thought, "mind" is individualized, for it is what one thinks oneself. Believing that "the nature of the gentleman is such that the cardinal virtues of benevolence, righteousness, courtesy, and wisdom are inherent in his mind,"[11] Mencius advocated the theory that human nature is good, since humans are endowed from birth with the beginnings of benevolence, righteousness, courtesy, and wisdom. The "four beginnings" are sympathy, sense of shame, politeness, and sense of right and wrong.[12] He defends the inherent goodness of human beings, which goodness he believed could be retained and further expanded through introspection. The precondition for one successfully to perform introspection is quietude, for, as is expounded in *The Great Learning*,

> The point where to rest being known, the object of pursuit is then determined; and, that being determined, a calm unperturbedness may be attained to. To that calmness there will succeed a tranquil repose. In that repose there may be careful deliberation, and that deliberation will be followed by the attainment of the desired end.[13]

Quietude is a psychological state needed for one to undertake self-cultivation, and one that greatly facilitates introspection, for it is a necessary condition for one to be able to discover one's true nature. This philosophical basis served to enhance the mental state needed in everyday life that allows for tranquility, a broad perspective, and tolerance, and opened the way of thinking for the ancients' view on leisure that would allow for "entering the path through one's mind".

Centered on the concept of Tao, the Taoist philosophy of Laozi and Zhuangzi stresses the importance of "following Nature". It espouses "the Way of Nature", but also puts much emphasis on the spirit of the individual and the psychological state associated with it, strongly advocating that one should transcend ordinary knowledge and common desires to attain a state of existence with calm and clear consciousness. Zhuangzi intimates a kind of immanent transcendence when he says one can "wander on the vehicle of Tao and *de* (virtue)"[14] and "let his mind wander freely on the vehicle of material objects".[15] The essential purpose of this transcendence is the freedom of the mind. For Zhuangzi, there are two paths to the Tao, "one can achieve human happiness by entering a harmonious relationship with fellow humans, or a cosmic happiness by entering a harmonious relationship with Nature". The human happiness is freedom, while the cosmic happiness comes from considering all things equal. As a modern scholar explicates, Zhuangzi's concept of freedom is

> soaring through the infinite universe freely and surveying the earth with the insight that all things are equal, so as to liberate oneself from the shackles of human conventions, and from the hell-like state of human existence and attain a spiritual transcendence.[16]

The distinction made by Zhuangzi between the two paths to the Tao not only laid the foundation for natural philosophy in ancient China, but also enriched and deepened the Chinese understanding of the mind.

Wang Yangming, a follower of Mencius' "mind" school of Confucianism and also a great synthesizer of that school, had "extension of one's inherent moral sense" and "the unity of knowledge and action" as the foundation of his philosophy. He founded the Chuanxin Institute to teach his "mind"-school philosophy. Carrying on that philosophy, Nie Bao, Wang's disciple, advocated "attaining to the emptiness and guarding quietude", or undertaking the cultivation of the mind with effort to achieve a state where one can "act or remain calm without intending either way, and forget both the external world and the inner self".

Support for "entering the path through one's mind" can also be found in traditional Chinese medicine. In *Huangdi Neijing*《黃帝內經》(Inner Canon of the Yellow Emperor), one of the earliest texts on Chinese medicine, the role of the pacification of the spirit in both health care and medical treatment is propounded thus,

> When one is in the state of quietude, one's spirit is retained, but when one becomes restless, one's spirit would be dissipated. Extreme restlessness would dislodge the spirit, resulting in the loss of its guarding for the vital energy and blood, which would then be disproportionately consumed. With that, the balance between *yin* (陰)and *yang* (陽) is broken, and inner organs would be damaged.[17]

This shows that nurturing the spirit in quietude and *yijing zhizao* (tempering restlessness with tranquility) are important means for preventing and curing diseases.

Of course, *yijing zhidong* (attaining motion through tranquility) is also a form of *xinjing* 心靜 (mental tranquility). Confucius says, "I reflect on three aspects of my conduct every day". This shows the sage already realized that, in a chaotic world, the mind is apt to be tempted by material gains and fall short of being earnest. Thus, the gentleman is especially careful about his own conduct when no one else is present. *Yijing zhidong* highlights the importance of introspection, putting emphasis on the individual's power of understanding for reaching a balance between motion and tranquility.

"Entering the path through one's mind" is in accordance with the restraint, reservedness, and inclination toward tranquility that are characteristic of the Chinese, who tend to enjoy peace of mind in quietude and believe that wisdom more often comes to a tranquil mind. Indeed, when one's mind is tranquil, the muscles are at rest, blood circulation becomes more regular, breath becomes soft, and the body enters a calm state, with his or her visual and auditory senses and nervous system all at rest. It is in such a state that

one can focus one's attention to feel and perceive the good and the beautiful. On the contrary, "listening to multiple voices at the same time easily leads to one's being cornered,"[18] or, in other words, one should keep one's mind in tranquility, rather than undertake multiple endeavors at the same time, so that one can do things methodically and wisely. When one is too busy, one is likely to have a muddled head and be upset easily, losing peace of mind. When one is too busy, one is likely to take a shallow view on things, failing to examine them carefully and think in calm. Furthermore, when one is too busy, one is apt to become nearsighted rather than consider the long-term consequences of one's action. These are all valuable spiritual assets passed down to us from the ancients.

In many documents from traditional China, the highest state of leisure is associated with the individual's self-cultivation and elegant taste attained by entering the path through one's mind. Chinese philosophy was imbued with this kind of disposition and temperament from its early stage, which led gradually to the formation of the unique philosophical system of the "mind" school, with *xiuxian* and *xinjing* as its important elements.

The Great Learning, one of the most important Confucian classics, starts with the following paragraph,

> What the Great Learning teaches, is – to illustrate illustrious virtue; to renovate the people; and to rest in the highest excellence. The point where to rest being known, the object of pursuit is then determined; and, that being determined, a calm unperturbedness may be attained to. To that calmness there will succeed a tranquil repose. In that repose there may be careful deliberation, and that deliberation will be followed by the attainment of the desired end. Things have their root and their branches. Affairs have their ends and their beginning. To know what is first and what is last will lead near to what is taught in the Great Learning.[19]

This paragraph tells us that only when one can maintain a peaceful mind and take no rash action, can one handle things properly. It is a universal rule that all actions require the collaboration of the mind. In his *Jiezishu*《誡子書》(Admonitions for My Son),[20] Zhuge Liang, the Prime Minister of Shu in the Three Kingdoms Period who has been considered the incarnation of wisdom in China, confers broader and more profound meanings to the concept of *jing* (靜):

> The gentleman cultivates himself in quietude and nurtures his moral sense with a life of thrift. It is only with indifference to fame and wealth that his ideal can be clarified, and only with tranquility of mind that he can go far in realizing his ideal. A calm mind is necessary for studying, and ability can be acquired only through studying. Without studying one cannot enhance one's ability, and without a calm mind one cannot undertake any fruitful study.

This, together with the paragraph from *The Great Learning* cited earlier, explicates well the philosophical idea contained in "entering the path through one's mind".

The close relationship between *xiuxian* and *xinjing* is directly connected to the passing on of the "six arts" among the ancients. Theoretical support for this can be found in Confucian, Buddhist, and Taoist teachings.

The Confucians believed the individual is "aroused by poetry, learns proper conduct through rites, and becomes a fully developed person through music",[21] so poetry, rites, and music were the basics of the ancients' leisure life, helping to nurture the personality and moral character of the individual. From Zhou dynasty on, the "six arts" of rites, music, archery, chariotry, writing, and arithmetic were incorporated into official curriculum in education for the aristocratic class, making them required skills for leisure life. As a set of skills for leisure life, the "six arts" helped to cultivate refined taste for the aristocratic youths, forming a coherent system in terms of both practice and logic.

"Thus, the gentleman's approach to learning encompasses learning by heart, practicing, stopping to reflect, and traveling",[22] and he can "playfully dabble in the [six] arts in addition to the more serious work of perfecting himself through moral cultivation in order to attain to the Dao, and guiding his conduct with the principle of benevolence".[23] The central idea in these statements is to stress that the gentleman should cultivate himself in four cultural areas, namely, the Tao, virtues, benevolence, and the six arts. With that, he would be able both to enjoy a proper leisure life and to "enter the path through his mind" and reach an inner peacefulness and tranquility. The relationship between "mind" and "nature" shows that *xiuxian* and *xinjing* are similarly interrelated.

The "Xianjin" chapter of the *Analects*《論語.先進》records an anecdote: when Zeng Dian said what he most wanted was "in the late spring, when clothes for the spring season are ready, together with a few friends and several disciples, I would like to take bath in the Yi River,[24] have my body dried at the dance altar, and then return home, singing songs along the way", Confucius could not help exclaiming, "I quite agree with Dian!" It is not difficult to see that Confucius considered leisure as an activity conducive to the improvement of one's moral character. Confucius also gave an excellent explication of the dialectical relationship between work and leisure, and that between exertion and relaxation:

> Having a day of carnival after a hundred days of hard work is a blessing. Working hard continuously without relaxation is something even the sagacious Kings Wen and Wu would not be capable of, whereas being always relaxed is something in which they would not indulge. Hard work interspersed with relaxation is the way of those great kings".[25]

The idea expressed here has subtly affected the spiritual life in traditional China and the development of China into "a country of courtesy and propriety".

Laozi stresses that one should "observe in tranquility and examine the profound", believing that "tranquility can subdue restlessness, and cold, heat; for serenity is the right way for the world".[26] It is in tranquility that one can obtain insight into human nature and set to follow the Tao and reach the destination afar. Tranquility is here elevated to a very high position.

In his theoretical reflections, Zhuangzi advocates that one should transcend all things to be united with Nature. His philosophical ideas are highly romantic, mingling reason and imagination with his personal character. In order to reach the realm of the Tao, Zhuangzi believes, one should seek to achieve serenity of mind and a state in which one is well adapted to whatever circumstances he is in by drifting along with time and changing with things around him.[27] Thus it can be seen that *xiuxian* and *xinjing* are inherently connected to each other in the process of "entering the path through one's mind".

In fact, the "mind" school had tremendous impact on later generations. It not only greatly enriched Chinese philosophy, but also had important effects on the leisure lifestyles in traditional China.

Leisure: a spiritual outlook

With regard to leisure, the ancients believed in "entering the path through one's mind", i.e., the mind enters a carefree state in leisure. Thus, leisure was often related to natural philosophy, cultivation of character, aesthetic taste, literature and art, self-cultivation, and lifestyles in traditional China.

A notable class of people in the cultural history of China was the "literati with refined taste". A person in this class could be a civil or military officer, an aristocrat or a commoner, but was usually good at poetry, painting, music, and rhetoric, able to write elegant essays, and had great moral integrity. Whether being a court official or living in his rural home after losing a political battle, he was likely to enhance his life with a rich leisure life. Such literati were likely to "have a lofty mind and treasure his purity, aloof from mundane pursuits, and distain wealth and power".[28] They were talented and well learned, but did not want to be

officials although they had the ability required for the officialdom. They did not want to make the effort to enter officialdom, even less to fawn on those in power in order to gain some benefit.

Tao Yuanming, a representative pastoral poet of the Eastern Jin dynasty, exemplifies the spirit of the literati. His writings brought a great deal of fresh air to essay- and poem-writing of his time. The first of a set of five poems by him entitled "Gui yuantian ju" (Returning to a Pastoral Life) reads as follows:

From early in life I have been disinclined to mundane things,
But in nature I love life in hills and mountains.
By mistake I fell in the net of mundane pursuits,
And for thirty years was entrapped there.
Like an encaged bird I longed for the old forest,
And like a fish entrapped in pond I missed the deep pool that had been home.
Now at a time when people begin to open up wasteland in the south,
I have returned home to live a simple and honest life.
Here I have a dozen *mu*[29] of land for housing compound,
With eight or nine thatched huts on it.
Elms and willows shade the rear part of my house,
While peach and plum trees stand in the front yard.
Dimly I see a village in distance encircled in a ring of embankment,
With smoke from chimneys gently swaying in wind.
Dogs are barking in the long alleys,
While chickens crow on top of mulberry trees.
The courtyard in front of my house is dustless,
And I spend much time in leisure in an empty room.
Ah, long have I been imprisoned in cage,
But now I have returned to the life suited to my nature!

This pastoral poem sings of return to a life in quietude and represents the mind's pursuit of freedom and the poet's attempt to enrich life with leisure pursuits. Such individualistic spirit and self-cultivation became a model for people of intelligence today as well as those in traditional China and symbolizes their integrity.

Su Shi, a great litterateur of the Northern Song dynasty, had an unrestrained disposition and a deep understanding of leisure. In his essay "Lin'gao Xianti" (Spare-time Chat at Lin'gao), he noted that "rivers, mountains, wind, and the moon – none of these has a definite master; and it is *xianzhe* (those who know how to enjoy leisure) who receive their service". The *xianzhe* are those who have reached the highest realm of leisure, and Su's comment here is an excellent explication of the idea of "entering the path through one's mind". He summarized the leisure activities that can help develop a harmonious relationship between humans and Nature into sixteen kinds of happy occasions, namely,

Riding a boat in a stream of clean water not so deep,
Having a night chat while it rains outside the bamboo windows,
Washing one's feet in a stream in the heat of mid-summer,
Climbing up a tower to look at mountains after rain,
Wandering on a dam in the shade of willow trees,
Smiling in a dale with flowers around while drinking wine,
Listening to the bells from a temple in the mountain across a river,
Hearing *xiao*[30] being played by a neighbor to the east,
Enjoying half a stick of incense after getting up in the morning,
Having a rattan pillow to put one's head on at a noon nap,

Opening a jar of wine in the absence of Tao and Xie,[31]
Receiving a guest without having to put on formal attire,
Having one's wish for famous flowers to blossom come true,
Having a talking bird fly to one's side,
Drawing water to make tea when friends come to visit,
Playing zither in the presence of one who knows how to appreciate music.

With a tranquil mind and full of energy, such literati with refined taste were extraordinary and unworldly. They could be ordinary hermits taking abode in mountains or forests, or great hermits capable of keeping a hermit mentality even while attending the court or living in the market place. Wherever they live, they would be able to maintain the tranquility of mind and enjoy looking far into the future. Having "entered the path through mind", they could joyfully do enjoyable things regardless of temporal and spatial constraints. In so doing, they had peace of mind – and a superb aesthetics of life!

Xi (禊), a worship to purify people of inauspicious things in streams in the third moon of the Chinese calendar, was an old Chinese custom, but the occasion was often used by people of refined taste to gather for leisure activities. The most vivid record of such activities is about the *xi* that took place in 353 CE, or the ninth year of the reign of Emperor Mu of Jin. On that occasion, a group of literati including Wang Xizhi, commonly considered the greatest calligrapher in Chinese history, gathered at the Orchid Pavilion in Kuaiji Prefecture, where they drank wine and composed poems. Wang was asked to write a preface for the collection of poems thus composed, and he wrote one in 324 characters, which became a masterpiece of calligraphy. The preface is also a very good essay, with excellent artistic conception and style. Thus was produced a great work of art combining the charm of Wang's personality and the best of his calligraphy.

Throughout the history of China, groups of literati such as the "Seven Scholars of Jian'an",[32] the "Seven Sages of the Bamboo Grove", the "Eight Great Essayists of the Tang-Song Era", and the "Hanlin Academicians" had gatherings where they drank wine or tea, composed poems, or had discussions on scholarly topics, leaving many excellent works of literature in the process. Such refined activities of the literati had a strong element of leisure to them: on the one hand they got close to Nature while touring scenic sites in mountains or along rivers; on the other they produced fine works of poetry, calligraphy, and painting aided by wine. In so doing, they had excellent experiences of "entering the path through one's mind".

Reading books and playing Chinese zither were also common activities of the literati in their leisure life. Hence the saying "there are always books on the left and a zither on the right where a gentleman sits".

Reading was not just an important part of the lifestyle of Chinese ancients, but also a necessary path to one's education in rites and proper manners. Indeed, many a poet commented on the importance of reading:

If you have read ten thousand scrolls of books,
You would be able to write magically well.
– Du Fu, Tang poet

You may have only coarse clothes to wear,
But if you are well learned,
There would be a natural grace in your demeanor.
– Su Shi, Song poet and essayist

I sold the three *mu* of land near my house,
To add to the library piled up on my couch at the window.
– Du Xunhe, late Tang poet

> My house came to be of great worth
> After I planted my bamboos around it,
> But my family was impoverished
> Because I bought too many books.
> – Xu Hun, a Tang poet

All these show the importance of reading.

The Chinese zither was also much valued. As Liu Ji, a literati of the Southern Song dynasty, commented,

> Its appearance is beautiful, but without too much glamour. Its tune is sad, but without excessive sorrow. Though a plain instrument, it is capable of embellishment when necessary. It can be eloquent, but not to the extent of being dishonest.[33]

Liu Xiang, a famous scholar of the Western Han period, even says in his *Qinshuo* (Discourse on the zither),

> The zither has seven functions, 1) to clarify the Tao and De (laws of Nature); 2) to move the spirits; 3) to change customs for the better; 4) to make one more sensitive; 5) to create nice tunes; 6) to give expression to one's refinement; and 7) to aid the master's instruction.[34]

Thus, zither playing was used to stop immorality and maintain moral uprightness. The zither and its music were therefore considered befitting the sages. It was an integral part of the daily self-cultivation of the literati, who used it to create an ethereal and limpid spiritual world with a serene and peaceful atmosphere, in which they could keep their mind calm for appreciating and reflecting on things.

The materials presented in this section show that the book and the zither not only were symbols of a leisure culture, but actually helped to shape the multicoloured life in traditional China.

Leisure: life aesthetics

The lifestyles and values related to leisure among the common people in traditional China were greatly affected by Confucian, Buddhist, and Taoist ideas, which moulded the life aesthetics of the Chinese with an emphasis on combining diligence with intelligence, ingenuity with dexterity, and human nature with moral sense. Areas of leisure activities, including the cultivation of refined taste (such as zither playing, *go*-playing, calligraphy, and painting), composition of various forms of poems, practicing of *qigong* and Taiji boxing, meditation, and the making of fine artifacts, brought much fun to the leisure life of common people and, at the same time, provided conditions for creativity among the people.

The twenty-four solar terms,[35] which originated in the Eastern Zhou Period, is a supplementary calendar the ancients invented to guide agricultural activities around the year. It was also a guide for life in an agrarian society where people worked hard but also had joys and repose in accordance with Nature's rhythm. Rituals such as praying for rain and for good harvest, worshiping mountain gods and earth deities, rituals performed before ploughing of the fields was started in spring and before the harvesting of crops with sickles in the autumn, festivals to celebrate a bountiful harvest, and various customs were all associated with the solar terms. These rituals helped to uplift people's spirits, upgrade their ethos, and their ideals regarding values, as well as their aesthetic taste, which were all woven into a colorful picture of their leisure life. In the annual cycle of the solar terms, "all life forms are nurtured without mutual harm among them, and the Tao works to allow things to grow simultaneously without mutual conflict".[36] This view of Nature on the part of the ancients profoundly affected the development of their life aesthetics.

The term *xiaokang* (小康), which has been used in the development discourse in China in recent decades to mean a stage of development where people are reasonably well off, appeared as early as the Western Zhou period, as in "Minlao" (People are Fatigued) in the "Daya" (Major Court Hymns) section of the *Book of Poetry*, which contains the following lines:

> People are fatigued from working hard (throughout the year),
> And it is time they should have *xiaokang* (some peace).

meaning the people deserved a few days' relaxation after a year of hard work. The state where human life contains a reasonable amount of leisure was considered a goal for social development.

An ancient text records the following,

> Zigong[37] went to see the *zha* festival.[38] (Upon his return) Confucius asked him, "Ci, did you have a happy time?" Zigong replied, "People of the whole town acted like they were mad. I do not know what there was to be happy about." Confucius said, "Well, you did not get the significance of the festival. The wild enjoyment is a bounty for the people after they have worked hard for a hundred days".[39]

Confucius went on to explain to Zigong that, since the common people have to toil in the fields for most of the year, letting them have some relaxation from time to time would help to balance life and production, and to allow their physical strength recover after much exertion. Thus, the ceremonies on festivals were a kind of leisure activity, and occasions for collective spiritual purification.

The ancients well understood that "the tailorbird may build her nest deep in an immense forest, but the nest occupies but one branch; the mole may drink from the Yellow River, but he can take at most a bellyful,"[40] and thus were apt to be satisfied with a modest amount of wealth. They believed, on the other hand, that "honesty and kindness, in addition to good education, would help a family to propagate for many generations", a belief that allowed for a great deal of space for spiritual development in the agrarian Chinese society. The most popular embodiment of such beliefs was the *jiaxun* or family instructions (家訓), which usually consists of teachings and admonitions given to the younger by the older generation of a family, with an emphasis on the cultivation of morality, and on ritual propriety and courtesy. The family instructions highlight the important role played by leisure education for the family in traditional China.

Famous family instructions include *Muxun* 母訓 (Mother's Admonitions) by Mencius' mother and the *Jiezishu* by Zhuge Liang mentioned earlier, which are all highly readable, easy to understand, memorize, and recite, with the contents closely related to the leisure life of common people and thus easy to put to practice. For that reason, these family instructions became model texts used to rectify the demeanor of family members and to enhance family reputation that have been passed on from generation to generation.

The family instructions were held important because their main purpose was to uphold the virtues of benevolence, righteousness, courtesy, wisdom, faithfulness, cordiality, kindness, respectfulness, frugality, and humility. The content of a set of family instructions often includes the following: (1) Respect family rules and state laws; (2) Maintain harmonious relationships with relatives and neighbours; (3) Be filial to parents and respect one's elders; (4) Behave in accordance with rites and norms; (5) Attend carefully to funeral rites of parents and the rites of ancestor worship; (6) Cultivate oneself and attend to one's studies diligently. Indeed, family instructions were considered part of the educational system in traditional China.

In order to cultivate leisure with refinement, many kinds of leisure activities and facilities for such activities were invented, such as cock-fighting, hawking, keeping birds as pets, fish watching, fishing, riddle guessing, composing couplets, poetry clubs, kite flying, shuttlecock kicking, boxing, sword dancing, tea sipping, book markets, gardens, Chinese painting, various folk art forms, orchestral instruments, traditional Chinese opera, calligraphy, collecting and studying inscriptions on ancient bronze wares and stone tablets,

and many others. By dabbling in one or several of these arts, one was likely to acquire enough skills both to make a living and to enrich one's life. As the saying goes, "a humble skill well learned is more valuable than ten thousand *guan*[41] of inherited wealth". The "humble skills" often included zither playing, *go* playing, calligraphy, painting, poem writing, and other skills for a refined life. In small groups, people often went on excursions in the spring, watched chrysanthemum in the autumn, chatted while having wine, sipped tea, listened to storytelling, sang tunes from operas, or appreciated works of calligraphy or painting. They well knew one could be broken by toil extended over long periods of time, just as "the zither or bow string can be broken when strained too hard".

The grace and refinement of leisure activities in traditional China can be seen from the description of the Crabapple Poetry Club in the GrandView Garden in *Dream of the Red Chamber* 《紅樓夢》, the greatest classical Chinese novel. The aristocratic boys and girls living in the Garden all learned to compose poems and couplets at a young age, which is an indication of the extent of artistic taste and style in the leisure life of the wealthy class. Girls from ordinary families, on the other hand, would begin to learn *nügong* (女紅) needlework, or such as sewing, weaving, and embroidery early on in their lives. In the rich variation of pattern designs of *nügong* products, things are made very lively and give much joy to life, creating uniquely feminine aesthetic values. *Nügong* in many ways was an important part of women's leisure life of elegance and taste in traditional China. First, *nügong* could directly or indirectly nurture womanly virtues. Second, it helped to foster kindness and goodness in women, which was then outwardly expressed through their speech, postures, action, makeup, attire, and teaching. Third, it played an important part in shaping the role model of the mother for generation after generation of women, especially in their role of giving birth to a later generation, bringing up their children, and inheriting and passing on the feminine virtues through their own earnest practice. Fourth, it was a good guide for leisure life of the family, and helped to enrich the cultural and spiritual life of an agrarian society with its general shortage in material goods.

Generally speaking, there are seven items that are indispensable for life in traditional China, and those are: the zither, the *go*, the book, painting, wine, poetry, and the tea. Tea-sipping, for example, has been a leisure activity for several thousand years, and had a special place in the life of the ancients. Although it is among the seven items for everyday life (oil, salt, firewood, rice, soy sauce, vinegar, and tea), tea can also be a symbol of the refined leisure life and can show one's style and taste. For the ancients, tea-sipping was often associated with moral cultivation. For example, there is the saying "Gentlemen's friendship can be expressed with a cup of tea", which means gentlemen would pursue a pure friendship unstained by the vulgarity of the exchange of large amounts of material benefits. Tea-sipping is also a process from which one can derive much aesthetic enjoyment – after hot water is poured into the cup, one can watch the tender tea leaves gradually spread out, going up and down in the water, enjoy quietude while watching the vapour rising from the cup and then spreading into the air, and enter a state where one's expression can be described by the following couplet,

> Undisturbed by honor or disgrace,
> I idly watch the flowers blossom and then fall in my courtyard;
> Unmindful of staying or departing,
> I casually follow the clouds folding and unfolding in the sky.[42]

Tea-sipping is thus a symbol that aesthetic appreciation had become part of everyday life, purifying one's soul and enriching one's spiritual world as one grows, which helps to check excessive desires for material gains.

Lüyou 旅遊 (travelling) was also highly valued by the ancients as part of the leisure lifestyle. The word *lü* (旅) denotes "to make an excursion", but also connotes "common" and "right conduct". In other words, when one makes an excursion, one should observe social norms and conduct oneself properly, for one's conduct reflects both the degree of one's self-cultivation and the quality of one's upbringing.

You (遊), on the other hand, means "to walk leisurely". Thus, the ancients interpreted *you* to mean "touring at leisure when unoccupied with mundane affairs"[43] and "unhurriedness".[44]

The rich meanings of *lü* and *you* gave much inspiration to people in traditional China. For example, Dong Qichang, an eminent painter and calligrapher of Ming dynasty, said,

> Once you have read ten thousand scrolls of books and traveled ten thousand miles, washing off the mundane concerns in your heart in the process, then mountains and valleys would naturally build up in your heart, and become as beautiful and majestic as those in Juancheng in Shandong and Ezhou in Hubei.

He means that, on the one hand, one can gain much from travelling only if one has enough knowledge, and, on the other hand, only by coming close to mountains and rivers in Nature and intimately feel them can one's painting reach a high artistic caliber.

Xu Xiake, also of Ming dynasty, spent the greater part of his life in travelling and scientific investigation. In *Xu Xiake's Travels* 《徐霞客遊記》, the book that earned him the title "the ultimate traveler", he describes many geographical, hydrological, geological, and botanic discoveries that he made. But he became "the ultimate traveler" also because he constructed an aesthetic dimension and a standard for evaluating the grandeur of Nature and the beauty of humanity through his travels.

Leisure: social institutions

Traditional Chinese culture was profoundly affected by the governance structure and other political dimensions. Thus, political factors, especially political institutions had an important effect on leisure. The ruling class had very high expectations for the role of leisure, and as part of its governance gave rather specific directions on the passing on of the tradition of *liuyi*. It is apt to say that the ruling class of every dynasty made many achievements in this area.

Requirements for ritual propriety were very detailed, covering clothes, food, shelter, transportation, etc. For clothes and appearance, "The cap must be worn upright, the clothes must be properly buttoned up, and socks and shoes must be pulled up tightly".[45] For proper conduct, one should "neither look at, nor speak of, nor listen to, nor do what is not in accordance with".[46] For proper speech, "when rhetoric is based on sincerity, it helps one to achieve high".[47] At a higher level,

> the Varied Airs[48] were inspired by emotions, but checked by rites and the principle of righteousness. Because they were inspired by emotions, they reflect human nature; and because (the possible excesses) are checked by rites and by the principle of righteousness, they also reflect the grace of the early kings.[49]

A comprehensive and systematic set of rites and ritual rules were formulated into a system of ethical rules that served as a standard to constrain people's conduct in society.[50]

More than 2,000 years ago, Emperor Wu of Han dispatched Zhang Qian on a diplomatic mission to the "Western Region" (largely Central Asia of today). That endeavor led to the development of the Silk Road, which served to propagate the refined lifestyles of the Chinese to many countries to the west of China with silk, tea, and porcelain as the medium. Goods "made in China" became luxury items most welcomed by the aristocratic class of Europe. By 1820, China's GDP accounted for 32.9% of the world total, while all countries in Western Europe together accounted for 23.6%, and the United States and Japan accounted for 1.8% and 3.0%, respectively.[51] These figures reflected the economic prosperity and cultural flourishing of traditional China.

Another great achievement of the Chinese ruling class is that they created many cultural and artistic forms that persisted for hundreds or even thousands of years in addition to managing the country's economic prosperity and cultural flourishing.

Liyuan 梨園 (the operatic circle) flourished in the Reign of Emperor Ming of Tang.[52] The term *liyuan* literally means "pear garden". It is recorded that

> Xuanzong was knowledgeable in music and very fond of the *faqu* music used for banquets at the court. He selected 300 musicians from the Seated Section,[53] and undertook to give them further training in the Pear Garden. When there was any error in their performance, the Emperor was always able to tell and correct it. These musicians came to be known as the emperor's Pear Garden disciples.[54]

This is how *liyuan* was started.

In the *Yongle Encyclopedia* 《永樂大典》, compiled at the order of Emperor Cheng of Ming[55] under the principle

> all classics, histories, works of different philosophical schools, and collections of individual authors, including materials on astronomy, geography, *yin-yang*, medicine and divination, and other, miscellaneous, arts, are to be comprehensively incorporated in this encyclopedia, and the extensiveness of the materials is to be welcomed.

As a result, most extant documents up to the fourteenth century on Chinese history and geography, on literature and art, on philosophy and religion were preserved in this massive encyclopedia of 22,937 scrolls, with a table of contents of sixty additional scrolls, bound in 11,095 volumes, with approximately 370 million characters.[56]

Emperors Kangxi and Qianlong of Qing dynasty were both well learned. Beside handling state affairs, Emperor Kangxi (1654–1722) was extremely fond of reading, and his diligence in learning is indeed praiseworthy. It is said that he

> delved in many fields covering numerous works, including histories, works of various philosophical schools, music, mathematics and science, Buddhist sutras and treatises, and Taoist works. Though he had to attend to numerous affairs every day, he always found time to write and practice calligraphy. He paid much attention to self-cultivation and to experiencing the higher realms of human life.[57]

Emperor Qianlong (1711–1799) was also a man of broad learning. He practised calligraphy, painted, collected art objects as a hobby, and was fond of travelling. In his *Nanxunji* (A Record of My Inspection Tours to the South), he said, "In the 5 decades I have reigned, I did only two things that can be called great. One is the military expeditions I ordered to the western region of the country, and another is my inspection tours to the South". In addition, he developed interest in many Western instruments and devices. Curious about Western musical instruments, he had an orchestra organized at his court that included cello, violin, piano, oboe, clarinet, and guitar.[58]

The institutional arrangements for leaves and vacations in traditional China can also help us appreciate the importance of the scholar-officials in the field of leisure and the benefits for the nation when much attention was given to the cultivation of talents and skills among those in high positions.

In the early stage of the Qin-Han period, the government did not make any institutional arrangements specifically for holidays, but there was legislation for regular worship of heaven and earth, and of gods and goddesses. Government regulations required people from all walks of life to put aside

their work in the field, walk out of their houses and palaces, or halt their official duties to participate in various kinds of religious rites, so as to show their reverence for and piety toward Nature, life, ancestral spirits, and the deities. These regulations not only demonstrated a well-developed political philosophy and administrative skills at controlling the officials, but also reflected efforts to nurture the soul, to enrich people's spiritual world, to enforce the moral order, and to demonstrate the solemnity of social life.

From remnants of the *Han Code*《漢律》, we can see that the government in the Western Han period had stipulated "government officers are to have one day off every five days to take bath," which means government officers at that time enjoyed something much like the weekend we have today. In addition to this, the winter and summer solstices in the twenty-four solar terms were also regular holidays for government officers. In *Houhan Shu*《後漢書》, it is recorded that "around the *lidong*,[59] the gentleman is supposed to rest in peace, so all officers are to halt their business. Imperial hearings will not be held until some auspicious day chosen for the hearings to be resumed".[60]

In the Tang-Song period, traditional China reached its apogee in prosperity and strength, which is partly seen in their institutional arrangements for holidays. Even the Jin dynasty[61] established by the Jürchens imitated the Chinese dynasties in promulgating a *Jia'ningling*《假寧令》(edict on holidays and leaves) with as many as eighteen articles covering holidays and leaves related to almost all aspects of life, including weddings, funerals, death anniversaries, and travel to and from official posts to which one was assigned.

There were fewer holidays in Ming than in Tang and Song dynasties, but during the Yongle reign, the emperor lengthened the Lantern Festival holiday to ten days, during which time officials could rest at home rather than have to report to the emperor at the court. Commoners also gained more liberty in celebrating the Lantern Festival, including drinking and making merry, since officials were no longer supposed to interfere with their celebrative activities. And these rules were "to be fixed forever". An important feature of the holidays for Ming officials is that many of them enjoyed searching for valuable books and getting their own or others' works printed, to the point where almost everyone who passed the official examinations "was likely to have a volume of his writings printed already".[62] "Although the number of holidays for officials decreased in Ming dynasty, the scholar-officials and other literati were engaged in very frequent social interactions related to reading and discussion on politics".[63]

Qing dynasty largely followed Ming dynasty in the field of holidays and leaves,[64] and scholar-officials used the vacations to gather with friends. Frequently, they composed poems and criticized literary works at these gatherings.

The principle that government is *yi ren wei ben* (for the people), first proposed by Guan Zhong, a great statesman of the state of Qi in the Spring and Autumn period (770–476 BCE), and humanistic concerns in politics also found their expression in legislation in traditional China. "The foremost thing in governing the state is to make the people rich".[65] "The people are the most valuable, the state is the second, while the monarch has the least weight (among the three)".[66]

> The ruler is not to deprive the people of their time for agricultural work (by levying corvee during their busy seasons), nor should he take people's work lightly. People should be allowed to have some extra food stored, rather than be kept in shortage; and have some leisure, rather than kept in constant fatigue. People in the capital city should be assigned to proper positions with clearly defined duties, while those in the counties should be set to work in an orderly fashion.[67]

The same idea is also stated thus, "No project that requires the levying of corvee should be undertaken casually".[68] Enlightened governance on the part of the ruling class helped to generate the splendor of Chinese culture in many areas, making China a centre in the world to which people from many lands would like to take pilgrimage.

Conclusion

In history, China was widely known as "a land of etiquette and righteousness" and a country marked for its "respect for teachers and emphasis on education", which earned her much respect in the world. With the "Silk Road" that has traversed more than 2,000 years of history, all the way from the pre-Qin era through the Han and Tang periods to Song, Yuan, Ming, and Qing dynasties, China has brought to the rest of the world art objects of elegance and taste as well as objects of practical use. Those objects have shown the world the philosophical ideas, the spiritual outlook, and aesthetic taste of the Chinese, and revealed the political institutions of the world of the Chinese ancients.

The Chinese tradition of leisure culture shows that leisure, a path that one enters through one's mind, helps imperceptibly but surely to nurture people's mind, intellect, and moral character, and silently build and guard the spiritual home of humans.

This tradition also shows that leisure is intimately associated with philosophy, literature, art, religion, and science, for philosophy studies the mind, literature cures it, leisure lends quietude to it, art gives pleasure to it, religion gives peace to it, and science rectifies it. Thus, leisure is a necessary condition for all cultural creation.

This tradition further shows that the leisure values of traditional China reflect a specific kind of mentality, mood, and disposition, and are a carrier for aesthetic appreciation beyond the physical and material life.

Lastly, this tradition shows that leisure can help to elevate the quality of human existence and is a realm to which the freedom of mind, the inspiration, spiritual creativity, and political all belong.

The power of leisure may not lend itself to accurate measurement, but all cultural traditions with long histories have given it a high position.

It is apt to say that China's cultural history is also a history of leisure culture.

Notes

1 "Wudi benji" (Lives of the Five Emperors), in *Records of the Grand Historian* by Sima Qian.
2 "Bayi" (Eight Rows of Dancers), the *Analects*.
3 "Baoshi" (The Chaperon), the *Rites of Zhou*.
4 Scholars generally agree that the Chinese script kept on evolving from Shang Dynasty to the end of Qing Dynasty, starting from the oracle bone inscription and evolving into the bronze inscription, the greater seal script, the lesser seal script, the clerical script, the regular script, the cursive script, and then the semi-cursive script, but as new archaeological discoveries are made, there have been disagreements on the details of this evolutionary process.
5 It should be noted that currently there are two systems of Chinese script, namely, traditional Chinese characters and simplified Chinese characters. In 1935, the Ministry of the Republic of China published *The First Set of Simplified Chinese Characters*, which included 324 simplified characters; but in February the next year, the Ministry of Education, conforming to request from the Executive Yuan, ordered that "popularization of the simplified characters is to be halted". After the People's Republic of China was founded in 1949, reform on Chinese characters was gradually pushed forward. Currently, simplified Chinese characters are used in mainland China, while the traditional characters are used in Taiwan and Hong Kong.
6 Cited in the commentary by Li Shan (of Tang Dynasty) on *Wen Xuan* (Selections of Refined Literature).
7 Chung-Ying Cheng (1935–) is one of the representative figures of the so-called Third-Generation New Confucianists, with *Zhongguo Zhexue yu Zhongguo Wenhua* (Chinese Philosophy and Chinese Culture) (Sanmin Shuju 1974) as his most important work. He has been teaching at the Department of Philosophy at the University of Hawai'i at Manoa and is a mentor to Ma Huidi.
8 Cited from a study in 2008 by Di Yongjun of the Chinese Academy of Social Science.
9 From a study by Professor Han Zenglu of Beijing College of Architecture.
10 *Xiandai Hanyu Cidian* (*A Dictionary of Modern Chinese*) (Beijing: The Commercial Press, 1986), p. 764.
11 "Jinxin A", in *Mencius*. The extant *Mencius* is divided into 14 chapters with 7 chapter titles, each title covering an "upper chapter" (here denoted by "A") and a "lower chapter" (denoted by "B").
12 "Gongsun Chou A", *Mencius*.
13 James Legge, *The Chinese Classics* (Confucian Analects; The Great Learning; The Doctrine of the Mean) (Taipei: SMC Publishing, 1991), vol. 1, pp. 356–357.

14 "Shanmu" (A Tree in the Mountain), *Zhuangzi*.
15 "Renjian shi" (The Human World), *Zhuangzi*.
16 Meng Peiyuan, "Zhuangzi's View of Freedom," in *Proceedings of the Third International Conference on Zhuangzi*, 2000.
17 "Bilun" (On Numbness), *Suwen* (Basic Questions) of *Huangdi Neijing*.
18 Chapter 5 of *Daodejing* by Laozi.
19 James Legge, *The Chinese Classics*, pp. 356–357.
20 *Jiezishu* is a letter Zhuge Liang wrote on his deathbed for his son Zhuge Zhan.
21 "Taibo" in the *Analects*.
22 "Xuiji" in *The Book of Rites*.
23 "Shu'er" in the *Analects*.
24 A river in Lu, the home state of both Confucius and Zeng Xi.
25 "Zaji II", *The Book of Rites*.
26 Chapter 45, *Laozi*.
27 "Keyi", *Zhaungzi*.
28 Zhong Xianghong, "Hermit Culture in Traditional China," *Huaxia Wenhua (Chinese Culture)*, 3 (1998).
29 The *mu* is a unit of land area in China, equivalent to about one sixth of an acre.
30 Vertical bamboo flute, a traditional Chinese instrument.
31 Tao Yuanming and Xie Lingyun, famous poets from the Eastern Jin Dynasty, both of whom were extremely fond of drinking – and thus would leave little of that jar of wine for others if they were present.
32 Jian'an was one of the reign titles of Emperor Xian of the Eastern Han, the last emperor of that dynasty.
33 Liu Ji, "Qinyi Pian," *(On the Art of Zither-Playing)* in Zheng Zhenduo, ed., *Zhongguo Gudai Banhua Congkan (Series of Woodblock Prints from Traditional China)* (Shanghai: Shanghai Guji Chubanshe), vol. 1, p. 348.
34 Jiang Keqian, ed., *Qinshu Daquan (Complete Works on the Zither)* (Beijing: Zhongguo Shudian Chubanshe, 2007), p. 195.
35 The twenty-four solar terms are points in traditional Chinese calendar specified according to the position of the Earth on its orbit around the sun. Starting with the vernal equinox, the points are spaced 15° apart along the ecliptic. After a full cycle of 360°, the earth returns to the vernal equinox, ready to start another cycle.
36 "Zhongyong", *Book of Rites*.
37 The style name of Duanmu Ci, a disciple of Confucius.
38 This was a carnival at the end of the year when a sacrifice was offered to all the gods and the people were given to drinking, eating, and much merriment.
39 "Guan Xiangshe" (Watching the Country Archery Contest), Chapter 28 of *Kongzi Jiayu* (Confucius' Family Teachings).
40 "Xiaoyao You" (Free and Easy Wandering), *Zhuangzi*.
41 In traditional China, copper coins, each of which had a square hole at the center, could be strung together, with one thousand to a string, to make one *guan* of money, so that they could be more easily stored or carried around, or counted when transactions involving a large amount of money were made.
42 This is a couplet from *Caigen Tan* (Talks over Vegetable Roots) by Hong Yingming of Ming Dynasty. In classical Chinese literature, the imagery of flowers blossoming is often used as a metaphor of someone receiving great honor or favour from the monarch. *Quliu* (staying or departing) can mean remaining at the court or departing from it (after being demoted to positions in local government or even deprived of all official titles).
43 Zheng Xuan, annotator, *Liji* (The Book of Rites), in *Hanwei Guzhu Shisanjing* (The Thirteen Classics with Annotations by Han and Wei Scholars) (Beijing: Zhonghua Shuju, 1998), p. 130.
44 Liu Baonan, *Lunyu Zhengyi* (The True Meaning of the *Analects*) (Beijing: Zhonghua Shuju, 1990), p. 257.
45 *Dizigui* (Rules for Disciples), by Li Yuxiu of Qing Dynasty.
46 "Yan Yuan", the *Analects*.
47 "Wenyan" for the *Qian* hexagram, *The Book of Change*.
48 *The Book of Songs* is divided into "Airs of the States", "Court Hymns", and "Eulogies". The Preface to the version of the work compiled by Mao Heng and Mao Chang in early Han Period makes a distinction for the "Airs" between "Airs Proper", supposedly composed when the Western Zhou Dynasty was at its height, and "Varied Airs", supposedly composed when the Western Zhou Dynasty was in decline – and thus the culture was no longer as "correct" as when the "Airs Proper" were produced.
49 Preface to *The Book of Songs* by Mao Heng and Mao Chang.
50 The Confucian literary theory allows for the expression of emotions in literary works but is against their excessive expression. An important function of the rites, according to the Confucians, is to keep the expression of emotions within proper limits. Thus, early kings, with King Wen and King Wu of the early Western Zhou Period as the most prominent exemplars, did the people a great favour by having the rites systematized to prevent such excesses.

51 Angus Maddison, *The World Economy* (Historical Statistics) (OECD Publishing, 2006), vol. 2, Table 8b on p. 641.
52 The emperor's name is Li Longji. "Ming" is one of the characters in his posthumous title, and "Xuanzong" below is his temple name.
53 A part of the orchestra of the imperial court, so named because the musicians of this section were seated when they played, in contrast with the Standing Section, whose musician were supposed to be standing while they played. Musicians of the Seated Section enjoyed a higher status and supposedly had better skills.
54 "Liyue Zhi" (Treatise on Rites and Music), *The New Book of Tang*.
55 "Yongle" was the reign title of Emperor Cheng.
56 "Yongle Dadian" (Yongle Encyclopedia), Baidu (Online) Encyclopedia, https://baike.baidu.com/.
57 Song Muwen and Liu Gao, eds., *Zhongguo Tushu Dacidian (A Comprehensive Dictionary of Chinese Books)* (Hubei: Hubei People's Press, 1997), 4 vols.
58 Zhou Yuanlian, *Qianlong Huangdi Dazhuan (A Major Biography of Emperor Qianlong)* (Xi'an: Shaanxi People's Press, 2008).
59 *Lidong* (the beginning of winter), one of the twenty-four solar terms, is one and half a month prior to the winter solstice.
60 Fan Ye, *Houhan Shu (The History of the Later Han Dynasty)* (Beijing: Zhonghua Shuju, 1965), p. 3125. The "Later Han" is the same as the "Eastern Han".
61 Not to be confused with the Western and Eastern Jin mentioned earlier, which was founded by Han Chinese. The Chinese character for the "Jin" here is written differently, though the romanization is the same for both occasions.
62 Ye Dehui, *Shulin Qinghua (Stories for Bibliophiles)* (Beijing: Zhonghua Shuju, 1999), p. 154
63 Yue Liangwen, "Gudai guanyuan de xiujia zhidu: tangsong zui kuansong, mingqing zhujian shoujin" (Holidays and leaves for officials in traditional China), *Xuxi Shibao* (Study Times), March 12, 2015
64 Lin Yongkuang, 2014.
65 Chapter 48 ("Governing the State"), *Guanzi*.
66 "Jinxin B", *Mencius*.
67 "Shan Xianggong lun Chen bi wang" (Duke Xiang of Shan on the Inevitability of the Demise of the State of Chen), Chapter 2 of *Guoyu*.
68 *Xu Zizhi Tongjian* (Sequel to the *Comprehensive Mirror in Aid of Governance*), scroll 156.

21
CHINESE SHADOW PLAY

Li Jie

Introduction

Chinese shadow play, also called shadow puppetry, lamp shadow show, leather-silhouette show, or shadow puppet play, is a traditional folk art of Chinese opera. It absorbs artistic elements from such various traditional Chinese art forms as paper-cutting, painting, wood or stone craving, sculpture, poetry, music, drama, dancing, martial arts, acrobatics, and ventriloquism. As a magic art of light and shadow, it is loved by the Chinese people from generation to generation.

Shadow puppets are made of skins of cows, calves, donkeys, sheep, goats and pigs, or of paper, plastics and other materials. Behind a white curtain used as a screen, artists give performance by manipulating puppets, speaking and singing accompanied on percussion and stringed musical instruments. The puppet shadows cast onto the screen, the folk stories, and the music with local flavors greatly gratify people's eyes and ears and hearts. Due to its rich content, superb craftsmanship in puppet making and unique way of performance, Chinese Shadow Play was enlisted into UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2011.

Chinese shadow play unfolds a panorama of Chinese people's life styles, values, religious beliefs, ethics, morals, folk customs, and social outlooks in different periods. For hundreds, even thousands of years, Chinese Shadow Play has been a popular folk art, an important entertainment for people to celebrate a wedding, a birthday, a bumper harvest, a festival or an opening of a new business; to drive off diseases and disasters; and to pray for happiness, longevity, and more descendants. Through each and every character and story, Chinese people's daily life, festivals and holidays, ceremonial rituals and etiquettes, entertainment activities, pursuits, yearnings, and happiness and sorrows are all presented. Chinese Shadow Play has a profound research value for social, historical, and cultural studies.

The complicated procedures and the elaborate techniques in making shadow puppets well demonstrate the superb craftsmanship of traditional Chinese artisans. Going through a sequence of procedures – skin-selecting, skin-processing, drawing or painting, carving, colouring and assembling – the vivid and lifelike puppets of characters, stage settings, and a variety of props are works of art with great aesthetic and cultural values, which are cherished as artistic treasures for decoration, appreciation, and collection.

Shadow play performance is a comprehensive and collaborative art. A performer manipulates the sticks with two hands behind a screen, making the puppet shadows on the screen flexible and true to life, and other performers speak the lines, sing, and play musical instruments in harmony with one another. The excellent puppet manipulation skills, various singing tunes, dialects with local colours, vivid portrayal of different roles, stylized dramatic make-up and costumes, and traditional musical accompaniment instruments

altogether constitute a splendid opera world, which absorbs essences from other traditional Chinese operas but retains its unique charm.

Historical development

As researchers Yang and Li (2013) have explained:

> Some scholars believe that Chinese Shadow Play originated from the Han Dynasty (202 BCE.–220), developed in the Tang Dynasty (618–907) and flourished in the Song Dynasty (960–1279), which means it has a history of approximately 2000 years; and some researchers base their study on the specific documented historical records and believe that Chinese Shadow Play started from the Song Dynasty about 1,000 years ago.
>
> *(p. 7)*

Up to now, there is no final conclusion.

As a matter of fact, Chinese Shadow Play has been veiled with mysteries from its appearance, and there are quite a lot of legends and folktales prevalent about its origin, which reflect people's rich and romantic imaginations.

One story goes that Lady Li, concubine of Emperor Wu of the Han dynasty, died young. In grief, the emperor had no mood to handle the state affairs. One day, a courtier named Li Shaoweng saw a boy on the street playing with a doll. The doll's shadow on the ground looked vivid and interesting. On a sudden inspiration, he thought of an idea to console and fawn on his emperor. He cut out Lady Li's silhouette with a piece of cloth, coloured it, and put wood sticks at the puppet's joints. When the night fell, he invited the emperor home. Behind a sheet of white curtain, the courtier manipulated the puppet with sticks in his hands. As the oil light flickered, the puppet's shadow on the screen looked clear and vivid as if Lady Li came back to life! Seeing his beloved woman again, the emperor's yearnings of day and night were greatly relieved. The other story goes that in the reign of Emperor Wu of the Han dynasty, the baby prince always cried and blubbered. A court maid found that when the baby saw shadows of leaves on the window he stopped crying. The maids then cut tree leaves into various shapes and played with them behind a piece of white cloth. Seeing the shadows, the baby waved his arms in great joy. As tree leaves withered away quickly, later, the solid and durable animal skins were used. Presumably, these stories have been regarded the embryo of traditional Chinese Shadow Play.

In the Tang dynasty, Buddhism flourished. In order to preach Buddhism, to make the scriptures more appealing and easier to understand, Buddhists turned to paper dolls for help. Paper dolls with colours and movable joints played a very important role in helping expound scriptures. "Qi Rushan, a Peking Opera playwright and a drama theorist, in his *Illustrations of A Hundred Dramas in Beijing* holds that Chinese Shadow Play started in Xi'an in the Tang Dynasty". (Tong 2013: 002) However, there are no documented records to support this view.

In the Song dynasty, shadow play performances were clearly recorded in documents and literature, which is considered the forceful proof that Chinese Shadow Play started from the Song dynasty.

And during the Yuan and the Ming dynasties (1271–1644), Chinese Shadow Play developed rapidly and was widely accepted not only among ordinary people but also within the military as a recreational activity. Since the thirteenth century, as the military expedition developed, Chinese Shadow Play was introduced to other countries in Asia and Europe.

The Qing dynasty (1636–1912) saw the acme of the development of Chinese Shadow Play. With more varieties of dramatic roles, drama scripts, singing skills, and performing schools, it became the favourable entertainment for ordinary people as well as wealthy influential families. During festivals, harvests, or other grand occasions, craftsmen were invited home to make puppets and shadow plays were put on continuously

for days. People greatly enjoyed themselves in a lively, mirthful, and hilarious atmosphere. Likewise, the emperor, empress, concubines, and ministers in the imperial palace were also addicted to watching shadow play performances for relaxation and entertainment. Since the late Qing dynasty, due to the social turmoil and years of warfare, Chinese Shadow Play began to decline.

After the founding of the People's Republic of China, this traditional art began to revive and thrive. However, today, as science and technology develop by leaps and bounds, Chinese Shadow Play has to give way to movies, TV plays, and various internet recreations. In the twenty-first century, UNESCO promoted the protection of intangible cultural heritage worldwide, and Chinese Shadow Play has again become the focus of public attention.

Craftsmanship in puppet making

Making shadow puppets is a complicated process, which requires a combination of skills and a sequence of strict procedures. Generally speaking, the key procedures are skin-processing, drawing, carving, colouring, dehydration, and assembling.

Skin-processing: The materials used to make shadow puppets vary according to different local conditions. For example, donkey skins are more used in the north China while cowhides or calf skins are preferred in the northwest. In China, people mainly use animal skins, among which skins of five- or six-year-old calves or donkeys are craftsmen's favourite, for such skins are thin, transparent but solid and wear-resistant.

After the skins are selected, the complicated scraping process begins. There are two traditional skin-scraping techniques: One is purely manual and the other is done with the help of some chemicals. The procedures for the former involve a craftsman's hard work and rich experience: put the selected skins into the cold, clean water for an appropriate period of time. The time span depends on the local weather, the quality of skins, and the temperature of the water. When the skins are soaked through and become soft enough, take them out and scrape or shave off the hairs and flesh step by step. The procedures for the latter are different: put calcium oxide, sodium sulfide, and other necessary chemicals into the water respectively, and soak and scrape the skins repeatedly until they become thin, clean, and transparent.

After the scraping, the skins are still "raw" and cannot be used to make shadow puppets directly. Craftsmen cut the skins into different sizes and shapes in accordance with their intended use, and put them into the water of about 70℃ for one or two days, then dry them in a cool place, and then press them with a heavy object until they become flat and dry through and through.

After such a series of skin-processing procedures, the skins are soft, elastic, flat, colorfast, oil tight, and ready for carving. The thin and transparent skins are usually used for the head, chest, and abdomen of puppets and the thick skins with darker colours are selected to make the puppet's legs, stage settings or props. In a word, traditional skin-processing techniques are done strictly in proper sequence.

Drawing: The pattern drafts are put under the skins, and with the help of light, craftsmen copy or score the pattern designs onto the skins with a needle-pen stitch by stitch. The patterns of facial make-up, headdresses, hairstyles, and costumes of various dramatic roles, props, and stage settings on the paper draft are in this way transferred to the front side of the skins, which is smoother and cleaner compared with the back side. The job needs to be done accurately with great care and patience.

Carving: Carving or engraving requires a craftsman's long-term accumulation and years of practice. A craftsman should be proficient in using all sorts of knives of different lengths, breadths, shapes, and uses. Some knives are long and broad, and some short and narrow. Normally a craftsman has eleven, twelve or even more than thirty carving knives with different shapes of edges: pointed, flat, circular, triangular, uneven, or jagged. He should be adept in exercising knives in various ways, such as piercing, thrusting, pushing, chiseling or scoring, in accordance with the pattern lines on the skin. For years, traditional craftsmen have summarized a set of mnemonic rhyming pithy formulas, which they firmly keep in mind and apply to practice. In their skillful hands, exquisite works come into being, which demonstrate their elaborate carving

techniques and their creativity. The refined facial make-up, beautiful hair-ornaments, costumes of different styles, pattern lines in shapes of snowflake, plum flower, or chrysanthemum, as well as fantastic stage settings and props are all carved remarkably true to life with rich symbolic cultural connotations.

Basically, there are two traditional carving methods. Intaglio is to make the pattern lines hollow, sunken or depressed and keep the remaining part untouched, which is a better way to display the complicated pattern lines. It is usually applied to carving a clown so that his comical exaggerated facial expressions can be clearly shown, or *Jing*, a male role, to make the painted colour of his face more visible. Cameo is to make the pattern lines in low relief and carve the remaining part off. The lines which stand out make a character's delicate brow, eye, nose, and mouth more conspicuous and the hollowed-out cheek and forehead look white, which is very much suitable to portray a character with fair skin and tender personality.

Colouring: The puppets need to be painted on both sides. The paintings used are made by old artisans themselves. Local minerals or plants are used to produce red, green, yellow, and other bright colours. With different colours matched and shades of changes, the colourized puppets look gorgeously fascinating. The colouring process should be done with care, otherwise, all the previous endeavors become in vain.

Dehydration: Dehydration is also called sweating. After the colouring procedure, the colour is only attached to the surface. In order to allow the colour to penetrate into the leather, it is necessary to dry the coloured puppets. The purpose of dehydration is to allow the colour to infiltrate into the skins and allow the moisture remaining in the skins to evaporate. The key lies in the temperature. When the temperature is about 70℃, the dehydration will be relatively smooth. The moisture in the skins is evaporated the colour eats into the skins. After such a process, the colour of the puppets stays bright and will not fade for a long time. In addition, the puppets remain flat and will not warp and twist.

Assembling: A complete shadow puppet normally has eleven parts: head, chest, abdomen, legs, arms, elbows, and hands. These parts need to be assembled to make a puppet complete and able to do actions. In the early days, leather stripes or threads are used to bind those parts up and later people used rivets or iron wires to make the puppet more durable. The assembling work seems simple but in fact it is also a job in need of excellent skills. After all parts are stapled, in order to make the puppet moveable, it is necessary to install the operating sticks (rods). The stick sewn onto the neck is called the neck-stick and those sewn on both hands are hand-sticks. After such procedures, the puppets are able to move with animation, displaying a character's actions as well as emotions and moods.

Quite a number of books on Chinese Shadow Play (Yang and Li 2013: 102–12; Wang 2015: 11–16; Huang 2013: 28–34; Jiao 2017: 45–56; Tong 2013: 77–93) have introduced this traditional puppet-making process in detail with different focuses. Here the author just makes a generalization and gives a very brief introduction to the key procedures. As a matter of fact, traditional Chinese handicraftsmen are particular or even fastidious about every procedure and they attach great importance to every detail of their work with great care, patience, perseverance, and continuous practice and accumulation. Today, with the help of modern technology, the puppet making must be easier and quicker; however, it is in this toilsome, complicated traditional puppet-making process that we realize the value of cultural heritage, the power of tradition, the urgent need of inheritance, and the impetus of innovation.

Art of puppet design

The artistic design of shadow puppets (including characters, stage settings, and various props) absorbs and incorporates the quintessential designs of Chinese pictograph, sculpture of Buddha, traditional opera facial make-up and costumes, and folk clothes in different ages.

Yang and Li (2013) have summarized four features concerning the artistic design of shadow puppets: firstly, the outline of a puppet, the overall image, is more emphasized than the interior details. Secondly, all the patterns are two dimensional, so how to display character images and various stage settings and props on pieces of flat animal skins requires artistic imagination and elaborate painting or drawing skills. An artist

should observe life closely and produce planarity designs with stereoscopic effect. Each design embodies an artist's wisdom, creativity, and aesthetic tastes. Thirdly, characters' faces and costumes are stereotyped and stylized, which is the common feature of almost all the traditional Chinese operas. Fourthly, the faces, hairstyles, hair-ornaments, colours and patterns of costumes are all symbolic with cultural implications and identity indications (p. 53).

A folk artist's shadow puppet kit or box contains at least seven packages, or more than a dozen. A package usually holds five or six hundred pieces of puppets. Every package contains at least three categories of puppets: head, body, and props, which are called "*Toucha*", "*Shenduan*", or "*Qimo*" respectively in their jargon.

"*Toucha*" (head), also called "*Shaozi*", refers to the head design of shadow puppets, namely, the design of faces and headwear. Chinese Shadow Play presents a kaleidoscopic world, in which there are characters from all walks of life: emperors, empresses, generals, ministers, concubines, servants, chivalrous swordsmen, common soldiers, handsome scholars, young ladies, vulgar scoundrels, innocent children, senior people, as well as monks, fairies, demons, and so on. Head design plays a very important role in portraying and revealing a character's dramatic role, social status, personality, disposition, and even temper and mood.

The puppet faces are all side-silhouette with only one cheek and one eye. Different roles have different facial features which are stereotyped and stylized. One can judge a character's identity, social status, and personality simply by looking at his eye, eyebrow, teeth, beards or the colour of his face. For example, a handsome young scholar's eyebrow is flat and smooth, which indicates that he is gentle-tempered; a martial man with soldierly bearings always has a knitted eyebrow and an eye slanting upward, which clearly show that he is valiant and bold; and a tender and delicate young girl must have an elegant eye and a thin curved eyebrow. A young man always keeps his mouth closed while a bad guy always keeps his teeth exposed; and a positive character is warm and kind-faced with benevolent appearance but a negative character looks ferocious. In terms of application of colours, black-faced are characters with faith and loyalty and red-faced with valiance and strength; the painted faces are characteristic of courageous and bold male characters; the hollowed-out faces with no colours best characterize fair ladies or handsome young scholars. As to carving methods, cameo is more applied to young males and females to sketch their delicate facial contours and intaglio to clowns and male roles with painted faces to better display the complicated pattern lines and facial colours. In brief, with exquisite patterns, coloured facial make-up and stylized expressions, shadow puppet faces are works of art themselves.

Headwear includes a variety of hairstyles, hair ornaments, hats, and head scarves or kerchiefs. A character's hairstyle and hair ornaments are the manifestation of his or her marital status and social positions. For example, a married woman wears her hair in a bun; an unmarried girl always wears a braid; a lady from a wealthy family must wear many luxurious hair ornaments; and a poor old woman simply wears her hair in a coil with no ornaments at all. Hairbands and hairpins of different colours, shapes, and sizes and such colorful ornaments as pearls, flowers, velvet balls, and pheasant tail feathers are commonly seen in headwear designs. In traditional China, people of different ages, professions, positions, and ranks wear different caps or headscarves: a person with high social status wears a crown; a military officer always wears a helmet; a civil official wears a cap; and an ordinary civilian a piece of kerchief. More specifically, the cap together with its ornaments always carries cultural or dramatic implications. For example, A Number One Scholar (*Zhuangyuan*, a title conferred on the one who came first in the highest imperial examination) wears a special cap with such ornaments as big velvet balls indicating glory and honor; a female military commander-in-chief wears a helmet with velvet balls and long feathers, displaying her awe-inspiring but feminine appearance; a landlord wears an unadorned square-shaped cap, indicating that he is rich but earthy; and a scholar wears a cap with simple ornaments like jade or a silk ribbon, showing his simplicity, frugality, and moral integrity. Frankly speaking, "*Toucha*" (head) is a dazzling world, which embodies features of character designs in traditional Chinese operas and wisdoms of traditional Chinese artists.

"*Shenduan*" (body) or "*Chuozi*", or "*Yingshenzi*" mainly refers to designs of various garments, such as emperor's robes, official clothes, armors, generals' cloaks, court dresses, and clothes of fairies, monks, Taoist priests, and common people. The colour, the style and the pattern of the garments indicate characters' social status and dramatic roles. Like the design of puppet faces, the design of "*Shenduan*" is also stylized and stereotyped.

Yang and Li (2013) have summarized three features:

> First, the color and the pattern of garments indicate characters' social status. The bright yellow is used in the robes for emperor, empress and concubines; purple, red, blue and black are usually used in the robes of court officials of different ranks; and brown, black and blue are the colors of ordinary people's clothes. Secondly, the color and the pattern of garments indicate characters' personality. . . . Red is used for bad-tempered characters, white for mourning apparel, pink for young generals or scholars, blue and green for greenwood heroes, and black for the bold and the resolute. The patterns are highly representative, for example, boa constrictor is a pattern commonly used in the imperial officials' robes; phoenix often appears in the dresses of the females of high status; cranes and some Chinese characters or geometric patterns with auspicious meanings are often used in the old people's clothes; lion, tiger, leopard and other beasts of prey are the common patterns in the coats of people excelling in martial arts. Thirdly, the color and the pattern of garments epitomize the aesthetic features of garments of different dynasties in China.
>
> *(p. 84)*

"*Toucha*" (head) and "*Shenduan*" (body) are separate. Roughly speaking, in a puppet kit there are about 800 "*Toucha*" (heads) and 200 "*Shenduan*" (bodies). Performers can assemble different heads to the same body to perform different roles.

"*Qimo*" refers to all the other pieces apart from human character puppets, such as decoration curtains, stage scenes, and a variety of props. Decoration curtains are hung on top of the screen to indicate typical environment. For example,

> a curtain with the pattern of dragon, phoenix and colorful clouds shows that the story happens in an imperial court; . . . a lady's chamber or boudoir must have a curtain full of patterns of beautiful flowers and birds; in a living room of a common family, on the decoration curtain, fisherman, woodman, ploughman and scholar are the patterns commonly used, which are the four major jobs in the traditional agricultural society, the symbol of a peaceful mundane life.
>
> *(Jiao 2017: 39)*

Stage scenes indicate the specific places where stories happen, such as imperial courts, offices, gardens, teahouses, family halls, hotels, heaven, and hell. Props include tables and chairs of various shapes and sizes, decorations for different uses, beds for people of different ranks, articles of daily use such as wine pots, brush pens, candles and lanterns, and weapons of different sizes and shapes for different uses. In addition, common animals such as donkeys, dogs, pigs, chickens, ducks and geese; fierce beasts like tigers, bears, wolves and hawks; and such auspicious animals as dragons, phoenixes, cranes, deer, kylins, and birds with nine heads are all indispensable props.

All of these are elaborately designed and carved with superb craftsmanship. They play an important role in decorating the stage and helping develop the dramatic plots. The stage settings and props are not used at random; instead, they are used for different purposes and with different cultural implications. Pine trees often appear in a martial art play, while pavilions, lotuses, and willows are often seen in a love story.

Generally speaking, intaglio carving is applied to stage settings and props, so as to manifest the refined and delicate pattern lines.

Art of performance

The necessary facilities for traditional shadow play performances are a sheet of screen, lights, shadow puppets, and props as well as musical instruments. Shadow play performers needn't wear stage costumes or makeup; instead, they give performances by manipulating puppets, singing, speaking the lines, and playing musical instruments behind a screen in harmony with one another. In this way, happiness and sorrows of people, ups and downs of history, and waxes and wanes of nature are put onto stage.

The screen is a curtain, called "*Liang-zi*" in professional jargon, mostly made of a piece of white cloth of about one metre wide and more than two metres long. Both sides of the cloth are supported by wooden frames and thus a "shadow window", the stage for shadow puppets, comes into being. Behind the screen, a long table is used to place props. The lights used in shadow play performances developed from oil lamps to gas lamps, bulbs, electric lamps, fluorescent lights, and LED lights. Interestingly, in some artists' heart, oil lamps are not out of date, instead, they produce better stage effect: the shadows cast onto the screen shiver with the flickering flames of oil lamps, which create sort of special effect. The musical instruments for accompaniment include *erhu* (a two-stringed bowed instrument), Chinese dulcimer, *sanxian* (a three-stringed plucked instrument), *Sheng* (a reed pipe wind instrument), flute, gongs, and drums, *suona* horn (a woodwind instrument) and a four-stringed bowed instrument, which is the most distinctive among shadow play musical instruments.

A shadow play troupe generally consists of performers of three kinds in accordance with their task allocations. One performer, called "*Qian-sheng*" (front-voice), is mainly in charge of singing and speaking the lines, and sometimes playing drums and percussion instruments; one performer, called "*Qian-shou*" (stick-hand) or "*Dengdixia*" (under the light), is mainly in charge of manipulating puppets under the light; and the others are in charge of playing musical instruments. In the north and northeast China, a troupe with seven performers is considered short-handed, eight still busy, and nine sufficient and comfortable.

The shadow play performing art is manifested mainly from two aspects: the puppet manipulation and the opera performance.

The puppet manipulation is done by "*Qian-shou*" (stick-hand). Like any other traditional Chinese operas, Chinese Shadow Play also has a complete set of dramatic roles. The difference is that the characters in shadow plays are not living people but lifeless puppets made by animal skins. They are flat, hard, and without emotions and facial expressions. Therefore, making these lifeless puppets come alive depends on *Qian-shou*'s splendid manipulation skills. Generally speaking, a puppet needs to be manipulated by three sticks or more. A "*Qian-shou*" holds, twiddles, turns, rotates, clips or rubs the sticks with his thumb, index finger, and middle finger to control the puppet and makes it move and act in an adroit manner. An experienced "*Qian-shou*" can even hold eighteen sticks to complete a series of complicated actions, making puppets animated, kicking and alive on the screen. In an artist's skillful hands, a character puppet can do such common actions as sitting and standing, walking and running, turning around, swinging sleeves, clapping hands, stamping feet, making a bow with hands folded, and kowtowing, and such complicated actions as washing face, combing hair, serving tea, pouring away water, thumping breasts, walking on the air, and fighting on horses. People's happiness, sorrow, exasperation, ecstasy, disappointment, surprise, and excitement can all be vividly acted out and vivaciously presented.

Qi Yongheng (Wei 2008:30), a Chinese shadow play artist, is well-known for his excellent skills in manipulating shadow puppets. He

> hails from a family of shadow players, and with his father, began manipulating the puppets at eight. He has worked for the Tangshan Shadow Play Troupe since the 1950s. He is called 'Qi, the living shadow play puppet' and 'King of the Rod' among the locals. International audiences have appraised his manipulation as 'a magic and lightning art'.
>
> *(Wei 2008: 30)*

In his skillful manipulation, White Bone Demon, a horrible evil spirit in a story from *Journey to the West*, can change the colour of her face in a flash; Qin Xianglian, a pathetic deserted wife in *Pipa Words*, cries, trembles, rubs her tears, and blows her nose as if she were a real human being (Wei 2015: 89–90)! Lifeless puppets become alive! In a word, practice makes perfect. A *Qian-shou*'s excellent manipulation skills come from years of practice, accumulation, inheritance, development and innovation.

The success of a shadow play performance depends on the whole troupe's cooperation.

Chinese Shadow Play has a complete series of dramatic roles: *Sheng* (male roles) includes *Xiaosheng* (immature young males), *Wensheng* (gentle and refined young males), *Wusheng* (males with powerful kungfu), and *Laosheng* (middle aged or old males); *Dan* (female roles) contains *Wendan* (tender and delicate young females), *Wudan* (females with valiant personality and good at acrobatic fighting), *Huadan* (young females with humorous and vivacious personality), and *Laodan* (old females with ease and grace); *Jing* (males with painted face) is divided into *Maojing* (bold and brave young males) and *Hongjing* (loyal and heroic males); and *Chou* (clown) refers to characters full of humor and wit playing a role of mobilizing the stage atmosphere. A "Qian-shou" (stick-hand) needs to manipulate puppets in accordance with the stereotyped action-patterns of different roles. Wang (2015), an expert in Chinese Shadow Play, illustrates the action-patterns with pictures: a female role good at acrobatic fighting moves in a tender but valiant manner; a humorous and vivacious female role with feisty personality always puts her hands on her waist; a male role with kungfu somersaults onto the stage; an old man walks with his back bent; an evil man always has a protruding belly; a female laughs with her mouth hidden in her sleeve; and a man claps his hands and jumps up when he is happy (pp. 21–22).

Different roles have different singing tunes and styles: *Sheng* (males) is sonorous with loud and clear tone, *Dan* (females) fine and smooth, *Jing* (males with painted face) bold and unrestrained, and *Chou* (clowns) full of humor and wit. All these roles' singing and speaking are done by "*Qian-sheng*" alone. Meanwhile, he also needs to play drum, side drum, and hand gong and give ventriloquism in the percussion music at the opening of a play. In a word, a "*Qian-sheng*" should have all-round skills in singing, speaking all the characters' lines and playing musical instruments, which is no easy job.

Other performers, such as "*Hou-cao*", "*Shang-dang*", and "*Xia-dang*" mainly play musical instruments. They cooperate with one another and provide good accompaniment music. Absorbing the essence of local operas and folk music, the music of shadow plays carries different local flavors.

In addition, to achieve better effect and attract more audiences, shadow play performers have created many performing stunts. They puff smoke onto the screen to produce an atmosphere permeated with thick fog and smoke; they spray a mouthful of rosin onto the screen and kindle it with fire to produce a scene of big fire; they pull the puppet head quickly off the body and make the colour paste spill onto the screen to demonstrate the scene that someone is beheaded.

In the earlier time, there were no written scripts. Later, with the development of shadow play performances, quite a number of good scripts appeared. Some stories come from other operas and most of them were created on the basis of classical Chinese literary works, local legends or folklores.

Different schools of shadow play

After hundreds or even thousands of years of development, Chinese Shadow Play has spread all over China and formed different schools in different areas. They differ in materials, puppet sizes, application of colours, carving techniques, singing styles, musical accompaniment instruments, plots of stories, and designs of props and background settings.

Professor Jiang Yuxiang of Sichuan University holds that Chinese Shadow Play has seven systems: Shaanxi-Shanxi system, Luanzhou system, Shandong system, Hangzhou system, Sichuan-Hubei-Yunnan system, Hunan-Hubei system, and Chaozhou system. And Wei Liqun, a well-known shadow play expert, a professor in Hebei Normal University, holds that there are three major shadow play schools: the northern school, the western school, and the middle and southern school (Huang 2013: 3).

No matter what criteria or bases for classification,

> mainly 13 local shadow plays are currently well preserved which have exerted far-reaching influences in history and maintain distinctive characteristics. They are Beijing Shadow Play (Beijing), Luanzhou Shadow Play (North and Northeast China), Guanzhong Shadow Play (Shaanxi Pronvince), Daoqing Shadow Play (Gansu Province), Chengdu Shadow Play (Sichuan Province), Shandong Shadow Play (Shandong Province), Zhongyuan Shadow Play (Henan Province), Hubei Shadow Play (Hubei Province), Hunan Shadow Play (Hunan Province), Haining Shadow Play (Jiangsu Province, Zhejiang Province, and Shanghai), Xiaoyi Shadow Play (Xiaoyi, Shanxi Province), Hehuang Shadow Play (Qinghai Province), and Chaozhou Shadow Play (Guangdong Province and Taiwan).
>
> *(Wang 2015: 75)*

Here is a very sketchy introduction to some of them:

Guanzhong Shadow Play, also called Shaanxi Shadow Play, is popular in Shaanxi Province, China. It is characteristic of its elaborate carving techniques and superb manipulation skills. Shaanxi Shadow Play is further divided into the eastern and the western sub-schools. The eastern sub-school is very particular about puppet-carving technique. The puppets have exquisite lines, patterns, and colours. Proud of their carved works, performers deliberately slow down their performance in order to demonstrate to spectators the beauty of their puppets in detail. Compared with the eastern sub-school, the puppets of the western sub-school are bigger in size and with rougher lines. The noses are typically high-bridged without curves and the facial make-ups are somewhat exaggerated. Among Shaanxi shadow plays of various styles, Hua County Shadow Play is the most famous. Well-known as "*Wanwanqiang*" (bowl-bowl-singing style), Hua County Shadow Play is complicated in singing style and accompaniment music. "As many as 19 musical instruments are used, including more than 9 percussion instruments, 3 stringed instruments, and 4 kinds of piped instruments" (Jiao 2017: 89). Although so many instruments are played, there are only five performers in a troupe. No matter how complicated the story plot or the performing task, they can cooperate well with tacit understanding. As to the name of "*Wanwanqiang*", the legend has it that Lady Yang, the most beautiful imperial concubine in the Tang dynasty, was good at music and dancing. She always drank with a bronze bowl when she listened to music. To add more fun, or to cater to Lady Yang, folk artists put the bell-shaped bowls into their musical instruments. By and by, this musical form was accepted and became popular.

Luanzhou Shadow Play, also known as Tangshan Shadow Play, is an important school popular in north and northeast China. Wang (2015) summarizes its following features: first, its facial design is distinctive with prominent features: The puppets' nose-bridge is a straight line stretching from forehead to the tip of the nose; the eyebrow is curved; the mouth is always a very short red line; the cheek is usually carved in intaglio; and bright colours, such as red, yellow, green and blue, are often used. Secondly, when "*Qian-sheng*" sings or speaks, he always strangles his throat with his fingers to utter sounds with special effect. This unique and strange "throat-strangling" vocalization method is an easy way for people to distinguish Luanzhou School from other schools. Thirdly, a puppet is carved normally by just one carving knife, which shows the amazing carving technique (p. 77). Luanzhou Shadow Play is also good at using various auspicious patterns or Chinese characters in designing character costumes, props and stage settings. For example, "three objects in a vase" means promotion for three times; "five bats (homophone for happiness in Chinese)" indicate a lot of happiness; "a Chinese *ruyi* (an S-shaped ornamental object, usually made of jade, as a symbol of good luck) in a vase" signifies good lucks as wishes; and Chinese characters 寿 (longevity) and 福 (happiness) always appear on the robes of old ladies (Huang 2013: 18).

Daoqing Shadow Play is popular in Huan County of Gansu Province. It has a history of almost a thousand years. In the late Song and the early Yuan dynasty, local farmers and Daoist believers often told stories to preach Daoism. To make their stories more appealing, they incorporated shadow plays. Daoqing Shadow Play has the following features: firstly, absorbing quite a lot of elements from the local songs, the singing style is rich in

local flavors. Secondly, praising virtue and punishing vice are the major themes. Thirdly, Daoqing Shadow Play puppets, made of high-quality calf skins, have distinctive designs: the puppet's head is bigger than the body and the upper part of the body is narrower than the lower part; arms are long, which almost reach the knees; and puppets are made bigger to highlight the images of different roles, while props are comparatively smaller.

Chengdu Shadow Play grows and thrives in Chengdu, a city with a history of over 2,300 years, known as "Heavenly Land of Abundance" and "Land of Honey and Milk". It is popular throughout Sichuan province. Having borrowed a number of artistic elements from Sichuan local operas, Sichuan traditional new-year paintings, designs of Sichuan painted cloth, and Sichuan embroidery, it abounds in Sichuan local features. First, the repertoire, the facial make-up, and the singing style are quite similar to those of Sichuan Opera. Secondly, the puppet design carries its own features: Jiao (2017) depicts that the puppet size is comparatively big, generally reaching sixty to eighty centimeters tall, some even up to one metre; the puppet head is designed to be realistic, mostly with a broad forehead, a big snub nose, an upper lip slightly outward, and a lower jaw tilted down, which looks much true to life (p. 167). Thirdly, cameo is more adopted, which makes the pattern lines more conspicuous much like embroidery works. Fourthly, the troupe consists of seven, eight or nine performers, up to even twelve or thirteen.

Haining Shadow Play is an important representative of shadow plays in areas south of the Yangtze, exerting great influences on Jiangsu and Zhejiang Provinces. With Shanghai to the east and Hangzhou city to the west, Haining city is a typical water town, a fertile land known for its abundance of silk, fish, and rice. Haining Shadow Play distinguishes itself from other schools in the following aspects: first, exaggeration is embodied in every detail. For example, the nose of either males or females is simply a straight line, with no curves at all; ears are quite big and long, drooping down like those of Buddha. Secondly, instead of carving, painting is used more. Sheepskins are often used in making shadow puppets, for there are not as many cattle and donkeys in Haining as in the north. As sheep's skins are thin, Haining artisans adhere to the principle of "more drawing and less carving". The head, face, and headdress are drawn with simple lines, which look delicate and graceful in conformity with the styles and features south of the Yangtze. Generally, the puppet face has no colour but the headdresses are painted with bright colours. Young females and males are drawn with thin lines, and crude and thick lines are more applied to roles good at acrobatic fighting. Thirdly, the puppets' design attaches great importance to simplicity. Most puppets have only one arm and their two legs are not separated. Two sticks are enough for a performer to manipulate such a puppet. Fourthly, in terms of singing style, Haining Shadow Play absorbs and combines local folk music and dialects, and forms a unique style called "Sea Salt Cavity", which sounds elegantly melodious.

Shandong Shadow Play is popular in Shandong Province. Its singing and speaking both use Shandong dialect. There are more immortal roles like deities, ghosts, or monsters and their facial make-up designs turn to be more personified. In Tai'an area, the manipulation, singing, drumming accompaniment, and all the other jobs in a performance are usually done by just one person. At present, there are few old artists who have such skills.

Hehuang Shadow Play is now popular in Qinghai Province. The yellow leather of the ox on Qinghai-Tibet Plateau is generally used, and the puppet making has been influenced by the local folk paper-cut art. The puppets are characteristic of big head, thin waist, and roomy sleeves. In terms of performance, the singing of Hehuang Shadow Play is rough and simple, rich in the local characteristics.

Beijing Shadow Play is mainly popular in Beijing, capital of China. It borrows and absorbs quite a lot of singing and design elements from the Peking Opera. Its singing and speaking carry prominent flavors of Beijing dialect and the puppets' faces are much like Peking Opera facial masks.

And the other schools also have their own features: Henan Shadow Play is widespread in central and eastern China. The puppets are made of thick leather and the colour looks heavy. Xiaoyi Shadow Play is well-known for its suona-horn. Chaozhou Shadow Play is popular mainly in Guangdong Province, and usually there are not more than five performers in a troupe.

Inheritance and innovation

Today, with the rapid development of science and technology, more and more forms of entertainment appear. People turn to movies, TV plays, online recreation, or games of artificial intelligence for relaxation and enjoyment. There are fewer and fewer shadow play spectators, even in the rural areas. The number of shadow play artists and craftsmen is also reduced. The old traditional Chinese Shadow Play is facing the problems of inheritance and innovation in the new era.

In recent years, efforts have been made to protect and disseminate Chinese Shadow Play. Books have been published in Chinese and in English, introducing the development, characteristics, and craftsmanship of Chinese Shadow Play. In Hangzhou, Xi'an, and other cities, there are shadow play museums and exhibitions open to the public, displaying shadow play arts and crafts so as to attract more tourists' and scholars' interest. Specialized institutes and centres have been established, where people interested in Chinese Shadow Play can study and do some research, or are taught to make shadow puppets or perform shadow plays. Some universities, high schools, and primary schools provide courses to spread the related knowledge. Shadow Play Art Festivals and competitions are regularly held in some cities. And in some places, shadow plays are always put on in teahouses.

Besides, a series of innovations have been done in the content, character images, facilities, and modes of shadow play performances. As the stories in traditional plays can no longer attract contemporary spectators, new stories are added to keep pace with the time. Themes and plots about present people's daily life, spiritual pursuits, beliefs, and values are written into scripts, and new characters, such as popular movie stars, cartoon figures, science fiction characters or contemporary heroes are portrayed and acted out. Facilities like light, screen, musical instruments, manipulating sticks, and materials for puppet making all take on a new look: new energy-saving lights are used; the traditional screens are replaced by plastic screens, or screens of other durable materials, or screens with a big breadth so that people can watch a shadow play performance from different angles and get a more comfortable watching experience; new musical instruments, or new musical elements are added; and more durable, wear-resistant materials are used to make manipulating sticks and puppets. In addition, new modes of performance have been explored; for example, shadow puppets are used in modern dramas, performing together with real people to create a special stage effect, or shadow plays appear in movies and TV plays to achieve some intended function.

Undoubtedly, although the spectators are reducing, the artistic value, collection value, and cultural value of Chinese shadow puppets have been continuously enhancing. The exquisite shadow puppets are produced and sold as artistic handiworks for collection or decoration, or as precious gifts for international friends.

Note

The in-text cited sources from references in Chinese are translated into English by the author.

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22

TAIJIQUAN AS A UNIQUE LIVING EMBODIMENT OF CHINESE PHILOSOPHY

Its essence, content, and terminology

Kit Chunyu

Introduction

Taiji (太极/太極, supreme ultimate/polarity)[1] is also spelled as *T'ai Chi* in Wade-Giles romanization using an apostrophe as aspiration mark, or more popularly as *Tai Chi* without this mark, or as *Tai-chi* or *Taichi*. It is used by most people to refer to *taijiquan* (太极拳/太極拳, also spelled as *Tai Chi Chuan*, *T'ai Chi Ch'uan* or Tai Ji Quan; literally, "taiji fist"), a popular form of nowadays physical exercise that has evolved from an ancient form of Chinese martial arts. As a term, however, it is in fact used to refer to several closely related notions of Chinese culture and philosophy that need stringent differentiation. So is taijiquan. In order to facilitate our discussion below in a rigorous way as desired, we follow ISO 7098:2015 (ISO 2015) to use taiji and taijiquan as their standard spellings. Note that ISO has adopted *Hanyu Pinyin* as the standard romanization of modern Chinese since 1982. We will follow this practice throughout this chapter to transcribe Chinese terms as necessary, especially for those that can find no equivalent counterparts in English, e.g., *yin* (阴/陰, shade) and *yang* (阳/陽, sun/sunshine). However, we also respect the convention of using taichi (mostly as tai chi in the past) as the short form for taijiquan and adopt taiji, instead, for the sake of brevity in a clear context that would cause no confusion between the two.

Taijiquan has become one of the most popular exercises for health in recent decades, and its popularity continues to grow worldwide. Harvard Health Publishing, Harvard Medical School, recommends it as one of the "5 of the best exercises you can ever do", listing it in the second place next to swimming and calling it "meditation in motion".[2] Informally, I also recommended it to friends as "swimming in the air". In numerous books, journal articles and other papers, taijiquan is defined in various ways, e.g., as "a Chinese exercise system that uses slow, smooth body movements to achieve a state of relaxation of both body and mind" in Gale Encyclopedia of Medicine;[3] "an internal Chinese martial art practiced for both its defense training and its health benefits" in Wikipedia;[4] and "a type of meditative and mind-body exercise, mainly consists of a series of slow, relaxed, and graceful physical movements connected together in a smooth and continuous manner" in a recent journal review article (Chow et al. 2018). Despite mentioning some key points such as internal martial art and relaxation of body and mind, all these are more like phenomenal descriptions focusing on its appearances than a terminologically sound definition to specify what it really is in terms of its essence. Without mentioning its relation to the core of Chinese philosophy, i.e., taichi theory, a sound definition for it appears unachievable.

In this chapter, we will first outline the basic notions in Chinese philosophy that underlie taijiquan, based on which we then move on to differentiate and define what it is. After that, we will present the full range of essential knowledge of taijiquan, with a focus on fundamental principles that can guide practitioners, including beginners and advanced learners, to learn and practice it correctly, efficiently, and effectively.

2. Chinese philosophy

There are many schools of philosophy in ancient China, especially the "ten schools" as representatives for the "hundred schools of thought" (諸子百家) that flourished during the Spring and Autumn period (771–476 BCE) and the Warring States period (475–221 BCE). Among the ten, six[5] were identified in *Records of the Grand Historian* (史記) by Sima Qian (司馬遷) and four[6] were later added in *Book of Han* (漢書) by Ban Gu (班固). There are also many unlisted, more practice-oriented ones[7] that added as significantly to the Chinese culture. Historically, many practical fields such as calendrics, divination, and medicine each offered a scope for applications of the philosophical thoughts of these schools. It is these fields, which existed long before and thrived to a certain extent already, that provided the soil for these schools to sprout and flourish, as evidenced by the typical marks of thoughts carried over from preceding dynasties, e.g., the mandate of heaven from the Western Zhou (1046–771 BCE) and the notion of cyclicity from the early Shang (1600–1046 BCE) or even earlier. This notion of cyclicity, evidently induced from repetitive moves of the sun, the moon, and star constellations, and the circular shift of seasons, underlies not only the symbolic system of divination, cosmology, and philosophy as in the *Book of Changes* (易經, *Yijing* or *I Ching*) but also the meridian system for the circulation of *qi* (氣, vital energy) as in *Yellow Emperor's Classic of Internal Medicine* (黃帝內經, *Huangdi Neijing*). Many essential taiji notions in these two ancient books, descending from an earlier time, lay an "intellectual shared common ground" (Raphals 2015a) not only for various schools of philosophy in ancient China, so as to enable dialogues among them, but also for later development of the culture and many philosophical thoughts. Among these notions, the most fundamental ones are qi, yin-yang, and five agents.

2.1 Qi

Literally, qi (氣, chi) means "air", "gas" or "breath" in the Chinese language. It was used as a metaphor to refer to the omnipresent primordial "material force" (as translated in most texts on Chinese culture and/or philosophy) that is presumed to constitute the universe and the myriad things in the universe and allows a constant change through interaction of yin and yang and cyclic regulation order of five agents (五行, *wuxing*, five agents/"goings"). It is a cornerstone notion shared by and, more importantly, underlying all classical schools of Chinese philosophy. In different contexts, it denotes slightly and subtly different conceptions, ranging from the physical to the spiritual realm, that are not always of "material". It presumes and conceptualizes the ultimate common essence of any kind of existence that makes up a physical object, forms a spiritual entity, or serves as a medium to bridge the physical and the spiritual world. Another way to put it is that everything is a manifestation of this qi, which is ever moving and changing, in that its coalescence in various ways brings the myriad things into existence and its dispersion brings them into extinguishment. In the view of philosopher Zhuangzi (莊子, 369–286 BCE), wind is the flow of qi on the earth, life is due to the gathering of qi, and death is due to the vanishing of qi. To Mencius (孟子, 372–289 BCE), the qi that pervades and animates the body has a bond with certain moral capacities so that the mind is its commander and in return it regulates thoughts in the mind. In his words, he is good at nourishing this vast, flowing qi, which is the greatest and strongest, filling up all between the heaven and the earth, and it is to be nourished with uprightness/rectitude and hence no harm can be caused (to/by it). This doctrine of nourishment with uprightness is incorporated and placed at the core of the taijiquan canon (Wang et al. 1991).

There are various English translations of qi, e.g., "material force" or "matter-energy" for the qi of inanimate objects and "vital energy/force" for that of living things. The latter is specifically used to refer to one's physical condition in Chinese medicine. But qi has broader and more abstract senses than these translations. For example, from the perspective of fengshui (風水), the goodness of a landscape, a house, and even a tomb is referred to as qi, and the quality (or the vividness) of a piece of art, e.g., Chinese calligraphy and painting, is also perceived as qi. In a word, the underlying abstract force (or principle) of (any aspect of) any object or phenomenon, be it spiritual, mental or physical, may be interpreted and, more importantly, perceived or sensed in terms of qi.

Highly comparable to the notion of qi is *pneuma* ("breath" in Greek, literally) in ancient Greek philosophy and medicine. In philosophy, it refers to the "air in motion" that makes all things, an idea in the material monism. In medicine, it means the "kinetic energy" (or "breath of life") that is brought by breath from the air into the lung and heart as "vital force" and then transformed into "natural force" in the liver and further into "psychic force" (of the indwelling soul) in the brain, in a form of circulation through human organs to maintain their systematic functioning. In contrast to the doctrine of Anaximenes (c. 586 – c. 526 BCE) that *air* is the source of everything, Heraclitus (c. 535 – c. 475 BCE) views everything as a form of the "ever-living *fire*", and even water is a frozen fire while the soul a mixture of fire and water. Aristotle (384–322 BCE) considers "connate pneuma" a kind of soul-carrying "vital heat" in sperm to pass quintessence of special characteristics to offspring, which partially coincides with the notion of prenatal/primordial (vs. postnatal) qi in Taoism and Chinese medicine, the part of one's life force solely dependent on inheritance from parents and condition of pregnancy that cannot be replenished through nutrition.

A notion more comparable to qi than pneuma is *prana* ("life force" or "vital principle" in Sanskrit) in Hindu and yogic philosophy, a perfect counterpart in another culture, which is conceived as the bioplasmic energy that permeates everywhere, coalescing to form matter and, in particular, empowering living forms. In the human body, prana moves along numerous pathways (or energy channels) called *nadi* and gathers at several (five in Buddhist texts and six or seven in Hindu) major loci called *chakra* ("wheel" or "circle" in Sanskrit) aligned along the spine to the top of the head, whereas qi moves along twelve pathways called *jingluo* (經絡, meridians) and gathers at three major loci called *dantian* (丹田, "elixir field"; literally, "cinnabar/red field") located at the centres of the low abdomen, the chest, and the head. Along each meridian are many focal points of qi, called acupuncture points (or acupoints for short). The meridians connect the qi of internal organs to respective energy channels in muscles and tendons from the body to the tips of fingers and toes through the limbs. Strengthening this connection, so as to improve one's health, is one of the main purposes of practicing taiji. At a certain high level of mastery of taiji, a master is able to unify all qi in the whole body (and even from outside) into one intensively and evenly, reaching a state that is described by the pithy formula "nowhere in the body is not part of the dantian" (周身無處不丹田) in taiji canon.

2.2 Yin, yang, and taiji

The notions of yin and yang originate from Chinese ancients' perception of the difference in the amount of sunlight on the two sides of a geographical landmark, typically, a mountain or a river. They called the side (e.g., the south of a mountain and the north of a river) receiving all or more sun the "yang" (= sunny) side and the side (e.g., the north of a mountain and the south of a river) receiving little or less the "yin" (= shady) side. Gradually, these two words were used to refer to contrastive and, especially, opposite properties of other objects in a similar analogy (e.g., bright vs. dark, hot vs. cold, moving vs. still, alive vs. dead, birth vs. death, active vs. passive) and to classify objects or phenomena in terms of an contrasting attribute (e.g., sun vs. moon, day vs. night, heaven vs. earth, summer vs. winter, man/male/masculine vs. women/female/feminine, rising vs. sinking, up vs. down, outside vs. inside). The doctrine of yin and yang is profound and yet simple that everything consists of these two forces, in particular, one positive/active and the other passive/negative, that co-exist in and unify into a whole, depend on but also oppose to each other, root in and

balance each other, compete against but also complement and depend on each other, circularly wax and wane according to each other and even transform into each other, so as to co-play the everlasting game of change through their persistent interaction in various ways. How these two forces run along with each other within and as a whole one is known as taiji, which is assumed to be the supreme principle under which the whole universe originates and runs. Its imprint is left on almost all aspects of Chinese civilization and Chinese people's daily life, e.g., medicine, calendar, fengshui, divination, art, sexual arts, martial arts, architecture, military, agriculture, government, and politics, to name a few, and its influence is so ubiquitous that one can seldom pass over this yin-yang theory to talk about Chinese philosophy and the origins of science in China (Raphals 2015b).

According to Zhuangzi, yin and yang are the greatest of qi. The critical roles they play are listed in the first Chinese medical classic, attributed to the Yellow Emperor, as this: "yin and yang, [are] the Way of heaven and earth, the general order and law of myriad things, the matrix of alterations and metamorphoses, the root and outset of giving and taking life, and the house of divine providence" (陰陽者，天地之道也，萬物之綱紀，變化之父母，生殺之本始，神明之府也《黃帝內經×素问》). There are two most famous, earliest quotes about yin and yang from the commentaries *Ten Wings* to the *Book of Change* (易經, *I Ching*), one of the six basic Confucian Classics: "one yin and one yang [constitute what is] called the Way" (一陰一陽之謂道) and "yin and yang [being] unfathomable [are deemed the greatness of] the Spirit" (陰陽不測之謂神). Another one is "the senses of yin and yang correspond to the sun and the moon" (陰陽之義配日月). The earliest recorded use of taiji can be traced back to this book too, as in this passage: "Therefore, in the Change there is taiji, which produces the two modes. These two produce the four images, and these four produce the eight trigrams" (是故，易有太極，是生兩儀，兩儀生四象，四象生八卦). The two modes (儀) are yin and yang, whose yin and yang (i.e., the major and minor yin and yang) are the four images (象). A trigram (卦) consists of three lines, either broken (for yin) or unbroken (for yang), to represent the yin or yang of an image. This specific use of taiji in the *I Ching* commentaries, conventionally attributed to Confucius (551–479 BCE), predates the one in Zhuangzi by centuries, which is "the Way, . . . is beyond taiji but not yet of height, is below the whole world but not yet of depth" (夫道，. . . 在太極之先而不為高，在六極之下而不為深). The latter is mistaken by many as the origin of taiji.

The next most important text on yin, yang, and taiji is the *Explanation of Taiji Diagram* (太極圖說) by Zhou Dunyi (周敦頤, 1017–1073), a pioneer of Neo-Confucianism in the Song dynasty. This short treatise, of only 249 Chinese characters (including 64 quoted from the classics), is an attempt to assimilate existing valid thoughts in Confucianism and Taoism descending from *I Ching* into a systematic whole, unifying the theories of yin-yang and five agents in a convincing way for the first time and sorting out the essentials for neo-Confucian cosmology and metaphysics (Hon 2010). This foundation rebuilt by Zhou was taken for granted by neo-Confucians as the groundwork to justify their ethics and believes. Zhu Xi (1130–1200), the greatest neo-Confucian, even elevates taiji to the principle at the unrivalled height under the name *li* (理, principle) or *tianli* (天理, principle of heaven/nature) beyond physical forms and asserts that it exists before, and hence gives birth to, qi that evolve into myriad things, and that yin and yang are within (or subsequent to) physical forms. His many arguments against the other scholars, which appear to have never been settled since, suggest that these bookmen so good at learning might not have ever practised taijiquan or reached a master's level. The most notorious two of their disputes are whether *wuji* (無極, non-polar(rity) or non-ultimate; a primordial unordered or chaotic state) is before taiji and whether inactivity (靜, stillness, motionlessness, tranquility) is the basis of (and hence more important than) activity (動, movement, motion). A similar dispute can be found in Adler's (2015) arguments for jettisoning "Supreme (or Great) Ultimate" and replacing it with "Supreme Polarity" as a better translation of taiji in English. We recognize that the latter gets closer to the intended meaning of the term but also see that it overemphasizes one side of the coin: the yin-yang (bi)polarity. Note that taiji subsumes both polarity and nonpolarity. Zhou highlights this in his Explanation twice: "wuji (nonpolarity) and yet taiji (supreme polarity)" (無極而太極) and

"originally, taiji is itself wuji" (太極本無極也). Accepting both wuji and taiji as loan words appears to be the best way out.

For a taijiquan master, disputes of this kind are all well resolved by the teachings of taiji canon and/or by one's self-cultivation of awareness of taiji at a certain level of accomplishment. The *Taijiquan Treatise* (太極拳論), attributed to Wang Zongyue (王宗岳) of Qing dynasty, starts with this: "Taiji, born from wuji, is [the mechanism of movement and stillness and][8] the mother/matrix of yin and yang. In movement it divides and in stillness it closes" (太極者, 無極而生, [動靜之機,]陰陽之母也, 動之則分, 靜之則合). A taiji master knows that when his taijiquan has reached a formless level, the taiji returns to (more precisely, re-unites with) wuji again, arriving at a state of wuji within taiji and also taijin within wuji, just like a pair of yin and yang in a superior taiji. Taiji is a self-contained and self-sufficient recursive model. Yin and yang are always in one, and so are wuji and taiji. A similar course typically takes place at the beginning (i.e., the first or preparatory) form of a taijiquan suite: at that moment one's body and mind are transformed from the wuji into the taiji state and yet in the former. Similar is the correlation of movement and tranquility, as reflected in the pithy formula "trigger movement in stillness and then move as being still" (靜中觸動動猶靜), revealing that they instantiate a pair of yin and yang in a similar way as the pair of wuji and taiji. How can this be possible? A simple (in fact, oversimplified) example is a flying airplane: It moves (over distance) but it is still (in itself as a whole). In contrast to this one-dimensional union of motion and stillness, taijiquan is a union of many instantiations of yin and yang in multiple dimensions, ranging from geometry (e.g., inside vs. outside, centre vs. periphery) to physics (e.g., tight vs. loose, light vs. heavy), energy (e.g., qi vs. force, internal vs. external), mental (e.g., motion of qi vs. calmness of mind), and spirit (e.g., enlightenment on soul vs. body, life vs. eternity, mortal vs. immortal). It involves so many dimensions and subsumes all in harmony as one, enlivening the doctrine of unity in multiplicity from the taiji theory – in Zhou Dunyi's words, "tens of thousands are ultimately (of the same) one and the one is instantiated as tens of thousands" (是萬為一, 一實為萬). Its fundamental principles are rooted in *I Ching* and re-moulded for higher integrality in Zhou's Explanation, which are mostly incorporated into taijiquan canons attributed to various masters. Note that Zhou's taiji diagram is not the popular double-fish yin-yang symbol, a circle divided by an S-curve into two fish-like halves, one dark for yin and the other bright for yang, each with a dot in the opposite colour at the eye of a "fish" to represent the seed of the opposite side. This symbol is a nice-looking cultural logo but it only conveys some rough ideas of taiji and is far from meaningfully comparable with Zhou's diagram for scholarly philosophical thinking in a serious sense.

2.3 Five agents

While the notion of qi represents the idea of monism in Chinese classic philosophy and cosmology, the notions of yin-yang and five agents do not really reflect dualism and pluralism, respectively, but "a dynamic monism through the dialectic" (Chan 1963: 245). It is commonly acknowledged that the latter two have separate origins in the remote antiquity and there was a long-term pursuit by ancient Chinese scholars to unify them into one. The five agents have their trace in the five seasons of the ancient solar calendar before the turn of Zhou dynasty to use the lunisolar calendar of four seasons and twenty-four solar terms. This turn must have to do with equinoxes and solstices, which naturally and clearly divide a year into four. There has since been a huge difficulty for calendarists, who were usually scholars in Yin-Yang School (or Naturalism), to match the five agents with the four seasons and the best compromise is to have the Earth (土) at the centre in support to the other four to match the four seasons in the same way as to match the four directions: Wood (木)/spring/east, Fire (火)/summer/south, Metal (金)/autumn/west, and Water (水)/winter/north.

A name of any of these five is not to refer to a type of matter but to the common nature of a category of matters that share this nature. As put in the Confucian classic *Book of History* (尚書) "Great Norm" (洪範), "the nature of Water is to soak and descend; of Fire, to blaze and ascend; of Wood, to be crooked and

straight; of Metal, to yield and remove; of Earth, to allow sowing and reaping" (水曰潤下，火曰炎上，木曰曲直，金曰從革，土爰稼穡), and consequently, they produce five savors/tastes, namely, salt, bitter, sour, acrid/pungent, and sweet, respectively. Following this pattern, things in many other categories are also aligned with these five: smells, colours, senses, organs, emotions, music tones, atmospheric conditions, planets, etc. In addition, the five also manifest their transformative nature in relation to each other, especially as in a cycle in terms of two typical orders, namely, generation (生) and conquest (克), according to *Huainanzi* (淮南子). The generation order, that one generates the next one cyclically, goes as Wood, Fire, Earth, Metal, and Water, whereas the conquest order, that one overcomes the next cyclically, goes as Wood, Earth, Water, Fire, and Metal. Even nowadays, these orders continue to find intensive and ubiquitous application in Chinese medicine. Although no writings of any Yin-yang scholar are preserved in the history, there are some passages scattered in a few ancient books that briefly sketch the doctrines of yin-yang and five agents and their application. The most significant is a passage in *Lu's Spring and Autumn Annals* (呂氏春秋) about Zou Yan (鄒衍, 305–240 BCE), the most representative scholar of the Yin-yang school, who is best known as a political philosopher for a famous account for the succession of previous dynasties in terms of the cyclicity of the five agents' virtues in the generation order, under the name of the destiny preordained by heaven: Yellow Emperor, for a time of Earth virtue and hence yellow colour; Xia dynasty, of Wood and green; Shang, of Metal and white; and Zhou, of Fire and red. Following this philosophy of cyclical history, the emperors of the next two dynasties, Qin and Han, believed the virtues of their times to be, respectively, Water and Earth and their colours black and yellow (especially for their suits, courts, and soldier uniforms).

The five agents are incorporated into the taiji canon Explanatory Note for the Name of Taijiquan[9] (Wang et al. 1991: 30) to represent the "five steps" (or stances), namely, advancing forward as Metal, retreating backward as Wood, attending leftward as Water, watching rightward as Fire, and keeping tranquility inwards as Earth. Most practitioners take them as five separate steps of moving, regardless of Zhou Dunyi's teaching that "five agents are one [through] yin and yang, which are one [through] taiji" (五行一陰陽也，陰陽一太極也). In fact, all these five are to be realized as one simultaneously, just like a balloon expanding in all directions while keeping its integrity, stillness, and evenness as a whole. In taijiquan, the cyclicity of the five agents and the two modes is to be achieved in many more subtle ways, e.g., continuous curvy movements circle after circle and wave after wave, bouncing an opponent's force back to the opponent, and so forth. In a word, taiji principles need to be followed and then realized through taijiquan practice, especially through solo dance, push hand, and meditation, so as to allow one's sensation of taiji to grow inside the body and the mind. It is in this sense that we may say taijiquan is a living embodiment of Chinese philosophy.

2.5 Eight trigrams

As mentioned earlier, taiji is a recursive model. Taiji as a whole has two modes, each of which has two modes too, namely, the four images (or quadrants), each of which also has two modes, namely, the eight trigrams. This recursive binary branching may go on with no end. Each trigram has a name and a symbol consisting of three lines, either broken (for yin) or unbroken (for yang), forming a binary representation system. With 0 for yin and 1 for yang, Figure 22.1 illustrates how the trigrams are generated from taiji (as the root at the bottom) through binary branching, with trigram symbols, names, and corresponding binary codes at the top. Figure 22.2 shows the association of the trigrams with directions, the five agents, and seasons. In Chinese culture, the relative directions are considered to associate with the cardinal directions, as front/south, back/north, left/east, and right/west, and accordingly there are four relative intercardinal directions too.

These trigrams are borrowed into taijiquan canons to symbolize the eight types of push hand skills, called Eight Gates (八門), which are also known as eight *jing*'s (勁, force skills). The latter term is cast to differentiate between muscle tension producing no physical force and body moves producing physical force. The former is dubbed *li* (力, strength, force) or *zhuoli* (拙力, stiffened strength; literally, dull force), while

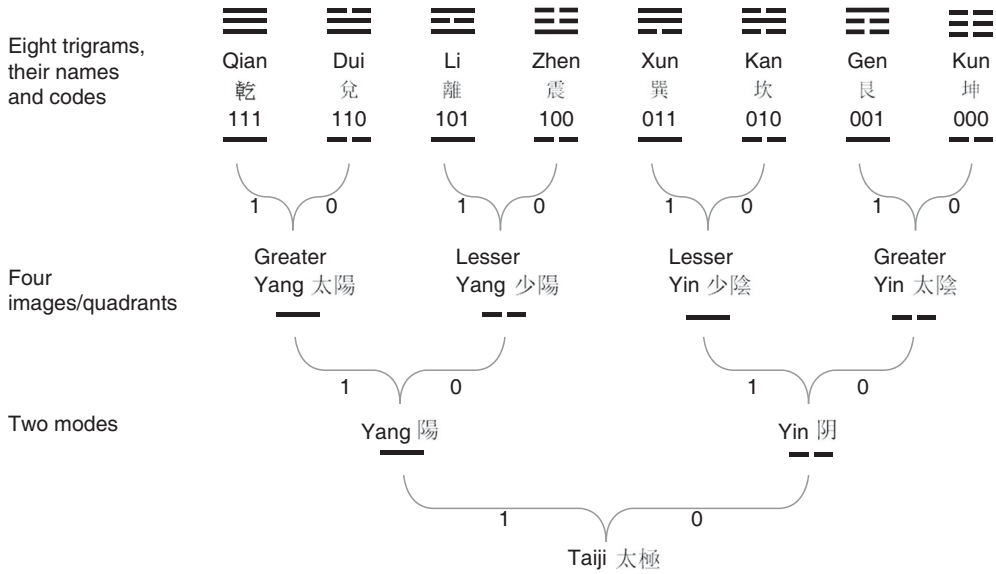

Figure 22.1 Generation of the eight trigrams from taiji through two modes and four images/quadrant

Source: By the author

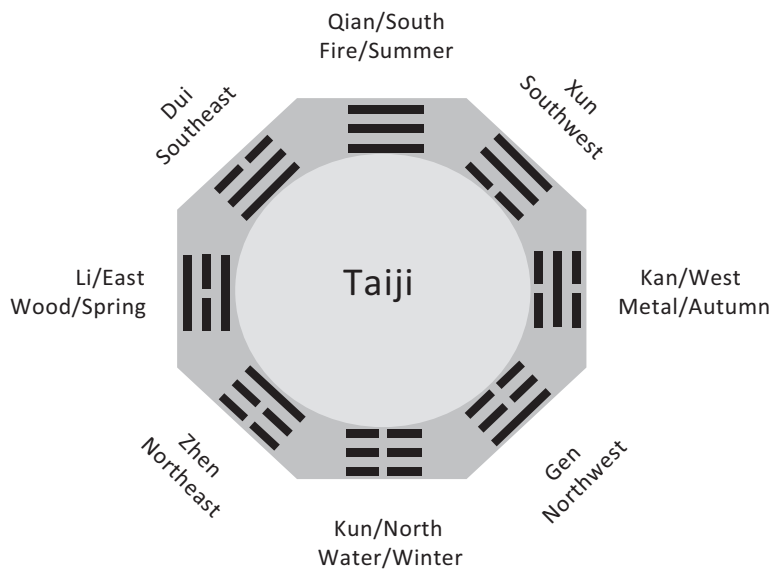

Figure 22.2 Association of trigrams with directions, five agents, and seasons

Source: By the author

the latter *jing* or *zhenli* (真力, true force). In physics, force is defined as interaction between objects that causes change to the motion of an unopposed object, and has both magnitude and direction. In this chapter, exchanging it with "power" or "energy" is unlikely to lead to any misconception or misunderstanding, because the eight force skills reflect an empirical decomposition of push hand into eight aspects, just like that of taiji into eight trigrams, and also an empirical categorization of *jing*'s in terms of direction. In this sense, the eight gates also mean eight categories. They can be summarized as follows:

1 *Peng* (掤, ward off), a supporting force of outward expanding quality like an air-filled balloon, to produce an upward force upon an opponent like buoyancy;
2 *Lu* (捋, roll back), a transverse force of yielding and diverting quality in a sideway direction of an incoming force;
3 *Ji* (擠, squeeze, press), a forward pressing force of bouncing (not pushing) back quality upon the opponent, like a coin bounced back from a drumhead;
4 *An* (按, downward push), a downward pushing force of water flowing quality, to let one's weight to permeate through the opponent;
5 *Cai* (採, pluck, pick), a pulling force of plucking quality to redirect the opponent's force to somewhere else, usually along an intercardinal direction, in a way like picking a fruit from a tree;
6 *Lie* (挒, split, rend), to split a force into two (as a combination of any two in the previous five) upon the opponent, usually in two opposite intercardinal directions;
7 *Zhou* (肘, elbow), to use the elbow(s) to perform any one or any combination of the previous six; and
8 *Kao* (靠, bump), to use the shoulder, upper chest, hip or the whole body to perform any one or any combination of the six upon the opponent.

According to movement directions, the former four coincide and hence are associated with the cardinal directions, and the latter four with the intercardinal. Many practitioners take the last two as issuing a strike with any of these parts of the body. We need to go beyond this narrow-minded understanding. Taijiquan is also called Thirteen Postures, which refers to the combination of the "five steps" and the "eight gates" into one, implying that any body part may perform all or any combination of them as one, not only a strike.

3. Taijiquan: forms, skills, and essence

Traditional taijiquan training includes three parts, namely solo forms, push hand, and weapons. The latter mainly includes sword, cudgel/stick (evolving from spear for the sake of safety in training and also due to an increasingly lower chance of use), and broadsword/sabre. The training of the latter applies the awareness of taiji gained from the former two and follows the same principles, despite different forms, skills, and experience. Given this, and the fact that genuine taiji weapon training has basically died out and is hence of very little significance in present urban society, we assume that it suffices to cover the former two in this section.

3.1 What is taijiquan?

Taijiquan has a long history, so long that its origin can hardly be traced. According to available documentation, several popular schools (or styles) of contemporary taijiquan, including Yang (楊), Wu (武), and Wu (吳) schools, are known to have evolved from Chen (陳) school. The inheritors of Chen school hold the view that taijiquan was created by an ancestor of Chen family. However, Chen style is argued by many others to closely relate to Zhaobao (趙堡; Zhao Fort) style, which is claimed by its inheritors of all generations

to have originated from Wudang internal martial arts with a strong Daoist tradition. There has been a huge gap between these schools in terms of their forms, techniques, and training procedures.

We define taijiquan as a mind-body exercise, typically in a form of martial arts, to cultivate practitioners' sensation or awareness of taiji principles, disregard its forms, styles, and approaches to training and teaching. This definition may nullify the notorious long-lasting argumentation about who created taijiquan and where and when was its authentic origin, which is mostly due to the lack of a clear definition of taijiquan. There is a long history of practical application of taiji philosophy in all aspects of Chinese civilization and the Chinese way of living, including medicine, calendar, religion, fortune telling, sexual arts, arts of war, etc. It looks unlikely that martial arts were not among them. It is the application of taiji principles to martial arts, not any legendary figure's watching the fight of a snake and a hawk (which is a story under so many big names, including Zhang Sanfeng (張三丰), a famous Taoist priest in Wudang Mountain), that gave rise to taijiquan.

Many people who are fascinated by taijiquan take the double-fish yin-yang symbol ☯, a font that has been turned 90° clockwise, as taiji diagram or the sign for taiji, and print it on their flags, cloths, tags, and posters, making it popular and, in fact, ubiquitous. There is nothing wrong with so doing, especially taking it to symbolize taiji, but there is a need to point it out that it is not the taiji diagram by Zhou Dunyi. As a sign, in linguist de Saussure's term, if it only has the signifier (i.e., the symbol) without a well-established signified (i.e., the notion or concept it denotes), it is not more than an ornamental motif, e.g., those double-fish like figures found in the Celtic and the Tripilia culture in Europe and those as shield patterns of West Rome. Despite also originating from the remote antiquity, these decoration patterns provide no hint for their connection with taiji philosophy, taiji diagram or the double-fish taiji symbol. The latter was first released by Zhao Weiqian (趙撝謙) only 650 years ago in early Ming dynasty in the title of *Heaven and Earth Nature River Diagram* (天地自然河圖), clearly attributed to Fuxi, the furthest ancestor of Chinese and the legendary author of *I Ching* and the eight trigrams (Li 2001: 80–84).

3.2 Taiji as the essence of taijiquan

Almost all practitioners start practicing taijiquan from learning the solo *forms* of a particular style (or school), e.g., the eighty-five forms[10] of Yang style, the most popular one among many. A set of forms are organized into a continuous sequence for solo exercise (or solo dance) called a *routine* or a *suite*, which implies that the whole set is to be performed throughout for a round of exercise. By the term "form" we mean a continuous dynamic body movement from a posture (i.e., an arrangement of one's body, head, and limbs) to another or through a number of postures from a starting one to an ending one. Intuitively, a posture is perceived, especially by most beginners, to be static or still. Although this inevitable (and even goal-directed) false impression is facilitative in helping beginners to pick up taiji forms step by step, it adversely leads to a widespread unnoticed misconception that taiji is performed in an interrupted manner. To rectify this misapprehension, it is worthwhile to point out that picking up individual taiji forms does not mean any genuine practice of taiji yet, which starts only after the forms can be performed seamlessly in a fluent sequence. Speaking metaphorically, forms are like a boat for you to cross a river – you have to build it first, without which river crossing is beyond reach. In this sense, learning taiji forms (which may take some months) is nothing more than preparing a means for practicing taiji, just like building a boat for river crossing. At an advanced level, forms are performed without any fixed posture but as a flow of movement for energy distribution in the body and then energy projection outward, and every temporary slice of the flow becomes a posture that is dynamic and yet static, unifying motion and stillness by what is known as the "mechanism (or pivot) of mobility and immobility (or activity and inactivity)" (動靜之機) in Wang's Taiji Treatise.

Gradually, a taijiquan practitioner may achieve a level of mastery of taiji to distribute energy evenly in such a fine way that all forms are (or mean) the same, i.e., they are all variants to be derived from (or to be unified into) the same one and, more importantly, to realize the true one. Ultimately, this true one can

be practised with any form (i.e., any form can do, or is as good, for the purpose of achieving the essence of taiji) and then with no form (i.e., performing forms so skillfully in a free manner). Then a practitioner is freed from forms and can do taiji mainly or even only with his mind-intent (意). This explains why taijiquan forms vary so transiently from generation to generation, from style to style (e.g., from Chen style to Yang and to Wu), and even from master to master of the same style. It also explains why top masters, as claimed by many, can keep practicing while walking, standing, sitting, and even sleeping, confirming that taiji, the very core or essence of taijiquan, is formless in itself. It is also a nice example to demonstrate the doctrine of unity in multiplicity and multiplicity in unity, a piece of the oriental wisdom.

3.3 Solo form and push hand

The relation and connection of solo forms and push hand are as follows: practicing solo forms is the best way to raise one's awareness (or sensation) of taiji, for which one of the most important aspects is the enhancement of internal power by cultivating qi, whereas push hand is the best way, actually the only effective way, to verify the achievement of this awareness, confirming or falsifying whether one's solo form play is pursued in the correct direction. Many practitioners focus too much (or even solely) on one of the two, ending up with making very little (or even no) substantial progress in mastering taiji. Typically, many young practitioners focus intensely on practicing push hand skills and turn out not to have much gain. They particularly need to understand that the skills without adequate internal power are like leaves on a tree without roots and that taiji sensation, which underlies internal power, has to be cultivated by slow and smooth play of solo forms in correct postures and movements for a long time period following a proper procedure of training and progressing. This is truly stated by the saying that "ten years is barely enough to unlock the door to success in taiji" (太極十年不出門; literally, "taijji ten years not leave the door"). I turn it into a more pessimistic but also more realistic version as "ten years is barely enough to set one's sights on the door" (太極十年不入門), which happens to be true for most practitioners. But this does not mean that the way around, i.e., focusing solely on solo form play, would be any better, for the play would be unlikely to give the right direction for one to make progress without adequate push hand experience for verification, feedback, and guidance. Playing solo forms exclusively is like growing a tree with only roots but not leaves. An untold secret in taiji practice is that push hand has to be enhanced by solo forms and vice versa, otherwise the two parts, which need to mutually inform each other in practice, would become "the sole yin [that] cannot generate and the sole yang [that] cannot grow" (孤阴不生，独阳不长).

3.4 First step of taiji practice: how to find a good teacher?

Genuine taiji practice needs to start with and then be continuously guided by a qualified instructor, preferably a taiji master. But how does one know if he or she is learning from a good-enough instructor? This is a serious concern shared not only by most beginners but also by many advanced learners. In order to find an answer, two criteria are highly applicable, namely, the level of taiji mastery and the capacity of explaining and illustrating basic notions and theories of taiji in teaching. A straightforward way to test one's taiji achievement is to push him and observe his responses. If any response is noticeable to you involving brute force or stiff strength to struggle against your push, you are advised to look for a better teacher. If your opponent allows you to push in whatever way you want and still stands firmly without much resistance, you meet a good taiji teacher. If you lose control once starting to push or your push is even bounced back to drive you away, especially in a way that the harder you push the farther you drive yourself away, you meet an even better teacher. If your pushing hands can find no landing point to push or your push disappears somehow or goes to somewhere unintended, you meet a master. If the first bit of contact by your push or even your intent of pushing before any physical contact makes you unable to stand, you meet a grand master. These are some experiences for empirical judgement that may help to a certain extent.

However, a taiji master, in terms of achievement, may not necessarily be a good teacher if he is only capable of instructing students to perform taiji skills by telling them to do "this and that". Taiji practice includes two aspects, namely skills and theory, both of which need to have a comprehensive coverage through systematic teaching and learning. A qualified teacher needs to teach a full range of yin-yang notions and principles in the taiji theory, that go far beyond those in the existing (or remaining) taiji canons, and, more importantly, demonstrate pairwise instantiations of yin and yang (e.g., looseness vs. stiffness, stillness vs. motion, solidity vs. void/emptiness) through push hand so as to let students feel what they are and what effects to achieve when performing them correctly following the taiji principles. Most taiji notions and skills are too abstract to be visible and even perceivable to laymen and cannot be taught by words or by actions alone. It is said that a good master allows waist-touching (摸腰) during teaching, to allow students to feel what is really happening inside his body. But feelings of this kind do not necessarily help one to conceptualize the internal happenings into proper notions without explicit instructions. Many masters share a piece of experience that they turned to taiji canons when having reached a certain level of mastery and benefited greatly from the key notions in taiji philosophy, helping themselves to advance to the next level of mastery. A long-standing problem in practical training is that many practitioners pick up the names of many notions without really realizing them in their skills while many others only work on skills without a thorough understanding of the notions behind them, both resulting in the so-called halfway practice. All these suggest that a good taiji teacher requires not only a high level of achievement in taiji skills but, more importantly, also the capacity of teaching taiji theory. Note that one cannot always rely on a teacher forever. Once having a sound understanding of taiji notions, one has in fact paved a path towards continuous skill advancement by self-teaching without a teacher. This may be taken as a general guide for taiji practice at the advanced level.

3.5 Solo forms for gymnastic taiji

Gymnastic taiji refers to playing taijiquan as a kind of gymnastic exercise for health purposes. For this purpose, one may not really need a master as instructor. Anyone who can teach a whole suite of solo forms of any style will do, and even a DVD of teaching taijiquan will do, although it is preferable to have an experienced teacher. The majority of nowadays taiji players, including many athletes giving solo form performance for martial arts competition in sports games, fall into this category. This kind of taiji dance is also known as "Chinese ballet", which focuses exclusively on solo forms only, with no push hand. Although some players may do push hand to some extent, they do it as gymnastic exercise, not as the conventional martial art training for potential skills of fighting or for cultivation of taiji sensation.

One may start gymnastic taiji with the 24-form Simplified Taijiquan, released by the State Physical Culture and Sports Commission (now the General Administration of Sport) of China in 1956. It is the simplest and the most popular suite for solo dance, consisting of unique forms extracted from traditional suits of Yang style. One of its greatest advantages is its simplicity and hence its ease to learn, but its obvious disadvantage is that it has too few forms for systematical organization into a suite for comprehensive genuine taiji training, which needs adequate exercise volume. There are several simplified suites derived from various schools for promotion of taijiquan in the public (PSPH 1998). After playing with one or some of them for a certain period of time, say, one year or two, most interested players usually turn to conversational suites of some school for advanced studies. As gymnastic taiji alone is unlikely to lead to any genuine martial art training, nor to any meaningful cultivation of taiji awareness, a player does not have to pay too much attention to the quality of forms as in stance, postures, and the movement of body parts between postures. When doing it, one may simply relax and enjoy some aspects of the forms in whatever way one may wish, e.g., some martial art "beauty" in the shape, rhythm, and fluency of the postures that one can conceive. One may do taiji dance in company with nice music too, which of course makes little sense for martial arts and taiji practice, or move on to other kinds of taiji dance with weapons

such as sword or fan. There are traditional suites for professional taiji sword, but taiji fan dance is created by amateurs for exercise purpose.

However, an interested player may take the simplified taijiquan as a nice starting point towards genuine taiji training by paying adequate attention to the form qualities, especially the stance of a posture and the continuous movement of body parts between postures. Stance does not only mean standing with two feet on the ground to support the body. A quality stance allows one to awake to the reality, which most people neglect for most of the time, that physically, we stand on our gravity centre. This was recognized by Gongsun Long (公孫龍, 320–250 BCE), a philosopher of the School of Names in ancient China, as the "third foot of a chicken" (雞三足). It is to achieve a natural and neutral stance to minimize leaning off from the gravity centre and to enable loosened legs for more movements than merely supporting the body weight. Typically, when one jumps, this desired stance is perfectly realized at two moments: the comment of taking off and that of landing. The difficulty of performing a high-quality taiji dance lies in that this stance needs to be constantly kept throughout the whole suite. Once having mastered this stance, one should be able to pass two simple tests: jump off from the ground at any moment without any extra move preparing for jumping and any of the two feet, including the front foot in the walking (or bow) step (弓步) position, can be lifted from the ground freely.

3.6 Taijiquan as health exercise

Taijiquan as a kind of martial arts may be pursued as a nice health exercise. However, it is popularly considered by most laymen a kind of aerobic exercise that typically and exclusively fits the aged. This is clearly a misconception. In fact, it fits people of all ages that need various levels of exercise intensity, and the younger to start to learn it, the better. Just like learning a music instrument or Chinese calligraphy, to start at a young age is definitely preferable, because it is about cultivation of sensation, which not only takes time but demands sensitivity and adaptability. This can be evidenced by the fact that all music masters and taiji masters start their career from a very young age.

When doing taiji for health purposes, one needs to follow all basic principles of physical exercise. The number one principle is to achieve a beneficial level of exercise volume, which can be measured in terms of exercise time and intensity. Quality is of course a closely related criterion. It is not rare that many taiji amateurs parade the good of taiji as a health exercise that brings comfort with no deepened breath, no sweat, and no faster heartrate. This is another misconception. The exercise volume of performing a taiji suite for serious training should be at least as much as that of jogging for the same period of time, which is seldom achieved by most amateur players, especially the comfort chasers among them, in their taiji dance. The necessity is highly recognized that one needs to adjust the exercise volume according to one's age, physique, and health conditions, typically by controlling the height of postures and the scale and speed of body and body part movements. No player is encouraged to hold too low postures for overambitious pursuit of kungfu (功夫; the power or accomplishment of martial arts), which may cause serious harm to one's knees. Instead, a better and also safer way of making progress is that when your internal power grows through more exercise, you are able to perform lower postures, which in return helps grow your internal power. Note that it is the quality (or correctness) of taiji forms, not the height of postures, that leads to the enhancement of internal power. Lower postures help only in the circumstance that the forms are performed correctly.

Safety is another principle that can never be emphasized enough in taiji exercise as in any other kinds of exercise for health purposes. All kinds of sport activity involve the safety issue. So does taiji. It is well known that adequate warming up is the most effective way to prevent unexpected injuries. For taiji dance, this is not really necessary because of both the nature of the dance, in that it involves only continuous slow and smooth body movements, especially at the beginning of a suite, and the design of a conventional suite, in that the postures in the first section, especially at the outset, are easy and simple (but profound). The most

commonly seen safety problem during taiji training is knee injury, mostly due to a too low posture or a sudden twist with stiff force. Most injuries during push hand are due to struggling with stiff force. Remember that rule number one in taiji practice is "not to use [any stiff] force" (不用力), which is also the most fundamental rule to guarantee safety in taiji training.

Taiji is also well known as the kind of meditation exercise through smooth mind-body movements. It is not easy for beginners to integrate meditation into taiji dance. It is therefore highly recommended that taiji practitioners also do some meditation exercise through stand still or sit still for cultivation of qi. Although the technical details of meditation are beyond the scope of this chapter, the general guideline one can have is very simple: empty (or neutralize) your body, and empty your mind, so as to sense the truth of what you are in the void. The first step is to sit (or stand) straight comfortably and relax by lightening and lengthening the breath, a natural way to calm down the mind, so as to sense the flow of qi (vital energy) in the body. One may concentrate on watching (by sensing, not with eyes) the breath first, then the whole body and finally the mind itself. Gradually, one may still the mind to such a level that the mind-body and the space-time become one like a vast void or boundless transparency, arriving at a mind state called enlightenment, in which one may experience certain ultimate truth, perpetuity, eternity or even omniscience. This is also the ultimate goal of taiji exercise as conventional practice in Daoism.

For taiji practitioners today, however, we may not need to go that far but do need to understand the relation of two fundamental categories of Chinese health exercise, namely, *jinggong* (靜功, quiescent or static exercise) including meditation through sit still or stand still, and *donggong* (動功, active or dynamic exercise) including taiji dance, *Wuqinxi* (五禽戲, the Five Animals Play) and spontaneous meditative movements, that they complement and mutually enrich each other. Cultivation of qi is particularly helpful to enhance one's awareness of taiji essence, and meditation is the best way of cultivating qi. Taiji essence is about how to use one's mind-intent to lead the qi to realize wanted distribution of one's energy (or power) following the yin-yang principles. Without the movement of qi, the finest material (or the essence) in the body, what is available for one to use is nothing other than stiffened force. Only when one's mind and body has calmed down and become still (and even empty, to a certain extent) can one feel the existence and the flow of qi in the body. From the viewpoints of Chinese medicine and Daoism, meditation particularly helps one to cultivate qi in dantian and then sense it and drive it to flow along meridians, the qi pathways. Taiji is a mind-body exercise to enhance not only the muscles, tendons, and bones of our body and limbs but, more importantly, the health of our internal organs. Chinese medicine values the ideas that the meridians are the qi flow channels of respective functional "organs" – accordingly each meridian is named after an organ, e.g., the heart meridian and the bladder meridian – and that performing traditional therapies like *zhenjiu* (針灸, acupuncture-moxibustion; literally, needle-heat therapy) or massage on the acupoints of a meridian, so as to strengthen the qi flow or release existing pain or other uncomfortable symptoms on or near these acupoints, has the healing power to help improve the health condition of the respective organ. In taiji practice, advanced practitioners may also follow these ideas to do organ exercise, so to speak, which means to engage wanted organ(s) in exercise, by the mind-intent to drive more qi and strengthen the qi flow along respective meridian(s). For this purpose, one of course has to acquire necessary knowledge of meridians and integrate it into taiji practice.

Meditation is particularly good at cultivating qi and enhancing one's awareness of qi, whereas taiji dance as a kind of dynamic meditation is a particularly good way of using qi to achieve health or martial art purposes. Without qi movement, taiji practice can be at most a halfway exercise towards cultivating taiji awareness. When having relaxed the body and having calmed the mind to a certain level, one can feel the qi flow. This is particularly helpful to guide one towards mastering two fundamental taiji principles, as stated in the taiji canons: pursue stillness in motion and motion in stillness (動中求靜, 靜中求動), and nowhere in the whole body is unlike the qi loci dantian.

3.7 Taijiquan as martial art

When talking about taijiquan as martial arts, a common question that one may ask is: Can it fight? The answer depends on what is meant by "fight". Certainly, all martial arts originated from combat skills, but many of them have developed into sports that allow competition in different ways following different rules. Whether one with these skills can fight like a kickboxer or MMA (mixed martial arts) fighters depends very much on a full range of training to enhance one's speed, strength, power, agility, sensation, and experience, etc., to a required level. Taiji practice focuses on sensation of taiji principles (including how force or power work) more than the others, and involves relatively little training on punching and kicking. In contrast of kickboxing, which is to end a fight by body contact, push hand as taiji training towards combat starts from body contact. It is hence unsurprising that a taiji athlete is as incapable of MMA fighting as an MMA fighter is of pushing hand. Many representative taiji masters are known to be very capable of bare handed fighting because they had adequate respective training to put their taiji skills to practical use. It is an oversimplified answer or a misconception to say taiji or any kind of martial arts can or cannot fight. The advantage or superiority of taiji does not lie in how capable it can fight, but in providing a path towards its universally valid principles. This may explain why only practitioners of other kinds of martial arts shift to taiji, not the way around.

Another commonly seen misconception that particularly needs clarification is about the taiji principle of "not to use force". Many practitioners feel very frustrated that no matter whether they do or do not use force, they do not get it right. It is not rare that many taiji masters even give contradictory teaching, like "do not use force, then you have force", that students can hardly understand and follow. Another term *zhenli* (真力; literally, true force) was hence cast, unnecessarily though, for a differentiation from *li* (力, force) that one can feel and "use" but produce no effect like a physical force does. This term is redundant but does reflect the fact that many masters lacked scientific knowledge about the notion of force as in physics. It is also redundant that other terms like "power" and "energy" are used in English taiji texts, to avoid using "force". This is unnecessary. A scientific explanation is that our nervous system is not as good to sense physical force (e.g., gravity) as other stimuli like pain and itch, so that when we feel any "force", it is actually the feeling about tension caused by muscle contraction, which produces no physical effect upon anything outside. We can do away with this misconception if we keep the term "force" for physical force and avoid using it to refer to the kind of muscle tension as force or strength. The essence of the "not to use force" principle tells that it is the correct body part movements, not extra muscle tension, that produce a force and that the less extra muscle tension, the more efficiently one can issue a force. This explains why relaxation to minimize muscle tension has to be one of the most fundamental exercises in *taiji* practice, and in other sports too.

Note, however, that the real essence of taiji does not lie in "not to use force", which is no more than a starting point for a practitioner's learning. It goes beyond using force or not, in that it nullifies an incoming force by either giving it a futile goal to go after, undoing its root before or after it has been issued, or even redirecting it back to its root. Certainly, any of these demands a very high level of sensation and mastery of taiji essence. To achieve such mastery, one has to spend years and even decades. Towards this goal, one certainly has to begin with both taiji solo form and push hand exercise, which without doubt needs face to face teaching and training. A written chapter like this one is unlikely to help in this aspect, no matter how many technical details are provided. Instead, it is more meaningful to end this chapter with an outline of high level guidance that practitioners may follow or take as a reference.

3.7.1 Instantiations of yin and yang

In the taiji theory, yin and yang are two abstract notions generalized from natural phenomena. Without instantiation, they are empty notions and no one can follow them to apply any taiji principles in taijiquan practice. To put it simply, any opposite aspects of one thing can be an instantiation of yin and yang. Instead

of attempting to exhaust all possibilities, we highlight a few representative yin-yang pairs in the following categories in hopes to facilitate readers' understanding. In a taiji movement, any yin-yang pair needs to be unified as one and coordinate with each other following the taiji principles.

1 Geometrical pairs, concerning postures and forms in the space-time: front and back, left and right, top and bottom, verticality and horizontality, curve and straight, circle and square, cardinal vs. intercardinal directions, centre and periphery, inside and outside, etc.
2 Movement pairs: motion and stillness, opening and closing, expanding and contrasting, loosening vs. tightening, sinking, and rising, in addition to movement pairs in the above geometrical directions. Note that all movements are to be realized by opening and closing simultaneously, with minimal movement of body parts. One has to have achieved successful training for opening first (e.g., "enlarging" joints) in order to get room for closing, and vice versa. It is about transformation of body shape for a better distribution of one's weight, the only source of power. Loosening joints and muscles so as to use no stiffened force is the prerequisite to enable this.
3 Energy distribution pairs: *youwu* (有無, existence vs. non-existence, being vs. non-being), *xushi* (虛實, emptiness vs. solidity, unfilled vs. filled), *qingzhong* (輕重, lightness vs. heaviness), internal vs. external, etc. The most common mistake in energy distribution is double weighting, and the most common misconception about this mistake is that it is about standing only and hence one could avoid it by standing on one foot more heavily than the other. In fact, any point (or part) and any move of your body are double weighted as long as it is not adequately opened and properly differentiated into yin-yang pairs, especially the last few previously mentioned.

There are also many ying-yang pairs concerning mentality and spirit. For example, the three-talents (三才) model involves heaven (天) and earth (地) as a yin-yang pair, with man (人) in between. Taiji practice is intended to unify them into one, so as to absorb the pure (清; literally, clean) energy from the heaven and the impure (浊; literally, muddy) energy from the earth into the body of man. At an advanced level of taiji mastery, one can achieve this by "hanging" the *baihui* (百會) acupoint at the top of the head to the sky and also "sinking" the yongquan (涌泉) acupoint at the centre of feet to the center of the earth resulting in a mind-intent guided posture that centralizes better and extends the vertical central line better to multiply one's energy. A push hand opponent can feel the substantial difference between doing so and not doing so correctly.

3.7.2 Taiji principles

The taiji philosophy is founded on the basis of the yin and yang notions, which give rise to a set of principles (or laws) about the truth of myriad things (or phenomena) in this cosmos that taiji practice should observe. A few key principles can be sketched briefly as follows.

1 Unity (or wholeness): taiji is one, a wholly one, of unbroken totality or completeness, leaving nothing out and including nothing extra.
2 Duality: every one can be divided or differentiated into two that are opposite, independent, and complementary to each other. The two co-exist in one, and none of them exist without the other. Accordingly, there is duality in unity and vice versa.
3 Recursiveness: the divisibility of one into two is endlessly recursive, as demonstrated by the division of taiji into two modes and then into four images, eight trigrams, and sixty-four hexagrams.
4 Everlasting change, balance, and harmony: the two opposites keep waxing and waning but remain in a balanced and harmonic state, maintaining a dynamic balance with no one overcoming the other.

5 Continuity and circularity: the waxing and waning of the two opposites take place in a continuous, seamless manner with periodicity in both space and time.
6 Mutuality: the two opposites enable and depend on each other while competing against each other, complement to and transform into each other, interact with and maintain faultless inter-correspondence with each other.

3.8 Taiji practice for awareness of taiji essence

Given the preceding, the key stages for taiji training, including solo dance and push hand, can be outlined as follows, despite that each stage may take many technical steps for one to go through in years. In general, one would not be able to move onto the next stage without a satisfactory level of mastery in all previous stages.

3.8.1 Unification

It is aimed to unify all body parts into an organic one. Without this unity, there is no taiji in any taijiquan form. Beginners are so used to moving body parts (e.g., hands and feet) separately with inadequate coordination. There is no direct way to put body parts any closer than they are, in pieces instead of as one. No matter how closely two pieces of ice are put together, they are two. One has to melt all body parts into one by numerous times of solo dance. The ten thousand times rule is also reflected in a saying about Chinese martial art training: "A fist manifests its law after ten thousand times of practice" (拳打萬遍, 其法自現). Going beyond a certain level of fluency of solo dance, a practitioner will gradually learn to integrate every move into a whole through nice coordination. Like an air-filled balloon, when one point moves or enlarges, the whole body corresponds spontaneously. Ultimately, a tiny move by mind-intent can be multiplied into great power. The best (and perhaps the only) way to achieve this unification is to relax and loosen all muscles, joints, and bones, and then let them hang, naturally, back to the vertical central line of our body in alignment with the gravity centre, i.e., the "third foot" on which we actually stand. In order to achieve this, we have to identify this central line first. Once having found it, we keep it and use it to coordinate all body parts in harmony and allow it to work as a spring to send power up and down and all around.

Then, the next level of unification is to integrate all five steps and eight gates into one. This is the number one rule that is specifically highlighted in the *Song of Thirteen Postures* (Wang et al. 1991: 34), one of the most important taiji canons. Its first verse reads: "The general posture of all thirteen should not be undervalued; an alive mind-intent finds its wellspring in the tiny interstice of the waist" (十三總勢莫輕視, 命意源頭在腰隙). It has to be enabled by and built upon central tranquility.

3.8.2 Centralization for central tranquility

Central tranquility (中定, centre-stillness) is one of the key notions and one of the most important techniques in taiji practice. The training for centralization is based on the well unified whole and aimed to further strengthen the central line by reducing use of force and enhancing the use of body weight. All taiji beginners share a question: What to use if not to use force? The answer is: our weight. Centralization is to further solidify the well-unified body and condense it towards the gravity centre, i.e., the centre of balance, so as to allow an effective expansion towards the periphery and ultimately, enable projection of power from the centre to the outside by mind-intent control. The latter is a process of decentralization, which has to be built up and co-exist with centralization. These two form a pair of yin-yang movements. Centralization enables relaxation, which is to loosen everything inward as well as downward, and decentralization co-works with the former to further enhance it. All taiji training for relaxation, starting from adequate fluency of solo dance, is to enable one to use the mind-intent, instead of any force (用意不用力; literally, use mind-intent, not use force). This is a bottleneck for all practitioners. A master's teaching of this principle to

a pupil would be in vain if the pupil has not well prepared to make things in the body loosened and hence light enough to allow the mind-intent, which is so subtle and powerless, to take control. In order to pass this bottleneck, the next two stages of training are needed.

3.8.3 Generalization of opening and closing for more yin yang pairs

The centralization and decentralization as a pair of yin-yang movements are known as *kaihe* (開合; literally, open-close) in traditional taiji terminology. One of the best-known maxims to highlight its importance reads: "The way of boxing is of nothing more than opening-and-closing" (為拳之道, 開合而已). Note that yin and yang are one in taiji. So are opening and closing. That is, they are one movement towards two ends simultaneously, from inside out and also from outside in, not two movements to open and then close or vice versa. When one has mastered it, the central line that enables these movements and the body parts in these movements are, inevitably, still double weighted. To further go beyond this, one has to keep moving forward to apply the opening-and-closing that he has mastered to both the central line and all body parts, in particular, the joints of the limbs and the spine, one by one and step by step. It is particularly important in taiji practice that once you have mastered a skill in one place of your body, you apply it to as many other places as possible. More importantly, opening and closing do not end up only with more possibilities of body movement. Instead, it enables self-teaching of differentiation of more and more pairs of yin and yang in various dimensions, ranging from space-time, movement, energy, and spirit, as outlined earlier. In this way, a successful practitioner will be gradually heading towards a state that is, as characterized in *Lu's Spring and Autumn Annals* and many Daoist classics, "so minute to allow no interior and yet so immense to allow no exterior" (其大無外, 其小無內). This may give a hints to why taiji practice was and still is recognized as a valid path towards the ultimate enlightenment in Daoism.

3.8.4 Neutralization

When a taiji practitioner is able to perform opening-and-closing in one dimension, it means that he achieves a better way to adhere to the point of balance in this dimension than before; otherwise, the opening-and-closing is impossible. But, still, it can be an unstable equilibrium. When he is further able to perform opening-and-closing to his standing point, it seems that he does not rely on any standing point in order to maintain his balance, achieving a kind of stable equilibrium, so to speak, as if all things in that dimension have been neutralized and no change can be caused to his balance. When one is able to perform this kind of neutralization in more and more yin-yang dimensions, he gradually arrives at a state that has been described by many grandmasters of taiji as emptiness, voidness, standing in the middle of nowhere, or every piece of me rooting in the air. A result of this neutralization, which is dreamed of by so many taiji players, is that it can nullify an incoming force by means of thinking (i.e., using mind-intent). One of the greatest contemporary taiji grandmasters, Wang Zhuanghong (王壯弘, 1931—2008), the founder of Wang's Water Taiji,[11] attributes it to the emptiness of Buddhism, the ultimate truth of the world, and presents the essence of taiji as the natural way of how water flows and how the world runs by their own nature (Wang 2008).

Notes

1 Adler (2008, 2015) argues that "supreme polarity" is a better choice of translation to convey the notion of taiji in the Cheng-Zhu Neo-Confucianism of Song Dynasty.
2 www.health.harvard.edu/staying-healthy/5-of-the-best-exercises-you-can-ever-do.
3 www.encyclopedia.com/medicine/encyclopedias-almanacs-transcripts-and-maps/tai chi.
4 en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tai_chi.

5 Namely, Daoism (Taoism, 道家), Confucianism (儒家), Mohism (墨家), Legalism (法家), School of Names (名家), and School of Yin-yang (陰陽家).
6 Namely, Agriculturalism (School of Agriculture, 農家), Vertical and Horizontal Alliances (School of Diplomacy, 縱橫家), Syncretism (School of Miscellany, 雜家), and Novel School (School of "Minor-talks"/Short Sayings, 小說家).
7 For examples, Schools of the Military (兵家), the Recipes and Skills/Methods (方技家), the Medicine (醫家), the Numbers and Techniques (數術), the Astronomy and Calendrics (天文曆法), Divination (占卜), Sexual Arts (房中术), etc.
8 Many versions of this treatise do not have this phrase, but its addition obviously makes the treatise, as a whole, closer to its origin, namely, Zhou's *Explanation*.
9 It is also put under the title Thirteen Postures (十三勢) in some taiji canon texts.
10 Or 105 forms if counting repeated ones, as in Yang (1997).
11 According to Grand Master Wang Zhuanghong, it is named after Wang Zongyue instead of his own surname.

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